Paper Cuts and Pyres

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/63733459.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
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Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Anaxa (Honkai: Star Rail), Flame Reaver of the Deepest Dark (Honkai: Star Rail), Stelle (Honkai: Star Rail), Aglaea (Honkai: Star Rail), Caelus (Honkai: Star Rail), March 7th (Honkai: Star Rail), Krateros (Honkai: Star Rail), Cipher (Honkai: Star Rail), Gorgo | Mydei's Mother (Honkai: Star Rail), Dan Heng (Honkai: Star Rail), Caenis (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Superheroes/Superpowers, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Slice of Life, Comedy, Phainon is Down Bad (Honkai: Star Rail), Librarians, Professors, Established Relationship, Secret Identity, Blood and Injury, occasionally, Fluff and Humor, Weird Plot Shit, Angst with a Happy Ending, What the fuck happened this was meant to be crack

Language:
English

Stats:

Published: 2025-03-10 Updated: 2025-09-30 Words: 179,737 Chapters: 19/21

Paper Cuts and Pyres

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Phainon and Mydei lead ordinary lives, navigating work, flirtations, and everything in between—except one thing: neither knows the other's secret identity.

While Phainon's got his hands full being a charismatic university professor by day and a notorious anti-hero by night, Mydei's just trying to keep his cool as a librarian while moonlighting as a vigilante.

They're together, they're happy, and the whole secret identity thing? No big deal.

Notes

GUYS A READER DID FANART FOR THIS CHECK IT OUT😍: https://archiveofourown.org/works/65909749

OMG GUYS ANOTHER ONE I'M TWEAKINF OUTJRJEJEDJ: https://x.com/piepie_lol28/status/1942600232677900483?s=46

Chapter 1: My Ordinary Life

Chapter Summary

> A typical day in the life of Phainon: running late, teaching class, bothering his boyfriend—and slipping quietly into the night to fix what others won't.

Chapter Notes

> JRKSKDKEDJRJ I WAS SO HAPPY WHILE WRITING THIS😭😭😭 THIS IDEA HAS BEEN STUCKKK IN MY HEAD
>
> Alright right off the bat this is gonna be very different from my other works since it's literally just gonna be slice of life with alternating POV's every chapter hdfjdjdjdjs
>
> Im still tweaking out but hope u enjoy😍

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon came to with the unmistakable, creeping sense that something was off.

The light spilling through the window was too warm—too settled to be early morning. The apartment was still. No alarm buzz. No hum from the morning news on low volume. No sharp, bitter trace of coffee lingering from the kitchen. Just the slow realization of stillness, and the weight of time already slipping past him.

His eyes opened.

8:39 a.m.

He stared at the numbers for exactly three seconds, his mind as blank as the ceiling above him. Then:

“…Damn it.”

He was up in an instant, pulling himself out of bed with the sort of fluidity that didn’t come from calm—just long-honed reflex. One hand dragged through his hair, the other already grabbing for clothes on instinct. No hesitation, no grogginess. That was the thing about being late often enough: the body adapted. It knew when the time for complaint had passed.

The shirt he’d ironed the night before was nowhere to be found—probably buried in a pile of laundry he’d sworn to deal with on Sunday. It didn’t matter. He grabbed a dark button-down from the closet—creased but wearable—and a pair of slacks already folded on the back of his desk chair. His socks were, unfortunately, mismatched. He didn’t stop to fix it.

He left them on the bed as he moved, feet bare against cold tile, into the bathroom. The water took a moment to heat; while it did, he stripped down and shoved a toothbrush into his mouth, multitasking with the determination of a man who knew exactly how long a three-minute routine could be compressed. Foam collected at the corners of his mouth as he stepped under the spray, bracing himself as cold hit skin first. He worked quickly—efficiently—mouth foaming, fingers scrubbing, water sluicing down his back. Two minutes. In and out.

He spat into the sink while toweling off, then turned toward the mirror and raked his fingers through his wet hair until it looked less like chaos and more like deliberate mess. Shaved just yesterday, thank god. He could skip the rest.

Back in his room, he dressed in quick motions, slipping into the shirt, slacks, and belt with the ease of routine. A tie was a luxury; today was damage control. He threw on a fitted jacket to give the illusion of intention and checked the time again: 8:47.

Technically, his lecture began at 9:00.

It was fine. It would be fine. Probably.

Shoes on—polished, at least, which felt like a small victory—he made his way through the apartment with purpose, grabbing his bag from the couch and slinging it over one shoulder. In the kitchen, he stopped only long enough to fill a water bottle and shove a slightly stale granola bar into his jacket pocket. The coffeemaker blinked at him, its timer long past. The carafe was bone-dry.

“Traitor,” he muttered.

Keys in hand, bag secured, he opened the door to leave—

And stopped.

There, just visible through the window, was his car. And on the windshield, vibrant against the dull grey of the dash, was a neon orange sticky note.

“NO GAS. Don’t push it. REFILL.”

He’d written it himself. Stuck it there last night in a brief moment of foresight—proof that at some point, he’d tried. A small part of him appreciated that. The rest wanted to tear it off and eat it.

He stood in the doorway for a moment, shoulders rising and falling with the slow exhale of a man not surprised, just deeply, deeply tired.

“…Right,” he said quietly.

And then he started running.

To call it a sprint would be accurate in the same way calling a lightning strike “a little spark” was accurate. Phainon didn’t run so much as *descend* upon the city streets—full force, half-dressed, and moving with the sheer unfiltered energy of a man who knew exactly how little time he had left to preserve his professional dignity.

The first block was a blur. He jumped a curb, nearly twisted his ankle on uneven pavement, and kept going without a second thought. His lungs

burned. His bag slammed against his side with each step. He still tasted toothpaste. Somewhere in the flurry of movement, he remembered to breathe—but only just.

He vaulted over a knee-high fence meant to keep pedestrians out of a construction shortcut, immediately set off someone's motion sensor, and offered a very genuine apology to the elderly woman whose dog leapt in surprise at his passing.

"Sorry!" he called over his shoulder, dodging a low-hanging branch. "Emergency academia!"

He wasn't sure that meant anything, but she waved her cane after him all the same. Possibly in support. Possibly not.

He cleared a flight of stairs three at a time, ducked through a narrow alleyway, and took a bite of the half-stale granola bar he'd pulled from his pocket. It lodged somewhere in his throat. He coughed violently mid-stride, then kept running.

He didn't usually have to run three and a half miles to get to work. But then again, he didn't usually self-sabotage via poorly placed sticky notes and pretend "five more minutes" was a sustainable sleep strategy. Today was a day of exceptions, most of them stupid, all of them his.

A few pedestrians turned to watch as he passed. He couldn't blame them. A grown man tearing across the city in business attire with wild hair and a messenger bag flapping behind him like a cape was probably not the most common sight on a Tuesday morning.

But fortunately for Phainon, he was *fit*.

Not in the "mirror selfie and macro counting" way, but in the kind of solid, quiet way that came from years of functional training. His body was used to movement—sharp, explosive movement. Sprints, climbs, hand-to-hand drills that weren't technically legal, but didn't leave marks if done right. There was a rhythm to it. His legs knew what to do. His lungs remembered

the cadence. His mind locked into pace. It didn’t matter that he was wearing loafers and khakis—he made it work.

There was a moment, somewhere in the second mile, when time slowed. A bird crossed his path. A man with a coffee stepped directly in front of him. Phainon swerved, spun, caught himself with a hand on a lamppost, and kept going without breaking stride.

Someone shouted, “Hey—watch it!”

Phainon threw a hand up in apology and didn’t look back.

The campus gates came into view like a divine illusion—rising out of the morning haze, backed by the rising sun and the slight tremor of his vision from sheer exertion. He pushed harder, rounding the corner with all the grace of a missile.

When the university building finally loomed in front of him, he was soaked in sweat, half-blind with adrenaline, and actively seeing god. She had her arms crossed and looked unimpressed.

He hit the front doors with a force that made them shudder open on impact, and staggered through the threshold like a man just barely escaping death. His chest heaved. His vision stuttered. His heart pounded somewhere near his ears.

There were students in the hallway.

A few turned. One leaned back against the wall slowly, as if unsure if they were witnessing a crime or an art piece.

Phainon bent forward, one hand on his thigh, the other raised as a makeshift greeting. He was breathless, flushed, hair a damp mess across his forehead. He looked like he’d either just run a marathon or barely survived a kidnapping.

“Morning,” he croaked, still catching his breath. “Lovely day, isn’t it?”

There was silence.

Then, a girl dropped her coffee with a soft splatter against the tiles.

He stood straighter—forced himself upright, rolling his shoulders back like it didn't hurt. Wiped the sweat from his brow with the inside of his sleeve. Straightened his jacket. Smiled.

It was the smile of a man who had almost certainly just violated several city ordinances, bodily limits, and laws of physics to make it here on time—and was absolutely not sorry.

One minute left.

Perfect timing.

The lecture hall was already half-full by the time Phainon swung open the door with all the subtlety of a man being chased by time itself.

Silence rolled over the room like a wave.

Dozens of students turned to stare, a few mid-sip with iced coffee, one midway through unwrapping a breakfast burrito. Phainon gave them all a winning, sweat-damp smile and tried to pretend his lungs weren't actively suing for damages.

"Morning," he wheezed. "Everyone's so punctual today. Love the commitment."

Dead silence.

Except for the unmistakable sound of one person slowly uncrossing their arms.

Anaxa stood at the front, stiff-backed, cold-eyed, the living embodiment of academic disappointment. His brow didn't even twitch. His voice could've refrigerated milk.

"You're late."

Phainon didn’t flinch. Just took one dramatic step forward, arms slightly out like he was finishing a performance.

“Correction,” he said, catching his breath between syllables. “I am… not *technically late.*”

Anaxa blinked. Slowly. Like he was recalibrating his tolerance for idiocy in real time.

“You arrived at 8:59 and forty-eight seconds. Panting. Disheveled. And bleeding.”

“Surface wound,” Phainon said, examining the tiny cut on his palm. “Adds character.”

“You tripped over a *bird feeder*,” Anaxa said without missing a beat. “I watched the security feed.”

“And yet—” Phainon spread his arms wider, as if to showcase his very existence. “Here I stand. Against all odds. Truly, a tale of perseverance.”

There was a long, withering pause.

Anaxa reached into the front desk drawer, pulled out a flash drive, and slapped it into Phainon’s open palm like he was delivering a cease-and-desist.

“I fixed your lecture notes. Again. Three citation errors. Two incomplete slides. And you spelled ‘epistemological’ with an ‘f.’”

Phainon grinned. “And that’s why you’re the wind beneath my wings.”

“I’m the iron chain around your ankle.”

“Poetic.”

Anaxa just stared at him. Phainon could’ve sworn he saw the faintest twitch in the corner of his jaw—either a suppressed eye-roll or the beginning of an aneurysm.

“You’re lucky I respect punctuality more than I loathe you,” Anaxa muttered.

“Love you too, Ana—”

“*Anaxagoras*.” His voice cut clean. Sharp as glass. “Use my full name in front of the students.”

Phainon blinked. “Even when I say it with affection?”

“Especially then.”

And with that, Anaxagoras turned on his heel, coat flaring behind him like he’d practiced it in a mirror. The door shut behind him with a satisfying *click*.

Phainon turned back to the class, who were now watching him like they weren’t sure if this was part of the curriculum or a live-action breakdown.

He clapped his hands, the sound a little too enthusiastic for someone who’d just sprinted three miles and gotten publicly executed by his colleague.

“All right,” he said, grinning. “Who’s ready to learn how to professionally win arguments and ruin dinner parties forever?”

One student raised a hand. “Are you okay, sir?”

“I’m fantastic,” Phainon said, voice bright, as he casually wiped blood off his hand with a syllabus. “Let’s begin.”

By the time he reached the podium, Phainon was settled. Breathing steady. Hands relaxed at his sides.

The room had already quieted. A few students had been talking, but now they were shifting in their seats, pulling out their notes, straightening their posture as if anticipating the shift in atmosphere.

Phainon had a way of doing that. A presence that settled across the space—not oppressive, not dramatic, but measured. The kind that made people sit

up and listen without realizing they were doing it.

He tapped the podium, and the screen behind him flickered to life, casting crisp lettering across the wall. No frills. Just the day's subject, direct and to the point.

"Let's begin," he repeated, composing himself.

He let the words carry, unhurried and steady. He was never the kind of professor who filled silences out of discomfort. He let them breathe. Let them stretch just enough to draw people in.

"Your assignment," he continued, "was to analyze existing cases and construct a counterargument for one you personally disagreed with."

A flicker of movement—students shifting, hands tightening over their notes.

"Some of you," he went on, "probably chose something easy. An argument so fundamentally flawed that it barely took effort to dismantle." He exhaled lightly through his nose. "Which is fine, if you enjoy mediocrity."

A murmur. A few wary glances.

"Others, I assume," he said, glancing up, "chose something more… challenging."

This time, there was more of a reaction—some straightened, some smiled. A few exchanged glances, the way students did when they were quietly measuring themselves against their peers.

Good.

He stepped out from behind the podium and leaned casually against the edge of the desk instead.

"The point of this wasn't to regurgitate the easiest answer," he said. "It was to engage with something that made you think. If you found yourself

second-guessing your own stance while writing, congratulations. You did it right."

Silence. Thoughtful. Expectant.

He tapped the desk lightly with his fingers.

"Who's confident in their work?"

A few hands lifted. He scanned them, then gestured to the nearest one.

"Come up," he said. "Convince me."

There was a slight hesitation—just a fraction of a second, the universal moment of someone realizing they were about to be put to the test. Then movement. A student stood, stepping toward the front.

Phainon shifted slightly, making space.

"Keep it concise," he instructed. "Direct. No rambling." He tilted his head. "And if you try to sell me nonsense, at least make it sound good."

The student nodded, took a breath, and began.

And just like that, the class was in motion.

For the next hour, Phainon listened, countered, redirected. He didn't just lecture—he engaged. He challenged. He made them think on their feet, adjust, refine. And despite the occasional stumble, despite the inevitable nerves that came with speaking under scrutiny, the students adapted. They pushed themselves.

By the time the session neared its end, the energy in the room was sharper, more focused. No one had checked the clock in a while. No one had even noticed how quickly the time had passed.

Phainon finally leaned back against the desk, exhaling lightly.

"Better," he said, nodding once. "Not perfect, but better."

He glanced toward the clock. Just enough time to wrap up.

“Alright,” he said, “for next time—”

And just like that, the rhythm shifted again. The closing notes. The final instructions.

He watched as they packed up, murmuring amongst themselves—some clearly still turning over arguments in their minds, others already letting their thoughts drift toward their next class, their next obligation.

As they filed out, Phainon lingered at the desk, tapping a finger lightly against the wood.

There was a particular satisfaction in this part. The weight of a room that had been fully engaged. A job well done.

Outside, the day stretched on, demanding his next move.

He rolled his sleeves back down, buttoned them at the cuffs, and straightened his jacket.

He had just enough time to stop by the library.

And he knew exactly who he wanted to see.

The walk to the library was just long enough to justify. Long enough to pretend it was for the fresh air, the stretch, the change in scenery. Long enough to let him lie to himself with a straight face.

Phainon didn’t often take his full lunch break—there was always something else to be done. A paper to mark. A stubborn student to email. A system to mildly outwit. But today, he’d found himself drifting. Fingers tapping restlessly against his desk. Thoughts wandering in precise, unrepentant circles.

So he walked. Down the stone path flanked with overgrown hedges. Past the baker who always gave him judgmental looks for skipping breakfast.

Around the fountain some poor department kept insisting was “historical.”

The library stood at the edge of the square like it had been carved out of stillness itself. Cool stone, high windows, doors heavy enough to suggest silence wasn’t a suggestion but a commandment.

He pushed them open with one shoulder.

Inside, it smelled like old pages and whatever blend of tea Mydei had decided was acceptable this month.

Phainon’s footsteps were light. Quiet, but not sneaky. He wasn’t trying to hide—he just knew better than to provoke the wrath of the librarian with echoes.

And there he was.

Behind the counter, half-shadowed by a crooked lamp, Mydei was deep in a hardcover nearly as thick as his patience wasn’t. His posture was elegant in the way statues were—still, composed, absolute. He didn’t look up.

Which was fine. Phainon was familiar with the opening choreography of this little dance.

He leaned an elbow on the counter, smile already playing at the corners of his mouth.

“I’m beginning to think you’re avoiding me,” he said, voice low and easy. “That’s cruel, you know. I was almost forced to grade papers to fill the aching void.”

Nothing. Not even a blink.

Phainon let the silence stretch just long enough to be dramatic, then tilted his head slightly. “It’s alright. I forgive you. Mostly because you’re devastatingly attractive when you pretend I’m not here.”

Still no reaction.

He squinted. “You are going to speak to me, right? I haven’t been hallucinating this entire relationship?”

Finally—finally—Mydei turned a page.

“You’re early,” he said without looking up. “And loud.”

Phainon grinned. “You wound me, love.”

“I’ll do more than that if you don’t let me work.”

“Now, now,” Phainon murmured, clutching his chest like a man freshly stabbed. “Is that any way to speak to the person who brings light into your dreary little world?”

“You’re tracking gravel onto my floor.”

Phainon looked down. He was. He dragged one foot slowly back over the threshold like that might undo the damage.

“And your shirt,” Mydei added, finally glancing up, “looks like it lost a duel with a hedge.”

Phainon blinked. “It did.” Then, after a beat: “I won.”

Mydei’s expression didn’t change, but one eyebrow lifted.

Phainon took that as a victory.

“I suppose I’ll let you get back to it,” he sighed, pushing off from the counter. “Try not to miss me too much.”

“I won’t.”

He was halfway to the door when Mydei called, without looking: “You forgot your tie.”

Phainon paused, then turned slowly, eyes narrowing.

“…You noticed?”

“It was the only thing not wrinkled.”

Phainon’s smile spread, slow and utterly unrepentant.

“I knew you looked at me when I walked in.”

“Get out.”

He did. But he was still smiling.

The afternoon passed in the steady blur it always did—lectures, questions, the faint clatter of notes being taken by students who thought speed equaled substance. Phainon taught with sleeves rolled up, one hand gesturing broadly while the other kept time with the flow of discussion. His students were sharp today—almost too sharp. They volleyed arguments like seasoned debaters, snatching phrases out of the air and turning them like blades.

He didn’t mind it. He liked the back-and-forth, the momentum of minds stretching themselves. It was the kind of quiet power that didn’t need to shout.

The bell rang—figuratively. There were no actual bells at the university, just the subtle shift of bodies and the rustling of paper that meant class had ended and attention spans had been reclaimed by hunger or boredom.

Phainon was reorganizing a few papers on the podium when he caught the tail end of a conversation drifting in from the back row.

“…—the guy they caught last winter, yeah. I thought he was locked up for good.”

“They said he broke out. Again. Same as before. Three guards injured this time. And one—”

A low whistle. “Damn. How does he keep getting out?”

“No clue. You’d think the heroes would actually… I don’t know. Do something permanent.”

Phainon’s pen paused.

It was brief. A second, maybe two. But there it was—a stillness. A flicker behind the eyes, just beneath the surface of his usual calm.

Then, just as quickly, it passed.

He looked up, smile folding easily back into place.

“Gossiping during a lecture break?” he called out, voice lilting with mock disapproval. “What an impressive misuse of academic freedom.”

The students startled slightly, some laughing, others ducking their heads. One of them offered a sheepish shrug.

“We were just—”

“Plotting the collapse of public trust in the justice system?” Phainon offered. “Very on-brand for this department. But unless the accused is going to submit a thesis, I suggest we stick to the syllabus.”

There were a few more chuckles. The mood lightened.

But as the students gathered their things and filtered out, Phainon lingered.

He tapped the edge of the desk with one knuckle, eyes skimming across the now-empty room. Whatever warmth had been in them earlier was tempered now, like steel pulled from the flame and hammered cool.

He didn’t say anything. He didn’t need to.

He just adjusted his cuffs, straightened his posture, and moved on.

If his lips were curved up into a strange smile, no one mentioned it.

School ended and the the last meeting of the day bled into the early evening, dragging itself across the hour like it had nowhere better to be. Phainon had nodded through most of it, occasionally offering a well-placed comment that made the department chair purse his lips and scribble something into his notes. He'd pretended not to notice.

By the time the university building finally began to empty, the halls took on a quiet, echoing stillness. The kind that made even the lights seem tired.

Phainon leaned back in his office chair, one leg slung casually over the other, his fingers typing lazily across his phone screen. The glow lit his face in the dimness, his expression soft around the edges.

Phainon✴:

Still working. Might be late tonight.
Don't wait up, darling <333

He watched the screen for a moment, then added:

Phainon✴:

Or do. You're very good at brooding into the evening.

A pause. Three dots flickered, then vanished.

Then:

Mydei :
I'm busy.

Phainon smiled. It was the same message he always got around this hour, when Mydei was finally closing up and done with social effort for the day. The man had the texting warmth of a glacier—but it was consistent. Familiar.

He typed again.

Phainon☀:

Miss you anyway.
I'll see you tomorrow, alright?
[♥]

He hesitated, thumb hovering.

Then added:

Phainon☀:

Or this one if you prefer: (ง ˘ ͜ ˘)ง)

The read receipt popped up almost immediately. No reply.

He tucked the phone into his pocket, the smile still lingering.

"Playing hard to get after two years," he murmured to himself, rising from the chair. "Bold strategy."

The office was dim, but he didn't turn on the overheads. He moved easily through the space, gathering a few things into his bag and slipping into his coat. His silhouette passed briefly by the window—just a figure against the deepening blue of the sky.

Campus after-hours had a different rhythm to it. Fewer voices. More shadow. The occasional echo of footsteps on stone.

He liked it. The quiet. The clarity.

Because soon, there'd be no more room for quiet.

Night wrapped itself around the city slowly, as if reluctant to settle in.

The sky had gone deep blue, starless, the kind of quiet evening that suggested storms on the edge of the horizon. Somewhere, faint sirens

stitched themselves through the wind—too distant to mean anything. Not yet.

Phainon moved through the old stairwell with practiced ease, every step measured, silent. His usual stride had vanished; there was no flippancy now. No offhand grace or exaggerated flair. Just the low hum of breath and the sound of clothes adjusting as he shifted his shoulders beneath the cloak.

It wasn't a disguise—not really. The world knew the Flame Reaver. Masked or not, there was no mistaking the man when the work began. But there were still rituals to be followed. The layering of fabric, the metallic glint of gauntlets cinched tight over his wrists, the whisper of a long coat as it unfurled behind him. Everything deliberate. Everything earned.

He paused near the rooftop exit, slipping a small device from his coat pocket—sleek, flat, nondescript. A single message blinked across the screen in clean white text.

Target spotted. Dockside. Level four clearance. Your call.

There was no sender listed. There didn't need to be.

Phainon's thumb hovered briefly, then tapped back one word.

Received.

No reply came, nor did he expect one. Anaxa was never one for sentiment.

He stepped out onto the rooftop, the wind cutting across his face with sharp, surgical precision. Below, the city pulsed with fractured light and fractured rules. Somewhere beneath it all, the subject of today's whispered headlines was still walking free.

A repeat offender. A known threat. Caught, jailed, released. Again and again.

That was the problem with heroes, wasn't it?

Phainon exhaled slowly, letting the air leave his lungs as he stared down into the night. Then, without hesitation, he moved—across the roof, over the ledge, into the alley below.

Gone.

Not a sound. Not a flash of flame. Just the ghost of motion and the quiet promise that someone had finally decided to finish the job.

Chapter End Notes

> Oh yeah forgot to mention but the writing style here is also gonna be pretty loose since I kind of want it casual if it makes sense?? But what’re we thinking so far?
>
> NDJDKDKD I LOVE THIS ALREADY OK😭😭😭

Chapter 2: Speeding Through Responsibilities

Chapter Summary

> A typical day in the life of Mydei: waking up too early, beating up criminals, riding motorcycles like traffic laws don't apply to him—and somehow making it just in time to pick up his boyfriend.

Chapter Notes

> Alright this was meant to be posted yesterday but I didn't have time so I said fuck it, let's write this at 2 in the morning to which I did cause sleep schedule? Never heard of her😍 I'll revise any grammar errors I have later but if u see any plz point it out cause there are probably some in here

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The alarm went off at six. A single chime, taut and immediate—silenced with practiced ease by the hand that reached for it.

Mydei opened his eyes.

He didn't rise right away. The room was dim, washed in pale early light that touched the edges of the neatly arranged furniture. For a moment, he simply lay there, stretching—long and slow, joints loosening with the elegant indifference of a cat. His spine arched just slightly as he drew his arms over his head, all the way to the headboard, then relaxed back into the quiet.

When he moved, it was with the unthinking fluidity of someone who didn't need to rush. The sheets folded themselves in his wake, the floor didn't creak beneath him. Every motion belonged to a rhythm he'd long since mastered.

In the bathroom, the lights glowed on with a soft warmth. The tiles were cool beneath his feet, a contrast to the already-steaming shower he turned

on. He stepped in without hesitation, the water striking his skin in a clean, steady stream.

He stood beneath it for a while—shoulders relaxed, chin tilted slightly up. The warmth soaked into him, traced the lines of his back, and caught at the ends of his hair. He worked in silence, washing with slow precision, methodical and practiced. No wasted movements, no distractions. Just water and heat and breath.

When he stepped out, he wrapped the towel around his waist and wiped a hand across the fogged mirror. His own reflection gazed back: calm, composed, and still somewhat snappy from being awake so early. He didn't linger on it.

He brushed his teeth next—still towel-bound, arms relaxed at his sides, the mint sharp against the lingering warmth of the shower. His gaze drifted toward the window. Beyond it, the day was starting.

The faintest twitch of an eyebrow. The smallest exhale of breath.

He rinsed. Spat. Swiped another towel once across his hair, then padded out into the apartment, leaving a faint trail of steam in his wake.

He dressed without much thought—layers folded neatly in drawers, socks stacked in perfect symmetry. Everything in its place.

Until the hoodie.

It was pink. Unapologetically so. The kind of soft, cozy pink that looked like it belonged to a sleep-deprived student with a fondness for bubble tea and pastel stationery. Not a six-foot-something wall of restrained muscle whose shoulders stretched most fabrics like it was on trial.

But the hoodie didn't care. Neither did he.

It slid over his head, the hem brushing mid-thigh. Loose. Comfortable. The sleeves hung past his wrists and covered half his hands. It still smelled

faintly of clean cotton and some long-ago detergent he could no longer name.

No one had ever questioned it. Who would?

He reached for his usual pants—black, fitted—and tugged them on with the same calm efficiency as everything else. His movements weren't rushed, just quiet and unbothered. Like a man whose priorities did not include justifying his fashion choices.

In the mirror, the hoodie looked absurd on him.

He didn't blink.

It was warm. It was his. That was enough.

The kitchen was quiet when he entered, still touched by the gray-blue hush of morning. A filtered light spilled across the counters, catching on glass and brushed steel. He tied his hair back in a loose knot before he began.

He moved through the space with the kind of still confidence that suggested he'd done this a thousand times and never once fumbled. Ingredients were pulled from the fridge with a practiced hand—eggs, cream, sugar, a bar of dark chocolate already half-gone from some previous indulgence. A mixing bowl was spun out from the cupboard with the ease of muscle memory.

The smell of vanilla and cinnamon began to rise, slow and warm. French toast, thick-cut and golden, crisped in a pan while a second batch soaked nearby. He worked without noise, without clutter, the occasional hum under his breath the only sound besides the sizzle of the skillet.

The plating was clean—precise, even. Stacked slices dusted with powdered sugar, a drizzle of syrup in deliberate arcs, fruit arranged with a subtle sort of care that made it seem like it had just landed there on its own. He placed the plate on the table and poured himself a cup of coffee, black, before sitting down.

He ate in calm silence, enjoying the contrast between the crisped edge and the soft center, the way the sweetness lingered but didn’t overwhelm. The hoodie’s sleeves were pushed back just enough to keep them clean, the cuffs creased from habit.

It was, by all measures, a quiet morning. But it was his—and that made it perfect.

The screen lit up across the counter, humming once. Mydei glanced at it only because he always did—habit, not interest.

Phainon✴:

Rise and shine, my sweetest librarian. Dream of me?

Mydei :
No.

A pause. Then another ping.

Phainon✴:

Ruthless. Is this what love feels like?

Mydei :
…Yes.

A beat.

Phainon✴:

:’(

Mydei scoffed quietly through his nose, but his thumb hesitated before setting the phone down. The corner of his mouth gave the smallest twitch—betrayal in its softest form.

Another message came in before the smile could fully form.

Phainon✴:

Can you pick me up later? I'll owe you one. Or two. Or all of me.

Mydei :
Fine.

Almost instantly:

Phainon✴:

You're an angel. (づ> v <)づ♡

Mydei stared at the emoticon. Then at the counter. Then back again.

He put the phone down with a sigh.

Ridiculous.

…But not unwelcome.

Mydei left the apartment with little fanfare.

The streets were still waking up—hushed and blue in the morning light, tinged gold at the edges where sunlight slipped through. He walked with the kind of ease that came from routine: hands tucked into the pocket of his pink hoodie, bag slung over one shoulder, footsteps quiet but steady.

There was a motorcycle parked a block away. Polished. Black. Unassuming, if you didn't know what to look for. He didn't take it this morning—didn't need to. The library was only a short walk, and Mydei liked the stillness. It gave him time to think. Or not think. Whichever the day required.

When he arrived, he unlocked the heavy front doors and stepped into the silence.

The library was an older building, all high ceilings and sun-dappled windows, with the faint scent of parchment and dust lingering in the air. Not

affiliated with the university, but known well enough among those who preferred their solitude curated with care.

Mydei worked alone.

He moved quietly between the stacks, sorting returns into carts, shelving what needed shelving, straightening spines with unconscious precision. A few pages of inventory updates awaited him at the desk. He reviewed them without pause, fingers skimming the list as his mind filed the titles away automatically.

The morning passed like mist. A couple of regulars came in—one unsure, the other chatty. Mydei answered questions before they could fully form.

“You’re looking for something with a slower pace. Try the second shelf, to your right. Gold spine.”

“Something shorter? No romance? Top of the fiction display, third from the left. Yes, that one.”

He didn’t linger. Just nodded as thanks was offered, then returned to his sorting, sliding a volume back into place with the soft hush of cloth against wood.

The quiet suited him. Here, the world stayed still.

The minutes passed uneventfully. Mydei was halfway through reshelving a crate of archival editions when the panel on his desk blinked once—quietly, subtly. An ordinary drawer front shimmered with the faintest pulse of blue, then shifted, revealing a discreet interface beneath the wood.

He straightened. Brushed the dust from his hands. Stepped over.

The message was already waiting.

From: Hyacine

Priority: Elevated

Status: Request

—We need your assistance. Urgent, if you're available, please.

He stared at the words for a breath, then let out a soft exhale through his nose.

So much for a quiet day.

He moved with purpose now—closed the panel with a gesture, rechecked the feed for the security cams, then began his practiced routine for shutting down. His hands were steady, but there was something tighter in his jaw, something quieter in the way he moved.

He flipped the "Quiet Study Hours" placard to "Closed for Maintenance" and calmly stepped into the main floor.

"Library's closing early," he said with a polite finality that left no room for negotiation. "Please wrap up your selections and exit."

"One girl blinked at him, halfway through browsing the poetry shelf. "Is something wrong?"

"No."

She stared at him a second longer, then wisely packed her things.

Mydei waited at the front doors, arms crossed, until the last few patrons filed out under his impassive gaze. Some left with questions in their eyes. None voiced them.

They knew better than to mess with the deranged librarian here.

He stepped forward and unlocked the door—just in time for it to swing open onto a man mid-knock, one arm raised awkwardly, mouth already

forming words.

“Hey, can I just drop—”

SLAM.

The door shut with a force that rattled the frame.

From outside: a stunned silence. Then a faint, bewildered, “…Alright.”

Inside, Mydei flipped the sign to Closed with the dead-eyed precision of a man who’d had enough.

He didn’t even sigh. Just turned on his heel, already walking away as he muttered,

“Tragic.”

Mydei exited through the back, the door shutting behind him with the soft hiss of an automatic lock. No one saw him leave.

In the narrow alley behind the library, leaning against the brick wall like a forgotten relic, sat a beat-up bike with one wheel slightly bent and a faded cartoon sticker peeling off the side. The sticker was smiling. Its origins were unknown. It had been there since before Mydei inherited the library, and in a display of both negligence and passive defiance, he’d never removed it.

So yes, the infamous Godslayer—the most feared operative in the Chrysos Heirs—was about to save the city in a pink hoodie and on a rickety two-wheeler with a grinning cartoon blob on it. Again.

He mounted it without comment and began pedaling.

The ride was smooth in the way only someone completely desensitized to potholes and poorly paved roads could find smooth. He coasted past sharp corners and winding lanes, letting the wind nip at his face. The city moved around him: alive, breathing, unaware. He didn’t rush. There was no need. The message had said *urgent*, not *immediate*.

It could’ve been a morning ride. A peaceful, if slightly uphill, commute from a man with a too-large clothing and somewhere to be. Mydei passed under iron bridges and between stone buildings, gliding in clean lines like he was drawing them.

He rolled to a stop in front of an unremarkable gray building tucked between a shuttered cafe and something else. Narrow windows. No signage. Just brick, concrete, and a locked steel door.

He parked the bike beside it, propped it with a foot, and opened the door.

The hallway beyond was pristine. Not a single mark on the marble floor. A wall panel blinked awake the moment he stepped in.

A soft chime. Then:

“Welcome. Identity confirmed: Mydeimos. Clearance: Class One.”

A portion of the far wall split and peeled away with a quiet hiss, revealing a hidden elevator of gleaming chrome and seamless walls.

He stepped inside.

“Please remain still for biometric authentication.”

There was a brief flicker of blue light.

“Retinal scan: verified. Vitals: stable. Aura signature: confirmed.”

“Descent initiated. Welcome to the Chrysos Heirs.”

The elevator dropped in a swift, perfectly controlled motion—silent, smooth, and fast.

He didn’t blink.

The doors opened to a cathedral of steel and glass.

Smooth marble floors stretched in clean lines under pale, ambient lights that hummed like something alive. Every footstep echoed faintly before being swallowed by the hush of controlled efficiency. Screens blinked with real-time feeds, teams moved with quiet intent, and distant murmurs of status reports carried like the low tide of an ocean. The Chrysos Heirs HQ ran like a heartbeat—steady, constant, indispensable.

Mydei walked in like it was a neighborhood bookstore.

He was still chewing.

A biscuit, half-wrapped in a linen napkin, rested between his fingers. Someone had offered it—he hadn't looked up to see who—and he'd taken it without question, because regardless of whatever the hell was going on, it was still twelve in the godforsaken morning. Early by anyone's standards. Even his. Even if he *was* an early bird (unwillingly).

He stepped onto the platform where she stood waiting.

Aglaea.

Goldweaver.

She was in full uniform, the folds of her tailored jacket resting like sculpture across her frame. Her presence was something like ancient nobility and something like cold fire—sharp, polished, and without flaw. Not a single strand of hair out of place. Not a single wasted word.

"Mydei," she greeted, her voice clear, poised. "Thank you for coming on short notice."

He nodded, tearing a clean bite from the biscuit. Crumbs landed somewhere on the left sleeve of his hoodie. He did not brush them off.

"We have a re-emergence," she continued. "Designation: *Obelis*. A fracture-class anomaly, last seen six months ago in the Lower Sixth District."

Her fingers moved across a console beside her, and a glowing outline flickered to life in the air—a vague, humanoid silhouette with spiked arms and pulsing veins of stone along its body.

“Abilities include: surface petrification, internal calcification, and blunt-force amplification. We believe he’s adapted since his last encounter with Castorice.”

Another flick of her wrist. Images changed: footage of a collapsed plaza, crumbling statues that had once been people. Charred outlines. A limp figure on a rooftop—Mydei didn’t react.

“Castorice was meant to intercept, but she’s currently deployed in the far north. She… hoped you wouldn’t be summoned so soon again.” Aglaea’s voice softened minutely. “She extends her gratitude. As do I.”

Mydei finally swallowed.

“Mm.”

Aglaea inclined her head in acknowledgment. Nothing more needed to be said.

“Oh,” she added with surgical precision, just as he turned slightly to leave, “and one more development.”

A final image, flickering into place. A security still of a burnt-out alley. At its center, a body. Unrecognizable.

“The Flame Reaver acted again last night. Another convict. Third this month.”

Silence.

Mydei licked the last of the crumbs from his thumb, pausing for a second before nodded once more, and throwing the napkin away in some trash bin nearby.

Then he turned to go, but not before he looked at the image one last time.

Obelis. Petrification. Amplification. Third this month. Castorice sends her regards. Etcetera, etcetera.

He exhaled softly through his nose, the sound the closest thing to a groan he could offer in polite company. Then: “I’ll handle it.”

Aglaea nodded, already turning to brief another agent, already trusting him to disappear and return with the problem no longer a problem.

He made his way down the corridor, past a few nodding operatives and a silent retinal scanner, until he reached the far wing—his designated quarter. Private. Stark. Familiar.

The door hissed shut behind him.

For a second, he just stood there, hand on the hem of his hoodie. Then, with all the energy of someone about to clock in at a very cursed shift, he pulled it off over his head in one long, reluctant motion.

Another sigh escaped him, quiet and resigned.

“So much for a quiet morning,” he muttered.

He folded the hoodie with unnecessary care, set it down on the chair like it was something sacred, and stared blankly ahead for a moment. Then he moved to the far end of the room, where the wall scanned him and began to shift.

Time to save the city.

Again.

Glass rained from the ceiling.

Mydei walked through it like it was mild weather. Shards bounced off his clothes. One sparkled dramatically past his ear. He didn’t blink.

The first man came at him with a crowbar, yelling something primal—probably meant to intimidate.

Mydei caught the crowbar mid-swing and stared at him, unimpressed.

Then he twisted. *Crack*.

The man screamed in a rather high-pitched tone and folded to the ground like bad laundry.

Someone behind him tried to be clever and swing a pipe at his back. Mydei stepped aside, reached back without looking, and grabbed the guy by the collar. A quick pivot, one neat slam into a support beam, and the second guy was down. Quiet.

“Two,” Mydei muttered.

Three more approached. Mydei sighed.

The first tripped over his own nerves. The second was yelling something about vengeance before Mydei stepped in and drove his elbow into the guy’s sternum with enough force to silence the rest of the speech. He crumpled with a wheeze.

The third paused. Considered her options. Ran at him anyway.

He caught her by the shirt, spun her in a wide arc, and let her crash into a pile of crates. A loud thunk, followed by a quiet groan.

He adjusted his sleeves. “Three.”

From the far side of the room, huddled civilians watched him with wide eyes, whispering behind hands. One of them mouthed *what the hell*, the other just nodded slowly like it was a religious experience.

It wasn’t. It was a Thursday.

At last, the villain emerged. Dressed in overdesigned black armor with pulsating neon lines and a gauntlet that looked like it had been soldered

together by a blind engineer with a grudge.

The guy grinned. “So you’re the Godslayer. I’ve been waiting for this moment.”

Mydei looked at him blankly. “Hm.”

“You think you can just walk in here, destroy my men, and—”

Mydei punched him in the face.

One hit. Lights out.

The man collapsed like a marionette whose strings had been cut, his fancy gauntlet flickering one last time before shorting out entirely.

Silence.

A long beat passed.

Then—tentative applause from one of the hiding civilians. Another gave a thumbs up. Someone else called out, “Yo, that was sick,” like they’d just watched a particularly clean trickshot.

Mydei touched the comm in his ear.

“Target neutralized.”

There was a pause on the other end, static crackling faintly.

“…Already?”

Mydei stared down at the unconscious body on the floor, then at his scuffed sneakers. “Yes.”

“Wow. Uh—okay. Stand by. Confirming clearance now.”

“Don’t sound so surprised,” he said flatly.

“Right. Sorry. You’re just… efficient.”

A civilian nearby coughed quietly. Mydei turned away, already heading toward the exit.

This was what passed for a warmup.

He barely had time to stretch his arms.

One moment, the air was thick with smoke and silence.

The next—*reporters*.

Where did they even come from? Were they hiding in the walls? Were they bred in the alleys like pigeons with microphones?

Mydei blinked as half a dozen cameras clicked in his face, lights flaring like miniature suns. Boom mics extended overhead with frightening speed, and a very chipper anchor in a magenta pantsuit shoved past the perimeter tape like it was suggestion-based.

“Godslayer!” she beamed. “How do you feel right now?”

“Tall,” he said.

That seemed to stun her for half a second. Not long enough. Another reporter chimed in: “What message would you like to send the people after this display of heroism?”

Ah, the PR part. Right.

Mydei stood a little straighter, his expression falling into the neutral, solemn default the press seemed to love. He prepared to deliver the usual message about hope, courage, resilience—all the buzzwords the Chrysos Heirs had approved.

And then he glanced down at the corner of his cracked comm screen.

4:25 PM.

There was a brief, almost holy silence in his mind. A quiet internal shattering.

Oh.

Oh no.

His eyes didn't widen, his face didn't shift, but his entire *soul* momentarily left his body. Not even during combat had he felt that cold pulse of dread. He had five minutes.

Five minutes.

Five minutes to get across the city, back in civilian clothes, and pretend he hadn't just suplexed a villain through an industrial beam.

Phainon was probably already standing outside with his coat, checking his phone with one hand and looking devastatingly patient. He'd probably even made a joke earlier that Mydei *would* be late, and Mydei had said "I won't be."

He would be.

And he was going to look like the world's worst boyfriend.

"Godslayer, your statement, please?" the reporter prompted.

Mydei stared blankly.

Then: "Stay safe," he said quickly. "Avoid alleys. Eat protein. Hydrate."

He turned and *booked* it.

Reporters called after him. Civilians tried to take photos. One confused fan tried to hand him a latte. Mydei ignored all of it, ducked into a side street, and made a break for his stored motorcycle like his *entire reputation* depended on it.

Which, tragically, it did.

They were too fast.

Mydei didn’t know if the reporters were genetically enhanced or just powered by the fumes of sensational headlines, but they were *gaining*. Cameras bounced behind him like caffeinated bloodhounds, chasing their next viral clip with the determination of people who had *nothing to lose.*

He took a sharp left. Then a sharper right. Someone yelled his name. Someone else yelled “*marry me*.” He did not look back.

With military precision and the calm of a man who had done this *way too many times*, he ducked into an alley, kicked off the nearest wall, climbed onto a dumpster, then a rusted fire escape, and vanished onto the roof like a very jaded, very tall alley cat in a pink hoodie.

When he finally reached his building, he didn’t even pause. Didn’t open the front door. That would take too long. That would look *suspicious*.

No. He vaulted onto his own windowsill—four stories up—and launched himself through the open window he *always* left unlocked for this exact kind of emergency.

He landed with the grace of a seasoned acrobat and the apathy of a man who’d done this too often to care about how absurd it looked.

His foot knocked over a chair. His hand hit a shelf. He didn’t stop.

Aglaea definitely had access to the cameras all the way here to Olympus’s surveillance grid. Half the Chrysos Heirs probably had bets on how long it’d take him to get back.

Whatever. They could keep their spreadsheets and silent judgment. He had exactly three minutes to stop being the God Slayer and start being a reasonably punctual boyfriend.

One problem though.

He didn’t have time.

The moment he landed, Mydei was already peeling off layers, hoodie hitting the floor like a fallen comrade. He kicked his shoes halfway across the room and beelined it to the bathroom, flicking on the sink with surgical urgency.

A splash. Then two. He scrubbed off the blood like it was just another stain on his reputation, wiping it clean with practiced indifference. The mirror fogged slightly, but he barely looked at it. There wasn’t time for vanity, only damage control.

Shirt off. Pants off. He yanked on a plain black tee that clung nicely to his frame—accidentally flattering, but whatever—and loosely tied a jacket around his waist. He looked normal. Civilian. Approachable. Definitely not someone who’d just reduced a minor crime ring to paste.

“Fine,” he muttered to himself, dragging fingers through his damp hair. “I look fine.”

And he did.

There was no time to celebrate that fact.

Motorcycle keys in hand, he was already halfway down the stairwell before the door even finished closing behind him. The second he hit the pavement, he swung onto the matte-black bike parked just where he always left it, engine purring like it missed him.

The machine was sleek. Fast. Clearly loved. Mydei treated it better than he did most of his own joints.

He revved the engine once, kicked off the stand, and was gone—cutting through traffic like sin through silk, disobeying at least five traffic laws with the casual ease of someone who had *definitely* done much worse and *definitely* gotten away with it.

Pedestrians stared. A few gawked.

Mydei didn’t even blink.

He had a boyfriend to pick up. And two minutes left on the clock.

The city blurred.

Back on the bike, Mydei slipped between lanes like smoke, weaving through traffic lights with a calm that suggested the law had no jurisdiction over him. Maybe it didn’t. No sirens dared chase him. No cameras dared flash. The wind tore through his hair and shirt as he leaned into a sharp turn, the machine beneath him responding like a loyal beast of war.

By the time he pulled up near the university gates, his expression was unreadable, visor still down. He parked neatly by the curb, engine purring once before dying to a gentle hum. Students were still loitering nearby, killing time, half-pretending not to stare as the tall, broad-shouldered rider stepped off with fluid grace.

Mydei exuded the same energy as someone stepping out of an explosion without checking behind him.

Heads turned. One girl muttered something like “Oh my god,” under her breath. Someone else dropped a water bottle.

Phainon was already waiting by the campus steps, messenger bag in hand. He looked up from his phone and paused.

“Oh,” he said, clearly taken aback. “I thought you’d be late.”

Before Mydei could respond, a voice from the side cut in—Stelle, one of Phainon’s more shameless students, waved a slow, impressed thumbs-up.

“Damn, professor. You bagged *that*?”

Phainon blinked. “Apparently.”

He walked toward the bike slowly, eyebrows slightly raised, gaze scanning Mydei like he was still trying to place this version of him. Mydei simply

stopped, one boot against the pavement, and lifted his visor with a slow flick.

Deadpan. “Well? Front or back? Which way are you riding.”

Phainon stared at him.

“…You.”

“…What?”

“Front, please.”

A long pause. Then, with no fanfare, Mydei wordlessly offered him the spare helmet.

Phainon took it with a blooming grin. He didn’t say anything, but the spark in his eyes said everything.

Mydei swung back onto the bike without a word.

Phainon followed.

“Anyway,” Phainon began, voice muffled slightly through the helmet. “I had this debate class today, and I swear to the gods, half the students didn’t even read the material. Do you ever get the urge to just—”

Mydei cut him off mercilessly, “Stop talking and hang on.”

Phainon’s voice lit up, a teasing tone creeping in. “Only if you promise not to crash.”

“Not unless you plan on doing something *else* on this bike.”

Phainon only chuckled, leaning back just slightly. “Fair enough.”

Mission accomplished.

Chapter End Notes

YIPPYYY WE GOT THE INTRODUCTION CHAPTERS DONE😍

if I’m able to double post, do you guys want Flame Reaver Phainon x Civilian Mydei next chapter? Or Civilian Phainon x God Slayer Mydei? It’s gonna be from Phainon’s POV btw

Ty for reading <333

Chapter 3: The Flame Reaver Doesn’t Do Romance (Until He Does)

Chapter Summary

> A kiss saves a life, a cloak raises suspicion, and Phainon learns that multitasking includes both murder and texting his boyfriend back. It’s called balance.

Chapter Notes

> IM ALIVEEE, AGAIN SORRY FORNTHE LATE POST THIS WEEK HAS BEEN FINALS FOR THE TERM AND ISTG ALL I WISH FOR IS FOR 5 HOURS OF UNINTERRUPTED SLEEP😭😭
>
> Well at least tomorrow is Friday, anyway☺ I’ll have break next week so I’m gonna work my ass off to post one chapter here everyday or even double post or die trying, enjoy <333
>
> (PS: Ignore that brief medical inaccuracy I just really wanted them to kiss ok😭)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The outskirts of the city were always too quiet.

No lights. Just neon glow bleeding in from miles away. No cars. Just the sound of electricity buzzing through frayed streetlamps that flickered like they were afraid to be seen. And no people—just whispers of them. A scarf left behind in a rush. A shoe discarded mid-sprint. The faint coppery scent of a skirmish long ended.

Phainon walked through it like a myth. Blade sheathed. Face masked. His breath steady and inaudible under the thick cloth and metal. Every step was measured. Silent. Like the ground didn’t dare echo back.

His comm crackled once, then cleared.

“Oh good, you’re not dead,” said Anaxa’s voice, clear with bored disdain. **“Regrettable.”**

Phainon didn’t respond. Just kept walking.

“I’m tracking movement four blocks east of your position,” Anaxa went on. **“Possibly our slippery little parolee. And by ‘parolee,’ I mean government-sponsored moral collapse in a trench coat.”**

A beat of silence.

Then Anaxa added, **“And before you ask, yes. I’ve triple-verified the ID. Unlike you, I don’t conduct fieldwork based on ‘vibes.’”**

Phainon gave the briefest hum, the kind that could be interpreted as either agreement or passive aggression.

Anaxa sighed, sharp and straight to the point. **“You’re in one of Goldweaver’s zones, by the way. Try not to set anything on fire this time. Or do. Honestly, I’m torn between professional integrity and watching her file another seventy-page incident report.”**

That earned the barest twitch of Phainon’s lip under his mask. Not quite a smile. More like a murder-adjacent smirk.

“Still nothing to say?” Anaxa asked, mock-sweet. **“Charming. It’s like working with a particularly vengeful housecat.”**

Phainon crouched low, eyes sweeping the ground. A drag mark. Blood, maybe. Fresh. Civilians had been here, and not long ago.

The comm crackled again.

“Anyway,” Anaxa said, more sharply now, **“you’ve got ten minutes before that perimeter closes. Unless you’d like to get close with Olympus’ surveillance team, which, by the way, is still absolutely crawling with Goldweaver’s little pet projects. Including one intern who said your blade technique was ‘overly theatrical.’”**

Phainon stopped.

"…He's dead to me," he said at last, voice low and dry as bone.

"Oh?" Anaxa said sweetly. **"So you can speak. I was beginning to worry you'd taken a vow of silence for the aesthetic."**

Another pause. Then a calm, gliding voice from the shadows:

"I don't speak unless I have to."

"And yet you text with emojis," Anaxa muttered. **"Gods help me."**

Phainon rose again, gaze locked ahead as the faint outline of his target came into view—two floors up in a ruined building, hunched over a body that wasn't moving.

No hesitation. No sound.

Phainon moved forward, blade unsheathed, and vanished into shadow.

The higher he climbed, the quieter the city became.

Not silent—no. Silence was clean. This was the low, muffled drag of something unfinished. Sirens echoed faintly, warped by distance. A dog barked once, then fell quiet. Somewhere below, glass crunched under a foot that wasn't his.

Phainon stilled at the sound, hand on the hilt of his sword, before slipping through the fractured archway of an abandoned bank. The lobby was gutted—charred walls, vines curling through cracked stone, gold filigree blackened and peeling like old scabs.

Three bodies lay against the far columns, spaced with uncanny neatness. Two women, one man. All unconscious. All breathing.

"Unarmed," Phainon murmured. "Breathing. Cold skin. Pulse slow."

A pause.

Then, over comms, Anaxa's voice filtered in—precise, detached, the kind of clinical you didn't learn from med school but from years of field triage.

"Blue tint?"

"Yes."

"Gas or contact agent. Circulatory suppressant. Five-minute exposure, maybe less."

Phainon pressed two fingers to a woman's wrist. "Non-lethal."

"Not for long," Anaxa replied. **"Move."**

He did.

The stairwell creaked as he ascended. Fifth floor, Anaxa had said. Top of the tower. No working elevator, no time for dramatics. The shadows stretched longer here, twisted by broken windows and half-dead fluorescents flickering like dying stars.

It was when he paused to pass a wide, cracked window that he saw it.

A flurry of movement below—flames licking the edge of the street, smoke curling into the night. Somewhere, metal groaned. A public bus had crashed into the side of a half-demolished structure. Its front end was crushed into the scaffolding like a kneeling beast, windshield webbed with cracks. One of the tires was still spinning, aimless.

Civilians were crawling out of the windows.

One woman climbed down the side only to slip and tumble onto the asphalt. Another helped a limping man hobble away from the wreckage. A child was screaming somewhere, high-pitched and muffled by the smoke. Emergency response hadn't reached them yet.

Phainon stilled.

The air around the bus shimmered faintly with that same synthetic gas—more subtle here, thinner—but unmistakable. He'd seen what it did when concentrated. This was already enough to ruin lungs.

And they were breathing it in.

One of the civilians, already staggering, collapsed against the curb. Another ran back into the wreckage. Phainon didn't know why—maybe for a bag, or a pet, or something else no one would understand until it was too late.

His fingers curled slightly.

They wouldn't all make it out.

For a moment, he stayed where he was, cloaked by shadow, eyes sharp and unblinking. He didn't move. Didn't flinch.

Then, Anaxa's voice crackled in his ear.

"Still breathing, I assume?"

Phainon blinked, pulse sharpening again.

"Yeah," he muttered, stepping back from the edge. "They're still moving."

He didn't say for now.

He didn't have to.

He bit his tongue and kept walking.

He didn't have time for this.

He had to have trust in their capabilities, he had to.

Still, his next step up the stairwell was quieter than the last.

And faster.

The man at the top of the tower wasn’t going to kill himself.

Unfortunately.

He reached the upper floors without resistance.

No traps. No alarms. Just more signs of rot—offices gutted, desks overturned, ceilings sagging with moisture. A half-dead hallway light sputtered as he passed, casting sharp shadows across the limp bodies slumped against the walls.

Three. No—four.

None were dead. Not yet.

One man convulsed once, then stilled. Phainon didn’t stop walking.

He knew what death looked like. This wasn’t it. Just the threshold.

“Building schematics show no recent records past Floor Twelve,” Anaxa said, voice filtering in through his comm again. He sounded more like a war doctor now—detached, not disinterested. **“No maintenance, no tenants, no surveillance footage. And then—suddenly—activity. Spikes in temperature. Magnetic readings. Toxic dispersals.”**

Phainon stepped over another collapsed civilian. A brief glance—livid skin, dark veins. A quiet pulse.

“Unregistered tech?”

“Tech, or something playing at it,” Anaxa replied. **“Too erratic for a sanctioned operation. And I ran the parole records again. Your guy’s clean on paper.”**

Phainon scoffed. “They always are.”

“No. I mean clean. Like someone scrubbed it this morning. Name’s there. History isn’t.”

At the end of the hall, he saw the faintest glow.

Phainon didn’t run. He walked.

He stepped into the top floor like it belonged to him.

The man was already waiting.

Mid-forties. Bad posture. Jacket two sizes too big. He flinched at Phainon’s entrance, fingers twitching near a case of tools—vials, syringes, wires tangled like veins. The remnants of whatever horror he’d tried to unleash downstairs sat behind him in cold steel.

“You,” the man spat. “You’re—”

He never finished the sentence.

Phainon’s sword was a blur—one clean arc, not toward the neck or chest, but just above the hip. A vital-adjacent strike. Deep enough to send him sprawling, twitching, writhing. But not dying. Not even close.

The sword hummed softly in his hand.

The man hit the ground hard.

He tried to scramble away—stupid, futile—but Phainon didn’t even look winded. He walked up and, without so much as a warning, brought his heel down.

Hard.

The man screamed. Or tried to. It came out broken.

Phainon’s leg remained planted on his ribs, pinning him like he wasn’t even worth crouching for. A footnote. A smear.

“Name,” he said calmly.

The man didn’t answer. Just wheezed.

Phainon dug his heel in further, leaning slightly, just enough for bone to creak.

“No?” he asked, tone cool. “That’s fine.”

He stepped back, letting the man gasp. His blade stayed unsheathed, resting easily in one hand.

“Anaxa,” Phainon said.

“Yes?”

“Five minutes. Get what you can.”

There was a pause. The faint sound of keys tapping. Then:

“Already tracing the comms data. He used a portable relay to mask the gas dispersal signature. Stupidly. I’ve got half the call history.”

Phainon hummed once, low.

“Should I be worried?” Anaxa added mildly.

Phainon glanced down at the man, who had started to tremble.

“Not yet.”

He raised the sword slightly—just enough to catch the light.

“But soon.”

The man coughed, choked, then rasped out a wet, miserable plea.

“Please—please, I don’t—I was just paid to—”

He reached out with one shaking hand, fingers scrabbling against the floor like he thought he could crawl to mercy.

Phainon didn’t even look interested.

He shifted his weight again, slowly, deliberately, and pressed the heel of his boot into the man’s back—right between the shoulder blades. Not enough to kill. Just enough to crush the breath from his lungs.

The man let out a garbled, half-scream. No one heard it but the walls.

Phainon tilted his head, expression unreadable. His sword hung loose in his fingers, more a promise than a threat.

“Paid by who?” he asked quietly.

The man sobbed.

“Mm.” Phainon’s gaze didn’t change. “Let’s try that again.”

By the time he gave the name, his voice was raw from screaming.

He’d started bargaining somewhere around the cracked rib, but Phainon never even flinched. He’d worked methodically—almost professionally, distant, never once raising his voice. Just questions. Then silence. Then more pain.

“Alzourin,” the man finally wheezed. “It was—it was Alzourin, I swear—he said he had ties—he said—he said I’d be safe—”

Phainon’s head tilted at that. He crouched at last, the first time he’d so much as looked the man in the eye since it started.

“Alzourin,” he repeated, voice smooth, thoughtful. “Now that… that is helpful.”

The man blinked, dazed, but alive. Hope, pitiful and blinding, sparked in his battered face.

Phainon smiled.

It was almost kind.

“Thank you,” he said, and drove the blade clean through the man’s chest.

There was no pain in the expression that followed—just confusion. Like he’d expected mercy from the devil wearing a mask.

Phainon watched the light leave his eyes.

Then stood, wiped the blood from his sword, and said evenly into the comms, “Got a name. Make sure Goldweaver never gets to it first.”

Phainon wiped his blade clean on the man’s shirt with practiced apathy. No theatrics. No pause. The body was still twitching faintly when he turned away.

He didn’t make it far—just a single step toward the stairwell—before Anaxa’s voice filtered through his earpiece again.

“I’d hold your position.”

Phainon paused.

“Why?”

“There’s movement two rooftops east. Multiple heat signatures. The gas wasn’t coming from a single source—looks like auxiliary dispersal teams. Sloppy work. Likely untrained.”

Phainon exhaled slowly, adjusting the grip on his weapon. His gaze cut toward the skyline.

“How many?”

“Three, possibly more. Patterns are erratic. But one location stands out—heavier output. Sending coordinates now.”

A soft ping followed. He crouched low, tracking the line between buildings, already recalculating his path.

“Tell me it’s not a school.”

“Condemned residential high-rise. Structurally intact. You’ll need to cross two lots and take the west exterior. And—”

Anaxa’s voice hitched for a breath.

Phainon froze.

“There’s something else,” he said. **“Near the node. Someone’s already up there.”**

Phainon shifted upright. A new feed flickered across his visor—grainy drone footage, static in the wind, barely stable. But the figure it caught was clear.

His breath stilled.

No. Not here.

A man moved through the smoke. Sure-footed. Unarmored. Supporting someone with one arm while gesturing for another to follow. His shirt was streaked in soot, sleeves rolled up, hair tousled from the heat. Familiar in every way that mattered.

It was Mydei.

Phainon’s entire body went rigid.

He wasn’t supposed to be here. Not on this building. Not in this operation. No protective gear, no comms, not even a damn mask. What the hell was he doing?

Phainon’s foot slid toward the ledge before he registered the motion.

“He’s evacuating,” Anaxa said quietly. **“Entered through the northeast stairwell. No surveillance coverage. Saw the gas. Moved on instinct.”**

Phainon didn’t speak.

His eyes stayed on the screen.

Mydei was guiding another civilian forward, moving like he belonged in the firestorm. Calm. Efficient. Like this wasn’t the first time. But something was off. His posture was stiff, movements tight. Not rushed, but deliberate—like he was one step from collapse and wouldn’t let it show.

Phainon’s fingers flexed against the rail.

He could go now. Cut across the lot, clear the building, grab Mydei before anything got worse.

But—

“Don’t,” Anaxa said, quieter now. **“You go down there, you compromise your route and him. He’s upright. He’s thinking. Let him do what he came to do.”**

Phainon didn’t answer right away.

He hated how right Anaxa was. Hated seeing Mydei there, just close enough to reach—just far enough to lose.

His jaw clenched.

Of course he’d be there. Of course he’s dragging people to safety with dust on his clothes and no plan at all.

“Tch.”

His voice was low when he finally spoke.

“He’s fine. He can handle himself.”

The words tasted like iron, but he meant them.

Phainon turned from the ledge, breath sharp, spine straight.

He had a job to finish.

Phainon was already halfway across the rooftop when Anaxa's voice came through again—brisk, exacting.

"Change of plan. There's a suppressant unit nearby."

He slowed, barely.

"Neutralizer?"

"Something close. We detected trace readings—low-range dispersion tech. Primitive but effective enough to destabilize the gas on contact. You'll want it before you hit the main site."

"Coordinates?"

"Sending."

The ping came a beat later. He veered off without hesitation.

The wind rose as he crossed the next lot, boots skidding briefly on gravel before finding grip again. His cloak snapped at his heels. Somewhere in the distance, a siren bled into static. He didn't look back.

Anaxa's voice cut through the crackle. **"It's a warehouse annex. North side. You'll want to move quickly—the emissions are thickening."**

Phainon didn't need the warning. He felt it in the air—sharp, acrid. Like something synthetic burning through metal.

The warehouse came into view two minutes later.

Which, of course, was when the ground blew up.

The explosion tore through the corner lot, flames bursting through concrete. Phainon twisted mid-air, thrown back by the shockwave—his cloak seared along the edge—but he hit the ground in a roll and came up with claws already drawn.

He didn't miss a step.

“Traps,” he muttered, darting toward cover. “Of course.”

“Improvised,” Anaxa replied. **“But targeted. Likely timed for your entry.”**

“No shit.”

He sprinted low across the debris field, dodging the next detonation by inches. Smoke split wide as he lunged over a fallen pipe. Sparks flew. One side of the building cracked and groaned under stress.

Another blast tore through the side wall just as he hit the base of the structure.

“Top of the roof,” Anaxa said. **“Confirming heat signature—neutralizer’s stored there.”**

Phainon stared up.

“Of course it is,” he muttered.

Behind him, the second floor gave a warning lurch. Metal beams shrieked under pressure. The firestorm spread quick across the structure.

He didn’t wait.

With a single breath, he launched up—claws out. Steel tore into concrete with a sharp, scraping shriek. His body arced high, legs coiled tight as he hooked himself to the nearest ledge.

The wind buffeted him. Another explosion sent debris past his side.

He climbed.

Fast.

One claw after the other, driving into the wall like fangs into bone. Every movement deliberate. Balanced. Controlled.

Flames chased him halfway up, licking at the building’s side. A window blew out near his left arm. Shards grazed his coat but didn’t slow him.

Ten feet from the roof, he shifted his weight, swung to one side, and launched off the final ledge.

He landed on the rooftop in a crouch, dust rising around his boots.

The air up here was worse—thick, metallic. Acrid.

And in the center of it all, nestled beside a half-melted vent shaft: the neutralizer.

Small. Ugly. Functional.

Phainon rose, eyes narrowing.

“Got it,” he said. “What now?”

“Activate and deploy it near the node. You’ll have sixty seconds before it stabilizes the air. After that—”

“I know.”

His voice was low and focused.

He picked it up, turned toward the chaos below, and moved.

There wasn’t time for anything else, he had yet another flight of stairs to climb after this.

The rooftop was louder than expected.

Wind keened across the jagged edges of broken scaffolding, rusted beams rattled overhead, and the neutralizer at Phainon’s back gave off a low, steady hiss, thinning the last of the gas with every breath it expelled. The air still carried smoke, acrid and chemical, but visibility had improved.

He stepped into the open slowly, bootfalls silent across the scorched concrete.

And then—he saw him.

A lone figure, dressed in sharp black, moved at the edge of the dispersal core. He circled it like it belonged to him, like he was admiring the centerpiece of a gallery, not a makeshift weapon suspended over a gas-leaking conduit.

Phainon's posture tensed.

"Someone's here," he muttered, gaze tracking the man's steady movements.

Anaxa's voice crackled through his comm. **"Confirmed. No friendly markers. I'm running facial now."**

Phainon didn't respond.

Something in the man's demeanor itched at him. He wasn't panicking. Wasn't confused. He moved with certainty. Calm. And then he bent down, examined the device, and said something to someone just out of view.

A second figure was dragged forward.

Phainon went completely still for one reason.

The reason being?

It was Mydei.

On his knees, hands bound behind his back. Head up. Shoulders square. Blood ran down one arm, staining the fabric at the seam. His jaw was tight, eyes locked forward, glaring at the man with the cool precision of someone who'd already memorized a dozen ways to kill him.

The breath in Phainon's lungs froze solid.

No gear. No support. Just Mydei in a torn shirt and that expression he wore when he was seconds from violence.

“What the hell,” Phainon whispered.

“I believe,” Anaxa said—tone neutral, almost bored—**“that might be our guy.”**

Phainon’s heart beat louder in his ears. “Alzourin?”

“Mmh. Lines up with movement reports from Sector 9. He’s been slipping through cracks for months—early parole, falsified IDs, access to tech far beyond his supposed means. Someone paid for this mess. We just found the check-writer.”

Phainon’s eyes hadn’t left Mydei.

How did this happen?

He’d been fine. Still standing. Still helping civilians not ten minutes ago. Phainon had watched him make it out of the haze—steady, methodical. Injured maybe, but not cornered.

So why is he here?

Why is he kneeling like that?

His pulse spiked.

Why did I let him stay?

Mydei was strong, of course he was strong, but this wasn’t strength. This wasn’t strategy. This was *reckless*. This was *stupid*.

Phainon’s hands flexed at his sides. The cold returned—sharp, numbing. Every instinct screamed to move. To strike. To grab Mydei and tear through the roof until nothing was left of Alzourin but blood and teeth.

But—

He froze.

Something shifted in the periphery.

Movement, fast and clumsy. A figure by the rooftop’s exit. Pale uniform. Nervous posture.

Phainon turned his head slightly, eyes narrowing behind the mask.

A vigilante.

Not one he recognized. Young. New. Maybe someone recruited recently, maybe not. Either way, he wasn’t acting like backup.

He was crouched low, hands shaking as he reached out toward a man in shadow. There was a brief exchange. Bills—thick, folded—passed quickly into the vigilante’s hand. He hesitated, then nodded, and stepped back.

A bribe.

Taken mid-crisis. In front of civilians. With Alzourin a dozen feet away.

Phainon’s expression flattened.

Not a word left his mouth.

He moved once.

There was no warning. No pause.

One clean slash.

Metal flashed in the low light, a single arc that cut the air like a guillotine—and the vigilante’s arms dropped to the ground with a dull, wet sound. Just above the elbows.

The man let out a choked scream, stumbled, collapsed.

Phainon didn’t look at him again.

He didn’t believe in vigilantes. But he believed in standards. And that man had none.

The rooftop felt quiet again. Not from silence, but from clarity.

Phainon turned his gaze back to Mydei.

His fingers tightened.

He wouldn’t let it happen again.

Not tonight.

He turned—

And saw Mydei, standing far too close to the edge.

Swaying.

One foot braced on cracked concrete, the other barely planted. Shoulders drawn taut. Head lowered like the weight of the night had finally caught up with him.

Phainon moved before he could think.

One breath, one heartbeat—and he was there.

An arm slid firmly around Mydei’s waist, pulling him back from the ledge with a grip that brooked no argument. Mydei tensed, instinctively twisting toward the touch—but Phainon was already steadying him, the line of his body acting like a barrier between Mydei and the drop.

“You’re fine,” he said, low, even. “I’ve got you.”

And for a moment, Mydei just… stared.

Wide-eyed. Breathing shallow. Shock tightening every line of his face.

Phainon knew why.

He wasn’t supposed to be here.

Not *him*. Not the Flame Reaver—the masked menace whispered about by heroes, feared by the corrupt. The vigilante who carved justice into every city block with surgical cruelty. Who showed no mercy. Who left no second chances.

And yet—here he was.

Holding him.

Mydei flinched slightly as screams rose again from behind them. The vigilante—young, foolish, now arm-less—still howled somewhere out of sight. The smell of blood was sharp in the air.

Phainon felt Mydei begin to turn. Just a fraction. Just enough to look.

His hand moved before Mydei could finish.

A gentle touch—two fingers beneath Mydei’s chin, tilting his face back toward him.

“Don’t,” Phainon said softly. “Not tonight.”

Mydei froze.

The contact wasn’t forceful. It didn’t need to be. There was something final in Phainon’s voice. Something immovable.

No more trauma for his idiotic, lovable boyfriend today. Not if he could help it. Not for *him*.

The city could burn. The rooftop could fall apart at the seams. But right now, Phainon only saw one thing worth holding onto.

And he was already in his arms.

Phainon didn’t speak as Alzourin monologued. He barely heard him, in truth. Words filtered through static—meaningless, slow, indulgent. The only

thing he registered was the strain in Mydei's body.

It was subtle—barely a falter—but Phainon felt it. The slackness beginning to settle in his frame. The faint sway of his balance, like someone leaning too close to a ledge. He was still upright, still trying to mask the weakness, but Phainon could feel it beneath his palm, humming against his ribs like a wire pulled too tight.

Then came the words that cut through everything:

"He's already marked."

Phainon's head snapped toward the sound, instinct sharp as glass.

"Poison," Alzourin continued. "Or a curse. Whichever term feels more poetic."

His fingers curled against Mydei's side. That cold, creeping pressure in his chest sharpened into something jagged. *Marked. Poisoned*. He hadn't seen a wound. No blood. That meant something internal. Inhaled? Ingested?

His mind moved fast. Faster than the fear. Faster than the dread clawing at the edges of his calm.

He scanned Mydei quickly—eyes flicking over his expression, the shape of his lips, the pallor blooming at his jawline. Still breathing. Still lucid. Whatever it was hadn't hit the brain yet. That was good. That bought him seconds. *Maybe*.

Then—an idea. Fast, precise, ugly.

Chemical dispersal. Spell tracers. Inhaled airborne agents often rooted in the sinus cavity first—especially arcane ones. Slower if the respiratory tract was disrupted.

He'd seen this kind of thing before. A binding curse with a time delay, meant to cripple the target just long enough to make them helpless. Not enough to kill them outright—not yet. Enough to make them collapse in front of an audience. A performance.

The counter?

It had to be forced out. Diluted. Interrupted.

A neutralizer.

Or something that could neutralize.

His jaw clenched. There was no time to call for Anaxa. No time to find the source and burn it out. But he'd taken the antidote earlier—on Anaxa's instruction, half-idly, not expecting to need it.

He had it in him. Right now.

His body was the filter. His bloodstream was the carrier.

And Mydei's breath was already starting to hitch.

He looked at him again—really looked. The fall of his lashes. The way his lips parted ever so slightly, unaware. He was pale now. Too pale. Still blinking, still standing, but it wouldn't last. A minute, maybe less. Then he'd crumple.

Phainon's heart pounded once, hard enough to hurt.

He could do it. This would work. This was necessary.

And gods help him—that wasn't all it was.

He took a breath and leveled his voice, crisp and direct.

"Close your eyes."

Mydei blinked at him, sluggish and confused. "Wait—"

There wasn't time.

Phainon moved.

His mask shifted just enough to bare his mouth. His hand caught Mydei's jaw—not tender, not cruel, but commanding. A pressure honed in combat, the kind meant to say *don't argue*. The other hand gripped tighter at his waist, an anchor against gravity and hesitation both.

Then—he kissed him.

No preamble.

It wasn't gentle. Their mouths collided in a way that bordered on brutal—lips sealing with precision, breath forced into breath, blood forced down as we. There was no room for anything else. Not for hesitation. Not for sentiment.

But the urgency made it worse.

Because Phainon could feel everything: the tension in Mydei's spine, the heat of his skin, the wavering fight in his breath. He could feel the way Mydei startled, tried to shift, maybe even open his eyes—

His grip crushed down for a heartbeat. A silent warning. *Don't*. He was steadying him, yes, but it was also a threat—one Mydei knew how to read. A single twitch, and Phainon would let go. He wouldn't, not ever, but Mydei didn't know that.

He stayed still.

His breath hitched—shallow and sharp—and Phainon swallowed it like a man drowning. The taste of the curse was acrid, bitter, metallic. It clung to the back of his throat. But beneath it—there he was.

That trace of Mydei, familiar and infuriating, laced with defiance even now.

It hurt.

Because gods, Phainon wanted to touch him properly. To thread a hand through his hair, to cradle his face, to kiss him slow and deep until Mydei forgot what poison was. Until *he* forgot.

But he didn’t.

Because this wasn’t about want.

He held the kiss just long enough. Just until he felt the shift—the slightest ease in Mydei’s breathing, the release of something inside his chest.

Then he pulled back sharply.

The mask snapped down. His expression vanished behind it.

But his hands didn’t move.

One stayed at Mydei’s waist. The other hovered, still near his jaw, just in case.

He didn’t speak.

He didn’t need to.

Because Mydei was still breathing.

And that was the only thing that mattered.

The moment Mydei exhaled, Phainon stilled.

Alzourin had already begun to run—boots scraping against the rooftop edge, retreat sharp and graceless. Whatever contingency he’d counted on—poison, panic, spectacle—had unraveled the instant Mydei stayed upright. The instant Phainon intervened.

It was over, and the bastard knew it.

Phainon adjusted his mask back on as his muscles coiled, ready to pursue. The air crackled with the promise of movement—smoke rising in spirals behind him, steel still fresh on his tongue. He tilted forward—

Then froze.

A breath. Fragile. Hitching.

It came from behind him, quiet as a sigh—and yet it hit louder than the detonation that had rocked the street minutes before. He turned slightly. Didn’t need to look. He already knew.

Mydei.

The sound wasn’t one of fear. Not pain either. But there was something raw in it. Strained. As if just staying conscious required more effort than he wanted to show.

Phainon’s stance eased. Slowly. The sharp edge of momentum dulled.

He breathed out through his nose, jaw tight.

“Anaxa,” he said quietly.

“Already tracking him,” came the response, unsurprised. **“He’s not gonna get far.”**

Phainon nodded once and turned.

Mydei stood where he’d left him, upright by force of will alone. His hands were braced at his sides, but the tension in his shoulders betrayed him. His eyes were clearer than before—barely—but his mouth was slack with exhaustion, chest rising in shallow pulls.

Phainon approached without a word. When he reached him, he ducked low, arms moving with calm precision. One under the knees, the other bracing his back.

He lifted him clean off the ground.

Mydei startled slightly. Not enough to recoil, just a flicker of awareness in his brow, breath catching against Phainon’s neck.

“…what—”

His voice was hoarse, a whisper dragged through smoke.

“Don’t.” Phainon murmured.

He adjusted his grip, shifting Mydei’s weight closer, steadying his breathing by sheer proximity. The air still tasted like ash, but he could feel Mydei’s pulse now—fluttering too fast under his skin, but there.

“I can walk,” Mydei mumbled after a moment.

“You can pretend to,” Phainon replied evenly.

Mydei huffed, low and amused, or maybe just tired. His head tilted slightly against Phainon’s shoulder—wary, uncertain. But he didn’t protest again.

“You’re not supposed to be…” Mydei started, the sentence falling apart halfway through. He blinked slowly, eyes unfocused.

Phainon didn’t respond.

There were too many possible endings to that sentence, and he wasn’t sure he liked any of them.

Instead, he descended the rooftop, boot treads scraping against broken concrete. Mydei’s breath warmed his neck. The rhythm of it was still uneven, but steadying. Recovering.

That would do for now.

The descent felt longer than it should have.

Each step echoed against the warped stairwell, carved through smoke and ruin. The fire above was dying, but the heat still lingered—clinging to the walls, curling under their clothes. Phainon moved carefully, arms steady around Mydei’s frame, boots grinding ash into concrete with every step.

Mydei didn’t speak.

He hadn’t since the rooftop. Not a breath, not a sound.

And that silence—it wasn’t normal. Not from him. He wasn’t the type to chatter, sure, but he always said something. A half-dry remark. A curt protest. A pulse of stubbornness just to prove he still could.

But now? Nothing.

Phainon could feel the tension in his body, the rigid discipline holding him upright even as his strength clearly faltered. His jaw was set. Eyes half-lidded. Breathing shallow. Not from pain. Not fear, either. Just… exhaustion. Deep and buried. The kind you didn’t admit to until someone else pulled you out of it.

He held him a little closer.

The mask scratched cold against his own skin, its edges sharp against the warmth he wanted to give. He could hear Mydei’s heart now—steady but slow, like it was working harder than it should. It made something twist inside him. A feeling with too many names.

He wanted to speak. He *wanted* to.

To explain. To soften. To tell him he was alright, even if he wasn’t afraid.

To tell him he would *always* come for him.

That he’d never let him fall. Never let him be alone.

He wanted to press his forehead to his, to breathe against his skin until his pulse steadied. He wanted to kiss him again—really kiss him. Without poison in the air or blood on their hands or fear in the margins.

But he couldn’t.

Not like this.

Not with the mask still up. Not with the city watching, even if no one was looking.

So he said nothing.

Just kept walking, each step measured, each breath held just long enough to keep from shaking.

And Mydei stayed silent too.

But Phainon heard every word he didn’t say.

They reached ground level just as the sirens rolled in—low, layered, and unmistakable.

Not local authorities. Special Operations.

Phainon recognized the sound immediately. It was always them in cases like this—when containment broke, when dangerous tech or arcane weapons were involved, when the air itself turned hostile. They were the kind of unit that arrived not to chase suspects, but to clean up scenes: isolate toxins, collect samples, quarantine the aftermath. Efficient. Quiet. Not heroic, not glamorous—but necessary.

He hated them on principle.

Not individually, but as an institution. For how they’d look at a dying man crying out for help and think of a statistic. For their loyalty to protocol over people. For the way they’d send people to their deaths while they lounged comfortably behind government enforced steel, always showing up thirty seconds too late.

He glanced down at Mydei, still cradled against his chest. His breathing was thin, but steady. Pale. Cold. The effects of the curse hadn’t worn off yet, and Phainon couldn’t fix that alone. Not without tipping his hand. Not without compromising everything.

Tonight wasn’t about principle.

So, he stepped out of the shadows just enough to be seen.

The response was immediate. A pair of medics peeled from the arriving team, dressed in reinforced suits, visors up, already moving with purpose. They didn’t ask questions. Didn’t even look at him properly—just zeroed in on Mydei, recognized the symptoms, and moved to act. One had a scanner. The other was already prepping a spell-seal, muttering stabilization lines under his breath.

Phainon laid Mydei down, careful with every motion. He adjusted the cloak around his shoulders before the medics reached him, tucking it close. Like armor. Or a promise.

Then he turned to leave.

But fingers caught his wrist—barely a touch, too weak to hold him, but enough to stop him.

Mydei’s voice came quiet. Rough.

“…Thank you.”

Sincerity. Quiet, reluctant, and legit sincerity.

Phainon paused.

He looked at him—really looked, just for a breath—and gave a single nod.

Then he stepped back and was gone. Slipping between the noise and movement, into the empty spaces between units, unseen and unrecognized.

They’d fix him. They had to.

He wouldn’t be far.

The wind met him first—cool, sharp, and cutting as he scaled the last ledge and vanished into the dark. The city stretched beneath him in blur and noise, but he didn’t stop.

Not until the silence returned.

Not until he was alone again.

“Are you trying to incriminate yourself?” Anaxa’s voice sliced through the calm, laced with irritation. **“You gave him your cloak?”**

Phainon groaned, dragging a hand through his hair as he paced a few feet down the gravel-strewn rooftop. “I knowww, I know. I panicked. It was a gesture. A moment. I blacked out emotionally.”

“You blacked out emotionally.”

“It was romantic!”

A beat of silence. Judging.

“Drama queen.”

Phainon sighed, flopping into a crouch near the edge of the rooftop, one hand covering his face as he temporarily took off his mask. “I peaked. If I die now, bury me somewhere poetic.”

“You’re not dying.”

“I might. Emotionally. From the shame.”

Another pause.

Phainon stayed there for a moment, arms draped loosely over his knees, wind tugging at the edges of his suit. But slowly, the curve of his shoulders shifted. The weight of the last hour crept in again, heavier now that Mydei was safe, heavier because he wasn’t.

His voice when it came again was quieter. Sharper.

“…Do you still have the location?”

The humor had gone.

Anaxa didn’t miss a beat. **“Always.”**

Phainon stood slowly.

No theatrics this time.

He reached for the hilt of his sword and drew it in one smooth motion. The metal caught the faintest gleam of citylight—silver like a promise, like justice made manifest. He turned it in his grip once, steady. Controlled.

One slash was all he needed.

But that wasn’t all he planned to do.

Mydei :
I’m sorry.

Phainon blinked down at his screen.

Phainon✴:

What happened?
Did you kill someone.
Did you touch my leftovers.

A pause.

Mydei :
I kissed someone else.

Phainon stared.

Then smiled.

He flopped back on the old couch that luckily was there, one arm tossed over his head, thumbs moving lazily over the screen.

Phainon✴:

Was he hotter than me?

Mydei :
I’m being serious.
I feel like I betrayed your trust.
Even if it was to save my own life.
It still counts. I should’ve fought it. Or told you right away.

Phainon kicked his feet in the air.

Actually kicked them. Like a teenager.

Phainon✷:

So what you’re saying is
You were thinking about me.
While kissing someone else.
Dear that’s the hottest thing you’ve ever said.

Mydei :
Phainon.
I’m trying to be honest.

Phainon✷:

And I love that for us.
I forgive you.
In fact I feel incredibly honored.
You’ve basically declared undying loyalty via mouth contact.
Very romantic.

Mydei :
You’re impossible.
But thank you.

Phainon grinned down at the phone.

Then kicked a severed arm out of his path as he stepped over the pool of blood soaking the floor.

The silence in the warehouse was thick with finality. Broken only by the faint drip of something viscous down the wall and the hum of city static outside.

Alzourin's body was sprawled across the broken concrete, head tilted back at an unnatural angle, his eyes frozen wide in disbelief—like he'd never thought it could end like this. That he'd never imagined someone could reach him.

Phainon tucked his sword away with clean, practiced grace, stepped around a chunk of ribcage, and leaned against a wall still streaked with soot.

He looked down at his phone.

Phainon✴:

You're cute when you're guilty.
I love you.

And with blood still drying on his boots and the last breath of a monster still lingering in the air, Phainon smiled.

And hit send.

Chapter End Notes

> Oh yeah I got the Iliad from my Library, YIPPYY😍😍 This chapter was less comedic than I thought it'd be, but I hope u guys still liked it.
>
> Next chapter is gonna be back to comedy and from Mydei's POV, and then idk if I wanna do it for chapter 5 or 6, but I wanna do a Godslayer Mydei x Phainon so be ready for that uhh
>
> I'll do another Flame Reaver chapter at some point with more comedy too, I just wanted to build sm up and get more of a POV into his role and all😊
>
> That's all I got to say YIPYPYYY

Chapter 4: Not All Heros Wear Capes

Chapter Summary

> A peaceful day off turns into light property damage, a tragic digital death, and deeply questionable vigilante mentorship. Somehow, it still ends with a date.

Chapter Notes

> YIPPYYY FINISHED THE CHAPTER!! Fair warning the next one is probs gonna come in like 2-3 days depending on how fast I finish my sacrificial lamb ff so be warned😍

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The strawberry parfait was almost offensively good.

Delicate layers of custard, sponge, and cream dissolved on his tongue like a sigh—soft, sweet, and unreasonably pleasant. Mydei sat at the corner window of *Bitter & Sweet*, one elbow propped against the table, the late morning sun slanting over his shoulder like an afterthought. The café had only opened last week, all pastels and woodgrain and mismatched mugs with personality, and yet here he was, already a regular.

He lifted another spoonful with methodical precision. Strawberry slice. Crushed biscuit. Whipped cream. It didn't even occur to him to smile, but there was something distinctly peaceful about the line of his shoulders.

Across from him, the other half of the café's couples-themed set menu sat untouched. A glossy, obsidian-black square of bitter espresso jelly with lemon zest and crisped sage, currently ignored in favor of sweetness.

He took another bite.

Somewhere between the caramel drizzle and the chocolate flake, a memory surfaced—brief, but sharp. The scent of smoke, his own blood—no, not his.

Someone else’s, darker than it should’ve been. The weight of a cloak pressed into his hands. The image of a man he didn’t know, or maybe knew too well.

The Flame Reaver.

He blinked. The spoon tapped gently against the glass cup. Right. That night.

The cloak had been turned in already. Standard procedure, even if the gesture had felt stranger than usual this time. The Chrysos Heirs had reacted fast—almost immediately. One of their elite containment-response units had been deployed within the hour, cordoning off the area, sweeping it for residuals, taking over the aftermath like it was a military operation. Which, technically, it was.

Mydei didn’t argue. He was one of them, after all. A vigilante, yes. But also Godslayer—one of the Chrysos Heirs’ top operatives, even if he didn’t flaunt the title.

Perks of membership: full access, full authority, and—on rare occasions like this—full emergency support.

He exhaled slowly and leaned back, spoon resting between his fingers.

The parfait really was good.

The door chimed.

Phainon strolled in like he owned the place, which, thankfully, he did not. In the span of ten steps, he managed to compliment three strangers and offend five, all with the same radiant smile and a tone that could only be described as well-meaning menace. Someone muttered something about “actors,” another about “flirts,” but Phainon just winked, found Mydei, and made his way over with the casual confidence of a man who’d once given a TED talk on charisma and didn’t remember doing it.

They’d both happened to have the day off—a rarity, considering Mydei’s secret career as an immortal black-ops vigilante and Phainon’s full-time profession as a charming academic nuisance to society—so they’d agreed to spend it together. Mydei had picked the spot. *Bitter & Sweet.*

The café’s couples pairing deal had been heavily advertised, promising a taste experience themed around contrast: one dish cloyingly sweet, the other soul-crushingly bitter. They were only served as a pair. Something about love and balance. It was ridiculous. Naturally, Phainon had agreed immediately.

When the dishes arrived, Mydei had leaned over his second parfait again with the focus of a man prioritizing joy. Across from him, Phainon stared down at his portion that looked exactly like the one from the dessert case: Still a pitch-black cube of espresso jelly, laced with activated charcoal and set atop a bed of bitter melon crisps. It was garnished with black salt, a scorched lemon wedge, and a sprig of something green and vaguely medicinal. The entire thing sat on a literal slab of slate, like it was being presented as evidence in a culinary crime.

Mydei blinked. “…You paid money for that.”

“I paid money so you could have *that*,” Phainon replied, nodding toward the parfait. “You deserve the sweet one.”

There was a moment.

Mydei didn’t move. Didn’t even blink.

Then he almost choked—not on his parfait, but on the sheer boldness of the line.

He recovered with practiced ease, face smoothing out like it hadn’t twitched at all. “…Shut up and eat your regret.”

And like a man, he did.

Phainon scooped up a bite of the jet-black abomination in front of him, posture dignified, eyes calm, like a man about to be knighted—not violently betrayed by his own tastebuds.

He chewed.

The silence that followed was deafening. His expression didn't shift so much as crack. One eye twitched. A shiver ran down his spine. Somewhere deep within him, a part of his soul packed its things and quietly moved out.

"Mmm," he said finally, voice dead and eyes hollower than the inside of a corrupt hero's apology video. "Delicious. So… complex."

Mydei didn't look at him. Just lifted another generous spoonful of parfait to his mouth, entirely unfazed. He didn't say anything. Didn't need to. The way he lingered behind the silver spoon, clearly hiding a smile, said it all.

He didn't offer to trade either.

Phainon, lips still stained with the taste of activated charcoal, lemon bitterness, and ego death, reached for his water like a man who'd just crawled out of the ruins of a desert temple. He downed it like it owed him child support.

"I'm fine," he rasped after a second, blinking. "It's…an acquired taste."

"A tragedy," Mydei murmured, still not looking up. "Is what it is."

Phainon fanned his tongue with the menu. "You know, I thought it'd be like those dark chocolate types that taste rich and expensive and maybe a little melancholy."

"And instead?"

"It tastes like if betrayal were a sweet."

Phainon was still recovering—chewing ice now—when Mydei sighed, setting down his parfait with practiced patience. "You're impossible," he muttered, then scooped a spoonful and held it out toward him.

Phainon blinked, brightening instantly. “Are you feeding me?”

“It’s either that or I let you keep eating whatever that was.”

“That’s romantic,” Phainon said, already leaning in.

“Hurry up before I change my mind.”

Phainon accepted the bite with a soft, exaggerated “*Ahh*,” like he was auditioning for a toothpaste commercial, then lit up with delight. “Oh my gods. That’s *so* good.”

“You chose the bitter one on purpose,” Mydei reminded him, flicking his spoon in accusation.

“For *you*,” Phainon said, wiping a nonexistent tear. Scratch that, after the jelly there might have actually been one. “A sacrifice in the name of love.”

“You’re not dying, you’re eating jelly.”

“Same thing.”

But then—there it was.

A smear of cream at the corner of Phainon’s mouth. Small. Harmless. Ridiculous.

Phainon didn’t notice. Kept talking. Kept smiling.

Mydei’s gaze lingered for just a second too long.

It was such a cliché. The kind you rolled your eyes at in books. Wipe it off. Lick it away. Some stupid excuse to be closer.

He wasn’t going to do any of that.

Obviously.

He just noticed it.

That was all.

Still, he couldn’t help imagining it.

Not the casual wipe—it was too tame.

He imagined leaning forward. Not to be sweet. To be *thorough*. Tongue sliding over the corner of Phainon’s mouth, then shifting—barely—to his lips.

He imagined kissing him slow. Tasting sugar and laughter and something warm.

Then deeper. Messier. Until Phainon forgot to be smug. Until he forgot his own name.

He imagined biting his lower lip, tugging it between his teeth until it was red and flushed and a little swollen.

He imagined dragging his nails down Phainon’s back, just to see if he’d shiver. If he’d swear. If he’d beg.

Mydei blinked.

Across from him, Phainon was licking the spoon clean, humming like a man who’d never had a dark thought in his life.

Mydei took a slow bite of parfait, watching him over the rim of his spoon.

He was fine.

Totally normal.

Not thinking anything weird at all.

Not at all.

Mydei sighed, already waving the server over with a resigned flick of his fingers. “One order of honey cakes,” he said. “For the idiot.”

Phainon gasped like he'd been struck, pressing a hand to his chest. "You love me~" he sang, shameless and smug and absolutely not helping his case.

Mydei didn't look at him. Didn't blink. Didn't move.

"You're ignoring me. That means it's true," Phainon added, cheerfully unbothered by the silence.

The honey cakes arrived quickly—still warm, soft, and drizzled in a light syrup that glistened under the café lighting. Phainon, undeterred by pride or presentation, popped a piece into his mouth and visibly melted.

"Oh," he breathed reverently, eyes fluttering shut. "Homely. Humble. Healing."

Mydei side-eyed him. "You're insufferable."

"Not according to these honey cakes," Phainon said, already forking up another bite. He looked so happy, so genuinely pleased with something so simple, it caught Mydei off guard.

And for a moment, Mydei just… watched him. The way his shoulders relaxed. The way his lips curved, unconsciously, around the next bite. The way the light caught in the soft strands of his hair and glinted off his lashes. He didn't say anything, didn't do anything. Just leaned on one arm, eyes fixed on the boy across the table as an inexplicable warmth bloomed behind his ribs.

He didn't smile much. But one tried to form anyway—small, tentative, honest.

And then he heard it. The sharp, unmistakable sound of a camera shutter.

His gaze snapped up.

Phainon was holding his phone, angled just so, the smuggest look known to man plastered on his face.

Click. Another one.

“You took a picture,” Mydei said, deadpan.

“I took *several*,” Phainon said proudly. “And in some of them, you look like you’re in love with me.”

“Delete that.”

“Can’t. It’s art.”

Mydei reached for his drink instead of lunging across the table. Barely.

Then he caught a glimpse of Phainon’s phone screen as the other checked the time.

“My face is your lock screen.”

Phainon didn’t even flinch. “You look radiant in natural lighting.”

Mydei *stood up.*

Phainon immediately slapped his card down on the table and waved over the server. “One sakura blossom shortcake, please!”

The server blinked. “To pair with—?”

“Strawberry parfait,” Phainon said, gesturing at Mydei. “It’s for my emotionally overachieving partner.”

Moments later, a delicate slice of cake arrived—layers of fluffy vanilla sponge alternating with whipped cream and flecks of preserved sakura, topped with light pink glaze and a single candied blossom resting delicately on top. The scent was floral and airy, the kind of thing that paired perfectly with the tartness of strawberry.

Mydei sat down. He took one bite.

Appeased.

Phainon exhaled like he'd just negotiated peace.

"See," he said, smug again. "Sweets fix everything. Including your wounded pride."

Mydei didn't answer. He just reached for the cake again and muttered, "I'm wiping your lock screen in your sleep."

"Romantic *and* threatening," Phainon said with a grin. "I *knew* you were the one."

They finished their desserts at a leisurely pace, chatting between bites like there wasn't a single looming catastrophe waiting in the wings. Phainon, now spiritually healed by sugar and the fact that he wasn't getting stabbed for the lock screen incident, leaned back in his chair like a man who had conquered the world with charm and cake.

"So," he said, licking a smudge of cream from his thumb, "how's your day been?"

Mydei stirred what was left of his parfait. "Catalogued rare manuscripts. Helped a student who somehow confused ancient romance poetry with a cursed summoning scroll."

Phainon blinked. "Okay, but you say that like it's normal. What kind of library is this?"

"A public one," Mydei deadpanned. "With extremely aggressive funding cuts."

"Right. Of course. That explains the summoning scrolls. I'm assuming next week you'll be fighting off eldritch horrors in the basement."

"I already rescheduled that for Monday."

Phainon laughed, tipping his head as he grinned at him. "Gods, I like you."

"That's sad," Mydei said, scooping the last bite of his parfait into his mouth. "You're already in too deep."

Phainon retorted with, “I’d sink gladly.”

The bill came and was paid without much fanfare—Phainon insisted on treating Mydei—before they stepped outside together, sunlight softening into gold around them. The late afternoon breeze ruffled Phainon’s hair, and Mydei reached up to fix it without thinking.

Phainon blinked, caught off guard, but didn’t move. He only smiled.

They walked hand in hand, no destination in mind, letting the city buzz around them. Their fingers brushed and curled together naturally, like they’d done it a thousand times. Phainon launched into a story about a student who had tried to win a argument by quoting a novel that didn’t exist, and Mydei listened, amused, as if this weren’t the most peaceful he’d felt all week.

“Did you ever get that issue sorted with your class assistant?” Mydei asked after a lull.

“No, but I’m choosing to pretend I did. I’ve decided if I don’t look at the problem, it no longer exists. It’s called professor’s optimism.”

“Sounds like willful ignorance.”

“See? That’s why we work. You’re the voice of reason. I’m the voice of—” Phainon paused as they passed a pigeon wearing a leaf on its head. “—of avant-garde street fashion analysis. Look at that icon.”

Mydei shook his head, the barest trace of a smile curling his lips. He didn’t let go of Phainon’s hand.

Just the two of them, walking nowhere fast, one day off in a life of secrets and chaos.

And for now, that was all he focused on.

Phainon, in a move as inevitable as the sun rising dramatically behind him, decided they were going clothes shopping.

Mydei had barely blinked before he was being towed down the boutique-lined street, hand firmly in Phainon's as if he'd lost the ability to steer himself. "You know," Mydei said as they stepped into a store lined with honey-colored wood and soft ambient lighting, "I thought we were walking off dessert."

"We *are*," Phainon said cheerfully, already scanning racks like a hawk spotting prey. "You just happen to look edible in sweaters."

The employee at the entrance looked up from her phone and paused. The new arrivals were, by all accounts, well-dressed already, but the taller one—the one with the wind-tousled hair and suspiciously good posture—was already holding three jackets and a button-up before she could even say welcome.

"You're trying all of these," Phainon said, piling items into Mydei's arms with alarming efficiency. "No arguments."

"I didn't even say anything."

"Your silence sounded judgmental."

"I was breathing."

"Exactly."

Mydei sighed, shifting the growing stack in his arms. The first fitting room they passed was already being unlocked for him, the attendant giving a vaguely impressed nod as if she, too, understood that love sometimes looked like a personal stylist with no sense of financial restraint.

Every time Mydei stepped out, Phainon straightened in his seat, legs crossed, chin in his hand like he was watching the climax of a very high-stakes romance drama.

“This is stupid,” Mydei said after the fourth outfit, turning in the mirror. “It’s just a plain knit sweater.”

“Exactly,” Phainon said dreamily. “It’s criminal how good you look in beige. Beige!”

The fifth outfit earned a low whistle. The sixth prompted a hushed, “Are you trying to end me?”

By the seventh, the employee was no longer pretending to organize anything. She stood nearby, arms folded, quietly delighted.

The eighth outfit—tailored slacks and a dark, high-necked top that hugged just the right places—brought a rare silence from Phainon.

“…That one,” he finally said. “We’re buying *that one twice.”*

Mydei blinked. “Twice?”

“In case you spill something on it. Like your own blood. Or honey.”

“You think I’m going to bleed on expensive clothing?”

“I think I’d fight someone if they made you.”

The clothes piled up at the counter like offerings to a very well-dressed deity. The total racked up with quiet brutality. The employee looked mildly stunned. Mydei looked not even mildly surprised.

“You’re not putting any of it back?” he asked as they stepped away from the register, bags in hand.

Phainon didn’t hesitate. “You were hot in all of it. I have no regrets.”

“…You bought a scarf just to ‘frame my neck.’”

“And I was right.”

Mydei paused. Adjusted the very scarf in question. “Next time I’m picking the place.”

He didn’t protest. Didn’t insist they return a few things. Because if Phainon wanted to act like a man freshly whacked in the face by Cupid’s bat, Mydei wasn’t going to stop him.

He just hoped the bat had installment payments.

The moment they stepped outside, a quiet thought floated through Mydei’s otherwise fond haze:

How the hell does a *professor* afford this?

He glanced down at the bag in his hand. The receipt poked out, curled and long, like an ominous prophecy. He tugged it free.

Then stared.

Then stared harder.

The number on it made his soul flatline for a second. There were entire black-market relics that cost less than this total. He knew Phainon’s university paid decently—very decently—but this wasn’t *decent*. This was *criminal financial decisions wrapped in tissue paper.*

“…Are you going into debt over me?” he muttered with a hint of worry, eyes still fixed in disbelief.

Before the question could blossom into an actual confrontation, Phainon plucked the bag from his hand with a flourish and a grin that could derail logic. “Don’t worry about it,” he said breezily. “I’m not spending. I’m investing.”

“In what?”

Phainon turned and walked backwards a few paces, holding the bag like it was a bouquet. “My happiness,” he said sweetly.

Mydei squinted.

The employee waved them off from the storefront window, chin resting in her hand, giving Mydei a deeply understanding look. The kind of look that said, *Could be your sugar daddy. Could be your simp. Either way? You're eating, king.*

Mydei sighed and looked away, scarf still warm around his neck, bags still heavy in his hand, and heart doing something annoying and fluttery in his chest.

He'd stop him next time.

Probably.

Maybe.

No, he wouldn't.

Evening settled in slow and golden, blanketing the city in the kind of light that made even cracked sidewalks and crumbling rooftops look poetic. The day had mellowed into that soft in-between where time felt like it could stretch out forever, and the two of them walked without any real destination—just the lazy rhythm of their steps and the soft shuffle of shopping bags swaying at their sides.

Phainon had insisted on carrying most of them, but Mydei had managed to reclaim at least one bag under the guise of fairness, which Phainon protested against and then immediately forgot about.

They passed a bakery giving out samples, a couple tangled in matching jackets taking pictures by a mosaic wall, someone's familiar fluttering overhead with a leash trailing behind it. Phainon kept glancing at them. Not the couple, not the samples—just the familiars, the pets, the companions. A dog in a bowtie trotted past with a bell on its collar and Phainon actually turned his head to watch it go.

Mydei noticed. Of course he noticed.

He let it sit for a while. Waited until they turned a corner onto a quieter street with soft lamps and window displays before saying, “Alright. Out with it.”

Phainon blinked. “What?”

“You’ve been watching every pet that’s walked by for the past ten minutes. I’m not judging. Just wondering if there’s a reason or if you’ve developed a sudden interest in domesticated creatures.”

Phainon laughed, rubbing at the back of his neck with the hand not holding six bags and a receipt that could have bought a small island. “It’s stupid.”

“Everything you say is stupid. Tell me anyway.”

He sighed, slow and a little embarrassed. “I lost my Tamagotchi.”

Mydei blinked. That was… not what he expected.

Phainon looked weirdly solemn. “I think I left it at your place last time I stayed over. I forgot about it until yesterday, and by then, I figured it was probably dead. And I know it’s just a dumb virtual pet, but I don’t know. I got attached to it.”

There was a beat. The air smelled like baked sugar and concrete.

Mydei stopped walking. He shifted the bag in his hand and reached into the inner pocket of his coat—then pulled something out and held it up between two fingers.

A Tamagotchi. Alive and well.

The screen lit up with a cheerful jingle, the pixelated creature bouncing in joy, little sparkles glittering around it. Clean. Fed. Very much not dead.

Phainon stared. “You’re joking.”

“Found it after you left,” Mydei said. “Been keeping it alive since.”

Phainon took it like it was a holy relic. Like he’d just been handed a second chance at life. He cradled it with both hands, bags rustling at his sides, and stared at the screen with a reverence that made Mydei feel like he was the weird one for not bowing.

Then, with all the seriousness in the world:

“I’m going to marry you.”

Mydei sighed. “Slow down.”

He didn’t look at Phainon. Just kept walking.

Didn’t stop the faint flush on his ears, though.

Internally? *Yeah. Same thought.*

They rounded a narrow alley—not because it was a shortcut or even remotely scenic, but because Phainon had seen a street cat with a heart-shaped marking on its back and absolutely *had* to follow it for photographic evidence. Mydei, who’d been dragged along mid-sentence and was now holding three shopping bags in one hand and a fourth looped around his wrist, said nothing.

He simply watched the cat disappear under a dumpster and then turned a slow look toward his companion.

Phainon, crouched like a hopeful cryptid with his phone out, was already sighing in disappointment. “It was perfect. Like a fuzzy little love confession.”

“I’ll be confessing something in a minute if you don’t keep walking.”

“Is it that you adore me?”

“No,” Mydei said, adjusting the scarf Phainon bought him out of spite and affection. “It’s that if I throw one of these bags at your head, it’s going to

hurt.”

Phainon laughed, stood, and bumped their shoulders together lightly. “You’re fun when you’re violent.”

They continued down the alley, shopping bags rustling softly between them. The sky had shifted from amber to rose, that soft twilight stretch where everything looked a little romantic, a little too quiet, the sort of lull that begged for gentle conversation and—

From the side, someone cleared their throat.

They hadn’t even made it halfway through the alley when four figures slipped out from the shadows with all the subtlety of a group cosplay gone rogue. One had a baseball bat. Another had what looked like a repurposed bike chain. All wore matching expressions of low-level menace and budget intimidation.

Mydei blinked. *Oh good. The Discount Delinquents have arrived.*

The one in front stepped forward, cocky. “Wallets. Bags. Phones. Now.”

Phainon took one glance, tilted his head, and murmured, “Really? You’re mugging us? In *this* economy?”

The guy with the bat scowled. “Try us.”

Mydei casually lowered one bag to the ground. It clinked. Phainon caught the sound and, without looking back, lifted his arm across Mydei’s chest—barely there, just a casual sweep of motion. A line drawn with his body: *Stay behind me.*

His smile didn’t drop, but it changed—less sparkle, more steel.

“Listen,” he said, tone still gentle. “You really don’t want to do this. There are heroes on patrol. City’s on edge after the last attack. You get caught with a weapon and attempted robbery? That’s not just gonna be a fine.”

“Then hand it over and we won’t get caught.”

Phainon shifted slightly. The bags on his arm swayed.

“I just spent a *lot* of money on tailored sweaters and an offensively expensive candle shaped like a duck,” he said, voice smooth but cool now, like honey drizzled over a knife’s edge. “And I’m going to be honest—I’m not in the mood to be inconvenienced.”

He smiled wider. It didn’t reach his eyes.

The air changed.

Mydei, who hadn’t moved, simply lifted his gaze and stared at the closest mugger like he was already cataloging how hard he’d hit the wall when thrown. He said nothing. Didn’t need to.

For the first time, the thugs hesitated.

Phainon took one small step forward, arm extended in the least-threatening gesture known to man—palms up, voice even, the faint *beep* of the Tamagotchi still chirping faintly in his hand.

“Look, we don’t want trouble. You can take the bags,” he said, all airy calm and professor-level diplomacy. “Just let us leave with our bones and dignity intact. And this.” He lifted the tiny toy slightly. “He has a job interview tomorrow.”

Mydei exhaled, barely stifling a huff. *Even now?*

One of the muggers—a guy who looked like he got kicked out of villain school for being too cliché—snorted. “What, this your emotional support keychain?”

He stepped forward.

Then, without hesitation or ceremony, *smacked* Phainon’s hand aside.

The Tamagotchi flew from his grip.

It hit the pavement with a crack so loud it felt personal. A glitchy buzz stuttered from the cracked screen before it sputtered out entirely, dark and dead.

Everything kept moving for a second—shouts, movement, threats. The muggers didn't even register what they'd done. Just kept circling like budget hyenas.

But Mydei did.

And Phainon—Phainon just *stopped*.

His hand hovered midair, fingers still slightly curled as if the toy were still there. He stared at the shattered remains on the ground with a look of quiet devastation. His mouth opened a fraction, but no sound came out. His brows knit, just slightly, like the grief was settling before it even had a name.

The streetlight above flickered once.

Mydei turned toward him fully, watching with new focus.

"…Are you good?" he asked low, cautious.

Phainon gave a faint, brittle smile. "Totally." His voice cracked slightly. "I mean, I only raised him for a week. Taught him how to eat. How to bathe. Taught him love."

Mydei blinked. The thugs yelled louder. One of them laughed.

Phainon didn't.

He crouched down slowly, collecting the broken Tamagotchi with deliberate care—as if he were picking up a fallen comrade on the battlefield. He turned it over once in his palm. The screen was fried. There was a tiny crack running through the casing.

He took a slow, deep breath. When he stood, he was composed. Polished, even. But something underneath had iced over. His eyes weren't soft

anymore.

He slipped the broken toy gently into his pocket.

“Mydei,” he said calmly. “If I die tonight, avenge me.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow. “You’re not dying.”

“True,” Phainon murmured, lifting his gaze toward the circling muggers. “They are.”

And this time, the streetlight didn’t flicker.

It just went out.

Mydei didn’t rush.

He reached out, tugged Phainon gently back by the front of his shirt—and, with the calmest casualness in the world, pressed a kiss to his cheek.

It was a subtle thing. Quick. Dismissive, almost.

But Phainon went still like someone had cast a spell. Bags still looped around one wrist. Broken Tamagotchi cupped delicately in both hands like a drowned mouse. His mouth parted. His lashes fluttered. He looked like he’d just witnessed a marriage proposal, a live execution, and a one-man opera all in one breath.

Mydei stepped forward.

Behind him, Phainon remained frozen. Perfectly still. Gorgeously lit by the dying streetlamp. *The light caught in his curls*, he noted. One of the thugs actually glanced at him mid-fight like *who is that*—before promptly getting kicked in the ribs so hard he folded like paper.

The beatdown wasn’t fair.

Mydei didn’t let it be.

He moved like he’d decided gravity was optional. Every motion compact, controlled, efficient. One attacker rushed—Mydei ducked under his swing and drove a heel into the back of his knee. The man dropped with a strangled yell and didn’t get back up. Another came from the side; Mydei turned, caught his shoulder, and flipped him clean over like he was weightless. The sound of bones hitting concrete echoed sharp and final.

Nobody landed a hit on him.

Someone tried to grab his scarf. He didn’t even glance over—just seized the offending wrist, twisted until something snapped, and used the momentum to throw the guy into a dumpster.

Even the dumpster looked surprised.

Phainon remained off to the side, hands still clasped around the Tamagotchi remains like a grieving widow. His expression flickered between awe and *how dare this be hot.* A piece of glass crunched under his boot as he adjusted his stance—only to immediately stop, glancing down in vague horror as if worried about scuffing his shoe.

By the time the last thug scrambled away, breath hitching, Mydei didn’t even break stride. He rolled one shoulder back, adjusted his scarf again, and let out a quiet exhale like he’d just finished a workout, not a war.

He turned back toward Phainon.

Still there. Still cradling that ruined Tamagotchi like it needed last rites. Still pretty.

Mydei gave him a look. Phainon blinked.

“…You kissed me,” he said softly, like the thought had just now made it to the front of the line in his brain.

“I also flattened a small gang.”

“Yeah,” Phainon breathed. “You really did. I think I ascended for a moment.”

Mydei stepped forward, took the shattered plastic from his hands, and tucked it into his coat pocket alongside his keys.

“You looked like you needed saving.”

Phainon blinked again. “From what, emotional stability?”

Mydei handed him one of the shopping bags.

Mydei responded while repressing another sigh, “From yourself.”

They didn’t speak at first.

The alley was quieter now—save for the occasional groan, the steady drip from a broken pipe, and the sound of Phainon gently shifting one of the shopping bags back up his wrist, like he hadn’t just witnessed the love of his life send five men to the ER without breaking a sweat.

He still looked a little stunned.

Still clutching the strap of his coat. Still standing like he was halfway between proposing and fainting.

Finally, after a long moment, he said, softly:

“I want to say thank you. But I also want to dump you a little.”

Mydei, adjusting his sleeves, didn’t look over. “Why?”

“You let my Tamagotchi die.”

“You lost your Tamagotchi.”

“It was an accident.”

“I kept it alive for a week.”

“A week and a *half*,” Phainon corrected, which only made his case worse. “We were bonding. I named him after you.”

That got Mydei to look at him. Slowly.

Phainon pressed on like a man who had never once felt shame. “He had your discipline. Your emotional distance. Your raw, feral edge when hungry.”

Mydei blinked.

“You’re making this worse for yourself,” he said.

“I’m mourning,” Phainon insisted, straightening. “Don’t silence my grief.”

There was a brief beat of silence as Mydei glanced over the alley one more time. Unconscious bodies. Broken glass. A smear of blood halfway up a wall like it got lost trying to escape.

Phainon, in the center of it all, dressed like a vintage romantic drama and still somehow managing to look tragic instead of ridiculous.

Mydei sighed.

“I’ll buy you another one,” he said flatly.

Phainon blinked. “…Really?”

“No. I’m lying to keep you from crying.”

“Too late,” Phainon whispered. Then looked down at the bags in his arms. “But thank you for your service. And for letting me be uselessly decorative.”

“You do it very well.”

“Thank you,” he said again, quieter this time. “For real.”

Mydei didn’t answer, but his expression softened.

Just slightly.

But then a sharp metallic *clang* cut through the alley like punctuation.

One of the dazed muggers—brave, or perhaps just stupid—had managed to crawl upright. He didn't get far.

A glowing baseball bat came down on him with a satisfying *WHAM*, and the man hit the ground like a sack of wet cement.

Standing over him was a figure in a star-dusted varsity jacket, glowing softly at the seams. The end of his bat pulsed faintly with pale light, as though it had been dipped in the cosmos. A matching cap shadowed his face, tilted at just the right heroic angle.

"Fear not," he declared dramatically, flipping the brim of his cap up with one finger. "Justice has arrived."

Mydei stared.

Phainon blinked once. Then, with the poise of a long-suffering mentor, clasped his hands behind his back and intoned, "Galactic Baseballer. A pleasure."

The hero's grin widened under the shadows of his cap.

"You've got a lot of nerve picking this alley," he said to no one in particular, giving one of the bodies a mild nudge with the toe of his sneaker. "This is my territory."

"I thought your territory was the arts building," Mydei muttered.

"Quiet," Caelus whispered, stage-whisper serious.

"My office is there," Mydei continued blandly. "This is just off campus. You're not even patrolling your own map."

Phainon turned slightly, face bright with indulgence. "Let the hero work, Mydei. It's important to support youth initiatives."

“Do youth initiatives usually come with glowing weapons and probable head trauma?”

“Only the good ones.”

The Galactic Baseballer, completely unfazed, adjusted his grip and nudged another groaning thug with the bat.

THWACK.

No more groaning.

“You ever heard of choosing better targets?” Caelus called, though it was unclear if he was addressing the unconscious or the air. “No? Guess I’ll just make the lesson stick.”

He punctuated this by hauling one of the larger thugs over his shoulder like a laundry sack. His bat slung onto his back with a casual magnetic click.

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “You still haven’t returned your books.”

Caelus whipped around. “Why is everyone bringing that up tonight?”

“They’re mythological encyclopedias,” Mydei said. “In Latin. You do not read Latin.”

“It’s for aesthetic immersion!”

Phainon coughed gently. “He cited three Instagram infographics, two Tumblr posts, and a tweet thread last essay.”

“They were annotated,” Caelus huffed, grabbing the second goon and starting to drag him by the collar. “And accurate. I fact-checked.”

“With what?”

“…More tweets.”

Mydei didn’t even blink. “Return the books.”

“You’re ruining my mystique.”

“I don’t believe you have mystique.”

The hero groaned, defeated, but didn’t stop dragging bodies out of the alley like it was just another Wednesday. The soft glow of his bat, swinging gently from its strap, left streaks of pale blue across the ground.

As he reached the mouth of the alley, he turned back with a grin. “Well,” he called, “guess this night’s wrapped up! Tell Professor Phainon I said hi!”

Phainon raised a hand in correction. “Caelus, I am Professor Phainon. You missed our last debate tournament,” he said mildly. “Very irresponsible behavior for a hero.”

“I was fighting crime.”

“And losing participation points.”

Caelus blinked. “Okay, you know what? Whatever, I have a life. Later.” Just as he was about to leave, Caelus turned around and yelled, “Tell Stelle I’m cooler than she is!”

Phainon waved with two fingers. “Will do.”

And just like that, the Galactic Baseballer vanished into the dark—bat on his back, unconscious criminals in tow, whistling something suspiciously heroic. The glow from his jacket flickered like a misplaced constellation before he disappeared around the corner.

There was a long beat of silence.

Then Phainon turned, voice perfectly neutral. “He once cried when I played the opposing side during a mock debate.”

“Now he’s possibly concussing strangers.”

Phainon hummed, his voice somewhat fond. “Growth.”

Mydei rubbed his temple. “Your influence is catastrophic.”

“Thank you.”

And with that, they returned to their stroll—Phainon quietly radiant, Mydei quietly resigned, and justice, very dubiously, served behind them.

Distant city sounds filtered back in—the low hum of traffic, a siren somewhere far off—but here, beneath the pale reach of the streetlamps, it felt oddly hushed. Private.

Phainon adjusted the shopping bags in his hands. Mydei’s coat, folded neatly over one arm, had somehow survived the whole incident unscathed. Of course it had. Phainon would have committed murder over a bloodstain.

They walked a few steps more. Then Phainon stopped.

Mydei turned—just as Phainon stepped in, close and without warning, and kissed him on the cheek.

It was a soft thing. Simple. Just the faintest brush of lips beneath the eye, a hand lightly grazing Mydei’s sleeve for balance. Chaste, in theory.

But the angle. The closeness.

Deadly.

“My hero,” Phainon murmured, with all the flair of someone bestowing knighthood. “I’m positively swooning.”

Mydei exhaled, exasperated. “You’re so dramatic.”

Phainon leaned in further, just enough to brush his mouth near Mydei’s ear, breath warm against the skin.

“Does my hero,” he murmured, “want to claim his reward?”

Mydei didn’t move. Not right away.

Phainon tilted his head, just enough to clarify—soft, smug, and deeply unfair:

“A bath. A massage. Me.”

Mydei’s ears turned red. Entirely red. The tips looked like they might combust on contact.

“I just committed six misdemeanors,” he muttered.

“And I’m offering reparations,” Phainon said brightly. “Very hands-on ones.”

Mydei groaned. “You’re unbelievable.”

“And yet,” Phainon said, stepping closer, “you haven’t walked away.”

Mydei opened his mouth, but whatever retort he had dissolved as Phainon’s smile curved into something warmer. Not just teasing. Not just smug.

Affectionate.

And just a little bit daring.

“…The bath sounds fine,” Mydei muttered, eventually.

“Oh?” Phainon stepped beside him. “Not the massage?”

A beat.

Then, quieter: “Maybe the massage.”

Phainon grinned. “And me?”

Mydei let out the slowest sigh in recorded history. Took the shopping bags from his hand like it was a peace offering. Then turned, muttering, “Come on.”

“Where are we going?” Phainon asked, delighted, matching his pace.

“My place.”

Phainon blinked. “Is that where the bath is?”

No answer.

“Massage?”

Silence.

“…Me?”

Still no answer.

But Mydei’s face was pink. And he didn’t look back. Just kept walking.

Phainon followed, smug and satisfied.

The city around them buzzed quietly, neon and soft shadows folding back into place. Somewhere behind them, the alley faded into memory. The Tamagotchi had long since passed into digital oblivion. The jacket still looked perfect. The criminals were concussed. Galactic Baseballer had vanished into the night, whistling off-key.

And Phainon—still smiling, still unfair—had absolutely no intention of letting his hero sleep alone tonight.

Chapter End Notes

> Hmmmmm, comment any ideas u have on a chapter, and I’m 99% sure I’m writing it. This is slice of life so literally anything would fit😭
>
> But yes they make me SCREAMMRJRJDJDJD

Chapter 5: How to Lose a Fancy Date in 10 Seconds

Chapter Summary

> Phainon suffers. From sickness, from his boyfriend's betrayal (he can cook?!), and from the sheer humiliation of forgetting their fancy date night. But somehow, between dodging Mydei's concern, getting aggressively nursed back to health, and nearly exposing his secret life, he still ends up exactly where he wants to be—wrapped up in Mydei's arms. Not a bad way to end the night.

Chapter Notes

> I'm so consistent with updates

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon followed at a leisurely pace, each step echoing through the empty corridors like a promise. A quiet, patient promise.

Mydei was running.

Not in that graceful, confident way he always carried himself, but something *messier*. Desperate. His breaths were sharp and uneven, his shoulders tight with barely restrained panic. Every few steps, he glanced back, as if checking that Phainon was still behind him—as if he had any doubts.

Oh, he was watching. He hadn't looked away for a second.

It was intoxicating, really, the way Mydei's pulse must be hammering against his skin, the way his muscles tensed like a trapped animal's. Did he realize how much he gave away? How every stagger, every quickened breath, only made him more irresistible?

Phainon could hear it—*the fear*. Feel it, even from here, curling in the air like a fine perfume. He let it linger, drinking it in, savoring the sight of Mydei's back as he fled.

And still, he did not run.

There was no need.

Mydei was fast, but fear made fools of even the strongest men. His steps were rushed, reckless, and he made a fatal mistake—turning too sharply at the end of the corridor, misjudging the space. His back collided with the cold wall, and for a split second, his entire body stilled.

It was all Phainon needed.

He closed the distance between them in an instant, pressing forward, *crowding* into Mydei's space as his hands found purchase against the wall beside his head. Mydei sucked in a breath, but there was nowhere to go now, no more space to flee. His throat bobbed as he swallowed, lips parting just slightly, eyes blown wide with something raw—something teetering between fear and anticipation.

Phainon leaned in slowly, deliberately, letting his breath fan against Mydei's cheek before dipping his head lower, lips ghosting just above his racing pulse. *So fragile*, he thought. If he wanted, he could press just a little closer, let his teeth graze that sensitive skin—feel the warmth, the quickening beat of his heart beneath his lips.

"Mydei," he murmured, voice a low rasp, silk spun over steel. "Why do you run?"

His answer was a sharp inhale, the tightening of his fingers against the wall as if searching for something to hold onto. He didn't speak, didn't move, only watched him with those deep, piercing eyes, as if torn between defiance and surrender.

It was beautiful.

Phainon smiled against his throat, lips barely brushing his skin. His fingers twitched against the cold stone beside Mydei's head, aching with something wicked and possessive.

Then, ever so slowly, he tilted his head—his lips parting, teeth just barely grazing the soft skin of Mydei's neck.

And Mydei shuddered.

Phainon let his teeth skim Mydei's throat, savoring the way he trembled beneath him. His lips parted—this was it. He could feel Mydei's pulse thudding wildly, his entire body taut with anticipation, with fear—

"AND—CUT!"

Phainon immediately abandoned all pretense of menace, his lips pulling into a delighted grin as he all but *smashed* his face against Mydei's neck. He nuzzled into his skin with all the enthusiasm of an overgrown golden retriever, practically *vibrating* with affection.

"Mydeiii," he whined climatically, refusing to budge an inch despite the exasperated groan from the man currently pinned beneath him. "I like it here. So warm. So comfy."

"Get. Off," Mydei gritted out, shoving at his shoulders with all the strength of someone who deeply, *deeply* regretting every life choice that led to this moment.

"Noooo," Phainon hummed, rubbing his cheek against Mydei's with such force it was a miracle neither of them got friction burns. "You smell nice. Like expensive soap and sweets."

"That was perfect!" March 7th all but sang, practically skipping towards them with her camera in hand, beaming like she just won an Oscar. "I'm definitely getting an A for this."

"Glad one of us is happy," Mydei muttered, still trying and failing to pry Phainon off of him.

Phainon, meanwhile, was far too busy reminiscing about how exactly he got himself into this situation.

It all started when March 7th—student, menace, and self-proclaimed creative genius—had been given a film project for her university course. Something about narrative storytelling in visual media. Phainon didn't really know the details. He had stopped listening after she said the words film project because the sheer look of *desperation* on her face told him exactly where this was going.

She had decided on a cliché vampire romance (of course she did), but there was one tiny problem—*all* of her friends were mysteriously unavailable.

Dan Heng, her ever-so-patient friend, had like ten different majors to juggle. Stelle, who could probably pull off being a vampire if she tried, had apparently chosen *cleaning her toilet* over acting. Which, honestly, Phainon kind of respected.

So, naturally, March 7th had gotten desperate.

And in that desperation, she had done something truly unhinged—

She had gone to an entirely *different department* and asked him, Phainon, a *debate professor,* to star in her little vampire movie.

He should have said no.

He *tried* to say no.

But then she hit him with the puppy-dog eyes, and his poor, bleeding heart caved faster than Mydei when confronted with a serious conversation about feelings.

Speaking of Mydei.

Getting him on board had been… a process.

Phainon had spent *hours* convincing him. Hours of bargaining, cajoling, and even resorting to the dirtiest trick in the book—*pouting*. And, in the

end, Mydei had relented. Probably out of sheer exhaustion.

And now here they were.

“Mydei, my love, my *eternal muse*,” Phainon drawled lovingly, finally pulling back just enough to look at him. “You were *incredible*. So *convincing*. I almost believed you were actually terrified of me.”

“I was terrified of you,” Mydei deadpanned.

Phainon beamed. “Acting! Amazing! My talented boy.”

“I will throw you into the sun.”

Phainon only snuggled closer.

March 7th, completely ignoring their nonsense, cheerfully checked the footage on her camera. “Yup! This is *gold*. Profess—uh, *Phainon*, you’re gonna be the best hot vampire ever.”

Phainon preened. “You flatter me.”

Mydei looked into the camera like he was in *The Office*.

Phainon was still grinning like a fool when he leaned in, his breath warm against Mydei’s ear. Mydei barely had time to react before—

Sharp teeth nipped at the tip of his ear.

Mydei shoved him. Hard.

Phainon went flying back with a delighted laugh, dodging a half-hearted attempt from Mydei to punch him square in the jaw. “Aww, you’re blushing~”

“I am *not* blushing.”

“Then why are your ears red?”

“They’re *always* red!”

“Uh-huh. Sure, honey.”

March 7th giggled as she checked the footage. “You two have way too much chemistry for this.”

Phainon wiggled his brows. “It’s called dedication to the craft.”

“It’s called being insufferable,” Mydei muttered, adjusting his now thoroughly wrinkled clothes.

Phainon ignored him, stretching his arms dramatically before flashing them both a dazzling smile. “Welp, that was fun! I’ll take my break now—be right back~”

And just like that, Phainon strutted off with all the confidence of someone who had never once in his life been bested. The laughter still lingered in his throat as he waved over his shoulder, utterly unbothered by Mydei’s very real threat of violence.

But the second he turned the corner, out of sight—

His soul left his body.

Gone was the smug grin. His posture *collapsed*. His swagger became a stiff shuffle. His face blanked out, eyes dead, like a puppet that had just had its strings severed.

He barely made it to the break room. The second he pushed the door open, he practically dragged himself inside, every step echoing the quiet agony of his existence.

A few students, clearly deep in conversation, turned to look at him.

Their expressions immediately shifted from casual disinterest to mild horror.

Phainon ignored them. His legs barely worked. His body *screamed* with each movement, the dull ache in his right side pulsing with every step. The bruise stretched over his waist like some grotesque inkblot, a brutal reminder that—

Oh yeah. He fell off a skyscraper last night.

Well, technically, he'd been caught mid-fall by something before he could go full street pancake, but that something had barely slowed him down before dropping him straight onto the pavement anyway.

The landing? *Awful.*

Right side first, bones rattling, nerves screaming, dignity *obliterated*. He had just laid there for a minute afterward, staring at the night sky, wondering if he should just start paying rent to the asphalt since he seemed to end up there so often.

And now? The bruising looked like he had angered a god and been smited accordingly. It wasn't as bad as it looked, but *holy shit* did it hurt.

To top it off, because the universe apparently hated him on a personal level, he also woke up this morning with a *fever*.

Phainon grabbed a coffee cup with the hands of a man holding on for dear life.

The students at the nearby table watched in quiet horror as he filled it to the brim with boiling hot, pitch-black coffee—and then, without even waiting for it to cool, downed the entire thing in one go.

No reaction.

Not even a blink.

A freshman *gasped* audibly. Someone else scooted their chair away.

Phainon exhaled sharply, staring at the empty cup in his hand like it had personally failed him.

He debated getting another one but decided against it—not because it was a bad idea, but because it wasn't *bad enough.*

Instead, he shuffled toward a chair and all but collapsed into it, groaning as if he was on his deathbed. His head hit the table with a dull *thud*.

A long, suffering sigh escaped him.

One of the students hesitantly leaned toward their friend. "Is… is he okay?"

"I don't think so," their friend whispered.

Phainon tuned them out. He just wanted to sit here and marinate in his own suffering.

With the last remaining ounce of his strength, he lifted his head just enough to glare at his empty coffee cup. His voice came out a hoarse, miserable mutter:

"Perfect day."

And then, once again, he lay slumped over the table like a corpse abandoned in the middle of a battlefield.

For a brief, fleeting moment, he actually considered just giving up. Just lying here forever, letting the universe claim his body and soul.

This is fine, he thought, staring into the table like it could open a portal to another dimension. *This is where I die. At least the pain will end.*

But no. His suffering was far from over.

With the most painful moan known to man, he forced himself to move, stretching his arms up—

—*and immediately regretted it.*

Agony. Terror. A betrayal deeper than any greek tragedy.

It felt like someone had taken a flaming sledgehammer and *slammed* it directly into his right side. His ribs screamed. His muscles *sang the song of their people—and their people were all dead.*

For a brief moment, his brain was *forcibly ejected from his body.* He saw the other side. It was cold. Unforgiving.

One of the students at the next table over stopped mid-sip of their coffee, eyes wide as they watched Phainon freeze, tremble, and then very, very carefully lower himself back down with all the grace of a dying animal.

He clutched his side. Inhaled. Exhaled.

“This is actual bullshit,” he muttered.

There was a beat of silence.

Then—

Divine Enlightenment.

Like the *second coming of the Buddha himself*, Phainon rose.

Slowly, dramatically, his body straightened. The tension *melted* from his shoulders. His breathing evened out, his expression softened—no, *serenely transformed*—into an easy, relaxed smile.

His posture, once hunched in despair, became that of a man with *infinite* wisdom and composure.

His aura radiated nothing short of inner peace.

And that peace?

Was a lie.

The students gawked.

The girl who had watched him suffer so miserably just seconds before slammed her cup onto the table, looking personally offended at the mockery of human existence unfolding before her.

Another, barely whispering*: "That's not a real person."*

"And here I thought I was fake."

"Look at Ken 2.0 over there…"

Someone crossed themselves.

Meanwhile, Phainon, now fully reborn as a divine being, dusted off his sleeves, casually adjusted his collar, and sauntered past the judgmental crowd like an untouchable deity.

He threw up a charismatic wave, flashing a smile that could charm the devil himself.

"Later," he said smoothly, voice silk and honey.

And then, as though a god descending from the heavens, he left.

Because he had a film to finish.

Phainon strode back onto the set with the confidence of someone who absolutely did not just transcend mortal suffering through sheer force of will.

His energy was pristine. Controlled, even.

And then he stopped. Blinked.

"…Where's my very attractive and endlessly amusing boyfriend?"

March 7th turned from reviewing the footage on her camera, hands still adjusting the settings. "Oh, Mydei? Yeah, he left."

Phainon tilted his head, processing. "…What?"

“Said he had an emergency.”

Phainon squinted.

March 7th barely looked up as she casually scrolled through her clips. “Something about saving the city.”

A beat of silence.

Then Phainon snorted, crossing his arms. “Oh, come on. That’s cheating. He could’ve at least come up with a real excuse.”

March hummed, not questioning it.

At the same time, Phainon was now mentally filing through all the absolutely ridiculous things Mydei had done under the guise of *“saving the city”* before—

Like that time he *single-handedly* stopped a ten-car pileup just by *existing* at the right place at the right time. Or the time he “heroically” helped an old lady with groceries and acted like it was an epic quest of destiny. Or that one time he wrestled a loose sheep in the middle of a university campus, saying *“someone had to do it.”*

Phainon shook his head, grinning. “I swear, he says stuff like that so dramatically—”

(Meanwhile, somewhere across town, Mydei was absolutely *demolishing* a group of armed criminals, hurling one through a window and *suplexing another into the pavement.*)

Phainon chuckled fondly. *He’s so silly.*

March 7th snapped her fingers. “Oh, yeah, he said he’ll see you later.”

“Mm. Alright.”

Phainon didn’t think much of it. He was still mentally distracted by how dramatic Mydei was being.

Instead, he rolled up his sleeves and looked at March 7th, his usual easygoing charm settling into place. “Well, in the meantime, what else needs doing?”

March 7th lit up immediately, practically sparkling with joy as she spun on her heel to face him fully.

“Ohhh, you wanna help? That’s great! I was this close—” she held up her fingers an actual inch apart, “—to losing my mind because Stelle and Dan Heng are *useless* and you’re literally my last hope.”

Phainon chuckled, ruffling her hair without hesitation. “You say that like I wasn’t already the best choice.”

She huffed, swatting at his hand. “Okay, debatable,” Was that a pun? It definitely was, “but I’m too happy to argue.”

She handed him a clipboard. “Alright, you’re officially my assistant-slash-pack mule.”

“I am so honored.” He mock-bowed, flipping the clipboard. “What’s first, my mighty director?”

March clasped her hands behind her back, rocking on her heels. “Help me set up the lighting for this next shot, oh mighty professor.”

“Say no more.”

And just like that, he got to work.

Phainon made himself useful.

Which, honestly, wasn’t hard—he liked being helpful, and March 7th was very easy to help. Mostly because she had the energy of a baby bird that had just been given coffee and needed someone to keep her from spiraling.

So, for the next hour, he adjusted lighting, held up props, carried equipment, and even made sure she remembered to eat while she ran around orchestrating her masterpiece.

At one point, he physically had to turn her away from the camera and push a granola bar into her hands. “Eat.”

March took an exaggerated, reluctant bite. “Ugh. This is what hell tastes like…”

Phainon arched a brow. “March. It’s chocolate chip.”

“Exactly.”

He sighed. *This child.*

Still, her enthusiasm was contagious, and despite the chaos, Phainon found himself genuinely enjoying himself.

“Alright, so this next shot?” March spun dramatically, eyes gleaming. “It’s supposed to be cinematic. Think: high contrast, deep shadows, the very essence of mystery and intrigue.”

Phainon, adjusting a light stand, nodded along. “So, basically every shot you’ve taken of Mydei so far.”

March gasped, clutching her chest like he’d just spoken truth beyond her comprehension. “Oh my God. *You get it.”*

Phainon smirked, tightening a bolt. “Of course I do. He’s the most photogenic man alive. Did you see the way his jacket flared earlier? *That’s pure power.”*

March sighed dreamily. “Right? Honestly, if I wasn’t *terrified* of him, I’d have asked him to model for me ages ago.”

Phainon hummed. “Oh, same.”

They shared a look, then *cackled like gossiping old ladies.*

By the time the sun dipped below the horizon, casting the campus in a soft amber glow, the shoot was finally winding down.

Phainon had helped with everything from holding reflectors to physically stopping March 7th from using a fog machine indoors *(“March, I am begging you to think about the fire alarms.”)*. Now, as she reviewed the last few takes with a gleeful sparkle in her eye, he finally saw his chance to escape.

With a lazy stretch, he grinned and ruffled March’s hair one last time—because it was fun watching her squawk in protest.

“Alright, kid. I’m off.”

March swatted at him, but she was smiling. “Finally. Go be free.”

Phainon chuckled, stuffing his hands in his pockets. “Don’t miss me too much.”

March beamed. “Bye Professor!”

He winked and turned toward the exit, stepping outside into the cool evening air.

And immediately sighed in relief.

Finally. Peace. Quiet. No more fake vampire nonsense, no more dramatic lighting setups, no more—

A sudden gust of wind blasted through the quad.

Phainon barely had a second to register it before his bag *exploded.*

Papers. Everywhere.

Like a scene straight out of a sad indie film, loose sheets took flight—gracefully, mockingly—scattering across the pavement in slow-motion betrayal.

Phainon stood there, stunned, as his entire night’s worth of work transformed into a chaotic confetti storm.

“…Oh, you’ve got to be kidding me.”

The wind howled. The papers *danced*.

And so, the chase began.

Phainon bolted after them, narrowly avoiding trampling over a very confused teenager. *“Move, move, move—”*

One paper soared *majestically* onto a tree branch. Another *cartwheeled* into a fountain. One somehow made it inside a passing cyclist’s backpack *(he’s never seeing that one again).*

He hated this. He hated this so much.

After several minutes of desperate, parkour-level retrieval *(and only mild public humiliation)*, Phainon finally managed to scoop up the last of his rogue documents.

Chest heaving, hair slightly disheveled, he stood there, victorious.

Then another gust of wind hit.

A single page slipped from his grasp.

Phainon locked eyes with it as it floated, tauntingly, toward the ground.

He inhaled sharply—

And stomped on it *with finality*.

Silence.

A passing person clapped.

Phainon slowly turned, giving them a dead-eyed stare.

They scurried away.

Shoving the papers back into his bag with great personal offense, Phainon straightened his clothes, exhaled slowly—

And marched off, like none of that had ever happened.

Because obviously it hadn’t.

(If anyone asked? No, it didn’t.)

In his head, a full-blown orchestral swell played—heroic, triumphant, worthy of a standing ovation.

He hrew back his shoulders, stretching and prepared to head home.

Then he heard it.

That sharp, thinly veiled fear in a woman’s voice. The tense, high-pitched note of a child.

His steps slowed.

A few meters away, at the edge of a quiet street, a man had a woman cornered against a storefront. His grip was *tight* around her wrist, his mouth twisted into a condescending sneer as he spoke too close, too casually.

The kid—a boy, maybe nine or ten—was pressed against his mother’s side, eyes darting in every direction like he was desperately hoping *someone* would intervene.

Lucky for him, I have time today.

Phainon’s fingers flexed as he changed course, each step measured, smooth.

He wasn’t reckless. He didn’t storm over with fists flying.

No.

He *liked* taking his time with people like this.

He liked the *build-up.*

He liked the moment *they realized.*

“Hey,” Phainon called, voice light, pleasant—just a touch intrusive. “Is there a problem here?”

The man turned sharply, annoyed at being interrupted. The woman looked startled—then almost *relieved*.

The man scoffed. “Nah, this is my wife.”

Phainon blinked.

Then blinked again.

Then slowly dragged his gaze to the woman and child, who were looking at the man like he had just threatened to skin them alive.

Ok, Phainon thought, *so we’re lying today.*

The man squared his shoulders. “Move along.”

Phainon didn’t move.

Instead, he tilted his head slightly, scanning the scene like he was considering something deeply.

“You know,” he said, voice still light, too light, “I find that hard to believe.”

The man’s face twisted. “I don’t care what you believe.”

Phainon hummed thoughtfully. “See, that’s the thing. Your ‘wife’ and ‘son’ look at you like you just crawled out of a sewer.”

The woman stiffened.

The man’s nostrils flared. “Mind your damn business.”

“Oh, but you see,” Phainon smiled, leaning slightly closer, “*I love minding my business*. And my business, right now, is making sure this woman and her actual son aren’t being pestered by some miserable little man.”

The guy bristled, stepping toward Phainon.

A mistake.

Because the second he got too close and reached out to him, Phainon’s hand shot out, catching his wrist in an iron grip.

The effect was *instant*.

The guy tensed as his wrist *cracked*. Not a break—just a warning. A cruel little preview of what *could* happen.

His breath hitched.

Phainon, *finally*, let his smile drop.

“You’re still talking,” he mused, pressing down just enough to make the guy’s fingers twitch involuntarily. “That’s annoying.”

Sweat formed at the man’s temple. “L-let go.”

Phainon’s grip didn’t budge.

Instead, he studied the guy—like he was a particularly *uninteresting* bug, something beneath his notice but *still* in his way.

He could break his fingers one by one.

He could twist his arm back until something gave.

He could drag him to the pavement and make him *beg*.

A pity, really, that the guy was stupid enough to *try to punch him*.

Phainon let it happen.

The impact was *nothing*. The weakest hit he'd taken all week.

The guy grinned, thinking he'd actually—

SLAM.

In an instant, Phainon had him *pinned* to the wall, one hand gripping his collar, the other forcing his arm into a brutal angle.

The woman gasped. The boy stared, wide-eyed.

Phainon leaned in, his voice dropping into something *cold*.

"Give me one good reason," he murmured, "not to break your arms right now."

The guy made a strangled noise, face pale, eyes darting—searching for some kind of out.

Phainon applied a little more pressure, just to hear him *wheeze.*

Then—

Sirens.

Phainon flicked his gaze down. The kid had his phone out. Likely called the cops a while ago.

Smart kid.

Two officers appeared at the scene, guns lowered but watching.

"Hands where we can see them!"

Phainon, without hesitation, let go and stepped back, hands raised in the most *harmless civilian* way possible.

His entire expression shifted.

Gone was the cold,menacing presence.

In its place—

A mild-mannered professor, polite, helpful, *innocent.*

One officer squinted. “What’s going on here?”

Phainon, effortlessly: “Oh, just a little misunderstanding.”

The man on the ground wheezed in sheer betrayal.

Internally, Phainon sighed.

Should’ve just broken his arm earlier.

The officers approached with caution, one of them already reaching for a notepad.

Phainon, ever the picture of innocence, took a half-step back and adopted the most agreeable expression in his arsenal.

“Good evening, officers.” He gestured lightly toward the wheezing man still crumpled on the pavement. “I was just passing by when I saw this gentleman harassing the woman and her son.”

The woman, finally free from the man’s grip, gave a frantic nod. “He wouldn’t leave us alone. He grabbed me—my son was scared.”

The officer turned to the boy. “Did you call us, kid?”

The boy swallowed and gave a firm nod. “Yeah.”

The other officer glanced between them all, then down at the miserable excuse for a man on the ground. “You want to press charges?”

The woman hesitated.

The guy—sweating buckets—started shaking his head wildly. “It was a misunderstanding—”

Phainon, watching the whole thing unfold, rested his hands in his pockets.

A small part of him wished the woman would say yes.

Because then he’d get to see this worm dragged away like he deserved.

But instead, she swallowed and shook her head. “No. I just—I just want to go home.”

Phainon sighed internally. *That’s always how it goes, huh?*

The officer still hauled the guy up by the arm, but his tone was lighter. “Alright, buddy. We’re taking you in for now. You can explain everything at the station.”

Phainon hummed, watching them go.

For all the things he hated about people like that, there was one thing that *really* got to him.

They never thought they were in the wrong.

They *never* understood what they did.

Even when thrown in cuffs, even when caught in the act, they always had some excuse. Always had some delusion that painted *them* as the victim.

It made Phainon sick.

But at least, for today, this one wouldn’t get to walk away so easily.

As the officers finished up, Phainon turned back to the mother and son, all his sharp edges tucked away once more. “Do you need me to walk you two back?”

The woman hesitated, then offered a small, grateful smile. “No, we’ll be okay. But—thank you.”

The boy, still clinging to her side, mumbled, “Yeah. Thanks, mister.”

Phainon softened slightly. “No problem. Good thinking, calling the cops.”

The boy beamed just a little.

And just like that, it was over.

Phainon turned on his heel, and finally *left*.

He didn’t look back.

His mind was already elsewhere, thoughts dragging behind him like shadows.

How many times had he seen this exact scene play out?

How many times had he watched the same thing—fear, hesitation, retreat—repeat itself over and over again?

How many more times would he *have to?*

Phainon’s jaw clenched.

Too many.

Too many people in the world thought they could get away with things like this.

Too many people *did*.

He could break them, one by one, and it still wouldn’t be enough.

It would *never* be enough.

A gust of wind swept past him, ruffling his hair.

He exhaled.

No use getting worked up now.

This wasn't his fight to dwell on anymore.

Instead, he let out a long sigh and *forcibly* lightened his mood.

"Alright," he muttered to himself, rolling his shoulders. "Time to go home and *actually* rest before I die."

With that, he picked up his pace, winding through the city streets with practiced ease, until finally—

His apartment door came into view.

Phainon entered his apartment.

The door shut behind him with a quiet *click*, and immediately, his body sagged. He was *done*. Mentally, physically, spiritually. His bones felt like they were held together by sheer spite. His *soul* was peeling away.

Without even turning on the lights, he zombie-shuffled toward the bathroom, stripping off his shirt on the way and tossing it vaguely in the direction of the laundry basket. (It missed. He did not care.)

Shower. Blessed, holy shower. He stood under the hot water until it stopped feeling good and started feeling like a boiling pot. Only then did he move again, sluggishly scrubbing himself down before dragging himself out.

And this—*this* was where he gave up on life entirely.

Phainon didn't even pretend to put together a reasonable outfit. No. That required effort. That required dignity. And he had none left.

So instead, he pulled on the most *heinous* outfit known to mankind.

A pair of sweatpants so loose they practically functioned as a dress. A t-shirt featuring an aggressively cursed, low-quality meme. A hoodie that was

once black but had been washed so many times it had become a depressing shade of charcoal. The sleeves were too long. The pockets were stuffed with *mystery items*.

And the slippers. Oh, god, the slippers. One was shaped like a bear, the other was from an entirely different set and had a hole in it. His socks didn't match, either. They probably weren't even *his*.

Looking in the mirror, he gave himself a slow nod of approval.

Perfect.

Then, with the grace of a dying man, he faceplanted onto his bed.

For a moment, there was silence. *Peace*. His body still ached, his brain was foggy, but he was home, and that was all that mattered.

And then his phone vibrated.

Mydei :
open up

Phainon cracked one eye open. Blinked.

Phainon✴:
?

And then his stomach dropped.

Oh, fuck.

Date night.

Date night.

He shot up so fast his mind lagged behind.

A rapid-fire sequence of thoughts hit him at once:

1.He *loved* date night.
2.He *forgot* date night.
3.He was currently dressed like an escaped sewer creature.
4.He had exactly *zero* motivation to fix this.

…But then again.

Maybe it was a lazy date?

Fast food. Movies. He and Mydei both sprawled on the couch in oversized hoodies. It made sense, right? Mydei wouldn't judge him. They'd just chill and eat junk food like the two barely-functioning adults they were.

Satisfied with this logic, Phainon lazily dragged himself off the bed, yawning as he shuffled toward the door. He even had a stupid little grin on his face, ready to say *Surprise!* like an absolute dumbass.

Then he opened the door.

Romantic music might as well have been playing in the background.

There stood Mydei.

In a suit.

A *tailored* suit. *Black-on-black, crisp lapels, top two buttons undone, looking like he was about to ruin someone's life.* His hair was immaculate, his cologne was subtle yet devastating, and in his hands was a *bouquet of flowers*, like he had just walked straight out of a goddamn K-drama.

Phainon took exactly *one* second to process this.

Then, in complete silence, with an utterly blank expression, he shut the door.

Click.

The music cut off.

He stood there, staring at nothing.

Ah, he thought distantly. *I have made a mistake.*

He slowly turned back toward his apartment, eyes hollow.

Then, still in total silence, he faceplanted back onto his bed.

The void welcomed him.

Oh my god. Oh my god. Oh my god.

His body tensed, then convulsed into full-body cringe. His legs kicked helplessly against the sheets. His arms flailed once, then fell limp. His soul attempted to eject itself into the astral plane.

He saw. HE SAW.

His beautiful, perfect, devastatingly attractive boyfriend—his *suave, elegant, K-drama-esque,* romantic as hell, better-than-*everyone Mydei*—had just witnessed Phainon at his absolute lowest.

In The Outfit.

The slippers. The meme shirt. The mismatched socks. The pure, unholy combination of all things cursed in one single ensemble.

This is it. This is how I leave the mortal plane.

Phainon groaned, rolling onto his back, gripping his own hair like that would somehow erase the last two minutes from existence. His brain was *burning*, running at a million miles per hour, trying and failing to process the depth of his humiliation.

Okay. Okay. Deep breaths. *This is fine.*

Sure, his *stupidly gorgeous, always-stylish* boyfriend had just witnessed him in the worst state known to mankind, but that was okay. It was okay. Mydei loved him. He loved him no matter *what*. That's what love *was*.

Right?

…Right?

His entire body twitched like a dying cockroach. *I can never recover from this.*

But no. No. He could *fix* this. There was still time. He just needed to change. Quickly, before Mydei got suspicious and—

Phainon practically dove into his closet. Ransacked it. Clothes flew everywhere. Shirts, jackets, a pair of pants that may or may not have belonged to Mydei, a single sock that *definitely* wasn't his—

Nothing.

There was *nothing*.

Cold realization dawned upon him.

Oh *fuck.*

He forgot to do laundry last night.

His hands clenched around the last remaining hoodie in the depths of his closet. He pulled it out, eyes dark, filled with horror. It was a relic of his past—*a neon green monstrosity* from his university days, featuring a ridiculous slogan in Comic Sans that read *DEBATE CLUB: WHERE ARGUMENTS GO TO DIE.*

He held it. Stared at it. Considered simply walking into the ocean.

No. This wasn't happening. He *could not* let Mydei see him like this again. There was only one solution.

Phainon gave up.

Quickly, he grabbed his phone.

Phainon✴:
hey Mydei can't do date night tonight actually I am dying. cancer. rip me. love u.

He pressed send.

Three seconds later:

Mydei :
open the damn door.

Phainon let out a long, suffering groan.

He squeezed his eyes shut. Took a deep, shuddering breath. He could *fight* this. He could *stand his ground.* He could—

No. No, he couldn't.

With the weary resignation of a man condemned, he dragged himself toward the door.

And caved.

Phainon took a deep breath, backtracked into his apartment, and ransacked his closet for the only thing remotely presentable. It was a simple black button-up and dark slacks—decent, but standing next to Mydei, he might as well have been wearing a garbage bag.

Reluctantly, he returned to the door, dragging it open at an almost painfully slow pace, as if stalling would somehow make Mydei disappear. No such luck. The moment the door was fully open, Phainon was once again blessed (cursed) with the sight of his perfectly put-together boyfriend, who looked like he had just stepped out of a luxury magazine spread.

Mydei had the audacity to be standing there like some divine entity, all sharp angles and smooth confidence, the suit hugging him in a way that had to be illegal. His pale fingers adjusted his cufflinks like this was some casual outing and not an event that was actively ruining Phainon's entire existence.

Phainon squinted, processing. Then, emotionally resigning himself to his fate, he sighed and muttered, "Don't say anything. I know it's bad."

Mydei, expression unreadable, gave a slow, deliberate nod. "Mhm."

Phainon groaned.

Before he could spiral again, Mydei held up a small, elegant envelope, sliding it into Phainon's hand. "I got us a reservation at Kremnos," he said, completely nonchalant, like he hadn't just casually named one of the most expensive and exclusive restaurants in the city.

Phainon's brain stalled. "I—hold on. *Kremnos*? You mean the place with a year-long waitlist? The place where they reject celebrities? The place that probably charges a small fortune just for breathing their air?"

Mydei, completely unfazed, adjusted his tie. "That's the one."

Phainon narrowed his eyes in deep suspicion. "…How?" Mydei was a librarian. That was self-explanatory.

Mydei simply smirked, mirroring the exact casual shrug Phainon had given him *last month* when he had spent an absolutely absurd amount of money on getting Mydei a custom-tailored outfit.

"Don't worry about it."

Oh, the hypocrisy.

Phainon opened his mouth, then closed it. His first instinct was to protest, to dig for the real explanation, but the look Mydei was giving him—the slightest softening of his gaze, the way his lips curled in amusement, the

way his entire demeanor practically radiated *I wanted to do something nice for you, just take it*—made Phainon hesitate.

He felt his initial guilt rise again, glancing down at his ridiculously mediocre outfit compared to Mydei's, but… this was happening, whether he liked it or not.

Phainon sighed, but a small smile tugged at his lips. "Fine. Let's go be disgustingly rich for the night."

As they stepped out of the building, Mydei—ever the gentleman—reached for the car door and held it open.

Phainon, being the overgrown theatre kid he was, placed a hand over his chest, fluttering his lashes as he stepped in. "How charming."

Mydei rolled his eyes but subtly smiled, following after him. The car interior was organized, dimly lit, and very comfortable. The second Mydei settled in, Phainon instinctively leaned into him, hands intertwining together.

For a brief moment, it was perfect. Peaceful. Romantic, even.

Then Phainon sneezed.

Loudly.

The force of it practically shook the car.

Mydei froze.

Slowly, ever so slowly, he turned his head, eyes narrowing as he observed Phainon like a scientist discovering an abomination under a microscope.

Phainon sniffled, rubbing at his nose. "What?"

Mydei didn't answer. Instead, his gaze trailed downward—and that's when he noticed it.

The faint discoloration on Phainon’s cheek. The subtle bruise, barely noticeable under the dim car lights but unmistakable once you knew what to look for.

In an instant, Mydei’s entire demeanor shifted. Concern Mode: *Activated*.

His fingers reached out, gentle but firm, brushing against Phainon’s forehead to check his temperature.

Phainon immediately recoiled like he’d been touched by holy water. “Oh, wow, look at that, we’re moving—”

The car had not moved an inch.

Phainon made a break for it anyway, attempting to dramatically slide further into the seat, twisting his body away as if sheer willpower alone could escape Mydei’s grasp. He looked like a scandal-ridden Victorian lady avoiding the touch of an eligible bachelor in a ballroom.

“Don’t be ridiculous,” Mydei muttered, leaning in further.

Phainon, full-on twisting himself into the most uncomfortable position imaginable, hissed, “I am never ridiculous—”

That was when Mydei moved and in a millisecond, *straddled him.*

Phainon choked on his own soul. “*MYDEI*.”

With the precision of a man who had clearly done this before, Mydei effortlessly swung a leg over Phainon’s lap, caging him in place with zero room for escape. The weight of him, the sheer *presence*, was completely unfair.

Phainon flailed weakly, pressing himself against the car door as if it was a hostage situation. “This is *entrapment*!”

Mydei, completely ignoring him, pressed the back of his hand to Phainon’s forehead.

A pause.

Then, his expression darkened.

“…You’re burning up.”

Phainon, sweating for multiple reasons, laughed weakly. “Well, you *are* on top of me—”

Mydei’s stare sharpened.

Phainon winced. “No, please, not the disappointment—”

Too late.

Mydei exhaled sharply, closing his eyes for a moment like he was *deeply* reconsidering his life choices the second time today. Then, he fixed Phainon with the most profoundly unimpressed look known to mankind.

Phainon wilted under it. His soul left his body. His ancestors turned away in shame.

“I can explain,” he tried.

“You’re sick,” Mydei stated flatly.

“*Technically*, I’m—”

“Sick *and* bruised,” Mydei continued, his voice taking on the cold efficiency of a doctor about to prescribe a lifetime of regret.

“I can see how that *sounds* bad, but—”

Mydei just *stared*.

Phainon shut his mouth.

This was going to be a long car ride.

The silence was uncanny.

Phainon, King of Shotgun, Lord of the Front Seat, had been *unceremoniously* demoted to the back like a misbehaving child. Mydei, ever the executioner, had not uttered a single word since slamming the driver's side door shut.

The restaurant? Nowhere in sight.

Instead, the city lights blurred past as Mydei drove *directly* toward his apartment.

Not Phainon's. *His*.

Which meant one of two things:

1.Phainon was being kidnapped. (Understandable, he was quite stealable.)
2. Phainon was *in trouble.*

Given the tense grip Mydei had on the wheel, the latter seemed more likely.

Phainon sunk deeper into the seat, feeling worse than the time he had *accidentally*—and he *maintains* it was accidental—started a city-wide pigeon war after feeding an unfortunate amount of bread to a particularly aggressive flock. *(Chaos. Ruins. Avian carnage.)*

The guilt creeping up his spine now was eerily similar.

Desperate to break the silence, he cleared his throat. "Sooo… nice weather we're having?"

Nothing.

"Mydei?"

Still nothing.

Okay. He could work with this.

Phainon glanced out the window. “Sooo, uh. We passed the turn to Kremnos a while back.”

Silence.

“…That’s the restaurant, in case you forgot.”

Still, no response.

Phainon’s stomach churned. “…Are we not going?”

That did it.

Mydei’s grip on the wheel tightened just slightly as he inhaled sharply through his nose. Then, finally, he spoke.

“You think I care about that right now?”

His voice had changed.

It wasn’t cold nor was it angry. It was offended. Baffled. As if Phainon had just suggested they abandon a burning orphanage *because dinner reservations were non-refundable.*

Phainon winced. “I mean, I care—?”

Mydei exhaled, as if *actively* restraining himself from saying something much, much worse.

Phainon internally shriveled.

He’s mad but he won’t say anything.

Which, somehow, was so much worse.

Mydei *obviously* wanted to ask about the bruise. He *obviously* wanted to know why Phainon was burning up like he'd been thrown into a microwave. And yet, *he was holding back.*

For Phainon's sake.

That was… kind of cute.

But also *terrible*.

Phainon sulked in the backseat, the weight of Mydei's disappointment pressing down on him. He had faced down many people as the Flame Reaver. Corrupt politicians, crime syndicates, and multiple existential crises, but nothing—nothing—was as soul-crushing as his boyfriend being silently mad at him.

The second the car rolled to a stop, Phainon barely had time to register his surroundings before Mydei's door swung open. His own followed a second later—ripped open with intent. Mydei had *zero* intention of letting him escape.

Before Phainon could even think about resistance, a firm hand grabbed his wrist.

"Mydei, wait—"

Nope.

He was *dragged*.

Not guided. Not led. *Dragged*.

Through the building, up the elevator, and straight into Mydei's apartment.

Phainon could only weakly protest, heels skidding against the floor as he was manhandled across the threshold. "Okay, okay, I get it, I should've—ow—just let me—ow—walk on my own—!"

Mydei ignored him entirely, closing the door behind them with a resounding click.

In any other circumstance, Phainon might've taken the moment to admire how unfairly attractive his boyfriend looked under the dim apartment lighting—*but alas*, he was currently being shoved toward the bedroom with the gentleness of someone disposing of a particularly annoying raccoon.

Only one thing saved him from immediate doom:

The bouquet.

Mydei still had it.

Phainon, still very much being manhandled, watched as Mydei paused, brows furrowing slightly as he looked down at the delicate arrangement in his grasp.

Then, with an almost comically gentle touch, he set them down on the side table.

Like they were sacred.

Like they mattered.

Phainon *almost* had a moment to process that whiplash—before Mydei returned his focus to *him*.

He braced himself.

Unfortunately, there was no bracing for Mydei aggressively taking care of him.

Because it wasn't violent—no, it was far worse.

It was the *deliberate* way Mydei pushed him onto the bed.

The *exasperated-yet-careful* way he pulled the blankets over him.

The *mercilessly efficient* way he undid the collar of Phainon's (painfully inadequate) outfit, making quick work of ridding him of any uncomfortable layers.

Phainon swore he could feel his heartbeat increasing.

"I can take care of myself, you know," he tried weakly.

Mydei, fluffing his pillow with *unnecessary aggression:* "Oh, really?"

"…Yes?"

Mydei snorted.

Phainon pouted from under the covers. "You know I would've been fine."

"You *know* that's bullshit."

Phainon opened his mouth. Closed it.

Fair.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Phainon swallowed, staring at the ceiling, and exhaled slowly. Then, before he could overthink it, he muttered, "…Sorry."

Mydei's hands stilled as he tucked the blanket around him.

Phainon closed his eyes. "I mean it. I know I can be reckless. And annoying. And probably a massive headache to deal with—"

"Definitely," Mydei murmured.

"—but I'm really, *really* glad I have you."

That shut Mydei up.

Phainon peeked at him through his lashes, watching as Mydei hesitated. His boyfriend's face was unreadable, his fingers curling slightly into the fabric of the sheets before he looked away.

"…Yeah," Mydei said at last, voice quieter than before.

Phainon bit his lip. He didn't know what else to say, but it didn't matter—because Mydei had already moved, reaching for his face. His fingers were slow, deliberate, brushing over Phainon's cheek where the bruise had darkened.

The touch didn't hurt, but Mydei's expression made Phainon wonder if it did hurt—just not him.

Phainon thought about reassuring him.

But then Mydei sighed, drew back, and said, "I'll make something for you."

Phainon's stomach dropped.

"…You're going to cook?"

Mydei raised a brow. "What else?"

So many things ran through Phainon's mind. *Ordering in. Heating up leftovers. Chewing on a napkin instead.*

But did he say that? Did he suggest an alternative?

No.

With a deeply unnatural, physically misaligned, and *entirely* forced, "Okay," Phainon gave up.

Mydei narrowed his eyes.

Phainon smiled weakly.

"…Just lie down," Mydei said, standing.

Phainon did in fact, obediently stay down.

Mydei let out a long breath, clearly seeing right through him, but—mercifully—didn’t comment.

Instead, he turned, rolling up his sleeves as he walked toward the kitchen.

Phainon dragged a pillow over his face.

This was fine.

This was totally fine.

It wasn’t like Mydei had ever… accidentally set off the smoke alarm boiling eggs before.

Wait.

Oh no.

You know what he was too old to care for this.

Phainon, for once, allowed himself to sink into the mattress, exhaustion creeping into his bones as he finally let go of the stubborn willpower keeping him upright. He dozed in and out, barely registering the sounds of Mydei moving around the apartment—pots clinking, water running, the occasional low hum of concentration. It was oddly soothing. Maybe he should be more worried.

By the time Mydei returned, a bowl in hand, Phainon was groggy but awake, blinking blearily at the offering.

“Mydei,” he said slowly, “is that *soup?*”

“Yes.”

Phainon stared at it, cautious. This was it. This was how he departed the living world, he’d had made his peace with it already. Swallowing his fear, he took a spoonful and braced himself for impact.

The taste hit him.

It was… fine? No, not just fine. It was *good*. The perfect amount of seasoning, a comforting warmth spreading through his chest.

Phainon froze mid-chew. Slowly, *slowly*, he turned his head to Mydei, eyes wide with unfiltered betrayal.

“You know how to cook?”

Mydei blinked, suddenly looking like a man caught in a crime scene without an alibi. “…You always ate it, though.”

Phainon’s spoon clattered against the bowl. He inhaled sharply.

“You mean to tell me,” he said, voice trembling with the weight of unspeakable suffering, “that all those times I suffered, all those *mystery dishes—” (his stomach still had PTSD from the ‘experimental’ casserole)* “—you could’ve just… *made* something edible?”

A pause. Mydei averted his gaze. “…You always said it was fine.”

Phainon collapsed back onto the pillow, hands covering his face.

“I was being polite, *Mydei*.”

The room was dimly lit, the only sound the occasional scrape of a spoon against ceramic. Mydei sat on the edge of the bed, one arm resting on his knee, the other holding the bowl of *deceptively* good soup.

Meanwhile, Phainon was firmly cocooned under the blanket, his back turned to the world—specifically to Mydei.

Silence.

Then, tentatively, “Phainon.”

No response.

“…Phainon.”

The blanket did not move.

Mydei sighed, rubbing his temple. He glanced at the soup, then at the blanket lump of his boyfriend, and exhaled through his nose.

“…Sunshine.”

A muffled groan. A victory.

Mydei pressed his advantage. “Come on. You need to eat.”

“No.” The response was sluggish, grumpy, full of sadness. “You *lied* to me.”

“I didn’t lie,” Mydei countered, shifting closer. “I just—” He hesitated. “—let you believe what you wanted.”

“That’s lying by omission,” Phainon grumbled, sinking further into the mattress.

Mydei stared at the ridiculous lump of blanket before simply deciding he was done with this. He reached forward, grabbed the edge of the covers, and *ripped* them away in one smooth motion.

“Backstabber,” Phainon whispered, eyes squinting at the sudden exposure to light.

Mydei ignored him, lifting the spoon with an expectant look. “Eat.”

Phainon, half-buried in the pillow, remained stubborn for a solid three seconds before the aroma of the soup hit him again. His stomach betrayed him with a low grumble.

Mydei’s lips twitched. “Oh?”

“…Fine.” Phainon grudgingly lifted his head just enough for Mydei to feed him, taking the first spoonful with a huff.

He chewed. Swallowed.

Damn it. It was *good*.

Phainon glared weakly at Mydei, eyes full of spite even as he reluctantly opened his mouth for another bite.

Phainon, ever the stubborn martyr, finished the last spoonful with exaggerated looks. He chewed climactically, swallowed like it physically pained him, and then turned his head away as if he was done with this entire existence and didn't scarf down every bite, savoring it.

Mydei, undeterred, set the bowl aside and watched him in silence.

Then, without a word, he leaned down and pressed a soft, lingering kiss to Phainon's turned cheek.

It was light, barely more than a brush of lips, but warm—warm in the way that settled deep in Phainon's chest, in the way that said *I see you, I appreciate you, even when you're impossible.*

Phainon froze.

Mydei pulled back just as casually as he had leaned in, standing up with no fanfare. "I'll be back," he said, voice as even as ever, before leaving the room like nothing had happened.

Phainon stayed perfectly still, brain completely short-circuiting.

Then, slowly, almost dazedly, he lifted a hand to press against his cheek where the kiss had been, eyes wide.

His face burned.

Mydei returned, this time with medicine and cooling pads in hand, his movements efficient, his expression unreadable. He didn't say anything as he handed Phainon a glass of water and the pills, just watched with quiet expectation.

Phainon sighed through his nose, took the medicine without complaint, and swallowed. Mydei nodded in approval, then placed the cooling pad against his forehead with practiced ease, the coolness a sudden contrast to the feverish heat prickling against his skin.

Then, just as quickly, Mydei turned as if to leave.

Phainon's fingers caught his wrist.

Mydei paused, glancing back. "I thought you were mad."

Phainon hummed, voice turning smooth—too smooth, practically dripping with charm as he tugged just enough to get Mydei closer. "I was. Still am, maybe." His grip firmed, slowly guiding Mydei down until he was hovering above him, knees sinking into the mattress on either side of Phainon's hips. "But I'm also very weak to you."

Mydei's breath hitched, almost imperceptibly, but Phainon felt it. Saw the way Mydei's throat bobbed as he swallowed. The way his fingers twitched like he wasn't sure where to place them. Cute.

Phainon's hands slid, slow and deliberate, up Mydei's sides before settling at his hips, thumbs brushing over the fabric of his shirt. He felt the tension there, the hesitation. It made something dark curl in his chest, satisfaction winding into something sharper, something he didn't bother naming.

Mydei's lashes fluttered. "…You're feverish."

Phainon smiled, all teeth. "I was feverish before you got on top of me."

Another barely-there shudder from Mydei, another point to Phainon. He tilted his head back against the pillow, gazing up at him, voice turning almost lazy as his hands kneaded at Mydei's hips like he was making himself comfortable. "You always take care of me." His voice dropped just slightly, enough to make sure Mydei felt it. "Makes me wonder what I'd do without you."

He saw the effect of his words immediately. Mydei's fingers curled into the sheets near Phainon's shoulders, his gaze flickering as if debating something, but his body language—tense, unsure, a little too still—spoke loud enough.

Phainon's grin softened into something slower, something more indulgent. His fingers flexed, pressing against Mydei's hips just enough to remind him who was holding him there.

"Not leaving yet, are you?" he murmured.

For a moment, Mydei hesitated. Then, just as Phainon was about to tease him for it, Mydei moved.

It was slow, measured—like he was testing the waters, but undeniably deliberate. His hands slid up, tracing the shape of Phainon's collar before his fingers curled slightly, gripping at the fabric just enough to make Phainon exhale through his nose, amused and intrigued.

Oh?

Phainon's hands tightened where they rested on Mydei's hips, grin widening. "Look at you," he murmured, teasing but approving. "So bold—"

Then Mydei shifted, adjusting his weight—accidentally pressing down on Phainon's side.

Pain flared up his ribs.

His breath hitched. It wasn't much—barely a wince, a brief twitch of his lips—but Mydei caught it immediately.

Phainon knew he was screwed the second Mydei went still.

"…What was that?" Mydei's tone was deceptively light, but Phainon could already feel the shift.

"Nothing," he tried, too quickly.

Mydei’s expression remained unreadable. His hand, however, did not—because he suddenly gripped Phainon’s shirt and yanked it up before Phainon could stop him.

A sharp breath. Mydei’s fingers, ghosting over the deep, ugly bruise stretched across Phainon’s right side, stark against his skin. The dark splotches had bloomed outwards like ink, the worst of it concentrated near his ribs.

Phainon clicked his tongue. “See, now this is awkward.”

Mydei did not laugh.

Phainon, ever the optimist, tried anyway. “Listen, I know it looks bad, but __”

A hand pressed carefully, firmly, to the injury. Not enough to hurt, but enough that Phainon felt the weight of Mydei’s touch.

His head snapped up, mouth open to protest—only to falter when he met Mydei’s gaze.

The concern was there, yes. But beneath it, layered in the tense line of his shoulders and the way his fingers curled slightly as they rested against Phainon’s bruised skin, was something colder. Something sharp-edged and simmering, barely held back.

Mydei’s voice, when he finally spoke, was quiet.

“…Who did this to you?”

His grip tightened.

Phainon opened his mouth.

Closed it.

Opened it again—then shut it once more, because what the hell was he even supposed to say?

Oh, Mydei, my love, my moon, my eternity and more—I may or may not be the Flame Reaver, that notorious terrorist-slash-criminal you probably hate, thank you for asking. Oh, and by the way, I fell off a skyscraper last night, hope that's cool with you.

Yeah, no. Not happening.

But Mydei was still staring at him. Waiting.

Damn it.

Phainon forced a grin, trying to wave it off. "Okay, so, funny story—"

Mydei just arched a brow.

"—Not actually that funny, but listen, I—"

The longer he spoke, the flatter Mydei's expression became.

That patient silence. That expectant look. The quiet understanding that was somehow worse than any accusation.

Because damn it, Mydei and Phainon had trust and honesty. They didn't lie to each other. And even when they did at first, they always came back and talked about it properly.

Phainon sighed, rubbing the back of his neck. "You're not gonna drop this, huh?"

Mydei did not respond. Which was an answer in itself.

Phainon groaned. "Fine, fine," he muttered, shifting slightly. He glanced away, voice softening. "Got caught up in something. It was… messy. I handled it, but—"

His fingers brushed against the bruise absentmindedly. "Didn't walk away unscathed."

Mydei's gaze flickered over his expression, reading between the lines.

Not obscure enough to sound suspicious. But not detailed enough to raise more questions.

Still, his frown didn't disappear completely.

"…You're okay?" Mydei finally asked, quieter now.

Phainon smiled—smaller this time. "I'm fine."

Mydei studied him for a long moment.

Then, after what felt like forever, he exhaled and finally—finally—relaxed a fraction, the tension in his shoulders lessening.

"…Alright," he said, eventually.

Phainon felt something warm settle in his chest.

Healthy communication, baby. His younger self would be so proud.

Phainon could tell—Mydei was still tense.

He didn't show it outright. To anyone else, he probably looked perfectly composed, just sitting there at Phainon's bedside after moving away, fingers barely twitching against the sheets. But Phainon knew him too well.

Knew the way his hands curled slightly when he was thinking too hard, the way his breathing slowed like he was trying to contain something he didn't want spilling over.

Yeah. Mydei wasn't letting this go.

And Phainon, well—he was too exhausted to deal with it.

So he did the only thing that made sense.

He grabbed Mydei by the wrist for the second time today and dragged him onto the bed once again, this time next to him rather than on top.

Caught off guard, Mydei barely resisted as Phainon shifted them both, guiding him down. Then, without hesitation, Phainon wrapped his arms around him, pulling him close with the kind of ease that came with years of knowing exactly how Mydei fit against him.

It was instinctive. Natural.

Mydei, on the other hand, was completely still.

Slightly stiff, but not resisting.

He exhaled slowly, then muttered, "…You're sick."

Phainon blinked.

Oh. Right.

He hesitated, arms slackening a little as he prepared to let go. "Damn. Forgot about that."

Mydei didn't move.

Didn't pull away. Didn't push him back down.

He just… stared at him for a long moment. His expression was unreadable, eyes flickering across Phainon's face like he was weighing something in his mind.

Then, without another word, he leaned in again—closing the distance, wrapping his arms back around Phainon, and burying his face against his chest.

Phainon stilled.

"…Uh," he started, feeling Mydei's warmth pressed against him.

"I have a strong immune system," Mydei muttered, voice muffled against his shirt.

Phainon stared at him.

Then, after a long beat, he huffed out a laugh—something quiet and warm and helplessly fond.

“Alright,” he murmured, shaking his head, but not letting go.

The air settled, the tension ebbing away into something softer. Phainon let his hand drift up, absentmindedly stroking Mydei’s back, feeling the steady rise and fall of his breath.

Mydei fell asleep first.

His grip on Phainon remained firm, but his body gradually relaxed, breaths evening out. It was earlier than usual for him, but Phainon could feel the exhaustion in the way he held him—like he’d been holding himself together for too long and finally, finally let go.

Phainon stayed awake a little longer.

Just watching him.

He brushed a strand of hair from Mydei’s face, traced a thumb over his cheekbone, and leaned in to press a kiss against his temple.

God, he was so—

He exhaled softly, finally closing his own eyes.

And later that night, when Phainon had drifted off completely, he didn’t see the way Mydei’s eyes slowly opened again.

Didn’t see the way he lay there, quietly, just looking at him.

Didn’t feel the way Mydei’s fingers brushed against his wrist—light, careful, lingering for just a second longer than necessary before he finally, finally let himself relax again.

Chapter End Notes

Well I hope it was worth the wait sorry abt that😭 Next chapter is gonna be Mydei’s Godslayer debut tho😍

Thanks for readingggg <333

Chapter 6: Godslayer’s Babysitting Duty

Chapter Summary

> Mydei survives a catastrophic Black Tide breach, gets an earful from an angry Goldweaver, dodges politics, helps rebuild a city, entertains some kids, and somehow ends up walking a very tired (and very oblivious) Phainon home.

Chapter Notes

> Sorry y’all I know I say this every time but this was pretty late😭
> Won’t go into details but family drama gets exhausted REAL fast

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The city groaned under the weight of its own destruction.

Smoke curled into the air in thick, suffocating waves, twisting between shattered buildings and flickering signs barely clinging to life. Sirens howled in the distance, a discordant symphony of emergency alerts and panicked broadcasts, all drowned beneath the far more immediate sound of people screaming.

And beneath it all, there was the Black Tide.

A pulsating, unnatural mass of shifting black and red, consuming everything in its wake. Like a virus given form, it spread over the streets in jagged, geometric patterns, warping metal and concrete alike, reducing them into something unstable, something wrong.

And at the center of it all, Mydei fought.

He dodged to the side just as a clawed hand swiped at where his throat had been moments ago, the air hissing from the sheer force of the blow. His gauntlets whirred as they absorbed the energy of his movements, golden

circuitry flickering as he twisted on his heel and slammed his fist into the creature’s face.

The impact sent it flying, crashing through what was left of an abandoned vehicle. The body convulsed once before going still, its corrupted flesh sizzling where his weapons had torn through it.

Another one lunged at him from behind. He moved before it could make contact, raising an arm to block the strike. The force rattled through his bones, but pain was an afterthought—irrelevant, temporary. Instead, he caught the thing by its neck and slammed it into the pavement, the crunch of bone sharp beneath the chaos.

Two down.

Mydei stepped over the body, scanning the street. Seven more. No—six. One of them had tripped over its own feet trying to lunge at him, landing in a heap against a wrecked motorcycle.

“Pathetic,” he muttered, raising his foot and stomping down without looking.

Five.

Somewhere in the distance, something hissed. He turned just in time to see a mass of tendrils lash out from the shadows, slicing through the air like whips. He barely dodged in time, the heat of the attack grazing his cheek as he reeled back, fists already raised.

Alright. Now they were getting serious.

His gauntlets hummed, energy coursing through the gold-plated metal as he rolled his shoulders. He exhaled sharply.

“Alright,” he said, shifting his stance. “Come on, then.”

The corrupted obliged, snarling as they charged.

He met them halfway.

The city was *alive* in the worst possible way.

Alarms blared from every direction, mixing with the sharp crackle of energy weapons and the distant, guttural howls of the corrupted. The skyline, once a proud testament to the city's technological prowess, was now a fractured mess of collapsing towers, flickering neon signs, and spiraling drones struggling to navigate the chaos. But the worst part—the part that had everyone on edge—was that this shouldn't have even been happening.

The Black Tide wasn't just some natural disaster you prepared for like bad weather. It was an absolute, basically cosmic-level *catastrophe*. A dozen different failsafes were in place to stop it before it even had a chance to manifest—automated purifiers, reinforced containment fields, early-detection sensors, *actual laws of reality*—yet somehow, against all odds, it had breached the city.

Which meant someone, somewhere, had *really* screwed up.

Mydei didn't have time to worry about that right now. He ducked under a massive, corrupted limb, bringing his gauntlet up just in time to obliterate the creature's face in a crackling burst of energy. It staggered, barely registering pain before he finished it off with a brutal follow-up punch that sent it skidding across the pavement.

His earpiece buzzed to life, cutting through the din of destruction.

"Sector D secured. Moving civilians to the south tunnel."

"Containment holding steady at the west perimeter, minimal casualties."

"Black Tide exposure rates are dropping—Trinnon's almost cleared the main access routes."

Good. That was *something*.

The Chrysos Heirs had full authority over this operation—not that they wanted it, but the government wasn't exactly in a position to argue. No one else could handle something of this scale, and by the time officials even started drafting a response, the Heirs were already in motion. The triplets took point on the evacuation, splitting up the work between them.

Trianne, the loudest and most chaotic of the three, had turned crowd control into something that shouldn't have worked but somehow did.

"Keep it moving! No pushing! No trampling! If you shove one more person, I will personally *throw* you into the ocean—do NOT test me!"

People actually listened. Out of fear, efficiency, or sheer confusion, Mydei wasn't sure, but the shelter lines were moving.

Meanwhile, Trinnon worked on purifying the Black Tide, her usually soft-spoken nature shifting into quiet, grim focus. The Tide wasn't like normal contamination—it was aggressive, like a living infection that *hated* being removed. Every time she cleansed a section, it fought back, writhing and pulsing like something alive before it finally dissipated. The air shimmered where she passed, traces of corrupted energy breaking apart in her wake.

Tribbie, from somewhere high above, had locked onto the worst-hit areas, directing operators and scanning for survivors while also suppressing any contaminated points until Trinnon had time to get to them. She was the main reason Mydei knew where to focus his efforts, sending him alerts on where the biggest concentrations of corrupted were forming and where the Black Tide was spreading the fastest.

Despite everything, they were *handling* it.

Which was good, because Mydei had his hands full with the creatures that kept coming. Another one lunged, all jagged limbs and distorted features, and he met it with a well-placed strike to the gut. It crumpled instantly, and he barely had time to process before another took its place.

He breathed in, shaking out his hands as the gauntlets pulsed in response.

“Alright,” he muttered, cracking his neck as more shadows moved in. “Next.”

His earpiece crackled again, this time with a much more chipper voice.

“De! You’re still alive! Great news—there’s a lot less corruption now, and Trianne hasn’t started throwing people into the portals, so I think we’re winning!”

Mydei snorted, sidestepping a lunging corrupted and smashing its skull in with a brutal backhanded strike. “Yeah? Tell that to the ones still crawling out of the ground.”

“Oh, don’t worry, they’re thinning out. Mostly! You’re still needed in Sector G, though. Couple of stubborn holdouts who refuse to evacuate, and—oh, wait—uh, maybe don’t go there yet.”

He barely had time to process before the battlefield shifted.

A massive wave of force rippled through the air, sending cracks spiderwebbing through the pavement. Mydei pivoted sharply, muscles tensing as the already-ruined sky above twisted in on itself, energy flaring at the center of the battlefield. A shadow streaked through the air—fast, controlled, and *deadly*—before slamming into the ground with enough force to send debris flying.

And then, through the settling dust, he heard the roar.

Not the mindless howls of the corrupted. Not the eerie shrieks of the Black Tide creatures.

But the low, guttural rumble of something *massive*.

A pair of glowing eyes ignited in the haze, followed by the slow, deliberate stretch of wings that blocked out the colorful skyline. Its scales gleamed like obsidian, coiling energy crackling along its ridges as it exhaled a stream of searing-hot mist.

And at its feet stood Castorice.

Undertaker.

Her scythe gleamed in the dim light, the curved blade catching the crimson glow of the Black Tide like it was drinking it in. The contrast was almost jarring—her quiet, almost unassuming demeanor against the absolute carnage she *commanded*. Without hesitation, she twirled her weapon, fluid and practiced, before darting forward in a blur of motion.

The creatures never stood a chance.

Corrupted fell one after another, cut down in wide, precise arcs, their bodies barely hitting the ground before her dragon followed up with a well-placed blast of energy that *vaporized* whatever remained. She was methodical, efficient—focused entirely on the fight.

Which meant Mydei could switch priorities.

“De?” Tribbie’s voice hummed in his ear again. **“Guessing you noticed the very big and very cool dragon? That means you’re good to move onto rescue!”**

“On it.”

With Castorice taking point in combat, Mydei turned his attention elsewhere. His gauntlet pulsed as he activated a scanner, sweeping the crumbling landscape for any trapped civilians. Red markers lit up his visor—a few people stuck under debris, some huddled in barely-standing structures, others too injured to move.

He didn’t waste time.

For the ones he couldn’t reach, he sent direct coordinates to Trianne, trusting her to open gates for extraction. The rest—he got to work. Sprinting through collapsing streets, pulling people out from under rubble, hoisting them over his shoulder when they were too weak to run. Every second counted, and he moved like he knew it.

And above it all, through the chaos, Castorice and her dragon tore through the battlefield, ensuring nothing got close enough to stop him.

A soft chime echoed in Mydei's earpiece, followed by the smooth, refined voice of Goldweaver.

"Mydei. I trust the battle is going well on your end."

He took a moment to adjust his stance, letting his gauntlet recharge as he observed the battlefield. Undertaker was still holding the perimeter, and evacuation efforts were proceeding without issue.

"As well as it can be," he replied. "Is this just a social call, or do you have bad news for me?"

A faint chuckle. **"Straight to the point. Good. Due to the severity of this incident, a temporary alliance is being enforced between independent operatives and state-sanctioned responders. The Council has already approved it."**

That was expected. "Not surprising."

"Then this next part won't be, either. Some of the more… opportunistic individuals have attempted to use this disaster to their advantage."

Mydei's jaw tightened. "Escaped convicts?"

"**Luckily, most were contained before they could flee. However, a handful slipped past the security measures. Your next priority is neutralizing them before they cause further harm."**

He could already tell where this was going. "Let me guess. They're deep in the city."

"Yes. The Black Tide concentration is significantly higher in that region, and most teams cannot risk prolonged exposure. You, however, are a different case."

Of course. He was the obvious choice. His immortality gave him an undeniable advantage, even if he didn’t particularly like the reason why.

“Alright,” he muttered, rolling his shoulders. “Give me the locations.”

There was a brief pause, then two markers pinged onto his visor’s display.

“Sector M-13. Intelligence suggests possible hostages.”

“Sector R-4. Reports of a high-priority fugitive last seen in the area.”

Hostages took priority. He was already moving before Goldweaver could say anything else, sprinting toward the nearest operators.

“I need a mapped route through the contamination zones,” he said quickly enough. “Potential hostages in M-13. Figure out the best way in *now*.”

They scrambled to comply, pulling up

projections of the district and marking possible safe pathways. Mydei committed the fastest route to memory.

Then, just before taking off, his gaze locked with Castorice’s.

A brief look. Silent understanding.

He didn’t need to say anything. She was already shifting her stance, angling herself toward the direction he was heading.

By the time he dashed past her, she was already covering him.

The city was a warzone, but still manageable.

The Black Tide clung to the streets in thick, pulsating masses, twisting the very air with its unnatural presence. Anything it touched was corroded—metal rusting, stone crumbling, the very fabric of reality warping at the edges.

Didn’t matter. He pushed forward, dodging a collapsed tram with practiced ease. Something shrieked to his right—one of the larger mutations, its body barely holding shape as it dragged itself toward him.

Too slow.

His gauntlet flared. One hit, and it crumpled.

The deeper he went, the worse it got. The Tide was heavier here, thick enough to blot out the emergency lights and shroud the streets in an eerie, suffocating dimness. Every step felt like walking through a battlefield long since abandoned—except this one was still very much alive, shifting, waiting.

A lesser fighter would’ve hesitated. He didn’t.

He vaulted over a barricade, boots landing silently against the ruined pavement. Another group of corrupted creatures had formed ahead, grotesque and unstable, their bodies still struggling to adapt to their own mutations.

Pathetic.

He didn’t even slow down. The first one lunged, and he met it with an elbow to the skull, feeling the brittle crunch of bone beneath his strike. Before the others could react, he slammed a gauntleted fist into the ground, sending a shockwave rippling through the street. The force splintered the cracked asphalt, sending the weaker ones sprawling. The ones that weren’t dead yet wouldn’t be standing for long.

This wasn’t a fight, more a cleanup.

Sector M-13 loomed ahead. Buildings reduced to skeletal remains, streets littered with debris and the unmistakable marks of struggle. But even in the chaos, he could see movement—people trapped, survivors huddled in whatever cover they could find.

And between them and safety?

Escaped convicts. Armed. Opportunistic. And very, very unlucky.

He pressed a finger to his earpiece. “Goldweaver, I’m here. It’s bad.”

“Expected. What’s the situation?”

“Survivors spread across multiple buildings, too many hostiles for a direct engagement without risks. But we got lucky—some heroes are already in the area.”

A flicker of movement caught his eye—government-backed responders setting up defensive positions. Good. He could work with this.

“I’ll coordinate with them,” he said. “Fastest way to minimize casualties.”

“Understood. Keep me updated.”

He cut the line and moved, dropping down next to one of the nearest hero units. They flinched at first, but then recognition flickered in their eyes.

“It’s Godslayer,” someone muttered.

Damn right it was.

“Status?” he asked, wasting no time.

“We’ve secured two buildings, but the hostiles have barricaded the third. They’ve got hostages, and we can’t risk a frontal assault.”

Mydei nodded. “Alright. We do this clean. No unnecessary losses.”

A plan was already forming. He mapped out the quickest routes, calculated the points of least resistance, and—most importantly—determined exactly how hard he’d have to hit to get the job done.

He cracked his knuckles.

“Here’s how we’re doing this.”

The plan went off like clockwork.

The heroes took position at the north and south entrances while Mydei handled the rest. He moved fast—too fast for the convicts to react properly. The first was disarmed before he even realized someone was there, his weapon skidding across the floor as Mydei drove a knee into his gut. Another lunged with a blade, and Mydei let him land the hit—just to prove a point.

The knife slid in, piercing fabric and skin alike.

The convict grinned for half a second. Then that grin faltered as Mydei, completely unfazed, grabbed him by the wrist and yanked the knife out himself. He twisted, flipping the guy over his shoulder and slamming him into the floor hard enough to knock him unconscious.

“Didn’t even need that kidney anyway,” Mydei muttered, flicking the blood off the blade before tossing it aside.

The others weren’t as stupid. They tried to run. Mydei was faster.

One by one, they dropped—disarmed, disabled, unconscious. He didn’t need to kill them. He was methodical, and every move was aimed at maximizing speed while minimizing damage. Within minutes, the threat was neutralized, and the hostages were free.

Normally, he’d guide them out himself, but the moment he stepped outside, he knew something was wrong.

The Tide was getting worse.

The air felt heavier, thick with the sickly distortion that came with its spread. The streets trembled as patches of it pulsed and expanded, latching onto the ruined buildings like an infection. This wasn’t just lingering residue—this was active corruption.

He clicked his tongue. No time.

Digging into his pocket, he pulled out a standardized Chrysos Heir-issued communication device—smaller, simpler, nowhere near as advanced as what he usually used, but enough to get the job done. He shoved it into one of the hero's hands.

"Use this to navigate out. I already linked it to the emergency channels—someone will guide you through."

The hero looked at him, confused. "What about you?"

"Got my own."

Every Chrysos Heir did. Their standard communicators were advanced, but their personal devices? Far more specialized, each tailored to their individual needs. Mydei's was his terminal earring—direct access to Goldweaver, encrypted signals, and more secure channels. He didn't need anything else.

"Get them out of here," he ordered, already turning away. "I'll handle the rest."

He tapped his earring.

"Goldweaver, heading to the second location now. Give me the fastest route."

"On it. Stay sharp, Godslayer."

He inhaled, rolling his shoulders. He didn't need to remember the pain from before—it was already gone. The wounds, the exhaustion, the damage—none of it mattered.

He started running.

The advantage of a disaster like this—if you could even call it that—was the instability it left behind. The Black Tide didn't just corrupt the physical world; in some places, it tore through reality itself, leaving behind unstable rifts that could lead… well, anywhere. Dangerous, unpredictable, and usually lethal. But if you knew what you were doing?

It could be a shortcut.

Mydei's terminal crackled to life, Tribbie's voice cutting through the static.

"De! You're heading the wrong way—wait, no, the right way—but also, uh, be careful?"

He arched a brow, sidestepping a pulsing vein of corruption as he sprinted down the ruined street. "You're not making a strong case here."

"Look, you're near a rift—Sector R-4's straight through it, so you could use it to get there faster. But also, it's a rift. So, y'know. Do that thing where you don't die. "

He exhaled, shifting his trajectory. "Got coordinates?"

"Already linked to your display! It's stable enough for a one-way trip, so—wait, before you go! How's the purge looking?"

A new voice cut in before he could respond. Goldweaver.

"The threads are in place." Her tone was smooth, measured, carrying that ever-present air of control. **"I'm reinforcing Trinnon's efforts—once everything is set, we'll be able to cleanse a significant portion of the Tide in one go."**

That was good. That was necessary. The longer the corruption lingered, the worse the city's chances were. Mydei gave a sharp nod, even though she couldn't see it. "I'll leave that to you, then."

And with that, he stepped forward and plunged into the rift.

The world twisted.

For a brief moment, he felt weightless, the sensation of movement shifting in every direction at once. Color blurred, space bent—and then, just as quickly, everything snapped back into place.

He landed in a crouch, boots striking cracked pavement. A gust of displaced air rippled outward, sending dust scattering across the ruined street.

Sector R-4.

His gaze flicked upward, locking onto the building ahead.

That was way too close to the source of the Black Tide.

Even with the corruption spreading throughout the city, there were places that were worse than others—pockets where the contamination was so dense that even trained responders wouldn't risk venturing inside. Civilians? They wouldn't have stood a chance. If there had been survivors here, they were long gone.

Which meant the fugitive inside was a much bigger problem.

His visor flickered as real-time intel flooded in. The suspect's profile was updating rapidly, a stream of encrypted data pulling from multiple sources. Mydei scanned through it, exhaling sharply.

"Of course."

He had every reason to turn back. This area was unsalvageable, the probability of survivors was almost nonexistent, and the criminal inside? Probably already dead.

But still.

He wasn't the type to leave things to chance.

Cracking his knuckles, Mydei rolled his shoulders and made his decision.

One way or another, he was checking it out.

He couldn't die, anyway.

As Mydei approached the building, his visor continued streaming data on the target. The profile flickered with corrupted patches—interference from

the Black Tide—but enough came through for him to piece together the picture.

Alias: Red Ghoul
Real Name: Unconfirmed
Species: Mutant (Class Unknown)
Known Affiliation(s): None (Suspected Mercenary)
Threat Level: High
Crimes: Multiple counts of homicide, illegal bio-modifications, suspected Black Tide experimentation

A mutant. Not just any mutant, either—Red Ghoul had a reputation. Reports painted them as a walking nightmare, something between an assassin and a scavenger, with cybernetic enhancements so invasive they blurred the line between organic and machine. Some claimed they harvested corpses for parts. Others said they could sense the dying, drawn to death like a vulture.

And now, they were here. In the dead center of one of the most contaminated zones in the city.

Mydei exhaled through his nose, stepping cautiously through the crumbling entrance. Even for him, this was dangerous.

The first thing that hit him was the stench.

Rot. Everything unnatural. It clung to the air, thick enough to taste. He ignored it, keeping his breathing steady as his gaze swept the ruined interior.

The place was beyond salvageable. Corruption twisted through the structure like veins, pulsing with a dull, malignant glow. The walls were warped, the floor cracked and uneven. Worse, it felt wrong. Even standing still, there was a sensation of movement, as if the space itself was subtly shifting, bending under the weight of the Tide’s influence.

Not good. Not good at all.

He should leave soon.

Even his internal systems were starting to register mild interference. He ran a quick check—still functional, but definitely not at full capacity. The longer he stayed, the more compromised his equipment would become.

His visor pinged, pulling his attention to the aerial surveillance feed from the council. The drones circling outside were barely holding together, their signals flickering in and out. The Black Tide wasn't just distorting their visuals—it was *breaking them down.* Machinery didn't last long in places like this. If they failed completely, he'd lose his external feed.

And he'd rather not be *blind* in a place like this.

Jaw tightening, he made his decision.

A quick sweep. Get eyes on the situation. Confirm the target—alive or dead—and get out.

At some point the aerial feed crackled with statistic again, its images distorted by the Black Tide's corruptive reach. The drones were failing, barely holding together, but one managed to push through the interference—just enough to capture movement.

A figure, jagged and shifting through the flickering data.

Red Ghoul.

He moved like something not entirely human, a silhouette stretched and wrong, half-eaten by the feed's decay. Mydei watched in calculated silence, waiting for the right moment to act, until—

"Leave."

Goldweaver's voice cut through the channel.

"This isn't the time, Godslayer. He'll come out. He has to. The Tide won't let him last long, and when he does, we'll take him down on our terms. Don't risk yourself over this."

She wasn’t wrong. Mydei hummed in agreement, already shifting his weight to leave—

—until the drone caught something else.

Another heat signature.

No. *Two*.

Huddled close in the same room as Red Ghoul, barely distinguishable through the noise of the malfunctioning surveillance. One smaller, child-sized. The other adult. Hiding.

They shouldn’t be here.

They *couldn’t* be here.

Everything about the situation was wrong—too close to the source, too deep in the contamination. No one should have even lived. Yet the scan held, confirming the trembling figures against the ruin.

Something about the way they moved—*the way they didn’t move*—made the space feel heavier. A pressure, not against Mydei, but in the atmosphere itself. A presence that had no place in a dying cityscape, in a place where no one should have survived.

Mydei braced himself, already about to advance forth. He wasn’t leaving. Not now.

“Mydei.”

Aglaea’s voice slipped through the comms with a chilling precision. There was no plea in her tone, no room for hesitation.

“You *will* leave that building.”

Silence.

“They are dead.”

The way she said it left no space for argument. It was not a guess, it was a verdict.

“You are the strongest of the Chrysos Heirs. We do not waste you for sentimentality.”

His fists clenched at his sides, but he knew better than to argue. It was not the first time he had to walk away from the already damned. It would not be the last.

He turned back toward the exit, but his gaze flickered one last time to the screen. The drone’s battered feed stuttered, breaking apart into static, then snapping back into clarity for just a second—just enough for him to commit their shapes to memory.

He would find their families. He would apologize, *personally*.

And then the blur sharpened.

For a single, impossible moment, the image cleared.

White hair.

A familiar silhouette, too distinct to be a trick of the flickering lens.

And then, the final confirmation—

A pair of blue eyes staring directly into the drone’s dying lens.

Everything in Mydei’s mind went blank.

The screen shattered into darkness. The last drone collapsed.

“Mydei, move.” Aglaea’s voice was sharp, urgent. “**You’ve lost visual. The Tide will—”**

But he did not respond.

For the first time, in the heart of ruin and death, Mydei stood frozen.

A minute passed.

Too long. *Far* too long.

Aglaea, attuned to every breath of hesitation, hesitated herself.

“Mydeimos?”

Not Godslayer. Just his name.

His hands trembled at his sides.

Because the reason he froze was painfully simple.

It was Phainon.

Aglaea kept speaking, her voice threaded with urgency, her words deliberate and cutting.

“Mydeimos, respond. Now.”

Nothing.

“Mydei.”

Still nothing.

A pause. He could hear the flicker of her patience burning low, the weight of command pressing into her next words.

“If you—”

“…Sorry.”

It was barely a whisper, barely a word, but it was there. Numb.

Aglaea faltered, something rare flickering in her composure. **“What?”**

But before she could demand clarification—

The connection cut.

Silence.

True, suffocating silence.

Mydei had severed the link, shutting himself off completely. The last tether to Goldweaver, to Aglaea, to any semblance of control—gone.

The next second, he moved.

The wind howled around him as he took off in a dead sprint, his body reacting before his mind fully caught up. He was fast—too fast for the ruined structures around him to even register as more than a blur. Debris collapsed in his wake, the ground splintering beneath each powerful stride, but he was already past it, navigating the destruction with inhuman precision.

His mind was a storm.

Why?

Why was Phainon here?

He should have been evacuated. He should have been safe.

A flash of blue eyes in a dying screen.

He should not have been there.

His body weaved through the labyrinth of devastation, every movement with intent, yet his thoughts were chaos. A thousand possibilities crashed into him at once, each one more infuriating than the last.

Did he get lost? Did something happen?

Did he—

The thought solidified.

Did he leave?

Mydei's breath hitched, realization slicing through his haze of panic.

Did he *leave* the shelters to give others space? To go save people himself?

Clarity hit him like a blade to the gut.

Of *course* he did.

That idiot. That complete and utter idiot.

Mydei cursed ten generations of Phainon's ancestors under his breath, spitting out every insult he could think of as he neared the location. His worry twisted into pure, unfiltered frustration.

That absolute fool. That self-sacrificing, reckless, idiot.

He swore that if Phainon wasn't already half-dead, *he'd* kill him himself.

But first—he needed a plan.

His pace slowed as he approached the ruined room, his movements shifting into something more slower. Reckless speed would get him caught; he needed to be quiet. Invisible.

Stealthy it is.

The interior was worse than expected.

The smell of rot was even worse here. Thick, suffocating, the walls slick with something that pulsed like a dying heartbeat.

And in the center of it all—

Red Ghoul.

The cameras hadn't done him justice.

In person, he looked *wrong*.

His body had deteriorated, flesh hanging in strips, his limbs elongated beyond what should be possible. His face was barely recognizable, his jaw unhinged, a grotesque mimicry of something once human. The Black Tide had done more than just consume him—it had *remade* him into something eldritch, something that no longer belonged in this world.

But Mydei wasn't focused on him.

His gaze swept the room, searching, calculating. He ignored the hushed, ragged breaths of Red Ghoul and instead traced the jagged lines of destruction, scanning—searching.

And then—

There.

His eyes locked onto a crumbled section of rubble, barely noticeable amidst the ruin. But beneath it, tucked in the shadows, were two shapes.

One small.

One familiar.

His breath caught.

Phainon.

Huddled there with the child, unmoving, hiding.

Mydei's fingers twitched. His mind sharpened.

He had a target.

Now, he just needed to get them *out.*

Fighting Red Ghoul was out of the question—too unstable, too much risk. Instead, he slipped past the wreckage, using the jagged remains of the

building as cover, weaving through the ruined space toward Phainon and the kid.

He got close enough to see them properly.

Phainon looked *wrecked*.

Even in the dim, sickly light, exhaustion was written all over him—too pale, too still, eyes half-lidded with barely any strength left. He was barely upright, only held together by sheer stubbornness.

But when he spotted Mydei—*really* saw him—something flickered to life in his eyes. Recognition.

And then he moved.

Mydei watched, confusion sparking as Phainon shifted, pushing himself up just enough to do *something*. It wasn't until Phainon struggled to lift the kid, an obvious *take them* in his expression, that Mydei realized.

You absolute moron.

Phainon—half-conscious, barely functioning—was still trying to *help*.

If it came down to it, he was planning to shove the kid into Mydei's arms and run, even if it meant staying behind.

Mydei wanted to slap him.

Just stay put for once in your life, he wanted to say. *Just rest. I've got this.*

Instead, he exhaled sharply, stepping in. No time for arguing. He'd handle it.

With the child held securely in one arm, he gripped Phainon's wrist with the other and pulled him along. He wanted to throw him over his shoulder, *force* him to rest, but Phainon was still standing, still moving—barely, but enough. So Mydei settled for dragging him at a pace just shy of urgent, putting as much distance between them and that place as possible.

They didn’t stop until the air felt cleaner, until the corruption wasn’t suffocating the very space around them, and until they were a safe distance away from Red Ghoul. Only then did Mydei slow, turn, and finally *look* at him.

“You absolute *fool*.”

It wasn’t shouted, wasn’t even particularly loud, but the sheer weight of those words could have crushed stone.

“What the hell were you thinking?” His voice was steady, too controlled. “Do you have any idea what would’ve happened if I hadn’t been there? If I’d been just a few minutes late?” He almost snapped, eyes flicking over Phainon’s exhausted frame, the barely concealed weariness in his stance. “You think you could’ve just handled it on your own? That you could’ve somehow saved both yourself *and* the child without consequence?”

His grip on Phainon’s wrist tightened for just a second before he let go.

“I don’t know what kind of martyr complex you’re running on, but I *promise* you—throwing yourself into a death trap isn’t heroism, it’s recklessness.” His tone wasn’t unkind, but it still cut deep. “And what’s worse? You didn’t even consider what your death would cause. Did you think about the people waiting for you? The ones who would have to carry the weight of your loss?”

His jaw clenched. He couldn’t say *I would have had to carry that loss.* He couldn’t say *Do you have any idea how much worse this could have gone?*

Instead, he calmed, voice dropping just enough to be softer—but no less firm.

“Don’t ever do something this stupid again.”

A pause. Then, curtly, “Are you hurt?”

Because no matter how angry he was, Phainon’s well-being still came first.

Phainon blinked, caught off guard, but he didn’t waver. “I’m fine,” he said, but there was no real point in pretending, so he pressed on. “But the important thing is—” He drew in a quick breath. “While I was hiding, I overheard something.”

Mydei said nothing, but his stance alone made it clear he was listening.

“The man,” Phainon continued, slower, like he was still working through what he heard. “I don’t know what he is, but he kept laughing. Kept saying it was finally happening. That he was finally going to be himself again.” He shifted slightly, glancing toward where he had been before Mydei arrived. “And he had machines. I didn’t see them, but he sounded desperate. Like they were his last chance.”

Something in Mydei’s expression hardened.

Figures.

Red Ghoul’s whole twisted goal had been to reverse what had been done to him. He had already tried using the Black Tide before. This had to be his next step—devices built to withstand the corruption long enough to force some kind of transformation.

Even if they purged the area, the effects wouldn’t end there. If those machines actually worked, the damage they left behind would be lasting.

Damn it.

“Let me help.”

Mydei nearly laughed. Instead, his hand caught Phainon’s shoulder, stopping him before he could say anything else. “No.”

Phainon stiffened but didn’t step back.

“You *can’t* help.” Mydei’s voice was firm, biting, and entirely unamused. “You don’t know what you’re dealing with. You don’t even know what he’s *trying* to do.” His grip tightened for a second before he forced himself to let go. “And you can barely stand.”

Phainon inhaled sharply. “I can still—”

“Don’t.” Mydei cut him off before he could even finish the thought.

This wasn’t just stubbornness—this was *insistence*. He actually thought he could contribute right now. That he *should*.

“You saved the kid,” Mydei said flatly. “That’s what matters. Now stop looking for a way to make things harder.”

Phainon looked away, jaw tight. Not out of regret, though. Not even out of embarrassment or shame. Like he was still trying to find an argument that would work.

Mydei closed his eyes, shoving down the very real urge to grab him and shake some sense into him. Instead, he reached out, catching Phainon’s chin just enough to make him look up again. “*Listen*.” His tone dropped lower, barely masking his irritation. “Do you think you’re helping? Throwing yourself around until you can’t even function anymore?” His fingers twitched, but he let go. “You already did your part. Now get out of here before you turn into another problem I have to deal with.”

He didn’t wait for an answer. He was already turning. “No arguments.”

Mydei scanned the area as his mind worked through the fastest way to get them out. No equipment, no backup, no way to call for help. That left only one real option—get Phainon and the kid out of the building, point them toward the rift, and let them handle the rest.

He didn’t like it. Leaving them behind in any capacity felt wrong. But Phainon could manage. He was capable enough for this, even if Mydei would rather be the one ensuring their safety the entire way through.

The child in his arms hadn’t stirred once. That wasn’t good.

His grip adjusted slightly, shifting the kid just enough to press two fingers against their pulse. Still there. Weak, but there. The Black Tide’s influence must have been creeping in. If that spread too far—

No. Mydei pushed everything else down, steadying himself. He couldn’t afford the distraction.

Then, without another word, he motioned for Phainon to follow.

Phainon hesitated. Mydei could feel it, even without looking. A pause just long enough to mean something, to make it clear that Phainon still wanted to argue.

But he didn’t. He only clenched his jaw and moved.

Good.

Mydei picked the best route in seconds, then they were running. He took the lead, clearing debris with quick movements, making sure the path stayed open. Phainon stayed close behind, steady despite how long he’d been in the contamination zone. He wasn’t faltering. Alright. That meant this was possible.

They just needed to make it out before anything else got in their way.

The child in his arms was still out cold—not ideal, but he could deal with that once they were safe.

He didn’t glance back when he asked, “You holding up?”

Phainon’s footsteps didn’t falter. “Yeah.” His voice was even, but something about it felt slightly off.

Mydei didn’t dwell on it. There were bigger concerns right now.

A sickening noise, wet and wrong, echoed through the hollowed-out building. Mydei immediately tensed, already bracing to deal with it—

But Phainon moved first.

By the time Mydei turned, Phainon had already grabbed a piece of broken piping from the rubble, wielding it with a grip that was too natural. He

didn’t fumble—he just moved. The pipe slashed through the creature before it could fully lunge, cutting straight through its barely-formed body.

A shriek, then silence.

The thing collapsed, its corrupted flesh warping and twitching from the Tide’s influence before finally going still.

Phainon barely reacted. His stance was solid, breathing measured, like this was nothing out of the ordinary. His mind seemed somewhere else entirely.

And then, suddenly, it wasn’t.

His expression flickered—like something had just occurred to him—before he abruptly let go of the pipe, letting it clang loudly against the ground.

Mydei’s eyes narrowed slightly. “You have training with a sword.”

Phainon blinked at him, then, after the briefest pause, smiled. It wasn’t forced, but it wasn’t quite real either. “Yeah. I had training.”

There was no tension, but there was something off.

Mydei’s gaze stayed firm. “From where?”

Phainon didn’t hesitate long. “An old instructor. Used to teach at a dueling hall before it shut down.”

That was a lie.

Mydei didn’t know if that meant Phainon had just never *mentioned* it before or if he was actively hiding something. But *why* lie?

His technique was too practiced for some amateur dueling lessons. He hadn’t just *learned* how to wield a blade—his body had *memorized* it. That kind of precision didn’t come from casual training. It came from repetition. From experience.

He was still Phainon. But the way he had moved, the way he had let that easy smile cover up whatever had crossed his mind before—there was a distance to it. A separation.

Now wasn't the time.

Mydei sighed, nodding toward the pipe. "Pick it back up."

Phainon hesitated.

"For protection."

A beat. Then, finally, Phainon grabbed the pipe again.

Mydei turned away, focusing back on their path ahead. "We're nearly there."

And just as Phainon was about to come, because the world hated him, the air between them *fractured*.

A ripple tore through the space like a living infection, spreading outward in jagged lines. The corruption *cut* through reality itself, warping the air into something solid for half a second before unraveling again. Mydei didn't wait to see what came next—he *swerved*.

So did Phainon.

They barely cleared the other side before the world *broke*. The structure beneath them twisted violently, as if the very ground had turned against itself. Stone and metal lurched, reforming into jagged, unnatural angles.

When Mydei landed, he steadied himself fast. Phainon wasn't as lucky.

The shift had left him standing too high, balancing on unstable terrain that hadn't been there a second ago. His footing slipped on the uneven incline, sending debris skidding down beneath him. He barely caught himself. One wrong move, and—

His stomach twisted.

Gritting his teeth, he called out without hesitation. “Phainon!”

He didn’t care if it was strange. If it gave away that he knew his name when he technically shouldn’t. It didn’t matter. Not when Phainon was in danger.

But Phainon *froze*.

It was barely a second, but Mydei saw it—the way his breath hitched, shoulders stiffened, fingers slightly curled as if bracing for something unseen. To anyone else, he would’ve looked merely winded, exhausted from the sprint and the sudden chaos. But Mydei *knew better*.

A shallow inhale. Too quick. His chest rising too fast, too unevenly.

Damn it.

Mydei forced himself to relax, pushing forward. “I need you to trust me.” His voice cut through the distorted air, steady despite the urgency of it.

Phainon looked at him now, eyes locked onto his.

Mydei adjusted his grip on the child, arms bracing. His voice softened, but the conviction behind it never wavered.

“Jump.”

Phainon hesitated. Just for a second. But it was enough.

Then, a sharp inhale. His body went rigid, like he was forcing himself past whatever was freezing him in place. And then he jumped.

Mydei caught him. Arms steady, the impact barely jarring, the weight settling against him as naturally as breathing.

I got you.

Phainon was stiff in his hold, his heartbeat too quick, too shallow, his fingers twitching against Mydei’s sleeve before he forcibly stilled them. But

Mydei didn’t let go immediately, holding him just a second longer, as if willing that lingering tremor away.

Then they were moving.

Fast. The ground beneath them was shifting unpredictably, the Tide still warping the air in sick, unnatural distortions, but Mydei didn’t falter. Phainon was silent in his arms, unnervingly so. If Mydei *didn’t* know him, he’d think he was fine.

But he did. And he wasn’t.

Then, finally, Phainon stirred, breath steadier, voice quieter than usual. “I know the way from here.”

Mydei shot him a look.

Phainon coughed, turning his head. “I… also took that rift.”

The words barely registered before something inside Mydei *snapped*.

He didn’t stop running, but his grip *tightened,* his jaw clenched so hard it ached, every instinct screaming at him.

You what.

He forced himself to inhale through his nose, but it didn’t help. His mind was already spiraling, conjuring every possible scenario, every horrible outcome. That rift wasn’t stable. That rift wasn’t *safe*. He had *Tribbie’s* guidance. He had a way back.

Phainon had nothing.

And yet he still took it.

His fingers twitched against Phainon’s side before he forcibly loosened them. *Not the time. Not here.*

When they finally reached stable ground, Mydei set Phainon down—not rough, but firm, his movements sharper than before. Then, he pressed the unconscious child into his arms, grip lingering just a second too long.

His voice came low, controlled, but edged with something raw. “Hurry up and get out. Stay safe.”

Phainon hesitated. Mydei didn’t. He was already turning away.

The tension in Mydei’s shoulders eased—just slightly—as Phainon finally disappeared from sight. Gone. Safe. He slowed down, steadying himself.

Now, there was nothing left to worry about.

His focus shifted, mind clearing as he assessed the situation. The structural integrity of the area was deteriorating, the air still thick with remnants of the Tide’s corruption, but none of that mattered anymore. The only thing that did was *finishing this.*

Then—an explosion.

It tore through the silence, rattling the foundations of the already broken city. But it wasn’t the erratic, unnatural rupture of the Tide. No, this was deliberate. *Manmade*.

Mydei’s lips curled slightly.

So, Red Ghoul was already moving. Good. That made things easier.

He rolled his shoulders, stretching out the tension left behind from carrying Phainon and the kid. His body was already adjusting, the strain fading. He was built for this—combat, pursuit, ending threats before they spread too far.

And right now, the threat was waiting for him.

He moved, each step carrying a purpose, slipping into the darkened remains of the city with an ease that was almost instinctual. No wasted movement. No hesitation.

If Red Ghoul wanted to burn the place down, fine.

Mydei would put him out himself.

The Rift Zone was a dead place. Not just in the way it looked—silent, empty, stripped of anything remotely natural—but in the way it felt. Reality itself seemed uncertain here, flickering at the edges like a dying signal.

Mydei moved through the collapsed research facility with practiced ease, scanning his surroundings as he stepped over fallen support beams and shattered glass. The place had been wrecked long before today—likely during the first Black Tide breach—but recent disturbances stood out. New scarring in the walls, footprints in the dust, and the faint, mechanical hum of something still running.

Then, he saw them.

Dark, metallic husks embedded into the ground and surrounding walls, pulsing with slow, unnatural light. Aberration Seeds.

Mydei's lips curled, not in surprise, but in recognition.

Back at headquarters, he had seen something similar—an earlier prototype recovered after one of Red Ghoul's failed attempts. Aglaea had called them *parasitic stabilizers*, a grotesque fusion of technology and Tide residue designed to force mutations into something… usable. Red Ghoul's ultimate goal had always been the same: reversing his own condition. He had already gambled with direct exposure to the Black Tide and lost. Now, he was trying to reforge himself with something more controlled.

Or at least, something he *thought* he could control.

Mydei followed along, humming in morbid interest. *So this is your last bet?*

Destroying them one by one would be inefficient. It'd give Red Ghoul time to react, and who knew what kind of failsafes these things had? Instead, Mydei traced the connecting points between them, noting the thinnest links.

There.

The Seeds weren’t working independently—they were networked. If he severed the relay nodes, the entire chain would collapse.

Now for Red Ghoul himself.

With the Seeds out of commission, Red Ghoul would panic, his one hope slipping away. Mydei could use that, force him into a vulnerable position. If he could bait him into attacking prematurely, it’d leave an opening—one well-placed hit could disable him before he had a chance to adapt.

Plan set, Mydei rolled his shoulders, stretching briefly before adjusting his stance.

The source had to be somewhere central, somewhere that could have plausibly been the first point of the Black Tide’s breach.

Mydei’s mind ran through the layout of the facility as he moved, footsteps light against the fractured ground. Research centers like these were built with reinforced containment zones—labs, testing chambers, and most importantly, power cores. If there had been an experiment involving Tide exposure, the central containment sector was the most likely ground zero.

That was where he needed to go.

Navigating the ruins, he kept his profile low, slipping through broken corridors and past rusted terminals. The deeper he went, the worse the damage became. Walls warped as if melted and reformed, the floor littered with remnants of failed experiments—twisted metal, shattered glass, and decayed instruments.

Then, at last, he found it.

A massive containment chamber, once secured behind reinforced doors that now lay in ruins. The air here was thick, humming with an unnatural energy, and at the center of it all was the source.

Red Ghoul.

Or whatever he had become.

He was *wired* into the system.

Cables, grotesquely fused with flesh, ran from his spine and limbs into the Aberration Seeds, linking them directly to his body. It was as if he had made himself the central node, forcing their power through himself in a desperate attempt to override his condition.

Was he insane?

Trick question.

Yes.

The last time Mydei had seen him, Red Ghoul had already been inhuman—deteriorated, grotesquely elongated, his body barely holding together under the weight of Tide corruption. But now?

He was worse.

His form had twisted further, his flesh a shifting patchwork of unnatural textures—some parts decayed, others pulsating like something *growing*. His limbs were jagged, new segments forced into existence where there shouldn't be any. And his eyes—if they could still be called that—were nothing but deep hollows, voids brimming with something that writhed and flickered.

Killing him would be easy.

Killing him *without* triggering a catastrophic reaction from the network? Less so.

Mydei needed a new plan.

Destroying the Seeds was still the key, but now that they were *directly* connected to Red Ghoul, severing them could cause unpredictable side effects. If he took them out too suddenly, the backlash could send whatever was left of Red Ghoul into a full-blown transformation.

No, he needed to overload the system first.

If he could force a surge—make the Aberration Seeds collapse under their own instability—then Red Ghoul wouldn't just lose his connection. It would *reject* him. *The* backlash might be enough to kill him outright, or at the very least, weaken him enough for a finishing blow.

That meant targeting the conduits. The way the cables pulsed, he could see the flow of power. If he struck *there*—

Mydei's grip shifted on his weapon.

Red Ghoul was motionless, save for the occasional twitch—like his body was caught in the aftershocks of something far worse than a nightmare. His breaths rattled through whatever remained of his lungs, shallow and uneven. If he was aware of his surroundings, he showed no sign of it. His entire being was tethered to the Aberration Seeds, to the corrupted network pulsing with unstable energy—his last, desperate grasp at something beyond his reach.

Good. That means I have time.

Mydei's eyes traced the flow of energy through the cables, following their rhythm. Every circuit had a pattern, a sequence it relied on to function. Disrupting it wasn't just about brute force—it was about precision. The conduits stabilized one another in a delicate balance. If he struck fast enough, severing them before they could recalibrate, the entire system would spiral into collapse.

His fingers flexed. Seven points. That was all it would take.

He moved.

A breath.

Then—

The first strike was clean. His blade cut through the conduit like it was paper, the severed link sparking once before dying. A ripple of energy

pulsed through the remaining connections, but Mydei was already gone, pivoting through the shadows.

The second fell just as easily. Sparks scattered across the floor, the circuit already starting to unravel.

Red Ghoul twitched. A sharp inhale—reactive, not conscious.

Mydei didn’t slow.

Third. Fourth. Fifth. Every strike landed in perfect rhythm, precise and merciless. The pulse of corrupted power stuttered, the Aberration Seeds flickering erratically.

The entire system was already failing by the time he reached the last two. Cables spasmed. Energy misfired.

Red Ghoul convulsed.

Not out of awareness—out of rejection.

The corruption that had once sustained him was turning against him, fracturing at its source. His body seized, the network unraveling, cables snapping one by one. His breath hitched, a garbled, wet sound tearing from his throat—

Mydei didn’t wait.

The final strike carved through the last conduit.

A shockwave burst through the chamber as the Aberration Seeds collapsed in on themselves. The cables shrieked, tearing free from Red Ghoul’s body like tendons ripping apart. The light in the chamber flickered, the unstable energy rupturing in its death throes.

And then, for the first time since Mydei had entered the room—

Red Ghoul screamed.

A sound that barely belonged to this world. A distortion of agony. Of something being *unmade*.

Mydei straightened himself as the dust finally settled. His plan had worked.

Now, it was just the two of them.

Time to finish this.

Red Ghoul lunged with a sudden, rabid force.

Mydei met it head-on.

They crashed, tangled in a violent grapple. Mydei ducked under a swipe meant to tear his face apart, bracing his stance before slamming his shoulder into the creature's ribs. It staggered—but not out of pain. There was no pain left in that body, only instinct and rot.

Mydei caught its next strike mid-air and twisted, using the momentum to flip Red Ghoul down onto his back. The sound of bone grinding against stone echoed through the room. He didn't let go. In one smooth movement, he pinned the thing's chest with his knee, grabbing its arm and forcing it behind its back with practiced strength.

It screamed beneath him, wild and broken.

But Mydei didn't move. He only looked down at what was left of the man.

"All this," he said quietly. "For this."

Red Ghoul bucked under him, a distorted snarl curling through its throat. Mydei leaned in, his tone sharp—not cruel, but cutting in the way truth always was.

"Look at yourself. Tell me this is what you wanted. Tell me this was worth the lives you've ruined, the cities you've infected, the people—"

His jaw clenched.

“—you *dragged* in with you.”

Red Ghoul writhed, muscles twitching under corrupted flesh. Mydei’s grip didn’t falter.

“You wanted to ‘be yourself again’? To prove you were more than what you did to yourself? And this is how you do it? Hooked into machines like some desperate parasite, too far gone to even *remember* what you were?”

His voice dropped, cold and controlled.

“Pathetic.”

The creature coughed something wet and foul. Then, barely audible, it rasped:

“Help me…”

A silence followed.

Mydei didn’t answer at first.

That voice—it wasn’t Red Ghoul anymore. It was the man underneath. Whoever he used to be. Whatever was left of him.

And Mydei almost moved. Almost reached for the blade that would make it quick.

Because death was mercy. Anything was better than the Tide consuming what little humanity remained.

But then he saw something else.

He saw Phainon again, high up on broken ground, breath shallow, hands trembling.

He thought of how close he’d come to losing him.

Of how this thing had *caused* it.

The offer of mercy shriveled in his chest.

Red Ghoul's hand reached up, weakly clawing at his leg. Mydei looked down, gaze unreadable.

"Why should I?"

His voice cut clean, no softness left. Final.

The hand fell limp.

But something else began to stir—low and unnatural. The air thickened with pressure, a tension Mydei recognized too well. The Tide was shifting again, warping the space around it like a wound tearing further open.

Not now. Not here.

And Trinnon would be closing in soon. If the cleansing unit caught the edge of this new surge, it'd trigger a far more volatile reaction. He wasn't about to be caught in that crossfire.

Mydei stepped back, casting one last glance at the barely-living husk, the failed dream rotting in real time.

Then he turned and left without hesitation, boots striking through the settling ash.

No satisfaction. No guilt.

Just a clean exit—and the knowledge that whatever came next, *this* wouldn't follow him.

The blast nearly caught him.

Mydei tore through the collapsing hall, heat coiling at his back like a breath on his neck. The air had turned white—radiant, not with fire, but with something searing in its purity. Trinnon's purge protocol had begun. The kind of cleanse that didn't leave ashes behind.

It erased.

He vaulted over a fallen beam, boots skidding across rubble as he forced himself forward. Behind him, walls rippled before detonating into dust, swallowed whole by the advancing wave of light. Cables sparked and disintegrated midair. Stone boiled. The old research facility was coming apart at the seams, undone not by violence, but precision.

Each beat of light moved like a pulse of judgment.

Mydei didn’t stop until he burst through the exterior breach and into the unsteady rift somehow still standing, the pressure dropping in an instant as the light behind him slammed against the walls and swallowed everything within. The shockwave flared, kicked debris into the air, and rolled past him like a second wind.

He staggered forward a step, then dropped to one knee.

The world had gone silent. Not from peace—but from the absence left behind.

A long minute passed. Then another.

His chest rose and fell slowly, breath just now catching up to what his body had done. He leaned back, one hand braced against the broken earth, watching as white light flickered and dimmed inside the ruins. What was left was husk and cinder. No more Red Ghoul. No more Seeds. No more anything.

Just the residue of what nearly had been.

Static crackled softly in his ear.

Faint at first. Then clearer.

The comms were returning.

He reached up, pressing two fingers to his ears, ignoring the weight settling in his limbs.

“Primary threat neutralized,” he said, voice gravel-edged and low. “Facility purged. Mission status: complete.”

A pause.

He let the words hang for a breath longer, then added, quieter:

“Returning.”

No one responded. He hadn’t expected them to. But they were listening.

And that was enough.

He stood, dust trailing from his clothes as he turned from the wreckage and walked into the city.

The streets were hollowed echoes of what they had once been—cracked stone and twisted steel, pillars blackened with residue, and the occasional flicker of Tide-burned light, dimming by the second. The air felt thinner now, like whatever poisoned it had finally begun to withdraw. Mydei walked steadily, not hesitating. Not once.

His comm crackled to life again, clearer this time. Familiar frequency.

“Finally.” The voice slid through the channel like velvet over a blade.

Goldweaver.

He didn’t stop. He didn’t answer.

“Status acknowledged,” she continued, too composed to pass as calm. “**But what happened down there? You went dark. No report. No signal. I was ready to list your name.”**

Still, he walked. His fingers twitched once at his side.

”You were supposed to wait for reinforcement. You know protocol, Mydei. What if you’d fallen inside the Tide’s resonance zone? Do you know how close Trinnon was to declaring a full burn?”

He finally responded, voice even, detached.

“I contained it.”

“That’s not the point.”

Her voice was sharper now, pressed tight into that polished tone she wore like armor. **“You’re not expendable. Don’t pretend this was part of the plan. You acted alone. You endangered yourself. Again.”**

He didn’t answer, not really. Just a soft, brief noise that might’ve been acknowledgment, if only in theory.

“And the criminal?” Her voice slowed—just a fraction. Less fury now. More calculation. **“We had systems in place for humane removal. Sedation injections. Tide-stabilizers. Even remote units we could have expended in worse case scenarios.”**

He stopped.

The wind shifted around him, the scent of burnt circuitry and char still clinging to the air. He looked toward the heart of the city, the structures still standing like shadows behind stained glass.

“Unfortunately,” he said, voice cool as dusk, “he didn’t make it.”

Silence from the other side.

Not disapproval. Not shock.

Just silence.

Goldweaver had known him long enough to recognize when the conversation was closing, whether she liked it or not. She also knew what it meant when his voice slipped into that edge—where control overtook anything human, where he moved like something designed for aftermaths.

And yet—she still asked, quieter this time, **“His name?”**

The pause that followed stretched.

Too long.

When he answered, he didn’t look back.

“Doesn’t matter.”

He cut the channel.

Behind him, the remnants of the rift flared again—faint warping across the edge of the skyline, the Tide trying, stubbornly, to linger. It wouldn’t win. Not this time.

He pressed forward, pace quickening as the structure behind him groaned in warning. Another breach wave. He could feel it in the air, tension prickling like static on skin. Trinnon was almost there, which meant the final phase would begin soon—total cleansing.

He made it to the outskirts just as the sky above the facility blanched white.

The light wasn’t blinding—but absolute. A dome of purity, unfurling with precision, swallowing the corruption whole. The ground shuddered under the weight of it, the force of the purge cleansing every twisted remnant with brutal efficiency. Whatever was left in that building wouldn’t survive. Not even memory.

Mydei barely cleared the edge, stumbling forward onto a ridge of half-buried stone. Dust scraped at his lungs. He fell to one knee, bracing himself, breath caught in his throat.

He stayed there for a long moment, unmoving. His body wasn’t broken, but it had been too close. Far too close.

The comms crackled faintly again—no voice, just the quiet return of connection.

He didn’t answer immediately.

When he did, it was even.

“Chrysos Heir Mydeimos. Returning to central node.” A pause. Then, steadier: “No casualties remaining.”

He stood, brushing ash from his sleeve.

There would be questions. Briefings. Reports.

But right now, all that mattered was that he walked away.

Then. The sky split with the rush of wings.

A shadow passed overhead—large, swift, scouting. Mydei barely needed to look up to know what it was. The rhythmic beat of its flight was too distinct, the presence too controlled to be anything else.

The dragon circled once, then descended, landing with a force that sent loose debris skittering. Dust kicked up, but before it could settle, a figure shifted from its back, peering down.

Castorice.

Blood streaked her clothing—none of it hers. Her scythe rested against her back, but she carried herself as if she could summon it to her hand in an instant. Her gaze met his, steady, unreadable. Then, with the barest tilt of her head, as if to say, *You need a ride?*

Mydei didn’t hesitate.

With practiced ease, he hauled himself onto the dragon’s back, settling just behind her. The moment he was secure, the beast moved, powerful muscles tensing before launching them into the air. Wind rushed past, the ruined cityscape shrinking beneath them.

From the corner of his eye, he caught the faintest curve of Castorice’s lips.

The Black Tide breach had been no accident.

It had taken only hours for the truth to surface—official negligence, a failure in oversight that had allowed the corruption to seep through the facility's weakened defenses. The fallout was immediate. Arrests were made. Officials stripped of power.

But the consequences didn't end there.

The department responsible for Tide containment, once an independent branch with near-total jurisdiction over incidents like this, was swiftly demoted. In its place, a new leadership structure formed—one that placed greater emphasis on cooperation with external forces.

Specifically, with vigilantes.

It wasn't a complete shift. Vigilantes had always been legally recognized, but they operated outside the direct oversight of government-backed heroes. Now, their involvement was not only permitted but quietly encouraged. The public, still reeling from the devastation, placed their trust in those who had acted first, without hesitation—regardless of their official status.

Not everyone approved.

Tensions simmered between traditional heroes and those who worked outside the system. Some viewed the change as necessary, a long-overdue acknowledgment of the role vigilantes played. Others saw it as a threat—a blurring of the line between sanctioned enforcement and unregulated power.

For Mydei, it wasn't his fight.

He stayed where he was needed, boots on the ground, helping with the cleanup effort. He hadn't intended to linger—his original destination was elsewhere—but watching the city pull itself back together shifted something in him.

The streets were a mess. Ruined structures loomed like hollowed-out ribs, and the scars of the Tide's presence remained in the blackened cracks and distorted surfaces. But amid the wreckage, there was movement.

People—volunteers, survivors, heroes, vigilantes—all working together. Clearing debris, offering supplies, ensuring no one was left behind. There was no division here, no argument over status or jurisdiction. Only action.

It was rare, seeing something like this.

A moment where the weight of everything didn't crush people apart—but pulled them closer.

Mydei took it in. Then, without ceremony, he stepped forward and joined them.

For hours, Mydei worked alongside the volunteers, clearing rubble, stabilizing structures, doing what needed to be done. Some people approached him with quiet gratitude—shopkeepers, workers, people who had recognized his silhouette during the worst of the disaster.

Each time, he responded simply. "No need. This is my responsibility."

It wasn't humility. Just a fact.

Then the elderly came.

An old woman took his hand, squeezing it with surprising strength, her eyes shimmering with unshed tears as she whispered blessings. Another grasped his wrist, her voice trembling as she thanked him for saving her grandson.

And Mydei—who had faced horrors and monsters without flinching—stood still, uncertain.

He let them hold on as long as they needed. He bowed his head when they murmured their thanks.

And when a child tugged at his sleeve, he knelt.

A group of them had gathered near the cleared rubble, wide-eyed and whispering. One of them, a boy with dust-streaked cheeks, pointed at him.

"You're really strong."

A girl with a missing front tooth nodded. “Are you a hero?”

“No,” Mydei said, shaking dirt from his gloves.

The boy frowned. “A vigilante?”

“Something like that.”

“Do you fight bad guys?”

“Yes.”

The children exchanged glances, and then, as if on cue, they broke into action—punching the air, kicking invisible enemies, making exaggerated sound effects. One, for some reason, started rolling on the ground.

Mydei watched in silence, then huffed. Not quite a laugh, but close.

Then movement caught his attention.

A convoy of white vehicles pulled in, emblazoned with the insignia of the Special Medical Response Team. Their personnel stood out—clean, efficient, specialized for high-risk contamination zones.

And among them was a familiar figure.

Hyacine.

She moved quickly through the field, tending to patients with practiced ease. Unlike the other Chrysos Heirs, she wasn’t a fighter. She didn’t need to be. Her strength lay elsewhere—healer, assistant, support. Someone who saved lives in ways that didn’t require masks or codenames.

Then she saw him.

Her entire expression brightened.

“Mydei!” She practically skipped over, radiating warmth despite the destruction around them. “Oh, thank goodness—I was hoping I’d run into

you!”

She stopped in front of him, tilting her head as she scanned him over. “You’re all in one piece… right?”

“I’m fine.”

She let out a relieved sigh. “You *look* exhausted. Have you even sat down?”

“I’ve had worse.”

She frowned, hands on her hips. “That’s not the same as an answer.”

He didn’t respond. She sighed.

“Well, at least you’re alive,” she said, then added, more brightly, “Oh! Do you need medical attention? It’s not too late to sit down for a check-up, you know!”

He gave her a look.

She giggled. “Okay, okay, I won’t pester you… for now.”

There was a pause before Mydei spoke again, quieter this time. “You’ve been treating patients all day.”

“Yep! Non-stop since we got the all-clear to move in.”

His fingers twitched at his side. “Did you treat anyone with white hair? Blue eyes?”

Hyacine blinked, then tapped a finger against her chin, thinking. “White hair and blue eyes… oh! Yes, I did! He just left, actually.”

Mydei’s gaze sharpened. “Left?”

She nodded. “I know, right? I was surprised, too! He was in the worst part of the city for hours, but when he came in for evaluation—” she gestured vaguely, “—he was *fine*. Like, barely affected at all.”

Mydei frowned.

Hyacine continued, “Everyone was so shocked that they actually asked him to consider joining this new civilian defense program! He’s kind of a miracle case.”

He narrowed his eyes slightly. “And?”

She puffed her cheeks. “He refused. Completely.”

That wasn’t surprising. But still.

Hyacine sighed. “I tried to talk him into at least considering it, but nope! He just smiled and said, ‘I appreciate the offer, but I have my own path to walk.’”

Mydei exhaled slowly. That sounded about right. He loved Phainon, truly, but only he’d say something like that.

Hyacine rocked on her heels. “He was polite about it, but he definitely wasn’t changing his mind. Then he left! Not in a rush, just… like he already knew where he was going next, so he should be fine.”

Mydei didn’t say anything at first. Then, finally, he inclined his head.

“Thanks, Hyacine.”

“Of course! Let me know if you need anything, okay?” She beamed, then hesitated. “…And *please* try to rest at some point.”

He said nothing.

She sighed, shaking her head fondly before hurrying back to her work.

Mydei remained where he was for a moment.

Then, finally, he turned and walked away.

He had been searching for nearly an hour when he finally found him.

Phainon stood at the edge of a quiet street, leaning slightly against a railing, watching the remnants of the night's disaster fade into the distance. The uneven glow of the streetlights cast long shadows over his figure, highlighting the exhaustion in his posture, the careful stillness of someone who had spent far too long holding himself together.

At Mydei's approach, Phainon turned, his gaze honing as he took in the red-clad figure before him.

For a brief moment, there was hesitation—then recognition.

"…Godslayer."

Mydei exhaled slowly. Even now, hearing that name directed at him felt strange. But he pushed that aside.

"You're still standing," he said. It wasn't quite a question, but there was something pointed in the way he said it.

Phainon's mouth quirked, something almost like amusement flickering in his expression. "I was given the all-clear by the medical team. They seemed more surprised about it than I was."

Understandable.

"…And the child?" Mydei asked after a beat.

"Safe," Phainon answered. "Reunited with her family."

Something in Mydei's chest eased, though he only gave a short nod. "Good."

A pause. Then—

"I'll walk you home."

Phainon blinked, visibly caught off guard. "That isn't necessary."

“Didn’t ask if it was.”

Phainon gave him a long look, as if trying to read his intentions. “…I appreciate the offer, but I can assure you, I am not in any danger.”

“I know.” Mydei’s tone was unhurried but didn’t lack conviction, “I’ll still walk you home.”

Another hesitation.

Then, finally, with a quiet breath, Phainon gave a small nod. “…Very well.”

They started walking.

The city around them was still in disarray, but there was a quiet effort in the way people moved—volunteers clearing debris, healers tending to the wounded, small clusters of survivors reuniting under the pale glow of the streetlights. The aftermath of a storm, but one that hadn’t completely drowned the city.

Mydei let himself focus on that. The steady rhythm of footsteps, the distant murmur of conversation, the rare moment of quiet that settled between them.

Then—

“I take it there was some unfinished business.”

Goldweaver’s voice, smooth and unhurried, filled his earpiece.

Mydei’s stride didn’t falter, but his jaw clenched.

“And here I thought you weren’t the sentimental type.”

He didn’t hesitate. He reached up and disconnected the channel without a word.

Phainon glanced at him, faintly curious. “Something urgent?”

“…Nothing that needs addressing.”

Phainon didn’t pry. He simply nodded and kept walking.

And Mydei, without even realizing it, fell into step beside him.

Chapter End Notes

Point out any mistakes yall I didn’t proofread sorry

This is not a good start to April I gotta lock in omg

Chapter 7: Mydei Jr. Deserved Better

Chapter Summary

> Phainon signs up for a civilian defense course without reading the fine print, promptly regrets it, names a training dummy “Mydei Jr.,” and nearly gets replaced by a clone with better posture. Mydei saves the day (and their fake child), Phainon flirts through an identity crisis, and somehow they leave more emotionally bonded than when they started. 10/10 romance, 0/10 government oversight.

Chapter Notes

> Half of this was written pre 3.2 the other post, and then at the end (abt roughly at the clone scene) it was kind of rushed for certain reasons so sorry abt that
>
> Hope the quality wasn’t too bad by the end, I needed a breather after that😭 Enjoy <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon sat on the park bench, gingerly pressing the side of his face. The sting had dulled, but the memory hadn’t. A few curious birds hopped near his boots, one of them tilting its head up at him like it, too, had just witnessed a man get obliterated by the palm of someone 2 centimeters shorter and way too handsome to be that violent.

“Damn,” Phainon muttered under his breath, flexing his jaw. “That man has arms.”

A squirrel chittered nearby, and for a second, he considered taking that personally.

The breeze was nice, at least. The kind of spring air that made the city feel deceptively normal again, despite the fact half of it had been swallowed by otherworldly corruption just last week. People passed by with coffee cups

and grocery bags, too busy returning to their lives to notice one of the Black Tide survivors sulking on public property. He had a hoodie pulled halfway up—not because he was cold, but because he was still emotionally nursing the absolute *hellfire* of a slap he'd received from his boyfriend.

Which, to be clear, was *after* the reunion. Not during. Not in place of it. **After**.

And oh, what a reunion it had been.

Phainon had turned a corner in the wreckage and found him—Mydei, alive, whole, shaken but standing. He hadn't been expecting it. One second he'd been scanning the crumbled streets, the next there was Mydei, backlit by smoke and unnatural golden haze, eyes wide like he wasn't sure Phainon was real. For a moment, neither of them said a word. Just *looked*.

Then Mydei broke. His knees gave out, and Phainon caught him before he could fall. The whole world around them had smelled like blood and ozone, but Mydei had buried his face in Phainon's shoulder, breathing him in like he was air and safety and proof the sky hadn't fallen completely.

Phainon remembered holding him, arms firm around that trembling back, and thinking something terrifying and stupid like *I'd do it all again.*

Then five minutes later, Mydei had stepped back, asked a single question —"*Where were you?*"—and upon hearing that Phainon had snuck out of the shelters, into the danger zone, and spent the next several hours helping pull survivors from buildings like he thought he was immortal—

Well.

Slap.

There was no ceremony to it. No windup. No dramatic monologue. Just pure, full-body fury compressed into a perfectly executed strike that damn near rearranged Phainon's internal compass.

His teeth still felt slightly misaligned.

Phainon tilted his head back now, watching the clouds drift by. “To be fair,” he said to no one, “I *did* deserve it.”

He heard again, in memory, the sharp crack of that palm meeting his cheek. He could still see Mydei’s face—eyes rimmed with leftover grief and something that looked too much like betrayal. His lips had been pressed tight, fists shaking at his sides like he wasn’t sure if he wanted to hug Phainon again or throw him through a wall.

Probably both.

“He’d clearly been waiting to do that for a while,” Phainon murmured, touching his cheek again with something dangerously close to fondness. “Guess it was overdue.”

He sulked a little deeper into the bench, hoodie slipping further over his face. The ache was dull now, fading. What lingered was not pain, not really—just the warmth of knowing someone cared enough to be *that* furious. A slap laced with love. Or at least with deeply affectionate homicide.

God, he was in too deep.

He didn’t even know if he was more flattered or aroused.

Probably both.

The city had no right to look this normal.

Phainon’s fingers drummed against the bench slat, slow and irregular. A mother pushed a stroller past him. Somewhere, a construction drone hummed through a half-finished building frame, patching steel with movements too fluid to be human. Storefronts that were craters a week ago now shined with fresh paint. No one was smiling, exactly, but no one was screaming either. The city didn’t heal—it was *forcibly stitched* back together. Brick and glass and quiet desperation, dragged into place by people who didn’t sleep.

Or didn’t have to.

Phainon watched the clean horizon with the distant look of someone trying not to look too closely. He knew what was behind it. Who was behind it.

The Chrysos Heirs.

He didn’t hate them. It’d be too easy if he did. Easier to shove them in a box labeled *problematic idols with a hero complex* and toss it into the fire. But the truth was messier, more apathetic. He didn’t worship them, didn’t really care to understand them. They were just there. Vigilantes who operated above any law but their own, who pretended the world could be purified if you just pressed hard enough on the dirt.

He was different.

He didn’t bother purifying things.

Phainon shifted, arms draped along the back of the bench languidly. He’d killed people during the chaos. Only the worst ones. The ones looting through bodies, the ones dragging women into collapsed buildings. Not a court on earth would’ve touched them. They never did. But he did. Quietly, cleanly.

And he didn’t lose sleep over it.

But Godslayer…

His brow twitched.

Godslayer was also different.

Phainon hadn’t seen him coming—no heroic pose, no dramatic intro. Just a ripple of energy cutting through the Tide, breaking it apart long enough for the path to clear. And Phainon had followed. That had been the plan. He was almost out. Almost.

Then the Tide split the ground beneath him, and he’d frozen.

He hadn’t planned on that.

It came from nowhere—his muscles locked, lungs stalled, heart climbing his ribs with a quiet, rising panic. The Tide rose between them, a black wave with teeth, and he just *stood there*, feet cemented to the broken earth like a child watching the sea swallow something they couldn't name.

Phainon's hand curled loosely against his thigh. Skin taut across knuckles. Tension sinking in slow.

He thought he was over that kind of thing.

Apparently not.

He stared straight ahead, posture slack but coiled underneath. Then, with a sharp breath through his nose, he let it go. Hand loosened. Shoulder rolled.

"Anyway," he murmured.

Godslayer had dragged him back across the barrier, voice sharp, movements tighter than necessary. He'd scolded Phainon like they knew each other. It was too close. Too personal.

He'd said his name.

I need you to trust me.

And he hadn't asked. He hadn't *guessed*.

He'd known.

That was the part that didn't sit right. Not the tone. Not the authority. Just the familiarity. The way Godslayer's hand had lingered a second too long on his shoulder. The way his expression had cracked when Phainon winced. It wasn't performative concern. It was worry barely restrained behind control. And not the general vigilante kind, either.

His.

And then there were the tics. Small things. The twitch in his left hand before speaking. The strange way he shifted his weight when standing still.

Even the phrasing—blunt and clumsy and weirdly endearing, like he didn’t want to intimidate him but still had to get his point across.

It reminded Phainon of someone.

He couldn’t put his finger on it, but it was like a word on the tip of his tongue, a voice echoing at just the wrong pitch, a face blurred at the edges of recognition. It crawled under his skin and settled in his ribs, right next to something he wasn’t ready to dig out yet.

He leaned back again, spine touching the cool metal of the bench rail. Breathing steady. Unblinking.

The sky was dull above him—washed gray like cheap fabric left out in the rain. The kind of day where everything felt paused, waiting for a cue that wouldn’t come.

He hated waiting.

He hated the way silence filled itself up with questions. The way his mind moved too fast when nothing else did.

He hated how long he’d been thinking about this.

Phainon ran a hand down his face, fingers brushing the edge of his jaw—still faintly sore from the slap.

“Gods,” he muttered, half-laughing under his breath. “I need a hobby.”

But he didn’t move.

He just sat there, letting the weight of everything he hadn’t said settle across his shoulders again.

And then, something bounced off the back of Phainon’s skull.

Not hard enough to hurt. Just enough to be intentional.

He blinked, turned his head, and stared down at the plush animal now rolling to a stop beside his foot. Chimera. Two-headed, stitched awkwardly together, little felt wings flopped sideways like they'd given up halfway through flying. Some kid's toy.

Or, more accurately, *his* boyfriend's.

Phainon picked it up and held it aloft by the scruff of its mismatched mane. "Really?" he called out, tone flat.

Mydei sat down on the bench next to him without a word.

Which was already suspicious. The silence. The weird, smooth calm. The way he didn't even *look* at Phainon after pelting him with cuddly wildlife. That was the kind of composure only possible when someone was either plotting something or had finally lost their grip on reality. And with Mydei, it could honestly go either way.

Phainon eyed him sidelong. "So… you hitting me with adorable mythical creatures now? Is this a warning? A threat? A seduction?"

Mydei said nothing.

Even worse.

Phainon opened his mouth to speak again—but barely got the breath in before Mydei suddenly grabbed his collar.

"—wha—hello?"

His voice cracked upward in shock as Mydei tugged the fabric sharply, popping the first two buttons open with no hesitation. Phainon's chest was suddenly on full display, pale and mostly unmarked except for the familiar smattering of old scars and the brand of someone who picked too many fights in his younger years and won most of them.

He blinked down at him.

“Bold of you to undress me in public. I mean—flattered, obviously, but I was hoping for dinner first.”

Nothing. Mydei didn’t even flinch.

Phainon smirked faintly, leaning back a little with all the faux-sultry bravado of a man very used to being ignored mid-flirt. “If you wanted me shirtless, you could’ve just asked. I have a whole routine for that. Music and everything. Real scandalous. Gets rave reviews.”

Still no reaction.

And that’s when he noticed Mydei’s hand. The way it hesitated, hovering near his sternum. The way his fingers lightly traced the edge of one rib, then slid to his side. He was through, too precise to be casual.

Phainon’s smile faded, eyebrows dipping just a little.

Ah.

He was checking.

The laughter stuck somewhere in his throat. Not because it was awkward—but because he didn’t expect it to hurt. Not like this.

“…Hey,” he said quietly. “I’m fine. I already got cleared, remember?”

Mydei didn’t answer. His gaze scanned across Phainon’s torso, sharp and quick and far too anxious for someone trying to act calm. His fingers twitched once, then steadied, brushing along skin like the residue of the Black Tide might still be lurking beneath it. Something clung to him, desperate and coiled.

Phainon didn’t move. Didn’t joke again.

He just watched him, eyes softening with a kind of ache he didn’t let out very often.

Because it wasn’t about the potential contamination.

It was about being sure.

Mydei finished a moment later, hand still at Phainon’s collar. He didn’t say anything when he let go.

Phainon reached up, slowly fixing the buttons himself—not that it helped. His chest still felt exposed. But not from the cold.

“…Thanks for the plushie, by the way,” he added, lightly, but his voice didn’t quite match the grin that tried to form. “Very aggressive delivery. I give it a seven out of ten.”

No answer.

Not yet.

But that was fine.

Phainon could sit with silence.

Especially if it was this kind.

Phainon barely had time to do anything before Mydei stood up like he was about to leave, brushing off his hands and turning halfway like he’d changed his mind mid-motion. Phainon opened his mouth to stop him—no clue what he’d say, probably something to stop him—but Mydei beat him to it.

“Phainon.”

He blinked, caught off guard by the way his name landed in the air—less like a question, more like a warning.

“Have you ever trained with weapons?”

There was a pause. Then a longer one. Then Phainon leaned forward slightly, squinting at him like he was trying to read through the question.

“…What an odd question,” he said at last, slow, measured, smile stretched too far. “Why? You planning to kill me?”

Mydei didn’t answer. His expression didn’t even twitch.

That made Phainon straighten a little. “Seriously though—any reason you’re asking?”

Silence.

He ran a hand through his hair, gears in his head beginning to click with more urgency than they should’ve. Something about the way Mydei asked felt targeted. Specific.

He thought back. Black Tide. The disaster. The chaos. The fact that he, against all logic, picked up a metal pipe and wielded it like a sword to draw a path for trapped civilians—an improvised solution. Godslayer had seen him do it. He was suspicious—Godslayer had questioned him even in the middle of an apocalypse—and Phainon, like the menace he was, said it was old training from an ancient dueling hall that got shut down. Total lie. Godslayer didn’t question it at the time.

But only Godslayer had been there. No one else.

So how the hell did Mydei—

The train of thought picked up speed. Phainon sat back a little, chewing the inside of his cheek. There were… ticks. The way Godslayer had spoken. Too familiar. Too worried. A hand twitch. Proximity issues. The way he’d yelled his name before pulling him across the broken barrier of the Tide.

His brows dipped.

No. That was impossible. Mydei couldn’t be—

His brain hit the brakes, practically skidding. No. No way. He dismissed the idea with a breath, waving it off internally like a bad punchline. He was spiraling. Overthinking. Godslayer had probably heard someone yell his

name. Or… maybe he'd mentioned the dueling hall lie to Mydei too, and just didn't remember. Had he? When?

He started scanning through their past conversations like a mental archive, suddenly suspicious of every word he'd ever said to Mydei. Did he ever act out something dumb in front of him? Accidentally show off? Leave a trail?

He didn't get to answer that. Because Mydei blurted:

"I wanna learn how to use a sword."

Phainon blinked. Again.

Mydei immediately looked away, shoulders stiff. That… wasn't what he'd meant to say. That much was clear.

"Wait, what?" Phainon said, but Mydei was already talking again, fast. If he didn't know better he'd think Mydei was trying to bury a body and pretend he was gardening.

"There's a new civilian defense program," he said, eyes fixed on something very, very interesting on the floor. "It's a government and vigilante collaboration. The Chrysos Heirs are involved. I thought—I don't know. If something like that happened again… it'd be good to be prepared. And. I didn't want to join it alone." He shifted awkwardly. "But I figured you wouldn't want to, anyway. So I was just asking. If you had experience. Or could teach me instead. If not. It's fine."

That was, objectively, the worst excuse Phainon had ever heard.

And still—adorable.

This man had baked up a whole half-lie, brought in vague governmental forces, vigilante programs, and an entire potential hypothetical natural disaster again—just to not say "please come with me."

Phainon felt the laughter flickering in his chest and swallowed it down, smiling wide.

“Okay,” he said.

Mydei looked up, puzzled. “What?”

Phainon stood, dusted himself off with more flair than necessary, and said, “Let’s join the program.”

The silence Mydei gave him was too stunned to be anything but genuine.

Phainon grinned like the sun and reached forward, ruffling Mydei’s hair before he could duck away. “C’mon, you’re awful at asking for things. Lucky for you, I’m great at agreeing.”

He walked a few steps before throwing a look over his shoulder.

“What kind of idiot would do something like this for a guy?” he said, almost amused, hands in his blue hoodie pockets like he hadn’t just rearranged his schedule, risked a full month of violent, screaming admin hell from Anaxa, and tanked every ounce of free time he had for the next four weeks. “Anyway, I’m normal.”

And then, as if he hadn’t just dropped that emotional piano on the park bench and walked off, he was already pulling up his phone, tapping away as he murmured, “We should color-code our outfits. Coordinated vigilante aesthetics. I want a patch. A patch that says ‘Mydei’s Favorite.’ Or maybe ‘Assistant Sword Holder.’ Something with range.”

He didn’t see the way Mydei just stood there, staring at him like he’d made some grave, irreversible mistake.

The registration desk was chaos. Organized, orderly chaos, but still chaos.

They stood behind a woman loudly arguing about whether bringing her dog counted as “emotional support armament,” while a teenage recruit waved a digital clipboard in their faces asking if either of them had any experience with crossbows, civilian trauma response, or “chokepoint maneuvering” (whatever the hell that was).

Phainon blinked at him. “I once watched someone choke on a breadstick. Does that count?”

The clipboard kid moved on without comment.

When they finally reached the front, the clerk behind the desk—a tired-looking guy with a badge that read *I Am Just a Volunteer*—handed them each a stack of forms and an ocular scan pad.

Phainon didn’t even sit. He leaned on the counter, skimmed absolutely nothing, and began signing with the confidence of a man who hadn’t read a legal document in his life.

Mydei watched him, arms crossed. “You’re not even looking at the waivers.”

“That’s because looking implies I have something to lose,” Phainon replied, dotting the last signature with a flourish. “Also, I already memorized your emergency contact. I’ll just scream your name in case I die.”

Mydei pinched the bridge of his nose.

As Phainon handed back the tablet with a little bow, he turned and asked, far too casually, “Wait. Is it still legally binding if I didn’t understand anything I signed?”

The volunteer gave a thumbs up without looking up. Mydei, meanwhile, stared at his boyfriend like he was re-evaluating every life choice that had led him to this moment.

Phainon leaned toward him, stage-whispering: “If we end up conscripted into some government-blessed vigilante army, I want matching jackets. I was serious about that. Yours says ‘Sword Dad,’ mine says ‘Hot Liability.’”

Mydei didn’t respond. Just took his own clipboard, calmly filled it out, and submitted everything with silent, seething grace.

This was his life now.

And unfortunately, he loved the idiot.

“You know,” Phainon said as they rounded a corner, “if we die in this program, I want it noted that I won’t perish thirsty.”

Mydei didn’t slow his pace. “We start in five minutes.”

“That’s five whole minutes of hydration opportunity,” Phainon countered, already veering off the sidewalk toward the first vending kiosk he saw. “And I happen to think I’d fight better if slightly sugared and carbonated.”

Mydei gave him a weird look, but followed anyway. Phainon scanned the menu like he was evaluating fine wines, then jabbed a button with zero hesitation.

The machine rumbled before reluctantly coughing out a tall, unreasonably bright drink labeled *Scorchberry Heat*. It fizzed at the top like it might be flammable.

Mydei read the label. “That has chili extract in it.”

“Yeah,” Phainon said, already sipping. “Spicy.”

Mydei looked away like he couldn’t believe he was in love with this man.

They walked the rest of the path with only the occasional slurp from Phainon’s drink filling the silence. The streets were quieter here—closer to the training complex, more regulated, lined with caution signs and too-clean sidewalks. Even rebuilt, the city still carried the scent of sterilized aftermath.

Phainon was in the middle of recounting a story about a dog who had once stolen his sandal mid-street duel when Mydei suddenly stopped.

Someone had bumped into him.

The contact wasn’t aggressive—just a misstep, accidental. But the shift in the air afterward wasn’t.

Phainon paused mid-sip.

The man was older, taller than Mydei, with a sharp, weathered face and a soldier's spine. His eyes—steely, worn—narrowed as they landed on Mydei. His tone, when he spoke, was deceptively soft.

"Mydeimos."

Phainon blinked. Mydei had gone still. Tension rolled off him like waves of heat from a forge. His jaw set. His eyes narrowed. There was something ancient in that expression, some silent wildfire tamped behind his pupils.

Phainon, entirely out of sync with the moment, took another sip. Loudly.

"Mm," he said. "Spicy."

Neither of them reacted.

They just kept staring.

Mydei's hand twitched slightly by his side—barely noticeable, unless you knew to look.

The older man's gaze didn't waver. His presence wasn't aggressive, not exactly—but he held himself like someone used to being listened to. The kind of man who could command a room with a glance. A mentor. A general. A ghost from another life.

Phainon blinked once more, then leaned around Mydei slightly and said, with polite cheer, "Sorry, do you two know each other? Or is this just the world's most intense sidewalk encounter?"

Still locked in the stare-down, Mydei exhaled slowly through his nose and said, "Phainon… meet Krateros."

Phainon's brain took exactly one second to compute. Then:

"Oh," he said. And then again, brighter: "Ohhhh. *Your* teacher."

Instant transformation. His voice took on that buttery, flirtatious lilt that usually preceded him getting slapped or kissed. “Sir. It’s an honor. I’ve heard so much about you. Your posture? Impeccable. Honestly, you carry yourself like someone who’s won wars *and* a pie-baking contest.”

Krateros looked at him. Once.

And then completely ignored him, eyes returning to Mydei without a word.

Phainon was not offended. He leaned in closer to Mydei and whispered, “He is kinda scary. I see the appeal.”

Mydei didn’t dignify that with a response. His focus was still on Krateros—jaw tight, gaze hard. Whatever history lingered between them, it wasn’t a soft one.

Phainon sipped again, the straw making a soft hollow sound at the bottom of the cup.

Silence.

Then Krateros finally spoke. “You’re participating in the Civilian Defense Course?”

Mydei’s mouth moved like he was about to answer—but before he could, Krateros glanced, just for a second, at Phainon.

That one look told him everything.

Mydei’s subtle shift. His unreadable glance. The small nod. Krateros didn’t ask again.

Instead, he said, “Good.”

And that was that.

The building rose from the ground like something carved from purpose itself—clean lines, gleaming panels, and the kind of reinforced structure

that screamed government money and lots of it. A wide banner above the entrance read: **CIVILIAN DEFENSE INITIATIVE – IN COLLABORATION WITH THE CHRYSOS HEIRS.**

Below that, in less glamorous text: *Orientation Begins Promptly at 8:00 a.m.*

Phainon and Mydei made it through the double glass doors at 8:00 and forty-seven seconds.

The instructor standing at the front—tall, tired, already regretting his job—clocked them immediately. His arms were crossed. His expression didn't shift. Didn't need to.

Phainon coughed.

Mydei looked away.

They shuffled into line like the picture of innocent punctuality. If innocent punctuality had shadows under its eyes and a Scorchberry Heat cup hastily shoved into the nearest trash bin.

Inside, the facility opened into an atrium that looked more like a military-grade training complex than a public civilian program. Floor-to-ceiling screens pulsed with digital maps. The walls were lined with reinforced padding and modular weapon racks. Observation balconies stretched high above them, most likely for supervisors or overfunded Chrysos interns with clipboards and superiority complexes.

Phainon tilted his head back and gave a low whistle. "Either this place makes superheroes… or war criminals."

"Both," Mydei muttered.

They were quickly ushered into an orientation hall, papers shoved at them, a woman in a blazer rapid-firing the rules in a monotone blur that sounded like she'd memorized it against her will. Phainon once again , signed everything upside down and backwards. Mydei didn't comment until after.

“You know that might’ve signed you up for organ donation, right?”

“If I die in combat, my pancreas should at least get a shot at heroism.”

They were split into squads next, sent through sleek hallways into a second, expansive chamber: the training facility proper. Here, it was all polished impact floors, mirrored walls, and sectioned sparring rings. Equipment gleamed in tidy lines. Instructors stood at attention like someone had told them this was the Olympics. Probably had been.

Phainon’s voice dropped low. “Krateros *definitely* hates me.”

“He doesn’t hate you,” Mydei said. Then, after a beat, “He just doesn’t like you.”

Phainon slouched in melodramatic despair.

“Bad first impressions happen,” Mydei said, patting him once on the back with all the sympathy he could muster. “There’s always next time.”

“Next time he’ll poison my lunch.”

They were herded to their designated section—Station C—and paired up for warm-up drills. A nearby instructor barked the orders: “Combat stances! Basic counters! If your partner breaks a limb, do it cleaner next time!”

Phainon’s expression brightened. “They get me here.”

Most of the participants were clearly new—wobbly knees, late reactions, the occasional flinch when someone raised a fist. Phainon looked comfortably average by comparison. He moved well enough, like someone who maybe had seen combat but was humble enough not to brag about it.

Too well.

Mydei squinted at him as Phainon executed a near-perfect sidestep that flowed straight into a restrained counter-grab.

“You’re pulling your punches,” Mydei muttered.

Phainon blinked at him. “What? Me? Never. I’m average. Dangerously average. A solid C+ in fisticuffs.”

“You did a counter only trained scouts use.”

“I saw it in a documentary.”

“You adjusted your stance for southpaw three moves ago.”

“I’m adaptive. It’s my charm.”

Mydei stared at him like he was trying to x-ray his soul.

“You’re hiding how good you are.”

Phainon shrugged with zero guilt. “Maybe I’m just modest.”

“You’re many things. *Modest* isn’t one of them.”

Before Phainon could retort, someone nearby—a girl in a grey compression suit, sweat already dripping down her forehead—looked over at Mydei and asked, a little too casually:

“Wait. Weren’t you training under Krateros since you were ten?”

Silence fell like a sword.

Phainon stopped mid-step. His brow arched, sharp and slow. He turned toward Mydei with the full weight of someone about to unearth a goldmine.

Mydei turned his head with agonizing calm. Stared at the girl.

She immediately looked away.

Phainon leaned in, voice blank. “Since you were ten?”

“That’s classified.”

Phainon paused just long enough to almost process it, then gave a lopsided grin like it made perfect sense. “Wow. My boyfriend’s a librarian *and* a Krateros-trained combat prodigy. Dragging me into a civilian program just to let me flex a little. I feel so honored.

“Correct.”

“And you’re still blushing.”

Mydei’s face definitely turned pink.

Phainon laughed, loud and pleased, narrowly dodging Mydei’s retaliatory swipe.

The instructor shot them both a look. Again.

They coughed in unison.

Back to stance.

The break came fast, and the instructors wasted no time splitting everyone up. A few names were called out—some volunteers, some clearly handpicked—and those individuals were directed toward different corners of the facility. A few even got taken aside for what looked like one-on-one assessments, instructors murmuring quietly to them as clipboards came out. It wasn’t subtle.

Phainon lingered near the water station, cup in hand, already plotting his quiet exit from the next half of the session. This was exactly why he’d said no the first time someone brought up this program to him. All it took was showing a little potential, and suddenly you were a “prospect.” Next came the offers—extra sessions, off-the-record evaluations, meaningless government-adjacent missions dressed up like some noble cause. He didn’t need any of that. He already did what needed doing.

He sipped the water like it was wine and kept his eyes away from the crowd.

But then Mydei got picked.

Of course he did—he walked like someone who knew how to handle a blade and stood like someone who hated being watched for it. One of the instructors waved him toward the far side of the room, where the more advanced group was being assembled. Mydei didn't argue. Just nodded once and started walking.

Phainon, as per plan, stayed planted.

Or he *would've*, if Mydei hadn't slowed down, turned halfway, and—without ceremony—reached back to grab his hand. Like it was the most natural thing in the world. No look, no words, just a casual come on tug.

And what was Phainon supposed to do? Say no? Yell "Sorry, I can't, I'm a shadowy antihero who works better alone"?

So he let himself be pulled along. Of course he did.

The second training area was set up deeper in the building, larger and more stripped-down, built less for practice and more for performance. Luckily, they weren't the only ones shuffled over. A decent-sized group was already filtering in, weapons and training gear issued in orderly stacks, instructors taking positions.

Not too elite, then. Just advanced enough to weed out the ones who couldn't keep up.

Fine by him. He could pretend.

He was good at pretending.

The third training segment was Simulation Missions.

The next room after was massive—vaulted ceilings, black-tiled walls fitted with emitters that flickered faintly like stars. A series of complex projectors and hard-light generators were suspended from steel beams above, whirring softly. It looked less like a gym and more like someone hijacked a tech lab and gave it more than a few little tweaks.

Once inside, instructors handed out slim wristbands and brief explanations. “These generate your environment,” one of them said, tone bored like this wasn’t the coolest thing Phainon had seen all day. “Your task is simple—rescue and extraction. Keep civilians safe. Contain the threat. Don’t die.”

No pressure.

The “civilians” weren’t basic mannequins either. They were hybrid constructs—part training dummy, part reactive AI, built to simulate panic, injury, and distress. One of them blinked up at Phainon when it activated, mouth opening in a tiny “o” before defaulting to a passive standing position.

“I shall name you… Mydei Junior,” Phainon said solemnly, resting a hand on its shoulder. “You’re braver than your father.”

Mydei, strapping on his own wristband nearby, didn’t even turn around. “I’m not doing this with you.”

“I’m doing this for *our* child,” Phainon replied, utterly straight-faced.

Then the lights dropped. The simulation began.

Reality dissolved into smoke and static—and rebuilt itself into chaos.

A city street, cracked and flickering with residual energy. The sky above rippled with a diseased, stormy shimmer, and the air vibrated with low distortion, like sound trying to escape a dream. Buildings were warped at odd angles, brick and steel groaning under invisible pressure. The familiar signs of a Black Tide incursion—twisted geometry, air that moved too fast, windows that stared back.

Something screamed in the distance. A corrupted figure burst down the street, limbs writhing in the wrong order. Others followed, glitching in and out, trailing residue like ash and flame.

Phainon drew in a breath. Time to stay perfectly average.

He ducked low, guided Mydei Jr. toward a nearby alley, keeping to the shadows, carefully applying exactly the kind of hesitance one would expect from a civilian-turned-trainee. He didn’t run too fast, didn’t hit too hard. A perfect performance.

Until, of course, the building exploded.

It was a slow, awful thing—walls buckling, the structure groaning like it knew what it was about to do. The Tide twisted its fingers into the foundation, and with a shriek, the floor gave out beneath him. Flames licked the walls. Smoke poured inward. Mydei Jr. let out a piercingly accurate simulation scream and promptly short-circuited in his arms.

“Well, shit,” Phainon muttered, brushing ash off his shoulder. “I’ll get out in a minute.”

Except the exits warped. Doors vanished into the walls. The windows melted like wax.

“I said—” he growled, rolling his neck. The hologram could take a hint.

Then someone kicked the wall in.

Literally kicked it in.

Mydei burst through the smoke like righteous fury wrapped in emergency response protocol. No helmet. No hesitation. Just grabbed Phainon by the collar with one hand and hoisted Mydei Jr. under the other like he did this sort of thing every weekend.

“Dramatic timing,” Phainon coughed as they stumbled outside, still trailing smoke. “I knew you’d come. I believed in you. And in our child.”

Mydei’s breath hitched on a laugh he tried to smother. “You were serious when you named it after me?”

“It screamed like you when it saw a spider.”

“It was a training construct.”

“And yet you’re holding it like you’re about to cradle it to sleep,” Phainon pointed out. “Just saying.”

Mydei didn’t dignify that with a reply. But he was still holding it, still pulling Phainon in a little closer than necessary. His jaw clenched like he had something to say and wasn’t sure how to say it.

Phainon leaned in, singed and smug. “I’d die for you. And our son.”

The simulation signified an end with a sharp bleep. Everything—flames, sky, city—vanished in a wash of static.

They were back in the chamber.

Mydei Jr. lay in Phainon’s arms, slightly melted. Phainon looked down at it fondly.

“He’ll grow up so fast.”

“Phainon,” Mydei said, finally, massaging his temple.

“Don’t thank me,” Phainon murmured. “Being a father is the real mission.”

The simulation fully disappeared with slow fade to white. Holograms dissipated, environments crumbled into digital ash, and the training room’s sterile light returned with a vengeance. Instructors clapped once—just once—as if that was enough to signal both “well done” and “don’t get cocky.”

People started filtering out of their pods or standing from their training zones, some flushed with adrenaline, others looking like they’d just survived actual urban warfare.

Phainon, ash-covered and triumphant, strolled to the evaluation station with Mydei Jr. half-cradled under one arm like a charred baby koala.

A clipboard-bearing official waved him over, barely looking up. “Name?”

“Phainon.”

They tapped the screen. “You were assigned a mid-tier threat level scenario. Scored high on agility, responsiveness, and teamwork. Low marks on regulation protocol.”

“That’s my entire personality,” he said brightly.

The official gave him a slow blink, then turned to Mydei. “You—excellent recovery time. Precision response. Strong marks on environmental adaptability and leadership tracking.”

Mydei nodded like it was a grocery list and not a glowing report.

Phainon held Mydei Jr. closer. “So… can I keep him?”

Both evaluators looked up—finally—and opened their mouths, clearly ready to hit him with a firm no, probably followed by a speech about proprietary government tech.

Then their eyes slid to Mydei. And paused.

Mydei stared back with that same mild, unreadable expression that somehow implied ten layers of both irritation and diplomatic influence. It wasn’t quite a threat. It wasn’t quite anything.

“…I guess,” the official mumbled reluctantly. “Just… don’t get it wet.”

Phainon beamed. “You hear that, Mydei Jr.? You’re free now. You’ll grow up strong and dramatic, just like your other dad.”

He made it five glorious seconds.

Someone behind them—tired, sweaty, distracted—uncapped their water bottle too fast and fumbled the grip. A sudden splash, a sputter of fizz, and then—

SPARK

Mydei Jr. twitched violently in Phainon’s arms. A soft, warbling noise escaped the construct’s speaker like a death rattle in binary. Its eyes

flickered once. Then went dark.

Phainon stood frozen, mouth slightly open. His arms cradled the now-limp husk of what was once his pride and joy. Water pooled around their feet.

The room went dead silent.

Even the person who spilled the water had backed away like they'd just assassinated a diplomat.

Mydei shifted awkwardly beside him. "I—um." He cleared his throat. "There's… only one or two more scenarios left today."

Phainon didn't move.

Mydei tried again. "We could… name the next one Junior Junior?"

Still nothing.

"…I'll take that as a maybe."

Phainon didn't even blink. He just slowly turned, gaze vacant, Mydei Jr.'s damp frame still in his arms like a fallen soldier.

A single tear might've fallen. Or maybe it was condensation.

Either way, the loss was real.

Phainon didn't speak.

He hadn't spoken since the tragic, watery demise of Mydei Junior. The synthetic citizen unit lay in his arms, lifeless and short-circuited, its once-vibrant simulation eyes now replaced with a blinking red X and a vaguely mocking shutdown chime. Some off-duty participant had muttered an apology and fled the scene, but the damage was irreversible. Phainon had not moved since.

Mydei lingered near the him awkwardly hovering in solidarity. His hands twitched every few seconds—hovering close to Phainon's shoulder like he might pat it. Every time, he stopped himself short and pulled away, as if afraid physical contact might make the grief worse.

"Phainon. We're…Almost done." Mydei offered quietly, his voice too unsure to count as real comfort.

Phainon's reply was the softest, most pitiful: "He was barely a day old."

They were summoned before Mydei could figure out what to say to that.

The next training scenario loaded while the previous team cleared the simulation space. A wide, steel-walled chamber slowly shifted around them, projectors flickering to life as the lights dimmed. The environment shimmered into shape—another fractured city square surrounded by half-demolished buildings, cracked pavement, and emergency tents.

Somewhere, faintly, a simulated siren looped.

The instructor's voice cut through the illusion: **"Crisis Convergence."**

Digital walls rippled with projected smoke once again and distant shouting. The space had expanded to nearly stadium-sized, the air cool from environmental controls. Portable crates appeared with coded markers, supplies highlighted by faint glows in their corner of the staging area.

"Civilians are stranded in a compromised zone. There are structural risks. Some may be infected. You will need to provide first-response aid, screen evacuees for contamination, and ration limited resources."

Three crates. One labeled *medical*. One *rations*. One *equipment*.

Also present: twelve "citizens." Semi-sentient constructs—not quite synthetic people, but not inanimate either. Their faces rendered with uncanny humanity, pre-programmed with a dozen personalities, needs, and conflicts. Phainon didn't name any of them this time.

Probably for the best.

“Teams will split responsibilities. Rescue. Supply. Screening. Choose wisely. Some evacuees may lie.”

That last line was delivered with far too much amusement.

Mydei turned to him slowly. “Which do you want to take?”

Phainon, still mourning, gestured vaguely. “Whichever job lets me avoid emotionally connecting with another fake child.”

Mydei paused. “…Screening?”

“Perfect.”

And with that, they stepped into chaos.

A few hours into the scenario, the fake sunlight hadn’t dimmed once. The simulation’s clock ran off something uncanny, bright and sterile as all things were here and humming faintly over their heads. Most participants had shed their jackets or tied their sleeves back, soaked in the sweat of virtual stress and civilian panic.

Phainon leaned against the edge of the folding table they’d been assigned, hissing under his breath as he clutched his arm. “That woman bit me.”

Mydei didn’t look up from his tablet. “You denied her clearance.”

“She growled at me.” Phainon peeled back the sleeve. The bite wasn’t deep, just impressively toothy. “What was I supposed to do, hand her a juice box and let her in with a souvenir infection?”

“You also called her a walking test tube.”

“It was meant to be educational.”

Across from them, a few other trainees were watching with thinly veiled interest. Phainon straightened his posture slightly, masked the wince as he

flexed the arm, and then leaned on the opposite side like that had been his plan the whole time.

Mydei stepped closer—not to check the injury, but to skim through the flagged profiles in their queue. He'd somehow been handed senior access, no explanation, no complaints. If Phainon had to guess, the system just recognized competence by scent.

Or maybe leadership had just seen the look in Mydei's eyes earlier—quiet and cunning. He'd slid into the coordinator role with minimal fuss, redirecting confused participants, approving calls without waiting on instructor feedback.

Phainon could respect that. He just wished it didn't make him want to show off.

A new civilian model was escorted in—disheveled, twitchy, fake bruises stamped onto their cheek. They slumped into the screening chair.

Phainon watched them, carefully this time. Mydei watched him. Neither said anything.

When Phainon finally moved to retrieve the scanner, he made sure not to favor his bitten arm.

"Totally normal simulation," he muttered under his breath. "No emotional baggage. No crisis of conscience. Just got attacked by a discount grandma with dentures."

Mydei didn't laugh. But he did nudge the bandage roll toward him in silent offering.

Phainon took it, wrapping it on himself. The bite still throbbed, but it looked cool from a distance. Probably.

He was halfway through bandaging his bite with one hand, still mumbling something bitter about "carnivorous civilians," when the lights dimmed

slightly. Not enough for alarm—maybe the simulation's way of saying the sun was setting.

Then came the announcement:
"Warning: Potential hostile presence detected in the perimeter. Please proceed with standard civilian containment protocol."

Phainon blinked, pausing mid-wrap. "…Containment?" He looked over at Mydei, who had already turned toward the sound, brows furrowed, but otherwise calm.

"Don't worry," Mydei murmured. "It's likely just an escalation test. They're probably going to introduce some corrupted figures or simulated panic to test our judgment."

"Cool, cool," Phainon said, nodding. "That definitely sounds like something they told us about. At registration. In the… documents I totally read."

"…You didn't read anything, though."

"I liked the font."

Then the music—a faint, generic hum in the background—cut out. Not slowly. Like someone yanked the aux cord out of the simulation.

Phainon blinked and looked down.

There, directly below the table, was a grown man folded the wrong way. Limbs contorted, neck at a ninety-degree angle, face twisted into a grin that didn't match his eyes. Just staring up at him.

Phainon froze. So did the man.

For about four solid seconds, they simply… stared at each other.

Like a polite but deeply cursed tea party.

Then the man *skittered*.

Phainon jolted back a step—too late. A clammy hand grabbed his ankle with shocking force, and he yelped, scrambling for grip as he was dragged under the table like it was a horror movie and this thing had been waiting to audition.

“MYDEI I’M TOO YOUNG FOR THIS,” Phainon yelled as he slammed elbows into the floor, flailing wildly while being hauled backward. “TELL MY FANS I WENT OUT BRAVE.”

“You don’t have fans,” came Mydei’s very unhelpful reply from somewhere far, far too calm.

“YOU’RE MY NUMBER ONE FAN—DON’T LET THEM TAKE ME—”

Whatever the thing was, it didn’t talk. It hissed. It *clicked*. It smelled weirdly like pennies.

And just as Phainon felt his brain hit that calm *oh my god I’m gonna die in a fake environment* phase, something cold settled over him. His mind stilled.

Oh right. I kill people.

He twisted his hand, something sharp igniting under his palm—not a real dagger, but the shape of it—and just as he prepared to send this simulation freak back to the corrupted code he crawled out of—

“Simulation failed. Trainee extracted.”

His body fizzled out in segments, light blue lining cutting across his limbs like an upload glitch.

And then he was outside.

Sitting on a chair. Alone.

“…Huh.”

The screens displayed the rest of the scenario as it continued, the dome shimmering slightly with projected movement. Mydei was still in. Of course he was. Probably looking heroic. Probably winning. Probably not getting dragged by Uncle Error from under a table.

Phainon leaned back, staring at the ceiling for a moment. “This is not what I signed up for.”

Technically, he reminded *himself, I didn’t sign anything. I just scrawled something vaguely resembling a signature on a clipboard and hoped for the best.*

He huffed out a slow breath, resigned. Might as well wait. He’d check his evaluation after Mydei was done. Maybe see if the simulation offered snacks. Or therapy.

The floor was cold, the lights dimmed. Somewhere in the background, a voice droned out instructions, then crackled into silence. Phainon had somehow slouched all the way down on the waiting bench, legs half-draped over one side, arms crossed loosely, one foot twitching now and then. His head tilted back, breathing soft and slow.

He hadn’t meant to fall asleep. He just… closed his eyes a little too long.

Then came the sharp buzz of the simulation ending. Lights flicked to normal.

A soft ding signaled the end of the final scenario.

Phainon’s head snapped up like a cat hearing food hit the bowl. “Mm—what’d I miss?” He blinked, squinting as the door slid open—then brightened instantly. “Oh hey, look who survived!”

Mydei walked in, brows furrowed, expression unreadable—except for the faint, traitorous twitch at the corner of his eye. He zeroed in on Phainon’s sprawled figure, taking in the sleepy smirk, the bedhead, the way his boyfriend looked like he’d taken a nap in the middle of an apocalypse.

“You’re impossible.”

“I try.”

They joined the small cluster of other trainees shuffling over toward the evaluation stations. Digital displays flickered to life as files queued up—individual rankings, performance assessments, behavioral markers.

Mydei tapped through his results efficiently, like he already expected the outcome. And of course he did—his screen was glowing with full marks. Leadership score, reaction time, coordination, even tactical execution under pressure. Flawless.

Phainon peeked over and gave a low whistle. “Someone’s going to be recruited into herohood at this rate.”

“I’m not joining the Heirs,” Mydei muttered, but didn’t elaborate.

“Aw, and here I was picturing us in color-coordinated armors again.”

Mydei shot him a look.

Then Phainon’s screen blinked to life.

For a moment, he looked almost smug. Then he read it.

…Then he scrolled.

Then his expression soured.

“‘Reasonable engagement. Subpar hazard judgment. Failed to follow Black Tide infection protocol. Treated contaminated wound with unapproved civilian bandages.’—That was a premium wrap,” he said defensively.

“You were going to use a floral-patterned scarf you pulled out of your own pocket until I gave you the bandages. Don’t even deny it.”

“It was absorbent!”

Mydei pinched the bridge of his nose.

“It also says,” Phainon went on, eyes narrowing at the *screen, “‘Subject displayed emotionally unstable behavior upon contact with corrupted figures. Requires reevaluation of panic response.’* I was not panicking. That was strategic screaming.”

“You yelled ‘save me, you’re my number one fan.’”

“And look! You didn’t!”

Mydei exhaled through his nose, looking away, but not before Phainon caught the very faintest quirk tugging at his lips.

“Still,” Phainon said, stretching a little and swiping the report off the screen like it personally offended him, “not the worst score. Could’ve been worse. Could’ve died.”

“It was a simulation.”

“A simulation with very real teeth, thank you. That grandma bit me.” He held up his bandaged arm like proof. “And not a gentle nibble either.”

Mydei stared at him, then rubbed his face. “There is only one scenario left.”

“One chance to redeem myself,” Phainon said brightly. “Or crash and burn with style.”

Mydei sighed. Hard. But he didn’t correct him.

An overseer finally stepped forward a while later, clipboard in hand, their presence marked by the mechanical hiss of the doors sealing behind them. The room quieted with the kind of anticipation only mild dread could conjure. Phainon leaned sideways, eyes half-lidded, already bracing himself for whatever weird test came next.

“This final simulation is a little… experimental,” the overseer began, with the exact tone of someone who legally had to say that. “One of you has been duplicated by our AI system to simulate an impersonation threat. Your

task is to identify and isolate the impostor before they compromise the scenario. The duplicate will behave as close to the original as possible."

Phainon blinked, then squinted. "Didn't some guy try to clone his ex last year? This city's weird."

Still, no one questioned it when sleek, practice-weighted blades were distributed to each of them—light enough for civilians, dull enough to not kill anyone, but just sharp enough to get the point across. Phainon turned his over in his hand and muttered, "Neat," even as his eyes narrowed.

He was pretty sure the officials had long since stopped expecting anything from him. Now they were just running these for entertainment. Honestly? Fair.

The setting for the final scenario was deceptively quaint—suspiciously so, if you asked Phainon.

Instead of a high-tech facility or eerie simulation chamber, the group was led into what looked like a perfectly normal neighborhood house. Cozy, suburban, obnoxiously average. The kind of place with throw pillows that matched the curtains, wood floors that creaked politely underfoot, and the faint smell of chamomile that definitely didn't come from tea.

Phainon stepped in, eyebrows raised. "Either this is a training scenario or we just broke into someone's grandmother's house."

No one answered, probably because they were too busy gawking at how aggressively normal the place looked. There was a living room with a modest TV setup, a round kitchen table with mismatched chairs, even family photos on the walls—though if you looked too long, the faces blurred just enough to remind you this was still government-issue uncanny valley material.

Participants spread out, situating themselves on couches, leaning against doorframes, milling into the kitchen where a fake fruit bowl sat on the counter. People started chatting, some relaxed, others keeping a wary eye

on the others like they were already trying to figure out who among them wasn’t real.

Phainon plopped down on an armchair with a quiet oof, flipping his practice blade in his hand once before laying it across his lap. “So. Casual small talk or casual suspicion?”

Mydei sat beside him on the armrest, arms folded, gaze scanning the room like he’d been given a script but wanted to burn it. “They said someone’s pretending to be someone else.”

“Mhm.” Phainon slouched deeper into the chair. “And all we have to do is point fingers and hope we don’t stab the wrong guy.”

Mydei didn’t reply, though Phainon could feel the tension already knotting into his shoulders.

Yeah. Homey or not, this place was about to get real uncomfortable.

It had been hours.

Tension simmered beneath the surface like an unattended kettle—occasional side-eyes, whispered check-ins that weren’t really check-ins, someone suspiciously polishing their practice blade in the corner like they were prepping for a murder mystery dinner party. The chatting had long since died out, replaced by a strained silence and the quiet hum of everyone pretending to relax.

And then it happened.

A scream rang out from the hallway.

Someone yelled about a body (a body? Really? Cliche.). Another about a broken lamp. The sounds of footsteps thundered down the fake wood floors, chairs scraped, people tripped over the aggressively normal living room rug. The air snapped from boredom to full-blown chaos like a rubber band.

“There’s two of him!”

And just like that, the accusations began.

Finger-pointing, shouting, wild theories spun like bad soap opera plots.

“I saw him twice, I swear!”

“He was in the kitchen, and then—in the kitchen *again*.”

“That guy? With the white hair? I knew he looked too smug.”

Phainon blinked. “Me?”

“Yes, *you*!”

He stood, hands raised halfway like he was being arrested for tax fraud. “Okay, first of all—how dare you. Second of all, if I were a clone, would I know that Mydei’s favorite tea blend is cherry plum hibiscus with a dash of cinnamon? Which, might I add, he pretends not to like but always drinks when he’s tired?”

Everyone paused.

Mydei looked like he was about to be forcibly removed from his own soul. “That’s not—”

Phainon turned toward him, full showman mode. “Would a clone know how your eye twitches *exactly* 0.3 seconds after someone leaves a mug on the table without a coaster? Would a clone recognize your ‘I didn’t make breakfast for you’ neck tilt when you *absolutely* made breakfast for me this morning?”

He spread his arms to the group like this was closing night at the theater. “Would a clone look at him the way I do?”

Mydei looked ready to dissolve into smoke. Or commit a minor felony.

Then the front door slammed open.

And there he was.

Clone-Phainon. Identical. Perfect. Too perfect. Like someone asked AI to generate Phainon based on his student records and filtered selfies.

Same hair, same face, same lazy stance—but *wrong*. Like someone bought his personality off the discount rack.

Phainon stared, horrified. “That is not how I walk.”

The room erupted. People dove behind furniture, blades came out, a few people screamed. Someone tried to grab the fake fruit for defense.

And in the middle of the chaos, Phainon could still be heard protesting over the noise, “Look at him! He’s walking like he makes spreadsheets for *fun*. I have *personality*!”

Eventually, the room settled. Not because anyone trusted each other, but because there was no energy left to keep throwing accusations.

Two Phainons sat side-by-side in the middle of the room like some twisted art exhibit. Both of them wore the same half-sleepy smirk, both leaned with that exact same infuriating slouch like they weren’t in the middle of a social breakdown. Someone had moved a lamp closer just to make sure they weren’t seeing double. They weren’t.

“So,” someone finally said. “We just… ask them stuff?”

“Until one cracks,” someone else offered.

“We’re gonna be here all night,” muttered another.

Still, the questions began.

“What’s your date of birth?”

“Name every Heir in the Chrysos system, backwards.”

“What did you have for breakfast?”

“Toast,” said the one on the left.

“Technically, leftover pie,” said the one on the right. “And a cold egg tart. You stole half of it, Mydei.”

Mydei, seated a few feet off with his arms crossed, didn’t even blink. “You offered.”

“After you gave me that look.”

“Which look?”

Phainon-Right mimicked it. Raised eyebrow, small squint, the faintest downward curl of the lip. A perfect imitation.

Phainon-Left’s eye twitched.

More questions. Dumb ones. Serious ones. Questions neither should’ve known but somehow both answered anyway. The room kept circling, restless, getting nowhere.

And then, as the tension simmered in its own confusion, Clone-Phainon—Phainon-Right—shifted.

“Alright,” he said lightly, “then let me prove it this way.”

He turned a little, directing his words more toward Mydei than the crowd. “Your coffee was too bitter this morning.”

Mydei didn’t look at him.

“You said it wasn’t,” Clone-Phainon added, quieter now. “But you kept stirring it like you were hoping it’d change.”

He didn’t say it like a gotcha. He said it like an observation.

The room started to quiet.

“You always stir things when you’re thinking too hard,” he added. “Tea. Soup. Paint. You get this furrow between your brows that you probably don’t even know you make.”

Mydei’s fingers twitched against his arm.

“And the last time someone asked how you were doing,” the clone went on, “you said fine, but scratched your wrist with your thumb.” He lifted his hand, mimicking the exact movement. “You always do that when you’re lying.”

A small sound escaped someone in the back. The room was entirely motionless.

Mydei didn’t look away, but his expression was hard to read. Just too still. A faint flush crept to his ears.

Across from him, Phainon sat too still.

Not stiff, not obviously tense—just thoughtful. His arms remained folded lazily over his chest, his legs crossed. His expression didn’t change. But his tongue swept once across his teeth, slow, thoughtful.

He was listening. That much was clear. Watching, too.

He didn’t bother pretending not to.

The clone kept speaking, voice low and familiar, threading memories into something intimate. Making it look easy. Making it look real.

Phainon didn’t interrupt. Didn’t even blink for a while.

Just sat there.

Watching this cheap replica play house with moments that weren’t his.

And it wasn’t the accuracy that bothered him—he could live with that. What got under his skin, what itched behind his ribs like an old bruise being pressed too hard, was the fact that the bastard didn’t even hesitate. Like he

thought he belonged here. Like knowing a few tells was enough to make him the one who mattered.

Phainon's jaw flexed once.

He tilted his head slightly to the side, eyes narrowing—not in disbelief, but in the way someone might look at a stain that wouldn't come out of a shirt they actually liked.

Annoying.

He shifted his weight just a little, a move so small it almost didn't register—but it bled purpose.

Just a quiet signal: you've overstayed.

The clone kept talking, unaware—or maybe pretending to be unaware.

Phainon's gaze flicked toward Mydei then. Not for confirmation or reassurance. Just to watch. To see how much of it Mydei was letting slide. And to remember it.

Then he turned his eyes back to the other version of himself.

Cool. Unimpressed.

And very much done with this game.

The temperature in the room hadn't changed, but something about it still felt colder.

Phainon leaned back slightly, letting the edge of the chair bite into his spine. The room had quieted into a tense kind of fatigue—civilians slouched in their seats, murmuring theories under their breath, others still too wired to sit, pacing near the walls as though they'd find the truth in the paint.

Across from him, the clone hadn't moved much. Still mimicking his posture. Still looking just close enough to make people squint. But it was

too polished now. Like a version of him rendered in clean lines and angles, missing the uneven rhythm of a real person.

More questions were being thrown at them—harmless enough, but useless.

Phainon crossed one leg over the other, resting his arm along the back of the chair.

He could feel Mydei watching.

That flicker of focus, sharp and measured, cutting between him and the other version. Trying to see something invisible. Something only Mydei would notice.

Eventually, Phainon straightened and spoke—carefully. Flatly.

“Alright. Let’s just end it here.”

A few heads turned. Even the clone blinked.

“I’m the fake. He’s the real one. Job done, right?”

There was a beat of stunned silence. Then someone scoffed, “Seriously?”

Phainon offered a half-shrug, expression unreadable. “Why not? If I were the real one, I’d have walked out twenty minutes ago.”

It was meant to be dismissive. To mislead.

But the clone twitched.

Not physically—at first. Something flickered behind its eyes, like a light dimming behind faulty glass. Its smile faltered, then reassembled, piece by piece. Too slow.

Phainon sat still, eyes narrowed.

The clone’s gaze swept the room—too fast, too focused—and then locked onto one of the civilians standing near the edge of the group. A teenage girl,

maybe seventeen, had been nervously watching the whole thing from a corner.

And then it stepped toward her.

Not with aggression. Not at first. Just calmly. Quietly.

Like it had made a decision no one else was aware of.

Phainon stood up, already tense. “Hey—”

The girl took a step back, but the clone reached for her anyway, hand outstretched in a mechanical approximation of reassurance.

“I wouldn’t,” Phainon warned, low.

But the clone didn’t stop. It moved faster now, grip shifting from open to forceful in a blink. Fingers curled around her arm—not hard enough to break it, but tight enough to hold. Tight enough to make her flinch.

Then came the sound—an ugly, grinding static—like something internal had misfired.

And in the next moment, the clone jerked, too suddenly, movements disjointed. Its head tilted slightly off-axis, and its voice—when it tried to speak again—came out warped, distorted with feedback.

“…confirming…target behavior…reset—reset…”

The girl cried out.

Now people were moving. Chairs scraped, feet stumbled, someone shouted for an instructor, but no one stepped forward. No one expected the simulation to break like this.

Phainon’s hand was already halfway to his weapon—training blade or not—but before he could close the distance—

Mydei moved first.

One step. Two.

Then his fist connected with the side of the clone's face in a clean, brutal arc. The impact sent the figure crashing to the floor. Sparks cracked along its jaw as it twisted unnaturally, back arching in a seizure of code. Limbs locked. Skin shimmered—and then collapsed into a facsimile of composite plating, tech and frame now visible where skin used to be.

Silence.

The girl scrambled away. People stared. One man near the back sat down slowly, stunned into immobility.

The dummy fizzled, glitching softly against the floor, its systems fried beyond repair.

Phainon stared at it, then turned to Mydei—who stood, hand still partially raised, breathing calm and steady, but eyes sharper than they'd been all day.

There was a beat. Then Phainon snorted, shaking his head once. "So… you knew."

Mydei didn't answer at first. His expression didn't shift, but the silence was enough.

"You hit him faster than I've seen you blink," Phainon muttered, mouth quirking up at the corner. "Violent, decisive, deeply romantic. But if there's a next time—I'm begging you. No more clones. No more robots. No more existential crises in moderately furnished living rooms."

The official debrief came two hours later.

And it was exactly as satisfying as getting stabbed with a retractable training blade.

Most participants were crammed into a too-bright multipurpose room where someone from the administrative board—flanked by a Chrysos Heir liaison

and an official from the Civic Engagement Division—stood at the front and tried very hard not to look like this had been a total disaster.

They failed.

"…a systems miscalibration," the woman was saying, tone overly rehearsed, "that bypassed intended safety thresholds. While the impersonation module was cleared for advanced defense programming, it was not meant to be deployed in a public civilian setting—"

Phainon stopped listening halfway through.

His arm still ached faintly from the earlier bite. His nerves were twitching from residual adrenaline. And across the room, someone was crying while eating a granola bar, which felt like a perfect summary of the day.

It wasn't supposed to happen. Everyone kept saying that.

Which was reassuring, in the same way someone telling you "this plane shouldn't crash" mid-flight is reassuring.

A collaboration between the Chrysos Heirs and the Government—years in the making, funded, tested, backed by oversight committees—and yet a full malfunctioning impersonation unit somehow slipped past every checkpoint and nearly dislocated a seventeen-year-old's shoulder.

The trainers assured them this had never happened before.

The looks on their faces said it better not happen again.

Half the room filtered out as soon as they were told they could go. Some stayed behind to file informal reports. Others mumbled about lawsuits. And somewhere amidst it all, Phainon sat in a chair against the wall, filling out a feedback form he didn't remember picking up.

"Overall satisfaction with today's session?" it asked.

He drew a box between Neutral and Dismal and checked that instead.

Mydei appeared beside him a few seconds later, holding both their bags and what looked suspiciously like an unopened ice pack.

“You done?” Mydei asked.

“I regret to every deity I’ve ever learned about that I signed all those waivers without reading them.”

Mydei didn’t smile, but the look in his eye was half an apology, half an I told you so.

They left quietly. No dramatic exit. Just a few nods to the coordinators and a shared, tired glance between them as they stepped out into the cool evening air.

It was quiet outside.

Too quiet for the day they’d had.

“…So,” Phainon said after a beat, “how long do you think until I start dreaming about punching my own face?”

Mydei adjusted the bag over his shoulder and exhaled slowly. “Depends. Was it satisfying when I did it?”

Phainon gave him a look. “A little too much, honestly.”

They kept walking.

The streets were mostly empty by then, save for a few lights still glowing behind café windows and the soft hum of a distant train crawling across the horizon. Mydei walked a little ahead, quiet in that observant way of his, and Phainon trailed beside him, hands tucked into his coat pockets, shoulders slack with exhaustion.

A few paces passed in silence.

Then, casually—maybe too casually—Phainon tilted his head. “So… hypothetical.”

Mydei didn’t glance over. “Hm?”

“What would you do if I had been replaced?” Phainon asked. “Like—actually swapped out. Not a test, not a simulation. Just one day, new me. Would you know?”

It was said with a light lilt, like a joke. But it hung there, just a second too long.

Mydei finally turned, his expression unreadable.

Phainon met his gaze, still walking, still looking faintly amused, but his eyes were quiet. Thoughtful. There was a pause where it was clear he wanted to follow up with something else—another line, another joke, another way to pretend it didn’t matter.

But he didn’t.

He just waited.

Mydei stopped walking.

And that was enough to make Phainon do the same.

For a moment, Mydei just studied him—really studied him—the small shift of his weight, the tired draw at the corners of his mouth, the way he kept his chin lifted like he was daring someone to challenge him, even now.

“You’re asking,” Mydei said, voice low, “if I’d notice if something happened to you.”

Phainon’s smile flickered. “I mean. You *did* hesitate earlier.”

“Because I thought the test was going somewhere worse.”

“Oh.”

Another beat of silence. Then—“Would you have known if it was me?”

Mydei’s answer came without hesitation. “Yes.”

Phainon blinked.

Mydei didn’t elaborate. He didn’t list the reasons, though he could’ve.

He didn’t say how Phainon had a habit of fiddling with loose threads on his sleeves when he was thinking too hard—never pulling them, just turning them over between his fingers like he was grounding himself in something small. Or how he always tapped his heel twice before taking a step toward anything dangerous, as if giving himself a beat to change his mind—though he never did. Or how, when he was about to say something self-deprecating, he always glanced up first, almost like checking to see if Mydei was still looking at him.

He didn’t say how all of that, stitched together, made a person no clone could copy.

And more than that—how no clone would ever stop in the middle of an empty street, under flickering streetlights, just to ask a question like that. One that was half-joke, half-promise, and all Phainon.

So Mydei didn’t say any of it.

But the answer still sat plainly between them.

Phainon looked down, a little overwhelmed, a little thrown.

“…Okay,” he said quietly. “That’s a good answer.”

Mydei gave the barest huff of a laugh. “It’s the only one.”

They kept walking again. The city moved around them, slow and distant.

And somewhere in that stretch of silence, Phainon let out a long breath he didn’t realize he’d been holding.

Phainon bumped his shoulder into Mydei’s, light enough to pass for a joke, steady enough to say *I’m still here.*

“You’re lucky I’m so damn charming,” he said, a grin tugging at the corner of his mouth. “Otherwise that clone might’ve actually had a chance.”

Mydei huffed a laugh, soft but real. He didn’t move away.

Instead, he let the quiet settle for a moment, long enough that Phainon thought it might’ve ended there—until Mydei spoke again.

“Thank you. For coming with me.”

Phainon blinked. His grin faltered—not gone, just… gentler now.

The warmth of Mydei’s words crawled beneath his ribs, unexpected and earnest. He looked away, then back, because it mattered. Because it was Mydei.

He said, voice low but sure, “I’d go anywhere if it meant walking beside you.”

And for once, Mydei didn’t correct him. Didn’t scoff or roll his eyes.

He just stood there, shoulder still brushing Phainon’s, as the last rays of sun dipped behind the city’s spires—quiet and full of things unspoken, but understood all the same.

Chapter End Notes

> Next chapter is probably gonna be delayed a bit since I’m working on sm else, and I’m thinking of a way to combine two ideas I had for the next chapter to make it sm enjoyable AND drop some Phainon lore if I can so uhh, sorry
>
> Anyway, you guys are always welcome to criticize or add new ideas for this fic since it’s pretty open-ended and anything can work really (Worst things worst if the criticism goes too hard I’ll develop a degradation kink or sm idk) so yeah😯

PS: just wanna add sm irrelevant and probably forgotten but stuck in my head. Abt the whole Mydei screaming abt the spider, Mydei screamed not at the spider, but because he'd nearly blurted out something hero-related—mid-kiss (Their first kiss probably), dizzy, bleeding just a little from getting his head smacked in by some guy an hour ago, and absolutely not thinking straight—and panicked to cover it. The spider just happened to be there, so he pointed and screamed like it was the problem

Chapter 8: Well, That's One Way to Meet Your Boyfriend's Childhood Friend

Chapter Summary

> Mydei just wanted a quiet day in the library. Instead, a mysterious vigilante dropped by with ghost problems, emotional trauma manifested in horrifyingly personal ways, and a battle that nearly got him shredded. On the bright side, he survived, helped neutralize a major threat, and hey—now he gets to surprise his boyfriend with a reunion years in the making. What could possibly go wrong?

Chapter Notes

> Stuck making a delinquent x nerd au from Mydei or Phainon's POV. Decisions decisions…Also not sure if I should make Mydei the nerd or delinquent, I was originally gonna go with the second option but idk now😩

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For once, the library was quiet in the right way.

Not the kind of quiet that came after someone triggered a defense glyph (Don't ask why he had that here) or spilled coffee on a restricted section. The peaceful kind—no alarms, no echoing footsteps, no undergrad sobbing into their third energy drink. Just the hum of the overhead lights, the gentle rustle of a turning page, and the soft clink of a teaspoon tapping porcelain.

Mydei sipped his tea, cross-legged behind the front desk with a stack of unsorted horror novels at his elbow. Some were barely holding together with cracked spines and yellowing pages, others shiny and obnoxious with dust jackets that claimed to "redefine fear." He'd believed that once. At sixteen. Now he just wanted to figure out if *The Third Mouth* belonged under psychological thrillers or allegorical body horror. Alphabetizing was

easy. Themes were harder, and themes that *lied about what kind of book they were* were the bane of his afternoon.

Still, he wasn't in a bad mood. Caelus had actually returned his books without needing to be hunted down this time—which was nothing short of miraculous. Even better, it was during a term break, so there'd been no throngs of panic-induced crammers. Mydei hadn't even bothered to make a joke (Not really) about charging late fees. Not out of mercy. He just didn't feel like it.

Which was, for him, a sign of rare and possibly worrying contentment.

He glanced at the digital planner floating off to the side of his desk, the pale blue light casting soft reflections over the surface of his tea. The reminder was still pinned at the top: *Meeting scheduled: Garden Hall @ 18:00. Guest: Cyrene.*

That was the other thing.

He leaned back in his chair, arms folded loosely across his chest, and allowed himself a small, private sense of satisfaction. Cyrene had reached out a week ago—soft-spoken, hesitant, asking if she could surprise Phainon. "Just to talk," she'd said. "He probably doesn't even remember me well, but I thought maybe… it might be good for him."

Mydei had said yes without thinking. And then he'd spent the next four hours reserving the space, coordinating schedules, and checking for surveillance nodes. Twice. No one was ruining this. Especially not him.

It was a dumb thing to be proud of, maybe. Setting up a simple meeting. But it was more than that. Phainon didn't know yet, but he'd be happy—probably talk too much, or forget to eat, or smile in that weird way where his nose scrunched up a little. Mydei already liked the idea of seeing it.

He wasn't the sentimental type. But every once in a while, when he wasn't being stalked by cursed abominations or dragged into vigilante nonsense, he could be a decent partner. He'd scheduled a surprise. Coordinated it down

to the minute. Hell, he even made sure the lighting in the garden would hit Phainon’s good side.

The day had started well.

Which, of course, meant it was about to be completely ruined.

He was halfway through labeling a misfiled edition of *The Weeping Engine* when the front doors opened.

He didn’t look up at first. People came in sometimes—students looking for a quiet place, researchers who still thought everything could be solved by finding the *right* obscure reference. He was ready to nod politely, maybe even offer directions if they looked sufficiently lost.

Then he heard heels. And humming.

He looked up.

Cipher.

In civilian disguise, technically. Which in her case meant a loose hoodie, reflective sunglasses despite being indoors, and an oversized messenger bag probably full of stolen access cards and questionable gum. She sauntered in like she’d personally paid for the floor tiles, waved cheerfully in his direction, and immediately veered past the reading area into the staff-only section with the sort of aimless confidence that only a true menace could radiate.

Mydei stared. Blinked once. Set his pen down very carefully.

There were signs. So *many signs.* “Authorized Personnel Only.” “Surveillance in Use.” One with a cartoon cat holding a ‘NO ENTRY’ placard. He’d added that one specifically to see if she’d take it seriously.

She had not.

“Out,” he said flatly.

Cipher glanced over her shoulder, eyebrows up, as if she was the one being inconvenienced. “Why? I’m not doing anything yet.”

“I can change that.”

She grinned. “Aw, come on, don’t be like that. I’m just here for a book.”

“You’re banned.”

“That was weeks ago.”

“For life.”

She wandered over to a shelf anyway, flipping through a random volume like she hadn’t heard him. “Ooh, this one’s got diagrams. Creepy little—wait, is that blood or ink?”

He reached under the desk.

Cipher’s head snapped up. “You wouldn’t.”

“Try me.”

There was a brief, tense silence—her eyes locked on the drawer handle, his hand hovering just above it.

“You bring that cucumber spray out and I swear I’ll scream,” she said.

“You’re not supposed to be here.”

“It’s a ridiculous weapon. Who carries weaponized vegetables? And why cucumbers? They’re smug.”

“You said they were ‘visually aggressive’ last time.”

“I stand by that.”

Mydei didn’t move. Neither did she. Eventually, Cipher sighed, dropped the act, and let her shoulders fall into something closer to serious.

“Okay, look. I didn’t come here to steal anything. Or break anything. Or touch the ancient cursed binder you keep pretending isn’t cursed.”

He raised one eyebrow.

“I need your help,” she said.

The tone shift was subtle, but unmistakable. Her voice didn’t pitch upward at the end of the sentence like it was a punchline. It was just honest for once.

Mydei frowned. “With what.”

“Something’s wrong,” Cipher said. “Weird-wrong. And it’s not the fun kind this time.”

Mydei didn’t bother answering her directly. He just sighed—long and tired, like her presence had physically aged him—and gestured for her to follow. As he turned, he made a point of slipping the cucumber spray into his pocket slowly, eyes never leaving hers.

Cipher huffed. “You’re dramatic.”

“You’re a thief.”

“Not today.”

He didn’t respond.

She trailed after him, hands visible and well away from anything valuable. It wasn’t fear—Cipher wasn’t the type—but she did know better than to provoke him in his own domain. The library echoed faintly under their footsteps. His office door was at the back, past the main stacks and locked behind three separate mechanisms: one electronic, one physical, one biometric.

She whistled under her breath. “Still overcompensating, I see.”

“It’s not paranoia if people like you exist.”

Inside, the office was… warm. Somehow. Wood shelves lined with annotated folders and battered paperbacks, a reading lamp that threw a golden pool of light over the desk, a second mug that might've been used by someone else recently—or maybe just wishful thinking. Cipher flopped into one of the guest chairs, slouching with the practiced ease of someone who didn't respect furniture. Mydei remained standing.

"You said something's wrong," he said.

Cipher didn't answer right away. She reached into her bag—not quickly, but Mydei still tensed—and pulled out a cracked datapad. She set it down between them and pushed it forward.

"People are seeing the dead," she started with abruptly, tone shifting. No foreplay, it seems.

Mydei didn't flinch. "Go on."

"Loved ones. Friends. Someone they haven't spoken to in years. Sometimes just in a crowd, sometimes directly in their homes. Always personal. Always intimate."

Mydei didn't sit. He skimmed the logs, eyes narrowing.

"It's not hallucinations," Cipher added. "Not some localized psychic echo, not emotional bleed. The encounters follow the same pattern. First sighting. Then conversation. Then blackout."

Mydei frowned. "You mean they faint."

"No." Cipher leaned forward now, more serious than he'd seen her in… maybe ever. "They *shut down*. Coma-level. Neural responses drop off the chart. You get people lying there like they're dreaming, but you run scans and the brain's just… *off*. I'm not sure how to describe it."

He processed that. Quietly. Cipher watched him do it.

"How many cases?"

“Not enough for public panic. Yet.” Her voice dropped slightly. “But enough for a pattern.”

“Why not alert the others?” he asked. “The Heirs. Or the agency.”

Cipher hesitated. Just for a second. “Because the more people you involve, the more chances this thing has to spread. Every encounter leaves a trace. Every *retelling* does too. It adapts, *learns*. Once you’re in its sight, it won’t let you go. That’s why I didn’t call Castorice until I had to. She picked up something in Sector 5—might be a linked anomaly. She’s tracking it now.”

“And what? You decided *I* was safe?”

“You’re immortal.”

“That’s not immunity.”

“It’s better odds than anyone else I know.” Her voice wasn’t flippant this time. “And frankly, you’re harder to replace.”

Mydei didn’t bother responding to that. His eyes stayed fixed on the logs, parsing every detail.

“They’re not just illusions,” he murmured. “They’re entities. Artificial. Possibly sentient. Definitely invasive.”

Cipher nodded. “I think someone—or something—is replicating them. Mimics. Not projections. They’re *built*. From data. Memories, emotions, patterns. Everything personal, down to the tone of voice and favorite arguments.”

He closed the pad. “How?”

“That’s what I need your help figuring out. But I’ve been digging, and I’ve found traces of something deeper.” She paused. The next words came slower. “There are anchor nodes. Places that stabilize whatever this is. I’ve found two for sure. The third is still buried—maybe even mobile.”

“Hive system,” he muttered.

She nodded. “Yeah. Everything branches back to the center. But if we can pull out two legs of the tripod…”

“The third collapses. Or at least stumbles.”

“Exactly.”

Mydei finally sank into his chair, fingertips pressed together.

“This is a lot of effort for someone who thinks cases are boring,” he said.

Another pause.

“…Yeah.”

Just that.

Mydei looked at her for a long moment. Cipher—who once rerouted an entire museum’s security grid just to leave a glitter trail in the shape of a middle finger. Who broke into a tech lab for a snack. Who said laws were more like “polite suggestions, if you’re into that.”

She was scared.

Not panicking or anything. But scared. It showed in the way she tapped her foot—small, unconscious. In the way her eyes didn’t linger on the datapad too long, like the logs might bite. In the way she said “yet” like she was already counting down to when she’d be next.

“I wouldn’t have come here if it wasn’t serious,” she said, voice quiet.

“I know,” he said.

Mydei sighed. For the second time that hour. And with markedly less resistance than the first.

“I’ll help,” he said, like it was a resignation. As if she was gravity and he was tired of fighting physics.

Across from him, Cipher immediately perked up. “Knew you’d come around,” she said, cheery again with all the grace of a car crash. “You’ve got that face. The ‘dammit, fine, give me the demon files’ face.”

“I have never made that face.”

“You’re making it right now.”

“I will throw you out a window.”

She grinned, pushing to her feet. “Cool, great, perfect. Gear up. We’re hitting the Archive first.”

Mydei arched a brow. “You’re assuming I’ve agreed to be seen with you in public.”

“Oh, please. Like they won’t all be too distracted wondering how no one’s figured out you were Godslayer.” She tossed that out casually, like a pebble into a pond. “I mean, come on, you didn’t even change your walk.”

Mydei’s hand drifted up, thumb and forefinger pinching the bridge of his nose with a kind of quiet grace, as if physically holding back the sheer wave of secondhand stupidity radiating off her.

“I operate under layered dissonance algorithms, reinforced by a reactive cloaking system calibrated to my voiceprint, gait, and signature field,” he said calmly. “People see what they expect. They hear what they want. And no one ever suspects the cranky librarian.”

Cipher blinked. “Wow. That almost sounded cool.”

Mydei turned toward the door.

“Except,” Cipher added, cheerfully malicious, “I *did* figure it out. So clearly your little disguise system doesn’t account for me being smarter than your average idiot.”

He stopped.

“My voice was run through a triple-phase modulator and my physical presence was blanketed by quantum masking, dumbass.”

The word snapped out harder than intended.

Cipher grinned like she’d just won a game she’d invented mid-conversation. “There he is.”

“Get out.”

“What?”

“Go, Cipher. Prep your plan, plot your route, pack your weird little grenades—whatever it is you do. I’ll be ready in twenty.”

“Wow. Rude.”

He was already opening the office door.

Cipher gave him an exaggerated bow on the way out. “You know, for someone who keeps a literal library of cursed books, you’re shockingly bad at dramatic exits.”

“And you’re still banned from the special collections.”

“*I put that book back!* Mostly.”

The door shut behind her with a decisive click.

Mydei stood in silence for a moment, letting the absurdity of his life soak in like the world’s worst tea. Then he moved toward his hidden gear cache and started suiting up. After all, it wasn’t every day someone asked you to go hunt memory-eating death mimics.

Getting inside wasn’t difficult. Not with Cipher.

She didn’t exactly pick the locks. She bypassed them entirely—moving through the lower access tunnels with the kind of precision that made it

hard to tell whether she was fast or just chronically disrespectful of the laws of physics. Either way, the surveillance was useless. The biometric scanner didn't so much glitch as… give up.

The deeper they descended, the quieter it got.

The freight elevator they took shuddered like it hadn't moved in a decade. Past a certain floor, the lights above stopped responding. Emergency strips lined the walls instead—pale, battery-fed, and dying slow. Each step echoed too long against concrete and metal, and the air started to feel compressed. Not stale exactly—just still. Like nothing had breathed here in a long time.

Cable conduits ran along the ceiling, many snapped open or ripped clean through. Old security plating had been scorched and rewelded. And here and there, splashes of abandoned signage peeled from the walls, warning about radiation or protocol tiers that no longer mattered.

A set of autonomous doors finally slid open ahead of them with a delayed whir. Cipher had to slap the side panel twice, then give it a swift kick before the biometric lag caught up.

"Very advanced," she muttered. "Love what they've done with the place. Real minimalist apocalypse."

"Keep your voice down," Mydei said.

She did.

They spoke in clipped bursts, low voices.

"Tell me you have a map," Mydei said, eyes scanning the long, sterile hallway ahead.

Cipher waved a small holotab over her shoulder without looking back. "I memorized it. You really think I'd break into a ex-government-esque death maze *without* doing my homework?"

"Last time you navigated with intuition, we ended up in a collapsing maglev tunnel."

“That tunnel was *mostly* intact.”

They passed a rusting security checkpoint. A flicker of motion down the hall turned out to be a wire swaying from a cracked ceiling tile.

They were still cautious. Banter didn’t mean blind.

They reached the vault.

A broad circular chamber opened before them—once sealed by layers of reinforced steel, now cracked just wide enough for someone to squeeze through. Inside, everything was too quiet. Consoles sat dormant around a central core, though faint glows still pulsed under the surface—like a sleeping heartbeat.

Mydei frowned. “This is it?”

Cipher’s usual smirk faded as she took a step forward, scanning the tall server racks along the walls. “Not what I expected.”

“Neither did I,” he said, stepping in after her. “This was built.”

Then he saw the center column.

A tall, humming core encased in crystalline housing, flickering with pulses of light—and beneath the crystal: neural threads. Rows upon rows of memory fibers. Each labeled with Chrysos codenames. Some still active.

Mydei froze.

Cipher didn’t speak.

He approached slowly, eyes narrowing as he spotted a familiar strand, labeled with a numerical code that shouldn’t have existed outside classified Chrysos archives. One he knew was tied to *him*.

“This is a Chrysos archive,” he said, voice lower now, more deliberate. “Not just general data. These are personal logs. Mission footage. Thought patterns.”

Cipher looked genuinely disturbed. “No one outside the Heirs should have this.”

“They don’t even share it internally,” Mydei muttered. “Not unless you’re cleared. Even then, only in fragments. How the hell—”

“Someone stole the archive,” Cipher said, voice flat. “And fed it to a quantum server.”

They exchanged a look.

Neither of them said it, but the implication hung heavy between them.

Whoever built this node didn’t just want to replicate memories.

They wanted to *understand* them.

To crawl inside.

And build something out of what they found.

Cipher after a moment, peeled off to the far end of the vault, slipping behind stacks of corroded processors and tangled cords with a practiced lightness. Mydei stayed near the central servers, watching the sluggish blink of interface lights across the old paneling. The air carried the sterile sharpness of disuse, like ozone and forgotten code.

He tugged on a pair of gloves, knelt by the mainframe, and began to trace the input feeds. “Interface activity’s still semi-live,” he muttered, half to himself. “Residual power. This wasn’t mothballed right.”

“Because it wasn’t supposed to be found,” Cipher replied from somewhere behind the server stacks. “This place wasn’t on any of the listings.”

“Of course it wasn’t.” He pressed his hand to the biometric override, waited for the low chirp of denial, and reached for his Chrysos ID instead. “I’m bypassing the failsafe. Keep an eye out for redundancy triggers.”

“Duh,” Cipher said, but the usual edge in her voice was dulled. “You think it’ll scream?”

“Something worse.” The panel clicked open, revealing a narrow feed of code windows—sluggish, fractured, but still learning.

They should have stopped there. Should’ve taken the coordinates, corrupted the chain, and left it to rot. But curiosity had never been kind to the Chrysos Heirs. Especially not the immortal ones.

Mydei linked in.

The interface recognized them instantly.

The lights overhead flickered—sharp, sudden—and the silence of the vault thickened.

Then the system started to speak.

Not in code.

Not in language.

But in *voice*.

Not just any voice.

“Mydei.”

His spine straightened. Just slightly. A pause in the breath, a stiffness behind the eyes. Nothing more, but Cipher, looping back around, caught it anyway.

She slowed to a stop beside him. “Who was that?”

He didn’t answer.

The voice came again. Warmer this time, a little playful. “Don’t pretend you didn’t hear me. You always try to look so serious when you’re

concentrating.”

And then the figure stepped through the far wall of servers—no warning, just a shift in the lighting, a tilt in perspective—and Gorgo was there.

Or something *wearing* her.

Cipher’s hand went to her belt immediately. Mydei didn’t move.

The projection wasn’t faded or holographic. It wasn’t a rough approximation built from low-res memory scans. This was *sharp*. Every detail was in place, down to the silver burn mark on the edge of her left gauntlet, the uneven twist in her braid.

And the look in her eyes. Proud. Tired. Softened by something that felt like recognition.

“You never came back to the house.”

Mydei stopped.

“You left everything as it was. Even the tea tins.”

It blinked slowly. Too human. Not human enough.

“The one on the shelf… You kept that sealed. Thought I wouldn’t notice?” A slight tilt of the head. “You were always good at pretending you’d moved on. You never were.”

“How is it doing this?” Cipher asked under her breath, unreadable now.

“Pulled from logs. Audio files. Mission reports, *memories.*” Mydei replied quietly, eyes still locked on the projection. “Chrysos archives don’t just track kills. They record everything. Even when they’re not supposed to.” That included your head apparently.

“And someone dumped that here?”

“No. Someone *stole* it.”

The figure tilted its head. “Still talking over me. You used to mumble back then, remember?”

Its smile was wrong. Perfect on the surface, but too smooth—like wax warmed just enough to warp.

Mydei stayed quiet.

He could feel the tension in his shoulders, but it wasn’t fear. Not exactly. Just a cold stillness. One he hadn’t touched in years.

The last time he’d heard her voice, it hadn’t sounded like this. It had been sharp. Annoyed. *“Duck faster,”* she’d snapped—right before it happened. Not some grand sacrifice, not a teary farewell. Just pissed she had to die doing something stupid because her son was too slow that day.

He’d replayed it more times than he’d admit.

And yet here this thing was, speaking like she’d never left. Telling him how proud she was. How well he’d turned out. As if it had a right.

As if it *knew*.

His hands twitched.

“Don’t,” Cipher said softly. “It’s baiting you.”

He didn’t respond.

The projection stepped forward. “I’m proud of you, Mydeimos. I always have been.”

Its face flickered.

For a fraction of a second, the skin smoothed over where her scar should have been. The pupils rotated wrong. Then the glitch passed, like it had never happened.

Mydei’s jaw clenched.

It wasn’t her. He *knew* that. But the voice… it *sounded* like her. And part of him—stupid, aching, traitorous—wanted to listen anyway.

“I miss you,” it said.

Then again.

“I miss you.”

It started to loop.

“I miss you.”

“I miss you.”

“I miss you—”

The voice stuttered mid-sentence, volume peaking just enough to spike the speaker output.

Then: a crackle. A sharp whine of overclocked circuits frying as Cipher jammed a spike charge directly into the access port beside them.

The illusion shattered with no fanfare. Just a blink—and gone.

The room fell quiet again, save for the hum of cooling processors.

The charge burned through the remaining memory strings, glitching the server until even the automated voice couldn’t rebuild itself. Static hissed for a few seconds. Then silence.

Mydei stood still. For a long time.

Cipher didn’t speak.

She just shifted a little to the side—just enough to stand in the line of sight between him and where the projection had been.

When he finally moved, it was to turn off the feed. A flick of the switch.

She still didn’t ask.

And he didn’t explain.

Cipher crouched by the still-flickering remains of the access port, visor flicking through data overlays as she scanned what was left of the corrupted server. Static danced along the edges of the projection glass—brief ghost-frames flashing, then dissolving.

“Someone hardwired this thing to pull from blacklisted archives,” she muttered. “Not just scraps. Direct uplink. Memory logs, audio stamps… someone’s been siphoning for a while.”

Mydei didn’t respond. He leaned against the wall with a hand braced near the switchboard, face unreadable.

Cipher’s tone shifted, quieter. “This shouldn’t even be possible. Chrysos archives are supposed to be locked behind three identity firewalls and a temporal checksum. You don’t just… *find* this kind of thing.”

She stood. Gaze lingering on the ruined projection panel.

“Someone wanted this to feel personal. That would’ve made it harder to shut down.”

He finally looked up at that. “They almost got their wish.”

Cipher nodded once, grim. Then kicked the access unit hard enough to spark a trail of dying blue light across the floor.

“One down,” she said, turning away. “Two more to go.”

Mydei followed, slower this time. The vault hissed shut behind them, and the silence that followed felt heavier than when they’d arrived.

The tunnels beneath the metro grid stank of ozone and old power. Low, thudding hums echoed off the walls, mechanical heartbeats pulsing somewhere deep ahead. Mydei barely said a word the entire descent—just

watched their surroundings, the way the lights shifted, the way Cipher walked without her usual dramatic flair.

That, more than anything, put him on edge.

“Is there a reason we’re walking directly into a place that gives off obvious mind-control energy,” he asked, dry, “or do you just enjoy ignoring basic survival instinct?”

Cipher glanced back with a smile that didn’t quite reach her eyes. “Didn’t peg you for claustrophobic, Book King.”

“I’m not. I just like knowing if I’m walking into a place designed to peel my brain open like fruit leather.”

“Ugh, gross.”

She turned a corner, crouched, and scanned the wall for a biometric seam. When her glove lit green, the panel slid open, revealing an old stairwell reinforced with psych-steel plates. Reinforced from inside.

Mydei stared at the layers of shielding. “This place was meant to keep something in.”

“Technically? Minds. Lots of them.” Cipher didn’t look back. “It’s called the Mirror Room.”

“And how, exactly, did you find it?”

“Luck. Gut instinct. A vaguely threatening dream about elevators.” She shrugged. “You ever follow a feeling so weird it *had* to be something?”

“I avoid feelings as a general rule.”

She grinned.

They descended. The door sealed behind them.

The room opened slowly—more facility than chamber. White, pristine, but wrong. Mirrors lined the walls in seamless rows, reflecting too much light. There were no frames, no angles, just endless glass. One flickered faintly, and Cipher immediately covered her eyes.

“Don’t look directly into them until we break the primary feed,” she warned. “This place reads your emotional map and tailors stimuli to it. That means—”

“I’m aware what emotional feedback loops are,” Mydei muttered.

“Okay, nerd.”

A monitor blinked to life above them, a silent stream of data pulsing across the screen. There were tags. Names. Brief flashes of faces, expressions mid-panic or reverie. Cipher paused beneath it, reading.

“This whole node was a psychological experiment,” she said after a moment, voice tight. “Run by something codenamed *Voxcore*. They tagged people—implants, minor enough to pass as headaches. Then ran simulations. Trauma exposure. Cycles. Like AI-driven therapy, except not.”

“Except weaponized.”

Cipher nodded. “It’s using this data to pacify or destabilize. Depending on who walks in. Guess what that means for us.”

“I’m going to see something I’d rather not. Again.”

“Yep. And I’ll probably see something that makes me want to punch a wall. Again.”

They exchanged a glance.

Then Cipher cracked her knuckles. “Alright. You hit the core; I’ll handle the reroute from the server spine. We move quick. Mirrors aren’t mirrors. They’re interface panels. Don’t let them catch your reflection for too long.”

Mydei didn’t reply. Just set his jaw, adjusted the strap of the reinforced glove on his left hand, and walked in.

They split the moment the floor panels lit up.

Cipher bolted left, slipping between panels with inhuman grace, each step timed between sensor flickers. Mydei moved with practiced, deliberate force, weaving past the mirrors with just enough peripheral awareness to map the room without catching his reflection.

Data arced above them—lines of code bleeding into the air like spectral veins. Somewhere deeper in, something pulsed once, faint and rhythmic, as if the entire facility had a heartbeat.

Mydei reached the core housing first. The vault was sealed behind reinforced plating, rigged with logic puzzles and outdated encryption cycles. Child’s play. His fingers flew over the interface, bypassing most of the system’s interactive layers and slipping beneath, directly into the skeleton of the feed.

“Spinal reroute in place,” Cipher’s voice crackled through the comms. “About to overload the primary channels.”

“Wait for the loop to hit forty-two percent,” Mydei replied, still focused. “Any earlier and it’ll just reroute to the mirrors again.”

“I *know* how to fry a loop, Mydei.”

“Then don’t *talk* while doing it.”

“Rude.”

He heard her laugh, faint and sharp through the earpiece—but it cut off too soon. Static crackled.

Then nothing.

“Cipher?” he asked. No response.

Mydei straightened from the console. “Cipher, report.”

No answer.

He moved.

The halls here weren’t uniform—stretched too long, corners angled just slightly off-center like someone had built this place in a dream. The air grew colder the deeper he went. Not temperature. Not really. Just… quiet. Like something had pressed a hand over the world.

He found her two junctions over, standing frozen in the middle of a mirrored corridor. One foot lifted, mid-step. Her arm was still halfway up, like she’d meant to wave something away. But she wasn’t moving.

Her eyes were locked ahead.

Mydei followed her gaze—and stopped.

Standing directly in Cipher’s path was… Cipher. Younger. Blood on her cheek. Hair tangled. Eyes wide and tearful.

“Don’t go in,” the younger version whispered. “Please. Don’t go in. It’s a trap. You’ll die. I—”

She stepped back, hands trembling. “I shouldn’t have come. I shouldn’t’ve done it. I *told* you. You never listen—”

Mydei took one step forward, reaching to grab Cipher’s shoulder.

She flinched like she hadn’t even realized he was there.

The projection glitched—once. A flicker, like static under skin. Then the young Cipher vanished.

Just gone.

Cipher exhaled sharply. Her hand clenched and unclenched at her side.

“She wasn’t part of the data feed,” she muttered. “I scanned the whole thing. There was nothing from that year. No mirror should’ve pulled that.”

Mydei said nothing. He just waited.

Cipher didn’t look at him. “I’m fine,” she said. Then louder, with more bite: “I said I’m fine.”

He nodded once.

And they kept moving.

Mydei didn’t comment on what had just happened.

He saw nothing in the corridor ahead—no flickers—but that meant very little in a place like this. Silence could be a lull or a lie. Cipher had gone quiet, and he respected it, shifting his attention instead to the path ahead, mapping the remaining grid lines and redirecting power flow.

Behind him, he heard the faint hitch of breath as she collected herself. No careful tone. He’d never insult her with that.

Instead, he asked, “You scanned the archives before we came. No entries from that year?”

Cipher exhaled hard through her nose. “I *triple-checked*. That memory shouldn’t be here. Not even close. My tagging was wiped by the time I joined Aglaea. I made sure of it.”

“Then the system’s pulling data it shouldn’t have access to. Unindexed memories. Possibly pre-verbal imprints.”

Cipher snorted. “You say that like it’s a comforting theory.”

“It’s not.”

They reached the anchor point three minutes later. Deep in the heart of the loop chamber, tucked behind a half-glitched array of emotion-mapping

relays, stood the core: a tangle of optic threads and mirrored neuromesh, glowing faintly blue beneath a stretched surface like skin over circuitry.

This wasn't just a storage vault. It was active processing. Multiple minds, thousands of signatures, all crammed and indexed by trauma severity.

Cipher rubbed her temples. "Why do I feel like this room is screaming at me without making a sound."

"Because it probably is."

Mydei stepped closer, careful not to catch his reflection in the walls. The pulse from the anchor was stronger here, vibrating through his shoes into bone. It wasn't a conscious force—but it wasn't unconscious either. It was built to *watch*, built to *feel*. And now that it had been disturbed, it was lashing back with the only weapons it had: memories and mimicry.

Cipher moved around the other side, flipped open her modified Chrysos terminal—sleek, almost skeletal, with glowing threads crawling across its frame like tattoos. Her own design, of course. "Alright, we'll hit it from both sides. Mydei, prep for sync. I'll spike the top layer."

He nodded once, linking his interface through hers. There was a flick of static, then—

Pain. Like memory itself had turned to shards and decided to burrow straight through their skulls.

He gritted his teeth as Cipher hissed, staggering back a step.

"This isn't a normal node," she bit out. "It's a convergence point. All the tagged signatures? They're not just stored—they're looped. It's *running* them. Endlessly. Like a fucking simulation engine."

Mydei's eyes narrowed at the code bloom unfolding on the shared display.

It was mutating.

He watched the lines writhe—once-sharp logic pathways now folding into themselves, data loops splitting and forking into tangents. Each cycle made it more complex. More cohesive. Not random.

“Adaptation,” he muttered. “It’s learning from every emotional imprint. Reconstructing its interfaces with borrowed behavior.”

Cipher was pale now. “You mean the mimics.”

“They’re not just images. They’re evolving constructs. The longer they’re active, the more information they pull from the surrounding network. Eventually…”

“They won’t need the anchors,” she finished, voice tight. “They’ll be real enough to stand on their own.”

They both went still.

That had been the plan—hit two of the three, destabilize the system, and let the third unravel on its own. But now…

“This place wasn’t a foundation,” Mydei said slowly. “It was a womb.”

Cipher gave him a sharp look. “So what—you’re saying we’ve just been playing midwife to a parasitic dream machine?”

“Something like that.”

There wasn’t a dramatic countdown after that. Just a shared glance, a flick of synchronization between their terminals, and a discharge so sharp and bright it fried the neuromesh like a snapped nerve.

The core screamed—not audibly, but in sensation. The room convulsed. And then it died.

They stood in the sudden dark, both of them breathing harder than they realized. Something behind Cipher sparked once, then stilled.

“…Two down,” she said, pressing a hand to her temple. “One left.”

Mydei’s voice was low. “And if the third’s already stable…”

“Then it’s not a node anymore,” Cipher said grimly. “It’s a nest.”

They hadn’t slept. Not once. Cipher looked like hell, and Mydei hadn’t said a word about it—because she, miraculously, had refrained from commenting on the bags under his eyes.

Wind skated across the rooftop, tugging at Cipher’s hood as she leaned against the rusted railing. Mydei stood a few paces back, arms crossed, eyes fixed on a flickering billboard across the city. Neither of them had spoken in a while. There wasn’t much to say that hadn’t already been said in fragments over the last ten hours.

The second anchor was gone. Destroyed. And yet—

“It’s slowing,” Cipher said, finally stopping her pacing. “You were right. The first two anchors hit it hard. Spread’s down. Mimic activity’s staggered. But—”

“But it’s not regressing,” Mydei finished, not looking up. “It’s consolidating.”

“Like it’s bracing itself.”

“Or hiding,” he muttered.

She pulled out another protein bar, stared at it, then pocketed it again. “You know what pisses me off? We actually did everything right. Blew the anchors. Tracked the feeds. Burned the backups. And it’s still slithering around like it’s waiting for an upgrade.”

They went quiet again. A loose pipe rattled in the wind. Sirens murmured faintly in the distance.

Then, quietly, Cipher said, “I can’t trace it.”

He looked over.

“My network,” she clarified, jaw clenched. “Even the back channels. It’s not on the grid anymore. If it ever was.”

Cipher sighed. “If the third anchor exists, it’s wearing a mask. And wearing it well. No energy signature. No signal bleed. It’s either mobile, cloaked, or —”

“Disguised as a person.”

Silence again.

Cipher leaned back, arms folded. “If it’s wearing a human face, we’ve already lost.”

“We haven’t lost,” Mydei said sharply—more to himself than to her. “But we’re running out of time.”

The third node wasn’t just another link in the chain. If the first was storage, and the second was evolution, the third was the heart. The control center. The stabilizer that allowed the mimics to function independently. Once it reached maturity, destroying it might not matter. The system would be too far along—capable of surviving without support.

After a long silence, Cipher pulled out a comm device and scrolled through a list. Mydei caught a glimpse—she hovered over Aglaea’s ID for a second, then switched tabs. Not a friend. A protocol line.

She clicked it.

“Cipher, transmitting incident code Black Echo Three. Requesting joint investigation support from the Chrysos-Gov oversight unit. Immediate response window. Full access permissions.”

The reply came fast.

“Received.”

Just one word. But even Mydei felt the weight behind it.

Cipher locked the device and shoved it back into her jacket. “Well,” she said. “Guess it’s officially a party now.”

Mydei didn’t respond. Just stared out at the city.

The third anchor was still out there.

And it was learning how to be real.

The debrief took less time than it should have.

Cipher and Mydei were brought in fast—no waiting lines, just silent nods and biometric scans as the guards ushered them through steel doors and sealed checkpoints. They didn’t even get questioned until after someone shoved them both into a heated bench seat and handed over standard-issue emergency blankets. Cipher had laughed dryly at that, but didn’t complain. Mydei just wrapped his around his shoulders and leaned back, grateful not to be standing anymore.

They explained everything. The anchors. The projections. The mimic of Gorgo. The memory absorption pattern and the evolution protocols. By the time they reached the part about the third node, even the high-ranking agents had stopped asking clarifying questions. Aglaea herself stepped in soon after—listened to their rundown, brows knit, arms folded. When they were done, she gave a tight nod and walked off without a word.

Cipher whistled low. “She’s either really impressed or really about to gut someone.”

Mydei didn’t answer. He was half-asleep under his blanket, chin resting on one hand.

Cipher shifted, nudged his leg lightly with her boot. “So that’s it. We’re done, right?”

He opened one eye. “Yeah. Our part’s over.”

Cipher sat back, expression unreadable. “Weird, isn’t it? We tear through all that, almost get mimicked to hell, and barely a few hours later they already have a lead on the third node.”

“That fast?” Mydei sat up.

She nodded. “Didn’t tell me much—shockers. But they’ve got someone sniffing it out already. Chrysos-Gov are freakishly efficient when they want to be.”

He rubbed his temples. “I’d rather be moving.”

Cipher raised an eyebrow.

“I mean it.” Mydei stood, blanket still around his shoulders like a makeshift cloak. “I’m not useful sitting around here. I’ll cover ground, even if it’s nothing. Keeps me sane.”

Cipher didn’t argue. She leaned forward, elbows on her knees. “I figured you’d bounce. Honestly, I’m thinking I’ll stick around here a bit longer. Maybe poke at some of their auxiliary feeds, see if anything slips through. If that third anchor’s got a face, it’s only a matter of time before it blinks wrong somewhere.”

He nodded. “Keep me posted.”

She reached out, patted his shoulder with a tired smirk. “Will do. I’ll update you once Princess Homebody decides to grace us with her divine return.”

Mydei chuckled under his breath. “Castorice always has timing.”

“Too good,” Cipher muttered. “Girl’s a damn oracle.”

He moved toward the exit, blanket still trailing behind him like some reluctant cape. “Good luck.”

Cipher saluted lazily with two fingers. “You too, Godslayer.”

He didn’t turn back. Just lifted a hand in farewell and disappeared down the corridor.

The city hadn’t quieted. Not really. But it moved differently now.

Mydei walked with his hands in his pockets, blanket finally ditched back at the agency drop-off. The streets still buzzed faintly, transit lines rumbling underfoot, light pollution dusting the sky in faint orange. But there was a lull in the air.

He wasn’t just walking. Every few blocks, his eyes swept the rooftops, tracked faint movement across crosswalks, watched for glints of unnatural light or static skipping across the edges of glass. If there were residual signals, if anything lingered from the anchors… he wanted to see it first. Just to know.

But that was only part of it.

The other reason—well. That one made his pace pick up a little when the old garden district finally came into view.

The park wasn’t large. Most of the trees were grafted biogenics, and the grass had a telltale grid pattern from whatever underground wiring powered the garden’s humidity systems. Still, it was green. It was quiet. It was enough.

He turned a corner.

And there he was.

Phainon sat on one of the swings, bundled in a too-big hoodie, kicking the toes of his shoes against the dirt path. Head tilted up, watching the way the artificial leaves rustled in the night breeze. The kind of calm that looked effortless, but Mydei knew better—Phainon wasn’t fidgeting, which meant he’d been waiting.

Mydei didn’t say anything. Just walked over, settled into the swing next to him, and let the chains creak a little under his weight.

Phainon didn’t look surprised. Just glanced over, smile tugging at his mouth, soft and warm.

“You’re late,” he said.

Mydei tilted his head back, feigning thought. “Am I?”

“Not by much,” Phainon admitted. “I gave you a fifteen-minute grace window because I figured you’d get distracted saving someone’s cat.”

“Bold of you to assume I didn’t.”

That earned a small laugh. “Okay, now I’m picturing you in a tree trying to talk a cat down.”

“I wouldn’t talk it down. I’d negotiate.”

“Bet you’d lose.”

They sat like that for a moment—just the soft sway of the swings and the hush of the wind skimming over steel and synth-leaf. The streetlights flickered lazily, casting long shadows across the worn rubber beneath their feet.

Phainon bumped his swing into Mydei’s, just barely. “You look like you haven’t slept in two days.”

Mydei glanced over. “You’re not wrong.”

“And yet,” Phainon said, voice light, “you still showed up. Swing and all.”

“I’d rather die than miss this.”

“Dramatic.”

“Accurate.”

Phainon smiled again. Not the usual crooked smirk or the half-laugh kind of grin he wore when teasing—but something more sincere. Seems like he wasn't the only one who had a bad day. He looked down at his hands, then back at Mydei.

"I'm glad you're here."

Mydei didn't answer right away.

The swings creaked again, and the city moved on around them. For now, there weren't any sirens. No flickers of corrupted light. No weight dragging down Mydei's shoulders except the usual kind—the kind that felt a little lighter when Phainon was close by.

And tomorrow could wait.

Mydei stood first. He glanced once down the path, then said, "We're going on a walk."

Phainon leaned back slightly on the swing, sneakers scraping the dirt beneath him. "That's ominous," he said, not moving. "Is this a trick? Are you leading me into some obscure alley to yell at me about misusing the stovetop again?"

"It was on fire, Phainon."

"Briefly."

"You ignited a sound sculpture in the shape of a plate rack."

"I was exploring the intersection of form and vibration! …Also I thought the metal would vibrate less if I microwaved it first."

Mydei turned his head just enough to give him a slow, unimpressed look.

Phainon stood with a sigh, brushing nonexistent dust from his sleeves. "Fine. Lead the way."

They fell into step together easily. The streets ahead curled through the edge of the residential sector, which had mostly quieted for the night. Buildings softened from sleek mirrored glass into older stonework, accented with green tiles and scattered signs of aging infrastructure. Phainon kept talking the whole way, hands stuffed in his hoodie pockets, hopping from one thought to the next without much coherence.

He went on about some bizarre theory he read involving vibrational memory patterns—how certain materials might absorb and re-emit emotional frequencies—and how he'd been testing it by yelling compliments at spoons. "You laugh," he said seriously, "but the one I praised all week stirred my tea smoother than the others. The other ones were…judgy."

"You're scaring me."

"You don't understand the emotional range of flatware."

Mydei didn't say much. He just let Phainon ramble, which was both strategic and affectionate. He was listening. He always did, even when the logic spiraled off into the abstract.

They turned another corner and the noise of the city dropped off almost instantly.

Ahead of them, tucked between the shadows of a cluster of highrises, a narrow walkway opened into something more carefully designed. Mydei had chosen it precisely for that contrast—a quiet, enclosed courtyard nestled between a gallery and a government archive, overgrown with flowering vines and soft gold lighting that spilled down from the glass canopy above.

It wasn't a flashy place, but it was serene, with tall stone arches bordering a reflecting pool and hanging plants swaying faintly in the controlled breeze.

Phainon slowed as they approached, his footsteps naturally easing back from their earlier rhythm.

“You do know how to set a scene,” he said, half-impressed, half-suspicious. “Is this the part where you propose? Because I will faint.”

Mydei didn’t reply.

His gaze had already shifted toward the far end of the garden.

Beneath one of the arches, standing in a soft spill of overhead light, was someone waiting.

She wore a long, pale jacket. Her posture was calm.

Her hair—long, pink, unmistakable—caught the light in a way that made it almost shimmer.

Phainon followed Mydei’s line of sight.

He stopped mid-sentence.

The silence between them didn’t feel immediate. It was more like the world itself quieted by degrees, one layer at a time—first the rustle of leaves, then the distant drone of a tram, then the hum of lights overhead.

Phainon didn’t say anything.

Mydei started to step back, already easing himself a little out of the way, giving space the way someone would before a private reunion. What a good boyfriend I am, he thought, not without a touch of smugness.

Then Phainon turned and reached for him.

Not a gentle reach. His hand closed around Mydei’s wrist, firm and fast.

Mydei blinked, caught off guard. “Phainon?”

But Phainon didn’t answer. His grip tightened, and he pulled.

It wasn’t a sprint exactly. Just a quick, focused departure, like they were late for something.

“Hey,” Mydei said again, confused now, glancing back over his shoulder. “Phainon, what—?”

“We need to go,” Phainon muttered, curt but clear.

They were already halfway back through the arch when Mydei slowed his steps, resisting slightly. “That’s her. You knew she—”

“No,” Phainon cut in, his voice sharp now. “We’re not doing this.”

He wasn’t looking at Mydei anymore. His gaze was fixed straight ahead, and there was something in his jaw—something too tight.

“She’s waiting,” Mydei said carefully, testing.

Phainon’s grip only locked harder. “I know. That’s why we need to leave.”

The last words fell into the space behind them like stones.

And though Mydei didn’t say anything else, he couldn’t help but glance back one more time.

Cyrene was still standing there, exactly where she had been. Her head slightly tilted. Not waving. Not calling out.

Just watching.

They didn’t run far, but the turn they made was sharp, instinctive—guided more by Phainon’s grip than any actual destination. Mydei’s boots scuffed tile, and before he could voice the hundred questions crowding his throat, Phainon yanked open a rusted utility door nearly hidden by the garden’s layered vines and dragged them both through.

It was a service alcove. Small. Barely enough room to turn around without brushing metal pipes or the uneven concrete walls. The door clicked shut behind them, leaving only the distant hum of automated fans somewhere deep in the ventilation above.

Then Phainon slammed his palm into the wall beside Mydei's head—his other arm still pressing him back, pinning him.

"Okay," Mydei started, breath catching from the momentum, "what the hell is—"

He stopped.

Phainon wasn't looking at him. His head was bowed slightly, breath short, uneven. Mydei's voice faltered as he registered the slight tremble running through Phainon's shoulders. The shallow, almost panicked rhythm of it.

The last time he'd seen Phainon look remotely close to this had been years ago—and even then, it hadn't looked like *this*.

The silence folded in tight.

Phainon's voice, when it came, was quiet. Raw. "That's not her."

Mydei didn't move. He felt the tension in Phainon's arm still caging him in, the way his hand clenched and flexed as if unsure whether to hold on or run.

"I didn't think," Phainon said again, barely audible now, "I thought I'd imagined it the first time. That it was just someone who *looked* like her. But I saw her again. Three nights ago. Not there, not… not like that, but on the train. Same jacket. Same way of tilting her head. Same voice when she turned to a stranger and said 'excuse me.' Exactly the same."

His fingers curled tighter against the wall.

"I told myself I was wrong. That she couldn't look that young anymore, that she wouldn't wear her hair that way. But tonight—" He finally looked at Mydei, face pale in the low light. "She looked just like she did when we were fifteen. And she smiled."

The silence that followed wasn't awkward. It was final. Like a door slamming shut inside him.

“She’s dead, Mydei.”

Mydei felt the weight of the words settle into the room like dust. Heavy. Undeniable. And for the first time since stepping into this entire garden, he understood the look in Phainon’s eyes when they’d seen her.

It hadn’t been shock, it had been recognition.

Not of a person though, but of a ghost that shouldn’t exist.

Mydei reached for him—not to stop him, not even to pull him back, just to make contact—but Phainon wasn’t really present anymore. He stood with both hands braced against the wall like he needed the pressure to keep from unraveling. His breathing had steadied, but it didn’t sound right. Like he was focusing on getting through it, not coming down from anything.

Mydei opened his mouth. “I didn’t know.”

“I know.”

There wasn’t room in his voice for anything beyond that. Not blame. Not comfort.

Then Phainon straightened and turned toward him, not completely relaxed, but no longer visibly shaking either. His expression had gone still, not blank—measured. He didn’t ask permission or explain when he leaned forward and pressed his lips briefly to Mydei’s forehead. It wasn’t affectionate in the usual way. More like giving someone—himself—a reminder of who he had with him to keep safe.

“If you’ve ever trusted anything I’ve said,” he murmured, “I need you to go when I tell you. I’ll pull it away from here.”

“Phainon—”

“I’m not asking.”

He took a step back toward the entrance, adjusting his footing, but didn’t move further. His body was still half-blocking Mydei from the gap in the

wall when the sound hit.

A long scrape echoed across the surface behind them—metal bending slightly under pressure, the edge of something hard dragging across it, like someone was testing for weak points. Mydei's breath caught. He turned to the source, but there was no shadow passing under the door. No shuffle of movement. No sound of breathing.

Phainon's arm came up to hold him in place, not roughly, but without hesitation.

It hadn't spoken once. It hadn't called out or glitched or tried to trick them. It didn't need to.

Mydei stood still, his thoughts running too fast now to sort through. The way it moved. The timing. The silence. It had followed them without alerting a single sensor, tracked them through an unlisted garden path, and arrived here already knowing who it needed to reach.

That wasn't mimic behavior. It wasn't projecting from stored footage. This thing was learning. Every twitch of Phainon's hand, every breath out of place—it had been watching and refining itself in real time.

It didn't need to pretend to be Cyrene. It had found something more efficient than memory.

It had learned Phainon.

And that meant this wasn't just another echo.

This was the third node. The core. Alive and adapting.

Phainon started toward the exit, already crouched, ready to move.

Mydei's hand shot out and grabbed his wrist, tight.

Phainon halted instantly, but the way he turned back wasn't gentle. His face was tense, expression tight like he was counting to ten in his head.

“Mydei,” he said, not harsh, but unmistakably serious.

And that tone—that flat, quiet insistence—set something off in Mydei that had nothing to do with fear. He stared at him, disbelieving, heart still pounding from the sound outside.

“You’re seriously going to pull that stunt?” he said, low. “You think you’re doing me a favor by throwing yourself at it?”

Phainon’s eyes narrowed, his whole stance wound up tighter. “If we both stay, we die.”

“And you don’t?”

“I’m faster than you.”

“Bull—”

The wall groaned.

They both stopped.

It didn’t creak or splinter—it *groaned*, like something was prying against the frame from above. A beat later, metal screamed overhead as the roof was torn away in a single, effortless wrench. Wind slammed down into the space like a wave. Debris scattered. Dust and glass rained down. Neither of them moved.

They turned around at the same time.

She was standing on what used to be the ceiling, limbs too long, joints bending just enough in the wrong directions to make it impossible to ignore. Her face still looked like Cyrene’s. But the smile that spread across it wasn’t human.

There was no twitch. Nothing indicating something robotic or glitching. Just a widening grin that opened further than it should have, inky black sliding into the corners of her eyes.

Neither of them spoke.

They just ran.

Phainon shoved the loose door off its hinges and pulled Mydei through it. Mydei didn’t let go of his wrist. They moved fast, cutting across the overgrown garden paths, weaving between hedges and statues and rusted benches half-swallowed by moss. The thing didn’t crash after them. It didn’t roar or shriek.

But they knew it was coming.

And for the first time, Mydei didn’t care how much noise they made. There was no point in hiding anymore.

They didn’t look back.

Phainon was fast, but Mydei was faster. No hesitation, no wasted movement—he tore across the broken paths, weaving between hedges and shattered glass domes, dodging collapsed trellises and blown-out fountains like he’d trained for this exact garden layout. Phainon kept pace behind him, close, but Mydei could hear the ragged edge in his breathing and didn’t waste time pretending otherwise.

“She’s gaining,” Phainon muttered, breathless.

Mydei didn’t answer. He already knew.

They cleared a stone railing and dropped into a lower courtyard, feet hitting the ground hard enough to rattle bone. Mydei didn’t slow—he grabbed Phainon’s wrist and pulled, dragging them toward the service tunnels. It wasn’t perfect, but it was enclosed, and the exit looped back toward the edge of the district. Isolated enough to cut through without risking civilians.

A sound slammed down behind them—dirt and stone crunching in rapid succession.

“She’s not running,” Phainon managed between breaths. “She’s skipping.”

Mydei didn’t ask what that meant. He could feel it. The way the mimic closed distance was wrong. No footsteps. No rhythm. One moment far, the next nearly brushing their backs.

He kept his grip locked, hauling Phainon behind him through the shattered archway. Branches caught on their clothes, shattered glass bit through fabric, but they didn’t stop.

He finally spoke, short and direct. “Service corridor. North vent shaft. If we can reach it—”

“It’s sealed.”

“Only from the outside.”

He turned a corner, yanked open the grate hidden behind an overgrown statue, and shoved Phainon through first. The mimic didn’t scream or claw at them—nothing so dramatic. But Mydei felt it the second he climbed in after him. It was right behind them. Too close.

He slammed the grate shut. Metal warped in his hands.

And still—no sound.

Mydei pulled himself up beside Phainon in the dark, both of them breathless, scraped, bleeding in places they hadn’t noticed yet. The vent was tight, barely enough room to crawl, but for now it was cover.

Phainon leaned his head back against the wall, eyes shut.

“Still think you’re faster than me?” Mydei muttered.

Phainon didn’t smile.

“We’re not done yet.”

The vent was silent for a few minutes. Just the sound of their breathing as it evened out, slower now but still heavy. The worst part was that Mydei couldn’t hear her anymore. Not even scraping.

Phainon shifted beside him. His knuckles were still pale from how hard he'd gripped the vent walls earlier.

"So," he said, voice steadier than it had any right to be. "What's the plan?"

Mydei hesitated, only briefly. "There's a maintenance hatch a few meters ahead. If we time it right, I can hotwire the exterior latch before it resets. That should get us out into the train depot. From there, we cut across to the west block. That side's been cleared since the gas line breach. She won't follow where there's no one to watch."

Phainon didn't argue. Not with that. But then he turned, eyes sharp, his tone more clipped now.

"If something goes wrong," he repeated, "you run."

Mydei exhaled through his nose, already shaking his head.

"I'm serious," Phainon went on. "She's after me. I don't know how, but she is. And if you try to get in between that, it's going to end badly."

Mydei bit down on the reply, the first one that came to him. Something sarcastic, probably. Something deflective.

Instead, what came out was quieter. "You don't know that."

"I do."

"I'm not leaving you behind."

"You might have to."

"I won't."

The tension stretched, stubborn and familiar. They stared at each other for a beat too long before Phainon sighed, frustration clear, but not angry.

"You're not taking this seriously," he said, voice lowering.

“I’m taking it seriously,” Mydei replied, the edge returning now. “I’m just not planning for you to die.”

Phainon stared for a second longer, then finally looked away, jaw tight. But something cracked between them.

There, in that dim, metal corridor, pressed between steel panels and the distant sound of wind scraping the ruins above, they stopped posturing. Just for a moment.

Phainon ran a hand through his hair, quiet now. “I didn’t mean to drag you into this.”

“You didn’t,” Mydei said. “I walked into it.”

A small pause.

Phainon nodded. “Still…I’m glad you’re here.”

And something about the way he said it—reluctantly honest. It landed heavier than anything else tonight.

They leaned in slightly at the same time, heads resting against the narrow steel wall, foreheads brushing just faintly. It wasn’t a kiss. Just stillness. Breathing the same air again, even if it tasted like dust and iron.

But then—something decided to fuck it up.

A faint change in pressure. A pop in the vent seal behind them.

Mydei tensed instantly. The panel at the rear end of the shaft creaked—no tearing, no booming entrance, just a subtle flex of metal that hadn’t been loose a moment ago.

His eyes widened. “How—”

Then it hit him. Not the mimic. The realization.

The vents. They were insulated, but not completely sealed as he thought. If that thing could trace neurological imprint, if it could adapt based on who it followed—

It didn’t need sound. Or scent. Or light.

It just needed proximity.

The panel behind them caved inward.

Phainon moved first, throwing his arm back to shield Mydei without thinking—but the thing didn’t lunge or strike.

It looked at them.

Still Cyrene. Still pink hair, still soft face. But something in the stance was wrong. She leaned forward on her elbows like someone listening to a lullaby only she could hear. Then she smiled. Slowly. That same smile as before.

And then—

Phainon froze again.

Not flinched or tensed. Froze.

His mouth parted like he meant to say something, but nothing came. His shoulders slumped as his eyes went glassy—not unconscious, but vacant. Like something reached in and turned the volume off.

“Phainon?” Mydei moved toward him instinctively, shaking his shoulder. “Phainon, look at me—hey, what the hell—?”

No response.

He remembered Cipher’s words.

First sighting. Then conversation. Then blackout.

But this wasn’t fainting. Phainon wasn’t drooping, wasn’t swaying. He was sitting upright, breathing steady, eyes open and tracking—but empty.

Like a puppet with no strings left.

Mydei didn’t move. Not yet.

The mimic didn’t either.

For a moment, no one moved. Three bodies, one breathing in a conventional sense.

The mimic stared down at Phainon like it was trying to figure out how to lift him without breaking something. Its fingers hovered above his collarbone, gentle in the way that made Mydei’s stomach twist.

He stepped between them.

It didn’t stop him. Just tilted its head, slow. Studying. Then it moved. Quick—too quick—and drove a hand clean through Mydei’s chest.

Straight through.

There was a beat of silence as it waited.

Mydei didn’t flinch. Didn’t fall.

He looked down at the blackened, clawed arm inside him and then back up. A flat breath pushed out of him—not pain. Closer to annoyance.

The mimic pulled back sharply. Like it had physically been burned.

It stepped away, a few inches first, then more. The lines of its face began to shift. Not morphing exactly, but more so as if it was trying to remember how to be human again and failing. It opened its mouth and no normal words came out—just a sound, somewhere between a hiss and the creak of something too old being forced to move.

Mydei took a step forward, not out of aggression, but curiosity.

It saw him now. Not just as an obstacle. As a problem.

He nearly smiled.

“You thought you were the only freak in the room,” he said, voice quiet, tone dry. “Shame.”

It hissed again, louder this time. The soft face melted back, jaw stretching wider than it should’ve, joints ticking out of place with quiet, wet pops. Its limbs grew longer. Sharper. Wrong.

Perfect.

Mydei’s fingers flexed once. Then, without taking his eyes off it, he shifted slightly and dragged the back of his foot across the floor—catching some debris and tugging it sideways.

The mimic twitched.

There it was.

He’d noticed it a second ago. A repeating detail in its reconstruction. Something off in the way the illusion maintained itself in physical spaces—geometry that didn’t quite update in real time. Almost as if its form couldn’t bend to environmental damage without resetting.

So he made it worse.

He stepped hard on the edge of the bent space and dragged a cracked stone paver back, hard enough that it scraped the mimic’s warped footprint.

It snapped.

The creature let out a jagged, scraping scream, then lunged—but Mydei was already moving, drawing it out with a few fast, brutal steps. Not away from Phainon—around. He was guiding it away, flanking.

It followed him.

Good.

Because now it was mad. Now it wasn’t thinking.

And now, it was *his*.

The vent shaft opened with a metallic clatter as Mydei kicked through the last grate, dropping hard onto the roof below. His boots hit slick metal, knees bending low to absorb the fall, and then he was already moving—down the slope, across a rusted maintenance ladder, and vaulting the low barrier that marked the edge of the garden’s upper walk.

The mimic was right behind him.

Mydei twisted as he ran, dragging a blade he kept in his jacket and flinging it back. The thing caught it midair like it weighed nothing, fingers curling tight before crushing it to dust.

Alright. No more distractions.

He pivoted hard at the end of the path, using a cracked trellis beam to slingshot himself left. He needed open space. Visibility. Somewhere it could be locked down.

And then—he saw it.

An amphitheater clearing tucked between the artificial riverbanks and ivy-swept stonework. Perfect line of sight, no exits, and most importantly: empty.

Mydei ran faster.

The mimic shrieked behind him—glitched sound torn through corrupted lungs—and the air warped around his shoulders as it closed in. Mydei hit the center of the clearing and turned fast, ready to—

A blur shot past overhead.

Then a sharp sound like laughter and glass.

“Really?” a voice called. “You couldn’t wait twenty more minutes?”

There she was.

Landing in a spin of black-and-purple silk, her boots cracking the tiles with impact, Cipher—no, Kitty Phantom Thief—flashed into view with the theatricality of someone born to make a goddamn entrance.

Her mask caught the light in a gleam of pale violet as she leveled her baton, modified with enough illegal tech to qualify as a war crime, directly at the mimic’s throat.

“Told you I’d bring backup,” she said, voice light.

And backup she brought.

Figures surged in from every side—Heir agents, vigilante allies, a full government tactical unit dressed in containment armor. Spotlights flared from every angle, beams locking onto the mimic as kinetic barriers shimmered to life.

The mimic screamed again. It lashed out, limbs warping in a final attempt to phase out—but the grid was already snapping into place. Traps deployed, energy fields compressed, and Cipher’s baton lit up in her hand with an almost melodic hum before she threw it like a spear.

It hit dead center, and the mimic dropped.

All at once, the air stopped vibrating.

Mydei didn’t even realize how hard he’d been bracing until his knees gave slightly. He sank down on the rough stone, arms resting on them, and finally—finally—let himself breathe.

Cipher padded over, nudging him lightly with the toe of her boot. “Told you we had a lead.”

He looked up, chest still rising fast, and gave her a breathless, half-exhausted glare.

She winked. “Next time, maybe check your texts.”

Behind them, the mimic was already being sealed away—its body flickering, glitching out as containment protocols locked down the last node.

Three anchors. Neutralized.

One goddamn nightmare less.

Mydei’s spine pressed to cool stone, lungs finally working like they were meant to. The chaos was still echoing—shouts from the agents corralling the last of the energy, Cipher rattling off updates to a nearby tech, some poor intern puking behind a planter—but for one small, blessed second, it was over.

He’d survived worse. Fought worse. But this? This had been a slow kind of terror. The kind that followed you around with a fake face and dead eyes.

He exhaled.

And then it hit him.

Phainon.

Still in there. Still unconscious. Alone.

Mydei shot to his feet so fast his knees cracked, chest already tight with panic.

“Shit—”

Cipher turned just as he started to move, hand snapping up to catch his arm. “Relax.”

“I can’t,” he snapped. “He’s still in there, Cipher—he’s still—”

“I know. I know,” she said, gentler this time, gripping his sleeve until he stilled. “Medical already got to him. They’re running checks now.”

He tried to pull away anyway, but she didn’t let go.

“I mean it. The moment that thing dropped, we sent a crew in. And here’s the good news—real news, not the vague ‘we’ll monitor the situation’ bullshit. Now that the anchors are broken, the trances should start to fade. They’ll wake up, eventually.”

He blinked hard, chest still rising too fast, but the pressure eased just slightly.

“And if not,” Cipher added, “we’ve got a few ideas. People smarter than me already running simulations. He’s gonna be okay.”

For the first time all night, the tension in Mydei’s jaw loosened. He didn’t smile. Couldn’t. But he nodded, once, and Cipher let go.

He turned to leave. He’d had enough. He just needed to see Phainon—just lay eyes on him, maybe touch his hand or something equally embarrassing—and then maybe collapse in peace.

But before he got two steps, Cipher called after him.

“Oh, and—Princess Homebody’s back.”

He stopped. “Castorice?”

Cipher grinned, already digging something out of the side pocket of her utility belt. “You know how she is. Went off the grid for a bit, came back with receipts.”

He turned halfway, cautious curiosity winning over exhaustion. “What’d she find?”

Cipher stepped closer. “She found a lead.”

“To what?”

Cipher’s smile was the kind that meant trouble. “Who’s behind all this.”

Mydei stared at her.

She raised an eyebrow, voice calm as a blade. “Tell me, Mydei. You ever heard of the Flame Reaver?”

Chapter End Notes

> As per usual last part got pretty rushed cause word count was going over what I expected/wanted but hey, hope what I was trying to convey went through😭 Stayed up the whole night for this one, hope you enjoyed

Chapter 9: Phainon’s Horrible No Good Very Bleedy Day

Chapter Summary

> Phainon gets his ass beat, barely escapes, hides under a blanket to avoid his terrifyingly hot and pissed boyfriend, lies terribly, cleans like a gremlin on a timer, accidentally falls asleep in said boyfriend’s sweater, and somehow survives the night through the power of stubborn affection and sheer dumb luck.

Chapter Notes

> Sorry abt the wait, my search history is between me, the government, and God
>
> (Man I’m going to sleep it’s like 2AM for me rn, point any mistakes my sleep deprived ass made pooky bears😭)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon had been awake for a few hours now.

Long enough to memorize the water stains on the ceiling, count the number of soft blinks from the monitor clipped to his finger, and go over—at least six times—what he should have said two days ago.

Also long enough to know that Mydei hadn’t left since he’d come to. The chair by his bed had a permanent crease now, and his posture screamed stubborn concern disguised as casual slouching.

“…I’m fine,” Phainon said, not for the first time.

“You were unconscious for nearly forty-eight hours,” Mydei replied, flat.

“I was *resting*.”

Mydei didn’t laugh, but the corner of his mouth twitched. “You always pass out after an argument, or was that just for effect?”

Phainon lifted an eyebrow. “You’re the one who decided yelling was more productive than running.”

“You’re the one who looked at me to run like I’m disposable.”

They stared at each other for a long, quiet second.

“…Okay, fair,” Phainon admitted. “That was a bad call.”

“You think?”

“I thought I was protecting you.”

“I thought *I* was protecting you.”

Another beat passed. Phainon shifted slightly against the pillow and gave a soft sigh. “So what, we’re just gonna take turns playing martyr until one of us flatlines?”

Mydei sat back in the chair, folding his arms loosely. “No. I think we need to actually trust each other. Even when we’re scared.”

Phainon gave him a sideways glance. “Even when you’re being an overbearing, reckless, self-righteous—”

“Yes. Even then.” Mydei smiled slightly, which ruined the attempted sarcasm beautifully. “And even when you’re being a rude, cryptic, self-sacrificing bastard.”

“Oh good. As long as it’s mutual.”

A silence settled again, more comfortable this time. The tension had bled out of the room, replaced by something gentler.

“I’m sorry,” Phainon said. The words felt weird in his mouth but not wrong.

“So am I,” Mydei replied. “You scared me.”

“Yeah,” Phainon murmured. “You too.”

Mydei stood, brushing imaginary dust from his shirt. “I need to go check in on a few things. But I’ll be back tonight.”

“You don’t have to—”

“I want to.”

Phainon blinked at him, unsure how to respond to that level of honesty before caffeine.

Mydei leaned in just enough to cross a line—one he rarely stepped over. He kissed Phainon on the cheek, light and confident, then headed for the door without waiting for a reaction.

“Rest up, professor,” he said casually. “If you flirt with anyone else while I’m gone, I’m breaking your legs. Gently.”

The door shut behind him with a soft click.

Phainon lay there, stunned into silence, one hand still half-raised like he might catch the moment before it faded.

“…Great,” he muttered, “and now I can’t even pretend to brood properly.”

Phainon sighed and let his hand fall to his chest, the corners of his mouth twitching in residual disbelief. He stared at the ceiling like it might offer an escape hatch or maybe just a less complicated form of consciousness.

But then his eyes shifted—slightly, subtly—and the whole mood flipped.

The warmth drained from his expression. That soft, half-lidded haze he’d allowed himself to bask in for the past few hours evaporated, replaced by something sharper, more familiar. Like slipping back into armor. His gaze cooled, jaw setting as the weight of reality crept in.

It wasn’t just the hospital room getting to him. Boring as hell, sure, but not unbearable.

No, the problem was the message.

He rolled onto his side with a grunt, reaching for the sleek, nondescript device stashed beneath his pillow. One of Anaxa’s custom rigs—encrypted six ways from hell and ugly as sin. The screen flickered to life with a soft pulse.

The message had come in a few minutes ago, cloaked in a cipher so sloppy it had to be one Anaxa came up with while drunk on expired energy shots and loathing.

> *rEsuRGENCE:n02//arise//shdwfrm//LOC VAR///BRINGFIRE, dumbass.*

He parsed it in seconds, chest tightening.

Translation: “Second Node is reviving. Bring your shit.”

Of course it was.

Phainon flopped onto his back with a groan, dragging a hand down his face. The device sat beside him on the pillow, its faint glow still pulsing like some smug little heartbeat.

Of course it fucking was.

Because nothing in his life could stay quiet for more than five minutes without detonating.

He exhaled slow, eyes fixed on the ceiling—though he wasn’t really seeing it anymore.

This all started three weeks ago.

Standard infiltration op. Basic data siphon job.

He’d gone in as the Flame Reaver, chasing a spike in Council data traffic. Not unusual on its own—the Council was always moving shady shit behind polished, official fronts. On paper, they were the nation’s clean-cut, elite regulatory body. A high-command task force with full government backing, responsible for overseeing vigilante activity, suppressing high-threat crime, and keeping the general population blissfully ignorant of how close to collapse everything really teetered.

Surface role: The good guys.

Reality: A control faction with a vendetta.

Phainon had learned not to buy the bullshit a long time ago.

Sure, they’d slapped on a pro-vigilante mask after the Black Tide fallout, but underneath, they’d always hated them. Especially the powerful ones. The heirs. The off-leash anomalies you couldn’t bribe, leash, or quietly erase. The Council’s real game was slow reclamation: replacing natural vigilante networks with clean, Council-trained agents. Dissecting every last scrap of Chrysos tech under the excuse of “containment” and “public safety.”

Phainon didn’t give a damn about their vendettas. Not usually.

He cared about keeping certain people alive. And, when the opportunity struck, making someone’s life a tactical nightmare.

So when that unusual data spike cropped up in a restricted cluster, flagged under one of the Council’s more obscure black vault tags, he figured it was worth a look.

Expected: A file dump. A corrupt resource ring. Another dirty ledger to pass off to Anaxa for his increasingly unhinged, spite-fueled spreadsheets.

What he found: A mess.

Fragments of documents. Chopped-up sentences. Acronyms stacked on acronyms, tangled with references to nodes, emotional patterning, memory

anchors, and something about cognitive resonance frequencies. Vague as hell—but it made the hair on the back of his neck rise.

He hadn't thought much of it at first. Government weirdness was basically tradition at this point.

But Anaxa took one look at the pulled data and got that manic gleam in his eye. The one that meant *this is your problem now too.*

Buried in the jargon was a half-erased set of coordinates.

After a good thirty minutes of arguing—and a healthy, mutually acknowledged *we probably shouldn't, but we're definitely going to*—they decided to check it out. No details. No name on the place. Just a dead location marker deep underground, tucked into a long-forgotten corner of the city's old sector.

Phainon still remembered the way Anaxa sounded in his ear when they reached it.

"This doesn't feel like a vault," Anaxa had muttered, tension crackling sharp through the comm.

"Nope," Phainon had agreed.

"Feels like a mistake."

They went in anyway. Because they always did.

They hadn't known what they were expecting.

But it sure as hell wasn't that.

The moment they crossed the threshold, both of them picked it up—a weird, low-frequency hum. Not audible, not exactly, but there in the bones. Like the static prickle you felt before a lightning strike. Whatever they thought was hiding down here, it wasn't just an abandoned vault.

And then Phainon saw the tag.

Not on the walls. Not on the servers. But on the old sublevel's core housing unit itself—an old, half-scraped-off Chrysos mark.

His blood ran cold.

Even Anaxa went quiet. And that never happened.

It should've been impossible. The Council wasn't supposed to have Chrysos tech. Nobody was. Not outside of heir control, and especially not something like this. Even if you could get your hands on it—which Anaxa, genius that he was, couldn't—you couldn't open it. Couldn't bypass the security layers. There were at least ten, maybe twelve safeguards hardwired into anything Chrysos-borne. Half of them weren't even mechanical.

The fact that it was here, under a Council site, felt…wrong. In the marrow-deep way only certain things did.

Phainon shoved the shock down fast. Focused on what he *could* do.

He scoured the terminal banks and found a cluster of heavily encrypted files—data clusters sealed behind some of the ugliest firewalls he'd ever seen. He grabbed what he could, pushed it to an external drive for Anaxa to dissect later. No time for grace.

And even half-corrupted, even through the encryption, it was enough to paint a shape.

The files were fragmented, incomplete. But they spoke in broken lines of a node system, of emotive mapping, of grief and memory as quantifiable metrics. Some half-formed theory about tracing trauma echoes in neural patterns—using residual emotional signatures to flag individuals who'd caused mass suffering.

At first glance, it looked like a forensic tool.

Cruel but justifiable. The kind of thing you could pass off as a moral gray area if you worded it right in a press briefing.

But there was something worse buried in there too. A recurring designation.

A new Council unit he’d never heard of: **Containment Integrity Unit. CIU.**

Anaxa had immediately zeroed in on that. Deduced that whatever the Council was really doing, *this* was probably the team pulling the strings behind the node extractions. The CIU wasn’t in any official records they’d seen before—which meant it was either newly formed, or very old and very buried.

Either way, the name fit too cleanly to be coincidence.

That had been the moment Phainon started to get the headache. A sharp, pressure-heavy throb behind his eyes. The deeper into the system they went, the worse it got.

And then everything blurred.

Phainon had pushed through it.

Even with the migraine clawing at the base of his skull, even when every instinct screamed leave it, he’d gritted his teeth and steadied his breathing. The Chrysos Archive sat there—silent, heavy, a relic that shouldn’t exist in Council hands. Locked behind what Anaxa immediately clocked as an Omega Lock encryption.

Which was bad.

Omega Locks weren’t just high-clearance. They were *impossible* clearance. Built for heir-level command chains and ancient vaults no one had the right to open. You didn’t just crack those. You didn’t even try.

But they did. Because of course they did.

Anaxa guided him through it—or tried to. Voice hushed in his ear, threading out code sequences and workaround theories at breakneck speed. The kind of rapid-fire thinking only possible when you knew you were already too deep to back out now.

For a moment, it almost felt like they had a handle on it.

And then the Archive lashed out.

Not physically.

It hit his mind.

A pressure—wrong and invasive. Like a hand gripping the back of his skull and shoving him forward into something vast and seething. His headache flared white-hot, nausea twisting up his throat. Vertigo hit so fast he staggered, grabbing onto the nearest wall for balance.

He barely heard Anaxa shouting over the comm, voice warping in and out.

Couldn’t breathe. Couldn’t think.

Something had reached back.

He didn’t remember leaving. Just remembered that single survival instinct roaring to the surface—*out out out*—and then he was on the surface again, drenched in sweat, heart hammering like it wanted out of his chest.

Later, once the worst of it had dulled, Anaxa called it a Neural Burn Protocol. A Chrysos-grade defense mechanism designed to trigger psychological overload in any unauthorized mental signature that tried to tamper with a live Archive. Phainon had bought into it too. Made sense. It was old tech. Dangerous as hell. Half of it probably sentient by now.

At least—that’s what he told himself.

Because it was easier than considering the other option.

That it hadn’t been the Archive alone.

The data Anaxa managed to decrypt after the fact suggested something worse.

The final node system—the third one—was incomplete. It required an anchor. Not just any tether, but an emotional constant. A grief that could stabilize the projection, give the fractured system cohesion.

Anaxa called it the N2 Catalyst. Because of course he did. Couldn’t just say *“this is going to get us both killed.”*

They’d backed off. Couldn’t afford another incident after the Archive. Not with whatever the hell had happened to Phainon’s head still lingering in the edges of his vision. But even with space and time, it gnawed at him. Anaxa had gone into full obsession mode, chasing threads, linking half-corrupted files, cross-referencing old Council logs. That wasn’t new. What was new was the conclusion they came to.

The system wasn’t for criminals.

It wasn’t a weapon to hunt the monsters outside.

It was meant for the ones inside.

The vigilantes.

Even knowing how bad things were between the Council and the off-leash operatives, they hadn’t expected this. A system built to fracture, map, and possibly erase vigilantes from within their own memories? It sounded like paranoia. It sounded like war.

And then six days later—she appeared.

On the train.

Cyrene.

Pink hair. Small polite smile. The faint skip in her step like she didn’t have a single care in the world.

He’d thought it was a trick of the light. A glitch in a too-long night.

And then the mimic incident happened. Two days vanished from his memory. He woke up here.

The rest…well.

Phainon let out a breath, sinking deeper into the pillow, the recounting hollowing him out more than he expected.

He knew now.

The Neural Burn wasn’t just a failsafe.

It was the trigger.

His memory—of her, of what she’d meant, what she *still* meant no matter how many times he’d tried to scrape it out of his bones—had been the anchor. The N2 Catalyst wasn’t a random occurrence. His grief gave the system form. His stubborn refusal to forget had been the spark to reanimate a dead project.

He couldn’t undo that. Didn’t even know how.

The room felt too quiet now.

He stared at the ceiling again, but this time the weight of it pressed down like stone.

“So that’s how it is,” he muttered to no one. “My head cracked open a vault and gave it a heartbeat.”

And all she did was smile.

Because that’s what friends do.

Even now, the memory of it—the skip in her step, the too-gentle way she’d held him after everything went to hell, like she was *grateful*—made his blood run cold.

Because nothing worked around her. Nothing made sense.

And for the first time in a long time, Phainon wasn’t sure if there was a way out of this one.

He dragged in a shuddering breath.

Right. No point lying here waiting for the void to finish gnawing at him.

Time to leave.

The moment he thought it, the crushing weight in his chest loosened just a fraction. Not because it was a good idea—it was a *terrible* one—but because it was something to do. Something to plan.

And plans meant jokes.

Dark, terrible, aggressively unfunny jokes. His preferred brand of denial.

“Okay,” he muttered, dragging himself upright with a wince. “Time for a good old-fashioned, deeply irresponsible prison break.”

If he played by the rules, Mydei wouldn’t let him so much as walk alone. He’d be handcuffed to this bed, force-fed kale smoothies, and by sunrise he’d be legally married to a heart monitor. And knowing this hospital’s obsession with procedure, probably a third-year med student named Chip.

No. He had to ghost out of here fast, before the staff noticed he wasn’t too concussed to walk.

He grabbed a scrap of paper from the bedside table—probably a patient consent form, but who cared—and scrawled a note in the messiest handwriting he could manage.

Dear students,
It’s me or your GPA.
Guess who’s more expendable
– P

Sincere. Poetic. Half-assed. Perfect.

Phainon rolled off the bed, made a face at the jolt through his side, and limped toward the window. Fire escape. Easy enough. He’d slipped out of tighter lockdowns before.

Of course, those times he wasn’t nursing a migraine the size of a small planet.

The first part was smooth. He slipped through the cracked window, eased onto the fire escape landing, and dropped down two levels without issue.

Then he twisted his ankle on a loose rung.

The sound he made was something between a snarl and a string of profoundly filthy swears in four different languages—one of which might’ve been extinct.

“Fucking chrysanthemum-ass spark plug—you absolute *whore* of a ladder —”

He gritted his teeth, limped it off, and kept moving.

Because if there was one thing he knew how to do, it was run.

The passage down to Anaxa’s underground bunker felt longer than it had any right to. An old maintenance shaft, crumbling concrete walls bleeding condensation, rust eating through every metal brace. The only light came from the flicker of his own half-dead wrist beacon, and even that was sputtering. His pulse pounded behind his eyes, a steady drumbeat of exhaustion and pain he didn’t have the time to process.

He reached the old service door, punched in the code—a string of numbers Anaxa insisted wasn’t significant but absolutely was—and it hissed open.

The air inside was cold, sharp, too sterile in a way that felt almost alien. Stark white walls, the hum of machines you couldn’t find on any legitimate registry, and lights that never quite seemed to settle on one steady color.

Phainon staggered in, bruised and smelling like hospital antiseptic and asphalt.

Anaxa didn’t even look up from the terminal he was working at.

“Took you long enough,” Anaxa muttered, fingers flying over keys, eyes fixed on cascading streams of incomprehensible data.

Phainon flipped him off without much heat. “Missed you too, asshole.”

That got a faint smirk from Anaxa. Brief, but there.

Phainon dragged himself further in, eyes locking on the containment tank at the room’s center—and the thing inside it. The recovered node fragment floated there, suspended in some viscous, iridescent fluid. It twitched, faintly. Like a heartbeat.

Like breathing.

His stomach lurched.

“That normal?” Phainon rasped, voice frayed.

Anaxa’s smirk flattened. He sighed, finally turning to face him. “Define normal.”

“It’s mimicking an early-stage neural cascade,” Anaxa muttered, eyes flicking back to the readings. “Technically it shouldn’t be possible without a host anchor.”

Phainon limped closer, squinting at the shifting patterns on the screen—some looping, fractal hell of symbols and pulse-lines that meant absolutely nothing to him, except for the parts labeled in angry red. Those probably weren’t good.

Anaxa sighed, like explaining advanced theoretical metaphysics to a half-conscious arsonist was the single greatest burden ever placed upon a man.

“Okay, short version for your concussed ass—the second node wasn’t a projection host like we thought. It was a convergence catalyst. It gathered resonance signatures from active anchors in proximity. Emotional charge, psychic bleed-off, unresolved trauma…you know. Your natural habitat. It creates the perfect storm, generates the conditions necessary for a projection

to evolve, rather than just mimic. An actual sentient construct built off accumulated resonance data."

Phainon stared at him.

Then, flatly: "So…a womb. Not a mirror."

Anaxa gave a grudging, almost pleased tilt of his head. "Exactly. And something's kicking inside."

He flicked through a series of projections, the screen casting his face in cold, alien light. Code spiked and bled like some malignant pulse across the interface.

"See this?" He pointed to a jagged cluster of readings. "It's reconstructing a pre-coded entity. Not random. Something embedded from the start. And guess what it's tethered to."

Phainon already knew. The weight settled in his gut like stone.

"Your grief gave it teeth," Anaxa muttered, tone caught between fascination and warning. "It's synced to you now."

Phainon's jaw flexed, the air in the lab feeling heavier.

Anaxa kept going, fingers dancing over keys. "The Council's not just monitoring anomalies. They're using anchors—people like you, high-resonance grief cases—to seed sentient constructs. Memory-based projections. Built to destabilize and spy. You can't fight a ghost that wears the face you miss."

Silence.

Anaxa's eyes flicked to another volatile cluster of readings. "And it's not sustainable. Entropy feedback from anchors like you causes decay loops. Every activation's another crack in the city's psychic field. Sooner or later, the whole system caves."

Phainon stared at the node fragment twitching in its tank.

“Well shit,” he muttered.

Phainon dragged a hand down his face. “So what’s the play here? ‘Cause I’m guessing the Council’s not just gonna politely shut this shit down.”

Anaxa gave a sharp grin. “Actually, this gives us an advantage. Their whole system relies on stable grief anchors. But unstable ones?” He gestured at Phainon. “Volatile. Unpredictable. Dangerous.”

Phainon sighed. “So I blow it up.”

“Not quite. You sync to it directly. Force a resonance spike, overload the cascade. If the node’s built to handle grief anchors, it’s not built to handle one going critical.”

Phainon eyed the flickering node fragment. “What’s the catch?”

Anaxa shrugged, too casual. “Could kill you. Or erase some inconvenient parts of your mind. Minor risks. It’ll especially be rough since the second node already housed thousands of minds for simulated trauma cycles. Which means you’re walking into a hell of leftover resonance patterns.”

Phainon grimaced. “Awesome. Love that for me.”

Anaxa offered a deadpan smile. “Probably fine. Or not. Scientific discovery either way.”

Phainon’s jaw tightened. “We destroy it. Now. Before it stabilizes.”

Anaxa didn’t look away from the terminal. “Wait.”

A pause. The tension in the room crackled like a live wire.

Anaxa finally turned. “Before that, this is our last shot to understand what the Council’s really building. If we torch every anomaly, we stay blind. You want to stop them? We need leverage. Data.”

Phainon’s stare was ice. “If this thing gets out, there won’t be anything left to leverage.”

Neither moved. The node pulsed faintly in its tank—like it was listening.

Anaxa exhaled. “One night.”

Phainon frowned.

“I run a full set of scans, under strict protocol. The second those readings spike—” he jabbed a finger toward the emergency override, “you pull the plug. No hesitation.”

A long beat.

“Fine,” Phainon muttered. “One night.”

They didn’t shake on it. Just turned back to their respective controls—both already regretting it.

As Anaxa adjusted a bank of monitors, he muttered, “You know, maybe if this city’s academic budget wasn’t run by cowards and bureaucrats, we wouldn’t have to jury-rig half this lab.”

Phainon leaned against the console, smirking. “Maybe if you stopped scaring grant committees by citing Lovecraft.”

Anaxa shot him a flat look. “Their fear is validation.”

Phainon snorted.

Anaxa turned back to the controls. “Anyway—if we’re doing this, your Flame Reaver gear’s in the back. Might as well suit up.”

Phainon pushed off the console. “Don’t have to tell me twice.”

The lab was oppressively silent, save for the hum of machines and the soft, rhythmic pulse of the node fragment suspended in its containment tank. Stark white light reflected off its surface—twitching, writhing, the movement almost…breathing.

Phainon stood near the far wall, fully geared now. Black Flame Reaver coat slung over his shoulders, gloves buckled tight. His eyes never left the node.

Anaxa tapped away at a series of terminals, muttering numbers under his breath. Graphs jittered. Resonance signatures fluctuated. The tension in the room thickened like wet cement.

Then came the hum.

Soft, distant—a low, tonal vibration radiating from the containment unit. The pitch climbed, twisted, shaped itself.

A lullaby.

Phainon stiffened. His stomach turned cold.

He knew that melody.

It was a song his mother used to hum when he was little, before everything went to hell. No one else knew it. He hadn't spoken about it in years.

Anaxa glanced up. "Alright…that's new."

Phainon's voice was a rough scrape. "Can it do that?"

Anaxa was already scanning readings. "Technically? No. It shouldn't have access to personal memory locks without a direct anchor sync. And I haven't connected anything to its—" He squinted. "Wait. Resonance bleed… it's mimicking your neural cascade. That's why."

"Translation?"

"It's copying you, Phainon. Pulling from your unconscious residuals. Early-stage neural echo. It shouldn't be this fast—we've only been running this for twenty minutes."

Phainon's fingers twitched near the emergency override. "How bad?"

Anaxa gave a humorless grin. “Depends. If the cascade stabilizes, it’ll build a partial construct. Sentient enough to act autonomously. Drawn entirely from your worst memories, obviously, because gods forbid it be anything else. And if it destabilizes—”

“What?”

“Local entropy spike. Psychic infrastructure fracture radius…probably four blocks. Maybe five.”

Phainon grit his teeth. “And you wanted to study this.”

“I am studying it. You’re welcome.” Anaxa’s tone stayed maddeningly casual, but his hands moved faster, tweaking calibrations. “Good news is—it’s incomplete. See here?” He gestured to the readings. “The resonance harmonics are peaking early. It’s bleeding too much energy to maintain form. This confirms the Council’s prototype isn’t stable yet.”

“Meaning we still have a shot.”

“Meaning if we collapse this now, the feedback might trigger a sympathetic shutdown in any linked nodes citywide. But…”

“But?”

“I need about another hour of data to map the cascade fully. Then we overload it.”

Phainon’s jaw flexed. “You’ve got thirty minutes.”

A grim pause.

Anaxa smirked. “Fifteen.”

Anaxa’s fingers flew over the interface, rerouting feedback loops and adjusting containment field parameters. The node’s glow flickered, shadows crawling along the walls in time with the pulse.

Phainon’s voice cut through the static. “How many more grief anchors do you think there are?”

Anaxa didn’t look up. “Dunno. Could be a dozen. Could be a hundred.”

Phainon scowled. “Comforting.”

“Doesn’t matter.” Anaxa keyed a new sequence. “This one’s the prototype. It’s the convergence point. Without it, they physically can’t finish the chain. No second anchor, no tether stabilization, no third node to start spawning mimics.”

“And the first one?”

“Seized. Chrysos Heir’s people raided the archive days ago—grabbed the core node and half the Council’s indexed resonance logs.” Anaxa’s mouth twisted into something almost resembling a grin. “Wonder how they’re feeling right about now.”

Phainon’s brow furrowed. The glow from the node painted uneasy shadows over his face. “Should we…tip them off? About this?”

The thought made his stomach turn. He didn’t owe the Chrysos Heirs a thing—but neither of them would survive another one of these anomalies blowing a crater in the city’s mindscape.

Anaxa snorted. “They already suspect the Council. You’d have to be a comatose turnip not to, considering where the archive was housed. And whatever they do with that node isn’t our problem.”

“You sure about that?”

“Positive.” Anaxa glanced over his shoulder, eyes glinting sharp in the alien light. “We survive this, we walk. Let them play power games with the Council. I’m not dying for a monarchist middle manager with a personal vendetta.”

Phainon grunted. “Fair.”

Another sharp pulse from the node. The lullaby twisted—faltering, warping into static.

Anaxa's gaze snapped back to the readings. "Hold onto your teeth, sweetheart. Resonance spike incoming."

The node's glow had settled into a steady, sickly pulse—less like a heartbeat, more like something thinking.

Anaxa rattled off data without pause. "Resonance ratio stabilizing at point-four-nine. Lattice integrity's holding. Neural cascade rate exceeding baseline but—acceptable parameters. If this trend holds, I can isolate the imprint architecture and maybe even—"

Phainon leaned forward against the side of a storage crate, half-listening, the words folding into static in his ears. His eyes stayed locked on the tank. Something about the cadence in the hum…off-key, like a lullaby sung underwater.

And then—

His stomach dropped. Instinct howled.

He moved without thinking.

One arm shot out, grabbing a fistful of Anaxa's coat, and yanked them bothdown behind a support console just as a shrill, piercing scream tore through the room. The air vibrated like a struck bell, and a surge of unseen force ripped through the lab—tables overturned, glass shattered, stray equipment lifted and flung against walls.

The node's containment tank bulged inward like it was breathing—and bleeding light.

Phainon blinked. "Uh. I think this's a real good time to overload the damn thing."

Anaxa hissed, glaring, half-crushed beneath him. "No! I'm not done yet—"

Another high-frequency shriek cracked the air, followed by a violent *crash*. A cabinet smashed against the far wall, scattering tools like metal confetti. Phainon didn't wait—he grabbed Anaxa by the collar again and hauled him bodily into cover behind a toppled table as a sparking coil snapped loose and whipped across the room.

Anaxa coughed, scowling. "…Fine."

Phainon's hand lit with heat, ember-crackles flickering between his fingers as he stared toward the node, jaw clenched. "Told you this thing had claws."

Anaxa wiped blood from his cheek with the back of his hand, voice dry. "In my defense, it was purring ten seconds ago."

The node screamed again.

"Phainon—!" Anaxa's voice cut sharp through the chaos as a row of monitors blew out in a shower of sparks. "On your feet, now! I'm rerouting the containment uplink but I need a direct resonance sync to destabilize its lattice."

Phainon ducked a flying shard of something metallic and charred. "Speak Common, Blasphemer!"

Anaxa's hands flew over the cracked terminal, lines of code flickering in frantic sequence. "You—touch the tank. Feed it everything. Rage, grief, guilt, all of it. It's tuned to your resonance signature now, so you'll override the cascade pattern long enough for me to spike the core. It'll collapse on itself if we time it right."

Phainon's stomach turned. "And if we don't?"

"Best case—you forget a week. Worst case—*Swiss cheese cortex*. Stop whining and light up, Reaver."

The node wailed again, light warping the air like heat off asphalt. Phainon's hands were already kindling, veins glowing molten beneath his skin as he shoved aside debris and stalked toward the containment tank.

The thing inside looked like a tangle of half-formed faces, blurring between childlike and monstrous, a thousand eyes in no fixed place. And it *knew* him. He could feel it, latching on, threads hooking into old scars in his head.

He slammed his palm against the glass.

White heat bloomed from his hand, a soundless shockwave buckling the air. The node shrieked in reply, the lullaby-thread in its hum cracking into static.

“Good—good! Hold it there!” Anaxa barked from behind, rerouting energy paths through the node’s stabilizers. “It’s syncing—point-seven-four resonance match. That’s deep tethering, Reaver! I’m initiating the spike charge—when I say now, you pour everything into it. You’ll feel it trying to pull back, override the reflex.”

Phainon gritted his teeth as something cold and wet slithered through his mind, dredging memories unbidden—hands in his hair, blood in snow, that stupid lullaby. His breath hitched, and fire flared along his arm.

“Anaxa—this is *bad*.”

“I know! Do it, now!”

A red pulse rippled through the node as Anaxa triggered the feedback loop. The tank shuddered violently. Alarms shriek. Phainon suppressed a scream and shoved harder, heat racing up his spine as the room blurred at the edges.

The faces in the node screamed back.

“Now—dump it all! *Now, Reaver!”*

Phainon let go—a brutal, raw surge of grief, rage, bone-deep fury. The node’s light inverted, a hollow implosion of sound and pressure snapping inward as if the whole world had inhaled at once.

Phainon’s head jerked back—images flickering like burning film—before everything snapped white.

Then silence.

A second later, the tank was empty. Blackened glass. A faint smell of ozone and old blood.

Phainon staggered back, one hand to his temple. His head *hurt*.

Anaxa limped over, checking the readings. “Collapse confirmed. Containment stable. Neural imprint—” He eyed Phainon. “You still with me?”

Phainon managed a ragged smirk. “Who the hell are you again?”

Anaxa snorted. “That’s the spirit.”

Phainon groaned as his body hit the ground, slumping against a half-melted support beam. The air still stank of ozone and scorched metal, the wreckage flickering with half-dead sparks. His head felt like it’d been cracked open and packed full of burning sand. Every nerve throbbed.

Dragging a hand down his face, he winced. “I’m not even gonna pretend I’m conscious for this,” he muttered, letting his head thunk back against the beam. His eyes fluttered shut, exhaustion settling like a heavy coat.

Across the room, Anaxa limped through the debris of his demolished lab, muttering sharp, ancient curses under his breath. The containment rig was a wrecked husk. Fractured terminals spat out dying lines of code. A notebook lay half-burned in a puddle of something that definitely wasn’t water.

“Two prototype regulators. Gone. Secondary dampeners, slag. That was a one-of-a-kind core stabilizer, you spark-huffing piece of garbage,” Anaxa grumbled at the charred remains, briefly mourning his equipment. He let out a long, ragged sigh. “What’s knowledge without a few sacrifices.”

Grabbing a half-functioning scanner, he waved it over the ruined node with grim focus.

Phainon cracked one eye open, watching from where he lay. “You done giving your lab a eulogy?”

Anaxa didn’t glance up. “You hush. Some of us value progress.”

Silence settled in—only the hiss of a coolant leak and the occasional groan of warped metal breaking the quiet. For a second, it almost felt like the worst was over.

Then a weak, half-melted sensor near the far wall let out a strained, flickering beep…beep…beep…

Phainon didn’t move. “What’s that?”

No answer.

His brow furrowed as he glanced over. Anaxa was frozen, scanner still in hand, staring at the display with a look Phainon didn’t like.

“…Anaxa?”

The man’s voice came low and flat, clipped sharp as a knife.

“They’re here.”

Something cold slid down Phainon’s spine. He didn’t have to ask who they were.

“What do you mean they’re—”

A distant, rising wail of sirens cut him off, growing louder by the second. The steady *thup-thup-thup* of helicopter rotors followed, making the dust vibrate in the air. A searchlight beam knifed through a crack in the ceiling, casting long, jagged shadows over the wreckage.

Phainon’s stomach dropped.

“Vigilant Integration Bureau,” he muttered, pulse quickening. The Bureau always came smiling—but wherever they showed up, vigilantes weren’t far behind. And neither of them were in shape for round two.

Anaxa snorted, bitter and resigned, shoving what little salvageable gear he could grab into a battered bag. “Guess we made the guest list.”

Phainon exhaled, forcing his aching limbs to move. “Do we run?”

Anaxa shouldered the bag. “You always run.”

Phainon’s pulse hammered as the sirens swelled outside, the faint roar of a helicopter cresting over the gutted lab. He forced himself upright, ignoring the burn in his limbs, and jerked his head toward Anaxa.

“Grab the core remains,” he ordered, voice sharp. “I don’t care if it’s slagged—I don’t want the VIB getting so much as a shard.”

Anaxa hesitated, casting a wary glance toward the ceiling as the searchlight beam knifed past again. His jaw clenched, but he didn’t argue. He snagged the scorched containment housing and what few half-functioning instruments he could carry, stuffing them into the battered bag.

“Don’t die,” Anaxa muttered under his breath, pulling a lever set into the wall. A concealed panel groaned open, revealing a narrow escape hatch lined with corroded rungs. Of course he’d built a secret exit. Of course.

Then he was gone, vanishing into the shadows below.

Phainon exhaled hard, rolling his shoulders. The old, familiar burn settled over his bones—the low, restless heat that came when the mask went on and the world stopped being complicated. He was the only one here geared up, and with Anaxa gone, someone had to hold the line.

He slid the Flame Reaver mask into place, letting the world narrow through the visor’s sharp filters.

Alright…think. The Bureau’s a pain, but manageable. Question is…who’s with them?

His gut twisted.

The Chrysos Heirs didn’t move openly. The actual *Heirs* even less so. But somehow, it felt like every time shit hit the fan, he ran into one. Or more.

He cycled through the roster in his head.

As long as it’s not Undertaker, I can handle it. Anyone else, fine. Just not—

A sharp whistle of air cut past his ear.

His instincts flared white-hot. He jerked his head aside just in time to feel a burning sting trace his cheek.

The world slowed.

Phainon’s hand rose to his face, fingertips brushing blood.

What the hell—

Then he saw it.

A shimmer. A hairline glint in the low, flickering light. Not one. Dozens. No—*hundreds*. Thin, gossamer threads crisscrossing the space, stretching from beam to rubble to rig, gleaming faintly gold.

His stomach turned to ice.

No. Not her. Anyone but her.

His throat tightened as the threads caught the flicker of a dying spark—like a spiderweb spun of light, closing in.

Goldweaver.

His heart dropped clean into his gut.

Worse than Undertaker. Worse than anyone.

He pivoted slow, careful not to snag a line. The threads shimmered, so fine they barely seemed real, but he knew better. He’d seen what they could do.

To people. To structures. To *everything*.

And if she was here…he didn’t have long.

A single string quivered, a predator’s silent herald.

Phainon’s mouth went dry.

“…Fuck.”

Phainon didn’t think.

He *moved*.

The second his brain registered those threads, those sickly golden strands slicing through the air like a noose closing in, his body was already sprinting. A jolt of primal instinct ripped through him, survival clawing to the surface like an animal.

Get out. Now.

His boots pounded against the scorched floor, vaulting over a half-collapsed support beam. He ducked a low-hanging wire, shoulder-rolled through the smoke curling off a slagged console, his pulse hammering so hard it hurt.

The strings vibrated.

A new glint in his periphery—another thread dropping down like a noose. He twisted mid-sprint, just missing it by a hair’s breadth. His side grazed a jagged steel panel, tearing fabric and skin, but he didn’t stop.

No. No no no—of all people—

His mind reeled as he weaved through the wreckage like a man possessed. He wasn’t just fast—he was trained, refined chaos, moving with predatory precision through a warzone. This wasn’t a fight he could win, and every fiber of him knew it.

Goldweaver.

The goddamn *leader* of the Chrysos Heirs. The one you *didn't see*. The one who didn't bother with cleanup jobs or chase-downs. If a target warranted her personal involvement, it wasn't a retrieval mission.

It was an execution.

And if those threads got around him here—in this tight, suffocating labyrinth of debris and half-flooded tunnels—it was over. No fight. No clever trick. No last-second escape. Hell, he wouldn't even actually be killed.

Just gone.

Why the hell was she here? Why him?

Sure, if they'd figured out this was a node site, it made sense to send an Heir. Undertaker for example, no matter how much he wanted to avoid her. Even Godslayer, maybe.

But *Goldweaver*?

He'd covered his tracks. Been careful. The serious jobs—the real forbidden ops—were buried. He and Anaxa had burned records, rerouted traces, scrubbed networks.

So why the *fuck* was she here?

Another thread snapped down. He dove, sliding beneath it, feeling it singe the air inches from his skin. His muscles screamed, lungs burning as he vaulted up a twisted ladder rung, grabbed a ledge, and hurled himself up toward the half-collapsed roof.

The entrance was compromised—front sealed, Bureau forces closing in. Surface extraction was a joke.

Only one way out.

Phainon sprinted along a narrow beam, leaping for a broken ventilation shaft overhead. Caught the edge with one hand, swung up, scraped his

shoulder bloody on the jagged frame—but didn’t slow.

He could *feel* her now. The threads shivering in the dark. The air itself seemed to hum with pressure.

Every instinct screamed trap.

And still no answer *why*.

His teeth clenched.

I’m not dying like this.

Another line snapped toward him—he ducked, skidded along the wall, then launched himself through the shaft’s jagged opening, not caring where it led.

Didn’t matter.

Anywhere was better than *here*.

The crawlspace was a maze of cracked pipes and warped steel, half-collapsed from the earlier blast. His fingers grazed the walls as he moved, leaving smears of ash and blood. Something flickered at the edge of his vision—a shimmer, a brief distortion like the world caught between blinks.

Phainon didn’t hesitate. He grabbed it.

It wasn’t a *thing*, not exactly. More a ripple in the air, a flicker of broken light where the explosion had warped the structure’s energy lines. His fingers curled around the raw, seething pulse, and with a sharp, instinctive twist—like pulling thread through frayed cloth—he *dragged*. The shimmer snapped taut, forming a jagged line of fire that lashed out, severing the nearest thread just as it struck.

The air sang with tension. He ducked again, his pulse hammering against his ribs.

The narrow passage spilled him into a lower chamber where the VIB units were sweeping through—black-clad figures with sleek helmets, visor lights cutting through the gloom. No time for stealth. He hit the ground in a roll, grabbed a half-collapsed support strut still radiating heat from the earlier overload, and *pulled*.

It bent in his hands like softened wax. The metal flickered—its shape warping, splintering into jagged, ember-bright shards.

He flung it forward.

The makeshift projectile split in midair, searing through the first line of agents. It didn't kill. Just enough to scatter, blind, buy seconds.

Phainon moved like a specter in flame. He didn't think—every move was raw instinct, chasing the flickers, the warped gaps in reality where energy buckled under stress. Broken data readouts on the walls, still throwing corrupted symbols from the earlier surge—he brushed a hand along them, and the symbols *stirred*, twisting into unfamiliar, sharp-edged shapes.

A barrier of heatless, smoldering light flared up between him and another wave of agents.

His head throbbed. His vision blurred.

No time.

He forced himself onward, vaulting over debris, one boot kicking a half-slagged rifle away. The exit was ahead—the main lift shaft, scorched, cables swaying loose.

And then his body jolted.

A searing line across his shoulder.

He staggered, blood hitting the floor in a hot spray.

From the far end of the ruined hall — green eyes. Cold. Unblinking. Watching from the wreckage above like a blade waiting to fall.

Phainon’s heart clenched tight.

Not a soldier. Not a Bureau agent. *Her*.

A figure half-wreathed in shadow, threads of liquid gold curling lazily through the air around her, each one glinting like strands of sunlight on glass. The strings hung suspended, waiting for a single twitch of her fingers to snap them tight.

He bit down a curse. The room was rigged. He could see it now—how the threads anchored to every surface, coiled around debris and bodies alike, tracing a lattice of death. And there she stood, still and patient as a predator, watching *him*.

Blood dripped from his shoulder, trailing in hot lines down his side. The sting kept him focused.

He forced himself upright, teeth gritted, feigning a stumble. Let her see the wound. Let her think he was faltering. The gaze stayed locked. No command issued. No hand lifted. But he could feel the threads start to shiver.

No way out the front—too many agents, too many threads. And the longer he hesitated, the tighter the noose would draw.

His eyes flicked up.

An exposed conduit, a fractured support beam still slick with coolant mist. A single spot where the threads didn’t quite reach—the burst of the earlier explosion must’ve scorched them there.

It was enough.

He moved.

A sudden burst of speed, raw and reckless. Pain flared bright in his shoulder as he surged forward, ducking low and skimming along the edge of the wreckage. The threads snapped at empty air behind him. A line grazed his arm, hot as wire, but he didn’t slow.

The green eyes narrowed.

Another flick of the strings. They lurched toward him, filling the space he was running for.

Phainon’s hand lashed out, fingers grazing the wall, and something unseen shifted. The air itself seemed to bend, a sharp ripple like heat distortion catching the threads mid-flight. For a fraction of a second, the web faltered.

He dove through it.

Rolled under a collapsing beam, flames licking at his heels. Wrenched a broken length of piping from the floor as he passed—not as a weapon, but a tool. The conduit above was cracked open, exposed.

One breath. One chance.

Phainon swung the pipe, striking a burst junction. A surge of scorched energy burst from the line, sending a wave of volatile heat through the chamber. The threads recoiled. The VIB agents cursed and scattered for cover.

In the chaos, he moved.

Not vanishing—*slipping through the seams.* Through the space between one moment and the next, trailing flickers of dying flame and bent light. A phantom silhouette, a smear of motion.

By the time the threads lashed out again, the chamber was empty.

And the only thing left of him was blood on the floor and the scent of burned air.

He barely made it three blocks.

Phainon staggered down a side street, half-seeing, half-sensing his way through the maze of alleys. The world pitched sideways around him, a sick blur of neon reflections warping in puddles and grime-slick walls. Every

breath scraped his throat raw. Blood dripped from his nose, hot against his upper lip, and he wiped it away with the back of a trembling hand.

The aftereffects hit harder this time. They always did when he pushed it that far—light distortion bending the corners of his vision, nausea twisting his gut, static crawling under his skin. His blood felt thin, like something vital had burned away with it.

He shouldn’t have done it.

But it was that, or get caught. And he knew what happened to people like him when the Bureau took their time.

The alley dead-ended against a crumbling wall. Phainon let himself drop to his knees there, back to damp brick, pulse hammering behind his eyes.

His hand brushed something cold.

A small vial. Clear glass catching the weak, flickering light. Next to it—a crumpled scrap of encrypted microfilm, flickering faintly as his fingers ghosted over it. Anaxa. Of course.

He unfolded it. Sharp digital text blinked up at him.

> *Go home. Cameras off for 20 min. Don’t be seen. Use the dose if you’re bleeding out. Get rid of this when you’re done.*

Phainon huffed a breath that was halfway to a laugh, though it hurt like hell in his ribs. A smirk ghosted across his bloodied mouth.

“Sentimental bastard.”

He pocketed the vial, thumb hovering over the note’s erase glyph before tapping it. The message dissolved into harmless static, vanishing between blinks.

The worst of it was over. For now.

He dragged himself upright, wiping his face with a sleeve already streaked in red and ash. His stomach lurched. The world spun. But he stayed standing.

Time to go home.

And maybe—just maybe—not die this time.

The window stuck halfway. Typical. Phainon grit his teeth, wedged his shoulder against the frame, and shoved it open enough to squeeze through. Every movement hurt. His ribs screamed. His head spun. But the familiar scent of old wood, incense remnants, and city air slipping through the cracked glass was enough to make his shoulders sag.

Home.

Or what counted for it.

He stepped inside and let the window fall shut behind him. No lights. He didn't need them. Knew every inch of this cramped apartment in the dark. The loose floorboard near the kitchen. The half-dead plant by the windowsill. The slight dip in the mattress where he always collapsed after nights like this.

No sirens. No strings. No VIB squads.

For the first time in hours, the city's chaos felt distant. He could almost breathe.

Phainon slowly stripped off his upper body, wincing as the fabric peeled away from dried blood and half-healed burns. Dropped it in a heap on the floor. His fingers fumbled the vial from his pocket, the glass cool and clean against his palm. He stared at it for a moment.

Faint streetlight caught the liquid inside, casting a fractured glimmer on the wall.

Anaxa’s work.

“Son of a bitch,” he muttered under his breath, a weak huff of something close to a laugh pulling at him. Because only Anaxa would leave some prototype concoction in an alley like a care package and expect him to just roll with it.

He uncorked it and downed it in one go. It scorched like liquid fire—acrid, chemical, bitter. His stomach lurched, but almost immediately the worst of the nausea ebbed. The edges of his vision steadied. Pain dulled from white-hot to a persistent throb.

Better.

Not good. But better.

He dropped back onto his bed, the mattress sinking under his weight. For a second, he just lay there. Letting the quiet in. The weight of the night peeling off in layers, leaving nothing but raw exhaustion in its place. He stared at the ceiling, watching faint cracks crawl through the plaster like distant constellations.

He could almost pretend—

Footsteps.

Fast. Unmistakable.

Phainon froze. Every muscle tensed. His hand twitched toward the dagger handle at his belt before he remembered he’d ditched it.

Those steps were inside.

Inside the apartment.

Nobody else had a key. Nobody should be here.

Break-in. Or—

Shit.

He had a heartbeat—less—to move. Rolled sideways, yanking the blanket over himself just as the door to a room slammed open hard enough to make the hinges scream.

The air in the room went razor-thin.

Who the hell—

The room hadn’t even settled from the last slam before the next one hit—the bedroom door bursting open like it owed someone money.

“Mydei—”

“Where the hell were you?!”

The voice could’ve peeled paint. Phainon felt his soul leave his body, circle the ceiling fan once, and snap back in. It was the kind of fury that could shatter a boardroom in thirty seconds flat, vaporize someone’s will to live, and yet here it was—in his crappy apartment.

Under the blanket, Phainon curled tighter, willing his body to stop bleeding, stop looking guilty, stop existing. He coughed quietly into the sheets.

“M’teaching,” he mumbled, muffled by fabric and half a pillow. “Left a note.”

Wrong move.

Wrong move.

The silence was the worst part. Heavy. Nuclear. The quiet before every power station in a ten-mile radius went dark.

The blanket yanked halfway off his head.

“A note?” Mydei’s voice was so sharp it could’ve cut stone. “You left a note. You left the hospital without telling anyone, turned your comm off,

vanished for an entire damn day, and you think a note counts?”

Phainon grabbed the blanket’s edge like it was a lifeline and tried to disappear into the bed.

“I was—uh—grocery shopping.”

“The hospital has a kitchen.”

“Yeah but… uh… no soy sauce.”

Mydei stared. The kind of stare that could split atoms.

Another tug. Phainon dug his fingers in.

“Okay, okay—I was meditating.”

“At an illegal fight club?”

“On the way to the grocery store.”

Another tug. The blanket almost went flying. Phainon clung like a man possessed.

“You have one and a half hours to fix your face.”

Phainon peeked out with one eye, blinking past the pounding in his skull. “Can I get… two?”

“One.”

Door slam.

The walls rattled.

Phainon exhaled, still tangled in the bedding, heart jackhammering.

“…I hate my life.”

He coughed up a little more blood. Wiped it off. Reached for the nearest pillow and screamed into it.

Smooth. Real smooth.

The clock on his wall clicked. A minute lost already.

Phainon cursed and forced himself upright.

The walk to the bathroom was its own personal odyssey. Every step sent a fresh wave of nausea rolling up his throat. His ankle twinged in protest, a dull ache from the earlier sprint over broken metal and debris, and the skin beneath his bandages felt raw, tacky with dried blood. The world tilted unevenly when he passed the mirror, but he didn't stop to look. Didn't need to see it to know how bad he looked.

First aid. Right. First aid.

He fumbled under the sink, knocking over a half-used can of something and a cracked mug before finding the battered first aid tin. Opened it. Antiseptic spray, gauze, tape—haphazardly shoved in from the last time.

"This is gonna suck," he told the empty bathroom.

And it did.

Every sting of alcohol against a split or scrape had him gritting his teeth so hard his jaw ached. He worked fast, patching up the worst of it. Some wounds he left alone. Not enough time. Not enough materials. Not enough everything.

A quick, lukewarm shower came next. The water hit his skin and he bit down a hiss so sharp it made his eyes water. He scrubbed blood from his hands and soot from his hair, careful not to tug the worst spots. Watched rust-red swirl down the drain.

Five minutes. No more.

By the time he dried off, his skin was flushed, raw, and aching, but at least the scent of smoke and adrenaline was gone. He slapped on gauze and tape, a half-assed job at best, but passable.

Clothes. Needed clothes.

He limped back into the bedroom, dropping the damp towel on the floor, and rummaged through the dresser. Most of it was garbage. Ratty shirts, old hoodies, stuff he hadn't worn in years.

And then his hand brushed something soft.

A worn, faded, ridiculously expensive cotton sweater.

Mydei's.

Left behind one night, long ago, and never taken back. Phainon kept telling himself he was holding onto it for practical reasons. It was warm. Comfortable. Good for emergencies.

But the truth was it smelled faintly like him for weeks after he left it, and Phainon never quite worked up the nerve to give it back.

He pulled it on now, the fabric heavy and soft against bruised skin, hanging loose on him the way it always had. The sleeves a little too long, the neckline slightly stretched. It shouldn't have made him feel better, but it did.

Some dumb part of him felt safer in it.

Like he wasn't entirely alone.

"Stupid," he muttered to no one, tugging the cuffs down over his hands.

His reflection in the window was a mess—bandaged, limping, sweater-draped, pale as hell—but at least it was presentable. Or close enough.

Forty-two minutes left.

Phainon dragged a hand through his damp hair and squared his shoulders.

Time to act normal.

The apartment was a disaster. Blood smeared the floor near the window, a streak trailing toward the bedroom. Bits of ash clung to the walls, soot-dark fingerprints on the frame. His sheets were beyond saving—torn, scorched at the edges where his suit's plating had burned too hot. One of the pillows was still stained with a perfect imprint of his face from when he'd screamed into it earlier.

He sighed. Grabbed a rag, soaked it with whatever cleaner was under the sink, and started wiping the floor. The metallic tang of blood clung stubbornly to the air. It didn't help his stomach any.

He worked in silence. Rinsing, scrubbing, wringing out the rag. Switching it for another when the first one turned dark too fast. It wasn't the kind of mess that cleaned easy. Dried blood was hell on wood floors. Another thing to deal with later.

The sheets? No chance. He pulled them off the bed, wincing as a muscle in his side protested. Hauled them into a trash bag, tied it shut. That could go out the fire escape later.

Another glance at the clock.

Thirty-four minutes left.

He leaned against the dresser for a second, catching his breath. Then back at it. Wiped a bloodstain off the windowsill. Pushed a cracked picture frame down so it wouldn't be obvious. Straightened a stack of old sketchbooks.

As he worked, his mind kept circling back to Mydei.

What the hell was he gonna say?

He rehearsed a dozen half-assed excuses.

Traffic. Fell asleep at a friend's. Got stuck fixing something. Phone died. Didn't think it was that big a deal.

Each one felt thinner than the last.

"Teaching," he muttered under his breath, snorting at his own idiocy. "Brilliant, really. Award-winning."

He grabbed another rag, wiped down the desk. Tossed a busted comm-link into a drawer. Cleaned another streak of red from the doorframe. The minutes bled away while he thought—about what to tell him, how to sell it, how not to look like death warmed over.

Twenty-one minutes left.

The apartment looked less like a crime scene now. Not great. But passable if no one looked too close. Phainon sat on the edge of the bed, elbows on his knees, rubbing a hand down his face.

His head still hurt. The sweater still smelled faintly of old soap and memory. His reflection in the window still looked like shit.

He should've eaten. Or slept. Or both.

Ten minutes.

His stomach turned. Not from nausea this time, but from the rising tide of what if.

What if Mydei caught on?

What if he saw too much?

What if this was it—the slip-up that cost him everything?

He hated this part. The waiting. The pretending. The constant rehearsing of a conversation he already knew would go sideways.

Five minutes.

Phainon let out a long, tired breath. Ran both hands through his hair. Prepared to get up.

Time’s up.

Phainon pushed himself upright.

And immediately sat the hell back down with a sharp wince.

“Son of a—” he hissed through his teeth, one hand flying to his ribs.

Alright. Maybe one more minute wouldn’t kill him. Mydei wouldn’t kick the door down *again* this soon… probably. He could spare sixty seconds. Two, tops.

He let his head tip back against the wall, staring up at the ceiling like it might have answers. His whole body felt like it’d been through a meat grinder set to “extra spiteful.” Every muscle ached. His lungs still burned. The room had that heavy, post-crisis quiet, like the walls themselves were politely pretending not to notice the mess he’d made.

He rubbed his face, groaning quietly into his hands.

But as much as the panic gnawed at him, it came with this weird, warm undertow too. The way Mydei had stormed in earlier—not just furious, but scared. That kind of rage came from somewhere real. From caring.

And if Phainon wasn’t stupid lucky to have somebody like that in his corner. Somebody who cared enough to come find him when he disappeared. Someone who noticed when he wasn’t where he should be. Someone who could level a room with words alone but still left him cryptic little notes and sweaters and safe windows to crawl through.

His lips twitched, soft and stupid, as the thought settled.

“Pathetic,” he muttered to himself. But the ache in his ribs didn’t feel quite as sharp now.

He yawned, long and heavy, his head tipping forward a little.

He really felt like he hadn’t slept in two days. The kind of bone-deep exhaustion that made his skin hum. The room blurred at the edges. His eyelids drooped.

Just a second. Just to stop the spinning.

He let them fall shut. His breathing slowed. The world tilted sideways in a way that felt almost nice.

Surely, closing his eyes for a moment wouldn’t hurt.

The quiet pressed in, thick and heavy, like a blanket all its own.

Phainon’s head lolled to the side as he laid on his bed. His breath came softer now, the ragged scrape of earlier dulled into something slow and steady. The pain faded at the edges, traded for that warm, heavy numbness exhaustion left behind when it finally pinned you down.

He kept meaning to open his eyes.

Any second now.

Any moment.

But the warmth of the room, the faint scent of old detergent and fading cologne clinging to the worn sweater, the way his body stopped protesting now that he wasn’t moving—all of it blurred into a thick, irresistible lull.

His thoughts wavered. Half-finished excuses. Scrambled words. The memory of Mydei’s voice sharp with fury, and the rarer, quieter way it softened when the world wasn’t looking.

The minutes slipped past unnoticed.

And he didn’t hear the door open.

Not until the sigh—sharp, tired, exasperated—cut through the quiet like a thread pulled taut.

Closer.

The covers shifted. Phainon barely stirred, but when fingers brushed his hair back from his face and tugged the blanket over his shoulder, his hand shot out, grabbing a wrist on pure reflex.

“Stay,” he slurred, voice wrecked and drowsy. “Just…tonight. I’ll explain tomorrow. Swear.”

A long pause.

“Oh, you’ll explain, alright,” Mydei said flatly. “In bullet points. With timestamps.”

Phainon let out a lazy, lopsided grin, his thumb absently brushing the wrist he still held. “You love me.”

“Unfortunately,” Mydei muttered under his breath.

And yet—he didn’t pull away.

Instead, he shifted closer, guiding Phainon’s hand to his cheek. The skin was warm. The stubble rough. And for a moment, the world felt a little less like it was trying to cave in on him.

“You look like hell,” Mydei murmured.

“Feel worse,” Phainon managed.

“Good. Serves you right.”

His voice didn’t match the words. It was quieter now, edged with something reluctant and fond. His thumb traced over the back of Phainon’s hand where it rested against his cheek.

“You had me out of my mind, you little bastard.”

Phainon made a weak sound that might’ve been an apology or just the start of a snore. His eyelids drooped again, and his grip slackened a little.

Phainon’s eyes cracked open just enough to meet his. “You’re not really leaving, are you?”

Mydei stared at him. At the mess of damp hair and old sweater and exhaustion written into every line of his face. At the reckless, infuriating, stupidly impossible person he loved in spite of himself.

“No,” Mydei admitted. “Not tonight.”

He leaned down, pressing a kiss to the back of Phainon’s hand. It lingered longer than it should have. Then he stayed right there, crouched by the bed, their hands still tangled together.

“You sleep,” Mydei murmured. “I’ve got…stuff. I’ll be here when you wake up.”

“You always say that,” Phainon mumbled.

“And I always am, aren’t I?”

A faint, crooked smile. “Yeah.”

Silence settled, not awkward, not sharp. Just quiet.

Mydei’s thumb swept once more over Phainon’s knuckles. He let their joined hands rest against his cheek a moment longer, then sighed—not the irritated kind this time.

“Goodnight, idiot.”

“Night, boss,” Phainon slurred, already halfway gone.

And this time, when sleep pulled him under, he didn’t fight it. Mydei stayed right where he was, hand in his, as the room settled into soft, steady quiet.

Mydei didn’t move, and Phainon didn’t let go.

Chapter End Notes

10 bucks to anyone who guesses Phainon’s abilities, it’s not as simple as it seems, TRUST ME . And I didn’t know how to end it properly so sorry abt that😔

Alright everyone real question what’s a good chapter to do Phainon’s reveal? I got three different routes I wanna take but ima need y'all's opinions first

Edit: Actually for anyone reading rn should I cut the chapters by say 3-5? Because it looks like I might finish this with a word count near 200k and idk if it’s too long or not for u guys😭

Chapter 10: Mydei's No Good, Very Bad, Definitely Not Fine Day

Chapter Summary

> Surprise surprise, Phainon lands in the hospital. Again. Mydei plays babysitter, they flirt, fight over nutrient paste, and almost start a striptease. Things go okay-ish until Phainon's brain short-circuits, breaks half the med team, glitches the lights, and trauma dumps about (Seemingly?) eldritch horrors. Mydei pretends he's fine. Hyacine pretends she's not worried. And somewhere in the chaos, a very inconvenient set of dots starts connecting.

Chapter Notes

> Title was in homage to the previous one.
>
> Random but my friend sent me a gacha singing battle video with a love story between Joe Biden and Trump and I have been laughing my ass off to that for the last 10 minutes.
>
> Anyway though in the mood to write smut for a seperate fic, real question is Myphai or Phaidei

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The clock on the wall ticked with the smug, self-satisfied cadence of something that knew it didn't have to be anywhere else.

Across the room, a vending machine flickered ominously between *"Enjoy a NutriBar!"* and *"Technical Error: Code 731-B."* Someone had scrawled **LIAR** in Sharpie across the glass. It dispensed nothing.

A holo-poster chirped to life on a glitchy loop, its too-cheerful mascot beaming as it pitched *"Join the Aureate Restraint Unit—Because Who Watches the Watchdogs?"* The recruit model on-screen hefted what could only be described as an ethically questionable energy cannon with a grin

that implied he had absolutely used it on a co-worker once and would do it again.

Mydei sat in a cracked synthetic-leather chair that felt faintly damp, trying to project the kind of cool, detached professionalism expected of a Chrysos Heir. It wasn't working. Not when the receptionist—some poor intern whose gold-trim badge was half peeled off—was actively losing a verbal war with a sapient filing cabinet.

"Form 77C, you obsolete slag pile! 77C is for cross-department violent containment! NOT 13-B! 13-B is for *hazardous plant-based anomalies!* How hard is this?!"

The filing cabinet emitted a mechanical click, popped open a drawer in pure spite, and made a noise that could only be described as a bureaucratic raspberry.

Mydei dragged a hand down his face.

A muffled announcement crackled from the overhead intercom:

"Code Selene in neuroptics. We repeat—Code Selene. Do not engage the levitating patient."

He let out a long, suffering sigh.

Somewhere behind a glass wall, there was a brief burst of static followed by the unmistakable sound of someone being tased.

A cheery automated voice called out, *"Have a nice day, citizen!"*

The vending machine flickered again. The clock smugly ticked.

And Mydei, slouched with his elbows on his knees, muttered to no one in particular:

"How did it come to this?"

A groan escaped him, half mortal exhaustion, half spiritual defeat.

And the worst part?

This still wasn’t even the worst waiting room he’d been in this month.

It all started that night.

The night Mydei found himself tearing half the damn city apart looking for him.

Stayed wasn’t even the right word. *Hunted down,* maybe.

Phainon had left the hospital without a word, vanishing like mist on a bad wind, leaving behind a half-scrawled note that might as well have been ancient cipher code for all the sense it made. Mydei had stared at the jagged handwriting so long it started looking like a Rorschach test. It took five informants, two underground contacts, a heavily bribed kiosk vendor, and nearly twenty-three and a half hours before he found them.

And when he did…

The apartment door hadn’t even been locked.

The room was dark save for the flickering light of a vid-screen on standby, static-blue shadows cutting the edges of the walls. Mydei’s eyes adjusted instantly, trained Chrysos instincts kicking in. He noted the signs the moment he stepped inside—minute things anyone else would miss.

A faint, sour copper tang of blood clung to the air, barely noticeable beneath the chemical clean of a hastily scrubbed floor.

The subtle warp in the fabric of a discarded jacket hung over the back of a chair—stretched at the elbow, suggesting tension in the arm.

A single swollen knuckle on a hand barely peeking from beneath a blanket draped like a defensive barrier on the couch.

Phainon wasn’t asleep so much as crashed, his breathing uneven, shoulders hunched in unconscious guard.

Mydei stood there in the doorway for a long moment, assessing—posture, gait tension, skin pallor, slight bruising at the temple edge where hair didn't quite fall right.

He didn't press.

Not this time.

The exhausted set of Phainon's face made it clear this wasn't the moment for interrogations.

So, he gave him an hour.

Left, closed the door, came back later, and by then Phainon had managed to pull himself together—washed up, the worst of the evidence gone. A comfortable sweater thrown on, face scrubbed clean, hair damp at the edges. The room smelled aggressively like cheap disinfectant, as if someone had gone ten rounds with a mop in a panic.

But Mydei still noticed the little things.

A faint scrape on the windowsill's paint. A newly fixed wall panel that didn't sit quite right. The displaced pattern of dust on a shelf like something heavy had been shoved hastily out of sight.

All of it subtle, smoothed over well enough for most eyes.

But not his eyes.

He clocked it all. Logged it away.

He would've stayed longer—wanted to, honestly—but he hadn't been lying about having business. Vigilante affairs didn't pause for personal crises, even if they should've.

On his way out, he did one last sweep of the apartment. Just habit.

The apartment looked normal, clean even. Too clean.

Mydei frowned.

But he left it.

Let Phainon have this small space of whatever it was.

He didn’t ask, didn’t demand an explanation.

Not then.

And maybe that’s what made everything worse.

It hadn’t even been twenty-four hours before Aglaea called him in.

He was barely out of Phainon’s apartment when the summons hit his comm like a slap. High priority. Encrypted. No details. Just her signature override code and the Chrysos sigil glinting cold on the message.

The Second Node.

He hadn’t wanted to believe it at first—it was supposed to be dead. Cold. Inert. Council records had listed it as fully dismantled, anomalous processes scrubbed, site sterilized and quarantined. A “closed chapter,” they’d said.

But of course, it wasn’t.

Of course.

Aglaea’s office was always curated to perfection. Every paper stack and data slate placed just so. Threads of goldweave diagrams hovering midair above her desk, half-finished constructs left hanging like dissected corpses of thoughts she hadn’t needed yet.

She’d been furious. Not the loud, explosive kind of fury—Aglaea didn’t waste energy on theatrics.

It was in the tightness of her mouth. The way her fingers flexed as if itching to weave some poor bastard into an execution cocoon.

The Node had tried to revive itself.

Not fully—not successfully—but enough to register anomalous activity spikes. Enough to open a broadcast gate. Enough to confirm someone or something had been interfacing with it off-grid for weeks.

It was destroyed now. Beyond salvage.

By, allegedly, *Flame Reaver.*

And wasn't that just perfect.

Aglaea hadn't even tried to hide her disdain. She'd confronted him at the site, left threads woven through his pulse lines to track his movement—but they hadn't held.

The report described it clinically:

"Subject manifested a recursive, self-consuming sigil during confrontation, unraveling conceptual bindings. Residual frequencies detected in a 2.3-meter radius, anomalous conceptual residue present. Marked reality distortion patterning consistent with digital artifact signatures. Dissolution event followed."

In plain terms: he'd slipped through her threads like they were smoke. Left behind a glitched, twitching watermark in the air where he vanished, and something about the space felt… wrong after. Stretched thin.

VIB teams reported gaps in their comm logs. Memory blanks. Time discrepancies. Full minute-and-a-half losses where security footage corrupted itself and field agents could recall nothing but static.

The Council's official explanation?

"Localized chemical weapons leak. Isolated vigilante interference. Unknown suspects."

Bullshit.

It took them less than an hour to issue the cover story. Less than an hour to scrub civilian witnesses, reroute traffic drones, and seal the sector.

Too fast.

You didn’t pull a narrative that airtight on the fly. Not unless you’d already written it in advance.

And that meant one thing:

The Council knew.

Maybe not everything. Maybe not about *him*, not yet—but about the Nodes. About what they were trying to build. About the fact that the Second Node should never have been capable of coming back online, and yet it did.

Aglaea had been fuming over it, even if she played her cards close.

And then there was *his file.*

Flame Reaver.

Flagged Class-Ω.

The highest threat rating the Council issued—reserved for world-altering anomalies, conceptual weapons, and entities classed as “Country-Tier Disruptive.” So in simple terms, not for an allegedly *human* antihero. And even then, his profile?

Suspiciously vague.

Entire sections were Epsilon-restricted. Not even Aglaea herself had clearance to view it, and if someone like her didn’t, something was broken in the chain. Or rigged.

Which meant whoever was pulling those strings wasn’t just powerful—they were untouchable.

And *gods*, did Mydei hate him for it.

Hated the way the bastard slipped between gaps in protocol and physics alike. Hated the way agents came back *wrong* from encounters with him, haunted and unspeaking.

Hated the way his name always showed up at the tail end of when Phainon gets injuried.

He didn't care how strong Flame Reaver was. Didn't care what kind of conceptual bending, data-weaving, impossible-logic-born bullshit he commanded.

If, no matter how impossible it was, he was the reason Phainon had ended up bleeding and half-conscious under a blanket, looking like something had crawled out of his chest and gnawed its way back in—then the only question left was how fast Mydei could kill him.

He drew in a slow breath, feeling the memory of blood from the Node site linger at the back of his throat.

Chemical leak, my ass.

The real reason he was here hadn't started with the Node. Not exactly.

It started when Phainon stopped acting like… *Phainon*.

Not in a way anyone else would notice.

But in the little things.

The way he used to text Mydei a snide complaint about civilian coffee shop playlists or ugly lobby lighting at exactly the same time every evening—stopped.

The way he'd always pick the left side of the couch and make some smug comment about "prime blanket jurisdiction"—stopped.

The casual little brushes of his hand in passing, the lazy grin that usually curled when he caught Mydei scowling at briefing slides, the obnoxious

tendency to hum old country songs under his breath whilst grading student essays—gone.

Like someone turned the dial down.

It was drigid in a way that left the air weirdly thin between them.

Mydei hadn’t pushed. He told himself it was fine.

People went through shit. Phainon had been through worse. He didn’t want to be *that partner*—the suffocating one.

So he left it.

Let the distance settle between them like a storm cloud you pretend isn’t there because if you name it, you’ll have to deal with the lightning.

And then came the checkpoint.

It was nothing.

Just a quiet, normal afternoon. Civvie district. They were headed to a street-level market, one of the ones where old-school booksellers and hand-forged jewelry kiosks crammed into narrow alleys because the permits were cheap and no one cared if you loitered.

The kind of place couples went to browse meaningless things and pretend the world outside didn’t exist for an hour.

They were halfway through a conversation about whether or not it was morally acceptable to deep-fry an entire nutrient bar when the Council patrol stopped them.

“Standard bioscan, sir. Routine clearance.”

Mydei barely registered it. Flashing his ID out of habit, expecting them to wave it off.

But the scanner on Phainon pulsed.

And then shrieked.

Not metaphorically.

The thing *screamed*.

Lit up like someone had just tried to smuggle a micro-fission core through a preschool.

Council officers stiffened.

One of them reached for his comm.

“Detain for secondary—”

No.

No, absolutely fucking not.

Mydei’s second ID was out before his brain caught up, cold authority snapping into place like a blade unsheathed.

Senior Chrysos Heir command override. High-threat incident protocol.

He barely remembered half of what he said. Something about jurisdiction, critical clearance levels, a medical anomaly flagged from residual Node exposure.

Some half-true mix of buzzwords and bureaucratic threats. Enough to make them flinch.

The detail that really set his teeth on edge wasn’t the Council’s presence—it was the VIB team.

They had no reason to be there.

Vigilant Integration Bureau units didn’t run civvie patrols. Their entire purpose, regardless of what they say they are, was to be a last-ditch

authority presence when sanctioned vigilantes got out of line, to cover for Council incompetence and spin favorable outcomes.

They were, by design, reactive. Not proactive.

And yet there they were. Hovering near the checkpoint, like carrion birds waiting for a corpse to finish twitching.

Sketchy didn't begin to cover it.

Which was how he ended up here.

Dragging Phainon—sullen, silent, and unreadable—to a Chrysos Heir facility under priority override and putting Hyacine personally on the scan.

Because if there was one person in the entire city who knew how to untangle high-anomaly exposure without triggering Council alarms, it was her.

And now…

Now he was sitting in a damp chair, listening to a filing cabinet argue about plant-based hazards, while somewhere behind a reinforced wall his partner was being scanned for gods-knew-what.

A voice crackled through the comm node embedded in the chair's armrest.

"Designation Mydeimos. Clearance confirmed. Subject's stabilized for intake—proceed to Bay Two."

He stood, the motion automatic, ignoring the way his stomach coiled tight like a pulled cable.

Time to see how bad it really was.

The med-bay was all brushed steel and matte glass. Monitors lined the walls, threads of data cascading down like rain, spooling through bio-

readouts and spectral imaging. It smelled like disinfectant and burnt circuitry.

Hyacine stood at the primary console, one hand braced on the glass display, the other flicking through readouts with efficient gestures. Her expression was all business, but the tightness around her eyes told Mydei everything he needed to know. This wasn't routine.

"Neural burn," she said finally, voice clipped. "Category IV. Prolonged exposure to high-output Chrysos-thread tech. Restricted class."

Mydei's gut gave a sharp, mean twist.

He forced his face neutral, mouth tugging tight at the corners. *No. No, that's not possible. Unless—*

"It's a byproduct," he said, voice carefully measured, threading plausible deniability into the words before they even left his tongue. "He was linked to the third node when it destabilized. It must've mimicked a neural burn signature. Temporary."

Hyacine didn't look up. "I ran it twice. Signature spike didn't appear until two days ago. Well after the incident."

A silence fell between them, thick and heavy, punctuated only by the faint hum of medical scanners.

Hyacine sighed, adjusting the overlay. "There's more. I'm seeing disrupted memory sequences. Regression patterns." She pulled up a visual—a ripple of data fluctuations marked in sickly blue, like bruises on the mind.

"It's not severe," she went on. "But it's enough. Certain memories might be… fragmented. Stuck. Behavioral loops reverting to older personality states."

Mydei's throat felt too tight for his liking. He folded his arms to keep his hands from flexing.

“And you’re sure it’s not from the node event?” The words sounded too brittle, like they might snap in half if he wasn’t careful.

“I’m sure,” Hyacine said quietly. “If anything, his baseline physiology’s compensating better than expected.” She gestured to a highlighted section of Phainon’s bio-readout, its metrics stable in ways they shouldn’t be.

“For anyone else, this would’ve killed half their neural lattice. He’s… tolerating it. Better than he should.”

Mydei’s stomach dropped again, this time deeper. He didn’t like mysteries. And he especially didn’t like them tangled up in the one person he couldn’t afford to lose.

He gave a sharp nod, jaw tight. “What’s the prognosis?”

Hyacine shrugged, a bleak little gesture. “Manageable. If the pattern holds. If it escalates—”

“It won’t.” His voice cut sharper than intended, and Hyacine raised an eyebrow but didn’t comment.

She keyed a final command into the system, logging the scan. “You can see him now.”

Mydei didn’t wait for permission.

The door slid open with a quiet hydraulic sigh, but Mydei didn’t bother waiting for it to fully retract before stepping through. His pace was purposeful—not quite a march, but damn close.

The room was dim. Not dark, not bright, just that sterile half-light that Chrysos med-bays defaulted to when they didn’t know what to do with you yet. Monitors lined the far wall, their readouts cycling through neural patterns, vitals, and bio-signature resonance. The steady pulse of data felt louder than it should’ve in the quiet.

And there Phainon sat, propped against the headboard, one hand resting limp on the blanket, eyes unfocused and turned toward the far window like

he could see something on the other side of the reinforced polarized glass. The wash of city lights flickered against his face in cold colors. He didn't even glance up when Mydei entered.

Which wasn't like him. *Not at all.*

Mydei's throat worked around something dry. He clenched his jaw and forced his focus back where it belonged—on the impossible, spiraling math problem of how any of this made sense.

Neural burn.

Category IV.

From restricted Chrysos tech.

And not from the node incident—after. The rational explanation he'd clung to like a lifeline had dissolved under Hyacine's readout in a matter of seconds.

But if not that… *then what the hell was he touching?*

And the injuries. Always the injuries.

Injuries that always, *always*, lined up with Council disasters. VIB "containment breaches." Unscheduled blackouts. Emergency lockdowns where security cams glitched just long enough to leave a four-minute gap. Incidents where *Flame Reaver* was reported active.

His gut coiled tight.

Was he hiding something? Or was Mydei—gods forbid—so blinded by proximity that he never really knew him at all?

He wanted to scoff at the idea. Wanted to dismiss it outright. But the suspicion was there now, gnawing at the edges like a corrosive acid that would keep eating until there was nothing left but truth or ruin.

The data would be flagged. Maybe not immediately—Hyacine was discreet, but Chrysos' systems ran auto-logs against everyone. It would get picked up. Forwarded. Reviewed.

And if it pointed to something it shouldn't…

I'll handle it before they do.

No matter what the hell this was, he wouldn't let it become a weapon against Phainon.

But gods, his chest ached looking at him like that. Mydei had seen Phainon injuried way too many times this month. How many monitors. How many unspoken near-misses. And somehow, it didn't get easier.

It got worse.

He cleared his throat, voice cutting through the static hum of machinery. "You planning to acknowledge me at any point, or should I just stand here and admire the wall with you?"

Phainon blinked, like it took him a second to process the words. He turned his head, slow, that familiar sharpness in his gaze dulled but still there, lurking under whatever shell had hollowed him out.

"Mydei," he said finally, as if remembering he could speak.

And Mydei hated that. Hated how his pulse stuttered at hearing it, hated the worry, hated the suspicion worming its way deeper under his skin.

He kept his face unreadable. "We need to talk."

Phainon's gaze lingered on him, sharp now. A flicker of calculation behind those too-dark eyes—not quite the reckless, easygoing sharpness Mydei was used to, but something *careful*.

And then, softly:

"…Why are we here, Mydei?"

It wasn’t an accusation, not yet—but it edged too close. There was no reason, none Phainon should know of, why a simple civilian with no official clearance would be in a secured Chrysos Heir med facility, let alone walking someone through the front without half a building worth of security detail throwing them both into containment.

And Phainon *wasn’t* in containment.

He was in an observation suite.

On Mydei’s override clearance.

A cold ripple worked its way up Mydei’s spine. He smoothed his face before the worry could show and forced a wry shrug, looking away like the monitors had just gotten very interesting.

“You gave the Council’s checkpoint scanners a glitch. Some kind of residual neural feedback from that anomaly incident probably. They got twitchy about it.”

He gestured vaguely toward the diagnostic equipment. “I pulled a few favors. Figured it was faster this way than you spending a week in their ‘detention wellness processing.’”

It sounded mostly plausible. Mostly. Enough that it passed on paper—enough that if Phainon wasn’t already suspicious, he might let it slide.

But his expression didn’t ease.

Didn’t crack with one of those crooked grins.

Didn’t soften like it usually did when Mydei bailed him out of something.

It stayed distant.

And it gnawed under Mydei’s ribs in a way he didn’t have a name for.

He sat down in the chair beside the bed, dropping into it with a sigh he hadn’t meant to let slip.

The tension coiled too tight. And like a fool, like an idiot reaching for something familiar, Mydei tried to cut it.

He offered a smile that felt paper-thin even to himself. “Guess you really are defective. Knew there was something off about you.”

It should’ve landed. Should’ve earned an exasperated laugh, maybe a shove. Maybe a muttered, “Only in the ways you like, Mydei.”

Instead, Phainon’s gaze dropped to his hands. He flexed his fingers like he was counting scars no one else could see.

“You’re not wrong,” he murmured.

No edge.

Just a plain, bone-bare statement.

And something in Mydei’s chest stopped.

The breath he took caught jagged in his throat, and he hated how his pulse stumbled. Hated the way those words landed too deep, like an old blade under new skin.

That wasn’t how that was supposed to go.

He swallowed around the guilt, masked it fast. “Hey—” the word came out rough, too rough. He cleared his throat. “I didn’t mean it like—”

Phainon didn’t answer. Didn’t even look up.

And Mydei didn’t know how to fix it.

The quiet stretched long enough to start getting awkward. Mydei, half out of instinct and half to *do something with his hands,* fished around in his jacket pocket until his fingers closed around a crumpled NutriBar wrapper and the last unopened one he’d grabbed from the waiting room dispenser.

Without ceremony, he tossed it toward the bed.

Phainon caught it one-handed without even looking. Muscle memory. The bar landed with a soft *pap* against his palm.

“You always bring me these,” Phainon murmured. Voice a little frayed at the edges.

Mydei scoffed, leaning back in his seat. “Yeah, well. Someone’s gotta keep you from passing out every time you forget you’re made of actual flesh and not recycled pipe insulation.”

Phainon didn’t reply, but the bar crinkled softly as he peeled it open.

And for a second, it felt almost normal. Almost.

Mydei grabbed a datapad off the counter beside him—Hyacine’s preliminary scan notes, mostly encrypted, but he could bypass that later—and flicked through it under the glow of the monitors. His brow furrowed as he parsed a particularly dense line of neural conductivity markers.

Without warning, fingers brushed against his temple.

He flinched.

Phainon had leaned forward, still absentminded, and pushed a stray lock of Mydei’s hair out of his face, tucking it behind his ear like it was the most natural thing in the world. His eyes stayed on the datapad, unbothered.

“It was in the way,” he said, like the explanation even mattered.

Mydei stared at him. Words half-forming, a dozen half-baked excuses crashing into one another because *that was their thing.*

The automatic, familiar touch.

The unthinking gestures neither of them ever talked about.

And his heart did a stupid, traitorous *lurch*.

He swallowed, made a valiant effort at a scowl. “Next time, ask before you start grooming me like a street cat.”

Phainon’s lips quirked—barely there, but it was there.

Mydei stared at the datapad, absolutely not noticing the way his pulse had picked up or how the air in the room felt the tiniest bit less suffocating.

Mydei set the datapad down with a soft clack, clearing his throat. “Gonna check in with Hyacine,” he muttered, already halfway to the door. “Be right back.”

Phainon didn’t say anything.

But as the door slid shut behind him, Phainon’s gaze stayed fixed on the spot where Mydei had stood—a quiet, unreadable look in his eyes, like he was trying to memorize the shape of his absence.

Well—according to Hyacine, and delivered with the kind of forced professional cheer that meant *this was going to suck for both of them*—Phainon needed to stay for observation for at least a week. “Neurological stabilization, memory drift mitigation, and protocol-compliant recuperation,” she’d rattled off, sending Mydei a subtle look over the scan logs. Both of them understood without a word: scrub as much of the suspicious data from his file as possible before the Council’s auditors could get their hands on it.

Mydei had agreed. Hell, he even thought it might be *good* for Phainon. A week. Some rest. Monitored care. Safer here than outside.

Apparently, Phainon didn’t share the sentiment.

Because not even twelve hours into his stay, Mydei caught sight of a familiar mop of messy hair and a *very shirtless* Phainon trying to shimmy out the window of the med-bay recovery suite like some half-dead delinquent making a break for it after curfew. Bandages loose, a

constellation of bruises blooming on pale skin, one sock on, one sock missing, datapad cables still half-tangled around one ankle.

“Are you serious right now?” Mydei’s voice hit an octave he hadn’t achieved since his teenage years. He stormed over and yanked him bodily back inside.

“Easy,” Phainon muttered, but didn’t fight too hard. “I just needed some fresh air.”

“Fresh air isn’t *three stories up* through a vent window, you idiot!”

The argument spilled across the room, sharp words and jabs exchanged between someone trying to be responsible and someone whose definition of self-preservation was “die stylishly, probably shirtless.” Mid-sentence, Mydei grabbed Phainon’s wrist to keep him from bolting again.

He never saw it coming.

In one sharp, fluid motion—too fast for someone supposedly disoriented and concussed—Phainon twisted their positions, and the next thing Mydei knew, *he* was the one pinned to the wall. A forearm pressing lightly against his collarbone, just enough weight to remind him who was more quick-witted, even half-dead.

Phainon leaned in, his breath warm against the curve of Mydei’s ear. Low voice, lazy drawl. “Careful, sweetheart. You’re giving me ideas.”

Mydei’s whole spine locked up. Face flushed. Skin prickling where their bodies brushed, but his glare didn’t waver.

“Try it,” he hissed, “and I’ll break your nose.”

Phainon grinned, all teeth, like it was exactly the answer he wanted.

“Bet you’d like to.”

Same infuriating smirk. Same impossible bastard. Same damn brat. And against every better instinct Mydei had, his pulse didn’t slow in the

slightest.

After physically hauling Phainon back inside—a process that involved entirely too much grappling for someone allegedly in recovery—Mydei barely caught his breath before the man pulled his next move: pure, unfiltered arrogance.

“I’m not staying here,” Phainon snapped, defiance sharp enough to cut. His hair was a disaster, eyes wild, voice frayed at the edges. “Unless you can get me a platinum-suite recovery room with an enviro-control bed, an unrestricted comm feed, synthwave-tinted skylights that actually track the lunar phases, and a minibar stocked with something top-shelf, you can choke on it. I’ll walk.”

He was half-bruised, half-bandaged, still had the audacity to look smug about it.

Mydei just stared at him.

“…That’s it?”

Phainon blinked. “Huh?”

“That’s your price?” Mydei scrolled something casually on his datapad, deadpan as hell. “You’re easier than I thought.”

He tapped the screen once. “Done.”

The silence that followed was immediate. So sharp it was almost comical.

Phainon’s mouth actually dropped open, blinking like his brain had momentarily blue-screened.

“You’re lying.”

“Check for yourself.”

Phainon did. The wall display blinked an alert: **Atrium Suite Transfer Confirmed—Patient: Phainon** with every absurd request he’d rattled off

listed neatly underneath. Enviro-control bed. Unrestricted comm privileges. Synthwave skylights with real lunar tracking. Minibar. And a note: *Authorization: [REDACTED] Clearance, Tier A.*

He looked up at Mydei like the man had just punched a hole through the laws of bureaucracy by sheer force of will.

“What the hell—”

Mydei’s expression didn’t shift, but his eyes gave it away—the faintest glimmer of *you idiot* threaded with the look of a man who’d spent too many nights seeing this idiot in a hospital bed and wasn’t about to add another.

“Welcome to The Atrium Suite, *sweetheart,*” Mydei said dryly. “Enjoy the synthwave skylights.”

Before Phainon could sputter a comeback, two Chrysos med-techs arrived with reinforced cuffs for “patient stability,” locking him down like a particularly good-looking flight risk. One of them keyed the door to Mydei’s biometrics on the way out.

For once, Phainon had nothing to say.

Mydei let the silence settle, savored it like a rare vintage, before turning to leave—the faint, exasperated fondness lingering in the set of his shoulders.

Might be a brat, he thought. *But you’re my problem, you reckless bastard.*

The scan suite had glass panels pulsing with quiet light as the bioelectrical lattice array booted up, pale blue schematics hovering midair. Hyacine keyed a sequence into the wall terminal, a lattice diagram of the human nervous system unfurling like a digital spine.

“Alright,” Hyacine chirped. “You’re up, Phainon. Clothes off—I need full contact for the mapping.”

Phainon, already halfway to uncooperative, sighed but tugged his shirt over his head with a lazy roll of muscle, fabric catching for a second before it came loose. He flung it onto the nearby chair and then glanced sideways at Mydei.

“Help me with this, would you?” he asked, casual, fingers absently toying with the waistband of his pants like it was just another Tuesday.

Mydei choked on his own breath. “Do it your damn self.”

Phainon smirked—sharp, predatory, the kind of grin that usually preceded catastrophic decisions. “Didn’t figure you for shy.”

Hyacine, without missing a beat, looked up from her holo-display, smile perfectly neutral. “I can leave if you two need a minute.”

Mydei’s brain short-circuited. “We don’t—He’s—” He gestured wildly at Phainon, who looked entirely too pleased with himself, then at Hyacine. “Just run your scan.”

Hyacine winked. “As you say, boss.”

Phainon tossed a cocky glance Mydei’s way, like he’d won some silent argument, then kicked his shoes off and stepped onto the platform, bare skin catching the soft electric-blue glow of the feedback lattice as the system powered up.

The room dimmed, leaving only the web of bioelectric pathways lighting up along Phainon’s frame—and Mydei, very intentionally, kept his eyes on the holo-monitor and absolutely nowhere else.

Because damn it, this was going to be a long week.

The scan completed with a soft chime, the lattice flickering as lines of bioelectric feedback translated into a three-dimensional nerve map. Hyacine tapped a command, and the rendered silhouette of Phainon’s body rotated lazily in the air—a web of lit nerve clusters and microcurrent readings illuminating in shades of indigo and green.

Mydei wasn’t trying to look.

Really, he wasn’t.

But his gaze snagged on a section of the readout—isolated red markers blinking along old scar tissue buried deep in muscle clusters, fractures in neural pathways rerouted by time and survival instinct. Abnormal stress-response loops. Memory trauma signatures. Combat-related strain patterns no normal civilian—no *professor*—should’ve racked up.

His gut twisted.

It didn’t add up.

Not with Phainon’s spotless record. Not with the carefully constructed nothingness of his official history. Not with the academic credentials Mydei had only half-cared to check before.

The scan was too clinical to make excuses for. Too damning.

Phainon noticed the silence first. Shirt in hand, half-forgotten, he glanced between the readout and Mydei’s face—something sharp flashing in his expression, instinctive calculation.

“…Something wrong, doc?” Phainon asked, voice light, but his eyes were tracking every muscle in Mydei’s jaw.

Mydei swallowed hard, forcing a smile. “Actually—” he stepped forward, rolling his sleeves up to his forearms, every movement calm, practiced, the kind you used before a bar fight you didn’t wanna start but weren’t gonna lose. “I think I’ll take you up on that offer.”

Phainon’s brow furrowed. “Offer?”

“You know.” Mydei gestured vaguely. “Helping you change.”

A flicker of something like self-preservation sparked in Phainon’s eyes. He grabbed his shirt—caution still intact despite how beat to hell he was—and made a very subtle, very strategic step toward the opposite wall.

“On second thought,” Phainon said, slipping the fabric down over his head, deliberately turning away, “I think I’m good.”

“Oh no,” Mydei drawled, stalking closer, sharp-edged and patient. “Too late for that.”

Phainon bolted for his jacket, trying to slip it on one-armed, one eye on Mydei like he was measuring the odds of a clean getaway versus losing a shoe in the process.

“I swear to every pantheon, Phainon, if you run I’m chaining your ass to that bed again.”

Phainon smirked, but it was thinner now. “Bet you’d like to.”

And then, because neither of them knew how to back down—they both moved at the same time.

Phainon was a miserable, grumpy fixture in the middle of a bed worth more than most officers’ annual hazard pay. The synthwave-tinted skylights above them flickered lazily between lunar phases—precisely as he’d demanded, and now looking more regretful by the second.

Pinned by reinforced restraint bands around his wrists (a precaution, Hyacine had cheerily claimed, since he “kept trying to jailbreak his vitals monitors”), Phainon stubbornly refused to meet Mydei’s gaze. He’d gone full petulant sulk mode.

Mydei leaned against the doorframe, datapad tucked under his arm.

“So,” he asked mildly, tapping a loose knuckle against the wall display, “enjoying your luxury accommodations?”

Phainon’s scowl deepened. If looks could kill, the Atrium Suite would’ve been declared a crime scene.

“It’s been two days,” Phainon snapped. “Two days of cortical sync scans, vasculature density mapping, bioelectrical resonance analysis—and those glorified med-drones trying to barcode my spine while I’m half-asleep.”

“You forgot the cognitive decay latency monitor,” Mydei said helpfully.

Phainon glared, then pointedly turned his face to the side.

Mydei sighed, stepping further into the room and leaning over the end of the bed. “Calm down. We’ve still gotta run you through the neural impulse relay diagnostics and the recursive memory cohesion audit before you’re cleared.”

“No.”

Mydei raised a brow. “No?”

“I’m done,” Phainon said flatly. “That’s it. No more tests, no more lattice mapping, no more *whatever-the-hell-you-called-it neural resonance differential sequencing.* I’ve had enough. The techs have had enough. You’ve had enough.”

“Actually,” Mydei replied, glancing at his datapad like he hadn’t heard a word, “we haven’t.”

Phainon shot him a dry look. “Name one I haven’t done.”

Mydei opened his mouth, then hesitated.

“…Look—”

“Quantitative microcurrent latency response. Electro-dermal feedback threshold mapping. Deep tissue vibrotactile stim assessment.”

A beat.

Mydei grimaced. “…Okay. That last one’s optional.”

“Bullshit.”

And for a moment it looked like the standoff would reset for round three.

Until Phainon, very quietly, muttered without looking at him,

“I hate hospitals.”

The words hung there, heavier than they should’ve been.

And for all of Mydei’s suspicion, for all the buried doubt he wouldn’t admit out loud, his heart still clenched like a wire pulled too tight. He exhaled through his nose, rubbing a hand down his face.

A beat of quiet.

Then Phainon spoke again, reluctant, jaw tight.

“…Less tests.”

Mydei fought down a smile. “Deal.”

He made a note on his datapad, signaling Hyacine for priority vitals only and essential diagnostics, then glanced down at the scowling man in the bed.

“You’re still wearing those restraints though.”

Phainon deadpanned at him. “You’re a sadist.”

“You say that like it’s new.”

The third morning started with Hyacine frowning at Phainon’s charts, chewing absently on the end of a stylus. She didn’t even bother with preamble anymore.

“Alright, stabilizer flush. He’s spiking too hard. Endocrine’s out of regulation, cortisol’s trying to start a fight with his dopamine, and his circadian markers think it’s 3 a.m. in four different timezones.”

Mydei, already nursing a cup of coffee he didn’t want, leaned against the far wall, arms crossed. “Side effects?”

Hyacine grinned, far too cheerful for someone about to chemically scramble another person’s brain for therapeutic reasons. “Nothing lasting. Maybe a little disorientation, mild inhibition drop. He’ll be fine.”

Which, in retrospect, should’ve been a warning.

By the time the stabilizer drip hit Phainon’s system, the effects were embarrassingly immediate. His head tipped lazily against the med-bed’s headrest, lids fluttering half-mast as his pupils dilated, the tension bleeding from his frame like someone had cut his strings.

He slurred out a soft, “Mm’ feel weird.”

Mydei tried not to react. “It’s the stabilizer. You’ll be fine.”

Phainon turned his head, hazy gaze locking on Mydei like he’d just now noticed him standing there. A slow, crooked grin crept across his face, something looser and too genuine.

“Mydei…” he drawled, voice warm and wrecked-soft in a way that was absolutely going to kill him later. “Y’know you’re… gorgeous, right?”

Hyacine snorted so hard she had to turn away, pretending to check a monitor.

Mydei, face instantly heating, scowled. “Shut up. You’re delirious.”

“Mmhmm,” Phainon hummed, reaching out like he might actually try to grab him. His fingers grazed Mydei’s sleeve, and it was nothing, stupidly light contact, but Mydei’s pulse stuttered all the same.

“Could kiss you right now,” Phainon murmured, eyes slipping closed, lashes casting faint shadows over flushed skin. “Bet you taste good.”

“Stars, you’re worse than a blackout rat on stim fumes,” Mydei growled, roughly batting his hand away, but it wasn’t sharp. Not really. And his ears

were red enough to fry with no.

Hyacine coughed into her hand, grinning as she scrawled a note on the datapad. “Vitals stabilizing. Endocrine’s leveling. Might wanna bottle this mood for later.”

“I will set your lab on fire,” Mydei deadpanned, glaring at her.

Phainon slumped back down, a lazy, contented sigh escaping him. “So bossy,” he mumbled, barely audible now, head lolling toward the side. “Lucky you’re cute.”

And then—mercifully—sleep claimed him, stabilizer knocking him out cold. The medbay monitor let out a steady, even pulse. Hyacine shot Mydei a look, one brow raised in smug amusement.

“He won’t remember a thing.”

Mydei stared at the unconscious idiot on the bed, heat still stubbornly clinging to his face. “…Good.”

But he didn’t leave right away. Just stood there for a long moment, watching Phainon’s breathing settle, the faint crease between his brows smoothing out for the first time in days.

He wouldn’t remember it.

Mydei wouldn’t forget.

The datapad chimed softly in Mydei’s hand. He hadn’t meant to check it again, but old instincts had a way of clawing up at inconvenient hours.

He flicked through the logs—standard vital checks, stabilizer balances, sensory recalibration files. Then he saw it.

Adrenal Response Curve: Flagged.

A spike right where there shouldn’t be one. Not under sedatives, not at rest.

He swiped again.

Situational Awareness Index: 92.7%

Mydei's tensed. That wasn't just above average—that was combat active. Field-ready. Numbers like that didn't come from a civilian with neural scarring. Not even one with irregular anchor residue like Phainon's.

Gods above…

Another soft ping. **Reflex Latency Test Results.**

He opened the file.

Visual latency: 0.142 seconds.
Auditory response: 0.219 seconds.
Neuromuscular coordination: 0.105 seconds.

He stared at those numbers. Chrysos-vetted enforcers barely clocked those in controlled simulations.

Phainon had blown through them like it was nothing.

Hyacine's note at the bottom:

"Not standard civilian baselines. Re-test pending."

Mydei didn't breathe for a full second.

Across the room, Phainon was reclining in his ridiculous luxe enviro-bed, one hand lazily tossing a nutrition bar into the air and catching it again like some overgrown street rat who'd lucked his way into a royal suite. Smug, cocky—entirely unaware of the storm curling tighter around him.

"0.105," Mydei muttered under his breath.

Phainon glanced over. "Talking about how impressive I am again?" he smirked.

Mydei gave him a thin, humorless smile. “Something like that.”

He scrolled further, cross-referencing the flagged readings against old mission logs, against old Flame Reaver field reports he wasn’t technically supposed to have archived. Situational awareness spikes in high-conflict nodes. Adrenal overclocks during flare riots. Reflex scores that only two known agents had ever clocked higher than.

And one of them was dead.

His stomach turned.

He didn’t say a word, though. Not yet. Just closed the datapad with a sharp flick of his thumb and forced his expression back to neutral.

Could be a neural burn side effect.

Could be trauma pattern crossovers.

Or it could be something worse.

He wasn’t sure what terrified him more.

The soft click of a releasing restraint band met Mydei the second he stepped through the door.

He looked up from his datapad, raising a brow.

Phainon was seated on the edge of his enviro-bed, one wrist free, a stripped stim patch casing pinched expertly between two fingers like a lockpick. The restraint band lay slack against the mattress, seconds from falling away entirely.

They made eye contact.

A beat passed.

“They slipped,” Phainon said.

Mydei stared at him. “Uh-huh.”

Another beat.

Mydei crossed the room, plucked the stim patch casing from his fingers, and re-secured the restraint—a little tighter this time.

Phainon gave a token tug. Scowled. “Abuse of power.”

“You’d know,” Mydei muttered.

Just then, Hyacine popped in, chipper as always, holding a tray with a nutrient paste blend that looked like it’d been extracted from a sewer runoff and smelled worse.

“Neural repair blend,” she announced brightly, setting it down with a flourish. “Formulated to regulate endocrine spikes and stabilize post-burn neurotransmitter crossfire. Tastes like shit.”

Phainon eyed the cup warily. “I’m not eating that.”

“Not optional,” Hyacine sing-songed.

“I’ll starve.”

“Can’t. Monitored intake protocols,” she said, then winked at Mydei. “You’ve got this.” and ducked out before the explosion.

Mydei sighed, grabbed the spoon. “Open your mouth.”

“You wouldn’t dare.”

He dipped the spoon into the sludge. Held it out.

Phainon glared. “I swear to God, Mydei—”

“Say ‘ah.’”

“You say ‘ah.’”

Mydei lunged.

They wrestled.

Ridiculous, undignified, elbows and half-choked insults. Phainon had one hand still cuffed but still managed to disarm Mydei, sending the spoon arcing in a graceful, traitorous arc across the room.

It hit the wall with a wet *splat*.

Silence.

Phainon grinned, breathless and smug. “Told you.”

Hyacine, from the hallway, let out an audible snort and vanished before either could retaliate.

Mydei let his head drop back with a groan. “You’re an absolute menace.”

“And yet you keep showing up,” Phainon shot back, and for a split second, there was a flicker of something softer under the banter.

Mydei caught it. Didn’t comment.

Just sighed, grabbed a fresh spoon, and muttered, “We’re not done.”

Mydei strode in, datapad tucked under one arm and a cheap ration chocolate bar in hand like it was some rare, coveted artifact. He flicked it onto Phainon’s chest with a practiced, unimpressed motion.

“Congrats,” Mydei announced flatly. “You survived Day Four. Here’s your prize.”

Phainon, lounging against the luxe enviro-bed like he owned the place, didn’t even bother to look. One hand absently palmed the ration bar, thumb running over the wrapper, eyes half-lidded and faintly amused.

“If this isn’t a striptease, I’m not interested.”

Mydei’s brow twitched. He sucked in a sharp breath, exasperated, and rolled up his sleeves with slow, deliberate intent—knuckles cracking for dramatic emphasis.

“Keep talking.”

There was the faintest smirk at the corner of Phainon’s mouth. That infuriating, self-assured curve that meant nothing good for anyone within a ten-foot radius.

Before Mydei could commit to murder, Hyacine poked her head in, datapad in hand and a too-innocent grin on her face.

“Hey. Neural sync leads need a manual recalibration. System flagged a misalignment in the upper conduits.”

She didn’t even wait for a reply, already tossing Mydei a portable relay patch and gesturing at the overhead node ports. “You’re closest.”

Mydei shot her a glare. “You’re joking.”

“Nope.” She winked and was gone, door sliding shut behind her.

Phainon arched a brow, finally turning his head to glance at Mydei. “Looks like you’re on top of me again, sweetheart.”

“Gods, you’re exhausting.”

Muttering curses under his breath, Mydei climbed up onto the edge of the bed, one knee digging into the mattress near Phainon’s hip, the other braced for balance as he stretched for the overhead interface. The position was a mess of awkward angles and far too much proximity, especially with Phainon’s wrist restraints still locked down.

And of course, because the bastard couldn’t leave well enough alone—

“If you wanted me tied down and begging, you could’ve just asked.”

The words were dangerously close to his ear. Velvet-smooth and unapologetic, like it wasn’t the first time he’d thought about it.

Mydei’s whole body tensed. A spark of heat shot up his spine before he crushed it, jaw tight, pulse in his throat.

“Say one more word,” Mydei warned, voice soft and lethal.

Phainon’s grin widened, sharp and satisfied, gaze heavy-lidded and too fucking pleased with himself. The air between them went thick enough to cut. For a beat, neither of them moved.

Somewhere in the background, a monitor beeped. The datapad in Mydei’s hand trembled slightly from the tension in his grip.

It took every scrap of discipline not to look down, not to acknowledge the proximity of their bodies or the heat radiating off Phainon’s skin, or the fact that Mydei’s thigh was pressed tight against his side.

But gods, it was a near thing.

And just like that, it was the fifth day.

Phainon, against all odds, was actually doing better. The color had come back to his face, his vitals were stabilizing, and most importantly—the bastard was getting cocky again. Old self inching its way to the surface with every smug remark and unrepentant grin.

Mydei figured it was safe enough to step out for a bit. Cipher was in the city—rare, considering she ghosted in and out of networked grids like mist, and when she showed herself it usually meant valuable intel wasn’t far behind.

And Mydei had been meaning to confirm a little suspicion of his own. It seemed their elusive antihero might’ve picked up a partner. Someone else running the streets, someone good—good enough to stay off the Council’s scanners and Hyacine’s encrypted tracers. The kind of dangerous, alluring problem Mydei could sink his teeth into.

He left with barely a glance back, Hyacine cheerfully waving him off and Phainon looking entirely too pleased to be unsupervised.

Of course, it would be the one time something went wrong.

Chrysos Heir medical centers didn’t fail. Not on mission, not off. It happened maybe once a decade—and apparently, this was their lucky day.

Hyacine had been running a neural integration stabilization procedure. Standard. Smart, even. The goal was to reinforce neural pathways destabilized by trauma-adjacent memory displacement, smoothing over erratic resonance spikes, clearing junk data.

It should’ve helped. It was helping. Right up until it didn’t.

Residual trauma triggers.

The system flagged a priority amber spike halfway through the recalibration phase—a surge of hyperactive node feedback. Which, in clean tech terms, meant Phainon’s brain decided to play back some very bad things at full volume.

And the worst part?

It happened when Mydei wasn’t there.

It went from bad to worse sometime around the fourteenth hour.

The logs Hyacine sent later painted a brutal picture. During the Neural Stabilization Recalibration, a residual trauma spike hit—higher than anything they’d seen. Feedback flooded the synapse lines, and Phainon panicked.

Bolted.

The Aureate Restraint Unit was deployed, fast and professional. Or at least they were supposed to be.

By the time they got him down, two had cracked ribs, one a dislocated shoulder, another a fractured ulna. Neural tech ruptured, monitors shorted out in a ten-meter radius, half the floor's lighting grid glitched so bad it left everything flickering like a failing pulse.

They called it a systems anomaly. Hardware degradation. Power loop cross-interference.

Nobody said the obvious. That it happened centered on him.

Now, hours later, Phainon was locked in the room. Not caged—they weren't animals here. It was still his room, with its ridiculous huge bed and adjustable enviro-temps and far too many pillows for one man. But the entrance authorization grid was restricted, sedatives loaded into the wall injectors if needed.

For his safety. And everyone else's.

Hyacine waited for Mydei by the observation pane. She looked tired for once—tired and small in a way she never did, leaning against the wall in loose scrubs, datapad clutched to her chest.

"I don't recommend going in," she said softly. "Not yet. He's… not himself."

Mydei's gaze flicked toward the sealed door. No flicker of concern in his face, just that unreadable composure he wore like armor. He exhaled through his nose, slow and unhurried.

"I'm not here to fight him," he started with carefully. "And he wouldn't lay a hand on me. Couldn't, even if he tried."

Hyacine opened her mouth, then thought better of it. She stepped aside without another word, letting him pass.

Mydei keyed the lock, stepped through without hesitation, the door sealing behind him in a hush of pressurized air.

He didn't puff his chest or make a show of readiness.

He just walked in, and if Phainon came at him, he wouldn’t strike, wouldn’t flinch—would catch him, hold him down if it came to it, and let him calm because that’s what you did when someone needed help.

But they both knew it wouldn’t come to that.

It never would.

Phainon looked like hell.

Sweat-dark hair clung to his forehead, the sharp line of his jaw shadowed with stubble. Bruises mottled his collarbone, ugly and blooming against pale skin. The restraint bands at his wrists had been resecured, red marks ghosting along the skin beneath them. He didn’t spare Mydei a glance.

Mydei crossed the room without a word.

The half-spilled water pitcher sat abandoned on the side table, condensation beading down the glass. He righted it, poured a clean glass, set it within reach. Still nothing from Phainon.

Not until Mydei leaned back against the wall, arms loose at his sides, voice soft.

“You hurt?”

A beat.

Then, dry as scorched earth, Phainon muttered, “You offering to kiss it better?”

The air pulled tight between them, a breath before a storm. Tension like a drawn string, neither of them willing to ease the hold.

Mydei didn’t smile. Just arched a brow, gaze steady and unreadable.

Then—the lights overhead stuttered.

A monitor on the far wall glitched, its feed warping for a heartbeat, data bleeding into static. A near-imperceptible distortion in the pulse of the room.

Mydei clocked it instantly. No comment, but his eyes narrowed, a flicker of calculation sparking in that sharp gaze.

Across from him, Phainon's jaw clenched. Not at the water. Not at the restraints. At that.

He'd felt it too.

And neither of them said a word.

Mydei exhaled, the sound soft, weary, like some heavy weight settled deeper into his chest. He pushed off the wall, closing the distance between them, his movements unhurried, almost careful.

Phainon tensed the moment he stepped close.

Mydei crouched slightly, one hand ghosting near Phainon's shoulder—not touching, just there. "What did you see?"

For a second, nothing. Just the uneven cadence of Phainon's breath, the twitch in his jaw.

Then—a sharp flinch, like instinct snapping through brittle nerves. He recoiled, not much, but enough. Shoulders tight, throat working like swallowing glass. His voice came hoarse, cracked.

"You said they'd do less tests."

The words landed harder than they should've. Like a blade between ribs. Mydei felt it—the way those words lodged under his skin, brittle and aching. His tongue pressed to the roof of his mouth, trying to shape something, anything in defense.

But no words came.

Phainon’s hands flexed in his restraints, colorless knuckles shaking with effort. And after a moment, quieter, eyes fixed somewhere past Mydei’s shoulder:

“…You weren’t there. It doesn’t matter what I saw.”

The room felt too still after that.

The comm crackled softly at Mydei’s hip. Hyacine’s voice came through, subdued, careful.

“Vitals are stabilizing, but the restraints… it might be doing more harm than good now. If he’s lucid—you can ease them. I’ll approve it.”

Mydei didn’t hesitate. He reached down, unfastening the restraint bands with efficient movements. The final one slipped free. Phainon didn’t react beyond a sharp flicker of his gaze, a look that landed somewhere just shy of resentment and exhaustion. He turned his head away, jaw tight. Conversation, clearly, over.

Mydei exhaled slowly.

He should’ve left. Every instinct said to.

Instead, he lowered himself to Phainon’s level, crouching again—not crowding him, just there, weight braced on one knee. Close enough to be felt but not pressed.

His voice was quiet. Steady.

“It matters to me.”

That earned a flicker of motion—a glance, wary and tired.

“You’re safe here,” Mydei added, words simple, heavy with the kind of certainty that didn’t beg for belief. “It’ll be alright soon.”

He rose, about to turn, knowing better than to linger. The quiet pressed in, thick as fog. The faint hum of the overhead monitors, the steady pulse of

the vitals feed—it all felt louder in absence of conversation.

Mydei's hand brushed the door control, the cool touch of the panel grounding. He should've left it at that.

But something made him glance back.

Phainon hadn't moved. His gaze fixed somewhere past the far wall, lashes low, jaw tight enough to crack. Beneath the bruises and the exhaustion, there was something fraying—an old fracture threatening to split open.

Mydei didn't speak. He just waited.

The seconds stretched, brittle.

Then—like something forced loose —

"…Back then," Phainon started, the words rough as gravel, "the only thing you could hear at night was the screaming."

A pause. A breath, sharp through his teeth.

"And the sound it made when it touched them."

His voice thinned at the edges, breaking down to something raw.

"You don't forget a sound like that."

The room held its breath.

And Mydei, for all the things he could've said—didn't.

He let the quiet settle around them like a shield. Then moved for the door, tension low in his frame, leaving space where no words would fit.

He knew when someone wanted to be alone. And sometimes mercy wasn't words—it was the space you left behind.

The door slid shut in his wake.

Mydei lingered there a moment, the faint sound of the lock cycling into place unusually loud in the stillness. He let his hand drop from the panel, flexed his fingers once, and drew a slow breath.

The hallway beyond was dim, quiet in that late-hour way only medical wings ever were. Hyacine was waiting a few paces down, leaning against the wall with her datapad half-forgotten in one hand. She straightened at the sight of him, scanning his face for something she didn't bother to ask aloud.

"How is he?" she murmured.

"Alive." Mydei's voice was rougher than he meant it to be. "Lucid enough to be pissed off. That's something."

Hyacine's lips tugged in a tired, fleeting half-smile. "Vitals stabilized while you were in there. If it holds through tonight, I can start the recalibrations early. Two days ahead of schedule, if we're lucky."

He grunted softly, the edge of a smirk flickering at his mouth. "Spoil him too much, he'll start expecting special treatment."

"I think he's earned it," she said, quiet.

They let the moment settle there, the hum of nearby equipment filling the space between them. It was a fragile kind of peace — the kind built on mutual exhaustion and too many unspoken things.

Then Mydei spoke again, too casually.

"When was the last time Flame Reaver sightings and power grid malfunctions happened in the same district?"

The words hung there. Heavy. Unwelcome.

Hyacine's expression froze, the datapad screen flickering faintly in her grasp. A second passed. Then another.

When she spoke, her voice was careful, laced with something wary. "Are you implying—"

“No.” The denial came fast, harder than he meant it to, but he didn’t soften it.

His gaze stayed fixed on her, unreadable in the dim light. Not an accusation. Just a dark, restless thing twisting behind his ribs.

“Goldweaver’s got a lead now, doesn’t she?” Mydei said, quieter this time. “It won’t be long.”

He pushed away from the wall, steps measured, the weight of the night heavy on his shoulders.

Hyacine didn’t stop him. Didn’t speak.

The hallway stretched on ahead, empty but for the low flicker of the overhead lights — one of them stuttering faintly, unnoticed.

And Mydei didn’t look back.

Not because he didn’t want to.

Because some part of him already knew.

Chapter End Notes

> For everyone sick of the whole repetition of the Node and memory things, I promise y’all I’m gonna try to wrap that arc up sooner or later
>
> I still wanna keep the whole comedic slice of life plot, but I do also need some things to go happen so the whole reveal and post-reveal happen as well. Point is, I hope this isn’t pivoting too far from the og plot😭
>
> Phainon’s ability reveal is gonna be next chapter by the way (Though someone already guessed it, kudos to them) so that’s sm to look forward to😍😍😍

Speaking of, reveal is like pretty soon. Like, REALLY close. Don’t know how I’m gonna go with it, but be ready (Gonna test out my nonexistent angst skills😫)

Chapter 11: Phainon vs. The Shelf Box: A Love Story

Chapter Summary

> Phainon accidentally glitches half the campus while having a breakdown, bleeds everywhere, ends up in his boyfriend's library (again), gets caught (again), and proceeds to emotionally unravel in Mydei's lap while aggressively cuddling him. Threats are made against innocent shelving units. Affection is weaponized. Somewhere in the distance, Anaxa's migraine worsens

Chapter Notes

> Oof this one was a doozy, y'all think I can finish this before 3.4? I'm gonna try to get to chapter 12-13 before version 3.3, wish me luck😍

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon was ninety percent sure his nutrient paste was plotting his murder.

It stared up at him with the consistency and flavor profile of wet cardboard abandoned in a server room. He jabbed at it with a spork—because in this wretched, chronically underfunded hellscape of an academic institution, forks had been declared "a hazard to metaphysical integrity" after last semester's Incident. Capital I.

Next to him, Dan Heng existed in his usual state of unbothered neutrality, methodically eating cubes of something that might've once been chicken while reading an ancient-looking book titled *Entropy and the Artificial Soul: A Treatise*. In Latin.

Dan Heng wasn't even enrolled in his department. Or his lectures. Or his building. Phainon was a debates professor; Dan Heng was a literature and cybersecurity dual-major with the social presence of a very well-read cloud of passive-aggressive fog. And yet, without fail, every time Phainon's life

derailed, this man materialized within a five-foot radius like a cursed NPC bound by invisible proximity triggers.

Phainon sighed, resting his face in one palm.

Rock bottom, he thought grimly, *is trauma-dumping to a guy only here for the vending machine*.

“Did you know,” Phainon began, poking his nutrient paste hard enough to make it shudder, “that these nutrient cubes are technically made of repurposed protein strings salvaged from terminated simulation loops?”

Dan Heng didn’t look up. “Makes sense. Entropy recycles.”

“Right?!” Phainon gestured emphatically with his spork, like this was a TED Talk attended exclusively by himself and one very tired-looking student. “Which means technically we’re all just repurposed glitches pretending to be real.”

Dan Heng turned a page. “You sound unwell.”

“Thanks, man. That means a lot.”

Phainon listlessly resumed stirring his paste. It made a wet, squelching noise like someone rebooting a corpse.

He sniffled.

And with a quiet, muted pop—the spork in his hand abruptly rethreaded itself into a perfect, polished metal pretzel.

Phainon blinked at it.

The universe, apparently, was doing bits now.

Carefully, without moving his head, he shifted his eyes to Dan Heng.

Nothing. The man didn’t so much as twitch.

Phainon cleared his throat. “Just uh… metaphysical turbulence. Happens to the best of us.”

Dan Heng, still reading, deadpanned, “You should see an educated professional about that.”

“I am an educated professional.”

A long, contemplative beat.

“Well. Get a second opinion.”

Phainon dropped the pretzel-spork back into the nutrient paste with a resigned *splorch*.

This was his life now.

It had been, what… a week? Two? Time blurred when you were neck-deep in metaphysical crises and minor war crimes. Since detainment, since that place, since he’d woken up in a hospital bed with his powers twitchy and his mind full of holes, staring at Mydei’s stupid, annoyingly flawless face.

He still didn’t know how Mydei pulled it off. Getting him out of the Council’s clutch should’ve been impossible—even for a Librarian. Especially for a Librarian.

Unless it wasn’t just him.

He didn’t like thinking about it. Which was why he hadn’t made eye contact with Mydei in nearly nine days, three hours, and twenty-six minutes. Not that he was counting.

Because if he did—if he so much as held that gaze a second too long—Phainon was ninety percent certain he’d spontaneously confess to treason, accessory to digital sedition, several counts of high metaphysical misconduct, and at least one incident involving the unauthorized reconfiguration of Council property into a giant flaming middle finger.

And the worst part was, somewhere under the jokes and deadpan banter, the dread sat.

Heavy.

Because he remembered what he said in that room. What he *gave away.*

And if anyone else did too—if it was on record, if it slipped through—he was already dead.

“Entropy recycles,” Dan Heng murmured again, turning another page like he hadn’t just dropped an accidental prophecy.

Phainon glanced over.

“Seriously, man,” he said, voice a little too loud, a little too sharp. “Stop saying shi—ahem, stuff like that.”

Dan Heng raised a brow, unbothered. “You started it.”

Fair.

Phainon grinned at the room like a man standing on a ledge and daring gravity to try him.

“Alright, moral degenerates,” he announced, dropping his datapad onto the desk with a dramatic clack. “Today’s debate prompt: If given access to an infallible predictive algorithm, should governments be allowed to preemptively detain citizens based on potential future crimes? Discuss.”

A beat.

The class stared at him.

Caelus, bless his eternally half-awake soul, raised a tentative hand. “Uh… isn’t that basically that one old dystopia sim?”

“Which one?” Phainon snapped, spinning to face the board like he was about to write down the secret to immortality. “We’ve had like fifty. Name your totalitarian flavor.”

“The one with the psychic cops.”

“Oh. *Preemptive Judgment Eight-Three-Seven*. Good reference. Two points for Caelus.”

He scrawled a giant, barely legible “+2” on the board like it meant something. It didn’t.

Stelle side-eyed him. “Professor, are you good? You’re kinda—” she made a vague spiraling motion with her finger “—today.”

Phainon grinned wider. “Define *good,* Stelle. Define today.”

The students exchanged looks. None of them moved to leave. They knew better by now.

“Debates,” Phainon declared, pacing like a caged apex predator. “A battle of wills, wits, and the occasional legally inadmissible threat. Real life application: how to talk your way out of government custody without crying.”

A long, slightly deranged beat.

“Hypothetically.”

Another beat.

He clapped his hands. The lights flickered. Nobody even flinched.

Somewhere in the back, one of the power conduits made a sad little *bzzt*.

Phainon’s smile faltered for half a second before snapping back into place like elastic.

He was fine.

He was *great*.

He was totally not spiraling into metaphysical paranoia because his morally dubious hopefully and lovingly still boyfriend hadn’t looked him in the eye for over a week and might be plotting either a date or a public execution.

“Anyway,” he said brightly, gesturing to the class. “Split into pairs. Someone defend the algorithm. Someone oppose it. Winner gets… I dunno, one of my backup access codes.”

“Is that legal?” Caelus asked.

“Debatable,” Phainon chirped.

And just like that, the students moved into groups, like this was perfectly normal.

Because for them, it was.

Phainon grabbed an eraser off the desk, mind still halfway in his own impending existential collapse, and absentmindedly squeezed it as he paced.

It burst into flame.

A small, miserable aetheric fire, flickering a sickly blue at the edges.

No one even turned their heads.

Not a single student flinched. No one asked if it was part of the lesson. Caelus didn’t even blink.

Stelle sighed, reaching into her bag like a veteran of too many low-grade supernatural crises, and pulled out a standard-issue fire suppressant stick. She pointed it at the burning eraser, pressed the button, and a puff of white foam snuffed out the flame with a pathetic *fzzzt*.

“Three this week,” she muttered, checking something off on her phone.

Phainon didn’t even stop pacing.

Because again, this was his life now.

While the students bickered over some ethics-of-televised-trials debate topic he absolutely didn't remember assigning, Phainon slumped down onto the edge of his desk like a man freshly mauled by a metaphorical bear. The wood groaned beneath him in solidarity.

God, he was tired.

Not in the *I stayed up too late doomscrolling Council leaks again way.* No —this was marrow-deep, head-splitting, *can't tell if I'm hallucinating or astral-projecting but either way I'm gonna throw up* tired.

He rubbed at his temple, and felt the faintest trickle of blood from one nostril. Cute.

The thing was—and this was a thing—at some point over the past week or two (post-detainment, post-interrogation, post-fucking-nightmare), his internal scaffolding had cracked.

He didn't have a better word for it. Anaxa called them his "ideal form templates." Little mental blueprints he kept in the back of his brain—structures for how reality *should* behave when he reached out and twisted it. They made things neat. Predictable. Safe.

Without them?

Well.

Now his power ran off subconscious, half-feral dream-logic. Instinctual belief systems forged in grief, caffeine, and denial. Every emotional spike a potential catastrophic misfire. Every burst of frustration or god forbid, *fond thought* a chance for the nearest pen to combust, reality seams to knot themselves wrong, or that one time yesterday when his comm decided it was a moth and tried to fly out the window.

It wasn't even that he used his power that much. Not unless he had to. But now the barrier was hair-trigger thin. It bled through in the margins, in

headaches that felt like his brain was trying to fold itself inside out, in flashes of static in the corners of his vision. In little things.

Like setting an eraser on fire.

Phainon sighed, leaning his head back against the wall.

As Anaxa liked to call it—Conceptual Creation. Reality-bending, if you wanted to sound pretentious. Which he often did.

But it wasn't *creation* in the true sense. No summoning something from nothing unfortunately. It was structure. Imposing pattern on chaos. Reconfiguring broken threads of reality and code, reworking corrupted aether, glitching systems, raw energy fields. If a place was stable, if everything was ordered and proper? He was powerless.

If it cracked? If it buckled, if entropy bled through, if the code frayed at the edges or the aether warped under pressure—*then* he could slip a needle in. *Then* he could stitch.

Weapons, sigils, doorways, conceptual barriers. Made not of matter, but of bent logic and realigned cause-and-effect. A flame-shaped dagger formed because he *believed* a dagger could hold the shape of flame if you threaded a reality seam just so.

Dream-logic engineering.

The more complicated the weave, the worse the backlash. Which was fine, back when his templates kept things tethered. Back when every creation came with clean edges and a neat little cost.

Now, without those, it was chaos. Every jagged spike of grief or anger or—god help him—*affection* could trigger a misfire.

It was partially another reason why he'd been dodging *him*.

Phainon made a noise, covering his face with one hand.

God, he missed his boyfriend.

There it was. The absolute state of him.

He didn’t even have it in him to self-censor anymore.

From across the room, a half-hearted argument about legal personhood rights for rogue AI floated over.

He groaned louder.

Phainon dragged both hands down his face now, took a deep, ragged breath through his nose—and immediately regretted it because blood.

He forced his head sideways, ignoring the sharp throb in his temple, and squinted blearily at the clock mounted above the classroom’s front console.

Two minutes.

Two goddamn minutes.

The only thing standing between him and blissful, dead-eyed solitude.

For a moment, he debated just growling *“Get the fuck out,”* and calling it pedagogical tough love. But some dim, flickering remnant of professional shame made him hold his tongue. He didn’t have the energy for the complaints form that would generate. Again.

Instead, he sat up abruptly—a little too fast, the room tilting nauseatingly—and slapped both hands onto the desk with a wide, unhinged grin.

“WELL,” Phainon declared, loud enough to make at least three students jump. “Fantastic discourse today! Excellent ethical chaos. Remember, kids: when in doubt, argue in bad faith and see what happens.”

A student gave him a look.

The rest of the class stared in wary, collective silence—not the *is this part of the lesson?* silence of week one, but *the if we stay very still, maybe he won’t snap the laws of physics again silence of seasoned survivors.*

Phainon clapped once, the sound sharp and a little too enthusiastic.

“Class dismissed!” he chirped.

Chairs scraped. Bags rustled. No one spoke. They shuffled out like cautious evacuees from a structurally unsound building, giving his desk a respectful five-foot radius.

Even Stelle didn’t bother putting the fire suppressant back in its case. She just left it on the front row seat like a grim little offering.

Phainon slumped back against the desk, exhaling through his teeth.

Merciful silence.

He stayed exactly where he was for a long, dragging second.

Eyes half-lidded. Breathing shallow. Head pounding like some ancient god was using his skull for percussion practice. He waited for the worst of the ache to pass—the sharp, searing bolt behind his eyes fading into a dull, electric throb.

When he could move without retching, Phainon sluggishly reached into his coat pocket, fumbling for the slim, battered comm tab.

Thumbed it open.

No sarcastic voice message this time. Just a quick, quiet ping sent straight to Anaxa’s secure line:

[hurry the fuck up.]

A beat.

[u said a few days at most. i am rapidly approaching ‘most.’]

He closed his eyes and let the device rest on his knee, waiting for the inevitable snarky reply. He didn’t care what it said. As long as it came. As long as someone out there was fixing this mess.

Fixing *him*.

Phainon’s break wasn’t so much a “break” as it was him slumped in a corner booth of the empty campus café, staring blankly into a cup of what the vending machine had promised was coffee.

It tasted like rust.

He stirred it anyway, watching the sludge swirl around like the event horizon of some tiny, caffeine-based black hole.

“So this is it,” Phainon muttered to nobody. “Drinking battery acid in the metaphysical equivalent of a war crime, contemplating whether job abandonment constitutes treason if you do it quietly.”

He took a sip. Immediately regretted it.

“God, what is this? Ground-up despair with notes of public transport floor?”

Somewhere behind him, the register made a distressed, warbling beep.

He didn’t look up.

“Kinda wish it killed me,” he told the universe, swirling the cup again.

A figure slid into the booth across from him, casual as you please.

“Careful,” came Anaxa’s voice, dry as ever. “If you die in here, your corpse legally belongs to the Department of Paracausal Waste Management.”

Phainon blinked, dragging his gaze up to meet Anaxa’s. The man looked marginally worse than usual—hair a little messier, eyes a little heavier, like whatever hell Phainon was enduring, Anaxa had met it, shared a drink, and then scammed it for spare parts.

“…Did you just hack the register?” Phainon asked, because one of the wall monitors was flickering *GET FUCKED MOTHERFUCTER* in corrupted

text strings.

Anaxa, still half-typing on his portable terminal, didn’t even look up. “Wouldn’t pay out my loyalty points.”

Phainon made a sound that was halfway between a laugh and a dying animal.

“God I missed you,” he muttered.

Anaxa snorted. “Yeah, well. Don’t get attached. You’re insufferable when you get clingy.”

“That’s rich, coming from the guy who broke into my server cache to leave me memes.”

“I was being supportive.”

“It was thirty-seven consecutive images of a dog on fire.”

Anaxa finally looked up, the corner of his mouth twitching into something like a smile. “And you’re still alive. See? Support.”

Phainon stared at him for a long, tired beat.

“Anaxa,” he muttered, letting his head thunk against the table, voice muffled against the cold surface. “I’m one minor inconvenience away from setting myself on fire out of spite.”

“Good,” Anaxa replied, going back to his terminal. “I need the energy to finish bypassing government firewalls. Stay mad, princess.”

Phainon sighd. The absolute worst part?

That *was* supportive, in Anaxa-speak.

“Nancy’s doing the waltz in Sector Seven.”

Anaxa said it like it was the most normal thing to utter in the middle of a half-condemned university café.

Phainon blinked. "…The hell does that mean?"

Anaxa didn't answer right away—just stared at him, the subtle kind of look that told Phainon to shut up and pay attention. His stomach dropped a millimeter.

"Oh," Phainon muttered. "It's one of those."

"Yeah," Anaxa said, casually tapping a key sequence. The lights overhead hummed. "One of those."

They lapsed into a weird, scratchy quiet, the flickering café monitor still scrolling some glitchy nonsense about "SOUL TAX EXCEEDED." Phainon took another sip of his coffee. It did not improve.

"I swear to god, Anaxa," Phainon sighed, "if this is another metaphor for you stealing library servers again—"

"It's not," Anaxa said, eyes still fixed on the screen. "This time it's the council's main grid."

Phainon almost choked.

"I told you to leave that alone!"

"I did," Anaxa said mildly. "And then I didn't."

A long, jittery beat.

Phainon leaned back, running a hand down his face. "Okay. Talk slow. Explain like I'm concussed. 'Cause I probably am."

Anaxa exhaled through his nose, expression flat. "The waltz is their internal sweep protocol. Nancy's their codename for any asset flagged for high-priority surveillance. Sector Seven's the upper clearance tier reserved for nation-breakers and abstract anomalies."

Phainon frowned, brain sluggishly untangling the metaphor web. “Okay… and?”

Anaxa finally looked up, the sharp line of his jaw tensing. “They bumped someone to top-tier clearance officially this morning. Seems like it’s been there for a while before that though. Full immediate termination protocol. No trial. No retrieval. Just wipe.”

Phainon’s pulse hiccupped. A faint, sourceless flicker rippled through the ceiling lights.

“…Who?” he asked, though something in him already knew.

Anaxa held his gaze for a long, stretched moment.

“Flame Reaver.”

The world dropped out for half a breath. The café’s old streetlamp buzzed outside, flickering once—in perfect sync with the throb of Phainon’s pulse slamming against his skull.

“That—” Phainon’s voice cracked halfway. He cleared it. “That doesn’t make sense. We’ve been careful with the important things. We’ve been ghosts. Even if they suspected, top-tier’s for things that can glass continents or...”

Anaxa’s face was stone, fingers twitching at his terminal. “Yeah. That’s why I hacked the grid.”

Phainon sat back hard, head pounding in a way that wasn’t entirely metaphor.

“God,” he muttered. “What did I miss.”

Anaxa didn’t answer. The absence of explanation was a bullet in its own right.

They sat there for a while, the brittle quiet only broken by the distant hum of server fans and the dull pulse of his own panic. Then Anaxa stood,

shouldering his bag.

“Anyway,” he said, his voice the same easy, wry thing it always was. “If you see Nancy…”

Phainon looked up, throat tight.

“Tell her the waltz is over.”

And then he was gone.

Leaving Phainon alone with his coffee sludge, a throbbing headache, and the creeping, awful knowledge that something had gone terribly, impossibly wrong.

The day, against all odds, got worse.

Phainon forced himself into *everything’s fine* mode with the sheer, unhinged commitment of a man on the edge of his third consecutive breakdown. He graded finals in his office like an *actual educator*, as though the entire infrastructure of his life wasn’t actively collapsing beneath him.

“Let’s see here…” he muttered, flipping a paper over. “‘Debate Question 3: In a closed system of moral decay, who holds authority over the unverifiable self?’” He squinted. “Okay, not bad, a little pretentious—”

The text shimmered.

His brow furrowed.

It flickered again, letters warping into something sharp and jagged before settling into neat, eldritch cursive:

”I saw the god beneath the latticework of stars and fed it my name.”

Phainon blinked. “…Okay, so, uh… bonus points for thematic commitment?”

He grabbed a red pen, circled it, and wrote *‘citation needed’*. Moved on.

Across his desk, the paperweight shivered.

A tiny, anguished *chirp* rose from it.

Phainon glanced up just in time to watch the glossy metal orb sprout brittle, beady eyes and a rapidly flapping set of wings. It screamed. A shrill, existential wail of tiny avian horror.

Without missing a beat, he grabbed a coffee mug and slammed it over the thing. The shriek muffled instantly. He slid a sticky note onto the cup that read *“DO NOT OPEN—metaphysical hazard”*.

“Anyway,” he sighed, reaching for the next exam.

The lights in the office flickered.

A knock came at the door—which then politely opened itself before he touched it.

He didn’t even flinch.

A student poked their head in. “Um, Professor Phainon? You’re, uh… bleeding again.”

Phainon dabbed under his nose. Came away with a smear of dark red.

“Yeah,” he said tiredly, “I do that sometimes.”

The student lingered a second too long, then quietly closed the door.

He sighed. The shadows under his desk stretched, curling like ink dropped in water. The reflection in his monitor blinked out of sync with his own.

“Normal,” Phainon muttered. “Perfectly normal. This is fine.”

The debate final in front of him rewritten itself again.

“The lattice will break. The tide is coming. Only the hollow king endures.”

“Okay,” Phainon muttered, capping his pen. “Pass.”

Phainon shoved the debate finals into a folder that didn’t actually exist. One second it was a folder, the next it flickered out of phase, and honestly? Same. He rubbed at the smear of blood beneath his nose with the heel of his hand and rose to his feet, ignoring the way the text on the last paper twisted into *confessions of forbidden rites performed beneath the twin moons.* That was probably fine. He gave it a B+ for creativity.

He slipped out of his office, shoulders stiff. A couple of students passed him, one of them snorting out a laugh over some brain-dead meme about a sentient machine uprising in Wing C. Their chatter blurred, words stretching and thinning like sound passed through static.

A decorative plant by the wall bent away from him as he passed, leaves shriveling at the edges. He ignored it.

Phainon ducked into the nearest supply closet with all the grace of a man fleeing tax evasion charges. Pulled the door shut behind him and slumped against the wall, cold metal biting through his shirt. Dust motes spun lazy constellations in the single beam of flickering light from the ceiling.

His head felt like a radio tuned to the wrong frequency. Thoughts overlapping thoughts. Memory bleed. The leftover static of a thousand thoughts trying to scrape meaning out of him. The soft, ever-present buzz of reality straining under his skin.

A laugh scraped out of his throat. Bitter.

“Damn,” he muttered to himself, “I am two bad hours and a government-sanctioned blackout away from buying a one-way ticket to the void.”

The supply room smelled like old printer toner and something vaguely lemon-scented. He tilted his head back against the wall, letting his eyes

half-lid, just for a second, until the afterimage of strange symbols he hadn’t meant to see scorched his eyelids.

Somewhere behind the stacked boxes of requisition forms and abstract-approved markers, a faint tapping started. He didn’t check.

His gaze snagged on the glass pane of a cabinet across the room. His reflection stared back—but the edges of his face rippled, blurring and warping like heat haze. Eyes too cold. A unreadable frown where his mouth hadn’t moved.

He looked away.

The tapping stopped.

“Not now,” Phainon told the room, voice brittle. “I’m booked ‘til Thursday.”

He shoved the door open and stepped back into the hallway like nothing happened.

Phainon barely made it three steps down the hall before March appeared, materializing out of nowhere like some aggressively optimistic poltergeist.

“Professor Phainon!” she beamed, practically bouncing in place. “Hey, are you—um, are you okay? You look kinda…” She made a vague gesture around her own face, a circle of concern. “Like, headache?”

He managed a crooked grin. “March, if I were any more okay, I’d be dead.”

She blinked. “That’s… not comforting.”

And before he could slap together another quip, his abilities surged.

The lights overhead flickered, stretching into long, twitching streaks of color. Time hitched, the sound of March’s voice warping like a tape spool unraveling. The walls breathed.

Phainon felt the pulse of it—like something inside his skull tuning every radio in a five-mile radius to the wrong channel.

He cleared his throat. “Office hours are over.”

And without waiting for a response, he spun on his heel and power-walked away at a speed just shy of undignified.

March stood there, watching him go, baffled. The lights settled. The air stopped crackling.

“…Kay, see you next week!”

A metallic tang hit the back of Phainon’s throat a second before the umpteenth nosebleed did—a single, sharp drop onto the floor, flickering faintly like old TV static before settling into ordinary crimson.

He dabbed it with the cuff of his sleeve, sighing. *On brand.*

The hallway ahead was empty, save for the soft buzz of ceiling lights and the scuff of his boots against tile. Except… then it wasn’t.

A low hum bled through the walls. Not music surprisingly. His own voice.

Layered, warped, fragments peeling off one another in messy overlaps.

“I don’t know what you want from me—” “They’re not supposed to—”
“I’m fine, Anaxa. It’s fine. I’m fine.”
”I’ll tell you whatever you want, just don’t—”

It bled out of the walls like radio static, old grief folded over itself. Faint, at first. Then louder. The closer he moved toward the door at the end of the hall, the more it closed in. The floor felt thinner. The air warped.

Phainon slowed.

Stopped.

The sound cut like a switch flipped.

A long, hollow silence.

He stared at the door a beat longer than he should've.

"…Nope."

Pivoted clean on his heel and took the long way around.

Phainon stood in the elevator, shoulders hunched, back to the mirrored wall, clutching his phone like it was the only thing tethering him to the waking world. His thumb tapped anxiously against the case.

The hum of the fluorescent lights above gnawed at his ears. Too loud. He forced a breath in through his nose, out through his teeth.

Grounding exercises.

Anaxa's rules. Count. Focus. Stay inside your skull, don't let the seams unravel.

Phainon lifted his gaze to the ancient floor panel display above the doors. The numbers flicked by—3… 4… B7… 44… ∞… 03:AM… ERROR.

His eye twitched.

"Nope. Totally fine," he muttered, voice a frayed thread of mock reassurance. "Normal elevator things. Definitely real numbers. Couldn't be more regulated."

He counted the pixels in the faulty display. Forty-nine. Forty-eight, no—forty-nine again. They pulsed, jittering in and out of alignment like reality buffering on a bad connection.

The mirrored wall behind him caught his reflection a beat too late, movements half a second off. His reflection blinked when he didn't.

Phainon’s fingers twitched. A stray, silver-blue spark crackled at his knuckles. The fluorescent lights above stuttered, throwing the cramped metal box into a half-second strobe. He shoved his hands into his coat pockets, jaw tight, forcing his breath steady.

Name objects. Count anchors. Hold it together, Phainon.

“Ceiling light,” he rasped to himself. “Floor panel. My phone. My… dignity. Somewhere.”

The elevator lurched, brakes catching, the hum of the world snapping clean. The display, mercifully, settled on 2. No ERROR, no infinity, no 03:AM.

The doors slid open.

A student waited outside, earbuds in, backpack slung low, nodding along to some track Phainon couldn’t hear. The kid’s face went still the moment their eyes met. Something primal, subconscious, like a deer realizing the trees aren’t trees at all.

The kid flinched.

Phainon, exhausted, managed a tight, weak smile.

“Not a good day for elevators, kid. Take the stairs.”

He didn’t wait for a response. Just stepped out, brushed past, the hum of the elevator closing behind him.

His pulse thrummed sharp in his ears. He didn’t unclench his fists until he turned the next corner.

His next location was the courtyard behind the lecture hall. A cracked, overgrown stone path, rusted-out benches swallowed by ivy, the occasional stray energy lamp flickering overhead. Perfect spot for anxious breakdowns, illicit deals, or pretending you didn’t exist.

Phainon cut through it on autopilot, boots scuffing over loose gravel, the pounding in his head getting louder by the second.

He rubbed a hand over his face. His skin felt too thin, stretched too tight over the bone. The aether currents in the air were wrong. Off-key. Subtle pressure drops in his peripheral vision. Everything about this day had been *wrong*.

“You’re fine,” he muttered under his breath. “Totally fine. Doing excellent, ten outta ten mental health. It’s not like you’re about two decibels away from turning a student into a conceptual cipher. Definitely not.”

A leaf blew past. It spun in the air in a way leaves shouldn’t spin.

He picked up his pace.

Started counting steps. Listing colors. Running through grounding exercises Anaxa drilled into him back when his head was clearer.

One, two, three—

“Professer?”

His name, called soft behind him.

It hit like a bullet. His entire body jolted, muscles seizing. The world *tilted*.

Not metaphorically.

Literally.

The ground under his feet warped, a fracture line splitting across matter. It was subtle at first—a shimmer in the air, like heat rising off asphalt. Then sharper. The sky twisted at the edges of his vision. The courtyard stones spiderwebbed beneath him, cracks forming not on the surface, but behind it, like a pane of glass held up against the world was shattering.

A static hum bled through the air.

He turned, pulse slamming so hard it echoed in his ears.

Dan Heng was there, a book in one hand, brows drawn in quiet concern, oblivious to the teeth of dimensional fracture snapping open a breath behind him.

A rift. Silver-blue, jagged like the world had been peeled back.

For half a second, Phainon didn’t move.

He felt it rise inside him—the place bucking loose, unspooling, licking at the seams of reality, eager to make something worse.

Stop. Stop. Lock it down—

His hands shook.

He slammed the brakes, locking every frayed thought into place by sheer instinct. His head screamed, pressure building like his brain was going to split at the seams. Blood broke from his nose again, thick and hot, crackling with static like old TV snow for a heartbeat before settling into normal crimson.

Dan Heng’s eyes flicked to it. Not to the rift. Not to the warping air. Just the blood.

“You’re bleeding again,” he said, voice cautious but steady as ever.

Phainon swallowed back bile, his grin sharp and splintered.

“If I tell you to leave right now for your own safety, you’ll do it, yeah?”

Dan Heng hesitated. Not long. He knew Phainon’s serious tone when he heard it.

“…Yeah.”

He backed away, slipping out the way he came, quick, efficient.

The moment he was out of range, the rift hissed closed with a wet, too-real sound. The world flexed. Reality rethreaded itself with a whisper, the

courtyard settling like a body exhaling after a held breath.

Phainon just stood there.

The taste of copper in his mouth. The burn in his sinuses. Blood on his hands, drying sticky against his skin.

If that'd slipped just a second faster—

No.

He didn't finish it.

Couldn't.

Instead, he wiped his face on his sleeve, let out a sharp breath, and laughed —brittle, humorless.

"Yeah. Okay. Normal fuckin' Tuesday."

And kept moving.

Phainon left the courtyard behind like he always did—fast, head down, pretending it didn't happen. It was a one-off. Glitch in the system. He'd had worse. Statistically speaking.

He cut through one of the older back wings of campus, the one no one bothered to renovating. The overhead lights flickered with the kind of lazy indifference only decades of bad wiring could produce.

But it was quiet.

And quiet was good.

His boots clacked against the floor in steady rhythm. One, two, three, four. A pattern. He focused on the sound, the weight of each step. It helped. Until it didn't.

Because about halfway down the corridor—another set of footsteps joined in.

Soft. Half a beat behind his own.

Phainon slowed. The second set didn’t.

Okay.

He glanced over his shoulder. Empty hall. Nothing but dim overheads, a warped window pane, a crooked bench against the wall. He waited. Silence.

He sighed. “Alright.”

Kept walking.

But the sound came too. Always a little off, just slightly behind, like something almost learning the rhythm of his steps but not quite getting it right.

He passed a wall scuff—a jagged little scrape shaped like a lopsided crescent moon.

Then passed it again.

And again.

The third time, his gut went cold.

A door on his left, one he could’ve sworn was supposed to be boarded over, hung slightly ajar. Beyond it: nothing but dark. Something moved inside. A sound like paper dragging against stone.

Phainon didn’t stop. Didn’t look in.

The floor underfoot sloped. Barely. But enough.

The overhead lights began to hum. Not a normal electric buzz—a frequency he wasn’t supposed to hear. It rattled in his teeth, made his molars ache. The

air thinned out. His skin prickled.

In the glass of a long-forgotten trophy case, his reflection flickered—a second behind, lagging like a bad video feed.

His throat tightened. “Totally fine,” he muttered, pulling his coat tighter around him. “Normal hallway things. Definitely real numbers on these doors. Very cool.”

A twitch in his vision. A ripple at the edges of his sight like heat off asphalt.

He swallowed. Willed it down.

The fountain in the courtyard outside the window froze mid-flow, water jittering in place, flickering between solid, liquid, something else. A dead branch curled inward, folding into itself like an origami figure handled too roughly.

Don’t look. Just walk.

The posters on the wall shifted every time he passed them—Debate Club Meet Tonight, then a Memorial Vigil for a name he didn’t recognize, then a stark, blood-smudged warning: **DO NOT FOLLOW IT HOME.**

His stomach flipped.

Still—sarcasm.

“You know, would love if literally anyone else was seeing this. Just for fun.”

His own voice sounded wrong. Thin, high in his ears.

He picked up the pace.

The hallway stretched, elongated just a little more with every step. Doors on the left now on the right. Windows vanishing when not looked at directly. The sound of footsteps behind him doubled. A half-beat behind. Close now.

He forced a bitter laugh, speaking louder.

“Hate it here. Hate it more now. Not a huge fan of whatever fresh Blair Witch found footage glitchcore bullshit this is.”

It was a joke.

It felt like the last one he had left.

Then—a window ahead.

His reflection stared at him. Lagged half a second behind. And *smiled*.

He stopped cold.

The air thickened. The sound of his own pulse slammed in his ears.

No footsteps now. None needed.

The walls on either side of him *breathed*—expanding on the inhale, contracting on the exhale. The posters on the wall all showed his own face now. Not quite right. The eyes empty, a little too wide.

His sarcasm evaporated.

His feet moved on their own—from a quick stride to a sharp jog. A desperate, brittle half-run.

The corridor blurred around him. Doors stretched impossibly tall. Light fixtures flickered, one sparking blue-white. Tables and chairs jittered in and out of place like buffering video frames. The hallway turned—and deposited him right back at the same corner, same scuffed wall, same open door bleeding darkness.

And still, something behind him.

He could feel it in his teeth. In the static charge on his skin.

Blood slicked warm from his nose again, down his upper lip.

He wiped it away with a trembling hand.

Didn’t dare look back.

The floor beneath him shivered. The walls twitched like muscle. The posters blinked with static.

His jog turned to a run.

Didn’t care if it looked insane. Didn’t care if someone saw.

Because something was behind him.

And if he looked—he knew it would have his face.

He didn’t remember when the run became a full on sprint.

Didn’t remember deciding to move faster—his body just *did.* His boots hammered against the floor, each step landing a fraction out of sync with the world around him. The corridor twisted as he moved, angles bending wrong, windows tilting down at him like watching eyes.

Every door he passed shuddered open an inch without him touching them.

A cold wind followed. From nowhere. Carrying the dry scent of old dust.

The lights snapped and buzzed overhead—one flaring too bright, then dead black. The hum set his teeth on edge. His ears ached with it. The walls seemed closer than before. Or maybe he was getting bigger. Or maybe the hallway was folding in on itself like an origami pattern made of brick and plaster and glass.

His breath scraped ragged in his throat.

He reached for a wall, meaning to steady himself, and the brick there pulsed under his palm—like flesh. Warm.

He yanked his hand back like it burned.

“Nope. Nope nope nope nope—”

The posters around him blurred. His own face. Names he almost remembered. Warnings meant for no one. He couldn’t focus on them now. Couldn’t focus on anything. It was like the air itself had weight, pressing down on him, crushing through his skull.

The floors shuddered.

A light fixture popped overhead, a single, sharp burst of blue-white that made the shadows stretch thin like oil across water. His own shadow dragged a half-second behind him, limbs too long, head tilted the wrong way.

Phainon stumbled. Didn’t stop.

A fountain he passed in a side alcove was glitching in and out of frame, water rising, freezing, then snapping into reverse. The plants in a corner planter recoiled from him, leaves curling, vines twitching like disturbed snakes like before but worse.

Just get outside.

The thought barely made it through the noise in his head. Every nerve sang with wrongness, his abilities clawing at the edges of things, warping everything he brushed against.

Windows blinked out. Door handles melted into the wall as he passed them. Every corner turned only led to another hallway that looked the same—but slightly *off*. Too long. Too narrow. Ceiling too low. Another half-step toward impossible geometry.

His vision blurred. The floor tilted.

Blood slicked his upper lip again, thick and hot.

He wasn’t even looking where he was going anymore, his focus shattered, steps uneven, limbs too heavy and too light at once. His heartbeat an arrhythmic pounding he could feel in his gums. Everything he touched

sparked—doors creaked open, shadows jittered, lights flickered like a warning.

“Get outside. Just—get—outside—”

He slammed through a final door without even registering what it was. The hinges screamed. Cold air hit him like a shock, sharp and biting, dragging a gasp from his lungs.

Grass underfoot. Distant floodlights bleeding into fog. The smell of damp earth and air.

It didn’t register.

Phainon kept running, not seeing the figures of other students scattered across the campus lawn, not hearing the muffled beats of someone’s portable speaker, not noticing the wary glances thrown his way.

The world felt thin. Loose at the seams. Like one bad thought might unravel it completely.

He finally saw an opening—a dark, narrow doorway set in a stretch of old stone wall. Half-open, light bleeding faintly from the other side like a slit in the night.

It could’ve been a sanctuary or a death sentence. Didn’t matter which. He didn’t think about it.

Phainon sprinted for it, boots skidding over damp ground, breath ragged. His hand slammed against the heavy wood, forcing it open. The hinges wailed like something dying, but he didn’t slow.

He staggered inside.

The moment he crossed the threshold, the air changed—cooler, dry, and dense in a way the outside hadn’t been. The world flexed around him, another pulse of invisible pressure like something uncoiling, then pulling tight.

He spun without thinking, grabbed the edge of the door, and slammed it shut behind him.

The heavy latch caught with a metallic *clack*. The echo of it shuddered through the space around him, too loud, too final.

For a moment, there was nothing but his own breathing, harsh and broken, blood running hot down his upper lip, his pulse roaring in his ears.

He leaned back against the thick wood, one arm braced against it as he fought to slow down, fought to pull the static back from the edges of his vision.

Didn’t register the warmth of polished stone under his feet.

Didn’t register the faint scent of paper in the air.

Didn’t notice how the world felt *contained* here.

Didn’t see the rows of tall, dark shapes in the gloom beyond him, shelves stretching high and far, lit by a few scattered lamps that hummed soft and steady.

Didn’t care.

His knees gave, and he sank down against the door, legs sprawled gracelessly, head tipping back to rest against the wood.

Blood slicked his palms, his ears, probably his throat now too.

Didn’t matter.

Didn’t open his eyes.

Didn’t want to.

“Alright,” he muttered to nobody, voice thin and cracked and almost a laugh. “Big fan of this. Ten out of ten. Just gonna sit here. Real normal choices happening tonight.”

And he did.

Too far gone to notice where he was.

Too far gone to realize it wasn’t over.

He let his head tip back, eyes half-lidded, staring up at nothing.

Delusions.

The thought came unbidden, lazy and offhanded, like an old friend dropping by to whisper in his ear.

They’d been worse lately. Shit like this—warped reflections, wrong doors, sounds with no source. Flickering walls, bleeding sky. The hum of his own voice in the static.

Some of it was real.

Some of it wasn’t.

And he was losing track of which was which.

Phainon let out a long, shaky breath, closing his eyes, pressing the heel of his blood-slick palm against one temple. His head throbbed like a muscle too long under strain, like a thousand tiny teeth gnawing at the edge of his brain.

It’s fine, he told himself.

Anaxa will fix this. He said a few days.

He exhaled again, tension bleeding off in a long, tired line.

It wasn’t fine. But he’d pretend a little longer.

The quiet around him felt too thick, the kind of silence that clings.

And then—as if the universe finally realized it owed him one good gut punch for the evening—a sharp, shrill voice cut through it like a siren.

"*Oh, oh dear!* Are you alright, son?"

Phainon's eyes snapped open. He squinted up.

An elderly woman, tiny, white-haired, one of those perfectly assembled types you knew had once run entire neighborhoods by sheer force of will alone, peered down at him over a pair of delicate glasses. Her expression hovered between concern and polite alarm.

For a moment, it didn't connect.

The space around him came into focus in pieces—the tall shelves, rows upon rows of old, meticulously arranged books, the heavy, steady tick of a clock somewhere nearby, the faint scent of paper and aged wood.

A…library.

Wait.

A *very specific* library.

Shit.

This was *Mydei's* library.

It hit him like a lead pipe.

He practically shot upright, too fast, blood rushing to his head in a dizzy lurch. He pasted on the most brittle, too-wide smile known to man.

"Oh, no worries at all, ma'am! Totally fine, you know, just taking a breather—love a good breather, me."

As if half his face wasn't smeared with drying blood.

He quickly stepped aside, opening the heavy door for her with a little flourish like a perfectly sane, perfectly unhorrifying individual. She offered him one last wary glance, clutching her book bag, and shuffled out.

The second the door shut behind her, Phainon's pulse spiked.

I gotta go. I gotta move. Now.

He turned on his heel, intent on making a break for it before anyone—

"Who the fuck—" a sharp voice started from somewhere between the shelves, edged with irritation and sharp timing, a stack of books cradled under one arm.

It softened at the end, the syllables folding into something wary. Familiar.

"…Phainon?"

He stopped cold.

Every muscle in his body locked up.

He knew that voice.

Knew it like a pressure point. Like gravity.

And it was, without question, the absolute last person he wanted seeing him like this.

He didn't even turn around. Just internally drafted his will and considered reincarnation.

Of course. Of course it's you.

Phainon sighed, and turned, half a grin already crooked at his mouth. "Heeeyyy."

Mydei didn't react at first. Just a glance up from the books in his hands, a flicker of surprise. The usual.

And then his gaze landed, locking onto Phainon’s face.

The blood. The pallor. The too-bright sheen to his eyes. A streak of dried red across his neck like a collar.

The books slipped from his grip, hitting the floor with a flat, dull sound.

Phainon winced. “Okay, not my most photogenic moment.”

Mydei didn’t laugh. He crossed the room in three strides, snatched a clean cloth from a counter like it was routine—because it was, wasn’t it? How many times had this happened now?

“Sit down,” he muttered, already locking the front door with a sharp flick of his wrist. The lights dimmed a little. The shopfront stilled.

Phainon hesitated, then dropped into the nearest armchair, hands loose on his knees, watching the way Mydei moved. Sharp, efficient, annoyed on the surface.

Except—

There. The smallest hitch.

A tremor in his hand as he rung out the cloth. Gone a second later, but Phainon caught it. And he didn’t know why, but it sat wrong. Lodged like a splinter under his skin.

The cloth was cold against his face, dragging away blood in clean strokes. Neither of them spoke for a long stretch. The only sounds were the faint tick of the clock overhead and the quiet rasp of cloth against skin.

“…Are you alright?”

Phainon opened his mouth, words already lining up.

Just peachy.

But then—again—that hand. Quick, steady. But a twitch, a tremor on the downswing. Not enough to notice unless you knew what Mydei's hands usually looked like. And Phainon did.

And something in him gave.

Not a dramatic collapse. Not some grand epiphany. Just a slow, creeping press of weight in his chest.

When had it gotten this easy to lie to him?

Phainon's throat worked. He tried the grin again. Couldn't quite find it.

"…No," he said quietly, voice scraping out of him like a bad wire. "It's not alright."

The cloth stilled.

Mydei didn't press. Just made a low sound in his throat—a frustrated, exhausted little huff—and kept cleaning the blood away like it was any other day.

And suddenly, he hated it. Hated knowing exactly how this would go. Hated that it wasn't even the worst scrape Mydei had cleaned up for him this month.

And before he could stop himself, he reached out, grabbed a fistful of Mydei's shirt, and tugged him down. Not hard. Just enough.

"What the—"

Phainon hauled him down until Mydei half-fell against him, braced awkwardly against the arm of the chair. Phainon tucked his face into the crook of Mydei's neck, the scent of old paper, ink, and sharp clean skin grounding him.

"It's really not," he mumbled, words feathering against skin.

Mydei let out a sigh. Not annoyed. Just tired. One hand came up, settling on the back of Phainon's head, fingers threading through tangled hair.

"Yeah," Mydei muttered. "I figured."

Neither of them moved for a long time.

At some point, Mydei must've fully slumped into his lap.

Phainon wasn't sure when. The world had softened at the edges, blurred into the steady warmth of another person against him, a grounding weight that made it a little easier to keep breathing.

His fingers moved absently, tracing nonsense patterns against Mydei's side through his shirt. Spirals. Loops. A jagged line.

Mydei shifted slightly, one arm draped lazily around Phainon's back, the other smoothing a stray bit of hair from his temple.

"Do you wanna talk about it?" Mydei asked. No gentle act—just there. Like the weight of his hand. Steady.

Phainon gave a dry little huff against his throat. "Not really."

"That's fine," Mydei murmured, the corner of his mouth twitching into something too tired to be a grin. "I can make fun of your haircut instead. That's still on the table."

Phainon snorted, the sound too close to a laugh for how hollow he felt. "Bold of you to insult a man literally bleeding on you."

"Occupational hazard," Mydei deadpanned.

The quiet stretched again. Phainon let it. His thumb catching along a seam in Mydei's shirt, grounding himself in the small, tangible things. The warmth beneath it. The steady, living thing that wasn't glitching apart.

He hadn't meant to say anything. He really hadn't.

But the words edged out like splinters from a wound that wouldn’t close.

“…What if I’m not who you think I am.”

It was soft. A fact he was unintentionally testing the weight of, seeing if Mydei has a reaction to it.

Mydei tensed—not much, but enough for Phainon to catch it. His hand stilled against the back of Phainon’s neck.

“Okay,” Mydei said after a beat, voice cautious. “You gonna elaborate, or should I guess wildly?”

Phainon smirked. It didn’t touch his eyes. “Could be fun. ‘Turns out I’m a cryptid’ was always my leading theory.”

“Phainon.”

His name hit harder than it should’ve.

Phainon sighed, forehead pressing tighter to Mydei’s shoulder. “I just… I don’t know. Some days it feels like I’m faking it. Like none of this—me, here, with you, teaching, existing—was ever supposed to stick.”

The air between them hung heavy. Phainon braced for it—the sarcastic jab, the harsh retort. A wall he could lean against.

But Mydei’s hand moved again, carding slowly through his hair. Not what Phainon expected. No lecture. No storm.

“You’re a fucking idiot,” Mydei muttered. But it was almost gentle. “A bleeding, sleep-deprived, emotionally constipated idiot. But you’re mine.”

And something sharp cracked in Phainon’s chest, quiet but clean.

“Yeah,” he rasped, eyes shutting. “Yours.”

And for right now—for this small, warped piece of quiet—it was enough.

The quiet settled again, less suffocating this time. Phainon's fingers slowed, tracing the faint line of a seam beneath his hand—then paused.

His brow furrowed.

"Wait," he murmured, squinting in the low light. "Is that a new scar?"

Mydei stiffened just a little, a muscle in his jaw ticking. "…No?"

Phainon leaned back, just enough to catch the curve of it along Mydei's side beneath the hem of his shirt. His gaze sharpened in that way Mydei had learned to be immediately wary of.

"I swear to every god left in this rotted plane," Phainon growled, voice dropping, "who the hell touched you?"

Mydei blinked. "First off, what the fuck—how did you even notice that?"

"I memorized your body since, like, week two." Phainon said it too casually, like it was a normal, healthy, non-unhinged boyfriend thing to confess. "I know every inch of you."

Mydei stared at him, deadpan. "…You are not well."

"Not the point. Who did it?"

"For the love of—" Mydei tried to shift, but Phainon's grip tightened around his waist like a steel trap. "It was a shelf box. A sharp one."

"I'll kill it."

"It's a box."

"I'll burn it and salt the ashes," Phainon said, entirely serious, though his lips twitched with a grin as Mydei squirmed against him.

"Okay, psycho, let go."

“Nope.” Phainon buried his face against Mydei’s neck, tightening his grip further. “You’re injured. You require immediate, life-saving affection.”

Mydei made a sound halfway between a scoff and a laugh, though he was visibly fighting the upward pull of a smile. “You’re disgusting.”

“Correct.” Phainon pressed a quick, obnoxious kiss to his jaw. “But I’m your problem now.”

“Unfortunately,” Mydei muttered, but it was softer than before.

Phainon grinned against his skin, then peppered a line of quick, teasing kisses along Mydei’s cheek and temple, the kind of half-annoying affection he knew would drive him up the wall but also melt him down.

Mydei flinched like a startled cat, making a half-hearted attempt to escape, but his grin finally cracked through.

“Let go, you damn leech.”

“Nuh uh,” Phainon laughed, arms tightening possessively as Mydei groaned in theatrical suffering.

And for the first time in hours, the static in Phainon’s head eased.

Phainon kept his grip firm, lips brushing the corner of Mydei’s jaw, his temple, anywhere he could reach without getting headbutted. Mydei grumbled through it, too lazy—or maybe too content—to fight it properly now, one hand still tangled in the back of Phainon’s shirt like it was second nature.

The world didn’t flicker anymore.

No warping walls. No glitching reflections. No gnawing static in the corners of his vision.

Just warmth. Steady breathing. The scent of old paper clinging to Mydei’s clothes.

Huh.

Phainon’s fingers curled a little tighter at Mydei’s waist, brushing the edge of that damn shelf-box scar, committing its feel to memory like everything else. And maybe it was stupid, maybe it was reckless, but he let himself sink into the feeling of Mydei’s weight against him. The way his heartbeat steadied against Phainon’s ribs. How the world had gone utterly, improbably still.

He missed this. Missed him. And it struck him then how long it’d been since he let himself feel that without bracing for something to go wrong.

A small, private thought flared in the back of his head—maybe he didn’t break things as badly when Mydei was near.

But he didn’t want to test the theory. Not now.

Not when the risk was Mydei.

And then—the sharp buzz of his phone against his hip.

Phainon groaned, dragging a hand from Mydei’s back to fish it out while keeping the other locked securely around his boyfriend’s waist. “If this is one of your idiot staff asking why the sun’s hot again, I’m throwing your phone into traffic.”

“That was one time,” Mydei grunted.

The screen lit up. Encrypted ping.

From Anaxa.

Phainon’s grin slipped.

The message was short. Just four words.

[Waltz isn’t over yet.]

Phainon stared at it, pulse catching—not enough to ruin the moment, not yet, but the edge of unease uncoiled, cold and sharp in his gut.

He thumbed the screen dark.

Arms tightening around Mydei like a shield, he kissed his hair once, just in case.

He wasn’t going to push his luck tonight.

Chapter End Notes

I’m not saying anything gonna happen the next chapter but I’m also not saying it won’t…Happy Mother’s Day

Chapter 12: Fatal Exception: Godslayer.exe

Chapter Summary

> Phainon's been weirdly clingy lately. Mydei assumes it's Phainon things. Spoiler: it's not. Turns out when your boyfriend is secretly a murderous anti-hero, no amount of coffee dates or dumb jokes can stop the inevitable. Mydei handles the reveal with grace and composure. Just kidding—he absolutely loses his shit. Meanwhile, Phainon picks the worst possible moment to text about brunch plans.

Chapter Notes

> Uhh 2 weeks late but hey, 2 weeks the charm? I'll shut up now
>
> I did read this when I was done but I feel like I missed sm so please point out any grammar mistakes u spot

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sun was setting, but the city didn't care.

Its skyline carved jagged teeth into the bleeding sky, a smear of violet and bruised gold stretching out beyond the balcony rail. Somewhere far below, the endless hum of traffic kept moving—a heartbeat Mydei had long since tuned out.

He sat cross-legged on the battered balcony chair, a mug of lukewarm coffee cupped in both hands, staring out like maybe, *just maybe*, the end of the world might finally put him out of his misery.

From somewhere inside the apartment, Phainon was singing.

Badly.

And loudly.

And off-key.

Mydei closed his eyes and tipped his head back against the chair. “I’m going to kill him.”

It had been like this for a week.

Ever since *The Incident*. Capital letters. The one where Phainon had kicked down the doors of Mydei’s library, mid-day, red-faced and breathless like a lunatic, before promptly trying to have a full-blown breakdown in Mydei’s arms. No explanation. No warning. Not even a half-assed excuse. And then, just as suddenly, he’d vanished again.

Mydei hadn’t asked.

Partly because he figured if it was something world-ending, he’d hear about it eventually. Mostly because some quiet, anxious part of him didn’t really want to know.

And now this.

A whole week of… whatever this was. The most aggressively clingy, overbearing, borderline manic boyfriend behavior Mydei had ever witnessed. He’d tried, once, to track the logic. See if there was a pattern. But Phainon’s reasoning—if it existed—was a conspiracy board of nonsense.

Quickfire rundown:

One: A dumb horoscope telling him to “cherish his brightest star.”

Phainon had taken it as divine law. Mydei had called him an idiot.

Two: Because Mydei made him coffee that morning.

By “made,” he meant “reheated a cup in the microwave and forgot about it twice.”

Three: Petty revenge for a four-month-old insult about Phainon’s gentle heart.

Which, for the record, hadn’t even been that scathing. Mydei had casually called him “the softest bastard he’d ever known” and apparently it had wounded him on a spiritual level.

Four: A vivid dream where Mydei died heroically stupid.

Details varied by retelling, but the latest involved tripping over a broom and plummeting off a skyscraper while trying to save a cat.

And last but not least: A possible injury Mydei had definitely lied about.

And denied. And expertly covered with a long-sleeve jacket. He was pretty sure Phainon knew, because his gaze kept flicking to the same spot on Mydei’s forearm every time they spoke.

Or, you know.

All of the above.

Who the hell knew anymore.

Mydei took a long sip of his room-temperature coffee and sighed through his nose. Inside, the sound of Phainon’s warbling grew louder, punctuated by the unmistakable shuffle of socked feet on tile.

He was coming closer.

Mydei closed his eyes and quietly wished for death.

And yet.

Somewhere deep down, in a place he refused to acknowledge, the corners of his mouth tugged upward.

The idiot.

The balcony door creaked open.

Phainon appeared, framed by the fading light like some kind of deranged, off-key angel, still howling the same ancient pop remix he'd had on loop for the past hour. The potted plant in his hands wasn't helping the image.

"Mydeiiiiiii," Phainon sang—badly, for the record—"you light uuuuup my liiiife."

Mydei lowered his mug, deadpan. "I will push you off this balcony."

Phainon only grinned, sauntering over and plopping the plant onto the table like an offering. "Meet Mini-Mydei," he declared, gesturing grandly at the tiny, mildly wilted thing. "He's thriving."

"That plant is dying."

"We all are," Phainon said cheerfully.

Mydei huffed out a laugh before he could stop himself. It earned him a smile so bright it should've been illegal.

Phainon flopped into the seat across from him, legs sprawled, hair an absolute mess, and launched into yet another verse of his terrible song—loud, unapologetic, and profoundly out of tune.

And, against all odds, Mydei let him.

He leaned his head back against the chair, watching through half-lidded eyes as Phainon butchered the melody and made hand gestures at the bruised sky like he was performing for a sold-out stadium.

It was stupid. It was ridiculous. It was…kind of nice.

His stomach chose that exact moment to betray him, a low, unmistakable growl breaking the quiet.

Phainon froze mid-note. His head whipped around like he'd just heard a proximity alarm, eyes wide and scandalized.

“You’re starving,” he accused, pointing as if it were a crime.

“I’m fine.”

“You’re *wasting away*.”

“It was one noise.”

“Emergency protocol enacted!” Phainon announced, already leaping to his feet and vanishing inside with the dramatic urgency of someone heading into battle.

Mydei closed his eyes, sighed, and let his head thump back against the chair.

It had been like this all week.

And he didn’t know how much longer he could take it.

At some point—and Mydei wasn’t entirely sure when—Phainon had talked one of his more ethically bankrupt acquaintances (Anaxa? Anaxo? It had an x in it) into rewiring the apartment’s central media hub so it could link to their personal uplinks and blast through the building’s external speakers.

Legal? Not even remotely.

Morally sound? Absolutely not.

Was Mydei about to argue? Like hell he was.

Which was why he was currently sunk into Phainon’s crime-against-interior-design couch, one leg hooked over the back, his boots abandoned somewhere under the coffee table graveyard, cueing up his melancholy, synth-drenched indie-dystopian playlist.

The first notes eased through the speakers, a soft pulse of atmospheric chords and a ghostly vocal line whispering something appropriately tragic.

Mydei let his head fall back against the cushions with a sigh, eyes half-lidded.

And then—

BZZZT.

The connection glitched.

The music cut.

Replaced by what could only be described as *aural terrorism*—a violently chipper, aggressively saccharine 22nd-century pop remix that sounded like someone had given a hyperactive AI an energy drink and told it to make a love anthem.

Mydei didn’t move. Just stared up at the ceiling like maybe, if he concentrated hard enough, the god of suffering would take him out on the spot.

“No,” he said flatly, to no one.

Reached for the control.

Switched it back.

The synths returned. Beautiful. Wistful. Full of yearning. Just how he liked it.

BZZZT.

The pop remix came back louder.

This time it had clapping.

Mydei sat up, glaring toward the kitchen. “I swear to every last decrepit deity in this system, Phainon—”

From somewhere out of sight: “You’re welcome!”

The sheer smugness in his voice could've powered a city block.

Mydei yanked the connection back, swapping to a track that sounded like it'd been composed by a sad android in a graveyard.

Barely two seconds later—

BZZZT.

The same godawful pop remix, now with extra bass.

"I'm going to kill you in your sleep," Mydei growled.

Footsteps padded closer, then Phainon's head appeared around the doorway, hair a mess, snack bowl in hand, eyes sparkling like a man who had just chosen violence. "I'd like to see you try, Mydeimos."

"Stop hijacking my connection."

"It's for your own good." He declared before cranking up the volume.

Mydei groaned, dragging both hands down his face. "This is psychological warfare."

"This is love," Phainon chirped, sauntering into the room like a menace made flesh. He dropped onto the couch next to Mydei with a bounce, scattering a few chips.

Mydei didn't even flinch. Just switched the track again.

This time, a devastatingly bleak ballad about city lights and being left behind by time.

Phainon made a face like he'd just tasted battery acid. "Ugh. You're so dramatic."

"It's called having taste."

"It's called needing serotonin."

“Die.”

“Later,” Phainon said cheerfully, reclaiming the interface. The pop remix was back. *Now with a keytar solo.*

“I hope you step on a rusted nail.”

“You’re smiling,” Phainon pointed out, elbowing him lightly.

“I’m imagining your funeral.”

“As long as I’m the center of attention,” Phainon grinned, leaning in close, breath warm against Mydei’s cheek. “Love you too.”

Mydei sighed, but the corner of his mouth tugged up, traitorous.

The music war raged on.

No one won.

And both of them knew it wouldn’t be the last round.

Said war had slowed to a truce of mutually assured destruction—Mydei curled into one end of the couch, Phainon sprawled across the other like a cat who owned the place, snack bowl balanced precariously on his stomach.

The unholy pop playlist churned on.

Some chirpy vocalist warbled about dancing through starlight, how love was forever, some line about chasing dawn across forgotten cities—typical overproduced schlock. Mydei was just about to open his mouth and launch another insult when the next lyric cut through, clear and sharp over the saccharine beat:

“I wear ten faces but none are mine.”

The air went still.

Not much.

Barely a hitch.

But it was there—that split-second, brittle silence that hit like the quiet before glass cracked.

Phainon didn’t look at him. Kept his gaze locked on the ceiling, jaw tight, fingers drumming a little too fast against the rim of the snack bowl.

Mydei didn’t look either. Just let out a low, unimpressed scoff and muttered, “Your taste in music is garbage.”

“Yeah, well,” Phainon said, voice light but just a little off-beat, “you’re still listening.”

The next track queued up before either of them could say anything else.

Neither one of them reached for the interface.

The apartment was, in a word, chaos.

Case in point: Phainon was currently stalking Mydei from the safety of the kitchen counter, narrating his every move in a flawless impression of an old-world nature documentary.

“Observe,” Phainon intoned, voice low and reverent, “the elusive Mydeimos in his natural habitat. Note the cautious, deliberate approach to the primitive caffeine dispenser. A creature of instinct, ritual. Noble. Standoffish. Slightly homicidal.”

Mydei, halfway to pouring coffee, didn’t even look up. “I will end you with a dish towel.”

“Fascinating,” Phainon whispered, as if to an invisible camera crew. “Note the immediate defensive display. Classic territorial behavior.”

“You’re about to experience a classic blunt force trauma to the skull.”

Phainon beamed, entirely unrepentant, and continued his documentary voice. “Notice how he bristles. A predator poised to strike. If I move too suddenly, he may—”

A dish towel sailed across the room, smacking Phainon in the face. He cackled like a lunatic.

“Direct hit!” Phainon crowed, peeling the towel off his head. “Aggression confirmed. Highly dangerous. Ten out of ten would provoke again.”

Mydei muttered something dark under his breath and retreated to the couch with his coffee, done with the sheer force of bullshit in his life.

It only got worse.

Because perched proudly on the windowsill was a new potted plant. Small, spiky, ugly in the way only stubborn things survived in this city. A tiny label stuck in the dirt read: **Mini-Mydei.**

Mydei squinted at it. “When did you get that.”

“Yesterday,” Phainon said, solemnly. “Named it after you. It’s prickly, thrives on neglect, and will absolutely outlive us both out of spite.”

“You’re a menace.”

“I’m your menace,” Phainon shot back, beaming. “Also, check this out—”

He pointed the remote at the system hub. The screen flickered to life and a prompt appeared:

[Commander Click Mydei, authorization required.]

Mydei stared. “You renamed the system remote.”

“Everywhere you exist is mine now,” Phainon declared, entirely too pleased with himself.

“You’re truly deranged.”

“You love it.”

Mydei sighed, took a long sip of coffee, and refused to dignify that with a response.

The plant’s downfall was inevitable.

No one in this apartment had a healthy relationship with gravity or personal space, and Phainon’s long, dramatic gestures while recounting some half-true story about the time he “definitely didn’t almost get arrested for public disturbance” were a recipe for disaster.

It happened in slow motion.

His elbow caught the edge of the windowsill. The tiny pot wobbled. Teetered.

Mydei’s eyes widened. “Wait—Phainon—”

Clink.

Thud.

The plant hit the floor with a sad, brittle crunch, dirt scattering across the tile like tiny, defeated landmines.

The room went still.

Phainon stared down at it. Completely silent. A blank, dead-eyed look settling over his face like the last light had gone out behind his eyes.

“Wait—” Mydei started again, a hand half-raised.

Without a word, Phainon turned and walked out of the room.

Not stormed.

Not stomped.

Just… left. Silent. Stiff-backed. Like a man carrying the weight of too many sins.

“Goddamn it,” Mydei groaned, setting his coffee down with a sharp clink and moving after him. “Phainon, get back here, it’s a plant. You can’t emotionally spiral over a fucking plant named after me.”

Silence.

“Phainon, if you’re planning a funeral for Mini-Me I swear to—”

By the time he got to him, the bathroom was dimly lit, a single candle flickering precariously on the sink’s edge, its light bouncing off the tile in trembling, overdramatic shadows.

Phainon knelt before the sink as if preparing to summon ancient spirits. His hair was a mess, one sock halfway off, and his face bore the kind of dead-eyed solemnity normally reserved for memorials and corporate performance reviews.

Mydei leaned in the doorway, arms crossed, expression caught somewhere between exhausted fondness and *what the actual fuck am I witnessing*.

“I,” Phainon began, voice grave, “gather us here, in this most hallowed of resting places, to honor the life, the legacy, of our fallen comrade—Mini-Mydei. A brave sprout. A steadfast soul.”

“It was a succulent,” Mydei deadpanned.

Phainon shot him a glare over his shoulder. “A warrior,” he corrected. “Struck down in the prime of life by senseless gravity.”

“You knocked it over while trying to moonwalk to a remix of *Neon Love Crisis*, Phainon.”

“That remix *slaps*, and your blasphemy has been noted.”

Mydei sighed, dragging a hand down his face as Phainon turned back to the candle.

“May his leaves photosynthesize in the eternal light,” Phainon murmured. “May his roots find fertile soil in the afterlife. May his tiny, judgmental soul finally know peace.”

“You’re so weird,” Mydei muttered, though he suppressed an exasperated chuckle.

“Shhh.” Phainon made a solemn, ‘moment of silence’ gesture. The candle flickered. Somewhere in the apartment, the sound of a neighbor’s holo-TV blared out a 21st-century sitcom laugh track.

Without warning, Phainon stood, face deadly serious. “I’ll grow a new one,” he declared. “A worthier heir. Stronger. Smarter. Braver.”

“Oh gods, here we go.”

“I shall name him… Mydei the Second. No. Mydei II: *Leafborn Betrayal*.”

“That’s the dumbest thing you’ve ever said and you once declared war on a vending machine.”

“That thing *ate my credits*.”

“You punched it so hard the security drone tried to tase you.”

“I *dodged* it.”

“You tripped over your own foot and face-planted into a recycling bin.”

“A tactical feint.”

Mydei made a strangled sound and stormed over, grabbing the fallen plant carcass from the counter. He scooped the limp dirt back into the pot with his bare hands, jammed the two least-dead leaves upright, and stabbed a bent fork into the soil like a flag in enemy territory.

“There,” he said, tone flat as dead space. “Resurrection complete. Your grief period’s over. Get a grip.”

Phainon stared at it like it was the most beautiful thing he'd ever seen. A single, melodramatic practically glimmered in his eye.

"You… you saved him."

"I hate you."

"I'm naming it Mydei Eternal."

"I will drown you in this sink."

Phainon grinned, unrepentant, and wrapped his arms around Mydei's waist from behind, pressing his face against his shoulder.

"Everywhere you exist is mine now, you know."

"Shut up, you leech."

He did not shut up. In fact, he started humming *Neon Love Crisis* again.

And against all odds, Mydei once again, let him.

The city at night was a different kind of beast.

Mydei leaned his head against the window of Phainon's beat-up cruiser, watching the world smear past in streaks of half-dead neon and hazy puddle light. The streets were slick from a late rain, still steaming faintly against the glow of signs advertising everything from noodle carts to questionably legal tech repair.

The seat creaked when he shifted. An abandoned cup of iced coffee sweated into the cupholder beside a crumpled receipt for six different pastries and what appeared to be a novelty keychain shaped like a knife.

Typical.

Phainon hadn't said much since he picked him up. Just leaned across the seat, popped the passenger door, and grunted what might've been a

greeting, or possibly a threat. Hard to tell with him. And now he was driving like a man with something to prove—jaw set, eyes fixed ahead, one hand drumming out some twitchy, offbeat rhythm against the wheel.

"…Alright," Mydei said finally, squinting at him. "What's eating you?"

"Nothing," Phainon answered, a little too quick.

"Convincing."

Silence.

Phainon took a turn slightly sharper than necessary, and Mydei grabbed the door handle on reflex.

"You're driving like you've got a body in the trunk," he pointed out.

"No body," Phainon replied without missing a beat. "We're going somewhere important."

Which was categorically the worst thing to hear from someone acting mildly sketchy in the middle of the night. Mydei gave him a look.

"Important like… 'illegal back-alley cyber deal' important, or 'found a haunted relic on the university black market' important?"

"You ask a lot of questions for a guy whose taste in tea is objectively criminal."

"I swear, if you bring up that hibiscus blend one more time—"

"It was pink, Mydei."

"It's a *floral infusion*, you uncultured gremlin."

Phainon's lips twitched. "Still looks like cough syrup."

"Says the man who drank half a can of 'Riot Venom: Extreme Combustion' before noon."

“It was on sale.”

“Yeah, because it’s banned in three states.”

Another beat passed. The radio hummed on, some upbeat remix of an old-world track with aggressively auto-tuned vocals about burning daylights.

Mydei let his head fall back against the seat with a sigh. “Work was a nightmare.”

That earned him a glance. “Yeah?”

“One attempted theft of The Black Archive Codex by a kid who panicked so hard he dropped it on his own foot.”

“Solid.”

“Security had to carry him out. He was crying.”

“Outstanding.”

“And then,” Mydei continued, “some poor bastard tried flirting by asking where the ‘spicy medieval murder texts’ were.”

Phainon blinked. “The *what* now?”

“Exactly.”

A beat.

“You smite him on sight, or…?”

“Tempting. But no. I sent him to Agricultural Histories.”

A grin cracked across Phainon’s face, sharp and delighted. “You beautiful, petty bastard.”

Mydei smirked. “Figured he could get lost in the thrilling accounts of 14th-century barley disputes.”

“You’re my favorite person alive.”

“That’s sad for you.”

The banter settled into a comfortable lull. The car rolled past shuttered shops, the scent of rain and street food thick in the air. Somewhere in the distance, an inflatable tube men flayed helplessly.

Phainon’s fingers tightened subtly on the wheel.

“We’re almost there,” he said, voice quieter now.

Mydei arched a brow. “Where’s ‘there’? And don’t say ‘somewhere important’ again, I swear—”

“You’ll see.”

“I hate when you say that.”

“I know.”

Mydei shot him a sideways look. “You better not be dragging me to another one of your ‘abandoned but totally safe’ urban exploration spots.”

Phainon smiled, wolfish. “Not this time.”

“Oh good. Last one almost got us chased by an unhinged maintenance drone.”

“That was one time.”

Mydei let out a long, dramatic sigh. “I tolerate you because no one else will.”

“Yeah?” Phainon’s voice softened despite himself. “I cope badly with your face, too.”

“…Was that supposed to be a compliment?”

“I dunno,” Phainon shrugged. “Your face does things to me. Complicates my life. Wrecks my strategic plans. I’m coping.”

“Strong comeback, genius.”

“Shut up and prepare yourself.”

“For what?”

Phainon glanced over, expression unreadable but smug as hell. “Destiny.”

“Oh, gods.”

The car roared on into the night.

Eventually, Phainon pulled the car to a stop without warning.

“We’re here,” he said, too even.

Mydei lifted his head from where it rested against the window, brow creasing. The street outside wasn’t one he recognized—narrow, half-lit, the kind of alley you didn’t find on official maps. Neon signs buzzed in half-dead colors, old paint peeling from the walls. The air tasted like rain on hot metal.

Before he could ask, Phainon was already out of the car, slamming the door and circling around. The passenger side cracked open and a hand appeared, palm up, waiting.

Mydei stared at it.

“What’s this.”

“Chivalry,” Phainon replied, blankly. “Now don’t embarrass me in front of the alley rats.”

A sigh. But Mydei took it. His fingers closed around Phainon’s, the grip warm, steady, and let himself be pulled to his feet.

And then he looked around properly.

It wasn’t the parts of the city he was used to. This was Upper Tier, somewhere in the folds of the city’s cleaner face—but this corner had been left to rot. Faded signage hung overhead, the kind written in languages nobody bothered translating anymore. A soft, irregular drip echoed somewhere out of sight.

No one else was on the street.

Phainon was already walking ahead, one hand tucked in his pocket, like none of it registered.

A cold knot twisted in Mydei’s gut.

Does he know?

It was a stupid thought. An impossible one. But the alley looked too familiar in the worst kind of way. The world felt thinner here, like it did after bad nights. And Phainon—who usually filled the space with words of assurance—was silent now, moving with a certainty that made the hair at the back of Mydei’s neck lift.

“Hey,” Mydei called, voice low. “This one of your backroom deals or are we sightseeing?”

Phainon glanced over, a flicker of affection breaking through. “You ask a lot of questions for a guy who owes me pastries.”

“Could’ve just said no.”

“Where’s the fun in that.”

He reached a battered door at the end of the alley and pushed it open, pausing to look back.

“You coming?”

Mydei hesitated. The door was unmarked. A faint warmth leaked out from the crack, carrying something sweet beneath the damp city air. The kind of scent you didn’t expect here.

His stomach dropped.

He knew this place.

Phainon waited, a question in his eyes but no impatience.

Mydei muttered a curse under his breath and moved.

“Gonna blame you when I get stabbed.”

“Wouldn’t dream of it,” Phainon murmured, holding the door wider.

And with one last glance at the empty street behind him, Mydei stepped through.

The door swung shut behind them with a soft *click*, sealing out the city.

Inside, it was warmer. The walls were the color of old bone, cluttered with hanging charms, faded paper talismans, and glass jars that caught the weak light and held it hostage. The air smelled like cardamom, baked sugar, and something darker—anise, maybe.

A figure moved behind the counter.

The woman was slight, draped in layered fabrics that didn’t seem to belong to any specific decade, with sharp dark eyes and a gaze that could skin you down to the bone without ever raising her voice. Her hair hung in loose, ink-black waves, and a single silver chain circled her throat.

She zeroed in on Mydei the moment they stepped inside.

Didn’t blink. Didn’t speak. Just stared like she was counting the threads of his soul and finding them… acceptable.

Mydei stiffened. He knew those eyes. Not because he remembered her name—if he'd ever known it—but because he'd seen that look on long nights when this was the only place that felt like it existed outside the city's rotten pulse.

He hadn't meant to come here with Phainon.

And yet.

"What'll it be," she asked at last, her voice a soft, meditative thing.

Phainon, undeterred by the entire funeral rite atmosphere, stepped forward like this was the corner deli. "Got it written down," he said cheerfully, pulling a slightly crumpled note from his jacket. "Told myself I'd memorize it but, you know. Life."

He handed it over.

The woman didn't look at the note. She just held it between two fingers and kept staring at Mydei.

Mydei, for his part, didn't move. He had the distinct, irrational sense that if he so much as shifted his weight, the walls might fold inward.

Phainon grinned, oblivious to the impending existential reckoning.

"Trust me," he told her. "It's the right order."

A long pause. The shopkeeper's gaze lingered on Mydei a beat longer, then she gave the smallest, barest nod.

"As it should be," she murmured.

And then, with a whisper of fabric and a scent of sweet spice trailing in her wake, she vanished into the back.

The moment she was gone, Mydei finally exhaled.

“You are so lucky she didn’t curse you on the spot,” he muttered, rubbing a hand down his face.

Phainon shot him a charming smile, leaning casually against the counter. “What, you mean my impeccable charm didn’t carry us through?”

“I mean you’ve got the self-preservation instincts of a drunk moth.”

“Moths have good instincts.”

“In what ecosystem.”

“This one,” Phainon said, smug. “Now c’mon, you’ll thank me in two minutes.”

Mydei gave him a flat look, but didn’t leave.

Didn’t want to.

He just huffed a breath, watching the bead of spice-sweet condensation on the counter’s edge.

The shop’s seating area was small—more cluttered than cozy, though it tried to pass itself off as both. Mismatched tables, chipped cups, a crooked heater humming in the corner. A radio crackled somewhere behind the counter, low and strange, some old-world string melody curling through the air like fog.

Phainon dropped into a corner booth like he’d claimed the territory by force. Mydei slid in opposite, arms crossed, gaze flicking to the door as it shut behind them.

It wasn’t dangerous.

It just wasn’t a place you brought people to.

“So,” Mydei said, breaking the stretch of silence. “How’d you even find this place?”

Phainon grabbed a sugar packet, flipping it between his fingers. “Hm? Oh. You come back smelling sweet sometimes.”

Mydei blinked. “I—what?”

“Not like your usual paper books smell. It’s this… burnt sugar and spice thing. Cardamom, maybe. Weirdly specific.”

A beat.

“You noticed that?”

Phainon shrugged, like it was nothing. “Coincidentally ran into the scent last week while I was… doing something out here. Recognized it. Thought, huh—Mydei’s sweet cinnamon smell.”

Mydei’s stomach flipped. He looked away, trying and failing not to smile.

“You could’ve just asked, you know.”

“Nah,” Phainon said, almost fond. “You wouldn’t have told me.”

Mydei opened his mouth—and closed it. Because yeah. Fair.

“It’s not like I was hiding it,” he muttered. “It’s just… far. And it’s got that weird occult vibe. Figured you’d think it was stupid.”

Phainon grinned. “Maybe I like weird occult vibes.”

“You don’t.”

“Maybe I do.”

“You don’t.”

Their eyes met. Phainon’s gaze lingered a second too long before it slipped, dropping to the table, fingers stilling.

“What were you even doing over here?” Mydei asked.

That landed.

Phainon’s expression didn’t shift much—just a small, almost imperceptible pull at the corner of his mouth. “Nothing important.”

It wasn’t convincing.

Mydei frowned. Was about to press.

A soft chime cut through the air.

“Order’s up,” the shopkeeper called.

Phainon was on his feet like the conversation hadn’t happened. “Perfect timing.”

And then he was gone.

The tray he came back with was ridiculous—a small mountain of pastries, steam rising from two cups of something spiced and dark. Mydei stared at it.

“You bought the whole menu.”

“I didn’t want to risk picking wrong,” Phainon said, unapologetic as he shoved a custard bun into his mouth.

“You’re insufferable.”

“And yet you suffer me.”

“You’re gonna drop dead before forty.”

“Probably.”

Mydei sighed, snagged a pastry. Warm, soft, stupidly good. He hated how much it helped.

“Alright,” he muttered. “You win.”

Phainon grinned, leaning back like he'd conquered a kingdom. "I always do."

"Yeah, yeah."

The question hung there, unsaid. Mydei didn't press. He bit into the pastry instead, warm spice cutting through the noise in his head.

This was good.

Good enough.

For now.

Phainon was half-distracted, idly sorting the assortment of pastries like it was a battlefield he intended to win.

Mydei's fingers ghosted over a plain-looking bun, attention caught more by the faint pulse against his inner sleeve.

Not the comm on his wrist—too obvious, too traceable. This was a thin micro-haptic embedded in the lining of his coat, keyed to a frequency known to exactly three people. Cipher was one of them.

He tapped a discreet code against his forearm to read the message without displaying it.

[CYPHER]:
Guess whose mask is about to crack?You've got one week.
Be there. No excuses.
That was it.

Mydei's jaw tensed, the message sinking in like a blade slipping between ribs.

So it seems the pursuit was at last reaching its end.

If Aglaea had broken the encryption chain, then the identity was within reach. The fact that Cipher hadn't simply handed him the name meant either

one of two things:

A—the final layer was locked behind an identity-bound failsafe only Mydei could trigger.

Or B—they weren't entirely certain of what they'd found and were using him as the final measure.

He exhaled, slow and soundless.

The reasonable part of him noted the inevitability of it. The other part—the one that lived in the aftermath of bloodied missions and too-close betrayals—wondered why Cipher had waited this long if the net was already closing.

A delay meant leverage. Or doubt.

Or something else entirely.

A presence shifted beside him. Mydei blinked once, letting the thought drift into the mental archive of *to be processed later.*

Phainon reached across the table without a word, thumb brushing the corner of Mydei's mouth, wiping away an unnoticed crumb.

"You missed a spot," he murmured, gaze soft, almost absentminded in its fondness.

Mydei's pulse flickered, not because of the touch—gods knew they'd traded worse—but because of the sheer ease of it. The way Phainon could cut through heavy air with something so painfully human.

He made a quiet sound, the ghost of a smile pulling at his mouth.

"I had it handled."

"Sure you did."

Phainon leaned back, looking obscenely pleased with himself. Mydei felt a laugh threaten and suppressed it.

The message still hummed in his awareness like a splinter beneath skin.

A week.

He had one week before whatever mask Cipher meant came off. And whether it was some cornered Chrysos operative, a double agent buried in the Archive, or the last remaining piece of whatever ancient calculus had begun this mess—it would mean blood.

And for the first time in a while, Mydei wasn't ready.

Not because of fear. Not the fight. It was the timing. The way these things always surfaced when the ground under his feet finally felt steady. A pattern he should've stopped being surprised by years ago.

He reached for another pastry, breaking it in half with a surgical flick of his wrist.

"I'm invoicing you for this," he said, dry, cool as ever.

Phainon grinned. "Can't put a price on fate."

Mydei gave him a long look. "I can and I will."

The warmth hummed back to life around them. The heater's sigh, the hush of rain against glass.

A week left.

He would take every second.

And as Phainon's gaze lingered—just a second too long, just soft enough to make his throat tighten—Mydei let himself believe it could stay like this.

For now.

That was enough.

The glow of his phone screen cast pale light against the ceiling. Mydei lay sprawled on the couch, scrolling through feeds he wasn't really reading. Mostly muscle memory at this point—flick, skim, move on. The apartment was quiet save for the low hum of the city outside and the distant sound of Phainon brushing his teeth in the bathroom.

He'd shown up around midnight, offering a vague *"couldn't sleep—figured you couldn't either"* as explanation. Mydei hadn't argued. No point. Phainon made himself at home with the kind of casual certainty you only earned after years of history, and now here they were.

The place was cleaner than it'd been all week. Dishes done. Blankets adjusted. Tea made and abandoned on the counter. Mydei noticed the overcompensation, but didn't call him on it. Some habits weren't worth breaking.

He flicked past another headline, some Council-approved fluff piece, and let his mind settle back into the thing that had been quietly circling it for days.

The Flame Reaver.

For weeks now, he'd been pulling at the same thread. Incidents where the Reaver should've been cornered but wasn't. High-priority targets taken out just before Council sweeps arrived. Damage control handled like clockwork, cleaned before official response teams so much as blinked. It wasn't coincidence. Even the most unhinged vigilante didn't have odds that good without help.

He'd suspected for a while now that the bastard wasn't working alone, this just confirmed it. Some invisible hand smoothing out the aftermath before anyone else caught on. Mydei wasn't naive enough to think that kind of efficiency happened by chance.

And then there was the Council.

Lately, their background chatter had shifted. Subtle, but there. Patrol routes rerouted without reason. Mid-tier officers suddenly out of the loop on

operations they'd overseen for years. And somewhere in that tangle, a new unit had surfaced—unmarked, unlisted, with no formal designation in any of the known branches. Either it was recently built, or worse, it wasn't new at all. Something old back into play when no one was watching.

He'd have to look into it. Soon.

The water shut off. Footsteps crossed the room, and a moment later Phainon dropped onto the other end of the couch, pulling a blanket over himself tiredly.

"Don't clear the whole feed without me," he said around a yawn.

Mydei didn't look up. "Wouldn't dream of it."

The room settled again. That quiet, easy kind of silence only a few people in your life ever earned.

He let it stay.

Mydei had half a mind to suggest calling it for the night when Phainon shifted—a small, restless scoot closer, then another, and then he just gave up entirely.

A warm weight landed against his side, Phainon's head tucking somewhere between his collarbone and shoulder, the line of his nose brushing lightly against Mydei's throat. Not quite a proper position, but one neither of them bothered to correct.

Mydei huffed out a quiet breath, phone still in hand. "You realize it'd be easier if we moved to the bed."

"Mhm," came the mumbled reply, entirely unbothered, entirely unmoving.

Figures.

Mydei let his head tilt back against the couch cushion, fingers absently carding through Phainon's hair. Soft, almost a nervous habit by now. The

strands felt damp-cool from a recent rinse, the ends curling against his palm.

“What’s wrong?” he asked, voice gentler than it’d been all evening.

Phainon made a faint sound, something between a sigh and a hum. Half-lidded eyes, exhaustion stitched into the corners of his face.

“Hope you never hate me, Mydei.”

The words were so quiet he almost missed them. Mydei’s hand stilled. Blinked, brows furrowing as he looked down. “What?”

A weary little laugh, and then Phainon was turning his head just enough to look up, grabbing Mydei’s face with one hand, thumb brushing carelessly along his cheekbone.

“Damn. You’re pretty,” he muttered softly.

“Phai—” Mydei started, some sharp question already forming at the edge of his throat.

But Phainon was faster. “Good night,” he breathed, eyes already slipping shut again. And this time, he didn’t move.

Within minutes his breathing evened out, warmth steady against Mydei’s side. The weight of him felt heavier than usual tonight.

Mydei stayed where he was, heart beating a little too hard in his chest, the sound of some forgettable sitcom washing over them. He glanced at the bedroom door, then back down at the sleeping idiot half-curled against him.

“…Yeah, fine,” he muttered, pulling the blanket higher and letting his arm settle around Phainon’s back.

The night stretched on. Neither of them moved.

Mydei wasn’t sure who, in this situation, deserved to feel more ashamed—Phainon, for the syrupy nonsense he’d been spewing for the last ten minutes, or himself, for absentmindedly dumping an entire glass of ice water over the man’s head in public.

Probably him. Marginally.

“You know,” Phainon was saying now, voice muffled as he attempted to drape his soaked, ridiculous self over Mydei’s lap like a damp, oversized cat, “your eyes… they remind me of dying stars. Tragic. Ethereal. Light born from the slow, beautiful collapse of celestial bodies.”

“Uh-huh,” Mydei muttered, dragging the towel roughly through Phainon’s hair. “Keep talking and I’m finding another glass.”

It wasn’t like he’d planned on weaponizing a drink today. He’d been sleep-deprived and zoning out while walking Phainon back from campus—a favor turned tradition at this point—when he’d realized Phainon had never stopped talking. Not once. Something about cosmic phenomena and the poetically tragic nature of Mydei’s cheekbones.

Somewhere around the phrase *‘existence-trembling jawline’*, Mydei’s patience had snapped. The cup had been in his hand. The ice water had, unfortunately, still been in it.

And now here they were. Public bathroom. One damp, unrepentant idiot, and one guilt-stricken man furiously towel-drying his hair.

“You could’ve just told me you were thirsty for me, you know,” Phainon went on, all teeth and sinfully smug smile, hair sticking up in uneven spikes.

“I hate you.”

“No you don’t.”

Mydei sighed, propping his chin on one hand as he kept working the towel with the other. “I had no idea there was ice in that glass.”

“Uh-huh.”

“Didn’t even know I still had that much water left.”

“Sure.”

“I swear to every soul, if you get pneumonia over this—”

“Then you’ll be guilt-stricken and cradle me in your arms while I waste away. Beautiful. Tragic. Very on-brand for you.”

“Shut *up*, Phainon.”

Phainon laughed, eyes half-lidded as he tilted his head up into the next pass of the towel, like some smug, sleep-deprived cat.

Mydei sighed again, quieter this time. “You’re exhausting.”

“And yet,” Phainon murmured, voice softer now, “here you are.”

He didn’t have a comeback for that. Just kept toweling, as the bathroom lights hummed overhead and the outside world carried on without them.

Mydei sighed, pressing the towel against Phainon’s head one last time before dropping it in defeat. “Sorry,” he muttered, voice low. “I didn’t mean to—”

“Hey.” Phainon cut him off, leaning up to press a quick, unceremonious kiss to his forehead. “I’m not made of paper, Mydei. Let’s just go.”

A simple thing. Stupid. It still left Mydei blinking, pulse hitching like an idiot.

Phainon stretched, rolling out his shoulders before glancing over. “Hey. Can we… actually swing by your library before you head home?”

Mydei arched a brow. “Why? Planning to steal manuscripts?”

“No reason.” Phainon reached out, intertwining their fingers with infuriating ease. “I just wanna spend a little more time with you.”

There was a beat—something small and sharp tugging at Mydei’s chest he didn’t have a name for.

He squeezed Phainon’s hand back. “Alright. Let’s go.”

They stepped out into the cool evening air. Mydei’s phone buzzed. A message from Cipher lit the screen.

[Enjoying your late-night vigil duty, Godslayer? Hope your stray’s behaving.]

He rolled his eyes, refusing to dignify it with a reply. A minute later, another message followed—shorter, written like a half-riddle:

[The candle’s burning low. Better find your way to the flame before it gutters.]

Mydei’s grip on Phainon’s hand tightened.

“Mydei?” Phainon’s voice, soft. “You good?”

He exhaled, thumb brushing against Phainon’s knuckles, and tucked the phone away. “Yeah. C’mon.”

And together, they walked outside.

The apartment was quiet. Evening light pooled pale and weightless against the floorboards, brushing over half-folded laundry and a forgotten cup of tea gone cold by the windowsill.

Mydei pulled his jacket on, smoothing a hand down the front absently as he reached for his phone and keys.

“Where you off to?” Phainon’s voice came from the couch, soft with the kind of lazy disinterest people put on when they were actually listening.

Mydei didn’t look up. “Work thing,” he muttered. “Last-minute.”

Phainon hummed. “You’re always working.”

“You’re always sleeping in my bed.”

A faint snort. Mydei slipped on his boots.

When he moved for the door, Phainon rose too, stretching the sleep out of his limbs. He lingered by the doorway, bracing one arm against the frame as a yawn pulled at his face.

“Don’t be gone long, yeah?”

Mydei almost smiled. “House isn’t gonna burn itself down.”

But then he caught the look in Phainon’s eyes—something soft and far-off, almost unreadable. Not quite worry. Not quite anything Mydei could name.

It left a faint chill prickling at the edge of his senses.

He turned away before he could start asking the wrong questions.

“See you later.”

“Yeah,” Phainon murmured. “Later.”

The door clicked shut behind him, leaving the apartment still and quiet once more.

The air inside HQ never felt right. Cool and dry, carrying that faint sterile hush of a hospital.

Mydei passed through the reinforced checkpoint without slowing, the resonance dampeners brushing against his senses like static in his bones. Soft-lit glyphs shimmered beneath the translucent floor, a quiet pulse of pale blue guiding him forward.

Security drones drifted overhead. He didn’t look up.

The halls were wide and mostly empty at this hour, their glass-panel walls catching the last of evening’s light. Status holo-displays hovered against the far side—faint projections mapping operative placements and city threat zones in thin, sharp lines of color. Everything moved. Everything alive in its own way.

And yet the place felt like a winter coastline.

He shouldn’t have left like that.

Not with that look in Phainon’s eyes—like he was watching something slip just out of reach. Mydei clenched his jaw, shoving the thought aside.

Focus.

He passed a cluster of operatives in muted silence, their conversation low and steady, the sound of the resonance lattice bleeding soft through the walls.

Cipher’s message burned in his pocket.

Mydei kept walking.

The door slid open with a soft hiss.

Inside, the room was a little warmer—pale overhead lights casting a diffused glow across sleek consoles and pale walls. A few holo-screens hovered idle in the air, data scrolling in slow, steady columns.

Mydei spotted Tribbie immediately. She was perched on the edge of a terminal desk, legs swinging idly as she chattered to one of the operators nearby. Her hair was a tangle of red curls, half-shadowed by the faint light.

The operator gave a respectful nod as Mydei stepped in, excusing herself without a word.

Tribbie’s face lit up. “De! You made it!”

Mydei let the door slide shut behind him, offering the faintest ghost of a smile. “You doubted me?”

“We told Trinnon you’d come,” she said, swinging her feet a little faster. “Now they owe us snacks. A whole box of the honey things.”

Mydei huffed a soft breath, shaking his head. “You’ll clean out the commissary at this rate.”

“That’s the plan!” she said, as though it were the most natural thing in the world.

Mydei sighed, rubbing a thumb against his palm as the room settled quiet again. “Alright,” he murmured. “What’s going on?”

Tribbie’s grin faded, though a flicker of wryness lingered in her expression. “We got a ping a few hours back,” she said, tapping her wrist console. A shimmer of translucent data floated between them, lines of pale-blue resonance telemetry casting soft reflections against the reinforced walls.

“From the First Node cache,” she went on. “That archive we snagged off the Council’s underground vault? Mr. you-know-who tried to poke at it.”

Mydei’s brow twitched. He remembered the place. Remembered how it felt like standing inside a sealed ribcage, inhibitors baked straight into the walls.

“Should’ve triggered a full lockout,” he said. “Neural feedback, maybe a burn.”

“Exactly,” Tribbie muttered. “Except it didn’t fully. System flagged an interaction signature, ran a cross-frequency scan… and instead of frying it, it aligned.”

She flicked a fingertip, calling up a filtered resonance map. Tether points glimmered like tiny stars.

“Compatible frequency,” she said. “Not just close, either. Dead-on resonance match within anchor tolerance.”

Mydei frowned, a faint pull of something colder in his chest. “You’re saying it read whoever it was as… familiar.”

“Not just familiar. Recognized,” Tribbie corrected, her voice serious in a way she rarely let show. “The system doesn’t do that unless there’s an existing relational imprint on file. And guess where the tether landed.”

She pulled up the final string of data. One line of ID code, blinking steadily in the dark.

Mydei’s own.

He didn’t flinch, didn’t move—but there was a measured shift behind his eyes.

“Could be a latent echo,” he said after a moment. “Residual trace.”

“Could be,” Tribbie agreed. “But the depth of alignment says otherwise. That kind of convergence doesn’t happen unless someone’s carrying a tether built off your resonance pattern.”

Meaning: someone tied to him. Personally.

She let the words hang in the air, didn’t press.

“We held it off the main grid,” Tribbie added, scrubbing the data out with a flick of her wrist. “Only me, Trianne, Trinnon, and now you know it happened.”

“Good call,” Mydei said quietly, his gaze steady.

“Trace report’s locked down two levels below,” Tribbie said, straightening. “We kept it hidden.”

Mydei gave a short nod, pulse a little too stable for how his stomach felt.

“Alright. Let’s go.”

The report felt rough at the edges, printed on synth-pulp stock. Mydei skimmed the telemetry log as he walked, the corridor around them cold, resonance dampeners humming faintly through the walls.

Lines of sharp, blocky print ran down the page:

Trace Report—Priority: Internal Anomaly
Anchor Tether: Confirmed Match
Primary Recipient: [Godslayer_A12]
Foreign Interaction Signature Detected
Neural Burn Expected: Undefined
Resonance Alignment: Verified

His jaw flexed.

Tribbie padded alongside him, looking up. “We caught it thirty-four minutes ago,” she said, almost absentmindedly, though she was watching him from the corner of her eye. “Trinnon said it was a glitch. We said no.”

Mydei kept reading.

Resonance Trace Pattern: Class-3 Echo Anomaly
Interaction Source: Undetermined
Alignment Probability: 99.8%

He didn’t realize he’d slowed until Tribbie tugged his sleeve. “Come on, De. You’re cleared.”

They passed another pair of drones idling in the alcoves, lenses flickering blue as they passed. The sub-level air was cold, the embedded floor glyphs glowing faint and steady underfoot.

Mydei’s gaze dropped back to the report.

Archive Access Attempt: Personal Anchor Files
Result: Tether Accepted
Recipient: [Godslayer_A12]

A pulse beat dull in his throat.

They stopped before the vault—a matte containment door layered in faint glyph shimmer, the resonance field heavier here.

Tribbie gave a small, knowing nod toward it. “We’ll wait for you.”

The door sealed behind him with a muted hiss, pressure locks sliding into place. The sound left the chamber unnervingly silent.

Dim light glinted off polished metal supports overhead. The chamber itself was wide, a suspended walkway stretching toward the center where the archive core floated—a crystalline structure encased in a stabilizing gyroscopic frame, pale-blue wires threads curling and shifting in the air around it like strands of light caught underwater.

Mydei’s boots struck the walkway in steady, even steps. Each one sounded sharper in the vault’s controlled hush, like winter air in your lungs.

He reached the archive interface panel—a smooth black disc inset on the pedestal, surrounded by faintly pulsing glyph script. Mydei pressed his palm to it. A subtle resonance spark jumped between skin and surface.

[Resonance Scan Initiated]

The panel’s light expanded upward, blue-white lines cascading through the air in delicate data streams. Holographic script unfurled like vapor, forming suspended arrays and tactical logs around him.

[Welcome, Mydeimos]

The interface intoned it in that lifeless voice.

A central data stream shimmered ahead, lines of Archive logs and security alerts coalescing into a primary command feed.

Mydei let out a slow breath, pulse tight in his throat.

He reached for the control tether, linking his resonance field to the Archive’s processing stream. Blue light rippled in response, awaiting his command.

Mydei flexed his hand once, then laid his palm flat against the interface again.

“Alright,” he muttered, mostly to the empty room. “Let’s get this over with.”

The archive threads bled open in a wash of pale blue light, lines of clean data streaming past like veins of icewater. He started sorting manually—bypassing the auto-indexes, the redundant safety pings, the unnecessary permissions prompts.

He didn’t need predictive queries. He needed control.

Files unspooled before him.

[Operative Maintenance Log | Anchor Calibration Stable]
[Post-Op Review | Sector 11B | Godslayer_A12: Cleared]
[Cascade Recovery Incident: 17 Minutes, 32 Seconds]

Routine. Tedious. He skimmed, muscle memory moving faster than thought.

Cool light brushed against the walkway’s reinforced glass walls. He caught a reflection of himself in the partition—pale, drawn, a little too still.

Another file flagged in red.

Restricted.

Executive Oversight Only.

He knew what it was before he saw the designation.

His hand hovered.

Just for a second.

A steady pulse beat at the base of his skull. The smart thing—the disciplined thing—would be to leave it. Stay focused. Trace the anomaly,

log the interaction signature, submit it to Tribbie for review.

His fingers moved anyway.

The log expanded with a ripple of pale light.

———

File: [Godslayer_A12] | Personal Anchor Archive Entry
Clearance Level: [CH-Prime/Executive Only]
Archive Log Timestamp: [REDACTED]

———

Subject Designation: Mydeimos “Mydei” (Codename: Godslayer)
Status: Active Operative
Resonance Classification: Type-XI | Synthetic Immortality (Anchor-Grafted)

—

Origin Summary:
Subject recovered during Chrysos Heirs breach of unauthorized bio-resonance experimentation sites operated by [REDACTED] (deceased). Confirmed as Primary Prototype (Designation: KTE-01) for regenerative Anchor Binding under *Kýklos Thanatou Eikon Initiative.*

Harvest Records: [REDACTED]
Operational Methods: [REDACTED]

Incident Notation: Fatality of subject’s mother [REDACTED] during hostile resonance event. Casualty recorded shielding subject.

Operative in Command: [REDACTED]

—

Post-Recovery Modifications:

•Anchor Stabilization Sequence
•Partial Memory Graft Containment (Degradation Noted)
•Cascade Regeneration Inhibitor Installation

—

Anomalous Observations:

•Irregular Anchor feedback under stress conditions

•Logged incidents of uncontrolled regenerative cascade
•Neural pattern instability flagged in post-retrieval scans

—

Contingency Status:
Subject monitored under standing protocol. Personal archives restricted to Executive Oversight. Anchor Tether: Active.

—

Access Warning:
This file contains sensitive event data. Unauthorized interaction will result in critical neural feedback or cascade event.

—

End Log.

———

The words sat heavy in the air, light cascading off his skin, reflecting sharp in his eyes.

A pulse.

Another.

Something cold threaded through his ribs. It was the kind of ache he didn’t let surface often.

You already know all this, he told himself. *Nothing new.*

He lingered for half a breath longer than necessary, throat tight.

Then his hand closed into a fist.

The log collapsed in a clean ripple of light, vanishing as though it had never been opened.

The hum of the archive lattice settled back into its steady rhythm.

His grip tightened on the console edge, grounding himself in the cold bite of it. He let the pulse settle.

Focus.

He rerouted the display, isolating the trace anomaly. Scrolling past timestamp redundancies, ping logs, clearance checks. Then—

There.

Anchor Tether: Confirmed Match.
Primary Recipient: [Godslayer_A12]

The room felt fractionally colder.

He breathed out through his teeth, slow and steady.

Found you.

He pulled up the Anomaly Interaction Log, fingers moving with mechanical precision. The system’s auto-sanitizers pinged an integrity alert the instant the corrupted data fragment surfaced.

He killed them. One by one.

Auto-Sanitizer Override: Confirmed.
Traceback Failsafe: Disabled.
Resonance Containment Net: Offline.

The lattice shivered around him, motes of static bleeding at the edges. He didn't care. Whatever this was, it wasn't getting erased before he saw it.

The anomaly signature surfaced—jagged, feral, half-burned. A Resonance Imprint Fragment, hovering unsteadily in the projection field. Neural band frequencies stuttered in the diagnostics. The Trace Cascade Map was incomplete. Echo Delay clocked nearly half a second too long.

Whoever this was should've flatlined halfway through the contact attempt. Should've ruptured their synaptic pathways instantly.

Should've left a corpse.

His jaw tightened as the thought surfaced, uninvited.

He started cross-referencing resonance pulses by hand, stripping metadata layers like peeling old paint. Each data strand floated midair, thin filaments of cold blue-white light. He followed the signal paths, isolating each flicker of harmonic variance.

Like unraveling a resonance braid—one twisted pulse frequency at a time.

Messy work. Dangerous work. The containment lattice around him didn't like it, flickering with each pulse.

Didn't matter.

He adjusted harmonic filters. Cut redundancy loops. Rerouted cascade echoes. Stripped the pattern bare.

And there—beneath the noise and damage—something rooted itself in his chest.

The core pulse frequency was irregular, but still there.

His tether.

A final pulse flickered in the resonance net. Still half-burned, warped by cascade interference—but Mydei recognized the modulation pairing. No one else carried that imprint.

The system chimed.

Trace Isolated:Display Full Sequence?

He didn’t move for a breath.

Then, with a hand like stone, he confirmed the command.

Distorted audio first.

Glitching frequencies. A low chuckle breaks through static. Unintelligible words under a hum of wind.

A partial voice—bright, careless, alive.

“…could eat like this forever, I swear—”

Another burst of static.

The resonance stabilizer chirps as Mydei’s manual tuning resolves the interference.

The feed clears.

A balcony.

Pale stone. Bright sun, diffused through thin curtains stirring against the wind. A glass of something half-drunk and an untouched plate of pastries.

The camera is tilted, handheld, like someone meant to turn it off but forgot.

It catches bare feet resting on the railing, sunlight catching on pale, white hair. A man’s laugh—light, familiar, *intimate in a way that should be*

impossible.

He’s out of frame. Only the edge of a grin, the corner of sky-blue eyes flicker across the lens.

A voice, bright and teasing:

“Bet you can’t catch this one.”

A pastry arcs toward the camera. The lens flares, scattering the image into brief streaks of gold.

And it’s not the scene itself that matters.

It’s the timestamp.

[Timestamp: RESTRICTED | YEARS PRIOR][Location: Internal Personal Archive—Godslayer_A12]

The resonance tag blinks active.

Primary Subject Resonance: [REDACTED]
Anchor Tether Affinity: 96.3% Match—Known Alias: Flame Reaver
Identity Confirmation: Pending Executive Clearance
Warning: Unauthorized Resonance Access Recorded.

And for a long moment—just a frozen frame.

White hair, a blue sky, sunlight, and the flicker of a man’s grin.

Silence.

The feed ends.

Mydei didn’t move.

Not a flicker. Not a breath.

The system hummed.

[Resonance Anomaly Logged.]
[Unauthorized Archive Access.]

A faint crackle—Tribbie's voice breaking in over comms.

"De…? You okay? You've been there for a while and—"

Glass exploded.

The sound wasn't clean. It was wet. The crack of impact followed by the grind of crystalized interface barrier turning to dust under flesh and bone. Shards scattered in a radial burst, blue light bending around the mess.

Alarms triggered mid-burst, Archive walls flashing with aggressive red glyphs.

[CRITICAL SECURITY BREACH.]
[RESONANCE INSTABILITY DETECTED.]

Mydei hit the console again.

A heavy, bone-thudding slam—metal folding under the weight of it, resonance strands recoiling like cut nerves. Blood smeared across the surface, thick and black in the harsh blue light.

"Dei?" Tribbie's voice again, higher this time, uncertain. "Dei—what's—"

Another strike. The core interface housing dented inward, more glass screaming as it split apart, interface threads fraying like exposed veins in the air. The Archive system blared warnings now, overlapping shrieks of alerts crashing over each other.

[CONTAINMENT FAILURE.]
[AUTOMATED SHUTDOWN DISABLED.]

The resonance lattice over the Archive's heart flickered erratic, like a dying thing.

"Dei! Stop—stop it, what's happening?!"

Her voice cracked, sharp with raw panic, the youthfu edge leaking through professional training like a hairline fracture in glass.

He didn’t answer.

Blood hit the floor in slow, thick drops, pattering against the slick glass and metal decking. The walkway’s sterile white turned slick crimson.

One last blow—brutal, terminal—drove through the primary panel, snapping it from its housing. Alarms howled louder, systems trying to reroute. Lights stuttered like frantic eyes.

The chamber reeked of copper and ozone.

Tribbie’s breathing hitched on the open comm, shaky and fast.

“Please… what’s wrong…?”

The only sound in return was the crackle of broken systems, the metallic ping of cooling glass fragments, and the steady drip of blood.

The Archive howled.

A synthetic shriek that didn’t stop, grinding up and down in pitch like some ancient predator’s dying scream fed through a thousand layered speakers. Warning glyphs strobed to life across every surface, crimson and jagged, data streams spasming into corrupted static.

[RESONANCE BREACH DETECTED.]
[CONTAINMENT FAILURE.]
[DEPLOYMENT TEAMS EN ROUTE.]

Lights stuttered, the chamber locking itself down by reflex. Shutters hammered shut on peripheral exits. The reinforced vault trembled as defensive lattices activated with the sound of a thousand knives scraping over glass.

And Mydei… didn’t move.

He stood at the shattered terminal, hand slick with blood, glass lodged deep in the meat of his palm. The Archive's panicked security grid spat out error after error as it struggled to reassert control. Sirens stabbed through the vault like needles, lights flickering hard enough to leave afterimages behind his eyes.

A crackle.

Then:

"Stop it, you're scaring us!"

Tribbie's voice—sharp, small, ragged. Not through the comms anymore. In the room.

He didn't turn.

Didn't blink.

Didn't hear her.

The alarms blurred into a single unending wail, one endless red chord of warning, and still, his mind registered only a single, savage truth.

It was him.

The words struck like a nail through bone.

Clean. Absolute.

Everything before it—denials, careful logic, the hundred rationalizations crafted in brittle moments of calm—collapsed like paper before a flame.

Another blaring announcement crashed overhead.

[CONTAINMENT AUREATE RESTRAIN UNIT DISPATCHED.]
[RESONANCE VOLATILITY: CRITICAL.]

Doors exploded open behind him, security pouring in. Shouts, boots hammering metal, containment fields snapping to life. Weapons primed, tactical orders shouted over overlapping comm lines. No one knew it was him.

Didn’t matter.

The Archive was hemorrhaging alarms like a wounded animal, environmental lights casting the room in seizure-quick flashes of red and blue. Mydei’s silhouette stood in the eye of it, blood dripping from his fingertips to the floor.

And then his comm vibrated.

A single, clean pulse.

Amid the sirens, blood, glass.

He glanced down.

Phainon✴:

Hey, you free tomorrow? Thought we could grab coffee <3

The timing was obscene.

A crime against the order of the world.

Tribbie’s voice cracked, panic breaking through training:

“Dei…No—no no no!”

The alarms screamed.

Security barked orders.

And Mydei didn’t look away from the message.

Not once.

Chapter End Notes

Well, probably not the reveal you were expecting. Hope it still hits😍

3.3 absolutely tore me apart—there's no way Mydei's dead, fight me. Like please, I'm hoping Flame Reaver was dumb enough to just slightly miss that spot, I meannn he did seem a bit drugged up with Cipher so…..

Also, if you wanna drop a hi or fangirl/boy with me, here's my Twitter: https://x.com/thelunaeryi?s=21

I'm almost done with the first chapter of another Myphai fic I'm creating with the most tropey of tropes in it to cope with that update, so yeah that's something nice at least:

Ok enough yapping guys, gn😭

Chapter 13: Schrödinger’s Trust Issues

Chapter Summary

> Phainon’s losing his mind, Anaxa’s slapping sense into him, and meanwhile some evil council lady is like, “Damn, the Heirs are doing our job for us—guess we’ll just swoop in and steal the kill.” Cut to her ominously grinning at a half-melted file like a supervillain watching her enemies self-destruct.

Chapter Notes

> Hey, how we doing fellas😍 Just wrapped this chapter, eight more to go. 90% sure I’m not finishing before 3.4 drops at this rate, but hey, a person can dream😭
>
> Anyway, hope you enjoy it <333
>
> (Also lowkey surprised no one’s brought up that file bit about Mydei yet… guess that means I get to keep gasping dramatically for a little longer 😬 Foreshadowing supremacy.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The room was too quiet for a morning class.

Conversations that should’ve overlapped hung at odd, careful volumes. The kind of hush that settled when everyone realized something wasn’t quite right, but nobody wanted to be the one to name it.

Phainon made a point of being the loudest thing in the room.

“—and if anyone tries to tell me The Parallax Directive wasn’t just state-sponsored fear-mongering with a glossy filter, you can get out now. Save yourself the embarrassment.”

A couple of his students cracked smiles. A few glanced sidelong at each other, uncertain whether it was safe to laugh. One girl at the back pretended to check her notes, though there was nothing open in front of her.

Phainon grinned wider. Bright, easy. *Friendly*. The beloved madman professor with a caffeine problem and zero regard for authority, just how they liked him.

He perched one hip against his desk and spun the notes in his hand like it was a coin.

“You know what? Screw the syllabus. Today’s special. Since the Council’s been so gracious lately about policing what you can and can’t say—” He gestured broadly to the wall where a campus code of conduct poster hung askew, “—I figured we’d ride that wave and have ourselves a good old-fashioned debate. Topic is: The Ethics of Authoritarian Surveillance in Times of Civil Unrest.”

He said it lightly, as though it wasn’t the most suicidal classroom discussion anyone had hosted in the past week.

A few heads lifted. One or two faces stiffened. A nervous shifting of shoulders. Phainon clocked them all.

There was Dymas—usually smug, currently staring a little too hard at his desk. Ione and Theros, who always sat together, now two seats apart. Three new faces near the front. Only one had officially enrolled last week.

He didn’t react.

He could feel the hum before he heard it: a thin, mechanical buzz overhead, quiet as static. The VIB drone hovered past the window in a slow, deliberate arc.

Fourth one today.

Phainon’s smile didn’t falter.

“And yes, yes, before any of you nervous nellies get your paperwork in a twist— it’s *still technically legal* to talk about hypotheticals,” he drawled, waving a hand. “For now. So I want gut reactions. No citations, no historical sourcing yet, no long-winded uncle-at-a-family-dinner monologues. I want to know where your instincts land. Who’s in favor, who’s against, and who’s about to pull a neutrality cop-out and say *it’s complicated.*”

A beat of uneasy chuckles. A cough.

Good. Keep them slightly off balance. Relaxed, but not complacent.

He tapped his notes against the desk edge and was about to split them when a hand went up.

Phainon’s gaze flicked to the student.

Tall. Clean-cut. Soft gray jacket. Neatly pressed collar. No scuff marks on his boots—new issue, regulation standard. The kind of face you forgot immediately after seeing it, which meant it was designed that way.

Not one of his.

The young man’s expression was open, a little curious. “Professor, would the scope of *‘authoritarian’* in this context also include civil surveillance established under declared states of emergency, or just regimes that never rescind control?”

Normal question.

Phainon’s smile sharpened by half a millimeter. Easy, bright. He chuckled like a man who definitely hadn’t just marked this kid as an operative the second he walked in.

“Ah, excellent clarification,” he said, voice smooth, hand gesturing animatedly. “We’ll call it… broad-spectrum authoritarian. Anything where the average citizen no longer has full consent in how they’re being watched. Emergencies, permanent states, whatever keeps you up at night.”

He met the kid’s gaze for just a heartbeat longer than necessary. Polite. Open. Completely harmless.

Agent. Definitely.

Phainon clapped his hands together.

“Alright, enough foreplay. Pros on the left, cons on the right, fence-sitters in the back. No hiding, no changing sides halfway through just because someone makes you feel bad about your morals. Move.”

The room stirred. Chairs scraped. Some lingered half a second too long before standing, waiting to see who went where.

Phainon watched them all. Cataloged the nervous glances, the ones who moved too quickly, and the ones who hesitated just long enough to be worth remembering.

He didn’t stop smiling.

Not for a second.

But when their backs were turned—chairs scraping, voices rising in half-hearted debate—his expression softened, the grin thinning at the corners. He leaned back against the desk, the heel of one hand pressing against the wood, a casual rhythm tapped out with his fingers.

Truth was, he didn’t feel much like smiling today.

Not with everything happening outside these walls.

In less than a week, the entire northern corridor of the district had fallen under what the Council labeled a civic preservation protocol. In official terms, it wasn’t a lockdown. No broadcasted emergency. No martial law order blinking across feeds. Civilians still moved freely, shops stayed open, lectures went on as scheduled. On the surface, it all looked unnervingly normal.

But the air told a different story.

Surveillance frequencies had surged in the last seventy-two hours.

Checkpoints appeared overnight in sectors with no logistical justification.

Drones blanketed the skies in layered patrol grids, monitoring not just government buildings or transit hubs—but schools, clinics, and even *cafés*. There was no pattern, no rationale.

Phainon had seen it before, of course. Power moves disguised as public safety. The Chrysos Heirs made their entrance first, slipping into the sector with the kind of subtlety they were known for. Operatives seeded into civil branches. Quiet scans. Minimal interference. Their net tightened slowly. Three days ago, no one so much as flinched when it started.

But then the Council moved in.

And this time, they didn't bother with subtlety.

That wasn't surprising in itself—the Council and the Heirs barely tolerated each other as it was. Their relationship was a balancing act held together by public opinion and the constant threat of mutual ruin. They each knew where the line was, and while tension ran high, neither side crossed it without cause.

This, however, wasn't edging the line.

This was obliterating it.

VIB forces stormed the sector like they owned it, deploying checkpoints without jurisdiction, seizing control of patrol routes meant to be under joint command. Heavy surveillance grids. Double-layer biometric scans, no civilian consent required. Drones under full override authority—something that hadn't been greenlit outside Black Tide containment zones in years.

It made no strategic sense.

The Chrysos Heirs already had operatives in place. They hadn't requested Council backup. No known incidents had triggered escalation. And yet, the

Council descended like a hammer, their forces overlapping Heir patrol routes, undermining their protocols.

And as if that wasn't enough, Goldweaver herself entered the field.

Two days ago, her threads began to manifest—some visible, glinting lines of gold strung between NetGrid nodes and public comm-towers, most unseen, laced through the atmosphere, woven into pulse lines and infrastructure relays. Phainon didn't have to see them to know they were there.

He could feel them. Even now.

Golden threads threaded through every conversation, every transmission, every shift of thought if you let your focus slip long enough. There was no such thing as a private word anymore, not with her watching. Thought-mapping resonance traps buried in the city's pulse, waiting to catch any stray idea that drifted too far from the sanctioned narrative.

The worst part wasn't that it was happening.

It was that no one seemed to care.

People barely blinked when the Heirs arrived. A few protests. Some grumbling. Nothing sustained. Then the Council brought their heavy hand down, and still—no headlines, no outcry. The NetGrid ran silent. Just the usual news cycle, polished and indifferent.

It felt… *quiet*.

Too quiet.

And Phainon knew better than to trust quiet.

Nothing stayed this still before unless someone intended it that way. And whoever was pulling the strings this time wasn't following protocol, wasn't sticking to old grudges and power plays.

This was something else.

Phainon’s gaze tracked a drone as it passed overhead—a soft, electric whine undercutting the hum of conversation.

Fifth one in the last hour.

Whatever this was, it was getting worse.

And he hated being the last to know.

His gaze flicked toward the drone again, then down—thumb swiping his screen awake.

No new messages.

The last text from Mydei was still stamped *Read 3 days ago.*

He hadn’t seen him since.

Phainon tapped the screen, half on instinct. Scrolled past his own messages, sent in uneven intervals. A few every few hours, sometimes a full day apart. He wasn’t keeping track. Not really.

Yesterday | 00:42

> *u better be alive bc if not I’m stealing your stupid jacket collection.*

Day before | 18:19

> *some kid in class asked if NetGrid used thought-echo tracking so I told them no but like. lies huh.*

Yesterday | 03:00

> *thinking about you idiot. but not in a gross way don’t get excited*

And then, nothing.

No read receipts. No reply.

He told himself it was fine. Mydei went off-grid sometimes. Got tangled in whatever business he had. It wasn’t unusual.

Except it was.

Not for three days. Not without a word.

Phainon scrolled further up, just far enough for the page to fill with the same one-sided messages, casual and teasing, sometimes affectionate in the way someone might toss a paper airplane into a storm. He let his thumb hover over the newest text bubble.

[Type message…]

His fingers moved before he could stop them.

I miss you.

He stared at it for a moment longer than he meant to.

Then deleted it.

Didn’t even leave it in drafts.

His thumb lingered against the glass, like the heat of his skin could summon a response by sheer force of will.

It didn’t.

It never did.

A sharp yell cut through the low hum of the room.

“Death to the standardized testing overlords!”

Phainon blinked up in time to catch Caelus standing on a chair, one arm raised like he was leading a rebellion, Stelle dramatically faking a swoon behind him, half-sprawled across a desk. A few students gave token groans,

others snorted into their sleeves. One girl near the window murmured *please get down before the drone notices*, which only made Caelus louder.

“Death to mandatory citation quotas!”

“And death to curriculum-approved historical interpretations!” Stelle called, back arched over the desk like she was perishing from academic oppression.

Phainon huffed.

Didn’t laugh. Didn’t cheer.

But let the edge of his fake grin tug a little closer to something genuine.

Because if he thought about the other thing too long—the unreturned messages, the absence of warmth where it used to live—he wasn’t sure what would be left to hold together.

So he let them be loud.

Let them fill the room with something stupid and reckless and alive.

And kept himself upright.

For now.

The last debate points had barely cooled in the air before students began packing up, the scrape of chairs and shuffle of bags breaking the classroom’s artificial calm. Conversations started with the kind of cautiousness people had when they weren’t sure who was listening.

“—saw ‘em changing the keycard panels on the east wing.”

“No one got a memo. Not even the staff.”

“Whole perimeter checkpoint doubled. Said it was a ‘precaution.’”

A pair of students lingered near the door, voices hushed.

“New cameras in the stairwells. Same model they use outside the halls.”

Phainon didn’t look at them. Kept his posture loose as he thumbed through a stack of debate notes left behind, scanning a page without reading a word. Every clipped sentence found him anyway.

Patrols outside.

ID verifications on floors that never needed them.

A sweep team no one had authorized.

He inhaled—slow, through his teeth—and let the papers settle into a pile.

One by one, they left.

The twins gone.

The agent-in-student-skin giving him a parting nod, which he returned with the exact degree of forced, easy charm required.

The room emptied. The hum of the overhead lights pressed in.

Phainon grabbed his coat, shrugged it on, and stepped out into the corridor.

The hallway stretched long, reinforced glass along one side offering a view of the courtyard below. A pair of VIB operatives moved past at a measured pace, helmets catching the pale overheads.

And then, from his left—

“Phainon.”

He turned at the voice, already feeling the sigh in his throat.

There, leaning against the wall like the day hadn’t gone sideways, was Anaxa.

Hair loose, expression sharp and unimpressed. The exact same unreadable face he’d had since they were sixteen, but worst.

“Anaxa—”

“—goras,” Anaxa cut in, tone flat.

A single glance passed between them. That was enough.

They fell into step without speaking.

Footsteps in sync, pace casual.

Phainon’s grin made a brief, tired appearance. “So,” he drawled low. “How’s your afternoon shaping up?”

Anaxa gave a humorless huff. “About as well as yours, apparently.”

Neither of them asked why the other was here.

Neither of them needed to.

They kept walking.

The staff lounge was three turns down and a floor up, past two new camera mounts and a door scanner that hadn’t existed last week. Phainon kept his stride easy, Anaxa at his side, neither of them acknowledging the way the halls felt a little too empty.

“I caught a lag in the sync modules by East Admin,” Anaxa started, as if continuing a conversation they’d been having since breakfast. “Nothing flagged it, but the spikes didn’t line up with operational hours.”

Phainon hummed like that was mildly interesting. “Could be a firmware drift.”

“Could be.” Anaxa’s voice stayed calm. “Problem is, it happened again thirty minutes ago. Same routing pattern.”

And there it was. Goldweaver’s threads pushing into places she hadn’t touched before. Administrative East wasn’t high-priority enough to merit her attention—unless someone was about to get boxed in.

Phainon flicked his eyes to a wall console they passed.

“You thinking proximity cascade?” he asked.

“If it is, it wasn’t us.” Anaxa’s lips twitched. Not quite a frown, but close. “And there’s packet noise I can’t source. Picked up a ghost log on the uplinks this morning. Pathing wasn’t local.”

A third party. Inside the net.

Not regular Chrysos or Council units.

Phainon didn’t react beyond a soft click of his tongue. “Anyone patch the breach on the northeast sector?”

“Nothing official,” Anaxa muttered. “Unit routing’s inconsistent. Feels like someone’s running custom configs off-books.”

The subtext wasn’t hard to follow. The VIB patrols were ignoring central command protocols. Meaning either rogue elements, or someone higher than the city post had their hands on the playbook.

Anaxa kept going. “Firewall drift’s pulled east. Left a gap. Two sectors wide. No one’s patched it.”

A blind spot. Undertaker’s doing, probably. A reallocation of her forces leaving a clean corridor between Chrysos and Council patrol routes. Could be dangerous. Could be perfect.

Phainon gave a soft, sardonic laugh under his breath. “You always bring me good news.”

Anaxa snorted, half a smirk breaking through for a second. “Server’s been behaving like it’s preparing a soft wipe, too. Nothing confirmed, but it’s too washed.”

Phainon’s stomach gave a quiet twist.

Silent lockdown.

He scrolled through the new pieces in his head—Goldweaver escalating, Council getting reckless, an unknown operator slipping between their teeth, and a city gearing up for something without saying it out loud.

Anaxa gave him a sidelong look. “You still smiling, or did that glitch?”

Phainon smirked faintly. “Oh, I’m in the best mood. Love it when things get messy.”

The lounge came into view ahead—mostly empty save for a tech staffer and a coffee machine cycling through its cleaning program.

Phainon opened the door with a press of his ID, and the officer silently trailing them peeled off.

“You in or out on this one?” Anaxa asked, deliberate.

Phainon didn’t answer right away. He let the question hang there.

Then: “I’m in.”

Anaxa nodded once, and that was enough.

Phainon let the door shut behind them, rolling his shoulders as he worked a stiffness from his neck. A vertebra cracked with a sharp, satisfying pop.

“Better?” Anaxa asked, already darting toward the coffee unit.

“Closer to death every day,” Phainon grinned, leaning back against the counter.

Anaxa snorted, grabbing one of the cups and stabbing at the machine’s menu with the kind of focused irritation of someone who hated every option it offered. He didn’t bother asking if Phainon wanted one.

“You sleeping?” Anaxa asked without looking up.

Phainon smirked. “You’re hilarious.”

“Didn’t ask if you were laughing.”

“Didn’t ask if you cared.”

That earned a scoff from Anaxa as the machine finally churned out something approximating coffee. He took the cup, sipped, grimaced.

“Still garbage,” he muttered.

Phainon tapped his knuckles lightly against the counter. “You should’ve calibrated it. At this point half your job title is fixing stupid things.”

Anaxa ignored him, instead grabbing a newspaper left on the corner of the table—one of the few relics still circulating around campus because some old professor refused to stop getting the print edition. He slid a plain disposable phone beneath it in one practiced movement.

Phainon’s eyes barely flicked to it before settling back on Anaxa’s face.

“You done playing hero today?” Phainon asked, casual.

“Depends on who’s watching,” Anaxa shrugged, heading for the door.

He paused, hand on the frame. “Swing by after you’re done babysitting.”

The words were easy, offhand, but Phainon caught the edge of it.

Phainon gave a lazy salute. “Wouldn’t miss it.”

Anaxa left without another word. The door hissed shut.

Phainon waited a breath. Then another. His gaze slid to the wall by the far corner—a small, nearly invisible Heir sigil etched behind one of the ceiling tiles, visible only when the angle of the light caught it.

Message received.

The threads were here too.

His expression didn’t shift. A lazy, absent flick of his fingers beneath the table, like brushing dust from his palm—but in its wake, the surveillance weave faltered. A temporary dead zone stitched into the ambient field, frayed wires of reality coaxed just wide enough for the next thirty seconds to belong to him alone.

Then, as if nothing happened, he set the paper down on the table and palmed the disposable phone. Standard cheap model. No encryption, no log history, no trace.

He powered it on.

One message.

[CIU went public. They’re ‘Cleaners’ now.]

Attached was a brief internal memo—grainy, scanned from a Council operations feed, judging by the formatting. The new designation:

Containment Integrity Services Division (CISD)
Operational Moniker: **CLEANERS**
Mandate: *Specialized emergency protocol team responsible for the neutralization and removal of high-risk operatives, anomalous materials, and compromised facilities as part of classified counter-threat operations.*

He read it twice.

And then a third time.

Phainon clicked his tongue, leaning back against the counter. His thumb flicked the edge of the phone absently, his mind already unpacking what Anaxa hadn’t put in writing.

So that’s why he didn’t say it aloud.

The Cleaners.

They'd buried the CIU's old designation like it was bad history—the same CIU they'd tracked months back in the records, the ones responsible for the Node extractions attempt to replace Heir figures with mimic constructs. And now, with no Nodes left, rather than dissolve the unit, the Council repackaged them.

New name. New badge. Same monster.

The wording was deliberate.

'Counter-threat operations.'

Which meant whatever the Council decided a threat was. Rebels. Heirs. Their own people. Hell, a static anomaly in the wrong sector would qualify if it was politically inconvenient.

And no one would question it.

Phainon exhaled through his nose, the ghost of a humorless smile tugging at the corner of his mouth. Typical.

But what unsettled him wasn't the rebrand—it was the timing.

Why now?

Why escalate a cold war into a public operation?

What was the Council afraid of that warranted pulling their old ghost squad out of storage and giving them open jurisdiction?

Phainon didn't have the answer yet. But he knew the kinds of things that made people like this nervous.

And it wasn't good.

He powered down the phone, snapped it in half, and tossed the pieces into the trash beneath a pile of half-eaten snacks and old disposable cups.

He’d think about the motive later.

For now, there were classes to teach—and a meeting to attend later.

Phainon pushed the lounge door open, already back on his face as he headed down the hall.

Showtime.

The sun had vanished hours ago by the time Phainon slipped out of the university’s north wing, bag slung over one shoulder, fingers working at the knot of tension between his shoulder blades.

“Who designs chairs like that?” he muttered under his breath, wincing as a joint cracked. “Sadists.”

He hadn’t planned to stay that long. The idea was to leave with the last of his students—a clean exit, simple. But between actual coursework, department bureaucracy, and discreetly tracking the shifting security net threading itself around campus, the day had devoured itself.

And outside, the streets had changed.

Patrol formations were tighter than they’d been at midday. Routes tweaked by just enough to tell him someone new was managing the perimeter. Cameras—fresh installations, industrial grade—glinted from corners they hadn’t occupied yesterday, lenses panning slow arcs across alleys and thoroughfares.

Phainon clocked it all without slowing.

His phone stayed in his pocket.

The first tail was easy to shake. The checkpoint guard near the southeast barrier lingered a beat too long on his tablet—eyes flicking the roster once, twice, too many. Amateur. Phainon slowed, stretched, pretended to check a

nonexistent notification, and slipped through a propped maintenance door left ajar from the afternoon’s HVAC inspection.

The shortcut was narrow, lined with old piping and the low hum of utility drones. It reeked of stale air and machine oil.

He never took the same route twice.

If he’d noticed the Council shifting patrol routes, then Anaxa had already mirrored the whole sector’s logs six ways from yesterday. Which meant sticking to static blind spots—the ones no one wanted to fix because the paperwork was a nightmare.

Some inefficiencies, it seemed, were still reliable.

He cut down a side alley where two buildings pressed close enough to leave a clean slice of dead zone between their cameras. The trick was timing—wait for the sweep, then move. He counted.

Three. Two. One.

Step through.

Further ahead, an old pedestrian underpass sagged beneath a main road checkpoint. The Council’s drones refused to fly low there—the overhead power lines scrambled their nav systems. He’d tested it last week, watching from a rooftop as three units glitched and spun in place before control pulled them back.

Still held.

He allowed himself a small smile and ducked beneath the archway.

“Alright,” he exhaled, rubbing his face. “Almost there.”

One last detour: a disused service hatch linking to the crawlspace under the old residential block. Off-limits, technically, but the access panel had never been rekeyed after restructuring five years back.

Phainon popped it open with a flathead coin, slipped inside, and let the hatch click shut behind him.

It was cramped. Damp. But quiet.

He leaned against the wall for a moment, eyes half-lidded, listening to the city hum overhead—a thousand frequencies, threads of information and silent orders moving through the bones of the district.

Another hour survived.

He pushed off the wall, breath steadying.

Time to see Anaxa.

The place didn’t look like much at first.

A cramped storage room tucked behind what had once been a machine shop—bare walls, a single flickering overhead strip, and shelves lined with rusted tools. Phainon stepped inside, the door hissing shut behind him with a hollow click.

Then the wall at his back slid into place with a final snap.

The overhead light dimmed, replaced by a subtle ambient glow as the illusion peeled back. Floors smoothed, walls retracted, and concealed panels unfolded, revealing matte surfaces and buried tech humming just below audible. A climate-controlled pulse washed over the space. The transition was seamless—one second derelict, the next the kind of precision-grade infrastructure only someone like Anaxa could rig this smoothly, under this much scrutiny.

Phainon gave a low whistle, slinging his bag onto a nearby counter as he moved further in.

“Gods,” he muttered, hands in his pockets. “Goldweaver could sew herself into the floorboards and she still wouldn’t find this.”

He wandered past the main console, where a holomap flickered above a circular display table—a living, shifting schematic of the district's aetheric grid, rendered in fine pulses of blue and gold. Power resonance mapping. Subtle aetheric seismic readings. Chrysos deployment threads tracked like faint, glimmering spiderwebs, tracing the ghost of Goldweaver's influence through the city.

"Impressive," Phainon mused, leaning down to study a sector junction. "You get bored or something?"

"Didn't build it for aesthetics."

Anaxa's voice came from behind him, tired.

Phainon glanced back to see the shorter man approaching, sleeves rolled up, a fresh cup of something dark in hand. The Heir's expression was as cold as ever, though there was the faintest amusement as well. Phainon grinned.

"No, no—really. I'm starting to feel underdressed."

"Good," Anaxa said. "You should."

The holomap shifted mid-sentence.

A sector of the grid in the eastern quarter flashed. The fine Chrysos threads frayed, pulling back as a dull red ring bloomed outward on the map's surface—an expanding radius marked with clinical precision.

Undertaker's kill field.

It shouldn't have been moving. There hadn't been an official shift. No perimeter change logs or updated warnings.

And yet there it was. Spreading.

The room fell quiet.

Phainon's smile faded, eyes fixed on the ripple as it ate through the map's edge.

Anaxa set his cup down with a careful tap. Neither of them spoke.

A long moment stretched.

Phainon cleared his throat, rolling his shoulders as if shaking off the weight. “Anyway,” he muttered, straightening. “Business before recreational existential dread.”

Anaxa huffed something like a humorless laugh, brushing his palm over the map’s surface. The projection stabilized, shrinking the radius. For now.

“Yeah,” Anaxa said. “Let’s get to it.”

The map blurred again, shifting from aetheric readings to clean satellite overlays and CCTV network logs. Rows of data crawled down one side of the display—Cleaners movement patterns, cross-referenced against traffic reports and archived patrol routes.

Phainon leaned forward, one brow raised. “They’re active,” he muttered. “That’s… not a sweep. That’s a hunt.”

Anaxa didn’t answer, too focused on flicking through logs, pulling in campus checkpoints, public camera captures, even merchant route manifests.

Phainon scanned the map, brow furrowed as he spoke. “Alright. Possible motives: One—they found technology we didn’t know about. Two—someone defected. Three—they’re prepping a lockdown for another culling, though they usually announce those through backchannels first. Or four—”

Anaxa sighed, sharp and tired, cutting him off. “Stop.”

The word hung in the space between them.

Phainon’s mouth closed around the rest of his theory.

Anaxa straightened, dragging a hand down his face before turning his head toward him. “We both know that’s not what this is.”

The room went still for a long, weighted moment.

Phainon exhaled, jaw tightening. “…They got a lead.”

Anaxa nodded once. “Yeah.”

“That’s impossible. We didn’t leave anything behind.” It sounded weak even to him.

“Phainon.” His name, sharp and final.

Phainon groaned, rubbing a hand through his hair. “Fine.”

Anaxa’s features softened for a fraction of a second—exhaustion in his posture more than his expression—then he leaned back, pulling up another set of files. “We’ll figure out how later. For now…”

He tapped the side display, pulling up a branching set of profiles, data sheets, and site maps. Anaxa’s notes scrawled in sharp, meticulous shorthand: Chrysos deployment patterns, Cleaners movement, and Heir registry intel pulls.

“Looks like they’re not just after you,” Anaxa said. “They’re doing recon on all the Heirs. Which means, whether you like it or not, your safety plan’s a priority tonight.”

Phainon rolled his sleeves up, flexing his fingers as he stepped closer to the display. “Alright. Let’s dance.”

Anaxa smirked faintly, pushing a fresh cup of black coffee his way. “Buckle up, buttercup. It’s gonna be a long night.”

Phainon grabbed the cup, raising it like a toast. “Wouldn’t be the first.”

The map’s glow painted their faces as the district’s cold, restless pulse stretched on.

The holoscreens flickered, cycling through the last of the compiled data streams. City grid overlays, operative manifests, resonance field fluctuations. The room's ambient hum had settled into the kind of oppressive quiet that made even the air feel heavy.

Phainon groaned and dropped his head onto the edge of the desk with a dull *thunk*.

Anaxa didn't even look up from his terminal. "Whiny."

Phainon lifted one hand, middle finger lazily extended, cheek still pressed to the cold metal. "If my brain liquefies, I'm haunting you."

"You'd have to die first," Anaxa shot back.

Phainon sighed, sitting up and scrubbing his face with both hands. "Alright, let's make some calls. Threat assessment. First pass."

He pulled up the local operatives roster, flicking through the flagged Heirs and external agents.

"Kitty Phantom Thief?" he suggested halfheartedly.

Anaxa snorted. "No."

"Why not?"

"Because one—she hasn't set foot in this district since the Node Incident. Two—she only intervenes if there's a direct Chrysos acquisition in play. And three…" Anaxa tapped a line of data highlighting her last three known activity clusters. "She sticks to the outer sectors. Statistically, odds of her interfering are under four percent."

Phainon whistled. "That's a hard no, then."

"Glad you're catching up."

They both turned their attention to the next set of names.

“The Tribios,” Phainon muttered, leaning back. “Annoying, but minor.”

Anaxa shrugged. “Agreed—though minor doesn’t mean harmless.”

Phainon sighed. “Problem is I’m weak to kids.”

“Yeah, you’ve got that whole tragic martyr instinct thing. It’s gross.”

Phainon grinned. “You love it.”

“Not the point. Let’s break them down.”

He tapped the display, bringing up the profiles.

Trianne—*Century Gate:* spatial manipulation, teleportation, dimensional folds.
Trinnon—*Purge*: resonance cleansing, anomaly neutralization.
Tribbie—*Enhancer*: proximity-based ability amplification for her siblings.

Phainon stared at the display a moment. “They’re problematic together.”

Anaxa nodded. “Their strength is proximity. Tribbie enhances them both—split the trio and their effectiveness drops dramatically.”

“Alright. Step One: Isolate.”

“Agreed.”

Anaxa narrowed his eyes. “Trianne’s the linchpin. With Century Gate, she can reposition them on a whim. Control the field.”

“So we neutralize her movement. How?”

Phainon considered it. “We limit spatial anchors.”

Anaxa perked up. “Good. She needs fixed resonance points to bend. Disrupt those, her jump range drops. Set traps in high-drift zones, somewhere with unstable aetheric saturation. Her gates will misfire.”

“Like the old Underworks district.”

“Exactly.”

They both marked it on the map.

“Then there’s their morality,” Phainon added, expression cooling. “They hesitate when civilians are in danger.”

“Soft spots,” Anaxa agreed. “Could use it.”

“Not saying hostages—but if we draw them into a sector with protected assets, high collateral risk… odds are they’ll back off or split to protect the civvies.”

Anaxa gave a faint approving nod. “Calculated risk. I like it.”

They both watched the map for a moment in quiet, the steady pulse of city grids cycling through projected overlays.

Phainon rubbed the back of his neck. “Any other cards on the table?”

Anaxa glanced sidelong. “Nothing worth burning yet. Cleaners are still the biggest problem. We deal with the kids if we have to—but priority is staying off CIU’s grid.”

Phainon let out a breath and leaned back in his chair. “Hyacine?”

Anaxa gave a small, dismissive shrug. “She’s not in this.”

“Right,” Phainon agreed. “I figured.”

On the holomap, her signature marker pulsed softly near the quarantine zone perimeter. Not in conflict. Never in conflict.

“Even being Chrysos-affiliated, she’s neutral ground,” Anaxa continued. “No one’s stupid enough to cross that line.”

Phainon smirked faintly. “Not if they want the sectors to stay standing after a breach. Half this district would’ve sunk into the Tide months ago without her stabilizing the drift.”

“Exactly. She doesn’t fight or scheme. She patches everyone up and keeps territories from falling in on themselves. Council, Chrysos, the strays—hell, even the Cleaners would leave her alone.”

“Because even if you win a fight without her,” Phainon muttered, “you’re standing on a dead city after.”

They shared a look, both knowing the unspoken reality: Hyacine’s neutrality wasn’t a courtesy. It was survival. You didn’t shoot the person keeping the ceiling from caving in.

“And frankly,” Phainon added with a tired smile, “she’s a sweetheart. Glad we don’t have to deal with that.”

Anaxa rolled his eyes. “Soft.”

“Says you.”

“Don’t start.”

Anaxa straightened, eyes narrowing at the map again. “That leaves three main contestants.”

“Yeah,” Phainon murmured, already dreading the next names about to come up.

Anaxa tapped a sequence on the control panel, and Goldweaver’s dossier flickered up on the holomap, her signature warping the map like a taut golden net stretched across half the district.

“Next nightmare,” Anaxa muttered.

Phainon grimaced. “Of course.”

“Luckily,” Anaxa continued, voice dry, “I’ve got a temporary workaround.”

Phainon laughed, leaning his elbow against the edge of the console. “Naturally you do. Damn, professor, you think about her so much it’s bordering on obsession. Did she murder your whole bloodline or what?”

Anaxa shot him a look sharp enough to cut glass. “Moving on.”

“She locks down the weave,” He explained, gesturing to the simulation. “No seams, no fractures. Which means no easy exits for your little tricks.”

“Yeah, trying to thread through that’s like sewing steel.”

“Exactly why I built this.” Anaxa swiped a small device schematic onto the display—a crude, flickering model labeled *Fray Pulse*. “Localized aether disruptor. Shakes the weave loose for about a second. You won’t get a clean construct, but you’ll get a tear wide enough to slip through.”

Phainon eyed it skeptically. “And the catch?”

Anaxa shrugged. “Volatile as hell. Might fry everything in a ten-block radius. Might make a gap. Might implode. Depends how lucky you’re feeling.”

“So a desperate GTFO card, not a weapon.”

“Only if there’s no other option. Avoidance first. I’ve mapped unstable seams her grid missed—use those to move. Drones will keep tracking live updates.”

Phainon gave a mock bow. “Yes sir, Sensei.”

Anaxa ignored him, switching to another screen. “Also—you’ve been stabilizing better lately. Since we started regulating your focal points.”

Phainon glanced up at that, quiet.

“You notice,” Anaxa went on, “your constructs hold longer when you don’t overthink the logistics. Instinct, then shape. Not the other way around.”

“I know,” Phainon said, rubbing his wrist absently. “It’s easier when I’m pissed.”

“That’s not a healthy strategy.”

“Never claimed it was.”

A moment of silence stretched between themm.

Then Anaxa cleared his throat. “Alright. Next pain in my ass.”

The holomap shifted again—Undertaker’s sigil expanding like a dead zone across the city’s southern districts.

The icon beside it showed an all-too-familiar shape coiled around her: Pollux.

Phainon made a face. “Gods, why does she even need the dragon? Isn’t the whole ‘kill-on-touch’ bit already overkill?”

“She’s an overachiever,” Anaxa said flatly.

Phainon folded his arms, watching the data stream. “Her ability’s too swift. One touch, she decides if it ends you or not—it’s not even metaphoric.” He sighed. “And then there’s her oversized lizard. Pollux eats the threads I work. Devours the energy I shape before it stabilizes.”

Anaxa glanced at him. “Energy can’t be destroyed, but death alters resonance states. Pollux doesn’t erase your constructs—it converts them. Shifts them into inert decay states you can’t re-thread. That’s why you can’t grab a seam near her.”

Phainon rubbed his temple. “Wonderful. So how the hell do we work around that?”

Anaxa leaned back, tapping his stylus against his chin. “Temporal Echoes.”

Phainon blinked. “Explain.”

Anaxa expanded a cluster of diagrams on the holoscreen—rippling outlines of Phainon's typical constructs, then dimmer, semi-transparent variants. "Your power's strongest when it's rooted in belief. But the echoes you make without anchoring them to reality—they're essentially dream-logic phantoms. Meaning no living thread."

Phainon's brow furrowed, catching on. "And Undertaker's ability only works on living threads."

"Exactly. The echoes will crumble if she touches them, but they won't trigger her kill-state. It's bait."

Phainon beamed, sharp and vicious. "You're a bastard."

"I know."

Anaxa's gaze flicked to the dragon's sigil on the map. "Pollux, though… that's trickier. It rides death sonority. Devours anything with an active life-thread."

"So unless I want to get my head turned into an ornamental paperweight, we need to jam its frequency."

"I'm working on it."

Anaxa pulled a schematic from a side console, starting to sketch an unstable-looking field generator as he spoke. "Pulse Cage. Temporary containment field. Disrupts death-energy harmonics in a localized area. Won't stop Pollux outright, but should scramble its lock for thirty seconds."

Phainon whistled. "Thirty whole seconds. You're spoiling me."

"Better than zero."

He scribbled a few adjustments mid-conversation. "Also—there's a lag before she summons it. Minor, but it exists. Chrysos binding protocol dictates post-summon sync calibration. Dead zone for about eight seconds before the link finalizes."

Phainon straightened. “Meaning if we hit that window and haul ass before she resets the board…”

“We’re clear.”

Anaxa flicked his wrist, and the prototype Pulse Cage diagram rotated in midair. “But—and this is important—only engage her in a pre-staged zone. Pulse Cage has to be active. No improvising.”

“No improvising,” Phainon repeated.

“I mean it.”

“Yeah, yeah. Stage the trap, bait the queen, slam the door shut.”

Anaxa gave him a look. “You make it sound like chess. It’s not. It’s survival.”

Phainon rolled his shoulders. “A survival I’m currently winning, thank you.”

“For now,” Anaxa muttered, adding another line to the diagram. “Alright. That leaves one more problem.”

The map zoomed out, leaving the last contested district blinking cold and blue.

Godslayer.

Phainon groaned outright, head thunking back against the wall again. “We can’t even do anything to him without dying.”

“Technically,” Anaxa muttered, “we could try.”

Phainon shot him a look.

Anaxa held up a hand. “I said technically.”

Another long, miserable silence stretched between them. Neither moved for a good ten seconds.

Then, reluctantly, Anaxa grunted and swiped through another series of feeds. “Alright, fine. I’ll pull up previous interview logs, surveillance threads… Chrysos public records, the good stuff.”

Phainon visibly winced. “You mean the censored, edited-to-hell garbage where everything mildly useful gets blurred out or cut.”

“Yup.”

He groaned again, dragging both hands down his face. “Gods, kill me now.”

Anaxa breathed out. “Sorry, that’s Undertaker’s job.”

They both chuckled, weak and bitter.

Anaxa exhaled through his nose, watching lines of code flicker across the display. “Y’know,” he started, tone casual, like they weren’t ankle-deep in paranoia, “for a bunch of Council grunts with baseline trackers, this sweep’s been uncharacteristically focused.”

Phainon didn’t look up. He was half-sprawled across the desk, scrolling aimlessly through a hollowed-out surveillance grid wishing for death. “They’ve had good days before. Even a stopped clock’s right twice.”

“Mm.” Anaxa’s gaze flicked to a second monitor. “Except this isn’t a random strike of luck. Pincers in the east quadrant, suppression fields along tertiary alleys, no redundancy in the wrong sectors. This grid’s been narrowed.”

Phainon grunted. “So someone got clever.”

Anaxa shrugged, tapping through another sequence. “Problem is, that kind of precision doesn’t happen without a prompt. Nothing’s pulling those routes on its own. Either someone high up flagged a location… or someone fed them something.”

That earned a flicker from Phainon—not a reaction so much as a twitch behind his eyes. He scoffed lightly, brushing a hand through his hair. “Yeah, sure. Because we’ve been so chatty lately.”

“Never said it was you.” Anaxa didn’t glance over. “But narrowing a manhunt like this, without a recorded trace? Someone either saw something, or someone whispered it. Maybe not a name. Just a zone, a direction. Happens.”

Phainon gave Anaxa a humorless smile. “Who’d be stupid enough?”

Anaxa was already moving on, pulling up a fresh stack of public logs. “That’s the part bothering me. Nobody should even know ‘Flame Reaver’.”

For a moment, Phainon didn’t care. Or rather—he told himself he didn’t. It was late, his head was pounding, and this whole damn night felt like one long, dragging crawl through half-finished panic attacks. He let Anaxa’s words hang, unimportant.

But then—the logic of it.

No one should know.

He stared at the edge of his monitor, his reflection faint in the glass.

Anaxa kept talking, more to himself than anyone. “Unless someone’s been watching patterns more than we have. Not hard if they had the right incentive. Or the right proximity.”

Phainon blinked.

Proximity.

And for the first time, the thought brushed him—not fully formed. Just the concept of it. Someone near him. Someone who shouldn’t be able to, who didn’t have a reason to, but somehow…

No.

It was absurd. It was impossible. There wasn’t anyone. Except—

The cold rolled in. Not sharp—not even fast. Just a slow, heavy drop in his chest like something settling inside him. A breath caught and refused to leave.

He tried to shake it. Told himself it wasn’t what he thought.

But his brain was already flipping through faces. Familiar ones. People who couldn’t. People who wouldn’t. And one face lingered just a second too long.

A dull, awful tightness behind his ribs.

No. No, it wasn’t—

“Shit,” Phainon muttered under his breath, louder than he meant to.

Anaxa glanced sidelong, caught the look on his face. “What?”

Phainon dragged a hand down his face. “Nothing. Just… I think I know how. Or might. Later.”

Anaxa studied him for a moment, expression unreadable. “You good?”

“Fine.” Lie. “We’ll talk after this.”

“Alright,” Anaxa said after a pause, and turned back to the screens.

But something in the room had changed.

Phainon kept his head down, kept his breathing steady.

He told himself it was nothing.

But the cold didn’t leave.

The room had gone too quiet.

The projection feeds kept shifting—old broadcasts, civilian-captured scraps, Chrysos-vetted “safety campaigns” with their sanitized vigilante footage. All of them featuring one thing neither of them wanted to look at anymore:

Godslayer.

“This is a waste of time,” Phainon muttered. His voice came out hoarse, somewhere between exhaustion and resignation.

“Patterns leave residue,” Anaxa replied, not looking up, scanning half a dozen overlapping data windows. His tone was maddeningly patient. “Even curated footage. No one’s perfect every frame.”

Phainon scowled, but stayed put.

They kept going. Clip after clip. Godslayer decimating Black Tide aberrants. Leveling rogue sectors. Every shot perfectly staged. Every move engineered for dominance.

Then—one of the more recent feeds, timestamped just under three months ago. A skirmish at the edge of Zone K7. Minor incident really.

Anaxa slowed it to quarter-speed on instinct.

Godslayer landed a heavy finishing strike against an anomaly spawn—textbook form. Clothes snapping, Guantlets carving a clean arc.

But Anaxa’s brow furrowed.

He scrubbed back. Again. Slower this time.

Right after the strike—a half-beat lag, barely perceptible. A micro-shift in torso alignment. Left shoulder tightening, mid-spine pulling slightly inward.

Anaxa’s head tilted, just a degree.

“…Huh.”

“What?” Phainon asked, not bothering to mask the tedium in his voice.

Anaxa rewound. Highlighted the alignment shift. “Doesn’t finish the torso rotation.”

“So?”

Anaxa pulled up another clip. Different day. Different fight. Same maneuver.

Same hitch.

Now Phainon leaned in, interest reluctantly sparking. “…Wait.”

“I thought it was a recoil reflex,” Anaxa muttered. “But no. It’s always left side, guarding something.”

He started cross-referencing. Layering multiple high-speed captures, phasing them together like ghost images. Every fight-ending strike had the same compensation. A minuscule body load. A protective tension in the same spot.

“Compensated vector load,” Anaxa whispered.

“A what now?”

“It’s when someone instinctively shields a structural vulnerability—think old injury or nerve cluster. You adjust without thinking.”

Phainon’s pulse skipped. “Wait, pull older footage.”

Anaxa didn’t argue. He called up a Council promo reel from three years back. Different setting, same godawful slogans. Slowed the playback.

And there it was. Mid-spine. Same pivot.

“Motherfucker,” Phainon whispered, a grin creeping in.

But then his brain clicked another gear.

“Wait—” He snapped his fingers, eyes narrowing. “Do we have any footage of him with Undertaker and Pollux?”

Anaxa raised a brow, intrigued. “Why?”

“Because if that’s what I think it is, and if Pollux is bound to death resonance—” Phainon was already leaning closer. “—then if something’s off, that dragon’s gonna react.”

Anaxa quickly pulled up a joint-op recording—both Godslayer and Undertaker on-site during the K-Field incident. Two Heir powerhouses in a closed kill zone.

They scrubbed through it. Godslayer moving like a storm, Undertaker trailing death, Pollux a massive, suffocating presence in the sky.

And then it happened.

An aberrant got a lucky shot—a spike catching Godslayer dead center in the upper back.

It barely staggered him. But Pollux, normally detached and deathly still, *twitched*. A flicker of tension in her coils, head snapping toward him, a snarl curling from her throat.

Phainon’s heart dropped to his stomach.

“Wait—there.” He jabbed a finger at the dragon’s reaction. “Look at her! She felt it.”

Anaxa froze the frame, zoomed in. Pollux’s gaze locked, pupils a needlepoint slit.

Both of them went silent.

For a moment, neither spoke. Then Anaxa’s lips split into a grin, sharp and feral.

“Well,” he murmured, “guess we’ve got a damn lead.”

Phainon huffed a disbelieving laugh, half exhilaration, half horror. “High five or breakdown first?”

“I vote both.”

Anaxa opened a fresh overlay—a neutral anatomy grid, extrapolating from the angles they’d recorded. “We’re not pinpointing it yet, but it’s thoracic. Upper mid-spine, somewhere between T7 and T11.”

Phainon ran a hand through his hair, still staring at the frozen image of Pollux’s reaction.

“Holy shit,” he whispered.

A vulnerability. A real one.

And for the first time all night—it wasn’t guesswork.

Anaxa started sketching out spatial vectors and potential approach angles, marking critical zones around the upper thoracic region with digital indicators. The room’s light dimmed further as tactical blueprints bled into the screen.

Phainon watched him work, a small crooked grin forming. “Alright, professor. What’s the play?”

Anaxa didn’t look up. “We don’t use it.”

Phainon blinked. “The hell do you mean, we don’t—?”

Anaxa raised a hand to cut him off, voice sharp and final. “*Unless we absolutely have to.* This isn’t for sport, Phainon. Or revenge. Or whatever spiraling breakdown fantasy you’ve got loaded in your head. This is a failsafe. A last-resort option if we’re pinned, dying, and out of time.”

The grin slipped from Phainon’s face. His chest tightened—not out of offense, but because he knew Anaxa was right.

“…Yeah,” he muttered. “I wasn’t planning to get creative with it.”

Anaxa finally glanced up, eyes sharp. “Good. Because whether you admit it or not, you’re not built for that kind of kill. And I’m not here to watch you collapse.”

A moment passed.

Then Anaxa leaned back, sighing. “Alright. Now that *that’s* settled—” he dismissed the screen with a flick of his wrist, the projections flickering out of existence. “Let’s circle back to your theory.”

Phainon’s brow creased. “What theory?”

Anaxa’s gaze pinned him. “The one where you said you’ve got an idea how the Council and Heirs started closing in on you.”

Silence. Immediate. The shift in the air was so sharp it felt like the room lost a degree of warmth.

Phainon’s stomach lurched, his earlier adrenaline curdling into something sour.

“Right,” he said, voice tight.

His fingers drummed once against the edge of the table—and stilled.

The moment lingered but Anaxa didn’t press. He just waited.

And somewhere deep behind Phainon’s eyes, that gnawing suspicion he’d buried days ago—maybe longer—started clawing its way up again.

He swallowed hard.

“Let’s…table the killing-Godslayer part for now,” he muttered, staring at nothing. “And…yeah. Let’s talk about that.”

The room stayed cold.

Anaxa only nodded.

“Alright.”

Phainon braced both hands against the table’s edge, the pulse in his wrist ticking like a war drum.

“I think it’s Mydei.”

He didn’t look up when he said it. Just stared at the scarred surface of the terminal, the words landing in the space between them like a dropped weapon.

Anaxa’s brow twitched. “What about him?”

Phainon’s jaw clenched, a pulse of pain behind his temple as he forced it out. “I think he’s working with the Chrysos Heirs.”

The room seemed to constrict. Even the hum of the monitors felt distant.

Anaxa didn’t move. When he finally spoke, his voice was careful, almost cautious. “As an Heir?”

Phainon’s head snapped up, eyes like cold glass.

“No.” The word cut the air clean. Final. “Lower than that. But high enough.”

Silence pooled between them.

“I haven’t seen him in days,” Phainon went on, voice tighter now. “Which isn’t unusual on its own—we both vanish sometimes. But the timing, Anaxa. The CIU grid closes in. The Council tightens their leash. And the only person close enough to even have a chance of connecting me to Flame Reaver is him.”

He took a breath, rough and uneven.

“But if they really knew? If they were sure? They’d come straight for me. They wouldn’t waste time fencing off this district, sweeping channels.

They’d come for me.” His hand lifted, fingers flexing once, twice, before dropping to the table again.

He tried to laugh, and it sounded wrong.

“Maybe he doesn’t know, then, right? ‘Cause if he did, I’d be pinned to a Chrysos slab by now. Or dust. Or worse.”

His mouth kept moving. The words like teeth clicking together.

“Maybe it’s nothing. Maybe it’s coincidence. Maybe I’m seeing shadows where there’s just—” he gestured vaguely at the room, at nothing “—the usual rot.”

Another laugh, sharper, hollow.

“Or maybe… maybe he knows and he’s waiting. Drawing it out. And it’s a sick joke, right? Flame Reaver blindsided by his own—” he swallowed hard “—his own… person.”

“Phainon.”

“Maybe I should ask him, you know? Just show up, like ‘Hey buddy, happen to be stabbing me in the back? ‘Cause I’d love to pencil that in between my existential crisis and your fucking sweet smile.”

Anaxa’s voice cut in firm.

“Phainon.”

He didn’t stop. Didn’t even hear it.

“Maybe none of it matters, you know? ‘Cause if it’s him, I’m already screwed. And if it’s not, well—hell, maybe I’ll owe him an apology for suspecting him between getting executed and processed.”

“Phainon.”

“Or maybe it’s all some Chrysos test, huh? See how fast the Flame Reaver can break down. Ten creds they say I crack in under a week—”

The slap cracked through the room like a gunshot.

Phainon staggered back a half step, blinking, one hand lifting to his cheek where the heat bloomed sharp.

Anaxa’s hand fell to his side, face hard, gaze unflinching.

“Stop.”

For a long moment, neither of them moved.

Phainon’s chest rose and fell, eyes unfocused, the weight in his chest anchoring him to the floor.

Then, quietly, like glass cracking, he muttered, “Yeah.”

Anaxa let out a breath through his nose, but there was no relief in it.

“I’m coming back later. Sit with it. Don’t do anything stupid.”

Phainon didn’t answer.

Anaxa left.

He sat alone.

The hum of Anaxa’s gear filled the room, a steady, mechanical whine. It should’ve been background noise. Lately, it wasn’t.

Just tired.

You’re just tired.

He told himself that, though it didn’t sound like his voice.

The phone was still on the table. He stared at it for a while before picking it up, thumb hovering over the screen longer than necessary.

The thread with Mydei was pinned to the top.

The last message sat there, unopened.

Phainon✷:

Hey. Didn’t see you today. Hope you’re eating.

Nothing.

He sent another.

Phainon✷:

You alive?

The little status bar stayed empty. No read receipt. Just the nothingness stretching wider than it had any right to.

He set the phone down.

The room didn’t feel right. He couldn’t tell what it was—the angle of the shadows, the way the datapad on the shelf seemed too far to the left, like it had shifted a fraction while his back was turned.

Or maybe it was the air.

It felt like being watched.

Not by a person.

By the room itself.

A voice surfaced, not real but real enough.

You should’ve known better.

He flinched. Nothing there. Of course.

He scrubbed a hand over his face. Tried to shake it loose. His stomach felt tight, hollow. It wasn’t even the idea. It wasn’t that.

It was the waiting. The not-knowing. The ache of a half-dead hope.

Backstabber.

The word rippled through his head again.

But when he tried to pin it on Mydei, it slipped.

Landed squarely on his own chest.

His hands wouldn’t stop shaking slightly. He clenched them tight until his nails bit into his palms, a faint flicker of heat flashing to life in one, dying a second later.

He told himself it was fine. That it didn’t mean anything. People got busy. Signals dropped.

But then another flicker of memory.

Blood on his hands.

A voice, somewhere behind him, calling his name, hoarse and breaking.

A ruined horizon.

You knew better than this.

The breath left him sharp and uneven.

“It’s not him,” he said out loud, just to hear it. “He… he wouldn’t.”

And something, not a voice but a shape in the bones of his thoughts, pressed back.

Wouldn’t he?

His throat closed. The world tilted, the edges of things bending—only in the corners of his vision, only when he wasn’t looking straight at them.

The phone screen stayed blank.

And the thing that cracked him, the thing that slid under his skin like a blade, wasn’t the possibility that Mydei had done it.

It was knowing—knowing with a hollow, gut-deep certainty—that if he had…

Phainon would forgive him.

Would make excuses.

Would crawl through glass to find a reason it wasn’t his fault.

And that was worse than betrayal.

He swallowed hard, the lump in his throat dry and sharp.

His voice came out thin, almost a whisper.

“If it’s him… it’s fine.”

He waited for it to sound like a lie.

It didn’t.

He meant it.

He truly meant it.

Somewhere deep beneath Council jurisdiction, far from the choking city lights and Chrysos territory, a woman stood alone before a wall of aging monitors.

The light from the screens carved sharp hollows into her face, all angles and cold intent. Data flickered. Surveillance feeds. Corrupted files attempting to rebuild themselves in fits and fragments.

An operative lingered nearby, his posture stiff beneath the weight of silence.

“Chrysos presence spiked in Quadrants Six through Nine,” he reported, voice thin. “Confirmed Heir deployment. Cleaners sweeping the southern sectors. Should we pull CIU teams back? Or wait for the Heirs to finish it?”

The woman’s mouth curled. Not quite a smile—something crueler.

“And leave our orchard to scavengers?” she murmured. “No. Let them flush out the rot… but the harvest is ours.”

The operative hesitated. “Respectfully, ma’am… their activity patterns suggest they’ve narrowed in on something. A location. Possibly the Flame Reaver’s sector. Should we—”

“You misunderstand,” she said softly, the tone of someone correcting a child. “A wildfire doesn’t care which spark set the earth alight. It consumes what’s left behind.”

She stepped forward, tapping a distorted monitor. A fragmentary file staggered to life—scorched data bleeding into static. Most of it unreadable. All but one thing in the top corner, still clinging like a burn scar:

NeiKos496.

The woman’s expression barely shifted. A sliver of satisfaction. A predator scenting blood in the water.

“A single blighted tree spoils the grove,” she whispered. “Fortunate for us… seems the Heirs already marked the one to cull.”

The operative said nothing.

The woman’s gaze lingered on the burned data a moment longer, before turning away into the dark.

Caenis smiled.

Chapter End Notes

Happy Pride Month btw, where are my fellow aces at / ???
(Or anyone obviously, love u all)

Chapter 14: Mydei’s Big Stupid Feelings Hour

Chapter Summary

> Mydei wakes up, discovers literally everyone in his life is either lying, dying, or about to be punched. Escapes medical detention with the help of a morally conflicted medic, elbows a guy into next week, and begins his dramatic sprint through a crumbling death facility in search of his maybe-traitorous boyfriend. Alarms blaring, grudges flourishing.

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! First off, I owe you an apology for how long this update took. I genuinely meant to have it out weeks ago, but then Myphai Week happened, and I got completely caught up in that. On top of that, the original draft I had for this ended up getting sidelined right up until now.
>
> I’m honestly really sorry for the delay, and I appreciate your patience more than I can say. I’ll do my best moving forward to stick to a weekly update schedule for this fic. I really hope you’re all still interested in following along, thank you so much for sticking with me!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The room was quiet.

Not silent in the pure sense of the word—there was always that low, steady hum of suppression arrays embedded in the walls, a muted resonance you couldn’t quite hear, but felt, like the pressure of a deep current beneath your skin. A soundless thrum that dulled the edges of thought, made you forget how unfiltered air used to feel when you could actually breathe it.

Mydei didn’t know how long he’d been here.

Days. A week. Longer, maybe. Time blurred in places like this. No one kept track, and if they did, they weren’t in the habit of sharing.

His wrists rested loosely against his lap, thin metal bands cinched around them—dull Chrysos alloy, the kind designed to look harmless at a glance. Enough give to move, to eat, to avoid sores at the edges of flesh. But the inhibitors buried inside would surge the moment he even considered pushing past them. Subtle, elegant enforcement.

He sat against the far wall, shoulders sagging. His knuckles were wrapped in sterile strips of med-cloth, flesh beneath still in the process of weaving itself whole, uneven where accelerated healing had botched the symmetry. The Heirs’ med-tech could repair the damage easily. He hadn’t let them finish the job.

This wasn’t a high-containment black site.

He knew what those looked like. The state-run detention cubes for war criminals and rogue operatives. Private facilities built for people whose body counts filled entire reports. The Council’s own disappearing places for dissidents they couldn’t afford to martyr.

And somewhere deeper, beneath the polished veneer of sanctioned justice, the Heirs maintained their own.

This wasn’t one of those.

It was containment, yes—but different in a way you couldn’t name at first glance. There were no kill-switches humming at full charge. No reinforced plates buried behind the walls. No squads stationed outside the door, waiting for a breach order that would never come.

The danger here wasn’t the threat of violence.

It was the absence of it.

A room meant for people they couldn’t leave unchecked, but weren’t willing to treat like outsiders.

For those caught between duty and circumstance—too burdened with dangerous knowledge to be let loose, too familiar to be discarded.

People the Heirs still cared about.

People like him.

He could imagine how many rooms like this might exist across the city. Tucked-away sublevels, repurposed admin suites, forgotten medical wings disguised as emergency shelters. Spaces built for those rare moments when politics and loyalty collided, and the only humane option was to hold someone close while keeping them out of reach.

But this room—this was different.

There were no other cells here. No sounds of restraints locking. No endless surveillance feeds threading through the corners. Only the containment arrays and the faint shimmer of glyph-lines etched along the far wall, gold against cool steel, like the last traces of some half-forgotten script.

Humane, they called it.

The best they could give him, under the circumstances.

Safer than what the Council would've demanded. Kinder than what the state would've offered.

He understood why they'd done it.

Didn't mean it was easy to swallow.

Since he'd arrived, no one had spoken his name.

They brought him food, clean bandages, whatever else he needed to keep going, but conversation had thinned to necessities, and even those came sparingly.

He shifted, a slow ache blooming along his shoulders. The wall behind him was cold—a weightless kind of cold that clung to the skin long after you'd

noticed it. Somewhere above, the arrays flickered again, a soft pulse in the stale air.

And for the first time since they'd brought him here—however long ago that was—the thought came, uninvited:

How in the hell did it come to this?

Mydei exhaled slowly, letting his head tip back against the wall. The room's pale, artificial light hummed faintly above him, a ceaseless glow that stripped the edges from everything it touched. Even memories felt sterile beneath it.

But he remembered.

Too clearly.

It had started in the archives.

He hadn't known what he was chasing that night. A name, maybe. A trace. Some half-erased report buried beneath layers of the data. Something he could use. He'd expected the search to be quiet, difficult, frustrating.

He hadn't expected what he found.

And when the alarms screamed—shrill, overlapping, setting every emergency protocol in the room alight—it was already too late to pretend he hadn't seen it. The containment units powered to full, barrier humming alive, and the restraint teams came in like they had a chance of controlling the situation.

Mydei's body had kept moving. Muscle memory and instinct, a dull awareness of the room around him, but his mind had already gone elsewhere. Staring down the thing he wasn't supposed to find.

The commands had come sharp and immediate.

Stand down, Godslayer. Disengage. Step away from the terminal.

The words barely registered.

Not until one of them—a kid, fresh-faced and too green for this kind of job—stepped forward, a hand outstretched like it was possible to reason with a man whose balance had already slipped.

The snap of bone was sharp, sudden, and horrifyingly human.

Reflex before thought.

The scream that followed still hung somewhere in the corners of his memory. A raw, desperate sound, like something primal forced through a throat too young. It clawed at the edges of his recollection.

And that's when it started to come apart.

Containment fields crackled, slamming into place. More figures flooding in, weapons raised, ciphers burning hot against the air. Orders shouted over each other.

Do not engage. Stand down. Stand down.

His knuckles still ached at the memory of it—metal, bone, maybe both. The archives reduced to molten slag and splintered glass beneath his hands. What had once been history, erased in minutes. The fields had flickered under the strain. Bodies moving too fast. Arrays faltering.

He hadn't resisted.

Not when the order came to drop him.

Not even when the bindings hit.

And then—the voice.

Small. High. Frayed at the edges.

"Stop! Stop, stop, stop! Leave De alone!"

A child’s voice.

But not a child.

Tribbie.

He hadn’t seen her. Didn’t have to. The sound had cut through everything else like a blade. It made the room pause, breathless. Every weapon lowered a fraction.

The world had gone still in that instant.

He remembered the taste of blood at the back of his throat. Couldn’t say if it was his. Hands raw, the ruined wreckage of the archive at his back, and a line of wide-eyed operatives in front of him.

Then came Aglaea.

He hadn’t expected her.

She didn’t handle breaches herself. Delegated those things, as any of them would’ve. But this wasn’t any breach. And the look she carried wasn’t protocol.

At first, maybe.

The golden threads bonded him tight, coiled like living things. Truth-weaving—the kind that left no room for lies, pulling words from your throat before you even formed them.

He could still feel the faint prickle under his skin.

And she’d asked him one question.

“Who is the Flame Reaver, Mydeimos?”

The name had sat heavy behind his teeth. He could’ve spoken it. Could’ve ended it right there.

But the shape of it wouldn’t leave his throat without breaking something irreversible inside him.

Even dazed, battered, barely standing, he’d seen the flicker in Aglaea’s expression. That moment where detachment cracked, and something quieter—something deeply, horribly human—surfaced. Not for the lost archive.

For him.

Her hand had almost lifted. Hovering just near his face, like she meant to—he didn’t know what. A gesture half-born. A comfort never given. It hadn’t mattered. The intent was enough.

Then the decision came.

No handoff.

They wouldn’t send him to the Ministry’s vaults, or let the state make a martyr of him.

They brought him here.

Not a cell. Not quite.

Isolated.

Safer than the alternatives.

And he understood, truly. He understood all of it. Every reason they gave, every line they couldn’t cross.

Didn’t mean it cut any less.

A long breath rattled from his lungs.

He closed his eyes, tried to slow the riot of thought, but it went where it always did—the one place he’d been avoiding.

Phainon.

The name scraped at the inside of his skull. He didn’t speak it. Couldn’t. His throat worked around it, an ache where the word should’ve gone.

It hadn’t mattered how careful Phainon had been.

The Heirs didn’t have his name, didn’t know his face. But they knew one thing.

He was close to Mydei.

And that was enough.

He could picture it now—patrols thickening around the places he’d been seen, checkpoints blooming like sickness around familiar corners, surveillance fields stretched tight across every space that he’d ever visited.

And the archive…

Maybe that was why his hands had kept moving.

Why he hadn’t stopped until every terminal cracked, every glyph bled out, every file warped beyond recognition.

Subconsciously, even then—protecting him.

Not a calculated erasure.

Just instinct.

A refusal, bone-deep, to leave anything behind that might be used against him.

Against *Phainon*.

And in those last ragged moments—before the archive was silenced—it hadn’t been the Heirs gnawing at him.

It had been *him*.

Phainon.

It twisted sharp beneath his ribs.

He should talk about it.

Not to them. Not to anyone here.

But to someone.

Or at least think it through, let it bleed out where it wouldn’t turn rotten in his chest.

The ceiling buzzed on, indifferent.

Somewhere overhead, the hum of the containment systems shifted. A subtle recalibration, a slight drop in the room’s ambient pressure, the faint ripple of field harmonics re-aligning themselves.

Across the far wall, a cluster of proximity beacons flickered to life. Thin lines of interface light traced clean patterns around the door’s frame, dormant blue giving way to soft gold. Lock sequences disengaged in quiet succession—not the jarring stutter of a breach response, but the smooth rhythm of an override someone had the authority to initiate.

He exhaled.

There was no need to guess.

The door slid open with a muted hiss, the pressurized seal breaking cleanly as reinforced alloy panels retracted into the walls. No alarms. No containment squads on standby. No drones crowding the entryway.

Only Aglaea.

She moved like certainty given form—every step unhurried, her presence folding into the sterile hush without disturbing it. No weapons, though the absence meant little; she’d never needed visible threats to command a room.

Her gaze found him where he sat, and for a moment, she simply regarded him.

Then, quietly—a name:

“Mydeimos.”

He didn’t reply. Not immediately.

She spoke again, softer this time.

“May I sit?”

He could feel the ache building behind his temples—a dull pressure at the base of his skull, not from her, but from what conversations like this always asked of him.

“Of course,” he murmured, voice rough from disuse.

Aglaea crossed the room without hesitation and lowered herself onto the floor beside him.

She made no immediate move to speak.

And that, more than anything, told him how serious this was.

Aglaea had always known how to wield silence. Not as absence, but as invitation. A way to let others fill the space, to measure the shape of what they chose to leave unsaid.

And Mydei—despite everything—recognized the mercy in that.

He didn’t need to look to feel her watching him.

She always had.

“What do you need, Aglaea?” He asked.

A soft exhale.

“You already know.”

He allowed himself the faintest tilt of his mouth—not quite a smile, more the suggestion of one. “I’m not giving it up.”

She inclined her head, unsurprised. She’d known before she crossed the threshold, before she’d ordered the locks disengaged. Still, something in her gaze dimmed—not disappointment, merely a quiet acknowledgment.

“I didn’t think you would,” she murmured.

For a moment, nothing else. Then, as if deciding there was little sense in postponing what had to be said, she spoke.

“The Council has formally requested your handover.”

That earned a brow lift from him.

“Of course they have.” His voice was dry, unsurprised. He’d expected as much the moment Aglaea had intervened, claiming jurisdiction before anyone else could. What caught him was how long it had taken for them to escalate.

Aglaea’s gaze never wavered. “It’s been… more persistent than anticipated. Beyond what protocol would require under the circumstances. Repeated demands, direct appeals to the Sovereign Circle. Some not even through sanctioned channels.”

There it was.

He dragged a hand down his face, feeling the faint, residual ache of bruising beneath his palm. “What else.”

She hesitated, though with Aglaea, even hesitation was a deliberate pause rather than uncertainty.

“We’ve increased security sweeps around sectors you’ve frequented. Old safehouses, contact points, workplace.” A glance toward him, slightly apologetic. “But the Council’s mirrored the pattern. Independent

deployments, no formal notice. Civilian grids, former operative corridors, assets long cleared of any actionable threat. They've doubled patrol strength, tightened surveillance, deployed active detainment fields in areas you haven't touched in years."

A faint line formed between her brows, a sign of thought more than concern.

"On record, it's nonsensical. The Chrysos Heirs hold purview over this situation. The Council retains no authority here—they answer to separate mandates, govern vigilante designations and rogue oddities, not matters concerning Chrysos operatives."

Mydei felt his pulse edge higher at that.

"And you've confronted them."

A slight inclination of her head confirmed it.

"We logged the first instance as a miscommunication. The second as unauthorized overreach. By the third, it was clear the pattern wasn't accidental."

He frowned at the implications. The Council preferred subterfuge, the sort of veiled manipulations one uncovered only after they'd already served their purpose. Open posturing didn't suit them.

"There's more," she continued.

"They've commissioned a new task unit. Code designation: the Cleaners."

That earned a sharper look from him.

"Never heard the name."

"Neither had we," she admitted, a trace of irritation slipping beneath the calm. "Officially, they're listed as a rapid-response division. Neutralization, asset retrieval, high-risk containment operations. The type of force typically reserved for black-site purges, *not* citywide civilian grids."

Task forces didn’t manifest fully operational just like that. Not with this kind of reach.

“How new are they, exactly?”

Aglaea’s expression tightened. “On record, barely a quarter-cycle. In practice… seasoned. Too coordinated for a fresh assembly. I’ve monitored their field patterns, tactical maneuvers, encrypted comm protocols. It’s precise work, Mydei. This is a unit built from experienced hands, repositioned beneath a new title.”

A long breath drew from his lungs.

He didn’t need to ask what came next.

“…They’re after the Flame Reaver as well,” she confessed.

He felt it land in his chest like a weight.

“Why.”

A question for the sake of asking. Neither of them expected an answer.

Aglaea’s jaw flexed, and for the first time since entering, the edges of her composure frayed—not visibly, but in the words that followed.

“I can’t say with certainty. They’ll name their reasons: threat classifications, public security justifications, escalation clauses. But it doesn’t align. Not at this scale.”

She paused, studying him. Weighing the risk of the truth against the futility of withholding it.

“They’ve been watching him for months. Longer than I realized. His operational file’s been elevated beyond reason. Every incident, including the Node collapses, and every sublevel blackout conveniently traced to his shadow, even when evidence pointed elsewhere. The narrative’s been shaped for some time now.”

She let that settle between them.

“I believed it, once,” she admitted.

Mydei closed his eyes.

It struck differently, hearing it spoken aloud, knowing what he knew now.

He’s—

The thought twisted sharp behind his ribs.

Aglaea didn’t press.

“I don’t know what’s true anymore,” she said quietly. “And neither should you.”

He exhaled, a humorless sound. “That lesson came a little late.”

She didn’t refute it.

There was no point.

He angled a glance toward her. “Anything else I should brace for before you tell me whatever the worst part is?”

A faint, weary curve of her mouth.

“You aren’t going to like it.”

He huffed a breath, leaned his head back against the wall. “Didn’t expect to.”

Aglaea didn’t waste time with preambles.

“Someone submitted a private request for you.”

His gaze flicked toward her, brow lifting in quiet inquiry. “Another transfer request?”

“Not to a faction,” she clarified. “To a person.”

That made him still. The slight shift in his posture wasn’t much, but it was enough.

She continued. “It wasn’t processed through formal channels. It came through a flagged echo point—one we abandoned six years ago. Buried deep in an obsolete relay center outside Grid South. Whoever sent it either didn’t know it was still monitored, or didn’t believe anyone would be watching.”

Mydei straightened slightly, a frown cutting through his features. “And you intercepted it.”

“It brushed against an old security protocol I left embedded in the relay’s substructure.” For the first time, a faint edge of displeasure tightened the corners of her mouth. “It was addressed directly. No chain of command, no formal handling. Only your designation, and a set of coordinates.”

His designation.

Godslayer.

A slow breath left him as he weighed his next words. “You know who sent it.”

Aglaea hesitated.

Second time today.

Her expression didn’t shift, but he caught it in the slight furrow of her brow, the subtle tension across her shoulders.

“I have a suspect.”

He didn’t press. He knew she would tell him.

“Caenis.”

The name struck like a stone into still water.

Leader of the Council. The one figure in all their constructed hierarchy who answered to no one.

He didn’t ask whether she was certain. If Aglaea spoke a name without formal proof, it meant her instincts had already outpaced evidence. And her instincts, he’d learned, rarely missed their mark.

“You have proof?” he asked anyway, because some part of him needed to hear it.

“No.” The word came quiet. “Not the kind I could take before a tribunal. The origin code piggybacking the transmission was an obsolete priority designation. Level Grey. Before it was scrubbed, there were three individuals with direct clearance.”

She held his gaze without flinching.

“The other two are dead.”

He let out a quiet curse under his breath and leaned forward, elbows braced against his knees. The pressure in his skull sharpened, a dull ache threatening to bloom into something worse.

“And the request itself?”

“Immediate physical transfer. No review or governmental oversight. Relocation to an off-record holding site. The destination tagged as restricted access, routed through Council internal systems.”

“They want me removed,” he murmured.

“They want you somewhere no one can witness what comes next.”

It wasn’t the same thing.

And it was infinitely worse.

For a long moment, neither of them spoke. The hum of containment fields, the soft shudder of internal conduits recalibrating, filled the room's quiet.

When Aglaea spoke again, her voice was calm, but softened around the edges in a way few ever heard from her.

"Which is why I need to know what happened in the Archives."

She didn't phrase it as a request. Not this time.

Her gaze held his. "What did you see."

And there was no deflection left to offer her.

He watched her for a long moment, weighing what little he could afford to say against what refusing would cost.

At last, he answered.

"Nothing worth killing over."

He saw the flicker then—the infinitesimal shift in the line of her jaw, the tightening of her fingers where they rested against her thigh. Anyone else would've missed it. But Mydei had known her too long, seen her weather too many impossible hours, not to recognize the fracture when it surfaced.

She was afraid.

Not of him.

For him.

Aglaea drew a breath. She didn't press further. Not because she didn't want to, but because she knew him well enough to recognize the futility of it.

"They've been watching you longer than you realize," she said at last. "Since the beginning. After we took you in."

That one landed.

He didn’t react visibly, but she would have felt the shift in him anyway.

She didn’t remark on it.

“Council assets embedded within external oversight teams. Passive surveillance, mostly. Movement records, incident reports, unofficial logs. No direct interference, at least none I’ve been able to confirm. But the eyes were there, Mydeimos. For years.” A pause. “I only uncovered the extent of it recently.”

He swallowed the sharp taste rising at the back of his throat. He could’ve pretended it surprised him, but there was no point.

It made a terrible kind of sense.

Aglaea didn’t dwell on it.

She glanced toward the sealed door, more a signal than a motion.

“When you decide to stop carrying it alone, you’ll know where to find me.” The words were even, but the steel beneath them remained unmistakable. “We are not handing you over. Not to them. Not to anyone.”

A final look.

And then, as she rose to leave, a last quiet warning.

“You’ll have a visitor soon. Prepare yourself.”

She didn’t wait for his reply.

The door’s locking seals disengaged with a sequence of clean, toneless chimes. She crossed the threshold, and the locks whispered closed behind her.

And then, as so often before, the room was empty.

And he was alone.

He drew a long breath.

Held it.

And let it out, willing his pulse to steady.

Piece it together.

Slowly.

Cleanly.

Without panic.

His mind, unbidden, drifted to the Archives.

The Heirs' Archive. The most secure, quarantined data reserve within their entire operational structure. It housed far more than mission logs and threat assessments. Buried within its vaults were personnel dossiers, class-locked biometric records, resonance blueprints, and incursion incident reports no authority outside the Chrysos Heirs had either the legal standing or the extrajurisdictional access to even request—let alone seize.

Its containment protocols were absolute. Unauthorized access didn't merely trigger a failsafe—it initiated progressive neural degradation, system-induced biofeedback seizures, and, in at least one recorded case, a fatal cascade collapse before the breach could propagate.

It was, in every conceivable sense, untouchable.

And yet—it had moved.

Not a sanctioned system migration. Not a crisis containment measure or routine clearance reallocation.

Moved.

Shifted from its subterranean stronghold beneath Kharon Sector to a Council-designated underground zone.

He’d seen the markers himself. Even through the haze and bloodied fractures of that room, the transfer indicators had burned through the fog of his mind.

The Archive didn’t drift.

It didn’t go missing.

Which left only two possibilities.

Either one of the Heirs had sold them out.

He discarded the thought before it could fully take shape. Not out of sentiment, but because the integrity of their structure had never allowed for such a weakness. If betrayal within the Heirs had been so easily bought, the faction would’ve devoured itself years ago.

Which meant only one other explanation remained.

The Council had orchestrated it.

And by every known protocol, that should have been impossible.

How?

He shut his eyes and ran the permutations.

A forged transfer order?

No. Even under emergency override permissions, Aglaea’s passive trace systems would have flagged synthetic access within minutes. The Heirs’ archives didn’t acknowledge foreign authorization masks. Their isolation protocols were hardwired, immutable.

Repurposed emergency clearances?

Riskier. Technically feasible during a declared crisis, perhaps bypassing surface pings. But even then, multiple biometric confirmations and sequencing protocols existed to prevent precisely this kind of infiltration.

Which left one plausible vector.

An internal Council asset.

Someone with native system clearance. Not a proxy or contract agent—but a legitimate, credentialed figure high enough to move between Council and Heir systems. Someone embedded long enough, positioned precisely enough, to bypass the security lattice entirely, reroute the Archive, and leave no trace until it was already beyond their reach.

And now the pattern could no longer be ignored.

The timing wasn’t coincidence.

The Cleaners.

The sudden scrutiny around his movements.

The Council’s fixation on the Flame Reaver—and, unspoken but undeniable, on him.

It wasn’t paranoia.

It was orchestration.

And the Archive hadn’t been moved for its own sake.

It had been taken.

Why?

His stomach twisted sharply, some instinctive wrongness settling deep behind his ribs, even before the answer emerged.

Because the Archive housed more than operational records.

It contained full profiles. Complete biometric matrices for every active Heir. Command signatures. Enmeshment threads.

And the original function of the Nodes—

His eyes snapped open.

Mimics.

He surged upright, breath catching in his throat.

That was the purpose. The intention. Synthetic resonance constructs—indistinguishable from the original, capable of carrying voice patterns, clearance credentials, even the weaponized abilities of their counterparts.

The Nodes had been designed to weave them.

To replicate authority figures.

To replace *them*.

And if the Council had gained control of the Archive's contents—

The mimics wouldn't be citizens.

They would be them.

Chrysos Heirs.

His pulse thundered against his throat, a cold sweat rising along his back.

The project had been terminated. The Nodes dismantled before replication reached operational scale. But if the data—if the complete resonance matrices and command threads hadn't been extracted and repurposed—

What had they intended to do if they succeeded?

And worse still—his stomach hollowed—what if those mimics hadn't been meant for their enemies?

What if they'd been intended for *replacement*?

One. Two. Ten Heirs at a time.

Removed quietly, without spectacle.

Without witnesses.

Until the originals were gone.

And no one would ever know.

A cold, oppressive weight settled behind his sternum.

He wasn’t sure which prospect was worse—that the Council had attempted such a maneuver, or that they might have already shifted to a newer, more insidious design the moment the first failed.

His hand lifted to his face, pressing against his eyes.

He never thought he’d say it, but with the terrible clarity of what was taking shape, he wished Aglaea hadn’t left.

Then how was the Flame Reaver involved?

He almost groaned.

It always came back to Phainon.

It had to.

For so long, it had been so simple. Easy, even. Blame the Flame Reaver. The faceless insurgent, the ghost woven through half-collapsed sites and destabilized sectors. The dossiers painted him as reckless. A destabilizer. The kind of violent, anarchist thing that didn’t care who burned, so long as the system bled.

And Mydei had believed it.

He clenched his jaw, teeth grinding against the pressure.

But now… now, knowing the face behind the mask, he knew better.

Phainon would never have done it.

Would never have triggered those Nodes with civilians in range.

Wouldn’t have left those children in comas with their grieving parents.

Not unless—

Unless what?

Unless there’d been no choice?

Unless it wasn’t him?

And if it wasn’t Phainon…

Then who?

And worse—why frame it so cleanly? So perfectly? Who benefits from stitching a rebel’s name to a crime like that?

He tried to let it go. Really, he did.

Tried to dig his heels into the facts, to count the patterns, to draw clean lines between logic and grief.

But the fractures were piling too fast.

The oddities stacking one atop the other until the shape of them couldn’t be ignored.

The injuries.

The disappearances he couldn’t explain.

The way Phainon always turned up in the aftermath—bloodied, broken, wearing that same reckless grin like pain was just another language he

spoke fluently.

And the looks. Gods, those looks.

Those sharp, brittle glances when certain Council divisions passed too close. Like old reflexes twitching alive, memories Mydei hadn't known to name back then.

It all fit too clean now.

Too damn neatly.

He heard Aglaea's voice in his head, slicing through the noise like a blade:

"They've been watching you since the start."

If they watched him…

They would've watched *Phainon* too.

His heartbeat stuttered.

And then—worse—the thought came.

The one so ugly it felt like something toxic blooming behind his teeth.

What if it was him?

What if Phainon had led them here?

What if every deflection, every ragged smile, every near-miss coincidence wasn't coincidence at all?

What if he was still an enforcer?

Not against the Council—but *for them.*

A loyal dog in insurgent's colors.

A rebellion curated by the very hands it was meant to defy.

His pulse spiked. His hands flexed against the resonance cuffs, jaw tight enough to ache.

No.

No—it was irrational. He knew it was irrational.

But pain didn't obey logic.

And betrayal didn't care about probabilities.

Because love blinds.

And for all his sharp-edged pragmatism, for all his clinical detachment, Mydei had believed Phainon's lies because he'd *wanted* to.

Because no one else had found him at his lowest and chosen to stay.

Because no one else had seen the thing beneath *Godslayer* and spoken his name so softly.

Because it was Phainon.

And now—now the storm inside him wouldn't stop.

Gnawing through memory and speculation, blurring fact and fiction until he didn't know which would be worse:

That Phainon had betrayed him.

Or that he hadn't—and Mydei had broken them anyway.

His chest tightened, breath shuddering through his teeth.

His hands wouldn't stop shaking.

He pulled against the cuffs.

A little at first.

Then harder.

The flare of pain—resonance backlash crawling through marrow like wildfire—punched the air from his lungs. He bit down on his tongue, tasted blood, didn’t care.

Did it again.

And again.

Because pain anchored.

Because it was better than drowning in a mind he couldn’t quiet.

Because if he stayed still too long, he’d start believing the things he was thinking.

And he couldn’t afford that.

He’s not a traitor. He’s not. He’s—mine.

But the ache wouldn’t leave.

He dropped his head to his knees, shoulders trembling, sweat beading at his brow.

Tried to tell himself it didn’t make sense.

Tried to tell himself he would never.

But heartbreak didn’t care about tactical discipline.

He was *Godslayer*.

He’d kept secrets whole generations of officers didn’t know existed.

Worn a thousand masks, spoken a hundred lies, played ghost in the ruins of dead systems.

It was hypocritical.

But this wasn’t the same.

Because it was *Phainon*.

And Phainon was—

Was what, Mydei? Yours?

Or was he the knife they turned on you while you weren’t looking?

The ache sharpened.

His hands shook like a fault line before collapse.

The certainty he relied on had abandoned him.

He just hurt.

He pressed his knuckles to his lips.

Closed his eyes.

Hoped, stupidly, for a moment’s peace.

It didn’t come.

And then—beneath the ragged rasp of his own breath—he heard it.

A hum.

Low, syncopated, barely audible. A subtle shift in the containment unit’s resonance lattice.

Someone was here.

A visitor.

His stomach turned. The room seemed to tilt.

He wiped a shaking hand down his face, forced his spine to straighten, ignoring the tremor in his limbs.

Breathe in. Breathe out.

Because no matter what broke inside his chest, no one—*no one*—got to see him like that.

Not them.

Not yet.

Not until it was over.

And gods help them if it ever was.

The reinforced threshold gave a final, mechanical click.

Mydei tensed.

Some part of him always would.

There was no point pretending otherwise.

And then—through the sterile light and brittle, dead air—Krateros stepped inside.

It struck harder than it should have.

Even through the mire of grief and suspicion, with thoughts unraveling faster than he could catch them, some ancient, bone-deep instinct still knew what to do when *that* figure entered a room.

Straighten your spine.
Center your breath.

Make yourself still.

His age didn’t matter.

Nine.
Twenty.
Now.

Krateros was Krateros.

And the part of Mydei that had never quite outgrown it obeyed without question.

His fingers stilled against the cuffs. The trembling didn’t vanish, but it pulled deeper, tucked itself into some quiet, hidden place.

The grief stayed. It always did.

But his posture held.

He expected the iron-hard gaze. That careful, assessing stare followed by a precise correction—a reprimand shaped like a lesson.

But it didn’t come.

What met him wasn’t the mentor.

Not the man who’d taught him to wield a blade, to silence fear, to build walls so high nothing could reach him.

This was something smaller.

A man without a mantle.

And without meaning to, Mydei’s shoulders loosened—because some buried part of him recognized, without needing to name it, that Krateros wasn’t here for Godslayer.

He was here for *Mydeimos*.

“Teacher,” he said.

Krateros inclined his head.

“Mydeimos.”

And then—to his quiet astonishment—Krateros didn’t remain standing.

Didn’t pace like an interrogator.

Didn’t linger at the threshold like a wary emissary deciding how close to risk.

He crossed the room.

Lowered himself to the floor.

And sat.

Cross-legged.

Close.

Deliberately human.

The way he had done when Mydei was small, when nightmares made sleep impossible and the world felt too wide to hold alone.

It was a signal.

Mydei’s throat tightened. The question slipped out before he could measure it, before he could summon the wisdom to leave it unsaid.

“This about them trying to pull something out of me?”

He meant for it to land sharp. Defiant.

It didn’t.

Krateros looked at him—truly looked—with the kind of steady, unimpressed clarity that cut deeper than any reprimand could.

It wasn’t anger.

It was something colder.

A quiet disappointment at the insult to his dignity.

As though the mere suggestion he’d be sent by them should’ve been beneath both of them.

The shame hit sharp and sudden, flushing under his skin before he could stop it.

Of course not.

Krateros wasn’t a man anyone commanded.

Not the Council.

Not the Heirs.

Mydei forced the words out anyway.

“Then why are you here?”

He braced for it—the reprimand, the clipped disappointment he’d always feared more than raised voices. He even shut his eyes for a moment, a pointless instinct, as though not seeing it would spare him the weight.

But the silence that followed wasn’t sharp.

No reprimand.

Only the faint, metallic sound of something moving between calloused fingers.

He opened his eyes.

Krateros sat motionless, save for the object turning slowly in his hand.

A ring.

Plain. Aged by time. Its metal dulled to a soft, worn gray. The crest still legible to anyone who'd ever belonged to them.

It hit like a blow to the ribs.

Krateros's voice broke the stillness.

"This was your mother's," he said, gaze not leaving the ring. "She wouldn't take it off. Drove your father mad."

Without ceremony, Krateros set it on the floor between them.

He didn't offer it.

Didn't ask him to take it.

Just placed it there.

The dim light caught on its edge.

And in that single, unspoken moment—Mydei understood.

This wasn't a test.

Wasn't leverage dressed in familiar skin.

Some debts lived longer than the ones who made them.

And some promises weren't made to the living.

He exhaled, the breath unsteady.

"So that's what this is about," he murmured, not entirely sure whether the words were meant for Krateros, or for himself. "You promised her."

Krateros didn’t deny it.

The ring stayed where it was.

“I remember the night she came to me,” Krateros murmured, his gaze never leaving the ring. “Stormed into the East Sector, clothes half-fastened in her haste. Blood on her knuckles from a man twice her size who thought to stop her.”

Mydei held his breath without realizing.

“She said she was finished waiting. Finished choking down your father’s lies. She meant to take you that night. Away from him.”

It was a story he’d never been told.

And one he could no longer pretend he hadn’t needed to hear.

“But it didn’t work.” Krateros’s voice lowered. “They’d built contingencies, buried in your blood. Invisible chains wound through your pulse, tied to your proximity. You wouldn’t have made it past the threshold before it unraveled your mind. Or worse.”

Worse.

“She learned too late,” Krateros continued, softer now. “And she made me swear. Swear to you. Not to the Heirs. Not to the Council’s gilded filth. Not to whatever promises that *wretched* Initiative whispered.”

Krateros’s fingers brushed the edge of the ring, turning it once.

“She said doors were being built,” he murmured. “Doors no one else could see. And if she wasn’t there when they opened, someone had to be.”

Mydei wanted to ask.

To follow the implications down, see where the threads led, no matter how jagged the end.

But not yet. Not like this.

He drew a slow, careful breath, steadying his voice.

“So what’s the point of this?” he asked. “Old history won’t unmake what’s been done.”

Krateros met his gaze—implacable, and sharp as old iron.

“You think this is history?” The words landed like an anvil. “Boy, the ground beneath your feet was laid by that night.”

Mydei scowled, the retort rising, ready to bury this finally. But before the words left his mouth, Krateros’s tone turned, the cold edge of it cutting straight through the air between them.

“And what if I told you the Council was in it from the start?”

The room seemed to contract.

Krateros saw the flicker of awareness—that lethal, subtle shift behind his student’s gaze—and his expression changed.

The fatigue of years gave way to something else—a soldier’s terrible certainty.

Then—without warning—Krateros moved.

In a single, swift motion, he drew a thin, compact blade from beneath his collar. Without waiting he drove it, not into flesh, but straight into the resonance conduit embedded in the cell’s control node near the wall.

The metal struck with a sharp, resonant sound. Sparks burst from the fracture point. A keening whine filled the air as the room’s lattice destabilized.

Alarms exploded to life. A high, shrieking wail. Lights stuttered, then stabilized into a raw, unfiltered pallor. Containment seals slammed down with a brutal, grinding finality.

[WARNING]

[WARNING]

The surveillance weave collapsed, flickering out like dying stars.

Containment seals slammed into place with a bone-rattling grind.

The entire cell was cut off.

Panic rippled through the facility's infrastructure—muted, but unmistakable.

And inside this room, there was only the howl of alarms and the unblinking weight of Krateros's stare.

He didn't flinch.

Didn't so much as shift his shoulders.

When he spoke, his voice was sharp— not raised, not barked, but with a gravity that pressed against the bones of the room itself.

"Listen to me now, boy."

Mydei's shocked eyes met Krateros.

"What I tell you doesn't leave these walls. Because if it does, you'll be forced to choose which ties you sever—and whether you have the teeth to survive what follows."

The alarms wailed on. The lights hummed, harsh and pale.

And neither of them moved.

Because in that moment, both of them understood what had just been set in motion.

And the only thing more dangerous than Krateros bearing a secret

was Krateros deciding this was the hour to let it bleed.

The alarms screamed through the sealed room—red light bleeding in jagged streaks along the walls, shadows stuttering with every pulse. Beyond the reinforced doors, shouts rose like a storm surge, the pounding of boots growing louder.

Krateros didn't hesitate.

"The Council," he spat, voice raw and vicious, a sound stripped to bone. "*They were the spine of Kýklos Thanatou Eikon*. The Initiative was never rogue. It was *theirs*. Eurypon was just a knife they pointed with."

Mydei's stomach turned so violently it felt like gravity slipped.

"What—?"

Krateros didn't let him finish. The words came like a dam burst—not elegant or careful at all.

"They funded it. Ran it. Buried it when the Heirs stormed the site. Erased the names. Burned the files. Lied about rogue cells and broken men. *I saw the fucking records*. I dug them out with my own hands from the corpse pits they left behind."

A fist hammered the other side of the door. The reinforced frame buckled. A jagged voice barked for clearance codes.

And then Krateros *snapped*.

He spun, grabbed Mydei by the collar, his fingers bruising flesh through fabric. His voice cracked wide, a jagged, half-hysterical snarl undercut with the brilliant, precise madness of a man who understood the machinery of power far too well.

"*Think, Mydeimos*. You were the only one. The *only one*. Thirty-three corpses in a pit, and you breathing. Why do you think they've been circling like carrion since the moment we dragged you out of that hell? Why every

transfer request, every quiet offer, every operation the Council's shadowed from behind the curtain?"

Mydei's pulse screamed in his throat. He tried to speak—but his mind was collapsing inward, memories cascading, half-heard conversations, Eurypon's ragged voice pouring out theories like poison, diagrams he shouldn't have remembered flashing behind his eyes.

Stabilizer rings. Fail-safe loops. *Resonance anchoring protocols.*

"They—" he started, breath scraping raw in his chest.

Krateros didn't give him the chance.

"That bastard," he spat, refusing even now to speak the man's name, "started claiming it was about the Tide. Immunity, protection—the usual fucking salvation myth. But it stopped being about humanity the moment he realized he could manufacture *immortality*."

The word landed like a hammer to the sternum.

Krateros's eyes gleamed—not gentle, not sorrowful, but bright and terrible and *alive* with the kind of knowledge that sickens you just to hold.

"And you, boy—" he rasped. "*You're the one that worked.* The one thing death couldn't hold. A tether they can't cut, no matter how many times the world falls down around it. Do you understand now?"

It hit.

Not like a revelation, not like clarity.

Like a *free fall.*

Mydei's immortality.

Not an accident.

Not a byproduct.

The entire point.

He staggered a half-step back, jaw slack, nausea rising sharp and sour in his throat. The room seemed to lurch sideways. His heart pounded against his ribs like it was trying to claw its way out.

If that's why they'd been waiting.

If that's what they meant to claim.

What would they do with it?

Krateros's hand crushed his shoulder, grounding him through sheer violence.

"I don't know what purpose those bastards have for it," Krateros bit out, "but I know men like them don't leave power lying in the dirt. They'll harvest you, Mydei. Strip the marrow from your bones. Build new things out of your skin and claim they were born to rule. And I'll be *damned twice over* before I watch them do it."

From outside—a final, gut-wrenching shriek of tearing metal.

Containment seals buckled under a manual resonance breach.

The lattice around the room stuttered, flickered. The doors began to split at the seams.

Krateros leaned in, so close Mydei could see the madness in his eyes, a manic sheen born of terror and rage and a soldier's bitter love for the last thing in the world he could still protect.

His voice dropped to a feral rasp.

"Listen to me, Mydei. You *never* go with them. Never take their offer. Never let their words inside your head. They'll gut you, wear your immortality like a second skin, and bleed others in your name."

And then—the doors blew inward.

A flood of light. Shouting. Boots. Faces locked in the empty-eyed stare of men given orders they no longer understood.

They seized Krateros. Two guards grabbed his arms, hauling him back. He fought like a cornered animal, a snarl on his lips—not at them, but at Mydei.

His gaze never left him.

And even as they dragged him toward the breach, his voice rose above the chaos:

"*Cut your leash, Mydeimos.* Cut it before it wraps around your throat. Or you'll wish you'd died with your mother."

Then he was gone—swallowed by a wall of armored bodies.

And in the aftermath, in the deafening absence of Krateros's voice, Mydei stood motionless.

The alarms still howled, but they were distant now, like sounds filtering in from a dead world. The light felt too sharp, every pulse of it like a blade against his skin.

His pulse spiked. His breath quickened—ragged, shallow. A pressure built in his chest, tight, constricting. His hands shook.

A new, deeper terror unfurled in him.

And Mydei, for once in his life, truly felt panic gnaw at the edges of his mind.

He drew in a shuddering breath, tried to steady it—and failed.

His head hurt.

He pressed trembling fingers to his temple, tracing the pulse there—as if anchoring himself to the last, indisputable proof that he was still here.

Think.

Krateros’s voice wouldn’t stop.

Not cleanly. Not as whole words.

Fragments. Shards.

The Council was the spine. They built it. Built you.

And the worst part wasn’t even that.

It was *why*.

That word.

It hung in his mind like a broken stabilizer coil, sparking and stuttering, threatening collapse.

Why?

If it had only been about him—about the lattice, about Eurypon’s rotten salvation masquerading as science—he could have followed the thread. But it wasn’t. Not just him.

The Flame Reaver.

They’d marked him too.

Why?

What did one have to do with the other? What pattern did two anomalies make when overlapped?

The thought snagged something raw in his memory. A loose edge. Then another. Then another.

And before he could stop it, *the betrayal reasserted itself.*

Phainon.

The lies. The omissions. The way the man had *steered him*, always steering, under the illusion of partnership. Every ‘coincidence’ of proximity to power players. Every quiet nudge toward people fated to die. Phainon had likely killed them, one by one, with the same detached precision a surgeon uses to cut away necrotic flesh.

But this wasn’t cleansing.

It was slaughter.

And Mydei tried—*tried*—to reach for rage, for that cold, beautiful thing Heirs were taught to refine into resolve.

Nothing came.

No fire. No hatred. No righteous vow to burn his name from the earth.

Just a hollow quiet.

And it *startled him.*

His brow furrowed, lips parting on a breath he couldn’t quite catch.

I should feel something.

He *should* be furious. Should want to rip the man’s heart out with his bare hands and watch it struggle to keep beating. Should curse his name, spit on the memory of every whispered night, every shoulder-to-shoulder moment pretending to be something like brothers, like comrades.

He should swear vengeance in the name of the people Phainon had dismembered, suffocated, burned alive in locked resonance cages. The girl who’d begged to be shot before the Tide took her. The old operative who’d detonated his own skull node to avoid being devoured inside-out by harmonics. The civilians who never even knew what was being done to them.

Each life another notch in a ledger Phainon never let him see.

But none of it conjured the anger. Not the way it should have. Not the way it *needed* to.

He didn’t feel hate.

He felt *sick*.

Not at the blood. Not at the scale of it.

At the lie.

And it was that—that small, bitter truth—that made his jaw clench tight enough to ache.

Because somewhere, somewhere in the marrow of him, Mydei understood the real betrayal wasn’t the atrocities.

It was the silence.

Phainon hadn’t just killed and lied and schemed.

He’d *known*. And he’d let him wander blind through it all, dangling half-truths like a tether. Had let him believe the world wasn’t quite as monstrous as it was, because somewhere in it, there was one man who wouldn’t lie to him.

And worse—Mydei had *let him.*

He felt his throat tighten—not grief, not mourning.

A suffocating, gut-deep clarity.

It wasn’t the deaths. It wasn’t even the cause.

It was trust.

The unspoken thing that lived between people when the noise fell away.

And that was the thing Phainon carved up with a scalpel.

He was a hypocrite for mourning it. He knew that. Knew his own hands weren't clean. Knew he'd buried names they'd never find and faces he'd long stopped remembering. Knew he'd buried the truth of Godslayer under a hundred aliases and quiet, efficient murders.

But none of it was comparable.

Because Mydei's lies had always been his own cross to bear.

Phainon's were a *leash*.

And the fear—the real fear—hadn't ever been death.

It was losing him.

It had always been *him*.

And it hit now, fast and sharp, like a spike driven through the ribs.

Mydei swallowed hard, bracing a palm against the cold wall, the room spinning sideways. The realization bled through like a hairline fracture spiderwebbing across glass.

He could survive the Tide.

Survive containment fields. Torture. Calamities.

He could even survive being made a liability in the eyes of the Council.

But the thought of Phainon vanishing—dragged into some Council chamber, into a blacksite vault, into a disintegration pit before he could *hear the truth from his mouth, before he could ask him if any of it was real* —

That was what made his lungs lock.

That was what left his hands shaking.

And when that settled in.

If they want me…

And they'd marked him too.

It was a tethered operation. A linked outcome. A convergence.

And if Mydei stayed here, pacing this cell without doing anything, the Council would take him first.

And then he'd *never know.*

Never find out if those nights leaning shoulder to shoulder meant anything. If the warmth in his voice when he said his name was ever *real*, or just another facade.

He realized, in that moment, that answers meant more to him than justice.

That he would kill to have them.

And maybe worse—he'd forgive to have them too.

Mydei sat motionless, shoulders pressed against cold alloy, the burn of restraint welts stinging at his wrists. For a long time, he let his thoughts slow, disassociate, unspool into something mercifully dull.

It was the footsteps that pulled him back.

Not the nervous, clipped cadence of a rookie. Not the heavy stride of a security enforcer.

Precise.

He didn't react at first.

Didn't bother.

In places like this, there were always footsteps.

Only when the door’s lock disengaged with a pneumatic hiss and a sharp, antiseptic scent cut through the stagnant air did he lift his head.

Hyacine.

She entered with the dual presence of a combat medic and a soldier, though he could see the strain ghosting beneath the surface—in the tightness of her jaw, the careful neutrality of her expression.

“Mydei,” she greeted softly, the tone a little too even to be natural. Her gaze swept over him, a calculated assessment. Not just a glance. A full trauma survey.

He knew the steps by rote:

Primary ABC check—airway, breathing, circulation.

Secondary—neurologic status, focal injuries, covert bleed risk.

She knelt beside him, fingers cold through the thin mesh of gloves as they wrapped around his wrist. Two seconds. Three. Pulse irregular but present. A faint tremor under his skin.

“Vitals are marginally stable,” she murmured, more for herself than him. “Neural strain with probable feedback. Suppressants destabilized. Adjusting now.”

He said nothing.

Not even a wince.

Hyacine continued regardless, the steady cadence of her voice a ritual in itself.

“I’m adjusting your neuroinhibitors. You’re experiencing cortical overload symptoms—delirium, disassociation. You shouldn’t even be upright.”

She reached for his ocular line, sweeping the penlight in front of his eyes. Pupillary response was delayed in one, reactive in the other.

His gaze barely tracked her, unfocused, until a sharper flicker of something registered in her expression.

It wasn’t professional.

She hadn’t cleared the room because someone ordered it. Hadn’t risked cross-traffic during an active lockdown for a duty check.

She’d come for him.

And he almost felt sorry for what would come next.

Almost.

Hyacine’s fingers ghosted across the bruised skin near his temple, brushing aside a wayward strand of damp hair.

“Honestly,” she muttered under her breath, an exhale that carried too much weight for casual reprimand, “one of these days, you’re not going to crawl back from these things.”

A long, brittle silence stretched between them.

Then, without lifting his head:

“I need to leave.”

She stilled.

Not enough for the now likely active cams, not enough for a ceiling scope to catch. But to him—it was there. A half-second’s hesitation.

The kind of pause that spoke volumes.

Then she moved again, seamlessly, finishing the adjustment of his suppressants.

“Mydei,” she said, too lightly. Professional. Coaxing. “You’re not cleared to move. Sit tight.”

A flawless deflection.

It would have convinced anyone else.

But it wouldn’t work here.

“I’m serious,” he rasped. “You don’t understand. I have to go. Now.”

Hyacine didn’t answer immediately. She finished checking the raw abrasions along his forearms from where the restraint bands had torn skin, her touch light but unflinching.

He waited for the reprimand, the clinical rebuke.

It didn’t come.

Instead, she murmured, low and neutral, as if discussing an inventory manifest:

“Your gear’s still tagged in C5. Sublevel 2. Same unit they toss your effects every time you decide to dismantle half my medbay.”

His eyes found hers. A flicker of something passed between them.

She didn’t look up.

Her hands moved slower now. Deliberate. And after a moment, he felt the faint, almost imperceptible shift at his wrist—the tactile click of the restraint lock disengaging.

Gone.

Her grip on his forearm tightened, feigning another vitals check, and she leaned in a fraction too close. Not enough to be flagged, but enough for her voice to slip beneath the sensors’ auditory sweep range.

“They’ll sweep this sector in fifteen.”

A breath.

“I won’t condone what you’re about to do. But I won’t watch you get dragged out of here either.”

It caught him off-guard, not the words, but the intent behind them. Hyacine didn’t owe him this. No one did.

And she was giving it anyway.

He looked at her—saw the edges, the strain she didn’t bother to hide anymore. Not weakness. Just a person, still here when she didn’t have to be.

Her lips twitched. The barest ghost of a smile.

“Make it count,” she murmured.

He didn’t hesitate.

Didn’t allow himself the indulgence of guilt or second thought.

In one sharp, precise motion, Mydei surged forward, his hand closing around the collar of her white coat. Hyacine’s eyes widened for a fraction of a second—not with fear, but with understanding.

She didn’t resist.

Didn’t call out.

The strike was clean—calculated for momentary syncope without lasting trauma. Her body sagged against him before he could let her fall, and instinct guided his hands, one cradling the back of her head, lowering her gently to the floor.

She felt smaller in his arms than he remembered.

He eased her down into the shadowed corner of the room, positioning her out of immediate sightlines. Pulled a folded piece of sterile gauze from the nearby kit and slipped it beneath her head to cushion the contact point.

The knot in his chest tightened.

His fingers lingered longer than they should have at her temple.

“Thank you,” he said, the words meant for no one but himself.

And then he stood.

Head pounding. Delirious. Muscles aching from restraint stress and cortical backlash. But steady. The inertia of earlier shattered clean through.

Krateros, damn him, was still raising hell somewhere down the corridor—the muffled echoes of shouting and metallic impacts a distant counterpoint. Most of the security detail would be focused there.

Fifteen minutes.

He wouldn’t waste it.

Not with Phainon still out there.

Not with everything unraveling.

Not anymore.

He closed his eyes.

Drew in a breath, every inhalation scraping like broken glass.

For a moment, everything slowed.

And then something inside him shifted.

A gear locking into place.

The fractured pieces of his mind pulled taut into ruthless, surgical clarity.

He moved.

A sharp, full-body pivot—muscle memory overriding hesitation, the ache in his side vanishing beneath the surge of momentum. His legs carried him

forward in a blistering sprint, the medblock exit already framed in his mind.

The corridors mapped themselves in real time in his eyes, automatic, as if the entire structure existed solely for this purpose.

Medbay A2 connects to Sub-Corridor 7C.
Two levels down through maintenance.
Storage Sublevel 2.
C5 along the northern access bay.
Then extraction.

The overhead strips flickered as he tore through the narrow passageways, the cold light warping into smeared streaks in his peripheral vision. Somewhere behind him, alarms would trigger soon—even with Krateros distracting them. Every second counted.

His brain parsed possibilities, firing rapid contingencies as his boots hit alloy.

How to contact him.

A message?

Impossible. The Heirs had his comm grid and phone flagged, every outbound line quarantined, every data thread triangulated within seconds. His signal was radioactive.

Anything traced back would bring a full tactical sweep before Phainon could even read it.

No.

He’d find him the old fashioned way.

Mydei vaulted over a waist-high security barrier, hitting the other side in a low roll before cutting down a side corridor half-lit by emergency reserve strips. A maintenance crawlspace hatch blinked green ahead, status panel on standby.

He didn’t slow.

His palm hit the override, fingers punching the sequence.

Grid pulse, five-second bypass. Manual override.
Old Chrysos tech. Fragile sensors. Laughable security.

The hatch hissed open and he dropped into the narrow crawlspace, weaving between cables and old conduit trunks, the scent of machine oil sharp in the recycled air.

The city beyond was too vast to sweep. Phainon wouldn’t be hiding at random. He was smarter than that.

Certain places made sense, if as Flame Reaver.

Places with no active surveillance. No clean data feeds.

The kinds of dead zones both of them had used before.

A flash of movement ahead.

A Chrysos operative—standard tactical rig, pulseblade at his hip. He turned just as Mydei cleared the hatch.

“Hey— wait, aren’t you—”

He didn’t finish.

Two strides, a sharp pivot, elbow driving hard into the agent’s throat, cutting the word off in a strangled gasp. The follow-through was instinct—a clean hook to the jaw, catching him before his body could crumple to the ground.

Efficient.

His pulse barely rose.

Another route.

Ahead, a narrow conduit access—one of the old plasma vent crawlways, long since decommissioned after the last reactor incident. No active scanners, no vid-links.

Forgotten by most.

Perfect.

Mydei ducked inside, the air thick and stale, thick cables coiled like veins along the walls. The passage curved ahead into a deeper sublevel, each step closing the distance between him and what waited at the end of this night.

He could feel it now

His hand clenched at his side.

I'll find you.

A promise. A threat. A certainty.

And as he picked up speed again, every muscle coiled tight beneath bruised skin, one final thought settled cold and steady behind his eyes.

And gods help you, Phainon—when I do.

Chapter End Notes

> Quick question for you guys, remember in the last chapter when the name Khaslana got dropped? I've been debating whether to stick with that or swap it out for NeiKos496. Would love to hear what you all prefer!
>
> Also, we got some Mydei lore drops this chapter . I tried to work in a few callbacks to stuff from the file in chapter 12 (if you remember that one). Looking back, I feel like I might've censored a bit too much of it, but hopefully the message still came through!
>
> If you've got any questions about the plot so far, feel free to ask! I can answer most of them spoiler-free probably, so don't hesitate to drop

your thoughts.

I’ll immediately start working on the next chapter tomorrow, so expect that in I’d say 2-5 days?? Right now I’m going to sleep since it’s nearing one in the morning for me, but thank you for reading <33333

Chapter 15: Anaxa’s Discount Rescue Service

Chapter Summary

> Phainon goes to a black market info-forum, makes terrible life choices, runs into a rogue Godslayer, accidentally kills him, has an existential breakdown, melts several Council enforcers, gets forcibly sedated by Anaxa (who arrives fashionably late with a gun and zero patience), gets yeeted through unstable space, and wakes up in one of Anaxa’s off-the-books trauma bunkers wondering if he’s lost everything. Again. 10/10 crisis management.

Chapter Notes

> Alright, first off, sorry for the delay AGAIN. Technically I could argue I’m only *kinda* late since I still have like 20 minutes before it hits June 10th in my time zone, but let’s be real, by the time I finish editing and posting this, it’ll probably be 12:40 or something. So yeah. Sorryyy.
>
> Anyway, I hope you guys enjoy the chapter! It’s a messy one, but what’s new.
>
> Heads up: guest comments are gonna be temporarily disabled for now because holyyyyy unemployment. Someone apparently had the free time to go through every single chapter and leave some nonsense comments. Honestly idgaf abt them, but I don’t want anyone else scrolling through and getting weirded out or discouraged from reading, SORRYYY😭

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The air thrummed.

High above the gutted carcass of the old industrial sector, surveillance drones drifted in lazy, predatory arcs. No flashing lights. You only saw them if you were looking—

and around here, no one with a survival instinct looked up.

The sky sagged low, a smear of sickly cloud dragging pale light across rusting catwalks and half-collapsed heat exchangers. Somewhere in the distance, a patrol crawler let out a mechanical whine, scattering the last of the stragglers like roaches. Officially, the curfew was *soft*. In practice, it meant the ground belonged to the Council, the air to the Heirs, and every blind corner was a loaded question with a gun for a mouth.

Which was why Phainon stayed off the streets.

He crouched in the shadow of a decommissioned coolant silo, one gloved hand absently rolling a worn coin while the other adjusted the setting on a pulse tool.

A drone shimmered past overhead. Just a faint ripple in the heavy air.

Phainon sighed through his teeth, tapped his comms.

“Nothing says ‘*welcome*’ like weaponized eyeballs in the sky.”

A click. Then Anaxa’s voice in his ear—clipped, and already several steps ahead.

“Four escape routes mapped. Three scramblers planted. Two fallback points marked. Stay focused.”

Phainon let out a low, slow whistle.

“Somebody’s gunning for a promotion.”

“Shut up and work.”

A grin tugged at his mouth before he could stop it. The place wasn’t kind to humor. If you didn’t bleed out, burn out, or crash out, you cracked. He was batting two for three.

Not that any of this had gone to plan.

The soft lockdown had hardened, thickened into a knot of overlapping patrol corridors and contested surveillance airspace. Council lockdowns were bad. Chrysos Heir counter-nets were worse. Together? A tangled mess of redundant protocols and half-synced tech, creating unstable fields, dead network zones, and interference anomalies where both sides' systems clashed.

Dangerous.

Which, unfortunately, made them useful.

For the past few hours, Phainon and Anaxa had done the only thing better than surviving: mapping weak points. Plotting where Council and Heir surveillance fields overlapped and failed. Gaps in the signal. Glitches in the feed. Little dead spots you could slip through if you were smart or desperate.

Or both.

Anaxa had whipped up a handful of scramblers on the fly, cobbled together from proximity beacon parts and an honestly alarming number of questionably sourced neuro-sync chips. They mostly worked. The last one had glitched so hard Phainon's teeth felt like they were vibrating out of his skull.

He eyed the one in his palm now—a fist-sized tangle of emitters and braided filament. Light seeped through the gaps in unsteady pulses, like a heartbeat with a bad rhythm.

Phainon grimaced.

"These things are a disaster waiting to happen."

Anaxa didn't miss a beat.

"You fry both our synapses and I'll bury your corpse with my tax records."

He snorted, arching a brow at the comm bead.

“Harsh.”

Another sigh. Phainon straightened, pressed a shoulder to the bulkhead, and started moving.

“Yes, your majesty,” he muttered.

The scrambler flickered in his hand. Like it agreed.

He moved without a sound, shoulders brushing peeling metal. He knew this layout. Knew which footfalls wouldn’t echo. Which struts had rotted hollow. The air thickened around him, an oily weight clinging to his skin.

A weak point.

He felt it before he saw it.

The faint warping of space.

A shimmer.

The hazard signage on the far wall rippled, warping in place as his pulse tool gave an irritable buzz.

Phainon’s mouth twitched.

“Well, that’s not ominous.”

He crouched by a tangle of dead junction cables, fished the scrambler from his belt, and thumbed the priming sequence. The sphere gave a flicker, then a sharp pulse. The ripple in the air expanded, jagged and wrong, making the wall stutter between rust-streaked plating and slick, black glass.

“Shit—” Phainon hissed as the thing spasmed in his grip. He slapped a control panel on its side, muttering,

“You couldn’t make this *less* homicidal?”

Anaxa’s voice crackled in his ear, dry as dust.

“You knew the job was dangerous when you took it.”

Phainon scowled at the scrambler as its glow finally stabilized.

“Next time, I’m wiring the gear. No offense.”

“Noted. Movement west sector,” Anaxa cut in, voice tightening. **“Heir patrol rerouting. And there’s chatter about a rogue contact.”**

Phainon gave a low whistle, rose, and slipped up one of the support beams with liquid ease. He reached a narrow cross-lattice and hauled himself into the shadowed framework overhead. Muscle memory.

“You wanna elaborate on that, orrr~?” he drawled, hanging from one arm as a patrol’s footsteps rang out below—three figures in matte-black armor, faint glyph sigils shimmering on their shoulders. He watched them pass, close enough to taste the hum of their weapon cores on his teeth.

A beat.

Then Anaxa again.

“Scattered intercepts. One of the Heir’s people went dark. Rumor says they were confined. Rumor also says they got out.”

Phainon’s brow furrowed.

“Seriously? Heirs don’t just lose people.”

“**Forget it. Irrelevant. We’ve got real problems.”**

The line went still for a half-second. Long enough for Phainon to sense Anaxa wanted to say something else. Instead, what came was a sharp, low whisper:

“You’ve got ninety seconds. My zone’s compromised. Relocating.”

Phainon hissed through his teeth, easing higher into the frame as another drone shimmered past overhead.

“Sure. Meet you at fallback six?”

“Negative. I’ll route you a new path once I’m clear.”

A pause. Then, almost distractedly:

“I picked up something. I’ll tell you when you’re out of this section. You’ll want to hear it.”

“Tease,” Phainon muttered, already moving.

“Anything else I’m clearing out here?”

“Negative. Objectives complete. Recommend access through lower utility grid—service runoff channel. West sewer junction.”

Phainon groaned, tipping his head back against rusted bulkhead.

“You would send me into the sewers.”

“Security’s dense tonight. Patrol vectors are a mess. Took a lot just to get you in there.”

Another pause.

“Your residential echo’s still holding, but it won’t last.”

Phainon smirked faintly.

“Good little trick though, huh?”

Not a clone. Not quite. An echo construct, his own handiwork—projected tight enough to fool proximity scanners and surveillance skimmers. As far as the city grid knew, Phainon was three districts away, passed out in his apartment, sleeping off a hangover.

The fact he wasn’t was the entire problem.

“Yes, yes, bask in your own brilliance later,” Anaxa muttered. **“Get moving.”**

“On it.”

Phainon scanned for the nearest maintenance hatch. It didn’t take long to find one buried behind a collapsed barrier.

He crouched, hooked his fingers into the grip ring, and hauled it open with a groan of metal. A breath of cold, sour air rolled up from the dark below.

Phainon peered into it, resigned.

“Love this job,” he muttered, and dropped into the dark.

The tunnel stank.

Not just of mold and standing water, but old blood, scorched oil, and something acrid that clung to the throat. Phainon’s boots splashed through shallow runoff as he jogged down the narrow maintenance artery. Overhead, dead fixtures hung like broken teeth, leaving only the faintest glimmers of streetlight filtering through grated slats above.

He ducked beneath a rusted pipe, tapped his comm.

“Hey, Professor,” he panted, voice light despite the gloom. “What were you gonna say, y’know, before everything caught fire again?”

A pause. The faint rasp of Anaxa shifting wherever he was holed up now.

“Keep left at the filtration stack. Drop down the ladder—utility corridor seven.”

Phainon rolled his eyes and veered left, vaulting a cracked barricade.

“You are *terrible* at meaningful conversation.”

“Occupational hazard,” Anaxa muttered. Then, after a beat, more audible, **“Right. Secured you an invitation.”**

Phainon nearly missed a step.

“An invitation? What kind of invitation?”

“You’ll like it. Underground forum. Analog only. No links, no grids, no eyes.”

Despite himself, Phainon grinned, weaving past a collapsed support.

“Let me guess—black-tie gala for the paranoid and armed?”

“Closer than you think.”

The line went quiet for a stretch. Only water and Phainon’s breath filled the space as he vaulted a rung ladder, landing on a rust-caked platform with barely a sound.

Then Anaxa’s voice, lower now:

“The reactor complex runs its own dead grid. No connections to the city circuits. I can skim the streets, piggyback unsecured comms, but inside? Only whispers count.”

Phainon hummed under his breath, crossing a brittle catwalk.

“And what’s so important even you can’t dig it out?”

Anaxa’s tone sharpened.

“Council relocation transport. Rumors of a cluster of ‘Bodies.’ Capital B. No manifest yet, but someone’s paying a fortune to find them first.”

Phainon grimaced.

“Yeah, that’s never good.”

“Better we get there first.”

A burst of static cracked over the line as Phainon slid under a low valve assembly.

“**And there’s a name circulating,”** Anaxa added. **“Not confirmed. But it’s… inconvenient.”**

“Oh?” Phainon’s brow quirked. “Someone important?”

“Someone problematic. Rumor says she can bypass chrysocite perimeters. Nobody’s sure she exists. But even the rumors are enough to get people killed.”

That got his attention.

He ducked beneath a cluster of warped pipes, lips curling.

“Wait, wait, I *know* that tone. You know her, don’t you?”

Anaxa didn’t answer.

Phainon pressed it.

“An Heir, wasn’t she? Before she bailed.”

A long pause.

“Leave it,” Anaxa said, curt. **“We’re not chasing her. Not tonight.”**

Phainon snorted a dry laugh.

“You’ve got more old friends crawling out of the rot than anyone I’ve ever met.”

“Networking is survival.”

Another turn. A narrow crawlspace, black water up to his shins, stinking of rust and worse.

Phainon’s grin faded.

“Alright. When’s this little masked meet-and-greet happening?”

“Tonight.”

He choked.

“Seriously!?”

Static fuzzed. Anaxa, distracted—probably elbow-deep in another bypass—replied absently:

“Also, Council’s starting residential sweeps. Spot checks. Random knock-and-scan.”

“Seriously!?” Phainon groaned, breaking into a faster run.

“How long before someone figures out my charming echo isn’t me?”

“If everything holds?” Anaxa mused. **“Twenty minutes.”**

“And if it doesn’t?”

“Hope you make it in fifteen. I’ll let you take a five-minute shower if you do.”

Phainon wheezed a breathless laugh.

“Asshole.”

But his pace doubled anyway.

The maintenance crawlspace was narrower than Phainon remembered.

Not that he’d known it long. Discovered it last week, actually—a personal tragedy, considering how many close calls it could’ve saved him from before now.

He twisted sideways, shoulder scraping grime-slick walls, overhead pipes sweating some unidentifiable chemical stink.

“Damn it, Anaxa,” he muttered, wriggling forward. “You and your brilliant shortcuts.”

A low, metallic *thud* echoed behind him—a bracket, maybe, or something less innocent. Phainon flinched so hard his elbow cracked against a rusted conduit. Biting back a curse, he wriggled faster until the passage opened into a jagged panel of crumbling drywall. He shoved it aside, the brittle surface giving with a muffled *crack,* and half-spilled into his own closet.

The door rattled in its frame.

Phainon groaned, braced a hand to steady himself, and dispelled the Echo he’d left slumbering in his bed hours ago. A faint shimmer, a soft pop—then gone.

No time to savor it.

Clothes hit the floor as he stripped, sweat-soaked layers peeled off in practiced haste. The comm receiver snagged off his ear, tossed onto a narrow shelf by the door, out of immediate sight.

The shower hissed to life, hot enough to sting. Five minutes to scrub the sewer off his skin. His fingers worked quick through his hair, chasing grit and clinging dust. The steam helped. The pulse in his chest slowed, fractionally.

Maybe he’d made it.

Maybe the sweep teams were sticking to perimeters, tagging clear homes and moving on.

The water cut off with a metallic shriek. Phainon grabbed a towel, wrapped it low around his hips, steam curling off his skin as he padded toward the living room—

A knock.

Sharp. Three precise, unhurried raps.

The sound seemed to reverberate longer than it should've.

He clicked his tongue against his teeth.

"Of course," he sighed.

Another knock. Polite, but firmer.

He cinched the towel tighter, mussed his damp hair with an artful rake of fingers, and pasted on a lazy smile. Then yanked open the door, leaning casually against the frame.

"Evening, officer," he drawled, eyelids half-lowered. "How's the sweep?"

The man on the other side wasn't a rookie.

Mid-thirties, heavyset, close-cropped hair. The matte black of his field uniform caught the low light, datapad flickering in his palm. His gaze swept Phainon's face, then the apartment behind him.

"Routine check," the officer said. Clipped. "Mind if I ask where you've been tonight, citizen…?"

"Phainon," he provided smoothly, thumb absently tapping the doorframe. "Been here. Mostly. Sleeping, showering, bit of reading. Quiet night in."

The officer didn't smile. His brow eased a fraction, but only barely.

"Alone?"

Phainon's smile tilted.

"Sadly, yeah. Though if you're offering—"

"I'm not."

"A shame."

The officer made a note on his pad. His gaze flicked up again—across Phainon's damp hair, collarbones, shoulders—

Then paused.

At the side of his neck.

A thin, fresh scrape. Just under his hairline.

The air changed.

A subtle tightening, a shift in the room's gravity. The officer straightened, eyes sharpening in a way that made the datapad seem incidental.

"That looks recent," the officer said evenly. "Care to explain?"

Phainon's stomach lurched—just for a second. His face didn't show it. The grin stayed, though it thinned, mouth moving before his brain caught up.

"Oh—that?" He reached up, fingers brushing it with a mock-sheepish chuckle. "Yeah, partner's been into… y'know. Intense stuff. It's a thing."

No flicker of amusement crossed the officer's face.

"Injury report filed?"

"Mutual fun, officer. No complaints lodged."

Phainon didn't blink. Let the smile turn lazy, half-lidded eyes holding steady.

Then—the officer's posture eased. Not much. A fraction.

"Well." He tapped the datapad. "Keep it down during curfew hours. We've had noise complaints."

Phainon flashed a razor smile.

"Wouldn't dream of it."

The officer gave a curt nod and turned, boots silent as he disappeared down the hall.

The moment the door shut, Phainon let the grin drop. Pressed his back to the door, slid down until he hit the floor, head thunking softly against the wood. His pulse still rattled like it wanted out of his ribs.

The comm crackled on the shelf.

“Your boyfriend, huh?” came Anaxa’s voice.

Phainon sighed.

“Eat shit.”

Anaxa’s voice came through again, quieter this time. Careful in a way Phainon recognized too easily—and hated.

“Speaking of… any contact from him?”

The words hung there.

Phainon didn’t answer.

The smile he’d been wearing slid off his face like a mask cut loose.

The steady hum of the vent fan suddenly was too loud, the distant bark of a stray dog down in the alley sharp and jarring. Lights felt too bright. The air too thick.

He stayed still.

A wire drawn taut.

Anaxa hesitated—Phainon could hear it. The pause before he spoke again.

“I… would’ve expected him to check in by now. I thought maybe—”

“Enough.”

The line went dead silent.

Anaxa didn’t speak again.

Neither did Phainon.

He closed his eyes. Jaw tight, pulse knocking too hard at the inside of his throat. For a moment it felt like his own body might betray him—breath stalling, eyes burning—before he forced it down. Locked it away where it belonged.

When he finally spoke, his voice was wrong.

Too light.

Too sharp at the edges.

“You’re gonna make me cry before my fancy party, Professor.”

Anaxa didn’t laugh.

Neither did Phainon.

The vent fan kept humming.

Phainon exhaled through his nose, the sound rough in the quiet. He rolled onto his side, propping himself up on an elbow, towel hitching low on his hips.

A beat, then—too bright:

“Soooo!” he chirped, a grin pulling at his mouth like it hurt. “Invitation tonight, right? Do I at least get to pick my outfit, or is this one of your formal parameters things again?”

Anaxa didn’t answer right away.

Then, finally—clipped. A little resigned.

“No.”

Phainon let out a long sigh, scrubbing a hand through his still-damp hair as he pushed to his feet.

“Knew it.”

“I had the foresight,” Anaxa added, **“to dead-drop a case at your place earlier this evening. Top drawer, left side. It’s marked.”**

“Is that so,” Phainon murmured, padding barefoot toward his room, the floor cool against his skin.

He slid the drawer open.

There it was—a slim black case, unmarked save for a pale chalk line at the corner. Classic Anaxa. Always leaving his fingerprints without ever leaving fingerprints.

Phainon flicked the latches and cracked the lid.

Inside: a suit, folded sharp enough to cut. Deep navy so dark it drank the light, shot through with threads of obsidian stitching that caught the faintest gleam. Black gloves, thin and close-fitting. A narrow choker, coiled like a promise of trouble.

And resting atop it all—a half-mask.

Venetian in style, matte black, faint filigree like static caught in glass.

Phainon raised a brow, holding it up between two fingers.

A smile tugged at his mouth, crooked and a little weary.

“Well, well,” he drawled, voice softer this time. “Y’know, if I had my way, I’d be showing up in a Power Ranger suit.”

Anaxa didn’t miss a beat.

“Which is precisely why you’re not choosing.”

That dragged a snort out of him.

He started pulling the suit on piece by piece. It fit like sin, smooth as a secret, the fabric heavy with concealed weavework and tailored to him down to the centimeter. Of course it was. Anaxa didn’t leave things like that to chance.

“Gotta hand it to you,” Phainon murmured, tugging the gloves snug. “For someone who pretends to have no sense of style, you’re disturbingly good at dressing me up.”

“Because one of us has to be.”

Phainon smirked, the gesture small and sharp as he set the mask aside for now. His fingers brushed the choker, tracing the clasp.

He rested an elbow against the shelf’s edge.

“Okay,” Phainon said. “Explain this place to me again. Masked info rave for revolutionary blackmailers, yeah? Got a proper name, or are we just calling it ‘the spooky reactor basement’?”

A pause on the other end. Faint background noise—a click, the shift of a tool or a keystroke.

Then:

“It’s called the Epitaph Court,” Anaxa replied at last. **“Used to be a place for quiet negotiations between government defectors and rogue mercenaries. Now it’s a ghost market for anyone with dirt to trade and a death wish.”**

Phainon gave a low whistle.

“And here I thought my social life was bleak.”

He picked up the mask, tilting it in the light, watching the way the dark filigree caught it like frozen lightning.

“Alright, boss,” he murmured.

“Showtime.”

Phainon’s fingers found the seam in the wall panel again. A flick of his wrist, a grunt, and the thing came loose with a soft metallic groan. It clattered to the floor, sending up a breath of stale air thick with dust, brittle wiring insulation, and the oil-slick tang of long-decayed lubricant.

He wrinkled his nose.

“Still can’t believe I didn’t notice this for months,” he muttered, ducking his head as he slipped into the crawlspace beyond.

He worked his way down the narrow shaft, grime smearing his gloves, until the crawlspace spat him out at a rust-caked access grate. The thing hung half-off its hinges, damp with condensation. Phainon gave it a sharp kick and dropped through.

His boots hit metal platform with a hollow clang, the impact rattling the framework and sending a lazy sheet of dust billowing. The sublevel stretched out before him in the dim glow of failing emergency lamps. Crimson pulses blinked at uneven intervals, painting the space in alternating bands of light and shadow.

Phainon stretched his arms overhead in a long, theatrical sigh.

“Home sweet home.”

His voice fell flat in the cavernous hush.

He made his way along the walkway, the rusted grating echoing under his boots. Another maintenance door yielded under his shoulder with a groan, and the corridor beyond opened into a narrow alley—a scar between two industrial service blocks.

Phainon rolled his neck, a sharp crack breaking the stillness.

Anaxa's voice came through.

"You have fifteen minutes. Recommend making that ten."

Phainon huffed a breath, one corner of his mouth quirking.

"Loud and clear."

And with that, he moved.

He slipped through blind spots he knew by heart. Down a forgotten service lot, into a stairwell barely wide enough for one person at a time. The deeper he went, the colder the air became, the walls sweating rust and condensation. Graffiti layered the walls in old spray paint, slogans bleeding through in palimpsest:

DON'T TRUST THEM
THE TIDE COMES FOR US ALL

Most of it half-erased by now. The only ones left intact felt deliberate.

The stairwell finally coughed him out onto a long-dead subtram platform. Steel rails lay rusted and broken, choked in rubble and water stains. Faded directional signs still clung stubbornly to the walls in blocky, corroded text:

REACTOR ACCESS—RESTRICTED PERSONNEL ONLY

Phainon grinned, dropping down onto the old tracks with a soft grunt.

"Never gets old."

A narrow corridor opened ahead—the walls curved and close. No emergency lights here.

He reached for his pocket.

Didn't find what he was looking for.

Frowned. Checked the other.

Nothing.

A tightness gathered at the base of his throat.

“…Shit.”

He even spared a quick glance back toward the tunnel mouth, as if some miraculous twist of narrative would have left the access card lying right there, next to the towel he’d left behind like some rogue laundry deity had intervened.

“Anaxa?” he hissed under his breath.

A dry crackle of static in his ear, then Anaxa’s voice, too amused for the situation.

“Left side. Inner pocket.”

Phainon froze. Slid his hand along the inside lining of his jacket. Cold plastic met his fingers.

He sighed. Long. Put-upon.

“…You’re lucky you’re pretty.”

A beat.

“I know.”

The dry fondness there was almost worse.

Anaxa’s voice shifted back to pragmatic.

“Surveillance’s near-zero down here. Proximity sensors still trip if you’re careless. It’s another dead zone—good for a meet like this, claustrophobic for the rest of us.”

“Charming,” Phainon muttered, pulling the card free and adjusting the mask where it hung around his neck. He scanned the dim corridor ahead, feeling the hair at the back of his neck itch.

“Alright, so where’s my hatch?”

“Rusted bulkhead, left side,” came Anaxa’s reply. “Hidden behind a loose panel. Two meters ahead.”

Phainon sighed, cracking his knuckles as he moved forward.

“Knew you were gonna say that.”

The darkness pressed in around him as he searched.

It didn’t take long before his fingers brushed cold, corroded metal beneath a film of grime. A pressure hatch, half-swallowed by debris and broken conduit piping. The faded outline of a hazard placard clung stubbornly to the bulkhead, its warning symbols still visible through layers of rust.

Beneath it, a narrow keycard slot blinked a sullen red.

Phainon exhaled through his nose. He fished the card from his inner pocket, rolling it between his fingers for a moment.

“Once you’re inside the conduit—keep left. Ignore the first two ladder shafts. The third one leads to the substructure threshold. And whatever you do… don’t linger at the door.”

Phainon scoffed.

“Stars above, Anaxa, it’s a club, not a death cult.”

No reply.

He slid the keycard through the reader.

A muted beep. The hatch shuddered against its own age, locking mechanisms grinding before the seam split open with a sluggish hiss.

The passage beyond made him grimace.

Half-collapsed walls slouched inward, streaked with water stains and old mineral blooms. Pipes overhead ran in crooked lines, sagging beneath their own weight.

Phainon gave a resigned grunt.

“On second thought… you might’ve been right.”

And stepped inside.

Twice he passed ladder shafts, their iron rungs slick with condensation, vanishing into darkness above and below. He didn’t look. Didn’t slow.

The third waited where Anaxa had promised—dented, the paint long peeled away. Rust—or blood—flaked along the edges. He didn’t stop to check.

The path twisted once more before dead-ending.

Or it would have, to anyone else.

A slab of matte-finished metal stood embedded in the wall. Seamless. No handle, no terminal. Only a shallow indentation set beneath a blinking red light—and a figure waiting beside it.

Cloaked. Masked.

A pallid curve of ceramic, cracked with age, obscured the face beneath. Hollow eye slits stared through him. The figure didn’t speak.

Phainon slowed.

Anaxa’s voice returned, softer than before—a thread of a whisper:

“Do not look at the guard too long.
Do not speak unless addressed.”

His jaw clenched. But he obeyed.

Eyes down.

No words.

He stepped forward, slotting the card into the reader.

A polite chime.

The metal slab split down the center, parting just wide enough for a rush of warm, close air to spill out. From somewhere beyond, music bled through—analog strings tuned to a minor key, the sound of a half-forgotten orchestra playing for a room no one had left in years.

Without waiting, Phainon stepped inside.

The door sealed behind him with a soundless hush.

And the air changed.

Warm, oil-sweet and thick with wax smoke and something medicinal. It clung to his throat, settled in his lungs.

Faded murals bled down the reactor walls, ghostly shapes half-lost to corrosion and time.

Somewhere ahead, a string quartet played. Not a recording—live. A quartet partially veiled behind drooping curtains, dressed in tattered formal wear. One of them dragged a viola bow across the strings, pulling long, dissonant notes that crawled along his spine.

Figures moved through the chamber, no two masks alike—some baroque, others grotesque. All designed to obscure. Eyes flickered through narrow slits, catching the light, marking his arrival.

Phainon rolled his shoulders loose, letting his pulse settle.

“Stay at the edges. Listen first. No trades until you know who’s here.”

He gave a shallow nod,

“Copy.”

The entry vestibule gave way to the main hall—a low, wide chamber held together by old reactor pillars. Thick curtains divided the space into makeshift alcoves and private enclaves where sharp whispers were traded.

Across the room, a trio he recognized from Anaxa’s dossiers—the Augurs’ Circle. Ink sigils marked their hands as they murmured over a glitching projection of black harmonics. Phainon didn’t slow.

The string music caught on a sour note.

“Seven faces not on the last manifest. Three Circle. One Vault broker I don’t trust. That’s Hyracian’s fixer by the east curtain. No deals till you clock him.”

Phainon’s lips barely moved.

“Copy. Taking a lap.”

He let himself drift. A peripheral presence, neither lurking nor conspicuous.

Near the south curtain, the Traders’ Cluster had gathered, their enclave loosely ringed around a scattering of brittle printouts and analog schematics.

Phainon angled himself beside a rusted support strut, posture casual. Close enough to catch voices. Far enough to remain forgettable.

“…clearing the manifest ahead of schedule.”

A gravel-voiced trader spoke, his mask cobbled from an old control panel casing, grime streaking the metal.

Another gave a derisive snort. “Cleanup protocol?”

“Would be, if there was a registry.” A third voice this time—younger. “No locational tag, no terminal codes logged. The entire manifest’s floating dark.”

That drew a pause.

“Another breach containment op?” someone ventured.

The gravel-voiced trader gave a humorless grunt. “Or a harvest pull.”

A fourth leaned in. Thin, breathy, words carrying just far enough:

“Synthetic-binding requisitions went out last cycle. High volume. But no accompanying retrieval logs. Not yet.”

That one landed.

Phainon felt a knot tighten at the base of his throat. So Anaxa wasn’t wrong — not exactly. The body transports weren’t a fabrication… but neither had they happened. The manifests were real, the prep work in motion. They just didn’t have the bodies yet.

Which meant the Council wasn’t covering up an event.

They were anticipating one.

Or worse, orchestrating it.

Anaxa’s voice came like a thread through the haze.

“Move along, lingering isn’t gonna help.”

Phainon exhaled through his teeth and peeled away, folding himself back into the wandering tide of masked shapes.

Near the east alcove, the Augurs’ Circle huddled around a magnetic map display. Its surface flickered with unsteady light. Ghostly flares bloomed across its surface, tracing the Black Tide’s latest spread along the outer parts.

Phainon adjusted his pace, letting their conversation bleed into the space between movements.

“…pattern shifts over the last cycle aren’t natural,” one old voice rasped, thick with an accent he didn’t recognize.

A half-mask in tarnished bronze turned toward a leaner figure swathed in Council-issue cloth—though the insignia had been scorched away.

“It’s moving like it’s being drawn,” the dissident murmured. “Tether points shifting without correlation. There’s no logic anymore.”

Phainon’s brow tightened, reading the tension in their postures more than their words.

Then one of them spoke, too soft.

“I saw her.”

The entire circle tensed.

A dry voice followed, laced with dread.

“By the breach perimeter. A woman. Dark hair. Violin in hand. Played like she wasn’t fully there—torso transparent like water.”

A ripple of sharp, quiet curses circled the group. Someone made a warding gesture with inked fingers.

Phainon’s pulse skipped, stomach giving a cold twist.

There was only one person that could be.

And only one rule Anaxa had ever delivered with absolute finality.

He couldn’t stop himself.

“‘We’re not chasing her. Not tonight,’” he muttered, just loud enough for Anaxa to hear, mimicking his words from before.

Anaxa’s response came as a low growl in his ear.

“If you get yourself pulled down by that specter, I’ll come find whatever’s left and finish the job myself.”

A smile tugged at the corner of Phainon’s mouth as he moved on.

Near the far end of the hall, the Vault guards stood. Two of them. Mirrored half-masks, cut from the same black glass, faces reflecting the restless light. No insignia, but their posture told the story.

They clocked him instantly.

One extended a gloved hand toward an embedded wall reader, silent.

Phainon retrieved his keycard. Ran it through.

A soft chime.

A nod from the left-hand guard. The curtain beyond parted just enough to admit him.

Anaxa’s voice returned, tension coiled around it.”

“This is primary circle territory. Confirm the broker’s presence before you so much as breathe about a trade. No assumptions. Half the Vault’s Council-aligned tonight, and you won’t know who’s who until it’s already too late.”

Phainon stepped through, the heavy curtain closing behind him.

Phainon moved with practiced ease.

He let his gaze drift, noting the faces—or masks.

A lean figure with a hex-glass visor that caught the light like a fault line.

Twin women in mirrored porcelain masks, their expressions unreadable, seated so still it unsettled.

And then—her.

Seated alone at a tarnished brass table near the east wall, half-veiled behind swaying chains sat the one known here as *Ferris*. Not her true name, but her reputation traveled well—a broker of classified manifests, embargo intercepts, and the sort of information that could make corpses long before morning.

Her mask was simple. A lacquered woodplate cut in the style of a mourning veil, the lower half of her face left bare: thin mouth, a sharp chin, and a pale scar that split the corner of her lip.

Anaxa had named that as the tell.

Phainon let his stride slow as he passed a nearby table, where two men bent over a map. His eyes caught on the empty chair across from her, then moved on—just long enough. He turned, stepped in, placed a single token chip on the table's worn surface, and spoke the code phrase Anaxa had sent him minutes prior.

"A fine evening for ghosts."

Ferris didn't look up.

Her hand moved instead, fingers tracing the rim of a glass.

"The dead travel quickest when the lights go dark," she replied idly.

Acknowledgment passed between them.

Without invitation, Phainon claimed the seat across from her.

A beat stretched.

"You're late," Ferris murmured, eyes flickering up, the scar at her lip tugging faintly.

"Unavoidable," he returned. "Freight lines were a mess."

The edge of a smirk ghosted over her mouth.

“Always are.”

The niceties spent, she leaned in—not by much, just enough for the words to slip beneath the vault’s thick hush.

“So. What’s your ask, traveler?”

Phainon tapped a knuckle once against the table’s edge, considering.

“Class-F transports. Manifests. Traffic patterns.”

That stilled her.

Just a slight pause, head tilting faintly, as if recalibrating the stakes.

After a moment, she reached beneath the table and drew out a narrow notepad—old paper, the edges browned—and flipped it open with a thumb.

“Those are sealed movements,” she said.

Phainon’s shoulders lifted in a loose shrug.

“Didn’t ask for the minutes. Just curious what’s shifting beyond the glow of polite company.”

A long, thoughtful silence.

Then, finally:

“Manifest code T-FLUX PRIMA.”

She tapped the page once, then angled it toward him, her fingers never leaving the edge.

“Council requisition. Two containment units. No contents listed.”

Phainon’s brow furrowed, an artful mimic of detached interest.

“Stasis caskets?” he asked.

“Empty ones. For now.”

Something in his gut twisted.

It wasn’t the confirmation—it was the implication.

Ferris let the words settle before continuing.

“The intended cargo’s marked viable carriers. Acquisition status: pending. No registry logs. Destination terminal’s blackout-tier. No comm traces, no preclearance pings. Too clean.”

Phainon exhaled softly through his teeth, murmuring without much inflection,

“Sounds like someone’s clearing a path for a bloodbath.”

A flicker of something—distaste, maybe, or grim familiarity—passed over Ferris’s face.

“Two options,” she said. “Either they’re prepping to sanitize a site no one wants traced. Or…”

She let the word trail, studying him.

He let a brow rise. “Or?”

“A projected incident,” Ferris murmured, eyes narrowing. “Casualties. Enough to merit containment units. If the Council’s clearing lanes this early, the bodies aren’t on the floor yet. But they will be.”

Phainon let the manifest code imprint itself in memory. T-FLUX PRIMA.

“An internal purge?” he asked, letting the note of naïve curiosity feather his tone.

Ferris gave a wry, humorless half-smile.

“Everyone here wagers on the things we’re paid to forget, traveler.”

She was closing the notepad when her hand stilled, fingers splaying briefly against the cover.

“Wait.”

Phainon tensed, a flicker of caution rising.

“The timing,” she murmured. “It’s too fast. Faster than Council procedure should allow. It isn’t some long-game purge. This feels like someone’s aligning stars. Tonight, maybe tomorrow. Before word spreads.”

A long breath.

“If you’ve any sense, you’ll be nowhere near it.”

She rose without another word, chain strands parting as she vanished into the veil of haze and oil-smoke.

Phainon remained seated.

Then, in one smooth motion, he rose, flicked the spent token chip toward the pool of candle wax at the table’s edge, and made for the exit.

He thumbed the comm bead by his jaw.

“You hear that?”

A beat.

“…Yeah. I heard it.”

Phainon ducked beneath a low sconce, sidestepping a pair of masked traders swapping chip vials.

“So,” he muttered, “I’m leaving. Obviously.”

A sharp sigh crackled over the line.

“Oh no, you’re not. Do you have any idea how many contacts I burned getting you that invite?”

“And it’s a fantastic party, Professor. Could use an hors d’oeuvre table though.”

“Phainon.”

He winced.

“Look. They’re moving soon, Anaxa. Whatever this cull, purge, sacrificial-theatrics-to-the-stars horseshit is, it’s planned. We hang around too long, we end up on one of those lists.”

Anaxa scoffed, brittle.

“We need eyes on the rest of the Vault. A thread, a route, anything that leads to the target site—”

“And no one here’s going to hand us that. Anyone who knows won’t say it in a place like this.”

Tension coiled tight between them.

“Damn it, Phainon. Don’t run now.”

“Not running. Calculating.”

Anaxa’s reply was poised on the edge of a retort when a sharp chime clipped through the channel—a muffled, distant alert tone on his end.

Phainon sighed.

“I’ll let you take that.”

He kept moving.

You didn’t draft a manifest like that unless you already knew who was going to die.

Forty-eight hours was optimistic. Could be half that. Hell—could be happening right now while he played dress-up in this crypt.

He was nearly to the outer corridor when he brushed a shoulder.

Tall figure.

Didn’t stop. Didn’t turn.

Lion mask.

A flicker of gold in the haze.

Phainon muttered, “Pardon.”

And kept going—but something about it snagged. A fishhook behind the eye.

The frame, the gait, the shape, everything.

Familiar.

He frowned. *Have I—?*

Gone. Swallowed by another knot of bodies.

“Anaxa,” he murmured, thumb to comm again. “Update?”

Silence.

A flicker of cold static.

A fine sweat prickled between his shoulder blades.

Then Anaxa’s voice came through, with a tightness Phainon had never heard.

“On second thought—get the fuck out. Now.”

It hit like a blow.

Phainon blinked. The sudden shift rattled him more than he'd like to admit.

"Uh, sure. But you wanna explain that dramatic pivot or—"

"Move."

An order.

His pulse climbed.

"Anaxa. Talk to me."

A brittle exhale on the line.

"Caught something on a sweep."

Clinical now, which means he's totally freaking out.

"Signature pattern. High-tier, masked so heavy I thought it was ambient noise. But it's fresh. Residual traces riding the internal shielding."

Phainon's stomach turned.

"Which means what, exactly—"

"Which means there's an Heir in proximity."

His feet stopped moving.

He forced his voice steady.

"Who?"

A pause.

One beat too long.

Then:

“Godslayer.”

Silence.

A sharp, acid weight settled behind his ribs.

He swallowed.

“Anaxa,” he whispered, already moving again. “I need a path out.”

“I’m working on it. Keep moving. Don’t look for him. Don’t talk to anyone. Don’t stall.”

Phainon’s gaze flicked toward the last place he’d seen the lion mask.

His skin crawled.

The deeper he went, the more the station seemed to forget itself. Old service alcoves sealed by corroded gates, abandoned maintenance bays drowned in layers of dust thick as felt. The walls wept condensation, and half-dead cabling twitched in the gloom like nerves beneath scarred flesh.

“Anaxa,” he muttered, ducking behind a loose ventilation panel as a pair of traders passed. “This path is shit.”

“You’ll live,” came the reply, but there was an edge to it. **“Front’s compromised. Too many unknowns shifting lanes. Take service passage Gamma-Seven-Five—tagging it now.”**

A marker blinked in his retinal overlay, a faint ochre pulse bleeding through the haze ahead. It led toward a side corridor sagging under collapsed bulkheads and the ruin of flickering hazard signs.

He brushed his fingertips against the pitted wall as he moved, warping the thin skein of reality along the edges—slipping fractures into seams, fraying borders, turning angles just enough to be overlooked.

The din of the Merchant Vault faded behind him to cracked durasteel walls slick with reactor sweat.

He found the service passage.

A battered grate hung askew, one hinge rusted through. He slipped inside, boots hitting the greasy floor in absolute silence. The corridor narrowed to a maintenance tunnel barely wide enough for two men shoulder to shoulder, overhead bulbs guttering between dull amber and dead black.

“Alright,” he murmured, breath misting in the cold. “In. Alive.”

“Good. Stay sharp.”

The tunnel forked ahead. He veered toward the narrower passage instinctively, crowded with discarded vent covers, old stasis clamps, coiled transfer cables knotted like dead serpents. It felt… marginally safer. The choking sense of eyes in the dark began to thin. His pulse eased. A shallow, wary calm.

Then a side vent caught his attention. Wide enough to crawl through, the cover hanging loose like a broken jaw.

Perfect.

“Fourth crawlspace tonight,” he muttered. “Hazard pay’s stacking, Anaxa.”

“Get through it, princess. You can invoice me later.”

He ducked inside, pulling the warped panel closed behind him. He moved on hands and knees, the air dense enough to taste, every sound amplified.

And then—footsteps.

Not rushed. Not hesitant. A steady, deliberate tread, pacing the corridor just beyond the vent wall.

Phainon froze.

His breath shallow, heartbeat ticking up not in panic, but in cold, efficient thought. Probably a scavenger. A stray trader. Nothing. He waited, spine pressed to the freezing metal, gaze fixed ahead.

“False alarm,” he murmured into the comm. “Someone passing through. No big—”

The footsteps slowed.

Drew parallel to the vent.

Stopped.

Phainon’s brow furrowed. The hairs at the nape of his neck lifted. It was the silence that did it. Not the pause itself—but the sense of it.

The tread moved on.

He exhaled slowly, tension bleeding out. A faint smile tugged at his mouth.

“See? Nothing. You get paranoid at your ag—”

A gauntleted fist punched clean through the vent wall beside him.

The shriek of tearing metal was a jagged, living thing in the dark. Before Phainon could even curse, a hand clamped around his ankle with unerring precision—inhumanly strong, cold fingers crushing down to bone.

“What the fu—”

It yanked.

Metal ripped like old cloth. He was dragged bodily from the crawlspace, his back slamming into the corridor’s grating hard enough to knock the wind from his lungs.

Instinct took over.

His hand snapped out, seizing a warped conduit. A pulse of resonance twisted it into a jagged spike and he drove it up toward his attacker’s throat.

The figure came through the torn vent in a single, terrible motion.

Godslayer.

Tall, built like a monument meant for executions. The lion mask from before—cracked now, its left side splintered like fractured bone. His presence hit like a shifting pressure, the air itself turning thick, resisting breath.

Phainon struck.

The jagged spike snapped forward, only to be caught mid-motion. Fingers closed around the weapon and crushed it to shrapnel.

“Shit—”

Phainon rolled, pulling the gravity around them into a warping lurch. Debris ripped free, conduits burst in showers of sparks, quick-flare snares detonating in his wake.

The Heir advanced through it as though moving through smoke.

“Stop,” the man’s voice said cautiously. “We can talk.”

“Not interested.” Phainon spat the words, twisting raw geometry into a barrage of shrapnel spikes. They drove at the Godslayer’s chest. It barely slowed him.

“Dearest Blasphemer,” Phainon snapped into the comm. “Plan B. Now.”

“Run.”

Phainon spun, slamming resonance threads into the floor to launch himself forward. Debris screamed behind him, the corridor buckling under the strain.

He ran.

Behind him, the Godslayer didn’t give immediate chase. But his voice followed, cutting through the din like a knife through cloth.

“You don’t know who you’re running from.”

Overhead conduits split apart, showering sparks. Lights burst in rapid succession, plunging whole sections of the corridor into stuttering half-dark. Pipes twisted inward, the walls warping themselves into crude, makeshift barricades behind him—not enough to stop what was coming, but maybe enough to delay it by a few precious seconds.

The footsteps didn’t falter.

“He’s still coming,” Phainon snapped, his voice brittle, breath ragged from the sprint.

“No shit. Listen to me—you’re close. Two levels down there’s a reactor sub-chamber. Cut through there. South wall’s got a service exit. That’ll drop you into an exhaust conduit I can patch into. Keep moving!”

Anaxa’s voice wasn’t steady either. There was a rawness to it, something uncharacteristically frayed. Not anger.

Fear.

The air ahead shimmered, a rupture yawning open along the tunnel wall—a narrow tear in the weave of space, unstable and half-born, edges flickering like heat haze caught inside fractured glass.

Phainon didn’t hesitate. He dove for it shoulder-first, the distortion pulling at his skin like wet static. Reality bent, folded, snapped, and he tumbled through, hitting cold durasteel on the other side hard enough to jar his teeth.

The sub-chamber stretched out around him—vast and hollow, the dead heart of a long-abandoned system. Reactor conduits rose like fossilized bones, crusted with corrosion, vanishing into the blackness overhead.

“I’m in,” he panted.

“Good—good. South wall, you’ll see a ladder, right side. It’ll—”

A burst of static swallowed Anaxa’s voice. When it returned, it cracked with urgency.

“Wait—wait, fuck. He’s rerouting. Phainon, don’t stop. Don’t stop moving.”

Phainon moved along the chamber’s edge, weaving between corroded supports and half-collapsed conduit runs. His eyes tracked the catwalks above, searching for any movement. Nothing.

His pulse slowed, just for a moment. A cold sheen of sweat traced the side of his face.

“Anaxa… how the hell did he—”

A flicker.

It wasn’t movement. It was something else—a wrongness in the air, a presence his instincts registered before his mind could name it.

He turned.

Too slow.

A hand clamped around his wrist, fingers encasing bone and tendon like iron bands. The cold shock of contact drove his heart up into his throat.

He hadn’t heard a thing.

No rush of breath. No ripple in the air. One heartbeat there was nothing, and the next—Godslayer.

“Stop,” the voice practically hissed. “I don’t want to hurt you. Just listen to me for one second.”

Every nerve in Phainon’s body screamed at once.

Go. Now.

“Go fuck yourself.”

He wrenched free, lashing out with a pulse of raw distortion from his palm. The space between them shattered like brittle glass, jagged lines cracking outward. The Heir raised his gauntleted hand, and the energy dispersed against it, harmless as mist breaking against stone.

Phainon’s other hand snapped up. Threads of force tangled in the air, coalescing into a flickering shield of warped space. He drove it forward like a battering ram. It struck with a sound like a freight train collision—the shield spiderwebbed, buckled, and burst.

Pain rattled his arm down to the shoulder.

He didn’t stop.

A conduit coil snapped loose with a flick of his wrist, reshaping mid-air into a jagged spear. He thrust it forward. Godslayer parried with an almost contemptuous motion, metal on metal.

Another pulse of force rolled between them, space distorting violently under Phainon’s feet. He hurled himself back, calling every last fraying thread of resonance to him. Hovering lengths of conduit and sheared metal shivered and lifted, spinning around him in a ragged halo.

But his grip on them was tenuous. The fatigue was setting in. His threads faltered, the makeshift weapons flickering unsteadily, shapes warping under his own failing control.

“Damn it,” Phainon hissed. “Route me an exit. Now.”

“I’m trying! Just buy me thirty seconds. That’s all I need!”

Godslayer advanced through the debris, moving like a shadow behind firelight, sidestepping the burst of collapsing gravity and the shrieking

distortions of his thrown spikes. Three launched. One shattered. Another spun wide as warped air knocked it off course. The last came apart mid-flight, dissolving into useless fragments.

Phainon's heart thundered.

Fissures splitting the floor, spatial tears forming like wounds in the air, the strain of his overtaxed abilities turning reality brittle.

The Heir came on, unhurried.

"I'm not your enemy," the masked voice said cautiously.

Phainon's fist connected with the mask in a wild, furious swing. A sharp jolt of pain ran up his wrist as bone struck hardened composite. Godslayer didn't so much as reel. The mask turned, fractionally, a slow pivot as though assessing.

"You don't have to do this."

"Then stop chasing me!" Phainon snarled, teeth bared, sweat burning his eyes.

Anaxa's voice cut in, sharp and breathless. "Exit's open! North vent—behind that coolant manifold—move, now!"

He sent a final destabilizing pulse behind him, the floor cracking as gravity inverted for an instant. Debris shot upward in a lethal scatter.

It wasn't enough.

He ran, every muscle screamed, nerves lit to fire, the edges of his vision tunneling. Warped space trailed behind him in flickering arcs as he sprinted for the coolant manifold.

He didn't look back.

The pressure of that presence lingered at his heels.

And it was gaining.

The tears he forced open were collapsing faster than he could hold them. His grip on his abilities was slipping, and fast.

“Anaxa,” Phainon hissed into his comm, voice fraying. “I need a path—”

Only static answered him. The comm cracked, hissed, then fell silent under the crush of interference. The line was dead.

He was alone.

A weight struck his side with brutal force. Phainon’s world spun, the breath punched from his lungs as his ribs collided hard against the frozen curve of a coolant pipe. The shock of impact jolted through his spine, a strangled sound catching in his throat.

The blow wasn’t clean. It hadn’t meant to be. There was restraint buried somewhere in it, like whoever hit him had pulled back at the last second—enough to stop him without breaking anything.

Before he could recover, a hand closed over his shoulder, another around his wrist, pinning him against the ice-flecked metal.

The lion-faced mask hovered only a breath away.

“Phainon.”

The name hit like a hammer, a shattering crack through the fog in his head.

His chest seized.

No one should know his name.

Not here. Not now.

Panic surged, rising so fast it blurred his vision, making his skin prickle cold. He twisted violently, straining against the grip, abilities lashing out in wild, jagged arcs around him.

“Let me go,” Phainon rasped, the edge of raw panic threading his voice in a way he didn’t have time to hide.

The hands didn’t tighten, didn’t strike back—they just held firm.

“Phainon.” The voice again, lower this time, softened beneath the distortion field of the mask. There was something beneath the artificial grit, a cadence that should not have belonged here in a place like this. “It’s alright. Breathe.”

His vision shimmered, tunnelled at the edges. His heart hammered so hard it felt like his ribcage would splinter beneath it. He kept fighting—instinct and terror demanded it—though some part of him registered that the hold wasn’t cruel. It anchored, rather than crushed.

“Listen to me,” the figure said quietly. “You don’t have to keep running. You’re safe, right here.”

Safe.

The word barely meant anything anymore. It ricocheted uselessly against the inside of his skull, swallowed by adrenaline.

Phainon bared his teeth. “I don’t know who the fuck you think—”

“It’s me.”

A murmur. Barely more than breath, softened in a way that made no sense. It slipped between the cracks in his panic, threading through the din of his pulse in a way nothing else could’ve managed.

His hands shifted, loosening by the smallest margin. Not enough to let him bolt—but enough to ease the strain. A hand like that didn’t hesitate without reason.

Something about it made him falter.

He could have torn a metaphysical gate wide and fled, could’ve shattered the air itself and vanished into whatever frayed geometry this place had left.

But instead…

“I’m not here to hurt you,” the masked figure said again. “I swear it, Phainon. You’re alright. I’ve got you.”

It shouldn’t have worked.

But somehow, it did.

The violent pounding of his heart didn’t stop, but it staggered. His muscles trembled beneath his skin, on the cusp of fight or flight, but something about that tone—the weight behind those words—slowed the inevitable. The way it was spoken, not desperate, not cruel, but steady, almost gentle.

It was disarming in a way Phainon didn’t have the language for.

The gauntlet shifted again. This time, two fingers brushed against his pulse point at his throat.

“You feel that?” the voice asked. “You’re here. Stay with me.”

His throat bobbed in a swallow he didn’t remember choosing.

He should’ve fought. Should’ve ripped reality open and left this place bleeding behind him. But still, he didn’t move.

It made no sense. Nothing about this did.

“It doesn’t have to be like this,” Godslayer said softly. “You’ll be fine.”

A ridiculous promise in a place like this. And yet…

something inside Phainon unspooled, just a fraction.

For the briefest instant, it felt like the air around them thinned. As though a different version of this moment tried to force itself through.

Phainon’s voice cracked when it finally came. “What… what do you want from me?”

Godslayer leaned a fraction closer, vapor curling between them.

“To talk to you.”

And then—

The air split with the sharp, rising howl of an alarm. A blaring, violent wail that knifed through the chamber, fracturing the fragile quiet between them.

Both men stiffened.

Voices cut down from the catwalk above, distorted through amplifiers, sharp and cold.

“By authority of the Council—designation Flame Reaver, you are hereby claimed into custody for high resonance destabilization, unauthorized breach of containment, and reckless destabilization of restricted sectors. Stand down immediately and prepare for retrieval.”

Phainon’s stomach lurched, blood turning to ice.

He jerked against the grip instinctively. “What the fuck—”

The sound hit like a hammer to the skull, reverberating through bone, every syllable a dull, concussive pulse inside his head. His heartbeat surged, a nauseating heat flooding his limbs, his chest straining against itself.

The grip on his shoulder tightened. He felt the gauntlet flex against bone and muscle, tension bleeding through the metal.

“Wait—Phainon—I didn’t—” The voice cracked, something desperate threading beneath the sound.

But none of it mattered.

The catwalk blurred, figures smearing into shadowed shapes. Every bootfall, every word, every echo slammed into him like shockwaves.

His chest seized.

Of course. *Of course*.

This had been it. The setup. Draw him out. Pretend to ease him down. Get him to lower his guard. And then deliver him straight into the Council's hands.

A trap.

The coolant mist thickened around him. Pressure pressed against his temples. His stomach turned. The sound of his own breath came in sharp, ragged gasps he couldn't control.

"No—you planned this," Phainon spat.

He shoved violently against the grip. Pain lanced down his arm as his shoulder jarred. He didn't care. Couldn't care. Instinct hijacked thought. His elbow struck him with a dull crack. Resonance bled out from him in uncontrolled slashes, sharp arcs of volatile light breaking against the gloom.

"Don't—don't touch me, get the fuck off—let me go—I'm not—I won't—"

His voice broke.

Then the comm roared to life in his ear, a burst of static that spiked through his skull like a blade. Anaxa's voice beneath it, jagged and desperate.

"PHAINON MOVE—GET OUT—MOVE MOVE MOVE—"

Too loud.

Too much.

His breath hitched in sharp, shallow pulls. Couldn't fill his lungs. Couldn't think. The coolant vapor crawled against his skin. The walls warped. Every edge buckled. The sound of boots on the catwalk above blended into a single relentless drumbeat behind his ribs.

I'm trapped.
They're gonna take me. Strap me down. Cut me

Rip through my head. Dig through my bones.
I'll never come back. I won't—I can't—

He could see it.

The restraint rigs. The cold straps across his arms. The sharp press of metal against his throat. Needles in his spine. White light over his face. The sound of his own scream, distant and thin, a thing disconnected from the body it came from.

Godslayer's voice tried to cut through, ragged and frayed.

"I didn't call them—I swear it—"

It barely registered. Muffled, drowned out, like shouting underwater. Phainon clamped his hands over his ears, thin crackling tendrils flickering uncontrolled. The coolant mist twisted, shapes moving where nothing should've been.

Anaxa's voice merged with Godslayer's with the pounding boots and the scream of the alarm—no separation anymore, just noise, one suffocating, deafening crush that filled every corner of him.

I'mgonnadieI'mgonnadieI'mgonnadieI'mgonnadieI'mgonnadie—

His knees buckled.

A choking, high sound escaped his throat. His vision blurred at the edges. The room spun, walls folding in. Every thought, every instinct spiraled.

They're gonna cut me open. They're gonna open my head. Dig through me. Pull the pieces out. I won't come back this time. I can't—I can't—

And then —

silence.

Not real, but enough.

A flicker.

A single memory cleaving through the suffocating dark.

“Thoracic. Upper mid-spine. Somewhere between T7 and T11.”

A pinpoint.

A single, impossible anchor in the flood.

His fingers twitched.

One small, unsteady movement.

His breath stuttered, catching on the ragged edge of a sob he never fully made.

His other hand fumbled, scraping numbly against the cold coolant pipe at his side. He didn’t even know he was moving, his body following instinct.

The world narrowed to a single, flickering point between T7 and T11.

Everything else—the voices, the pounding footsteps, the alarms, the crushing walls—fell away.

Just a target.

Just one desperate, dying chance.

His knees hit the grated floor with a sharp clang. Arms scrabbled weakly against Godslayer’s frame. The hold around his shoulders instinctively loosened. A hand clamped at his ribs, steadying him.

“Hey—” The voice cracked, a frayed edge of concern bleeding into it. Too close to something Phainon knew but couldn’t name. It slipped under his skin like a needle.

And that was the opening.

His fingers twitched.

A fractured pulse of energy gathered in his palm—not a clean resonance spike, no neat construct, but a jagged, unstable splinter of ambient charge scavenged from the chaos around them: bent conduits, collapsed magnetic seals, the room's gravity fields knotting and flexing like a storm surge.

It burned in his palm. The skin split, thin strands of flickering white-gold light bleeding through his fingertips. Blood mixed with it. His nose leaked crimson.

Good.

It was real enough.

In the heartbeat of feigned collapse—as Godslayer's grip shifted, one hand moving to brace him—Phainon surged what was left of his strength into that single, desperate strike.

And drove the crude spike upward.

Straight into the narrow, lethal gap between thoracic plates.

T7 to T11.

Exactly where Anaxa had said.

The effect was immediate—a sickening, resonant crack as the spike punched through pulse fields and nerve bundles. The charge lashed out, sending a jolt through the other man's frame. Godslayer's body recoiled. A strangled, guttural sound burst—halfway between a grunt and a choked curse. His hold spasmed, locking for a half second… then gave.

His knees buckled.

Phainon shoved himself free, stumbling back, his whole body screaming in protest. Vision blurred, chest heaving in sharp, thin pulls. Every nerve lit with raw, static agony.

But he was up.

Alive.

And then it happened—a sound he hadn’t expected.

Godslayer staggered against a coolant pipe, one hand pressed hard against his side. Blood welled between his fingers, staining the gauntlet, thick and dark.

And in a raw, guttural rasp, so low it barely registered over the alarms—

“…How?”

A word ripped from somewhere primal. Not a curse. Not an accusation.

A question.

One no one should ever need to ask.

Phainon froze. Just for a breath. Just long enough to *feel* it—the weight of what he’d done hanging between them like a loaded charge.

Godslayer’s gaze—dark through the cracked visor—locked on him. Wide. Disbelieving. There was no vengeance in it. No anger.

Only that stunned, uncomprehending horror of a man who thought he was unkillable realizing, *for the first time*, that he wasn’t.

Phainon’s pulse hammered in his ears. The spike dissolved in his hand, motes of unstable light unraveling into nothing. His skin stung where the energy had burned him.

He turned—*because he had to*—scanning for a way out. Every step felt unsteady, like moving through water, his legs uncertain beneath him.

Behind him, something small struck the floor.

A metallic clink.

A soft, steady roll.

A ring.

Simple. Plain. A worn signet catching the coolant haze as it spun, tracing a lazy arc across the grated floor.

It came to rest against the side of his boot.

Phainon's foot twitched.

He stared.

Not at the bloodied man crumpled against the pipe.

Not at the Heirs above, shouting, closing in.

At the ring.

At the insignia carved into its face.

And for one single, stuttering heartbeat—the whole world *stopped*.

The noise, the alarms, the pressure—all of it fell away.

Nothing but the ring.

And the terrible, impossible recognition curling in his stomach like a blade.

The world spun, and somewhere in the background, Godslayer's ragged, fading breath choked out again —

"How…?"

Phainon didn't move.

Couldn't.

And then the moment shattered.

He crouched, his knees creaking against the grated floor. His hand didn’t feel like his own. It trembled as his fingers closed around the ring, the small, unassuming weight of it somehow heavier than the weapon he’d just forged.

The metal was cold.

It bit into his palm.

A smear of blood clung to the underside, drying in a thin line.

For a moment, nothing else existed.

No alarms.

No closing boots.

No screaming comms.

Only that object—the ring, the impossible familiarity of it, and the quiet rasp of his own breathing stuttering against the back of his throat.

Anaxa’s voice snapped.

“Phainon.”

Another burst of static, rough, ragged, his voice frayed in the way it only got when something was already too far gone.

“What the fuck are you doing—”

He didn’t answer.

Couldn’t.

His gaze stayed locked on the ring, the insignia etched into its surface, the way light caught against a faint, uneven mark near its edge. His pulse thudded in his ears, drowning the rest of the world to a dim, distant hum.

His throat worked. A breath caught.

Then words came, breaking apart in his mouth before they fully formed.

“Rings are common,” he murmured.

The sound of his own voice startled him. It didn’t sound like something he’d said. It was thin, loose, disjointed, as though spoken by a stranger standing just to his left.

“People have them.” Another breath. “It’s not… it doesn’t mean anything. It’s just a ring.”

A beat of silence on the comm.

Then Anaxa again, stumbling.

“What—?”

“It’s normal.” His words sharpened, an edge creeping in unbidden. “Anyone could have one. People wear them. It’s just a thing. Just a piece of fucking metal.”

A breath huffed out, something too harsh to be called a laugh.

“It’s a coincidence.”

A sound behind him.

Not a curse, not a snarl—something softer, cracked and hoarse, a threadbare remnant of a voice dragging his name like it hurt to speak.

“Phainon…”

The word crumbled in the air.

It hit him harder than the alarms ever could.

His spine stiffened.

A cold, animal terror settled in his stomach—not the sharp, bright kind that came with battle, but something heavier. The dread that crept in when your mind recognized what your heart hadn’t yet, when you knew something was wrong in the way gravity sometimes felt heavier just before a fall.

His fingers turned the ring in his palm.

And there it was.

The scratch.

A thin, diagonal gouge along the outer curve of the insignia. Stupid, meaningless damage. A mark from a half-forgotten night in a back alley years ago, a piece of fencing, a fight Phainon had mocked him for afterward, grinning through split lips while warning him to stop getting involved in things that didn’t matter.

That scratch shouldn’t be here.

Couldn’t be here.

Not on a Heir-issued ring.

Not on a dead man’s hand.

His pulse surged.

The comm kept crackling—Anaxa’s voice rising now, strained, desperate, but it might as well have been radio static.

None of it mattered.

The only sound was the rasp of a shallow breath behind him.

And his own heartbeat, loud and relentless in his ears.

Phainon stood.

His legs didn’t want to. It took effort. The ring bit deeper into his palm, the edges sharp against his skin.

He crossed the floor.

Each step felt longer than the last.

Metal groaned above.

The cooling systems hissed and stuttered.

The storm of movement on the catwalk blurred to a distant, inconsequential clatter.

His hand reached out.

Fingers found the fractured edge of the lion mask—cracks radiating from the place his strike had landed. His grip closed over it, the modulator sparking against his palm in protest.

And then he pulled.

A single, steady motion.

The mask came away.

Blonde hair, matted with blood and coolant vapor.

A face beneath it, pale and battered, lips parted on a shallow, ragged breath.

Phainon stared.

Every detail landed like a blow—not a sudden impact, but a slow, crushing weight.

The curve of the jaw.

The line of the brow.

Every impossible detail.

The ring slipped from his fingers. It hit the floor with a dull clink and rolled lazily to a stop.

His knees gave out.

He dropped, not with violence, but like a man whose strings had been cut. A sharp, broken sound clawed from his throat—somewhere between a gasp and a sob, though his eyes stayed dry.

He didn’t speak.

Couldn’t.

Could only kneel there, frozen, the breath torn from his lungs as the impossible face of Mydei bled quietly in front of him.

Phainon’s hand trembled as it brushed the side of the bloodied face, fingertips ghosting over skin gone clammy with coolant mist and blood. Too cold. Too still.

“Mydei…”

The word broke in his throat, thin and brittle.

He eased him down, cradling Mydei’s head against his chest. The floor dropped away. The walls seemed to breathe, the air gone thin and sharp as glass. He could barely feel the weight in his arms. Everything felt stretched, too far.

“You’re fine,” Phainon murmured, voice catching. “You’re okay. It’s—it’s nothing.”

It wasn’t a lie.

It was a prayer.

His voice came out high and breathless, a raw insistence, like if he could just string the words together fast enough, reality would remember its shape and obey.

“Hey. C’mon. Look at me. You always—”

A laugh snagged in his throat, brittle as cracked glass. It came out wrong. Too bright. Too sharp.

A faint sound from the figure in his arms—a broken breath that might have been a word.

“…m’sorry.”

Phainon froze.

The world tipped, something cold sinking teeth into his stomach.

“No,” he whispered, breath hitching. His grip tightened. “No, you don’t—you don’t get to say that. You don’t—fuck—you’re fine. We’ll leave. We’ll —”

The presence behind him arrived like a tide.

Not stealth.

Not subtlety.

The kind of dread you felt in your bones before you even heard them move.

The Council enforcers fanned out across the catwalk and floor, armored boots ringing against metal, the dull thrum of kinetic induction charges humming at his back—weapons primed, safeties off.

One of them spoke.

“Hold position. That’s him. Engage.”

Another breathless half-second.

And Phainon’s mind broke open.

A laugh slipped from him.

Soft at first.

A fractured, unmoored thing.

Then another, louder, bleeding out between his teeth like something sharp.

The sound didn’t belong in the room.

It didn’t belong anywhere.

The enforcers faltered. A ripple of hesitation through them, armor sensors flickering against some invisible pressure spike. Even through visors and synaptic dampeners, something primal in them recoiled.

And then it happened.

Not clean.

Not like an overcharged amplifier popping its buffer.

The air *fractured.*

Light stuttered.

The walls around him blurred, textures doubling, then peeling apart.

Phainon’s hair kept flickering between white-gold like a glitch, threads of gold spiderwebbing through the veins beneath his skin. His irises caught the failing emergency lights, burning molten amber one heartbeat, normal blue the next.

The pressure in the room surged.

A low, bone-deep hum vibrated through the walls, rattling teeth and glass. You didn’t hear it so much as feel it in the roots of your teeth, in the back of

your skull.

The nearest enforcer staggered, one hand going to his helmet.

“Get out. Disengage—*the man is a lunatic!*”

Machinery buckled.

A coolant conduit burst overhead, vapor hissing down in thick fog.

Floodlights cracked, the glass breaking in long, languid arcs as though gravity had to be reminded to finish the job.

Phainon didn’t know what he was doing.

Blood slipped from his nose, from his ear, a thin line down his throat.

He didn’t feel it.

The floor beneath his boots warped—not metaphorically. The *metal flexed.* A concave ripple moved out in a perfect ring from his feet. Golden shards shimmered in the air, fragments of resonance unbound from their logical moorings, hanging like the splinters of a shattered star.

The enforcers backed up.

But too late.

Phainon’s laugh broke again—louder this time, serrated at the edges.

And the collapse came.

His body seized, resonance surging outward in a cascade of concentric waves. Not light. Not heat. The boundaries of space and matter folded like wet paper, walls bending inward, catwalks shuddering, alloy pylons twisting as if they remembered they were never meant to hold this kind of force.

The resonance imploded, then detonated in a pulse so violent the shockwave kicked half the enforcers off their feet.

Sirens blared.

Not the usual incursion protocols.

The system lights shifted from red to a cold, sterile white.

A new warning replaced the alarms.

[CLASS ONE BREACH DETECTED]
[BLACK TIDE EVENT PROBABILITY: 72%—EVACUATE IMMEDIATELY]

The walls wept condensation as the temperature dropped.

The floor panels liquefied, then re-solidified.

Somewhere high above, a structural support failed, the screech of metal shearing under strain echoing through the dark.

Phainon barely registered it.

His vision blurred, faces melting to shapes, colors bleeding into one another.

The ring in his fist dug so deep into his palm the skin split, blood mixing with the golden resonance still clawing at the air around him.

He knelt there, one hand still tangled in Mydei's hair, the other clenched tight, as the world came undone.

And for the first time in years—maybe ever —

He had no control over his abilities.

Phainon's lips moved soundlessly, cracked, mouthing the same words over and over.

“I’m sorry. I’m sorry. I’m sorry.”

A mantra, a prayer, a death rattle in disguise.

Then—footsteps.

Not one pair.

Many.

From the far corridor, the enforcers poured in, their resonance dampeners slung across their backs, pulse ordnance primed. They moved in formation—rigid, tens.

“Hold formation. Target unstable,” the squad leader barked, visor down. “Deploy containment on my mark—”

He didn’t finish.

The first field flared up—a mesh of light and spatial anchors snapping into place around Phainon.

It buckled in less than a second.

The space around him *ate it,* the energy net twisting, folding back on itself like a living thing curling from fire. The projection whined, tore apart in a burst of white-gold static, leaving nothing but scorched air in its wake.

“What the fuck is wrong with—”

Another containment net fired. Same result.

A third.

Space itself seemed to ripple with disdain.

Then one of them—desperate or catastrophically foolish—edged closer, trying to flank, hoping for the lucky shot.

The resonance didn’t strike him. It didn’t need to.

A single tendril of that flickering light—thin as a vein, sharp as a filament—*brushed* the man’s chest.

He locked up mid-step. His scream rose but never left his throat. His veins went dark, then gold, then black, fat strands spiderwebbing under his skin like roots burrowing through rotting wood.

His eyes burst first. Then his skull caved in from the pressure building behind it, helmet splitting like fruit under a press.

Blood. Grey matter. A soft, wet explosion against the wall.

The body dropped, nerves still twitching.

Phainon didn’t react.

Didn’t even blink.

He clutched Mydei tighter, murmuring to no one, words unraveling into cracked, half-formed sounds.

More enforcers hesitated. Some started backing up.

The pressure in the room rose, a deep, concussive weight that pressed into lungs and made breathing a conscious effort.

Sirens shifted again.

[EMERGENCY BREACH IMMINENT—BLACK TIDE ESCALATION PROTOCOL ENGAGED]

System-wide. Not a facility alarm. Not a sector alert.

The whole city.

That was when the dying began in earnest.

One enforcer’s helmet visor spiderwebbed from the inside, the man clawing at his throat as his organs liquefied mid-sentence. His scream turned into a bubbling gurgle as his chest caved in.

Another staggered back, convulsing as blood burst from his ears, his brain tissue boiling inside his skull. He dropped, limbs twitching like severed cords.

The others lost formation.

Someone yelled for retreat.

And it wouldn’t have mattered.

The walls bent inward, catwalks shrieking, steel pylons warping. A coolant line burst, showering the chamber in mist so cold it flash-froze blood mid-air into crystalline droplets.

Phainon’s abilities lashed out without aim or mercy. Tendrils cracked the floor like glass, split a man’s torso clean through, his upper half peeling away from his waist in a neat, bloodless instant before the spray hit.

It was less a fight and more a massacre.

And then—

A flicker.

Behind the enforcers.

Not a displacement boom.

Just a distortion.

Like heat shimmer on asphalt, the air *rippled*. A fragmentary, sickening lurch in the space behind the last remaining soldier.

The squad leader spun, trying to catch it.

Too late.

A sharp, brutal crack split the air.

An old, ugly sound.

A bullet through bone.

The leader’s head snapped back, a plume of blood fountaining from the exit wound. He collapsed in a heap.

“Contact, behind—”

Another shot. Skull. Gone.

A third. Through the heart.

A fourth. The base of the spine.

Each shot surgical. Unhurried. Cold.

The enforcers broke, stumbling in blind terror now, some collapsing, others trying to scream commands the air didn’t seem to carry.

Phainon barely noticed.

His breathing rattled in his throat, golden light seeping from his eyes, his nose, from the hairline fractures webbing across his skin. His vision blurred, everything smeared, golden-blue-red.

The air buckled again.

And through it stepped a figure.

The distortion *resisted* him, the shimmering wall of sickened air reluctant to let him through. The man emerged, smoke still curling off the sleeves of his longcoat, a battered sidearm steady in his grip.

Anaxa.

The prototype phase-slip device flickered at his hip, still smoldering. The kind of tech you don’t use inside a unstable collapse zone unless you’ve given up on coming back whole.

And yet, here he was.

Anaxa sighed.

“Of all the places to spike,” he muttered. “Had to pick the one wired for full-detection response.”

Phainon’s power lashed toward him. Tendrils sharp enough to split steel.

And stopped.

Mid-air.

A shudder.

A flicker.

Like recognition.

Anaxa took another step forward. Then another.

“Easy,” he murmured. His voice wasn’t soothing. It was the kind you used with cornered animals and dying friends. “It’s me.”

Phainon clutched Mydei tighter, shivering, his eyes caught somewhere between hatred and plea.

His voice shredded the air.

“Stay… stay back.”

But Anaxa didn’t stop.

Glass crunched underfoot. Bone. Metal.

The dying field snarled around him, rippling, hissing against his skin, but it didn’t touch him.

He knelt.

One slow, careful motion. Not reaching. Just lowering himself beside Phainon.

He glanced down at the bloodied, ruined thing in Phainon’s arms. The shattered mask. The skin gone pale.

And Anaxa’s jaw clenched.

A breath. A shake of his head, small, broken.

“I’m sorry.”

He moved fast.

Suppressant injector in hand, pressed against Phainon’s throat. A single, brutal push of the plunger.

Phainon spasmed. The light in his eyes flared, cracked, and then —

the world tilted.

Phainon convulsed instantly, a sound torn from his throat so raw it barely resembled a scream—more a ragged, broken noise scraped from the back of his lungs. Pain spiked white-hot from the point of injection, radiating out in jagged, shuddering waves that clawed through his nerves and ignited every frayed thread of his unraveling signature.

His body fought it, violently, lashing cracking out like wild, blood-edged lightning, fracturing the air in sharp, erratic bursts. The room buckled again, tendrils warping into existence and then snapping apart as the suppressant tore through him.

For a sickening second it felt as though his bones would rupture, splitting apart from the inside out, pressure building so fast his vision went blood-

black at the edges. His fingers clenched tighter around Mydei's limp form as if bracing for the moment his own body gave out.

Anaxa's hand came down, pinning him by the shoulder.

"Stay down. Let it take."

Phainon thrashed, muscles seizing in relentless spasms. His vision smeared gold and blue, blood seeping into his eyes. Every breath dragged itself through him like glass, his ribs shuddering with the effort of keeping his heart from tearing itself apart. The suppressant didn't numb the agony—it gnawed its way deeper, latching onto the last flickers of his spiral and tearing them loose one by one.

The threads stuttered. Broke.

One by one, those razor-edged tendrils dimmed.

The flickering edges of unreality around him began to smooth, the impossible fractures in space retreating like receding tidewater, leaving shattered debris and silence in their wake.

Golden shards of dead light fell from the air, brittle as glass. They struck the floor with a strange, crystalline clatter, like fragments of bone. The oppressive pressure in the room slackened in aching increments, but it never fully left.

And then nothing remained but the hollow rasp of Phainon's own ragged breathing.

He sagged forward, every part of him shaking, still clutching Mydei's body as if he could force it back together with sheer will. The blood on his skin glimmered faintly before dulling, tears in his flesh sealing themselves with sluggish, flickering effort. His body tried to recover. It didn't succeed.

Anaxa moved immediately, catching him before he collapsed completely. He hooked an arm around Phainon's torso, steadying him.

“You’re alright. I’ve got you.” His voice was stripped bare of softness but still solid. A tether.

Phainon clung to it like a drowning man, fingers fisting into Anaxa’s sleeve, blood-slick and desperate.

Neither of them moved for what felt like an eternity.

Somewhere beyond the breached walls, the wail of sirens began to rise again—a new chorus. Not just the Council’s systems now. Different tones. Higher frequencies. Citywide emergency signatures. Strike-force mobilizations.

They were coming.

Phainon barely noticed at first, too lost in the suffocating weight of his own breathing, the too-sharp ache of his pulse hammering behind his eyes.

Anaxa heard them.

And he snorted, a dry sound.

“I’m shocked the Heirs haven’t landed on your head yet. Guess they’re slipping.”

It should’ve been a joke.

It wasn’t.

Phainon’s stomach twisted, nausea and panic clawing at the base of his throat. The edges of his vision swam. His voice broke, thin and frayed.

“Don’t.”

A whisper, no weight to it.

“Don’t. Don’t do this. Anaxa, don’t—”

Anaxa didn’t respond. His jaw set, something flickering behind his eyes too tired to be anger, too resigned to be grief.

Phainon’s hand shot out, fingers seizing a fistful of his coat, slipping against blood and sweat-slick fabric.

“I can’t—” the words came in a breathless, splintered rush, raw with panic and grief, his throat already wrecked but the words tearing their way free anyway. “I can’t do this without you, don’t leave me here, I’ll fix it, I swear to god I’ll fix it, just—just don’t—”

A sharp shake of the head.

Anaxa’s expression softened in that terrible, exhausted way that felt worse than anger.

“I can’t hold this place, Phainon.”

Quiet. Final.

“You’ve gotta go.”

“No—”

Phainon’s voice broke into something too ugly to be a word.

Anaxa exhaled, a thread of dry, humorless sound, and pulled a battered, half-cracked device from his coat. The last portable foldpoint unit. It shimmered faintly, edges scorched, the casing dented from the jump that brought him here.

“One tether left.” His lips twitched in something almost like a smile. “Didn’t even think. Ran straight in. That’s not me, you know.”

Phainon’s chest caved in around the ache, heart hammering so loud the sirens became little more than distant, meaningless noise.

Anaxa’s grip on the phase tether tightened.

“Find Hysilens when you’re back.”

A beat.

And then, quieter.

“One chance, boy. Take it.”

Phainon barely had time to choke out a sound before Anaxa pressed the foldpoint against his chest, locked eyes with him for one last heartbeat, and slammed the activator home.

The world ruptured around him.

White-hot light. A sickening scream of gravity folding in on itself. The sense of every molecule in his body tearing loose, shredded by unstable space —

and then nothing.

By the time he realized he was still alive, it was because his body struck the floor.

Hard.

The impact sent a fresh wave of pain through his side, sharp enough to catch behind his ribs and stay there, blooming outward in dull, steady pulses. He lay where he landed, half-curled in a patch of his own blood, though the sluggish warmth of it barely registered against skin gone cold.

The suppressant still clung to his nerves like frostbite, numbing him at the edges and leaving only the worst of it—the ache in his chest, the faint tremor in his hands, the hollowed-out space where his resonance used to be. His fingers twitched once, a weak, uncoordinated spasm. No strength behind it.

He couldn’t move.

Couldn’t lift his head.

Could barely manage a shallow breath without everything threatening to seize again.

The world spun slowly overhead, lightstrips smearing into dull streaks against a ceiling he didn’t recognize at first. The air was cold, not sterile, not antiseptic like the Council clinics, but sharp with stabilizers and the faint metallic ozone bite of heavy shielding.

It took him minutes to focus, for the haze to thin enough to piece together where he was.

One of Anaxa’s labs.

Not one of the public ones, or even the deniable safehouses scattered across the city grid. This was deeper than that.

Unlisted. Untraceable. Wiped from every Chrysos archive, Council registry, and surveillance loop alike.

And of course—of course Anaxa had pre-encoded the tether to land him here. It was the kind of contingency he built into everything, always assuming the worst because it usually found them in the end.

Phainon knew the dull gray of the walls, the precise hum of the shielding field overhead. He remembered this place now, though he wished he didn’t.

A faint, rasping breath scraped out of him. It might’ve been a laugh, if there’d been anything left in him to carry it.

But there wasn’t.

He tried to move, and his body revolted. His legs wouldn’t move. His hands wouldn’t tighten. Even the simple act of breathing felt precarious, sharp threads of pain catching with every shallow rise of his chest.

Darkness tugged at the edges of his awareness, a slow, inevitable pull. His vision blurred, the cold creeping deeper, though whether from blood loss,

shock, or suppression, he couldn’t tell anymore.

He wasn’t going to stay conscious much longer.

Still—he tried.

Tried to push up from the floor, to force himself onto his hands, though his arms gave out halfway and left him slumped. His vision swam. The world tilted.

No.

Not yet.

Not—

But the black kept coming, cold and relentless, pulling him under one breath at a time.

And as the dark closed in, smothering the last shreds of strength and clarity, a single thought surfaced, splintered and desperate, a half-formed thing clawing at the inside of his skull.

Did I lose them both?

The words echoed, and then the dark took him.

Chapter End Notes

> Alright, I didn’t actually have time to properly beta read this before posting, so if you guys spot any mistakes or weird phrasing, feel free to yell at me nicely. I appreciate the heads up.
>
> Also, I’m gonna take a short break from writing on this fic for a bit. I wanna focus on a couple of my other longfics and a 20k one-shot or two I’ve been meaning to plan out. Hope that’s alright with you guys. It’s not gonna be a month-long vanishing act or anything (hopefully, probably not), but honestly these chapters, ESPECIALLY for this fic since it’s so plot-heavy and sci-fi dense, take a lot of brainpower.

Which is fine! Love the lore. But doing them back to back kind of kills the joy and whimsy after a while. 😭 (For context my goal for 3.4 is to get to 18 chapters and fully finish the thing in one go in 3.5, or earlier actually)

And before I forget, just putting it out there, but yes, that whole Council body transfer thing was actually planned out and for Anaxa and Mydei's body/for Phainon's crash out. I realize I probably didn't imply that nearly well enough in the chapter and I really didn't wanna delay it any longer for revisions, so… hope at least some of you picked up on it. Sorry if it was vague.

Anyway this was slightly rushed but still, thanks for reading, as always! You guys are the best

(Unrelated by anyone wanna try and guess Phainon's backstory ?)

Chapter 16: Groundhog Day But It’s a Crime Against God

Chapter Summary

> Mydei takes a relaxing nap, wakes up inside a memory blender, gets emotionally body-slammed by Caenis, forgets what’s real, remembers too much, almost becomes a USB stick, and then gets forcibly yeeted out of a tank by a feral academic with bad timing and worse aim. Alarms happen. So do feelings. Also, ontology does a thing.

Chapter Notes

> I promise next chapter is gonna be less tech/sci-fi heavy, brace with it a bit longer please

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first sensation was warmth—

—but not the kind that consoled. It was dense and unmoving, like the breathless air sealed inside a jar just before the oxygen thins.

He drifted, neither standing nor falling. Suspended in a place without edges. No ceiling, no floor, no orientation—only a vast, humming dark threaded through with veins of silver light, shifting like water disturbed by distant sound.

Mydei floated upright, his spine bowed slightly, arms bent at the elbow as though he had been caught mid-drowning. The pulse of the space moved with a rhythm not his own, pressing in on all sides.

There had been a lab here once.

Or something like one.

Steel consoles hung in the void, disconnected from structure or logic. Tubes drifted like dying tendrils, coiling and uncoiling with no purpose. Everything shimmered faintly, warped and half-dissolved, as if submerged for too long and only now beginning to surface.

Blood had pooled beneath a surgical table—though it didn’t look like blood. It gleamed with a slick, oily sheen, refracting in hues that didn’t belong to this spectrum.

His mother lay motionless on the slab.

Eyes open.

That detail caught. It shouldn’t have.

Her lips moved, slow and deliberate, though no sound emerged—until it did.

ᓀᒥᐁᑐ…

Reversed syllables. Her voice played backward, each consonant cracked open and hollowed.

Mydei tried to move. His fingers remained inert.

Tried to speak—but there was no breath to push sound forward.

He could only watch her jaw unhinge further. Wider. Still wider. Far beyond the limits of anatomy.

A tremor passed through her skin. Not a movement, but a glitch—her features flickering, distorting, as though corrupted from within.

Then, pressing against her cheekbone, something familiar began to surface —another face, his own—

He blinked.

Gone.

LOG: *Fragment stabilized at 00:03:22.89*
CONDITION: *Cortical recursion pattern detected*
STATE: *Reintegrating memory unit…*

⟲

He saw faces—shattered and incomplete. Flickering across his vision like reflections across water. The dead ones. Other candidates.

Each expression frozen in the final instant, that irreversible moment when comprehension eclipsed fear: they had been used.

A high-frequency shriek rolled overhead, splitting thought from presence. Not noise—language. Eurypon's voice without phonetics. He couldn't parse the words, only the tone, and even that carried weight like doctrine:

Pain. Progress. Purpose.

The memory buckled. A new one slammed into place, seamless and far too sharp.

A voice cut through the dark—

"Mydei."

Phainon.

He turned toward the sound, though the movement felt delayed, as if the idea of turning had arrived before the impulse. The voice was colder than it should have been.

Something was wrong.

Even here, something was trying to rewrite him.

He stepped forward—and the world shifted sideways, not like walking, but like dragging a memory across its grain.

The lab folded in response. Furniture collapsed inward. Consoles rotated, their insides hollow and segmented like puppets stripped of skin.

Mydei’s jaw locked tight.

Then—

A door.

Not from his memory. Something else entirely.

And yet, he stepped through.

LOG: *Fragment corrupted. RESTARTING INSTANCE…*

⟲

A house.

The scent reached him first—dust and sunwarmed tile. Light slanted through invisible curtains, golden and slow-moving, touching the air gently.

Here, his body obeyed again.

He moved without effort, and each step along the creaking wood told him this place had been lived in.

Down the corridor, a door opened to light.

He stepped through it.

A woman sat near the window, her hair soft and loose around her shoulders, colored like old sand. She smiled gently, eyes holding a kindness he didn’t remember her ever having.

In her arms, a child.

Swaddled in pale blue, impossibly small.

A man crouched beside them, one hand reaching out to the child, laughing —quietly, reverently—as if the touch itself were a sacrament.

Mydei didn’t breathe. Couldn’t.

He remembered them. Or nearly did.

Mother…?

He inched forward. The woman looked up. The smile remained.

Then—

The baby’s eyes opened. Gold. Not the warm kind.

A crack opened somewhere beneath his awareness.

The room dimmed—only for a moment—and when it returned, the woman’s features had blurred. The man’s eyelids were sewn shut, black thread pulled taut through delicate flesh.

Mydei staggered back.

Then, a voice:

“Continuity is survival.”

He turned. “Where—”

The house had vanished.

> ***REPORT:*** *Memory instability detected in node 004-A*
> ***PROJECT:*** *Khaslana Candidate Sequence*
> ***ROTATION:*** *Loop 6/∞*

⟲

Now: the stabilizer chamber.

Or a version of it—distorted and recursive, replayed so often its structure had begun to thin.

He was already strapped in. The pressure on his wrists was real enough. Steel restraints against bone. Cold metal beneath his spine.

A shadow passed across the ceiling—Eurypon.

“Mydei. You understand what this means, don’t you?”

A hiss followed.

A new figure leaned into view—Gorgo. Her hands fumbled at the interface, her face streaked with panic she rarely showed.

“This isn’t you, Mydei—this isn’t—”

The sentence splintered.

“This isn’t—this isn’t—this—”

Her face fractured.

Phainon looked back at him. Terrified.

Then—again.

Straps. Voice. Hiss.

Loop.

Faster.

The walls began peeling away like wet paper, revealing veins of light beneath—impossible fractals coiling inwards.

He screamed, but the sound did not emerge from his own throat. He was outside himself now. Watching from somewhere wrong.

Was he even here?

Layered voices spiraled upward—

“He burned through the stabilizer—”

“It’s not holding—”

“Another failure—”

“four-nine-six—”

“Gorgo, get clear—”

And then:

“Khaslana.”

It rang like a chime struck inside the skull.

A name. Not his.

But beautiful.

His heart scattered.

He saw a face. No eyes. No voice.

Still, Mydei fought.

Again.

And then—

Light.

Sound.

Snap.

White.

Silence.

LOOP TERMINATED
REINITIALIZING CORE MEMORY SEQUENCE

The breath tore its way out of him.

Air dragged in through the narrow seal of an oxygen mask. Thin streams of it bubbled into the viscous suspension that enveloped his head, curling upward in luminous spirals before fading into the gel. Each breath felt foreign, intruding rather than sustaining.

The silence around him pulsed faintly, a ceaseless hum reverberating through the fluid.

He floated, upright and restrained, within a towering cylinder of reinforced surgical glass. Wires trailed from his forearms. Dull restraints clasped his ankles—not painfully, but denying even the illusion of motion.

At the base of his spine, fixed across the tenth thoracic vertebra, a band of black metal clung to the bone. A stabilizer suppressor—its glow a soft, intermittent amber, like a dying star caught mid-pulse.

Where the fuck am I?

The light filtering into the chamber was cold . A sterile blue-white that flattened every surface into clinical abstraction.

Around the perimeter, instruments gleamed. Scalpels. Resonance forks. Mnemonic splitters. Many of them had already been used.

On the far wall, a neural tuning fork flickered—shifting erratically between harmonic patterns. It emitted no audible sound, but something in the way it stuttered made his skin tense, as if it were broadcasting through the thin layer between thought and sense.

He tilted his eyes upward, barely.

Screens hovered in the gel above him. Vital signs. Neurological scans. A haze of data. But one line caught him.

[Ontology Stability: 73%]

His throat moved against the mask. The sensation lodged in his chest like a swallowed shard.

He could feel his limbs, but he couldn’t move.

He was conscious—entirely. And trapped inside that awareness, unable to act on it.

The cold that filled him didn’t come from the gel. It rose from within.

He narrowed his eyes. The muscles obeyed, slightly. He shut them.

Don’t panic.

He pulled himself inward, memory, stacked. Recall through discipline. Find the last fixed thing.

Containment—he had broken it.

Hyacine had helped him. That much was true.

He had been injured, yes, but he had moved. He had been in the clear. Ahead of the Council. Focused.

There had been a lead—something hidden, masked, encrypted. An underground gathering. The masquerade. He remembered moving through coded doors, into something theatrical.

He remembered pursuit. That sensation was strongest—his body angled forward, lungs burning, every step tethered to urgency.

He was chasing someone.

There had been motion—fast. A blur in front of him. Echoes along marble corridors.

Panting.

And—white hair.

Yes.

White hair, glinting through smoke and masklight.

His thoughts caught.

Something was wrong.

There should have been a face, or name. But that part was missing.

He frowned.

There had been pursuit, but the details dissolved when he reached for them.

A sound—quick. A breath behind him. Then pain.

Something sharp had struck him, fast and deep, right in his back.

And then—

Phainon.

Fuck.

Every part of him reacted. His back arched violently, the stabilizer igniting in a sputtering flare of gold that danced through the fluid. Bubbles burst upward. His limbs strained against their bindings—trembling, convulsing.

A growl clawed its way through his throat, malformed around the mask.

“Where—”

He slammed forward, shoulder-first, shoving as far as the field would let him. The impact reverberated through the glass. Instruments blinked in response. One of the overhead sensors flashed red.

He twisted again. This time harder. The bindings groaned, resisting. The suppressor struck back—a pulse of heat down his spine, white and spiked, shattering his vision with light fractures.

Still, he didn't stop.

"Where is he—?"

Another heave. His ankle pulled, the restraint straining. A warning chime activated. The pain was cataclysmic. His nervous system lit up, buckled, snapped taut like a bridge under siege.

He slumped slightly. But even now, with his breath ragged and shallow against the filter, he was not defeated. Something inside him refusing to yield.

And then—

A sound.

Clapping.

Once, slowly.

Footsteps followed. Unhurried. Metal against metal, a rhythm so composed it felt performative.

He hadn't seen them yet. But they were already here.

The breath caught again in his chest—

but not from panic.

Not this time.

Then she stepped into view.

She was immaculately composed. Tailored gloves, coat sealed with a muted clasp at the collar, every line of fabric architectural. Her hair framed her face with clinical precision, and yet, it wasn't the details of her appearance that commanded the space. It was her expression—something that hovered just outside empathy. A warmth so distant it read more as memory than emotion.

She offered a smile.

"You've lasted longer than projected," she said. "A few more hours, and the collapse would've finalized. Mind-to-lattice degradation isn't linear—but it does reach a tipping point."

Her voice was gentle. That unsettled him more than anything.

"We've learned to be careful. The difference between dissolution and integration is smaller than it looks from the outside."

She walked with calmly towards him.

Caenis stopped a few paces away from the tank, folding her hands. Her eyes moved across his face, tracing subtle changes in the way he observed her.

"Metaphysical resilience is a strange phenomenon," she murmured. "Even now, your mind insists Gorgo reached you. That containment failed. That they'd escaped. That someone else struck you from behind."

A slight glance upward, casual but exacting—

"White hair, right? And then silence."

The shift in Mydei was not visible, but it echoed through the room.

Caenis tilted her head.

"He reached you, didn't he?"

The words didn’t sound like a question.

And something snapped.

The response surged upward. His spine arched against the field, the gel fracturing with heat where the suppressor flared gold. Bubbles burst upward from his shoulders, trailing like smoke. His wrists shuddered against the restraints, fingers twitching with submerged tension.

Pain arrived late, but it had no leverage. His chest rose again, and through the mask, shaped by sheer will:

“What are you doing.”

Because this was beyond being incredibly illegal.

The Council had no authority over the Heirs. Not in this context. Their mandate extended only to experimental oversight and fringe-zone containment. They were auxiliary, not sovereign. For them to act against a living Chrysos heir wasn’t misconduct.

It was rebellion.

Suicide.

Caenis smiled again, ever so slightly.

“Authority expands in the absence of witnesses,” she replied. “You’d be amazed what becomes permissible when entire clearance divisions are convinced they’re observing protocol. It takes only one redefinition—one procedural eclipse.”

She walked a slow half-circle around the tank.

“But your classification wasn’t the reason. What you are to the Chrysos meant access. What you are to him made the risk necessary.”

That word carried weight. Not just him—*to* him.

Mydei stared through the gel, breath sharp against the mask.

His next words were carved out with venom, low and steady as a current of voltage beneath polished stone.

“What do you know.”

Caenis paused near a side console. Her fingers touched the edge without looking.

“After your collapse, we detected a cascade across five surveillance nodes. At first, we assumed a breach. Internal sabotage. But the signal disruption wasn’t targeted. It was ambient. There was too much pressure on the interface—almost like a short.”

Her hands moved with fluid control across the panel. A faint glow rose.

“A rupture, they called it. But it wasn’t spontaneous. Something responded.”

The screen projected a blurred fragment of surveillance footage—grainy, refracted through low-tier filtration.

The corridor warped under stress. Walls folded like paper caught in fire.

At the center of the distortion, something half-visible—shaped like a person, but refracted around the edges, defined more by absence than presence.

Blue heat coiled around gold. Sirens curled in the distance.

Mydei recognized the posture before the image stabilized.

Not entirely human.

Not anymore.

His fingers closed reflexively, restrained by the field.

Caenis didn’t look at him.

“We had been preparing for something like this,” she said. “Those cameras were designed to capture event-horizons during early-stage Tide encroachment. Built to witness inside the hollows without malfunction.”

She paused.

“Rare tech. Difficult to justify. Even harder to authorize. But sometimes, intuition is a better guide than nothing.”

She let the implication settle.

This hadn’t been an accident. They had planned for Phainon’s emergence. Prepared to catch it. Observe it.

Expect it.

The weight of it crashed through Mydei’s chest.

He should have died. He remembered the strike. The exact vector. The way it had pierced the graft. The moment sensation ceased.

But he had been pulled back.

How?

Why?

Caenis stood near the tank again, the glow of the recording flickering across her coat.

“When the footage leaked, the internal response was predictable. Panic. Damage control. The Flame Reaver was a criminal yes— but something dramatized and elusive in most people’s eyes. But there he was. Not some shadow weapon. Not a vigilante’s asset.”

She gestured toward the image.

“A debates professor with impeccable attendance and a favorite chalk pen.”

The corners of her mouth lifted slightly. But the humor never reached her eyes.

“And then he broke through the stabilizer net. Burned the lattice architecture itself. Physically. The instruments still carry trace corrosion. Entire corridors collapsed before the system could interpret the data.”

Her voice narrowed.

“He didn’t act in defense, he acted because you were gone. Quite the romantic gesture, no?”

Mydei’s breath sharpened.

The words dug deep. They didn’t illuminate something new—they confirmed what he had already begun to suspect. But the confirmation hit harder than the hypothesis.

Caenis stepped closer.

“You didn’t die,” she said. “You adapted. In a way, you’re both survivors.”

Her gaze didn’t waver.

“One burned through the lattice.”

She leaned forward, hand touching the glass.

“The other became it.”

He scoffed.

The sound cut cleanly through the room.

Caenis arched a brow at the noise. “Ah. Impatience. Good. That means the trance hasn’t fully taken hold yet.”

Then her smile curved.

“His reaction, after your little death spiral, was extraordinary.”

Mydei glared.

“The incident triggered a Tier-1 Tide protocol lockdown. Seven precincts sealed. Eighty-two forced evacuations. Sixteen paranormal trauma ruptures across three districts—all traced back to a single source. Not the Tide. But something close enough to fool the alarm systems.”

Her voice softened.

“One boy. Grieving.”

She made no effort to disguise the implication.

“The sensors flagged identity shear, soul-field instability, thread signatures… the usual hallmarks. But none of them held. The resonance decayed before the alert could lock. There was no event horizon. The waveform was recursive.”

She stepped closer to the tank now, head tilted in careful study.

“He didn’t rupture. He mimicked it.”

Still, Mydei said nothing.

“Eurypon’s theory always sounded like hubris to me,” she went on. “Stabilizing identity through an external constant? That a mind could adapt to the structure of entropy itself, not as a counterforce—but through behavioral convergence? Ridiculous.”

She paused.

“And yet. Your little friend responded with what can only be described as an emergent echo with no external triggers.”

A silence passed, slick and sickly.

“He imitated the Black Tide reflexively, sown to the waveform. Ever wonder how?”

The words settled.

But Mydei’s reaction didn’t arrive right away. It didn’t flare. It built. Quietly. Like pressure under a sealed valve. He blinked once, slow. His mouth opened slightly, then stopped. As if waiting for some internal confirmation he hadn’t yet allowed himself to believe.

Caenis smiled thinly.

“Your tether wasn’t engineered. It formed itself.”

And then it clicked.

He blinked again, harder this time. The breath that came afterward wasn’t sharp—but slow. Hollowed out.

“You—”

The rest snagged in his throat.

“You tested on him before.”

Caenis didn’t blink.

“We test on all of them,” she said. “But he required particular effort.”

she continued.

“And if he never told you, then I suppose you weren’t quite as special to him as you thought.”

That one hit. More than it should have.

She took a step around the tank.

“Don’t feel bad. Secrets are the scaffolding of survival, Mydei. If you’d told him everything you are, everything you came from—would he have stayed?”

His chest lifted, then fell again, too evenly.

She studied the line of his spine, his restraint posture, the tension around the mask seal.

She turned her back as if already bored.

“Do you even know where we are?”

Still no answer.

Her smile curved faintly. “Of course not. You’re perceptive, but not omniscient.”

He lifted his head slightly—barely enough to glare. “I assumed it was a trash site,” he said. “But the smell is worse than I thought.”

Caenis’s brow twitched. Almost imperceptibly.

He continued, voice calm, cutting.

“Let me guess. You begged the Council to fund your pet experiments and settled for a derelict fallout zone. Or did you barter for this place with whatever scraps of credibility you had left?”

She clicked her tongue.

“Aedes Elysiae,” she said, voice cool.

The name fell into the chamber like sediment from an opened wound.

Mydei stilled.

The name drifted like rot from a sealed file—half-familiar, almost forgotten. He remembered a faint redacted smear on an old crisis report.

Aedes Elysiae. A minor village. Off-grid. Low-density. No military assets, no geopolitical leverage. Not even worth the term ‘strategic.’

Except…

Except it had been the site of the first confirmed Black Tide breach.

His stomach turned.

“Birthplace of Subject NeiKos496,” Caenis said. “I believe you knew him by another name.”

His chest tightened.

“He tried to change it before as well,” she continued, as if recalling a minor annoyance. “Khaslana. That was the word he chose. I believe it mattered to him. A personal mythology, perhaps. Something poetic.”

She tilted her head.

“No one used it.”

She chuckled fondly.

“He got very upset about it. For a while, he refused to answer to anything. That was a bit inconvenient during testing, so we had to reinforce name-response drills. Conditioning’s hard when your subject doesn’t want to be anyone at all.”

A pause.

“I imagine that’s why he chose ‘Phainon’ in the end. A clean break. All that precious dignity. All that myth-making.”

She watched Mydei carefully.

“But you know what he never learned to be?”

She clicks her tongue.

“Useful.”

Mydei inhaled—and that was when the shift occurred.

His words came quietly.

“Your mouth soils him.”

She ignored him, watching the readout blink above him. 91% Ontological Stability. Still high. Still lucid. But starting to tilt.

“I’m *saying* he was built for secrecy. We ran thousands of simulations on null-born subjects—individuals whose profiles were erased in early formation. Birth records gone. Lineage disrupted. Nothing to hold them in place. Clean slate candidates.”

A pause. Then:

“Pliable.”

Her gaze drifted to the data screen again, serene as a physician.

“And through it all, he never told you it seems. Yes?”

Her voice dipped lower.

“Not even a hint.”

She leaned closer.

“So the question is: was he protecting you by staying quiet—”

A breath.

“—or protecting the lie?”

The edges of Mydei’s vision shimmered faintly.

“Do you know how many times he failed integration before we got anything remotely usable?”

A soft sigh—deliberate annoyance.

“Most of his errors stemmed from clinging. He insisted on remembering his mother’s face.”

She added offhandedly—

“We corrected that. Several times.”

He clenched his teeth.

“He learned quickly to become whatever kept him from being discarded. That sort of flexibility mimics loyalty quite well, don’t you think?”

She studies Mydei.

“Of course he isn’t above lying. It’s more so instinct rather than deception. That boy would counterfeit sincerity just to simulate connection.”

A slight smile.

It worked. You trusted him.”

Then, gently.

“But tell me—how would you tell the difference?”

The readout blinked. 86%. 82%.

The oxygen hissed louder now. Or maybe his breathing had shifted. It was hard to tell.

“He was compliant,” she said. “It’s what made him useful.”

The static crept inward.

And then—unbidden—a whisper laced itself into the corners of Mydei's mind, it almost felt prodding.

What else didn't he say?

What else did he fabricate?

Images surfaced behind his eyes—uninvited. Phainon again, haloed not in light but in static. His mouth moved, but the words were strange now. Too polished. As if he'd said them before.

Every breath was too measured to be spontaneous.

Not false. Just… practiced.

Not distant. But oddly impersonal.

Mydei's chest pulled tight. It wasn't a lie. But what if it hadn't been truth, either? What if the feelings had been molded—shapeable, repeatable? What if all of it had?

He blinked.

Phainon didn't.

For one moment, those eyes failed to follow. They didn't mirror him. Didn't sync. As if the link between them had decayed—or never existed.

Hadn't something always been missing?

He didn't—

He didn't—

The thought fractured.

Mydei slammed his head forward.

The crack echoed through the fluid. A smear of blood bloomed across the inner dome.

He gasped.

Not from pain.

From clarity.

The trance shattered instantly. Whatever chemical spiral had been triggered, it collapsed on contact with the raw jolt of self-inflicted violence. The room roared back into focus.

And with it: rage.

Caenis turned sharply, eyes narrowing.

“You’re not immune to suggestion,” she said coldly. “That was a calibrated dose—”

“Then calibrate it better,” he said, voice jagged and wet with heat.

Her mouth parted. Just barely.

“No witch this time?”

He laughed. No joy in it.

“Don’t flatter yourself.”

He leaned forward, blood still streaking his temple, mask fogged.

“You’re not a witch. Witches had power. You’re a glorified clerk with a scalpel and a god complex—carving people open just to feel taller.”

The flicker in her expression was slight—but it was real.

He smiled faintly.

“The Tide doesn’t pretend to be merciful.” he said. “You do. That’s the difference.”

Caenis stepped back, too measured to flinch.

But her knuckles had gone white.

“What a shame,” she murmured.

The blood inside the tank curled into slow spirals, delicate as smoke. It spread in thin, copper-red ribbons, drifting toward the filtration vents like ink drawn to paper.

Caenis watched it bloom.

Only after the pattern began to fade did she speak:

“If we wanted you for regeneration protocols, the harvest would’ve started at the base of the spine.”

She didn’t wait for a reaction.

“The lungs come first. If you flood the thoracic cavity with saline and keep the spinal sheath pressurized, they stay viable for almost nine minutes. Marrow’s more temperamental. You have to drain the vertebrae individually, and even then the yield degrades on contact with air. But the glands—”

Her gaze lifted, almost absently.

“The glands only require paralysis.”

Mydei didn’t respond. But something in him coiled tight, instinctive and recoiling.

She was still watching him.

“Of course, none of that applies if the subject’s conscious,” she added. “It disrupts the sequence. Throws off the time-to-failure. They thrash too

much.”

His fingers twitched inside the restraint shell. Barely perceptible.

Mydei laughed.

Caenis’s eyes narrowed.

“That,” he said, “is how I know you’re lying.”

The corner of her mouth twitched—but not enough to read.

“You couldn’t replicate a fever spike, let alone immortality. Don’t tell me you thought I hadn’t noticed. The regeneration files you stole from Eurypon? Half the schematics weren’t even his. He never wrote them down.”

He tilted his head slightly, a smear of blood sliding along his temple, carried in slow arcs by the suspension fluid. It traced a line toward his jaw, fine and almost ceremonial, like war paint caught mid-dissolve.

“He didn’t trust you.”

Her posture tightened.

“You think me incapable?” she asked.

“Not incapable. Just limited.”

He continued.

“You needed someone you couldn’t out-think. That’s why I’m here.”

She said nothing.

“But it’s not just me, is it,” he added.

“You and that… anomaly,” she began—too lightly.

“Phainon,” he said, correcting her with surgical coldness.

He was ignored.

She pivoted toward the tank again, almost idly. “You sound like your father,” she said. “Shall I remind you of his theories?”

“No need. You’re gonna talk about the Initiative, right?”

Caenis paused.

“Filed under Tide hazard modeling,” Mydei continued. “Presented to the Council as an early warning architecture. Nothing but a lie.”

The fluid hissed around him,.

“In practice, it was a salvage doctrine. A last-ditch effort to secure identity in contamination zones where memory dissolves and continuity rots from the inside out.”

He turned toward her.

“It promised permanence. Stability against the Black Tide. A version of the self that could endure.”

His mouth hardened.

“What you built was a machine that fed on living minds.”

She didn’t move.

“You weren’t modeling infection, you were accelerating it. You created synthetic collapse states to test whether a soul could hold its shape after being flayed apart.”

Caenis’s hands remained steady at her sides. But her eyes had begun to narrow.

“They weren’t volunteers,” he said. “You selected them systemically. Orphans. People no one would search for.”

He exhaled.

“Thirty-three subjects.”

She still didn’t respond.

He went on anyway.

“They didn’t fail,” he said. “They matched your parameters. They showed continuity. They held.”

A beat.

“Just long enough for you to watch their bodies reject the illusion. Long enough to hear them scream as their sense of self unraveled. You measured the sound patterns.”

He paused.

“And then you recorded how long it took for them to stop.”

Silence gathered like soot in the corners of the room.

“You were never trying to survive the Tide,”

“You wanted to master it.”

Caenis stood still for several breaths.

Then she stepped forward—unhurried, composed.

But something had changed. Her expression was more considered now. She studied him the way one might study an unsolved proof—dispassionate, but undeniably invested.

“You’re still alive.”

She said it without triumph.

He didn’t reply.

“You,” she said again, a shade more softly. “You, out of all of them.”

She didn’t emphasize the word, but it hung there anyway.

“You endured what none of them could. The boundary rupture. The integration cycles. The recursive drift. You didn’t fracture. You stayed.”

There was no reverence in her tone.

There was something colder.

Ownership.

“Thirty-three collapsed,” she said. “But the thirty-fourth subject?”

She stepped closer.

“The thirty-fourth proved it could be done.”

She tilted her head.

“You were never meant to die, Mydei. You were designed to stabilize.”

Her voice had dipped lower now—almost intimate. The tone one might use to praise a student, or a blade finally tempered after countless failures.

“Everything you endured wasn’t a cost, itwas confirmation. Your suffering produced results. You became *proof*.”

She smiled faintly.

“And that’s why you matter. That’s why I kept you.”

She waited.

His breath came slow, steady. His expression didn’t shift.

Only his eyes moved.

He watched her in total silence,

When he spoke, he looked at her as if she was repulsive.

“You think dressing it up in admiration makes it alright?”

Caenis didn’t blink.

He leaned forward slightly.

“You built a theology around violation and called it science,” he said.

Her mouth parted slightly.

Mydei stared at her, and this time, there was nothing left in his expression but calm disgust.

“You crowned trauma like it was a prize. That doesn’t make me grateful.”

His voice lowered.

“It makes you repulsive.”

Caenis remained still.

Mydei didn’t clarify. He didn’t soften the edge. Let her sit with it.

But he wasn’t here to vent fury. Fury accomplished nothing.

He was at a disadvantage.

He was submerged in a controlled system. Restrained. Studied from angles he couldn’t track. If he fractured the surface too early, he’d lose whatever leverage lay below it.

So he let the disgust settle. Allowed it to cool beneath the skin.

His next words emerged quietly—absent ornament, almost incidental.

“Eurypon thought so too, didn’t he.”

It wasn’t phrased as an accusation.

But it struck like one.

Caenis’s gaze shifted to him. Narrowed. She didn’t speak right away, and when she did, the smile from earlier was gone—replaced by something thinner.

Eventually, she answered with a faint shrug.

“He thought a great many things.”

“He never gave you the raw data.”

Mydei’s voice had steadied into something measured. Curious, even.

“Not even when threatened.”

She didn’t dispute it.

“And you hated him for that.”

This time, she exhaled—half scoff, half sigh. She tilted her head slightly, like someone amused by an unexpected move.

“You remember what your father did to reach that point?”

The word *father* was placed with intent.

Mydei didn’t react visibly.

But something flared in his jaw—tight, then gone. He didn’t rise to the bait.

“Yes,” he said simply.

It told her what she needed to hear: that he remembered. That he wasn’t afraid of the remembering. That the memory, in his hands, can be wilder like a blade.

Caenis watched him for a moment longer. Then—almost absently—she moved across the lab to a recessed bench hidden in the curvature of the wall. She pressed her hand to the panel. The structure slid outward.

She sat with the ease of someone returning to a familiar position of power. One leg crossed over the other. Perfect balance.

“Well then,” she said.

There was nothing casual about her tone. It was calm, yes—but threaded with tension.

“Let’s hear it.”

Not permission—*provocation*.

She was opening the floor. But not to listen. To evaluate.

Mydei met her gaze.

Something flared behind his eyes—but he supposed it.

If this was a game, he’d play it better than she expected.

And he wouldn’t bluff.

“I remember,” he said, “that he was a theorist. Decorated. Brilliant. He specialized in bio-temporal mechanics, identity continuity, neural architecture.”

A breath passed. His gaze stayed unfocused.

“He was respected. Normal, once.”

He paused.

“Then came the first Black Tide breach.”

He didn’t dress it up.

“That was the break. He lost most of his colleagues and students. Half of them had been at his house the week before. He unfortunately lived.”

He glanced at Caenis then—nothing warm in it.

“And he decided that wasn’t enough.”

“He shifted everything to Tide research. His theory was… unique during his time to say the least. Believed if you could tether identity—anchor it to something fixed, external, constant—then the Tide couldn’t erode it. Thought, continuity, presence… all sealed against collapse.”

Mydei sighed.

“He started building stabilizers. Crude at first. Mechanical grafts. Memory locks. Devices meant to keep the dissociation from starting.”

Now, he looked directly at her.

“He worked with participants. At first.”

A pause.

“Later, he accepted other subjects. People the Council could vanish without paperwork. Political undesirables. Transit ghosts. Entirely off-record.”

The air between them held the words for a long moment.

Then, almost conversationally:

“Am I tracking so far?”

Caenis didn’t smile. That, in itself, was confirmation.

He exhaled once through his nose before continuing.

“As the breaches worsened, so did his methods. He moved into resonance manipulations. Direct psychic latticework. Procedures designed to bind identity inside a conceptual feedback loop—create a synthetic ‘proof-of-self.’”

He hesitated.

“They worked. Briefly. But extended exposure to destabilized field environments started… stripping him.”

Mydei’s voice lowered.

“Erosion at first. He wasn’t immune to the Tide’s corruption. And eventually, he stopped trying to resist the Tide.”

His gaze turned hard.

“He started trying to outlast it. And that’s when the Council stepped in.”

He didn’t need to name the obvious.

“The Initiative was born from that pivot. They saw opportunity—containment, operational continuity, maybe even immortality. Operatives so deeply grafted into lattices, they couldn’t defect. Couldn’t disobey.”

His voice cooled further.

“They made him the architect, running over thirty human trials. Stabilizer failures. Cognitive fractures. Identity degradation. Subjects lost speech. Lost memory. Some became unresponsive. Others turned on themselves.”

Finally:

“One survived.”

Caenis’s eyes glinted.

She waited—then asked, mildly, “Is that the version you were given?”

Mydei turned his head toward her. His eyes narrowed. His voice stayed level.

“It’s what I remember.”

A soft hum left her lips.

Then, without urgency, she stood.

She walked past the console as if adjusting a lecture slide. Completely at ease.

“Your mother,” she began, “understood too late. By the time she realized what Eurypon had become, there was no salvage.”

Not wrong exactly.

“She couldn’t run far with you. The breach had already started. The lattice was mid-calibration. So she did the only thing she could.”

A slow breath.

“She forced a sync.”

Mydei’s shoulders tensed—just slightly.

“She reached for you, while the resonance field collapsed, and while continuum fractured.”

Caenis’s voice softened, but not with sympathy.

“She never made it out. The wave tore her apart. But the instinct—the reach—was enough. That final imprint held you in place just long enough for the lattice to finish binding.”

Silence.

Mydei’s throat moved once. No words followed.

“And Eurypon?” he asked, though the answer he already knew.

Caenis exhaled, light as fog.

“Unclear. He may have destabilized. You may have lashed out. The lattice was incomplete, the breach uncontrolled. Who knows?”

She shrugged it off.

“It doesn’t matter. When the Chrysos Heirs arrived, they found a dead theorist. A ruptured stabilizer core. And a child, still alive, surrounded by blood over Eurypon’s corpse, with every lattice node stabilized.”

She stepped closer.

“Your mother’s final memory created the anchor. That single moment became your tether. And your body did the rest. High conceptual resistance. Bio-temporal fusion at T10 vertebra. That’s where your lattice lives. That’s what keeps you coherent.”

She tilted her head.

“But if it breaks—if the nexus fails—your memory degrades. Your regeneration stops. And your body forgets how to continue existing.”

A pause.

“You would dissolve. Just like the others.”

Mydei stared at her.

Caenis moved one step closer, almost rapturous now.

“Don’t you see?” she said, voice nearly dazed. “The solution was never physical continuity.”

Her pupils widened.

“The solution is memory.”

A hush fell.

He blinked hard. Once. Twice.

The dream. The house. The baby.

Shit.

If what she’s saying was true, then that hadn’t been a dream.

Or not entirely.

He inhaled sharply, the restraints creaking as his body reacted faster than his thoughts. If that’s true, then he’d *cycled* there. Each loop a forced tether. The dream-state hadn’t *preceded* this moment—it had *shaped* it.

But—

If memory was the anchor, if the mechanism was built to stabilize him—

Why manipulate it?

The contradiction snagged him.

He jerked violently against the restraints. The steel groaned under the sudden torque, but it didn’t give. He wasn’t trying to escape anyway.

“What,” he rasped, “are you doing to me?”

Caenis glanced at him.

“Such a sharp question.” She mused. “But really, Mydei—if I explained the entire project, where’s the fun in that?”

But something in her expression betrayed her. She was circling something she wanted him to understand. Her eyes were almost expectant.

“Although… I suppose a few details couldn’t hurt. Not that you’ll be able to tell anyone afterward.”

She tilted her head thoughtfully. “NeiKos496 is wild. Brilliant, but unstable. Every time he taps into his potential, he fractures. Burns like a ruptured battery pack, really.”

A short pause.

“Unlike him, you’re permanent,” she murmured. “You hold.”

Mydei’s confusion simmered just beneath his anger.

Permanence?

Then then the next words dropped.

“I’m building the first true Eternal Operative. A living archive. One that can’t break under transfer or stress.”

He stared at her blankly.

Caenis sighed before speaking bluntly.

“I’m going to use your body,” she added plainly, “to store the stolen abilities of every Chrysos Heir we can harvest.”

It didn’t land all at once. He took a second to process it and then—

Then came the cold rush of comprehension, sharp and acidic, crawling inward from his chest.

What?

That wasn’t just grotesque. That wasn’t possible. She was talking about converting living people—*his people*—into data. Into parts.

“That’s not how it works,” he said, voice incredulous. “That’s not even coherent—”

“Oh, it isn’t.” Her smile widened. “But the Council’s never been interested in playing fair with coherence.”

Mydei stared at her, blank. Unmoving. Then slowly, he shook his head.

“You’re talking about *Tribbie*. About *Trianne*. Trinnon. Hyacine. Castorice. Aglaea—” His voice was still stuck in disbelief. “You’re going to kill them.”

She said nothing. She didn’t *need* to. His mind was already taking over.

He didn’t mean to think it. It was ridiculous. Hell, *Impossible*. But he still couldn’t help imagine the younger ones first.

He pictured the Tribios in a chamber like this one. Their bodies slumped together, small limbs overlapping. Holding each other because that’s how they’d always survived.

Then thought of Aglaea. Steady, brilliant Aglaea. He imagined her falling forward with her threads dulled, eyes closed for the final time, no one there to catch her.

His stomach churned. His vision blurred.

“You think I’m going to *let* you do that?” His voice was shaking. With rage. With disbelief.

“You can’t even stabilize *one* harvested tether. That’s what the constructs failed for, isn’t it? They collapsed. They dissolved. You don’t even know how to hold a conceptual profile intact—”

“That’s why I need *you*,” Caenis said calmly, already moving back toward the datapad. “You’re the constant. Everything else can be mapped onto you like architecture. We remove the instability. No independent cognition. No identity rupture. Just replication.”

The world was splitting in half around him. Her words had crossed from horror into something *stupid*. Delirious. A philosophical category error pretending to be strategy.

“You want to graft entire identities into me? Turn me into some—some grotesque vessel of the people I love—”

“Not them,” she interrupted. “Just their *capabilities*. Their conceptual *functions*. Their gifts.”

He wanted to throw up.

“Do you even *hear* yourself?”

She didn’t answer.

And then—casually, like a second knife into the wound:

“We’ll start with the ones easiest to contain. But the real deal comes when we get a hold of your boyfriend.”

The breath left his lungs in a single, brutal exhale. His entire body convulsed against the bindings.

“You’re not touching him.”

She didn’t look up.

“We’ve made arrangements.”

The air thinned. His chest locked. He couldn’t tell if the sound in his ears was the hum of the datapad or his own pulse accelerating.

“You’re going to try to harm him for something you don’t even properly understand,” he said, low. “And use me to do it.”

“That’s the beauty,” she murmured, eyes flicking over calibration data. “I don’t *have* to understand. I only need it to work.”

He didn’t respond. Not immediately. Because there weren’t words for what this was—not in any language he remembered.

All the while she was smiling through it.

“You don’t get to use him.” His voice was no longer shaking. It had fallen into something cold and angry. “You don’t get to touch *any* of them.”

She turned her head slightly. Not enough to meet his eyes.

“Says who?”

Mydei didn’t freeze this time.

He lunged—hard, brutal, enough to make the collar pulse red-hot and the entire brace groan under the force. The restraints crushed into his shoulders as he strained forward, spitting each word with open, venomous hatred.

“If you go near them—if you lay one fucking hand on them—I’ll gut you down to the marrow and make you choke on what’s left.”

His voice was shredded, half-raw from rage, half-torn from panic. But the meaning landed sharp.

“They’re mine. Every single one of them. You think I’ll let you experiment on the Tribios? Aglaea? Hyacine? Just for you to build your next fucking science fair?”

He didn’t care that he was trapped. He didn’t care that his ribs ached from the strain. The words kept coming, rage burning straight through every nerve in his body.

“You leech-ridden butcher. You’re not a damn genius, you’re a grave robber. You tear things apart and gamble everyone’s lives on some half-assed theory for *what*?”

Caenis said nothing at first, but something in her jaw locked tighter.

“You don’t deserve the title of researcher,” Mydei went on. “You’re a state-sanctioned scavenger with a lab coat and way too much arrogance. You’re a mistake with clearance.”

“You won’t even get near Phainon,” he growled. “He’s survived more than anything your empty little programs could simulate, and if you so much as

breathe in his direction, I'll bury you in the ruins of this fucking facility."

The silence that followed was dense, stretched taut by the sheer weight of it.

Then Caenis exhaled. Quick. Clipped.

A ping from her wristband cut clean through the moment. She tilted her head slightly and tapped a few commands. When she spoke, it wasn't even directed at him.

"We finally took care of the Blasphemer as well," she said, more to herself than anyone else. "Seems he's ready to trade. Offered the Reaver's coordinates."

She let that hang.

Mydei didn't respond.

Not right away.

His chest was still rising hard, the force of his breathing more strain than rhythm. Something inside him felt peeled raw.

"I don't care what deal you think you've made," he said, voice low. "You don't touch my people."

Caenis turned her head slightly, then walked to the panel beside him.

"You think I haven't heard that before?" she murmured. "That line dies with everyone who says it."

She keyed in a sequence without hesitation. The clamps around his arms hissed, realigning. A secondary chamber rotated from beneath the panel, releasing a soft, mechanical whine. Something surgical clicked into place.

Mydei felt it before he saw it.

The pressure changed.

His body recognized it first—an instinctive lurch, a pull of muscle and nerve warning him that something had breached the threshold.

When Caenis picked up the injector, his muscles convulsed. Hard. He thrashed against the restraints with everything he had left, tendons screaming.

“Try whatever you want,” she said, flat. “The interface is already keyed.”

She pressed the injector to the base of his neck.

He didn’t scream.

He choked.

The burn was instant. Not fire. A deeper invasion—something threading directly into the signal structure of his mind. His breath caught like it was yanked out of sequence. His back arched. His legs twitched against the reinforced clasps.

He tried to speak and only coughed. Tried to breathe and his lungs locked.

His teeth ground against each other. He didn’t know if the noise in his ears was machinery or something internal—like static had grown teeth and was chewing through his thoughts.

His fingertips went numb from how hard he was gripping air.

He could feel it.

Something coiling.

Taking space.

If he slipped—if he let go of even one part of himself—the thing pressing in would swallow whatever he left behind.

And Caenis was already halfway to the door.

No glance back.

Her datapad flickered faintly in her hand—still active. Still pinging with location markers.

Still hunting Phainon.

That was the last thing Mydei saw.

The pain surged once, then—

Everything cut.

Not a blackout.

An erasure.

Like someone had taken a scalpel and peeled him away from the edge of waking thought.

And then there was nothing.

INSTANCE ID: 496–Δ
STATUS: Feedback instability rising
SUGGESTED ACTION: Extend loop perimeter
CYCLE COUNT: [REDACTED]
LOOP STATE: Localized
SUBJECT RESPONSE: Erratic

⟲

He sat on the edge of the bed.

Sunlight poured in, angled just so through a half-lowered blind. The warmth in the room didn’t comfort—it settled like a second skin. Dust drifted through the slanted light in slow motion, glittering faintly.

The static from the screen whispered like breath over snow.

The kettle was already warming. The stove gave off that faint metal-humming sound, the one he remembered from childhood.

There was a drawing on the table.

It was unfinished, but familiar. The kind Phainon would sketch when he was restless, sharp lines crossing over themselves again and again like a broken circuit pretending to be a face. couldn’t look at it for long.

Phainon moved behind him.

“Mydei,” he said yawning, like he’d said it every morning, “you left the window open again.”

Mydei didn’t remember doing that. But the apology came anyway. His voice slid out of him without thought.

“Sorry.”

“I closed it,” Phainon said.

Then he sat beside him. His shoulder pressed into Mydei’s—solid, real.

Warm.

Mydei froze.

Something stung behind his eyes.

He didn’t know why yet. But he remembered this, didn’t he? This apartment, this light, this exact—

⟲

He sat on the edge of the bed.

The same dust. The same smell of something beginning to burn.

The static again. Still whispering.

“Mydei,” said Phainon, at the window, “you left it open again.”

The words slotted perfectly into place.

He turned, slowly.

Phainon smiled at him—no, not smiled. Just looked. Looked like someone with skin.

But his face blurred for a moment. Like poor reception. Like a copied file overwriting itself and then flicking back.

Mydei blinked hard.

Phainon was normal again. But when Mydei looked down, his fingers were clasped too tightly in his lap. A dull ache bloomed in his knuckles.

He glanced toward the stove. The kettle hissed.

But he couldn’t remember putting water in it.

Phainon turned from the window. Walked closer.

“Mydei.”

His voice was warm. Too warm.

Like breath against a wound.

Then the chair was gone.

He stood in a hallway. No sound. Just stillness so thick it bent the air.

There were doors on both sides—identical. Dozens. Maybe hundreds. The walls sloped inward like a narrow gorge. Almost claustrophobic, like the whole place had been carved into a mountainside and forgotten.

He touched a door.

The nameplate read:

MYDEI—ONTOLOGY OF NEIKOS496

He opened it.

A child sat at a desk, back turned. Pencil to paper. Drawing.

The hand holding the pencil was twisted backward. Bone jutted like a snapped branch. Still, the pencil scraped. The graphite dragged across carbon paper in a way that sounded too close, like someone was carving the inside of his skull.

He backed away.

Turned.

All the doors were gone.

He was alone in the corridor.

No footsteps, but he heard running. Somewhere ahead—or behind?

He ran.

The hallway didn’t change. The lights above him glitched and reversed, colors swapping in and out like a memory being rendered upside down.

His own footsteps fell out of sync.

He blinked—and was back in the apartment.

⟲

This time, he was already seated. Already staring at the flickering screen.

The sketch on the table had changed.

It looked like his body—sprawled in a chair, something branching from the base of his skull. The lines twitched faintly, like they were trying to finish drawing themselves.

Phainon stood beside the screen. His back turned.

Mydei didn’t speak.

He didn’t move.

He knew what was coming.

Phainon turned.

And for a second—just one—it wasn’t Phainon.

It was him.

His face. Staring back at him.

He stepped back from the table. Hit the chair with his knee. It scraped against the tile. The sound distorted.

“—Mydei,” Phainon said. But the voice warped, pitched too low, dragged through static.

Mydei reached for the kettle. Picked it up. Threw it.

It didn’t shatter. It simply phased through the wall.

He tried speak. Nothing came out.

⟲

He was back at the house again.

He was sixteen this time, watching his parents argue about garlic again.

His younger self laughed in the background.

His mother smiled, shoulders relaxed.

His father reached across the table, touched her wrist.

Mydei stood in the doorway, silent.

The boy at the table turned and looked at him.

Stared too long. Too directly.

Then the skin beneath his eyes fractured—like ice beginning to crack.

He smiled.

Mydei turned to run.

⟲

There was no running.

He was in the chair again. Strapped down.

He screamed until his throat tore—but the scream layered, echoed, distorted. A second voice twisted inside it.

Not Caenis.

Not his.

A failure protocol.

A synthetic playback looped through the air:

—MEMORY-ANCHORING FAILED—
CONCEPTUAL REINTEGRATION UNSTABLE

The room began collapsing sideways.

Not breaking, more so folding as the angles bent inwards.

Symbols crawled across the walls—half-born glyphs that pulsed and jittered. Names tried to write themselves but devolved into numbers. His name flickered between letters and designations:

MYDEI. 496. MYDEI. 496. MYDEI. 4—

He screamed again.

This time, it cut through.

It fractured something.

But the loop kept going.

⟲

He couldn’t take it.

He couldn’t breathe.

And he knew—somewhere in his gut—that if he kept letting this go on, it would never end.

He stared at the sketch on the table. The one with the spinal cord drawn wrong.

He reached for it.

Tore it in half.

The graphite screamed when it split.

The apartment flickered—one frame at a time.

He moved like something dislocated. His body wasn’t his anymore. His legs broke and reformed mid-step. His fingers split and reknit.

He staggered to the wall and slammed his head into it.

Hard.

Once.

Twice.

A third time—

It clicked.

Everything stuttered.

The entire room blinked, like a frame was missing.

Phainon turned again—his face mid-flicker—half-Mydei, half-blank.

The sketch on the table burst into flame without burning.

He lunged for the wall again, his hands trembling violently now. His skin no longer felt like his own. His fingertips twitched in strange, recursive patterns, like they were repeating commands he hadn't given. Every movement dragged behind itself, as though the loop was trying to rerender his body in place.

His breath snagged. Something beneath his skin had started to pulse out of rhythm.

He needed to hurry.

His hand snapped upward, almost without meaning to.

And he clawed hard into his neck.

Fingernails tore past skin, deeper, until hot blood spilled over his collarbones and sprayed across the room in jagged arcs. It struck the walls, the floor, the unfinished sketch—blotting it all with sharp, living color.

And then—

It broke.

The color left.

The light tore sideways.

Reality peeled like wet paper.

Mydei was falling—no, *exiting*.

Flung out of the memory like shrapnel ejected from a closed system.

There was no resolution. No message.

Only the rupture.

And the sense that something *watched* him leave.

He gasped awake.

The breath tore through him like he hadn’t taken one in hours. His spine snapped inward, then arched again, shoulders crashing against the wall behind him with sickening speed.

Every nerve in his body fired at once.

The tank stirred.

The gel spun in violent spirals around his limbs, a dense current trying to pull him back under. Everything blurred—white, red, gray. Flashing. Collapsing.

He couldn’t find the rhythm of his own movement.

He thrashed. Hard. Once. Then again. Muscles convulsed without sequence. His arms struck the curve of the tank, missed, rebounded. His legs kicked as

if someone else controlled them.

The oxygen mask sealed tight across his face, hissing with each mechanical breath—but he clawed at it like it was suffocating him. His fingers caught beneath the straps, bent at awkward angles, ripped upward with too much force. Tubing snapped.

Warm gel rushed into his mouth.

He gagged. Choked. Air never came.

The gurgle caught in his throat, reshaped itself into foam.

His jaw opened too wide. He slammed against the glass again, shoulder-first. The pain didn't register right. It felt distant, like it was happening somewhere behind his skin.

His vision stuttered. The glass surface warped his reflection until it shattered—split in layers like cross-sectioned film. His own limbs stretched unnaturally, smeared with distortion, one arm flickering between positions like the tank couldn't decide where to render him.

The lights above fractured into kaleidoscopic spirals.

His pulse crashed against his ears.

He needed out. Needed to move faster. Harder. Past the containment. Past the memory still rotting under his skin. He launched forward again—hands curling into fists, striking the wall with everything he had.

The first impact bled.

The second cracked something—bone or glass, he couldn't tell.

Thin clouds of red drifted outward through the gel, blooming like ink across paper.

The pressure in his skull climbed.

He jerked backward and twisted, trying to find any seam in the tank’s curve, anything that could be pulled open, pried loose, broken. His nails scraped across his forearms now, digging beneath old scar lines, beneath sensor ports and embedded node sites. If there was a thread, a boundary, an edge to any of this—he would tear it out.

The tank groaned.

Alarms ignited above.

At first, they didn’t register. Just noise layered over noise. Then they broke through.

[Containment breach. Subject destabilizing. Emergency override engaged.]

The warnings weren’t his.

They came from further away.

The alert tone pulsed outward—repeating through concrete, rebounding off long corridors he couldn’t see.

Another noise followed.

Sharper.

One gunshot.

Short. Controlled. Close.

The sound hit him through the floor like a blunt weapon. His hands flailed outward in suprise, fingers leaving thin trails of red across the inner wall. His eyes bulged open—half-seeing, fully registering—and for a moment, the tank felt like it had shrunk in on him.

The gel thickened.

It dragged into his throat like a second tongue, coating the back of his palate with a taste that didn’t belong in the body. Something synthetic.

He jerked, hard—lungs contracting around it, reflex overriding instinct. His chest seized as he coughed it back up, only to inhale more. Every breath doubled the weight inside him. Pressure locked his ribs from the inside out.

He kicked off the tank wall, limbs spasming in all directions.

The seal had broken, but the air hadn’t reached him. His head snapped back involuntarily. His throat locked again. He clawed upward on nothing, hands scraping the inner curve of the tank with a desperation too deep to contain.

His body convulsed once. Then again—harder.

He couldn’t hold on to where he was. Panic detonated inside him, not like a thought but like a seizure.

Then—

Gunfire again.

Close.

Everything inside him froze.

Another shot—closer still.

Then the door shattered inward in a flood of smoke and steel, blown off the hinges with deliberate, surgical force.

A second shockwave tore through the room. Cracks bloomed across the front of the tank like ice fracturing on impact.

Something struck the glass—hard.

Then again. Then—

CRACK.

The structural seam ruptured.

Glass ruptured inward. Pressure folded. Stabilizer gel exploded in a tidal burst, dragging his body with it. He hit the tile hard enough to knock the sound out of his skull.

Air hit him like a weapon.

It burned into his skin and throat, colder than anything he could remember. He twisted to one side, heaving. A torrent of gel poured from his mouth, from his lungs, from everywhere it shouldn't have gone. He didn't cough so much as tear himself apart trying to breathe. Fluid splashed across the floor. He retched again. And again. Muscles locked mid-spasm.

Alarms screamed overhead.

Red light poured down in pulses that didn't line up. His vision collapsed in waves. The world bled sideways. His fingers slipped across the floor, trying to find a grip, but everything beneath him had turned to chemical runoff and blood.

Then—footsteps.

His head snapped up, slow and lurching.

A figure moved through the chaos—green hair soaked, shirt torn wide open from a rib wound that hadn't stopped bleeding. Gun still smoking at his side. Movements sharp, but loose in a way that didn't feel human. Someone who hadn't just survived a gunfight. Someone who had walked through it.

Mydei blinked hard.

It took a full second for the face to resolve.

Phainon's professor friend.

Anaxa.

He looked like something feral and divine at the same time. Burned halfway to hell, then dragged back for the encore. One eye slightly wider than the other, like a madman.

He didn’t say anything at first.

Just stood there. Breathing. Taking stock.

Then he looked down at Mydei.

“Right,” he said flatly. “That’s enough dying for one day.”

He didn’t wait for permission.

Crossed to the nearest wall console, ignoring the flickering lights and blistered insulation. His hands moved with deliberate rhythm, overriding manual locks, bypassing biometric protocols, tripping circuits like he’d rewired the place himself on a bet.

Static curled through the air with each bypassed fail-safe.

Mydei coughed violently, trying to speak.

Only fragments escaped. A hoarse, wet rasp. “You…?”

“Would love to catch up,” Anaxa said, not looking. “But I just shot three people and blew a door off its hinges with a rigged stabilizer battery, so let’s hold the sentiment until we’re out of arm’s reach from the next security drone.”

Another lock cracked. Another hiss of pressure failed behind the wall.

Mydei’s body still wasn’t listening. Arms shaking. Legs twitching out of rhythm. He tried to brace himself upright. Failed.

Anaxa glanced over.

One swift movement—he crouched, grabbed Mydei by the arm, hauled him half-upright in a single, graceless pull. Mydei’s weight hit his shoulder.

Anaxa flinched, but didn’t drop him.

“You weigh like a dying ox,” he muttered.

Mydei choked back another cough. “What are you doing?”

“Not dying,” Anaxa said. “And neither are you.”

He adjusted his stance, got one of Mydei’s arms around his shoulders, and started dragging him toward the hallway, half-limp, half-upright.

“I know you don’t trust me. That’s fine. You can interrogate me later. Right now, all I need from you is one thing.”

Mydei didn’t answer. Didn’t resist, either. His legs scraped across tile, trying to keep up.

“Stay conscious,” Anaxa said. “Don’t blackout on me. If you do, I’ll leave you. That’s not a bluff. I’m not carrying you through two kilometers of corridor just to get shot by your lab friends.”

They reached the open threshold.

The alarms had changed tone again.

“Shit,” Anaxa muttered. “That’s going to be a problem.”

He adjusted Mydei’s weight, leaned him more solidly against his own side.

“We’re looking for a cat,” he said, more to himself than anyone else.

Mydei’s head rolled toward him.

His brain didn’t know what to do with that.

“…What?”

Anaxa didn’t clarify. He didn’t need to. Whatever he was doing, it had already begun hours ago.

“Later,” he said. “You’re not going to believe me yet.”

He looked at Mydei fully for the first time.

Expression still sharp. Tired. Unreadable.

“You in or out?”

Mydei’s breath hitched. Blood still trailed from one nostril. His body screamed in every direction.

But his eyes stayed open.

Beat.

“…I’m in.”

They disappeared down the corridor, alarms shrieking behind them.

On the shattered console, a single readout blinked once—then stabilized.

ONTOLOGY STABILITY: 99% → 100%

Chapter End Notes

> 2AM again so I’m going to sleep obviously, but lowkey I kind of find it funny Mydei calls Phainon’s hometown a trash site indirectly😭
>
> Edit: oh yeah I think that whole situation with the guest comments is resolved so I’m gonna turn it back on

Chapter 17: Girlbossing the Apocalypse

Chapter Summary

> Phainon, despite actively hemorrhaging, treks into the world's most unlivable HOA to meet a violin-playing war criminal. Several hallucinations, one childhood trauma loop, and a casual ear bleed later, he leaves with a deal, a headache, and a mermaid (Siren?) business partner. Also, Goldweaver's invited. Against his will.

Chapter Notes

> Gosh, wish me luck in posting chapter 18 before 3.5 drops. On the bright side though, next chapter we're going back to our roots with comedy (and it's gonna be the reunion chapter too!!) so be prepared for Mydei, Anaxa, and a special guest's shenanigans :)
> (I think it's pretty obvious who tho😭)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

[Zarq Neon District—Repurposed Mechbay M-77]

The coolant leak marked time the way clocks did.

Not loud. Not fast. Just consistent. One drop, then two. A short pause. Then again.

The puddle beneath it had spread wide across the cracked concrete floor, its surface smeared with oil and dull neon. Pink. Blue. Green. Each color bent as it passed through the water, crawling over rusted panels and the bent scaffold bolted to the rear wall.

A man hung from it. Not limp. But close.

His legs buckled slightly at the knees. His breathing rattled through a throat bruised to plum. Steel cord wrapped under both arms, biting deep enough to

leave bone impressions where the skin had worn thin. One hand twitched against the restraints, a reflex that had no fight left in it.

The mechbay still smelled like it’s old original purpose—hydraulics, solvent, scorched wiring—but something else had taken over. Rotted cloth, dried blood, and copper-rich damp.

Phainon didn’t speak right away.

He moved through the flooded garage with steady steps, boots sending faint ripples across the surface. One arm grazed a decommissioned servo claw hanging from the ceiling, its housing peeled open like a cracked rib. The wind outside gave the broken paneling just enough voice to rattle like breath caught in a damaged throat.

Mirel, or maybe Mirin—that had been the name. He couldn’t remember. The man had worked logistics under ECHO/OBELISK, long before they shuttered the Tide program. Not military, but closer than most. One of the ones who’d kept the paperwork moving. Routes. Transit approval. Clearance for deep stabilization zones.

And clearance for her. Hysilens.

A slight sound escaped the man’s mouth. Half cough, half choked laugh.

“She’s gone,” he muttered. “You’re late by a decade.”

He coughed again, deeper this time, and shifted his weight like it might help. His face was swollen on one side, jaw offset. Blood soaked into the collar of his coat and darkened the fabric down the ribs.

“You think she’d leave a trail? She wiped herself off the Earth.”

Phainon crouched beside him, not close enough to speak into his ear, but close enough that the man flinched anyway.

“You don’t need coordinates,” the man said. “You know that already. You’re just hoping something slipped through. A file. A pulse reading. Something.”

The corner of his mouth twitched. “There wasn’t.”

Phainon reached up and turned the man’s head, fingers light but steady, adjusting his gaze until it met his own.

“I don’t care about the files,” he said.

His hand stayed there, thumb under the cheekbone. The man tried to keep his eye steady. For a moment, it worked.

“You think she’d let herself be tracked? Hell, that she *wants* to be found?” Another bitter laugh. “No one survives that long without going insane. She was already cracking before we sent her in. They wanted to see how far the Tide would take someone. And she showed them.”

A silence passed.

“She flooded the site,” the man said. “Collapsed the entry point and bled the perimeter loop into open recursion. Nothing worked after that. Comms, mapping, scans—dead zones. She turned the whole region into noise.”

His breath hitched again. Slower now. Voice wearing down. “They called it a failure and locked it up. Some coastal subsector. C9. I heard they posted a perimeter, then stopped sending teams. One of the old observatories stayed active—barely. Still caught some residual Tide noise. But no one checked.”

His head fell forward slightly.

“You want a name? Find the archivist who stayed behind. He kept the old logs. Maybe he knows where the drift started.”

He closed his eyes.

Outside, the neon sign buzzed louder. Something in the power grid surged, then dimmed.

Phainon stood.

His coat brushed the scaffold. Water dripped from the hem and vanished into the growing puddle below.

A hand pressed to the side of the man’s head. The other locked under his jaw. Smooth movement, practiced. A short shift in leverage.

The sound came sharp and final.

The man’s body jerked, then stilled. His head lolled at an unnatural angle, eyes glassy and locked upward. His mouth stayed slightly open, lips frozen around the breath that never finished leaving.

Phainon held him there for a moment.

Then he let go and stepped back.

The garage creaked. Wind passed through a cracked overhead vent, carrying the distant sounds of sirens and static. Outside, the “CLOSED” sign flickered, then held steady in red.

The room settled again.

Only the dripping stayed.

The rain didn’t sting at first.

It started like any other—thin sheets slipping down the steel towers, harmless enough. But twenty minutes in, it changed. A faint chemical trace coated the droplets, like aerosolized stabilizer. The burn didn’t cut skin, but it left behind a subtle, plastic itch—like antiseptic that never quite dried.

They called it atmospheric conditioning. A byproduct of the district’s entertainment zoning. Not dangerous, just uncomfortable. Simulated hazard. Keeps the adrenaline high and the cameras running.

Phainon vaulted from a leaning antenna platform to a floodlit rooftop, landing hard with bent knees. The metal underfoot groaned but held. The paneling had been installed as part of a thrill tourism initiative—marketed

as “immersive instability.” Cheap stainless under polymer coating, designed to wobble but never collapse.

Tourists hated it. Residence ignored it. He preferred it that way.

The Verge had been built fast—five years of nonstop vertical development with zoning overrides passed under emergency economic incentives. Towers meant for luxury arcades were repurposed into housing halfway through construction. Security nodes were copy-pasted from older districts without adapting to the new architecture. The result? A sector with layered dead zones and spatial blind spots baked into its foundation.

No one knew where anything actually was, not even the grid. That made it dangerous.

And perfect.

Phainon adjusted his coat and broke into a jog.

He crossed an exposed catwalk with no guardrails, then dropped down into a maintenance alley between two overheating vent columns. Above, a billboard cycled through implant upgrade offers no one could afford—lines of code flickering behind the commercial overlay like it had forgotten which version it was meant to run.

The Verge worked in his favor. Conceptual powers didn’t function cleanly in stable zones; too much internal resistance from infrastructure logic. But here, entropy came built-in. The sector’s metaphysical baseline had degraded to the point where reality warped around its own render errors. No one designed it to fail. It just did.

Every time Phainon used his field—vaulted higher than gravity liked, glitched a camera frame just wide enough to pass unnoticed—it cost him something. Headaches came faster now. Bone-deep strain in his spine. The sense that his body’s inner map didn’t quite match its surface anymore.

Still worth it.

His most effective trick had been diversion. Echoes—Constructs shaped from his profile and seeded across predictable routes. They mimicked thought patterns, energy signatures, movement habits. Not perfect replicas, but enough to convince scanners. He left one behind every few days in former safe zones—just long enough for the Council to triangulate false sightings and the Heirs to send in strike teams.

They'd caught one in Auric Sector last week.

It crumbled under pressure, exactly as designed.

He didn't expect that tactic to last much longer. Echoes degraded too quickly under observation. The more people watched, the more inconsistencies appeared. And once they realized they weren't chasing the real thing, they'd come for the quieter zones next.

That's why he was here now. Not to hide.

To stay ahead of the correction.

Another gap opened ahead—wider this time, between a lightwell and a skybridge. Phainon accelerated and jumped, bending his Conceptual field just enough to tweak the drop. His body shifted mid-air, not lighter, but momentarily less counted by the surrounding logic.

He landed with one hand against a rusted ledge, boots skidding across soaked glass tiles. Stood. Rolled his shoulders until the pop settled the joint.

The rain kept falling, now fizzing slightly against his coat.

He gave himself a moment to breathe.

The city stretched out below. From this height, the Verge looked almost coherent. Blurred neon streaked across rooftops. Drone paths stitched between satellite relays. Steam bloomed upward from broken coolant stacks.

But Phainon didn't see it like that.

He’d split it into three parts to make

It simpler.

Golden Zones—territory under Chrysos control. Clean. Brutal. Regimented. Biometric gates and perimeter mines. The kind of place where a failed entry scan meant a rail round through the chest.

Glass Curtain—Council domains. Full-spectrum surveillance, sterilized transit hubs, crowds engineered to move in synchronized flow. Every step archived. Every breath tracked.

Deadlight Zones—everything else. Places without upkept records. Sub-levels of half-built towers. Transit lines that didn’t appear on the public map. Slums between testing yards. That’s where he stayed. That’s where the Verge was headed. Maybe not fully collapsed yet—but getting there.

The architecture told the story really.

He walked to the edge of the rooftop and looked toward Sector C9. A broadcast tower blinked at irregular intervals—soft red pulses against the skyline. That was his target. The informant had mentioned something about an “impossible structure.” A phrase thrown around too often when the Tide touched something unfortunately.

He didn’t believe the man completely. But he hadn’t had a better lead in weeks.

Phainon tapped two fingers against his coat pocket. The pills inside shifted slightly—synth-regulators from black market caches. They kept his pulse regular enough to keep moving. Sort of. He hadn’t eaten in four days, appetite hadn’t been an issue. The stomach stopped asking after the third blackout.

He felt the push in his limbs. The familiar pressure under the skin when the field wanted to activate on its own.

Not yet.

There’d be time for that soon enough.

For now, he picked up speed and moved again.

He was almost at the ledge when it happened.

Hands steady. Breath held. Weight angled to the metal. He’d scaled worse in worse condition. But his mind was stretched thin—split between the echo trail he’d left stuttering across three districts and the tideweight headache blooming behind his eyes.

A loose bolt turned underfoot. His boot twisted.

He dropped.

He didn’t even have time to curse. Just enough to brace.

The world snapped sideways—scaffold, wall, steel edge—and then gravity slammed into him like a wall. A bone-rattling *thud* as concrete met spine. Pain bloomed sharp and immediate through his ribs. The impact knocked the air out of him in a stuttering hiss.

He rolled, arm shaking as he dragged himself up just enough to sit back against the wall. Wet metal pressed cold through his coat.

He groaned. A low, pained sound. Then stayed where he was. Eyes shut. Waiting for his nervous system to sort itself out.

Somewhere deeper in his awareness, one of his decoys glitched and shimmered, sparking against a surveillance line. He let it falter. Not worth the exertion.

He exhaled again. Slower this time.

God. He needed sleep. Real sleep, the kind where his mind wasn’t crosswired to three active zones just to stay ahead of the Cleaners and Heirs.

He let his head tip back against the wall. Concrete kissed the base of his skull.

Five billion dollars for this?

The thought was dry. Bitter. Almost amused. His ribs hurt. His knee was probably bruised to hell. And his shoulder ached from where it'd hit a bracket on the way down.

This sector helped him stay hidden. The energy density here was fractured, slanted, hard to track. His field blended in.

But gods, was it annoying.

The wall opposite had been layered with years of graffiti. Some old, scrubbed halfway off. Others recent, still raw in color. The newest stood out sharp under the glow of a flickering streetlamp. Red paint, half-dried. The year had been crossed off.

"CLASS OF ████—DEAD BEFORE GRADUATION.
NO REPAIRS. NO JUSTICE. NO FUTURE."

He stared at it.

A beat passed. Then he snorted.

"Ain't that the truth."

His eyes fell shut. Just a second. Enough to let the nausea ease. Enough to not bite his tongue from the pain.

Clank.

The noise cut through the alley like a blade.

Metal on stone. A spray can hit the ground nearby and rolled.

Phainon's eyes snapped open.

Three kids stood ten paces away.

Graffiti still wet on the wall behind them. Bandanas. Spray caps. The light from the paint stencils lit their faces just enough to show every inch of frozen horror.

He blinked. Slow.

Right. Kids lived here.

The smallest one whispered, “Dude, did he just fall from—?”

“How the hell is he not dead?”

The girl narrowed her eyes.

“Wait a damn minute. That’s him. That’s the guy. The one with the bounty.”

The silence collapsed.

“Shit.”

They turned and ran.

Phainon’s teeth clenched. He pushed himself up. The pain tore through his leg like glass—his muscles screamed—but he moved. Fast. Fluid. Dangerous.

He hit the pipe with one hand, angled his weight forward. The first step nearly buckled his knee, but he compensated. He used the wall as a brace, kicked off a half-fallen panel for height.

They were fast.

But he was faster.

He caught the first one mid-turn, clotheslining him lightly across the chest and pulling him down.

The second tripped over exposed wiring just as Phainon reached him—he adjusted his angle and delivered a clean elbow to the side of the head, catching the boy's collar to keep his head from hitting the pavement.

Only the girl was left.

She bolted toward the edge of the alley's open sector.

He closed the gap fast, even limping.

One long reach caught her by the arm. He pulled her weight around in a circle, eased her to the ground with a twist and a downward sweep. Her body slackened. Unconscious. But breathing.

Phainon stayed crouched beside her for a second.

No injuries, luckily.

Three unconscious teens. A chase. A fall. And still—no one came.

No sirens. No intervention. No guards.

Of course not.

Just three kids tagging protest lines in an acid sector. One misstep from potentially being dead, and no one gave a damn.

His jaw locked. A tight, silent burn coiled under his ribs.

Children lived here. In these ruined spines of metal and half-melted walkways. And somehow, the only stability they had came from risking their lives to scream into paint.

This wasn't a city. It should be a damn apology. Badly built. Never honored.

Even the Council—twisted, manipulative, rotten—had sent stabilizer drops here when the Verge first started breaking down. Enough to claim credit. Enough to do *something*. The Chrysos Heirs? They'd ignored this entire

grid. They didn’t come here. Didn’t help. Didn’t care. The government? Even worse.

The construction here was rushed. The terrain never reinforced. Half the underlayers still registered as active sink zones. But the moment complaints surged, the government passed the blame. Let it rot.

Kids still lived here anyway.

He looked back down at them. Quiet. Small. Caught in something they never asked for.

Phainon stood. Limped.

An old canopy jutted out from a sloped corner, its frame bowed but intact. Good enough.

One by one, he dragged the teens there—careful hands steady despite the shaking in his leg. He laid them down under the makeshift cover, shielded from the chemical drizzle falling from above.

When he was sure they were safe, he straightened again. A tremor passed through his thigh. He ground it down.

One of their bags sat open.

He pulled out a simple black face mask. Slipped it on.

His hair was still too pale to hide, but his hood helped. With the coat zipped and his stride steadied, he could pass as anyone. Just another body in the rain.

He didn’t look back.

Didn’t say anything.

He just turned, picked a side route away from the alley, and walked.

No one came to check the noise. No one asked what happened. And above them, the graffiti still bled red down the wall.

The name was almost poetic, if you had the stomach for irony.

Tessera. Tiny shards of colored glass, used to build mosaics—whole images made from ruin.

Locals just called it the Sprawl.

Zone 8A-N, formally. Another vertical coffin welded together during the last Stabilizer Initiative. Urban overflow masked as policy. They'd stacked it high, wired it tight, pumped it full of neuro-ads, then called it progress.

Nobody really used the term anymore.

Phainon moved with purpose—not slow enough to draw attention, not fast enough to trigger suspicion.

The streets were congested with runoff markets and stallfront clinics. Neon signs flickered overhead, half-fused to corrupted code loops—ads for black-market immersion pods, off-brand neural augments, stim-laced protein sticks that boasted military-grade absorption. A vendor barked at a half-sleeping crowd hunched under a tarped awning, waving cyber-cigs and secondhand Tide mods. Someone coughed blood into the curb. The medcart behind him was long dead, its wheels rusted into the pavement.

No one slowed to help. No one had the means.

Phainon didn't look directly, but he noticed the girl squatting beside the vendor, hands blister-red from heat exposure. Not old enough to be alone. Already had that look.

You had to be careful looking lost in the Sprawl.

A low rattle passed overhead—the hollow buzz of a magline runner, rails groaning beneath its weight. Once meant for district transit. Now it ran on

scavenged pulse and bribes. Three more surveillance halos pinged in his periphery. He shifted his gait just enough to throw off any tracking vector, ducking past a stall flanked by scorched chassis rigs. A woman shouted about “Tide shielding for all zones!” and waved a shattered shoulder plate. The insignia on it had been an VIB unit once.

Someone else would’ve stopped to scavenge. He kept moving.

And then—a flicker.

Upper glass, second tower. Left.

He looked up before he could stop himself.

A public holo-display flared to life across the skyscraper’s side. First came the static. Then the red-letter type, punching through city noise.

❝GODSLAYER DEAD? COUNCIL DENIES ALL.**❞**

❝HEIR FACTIONS NAME PHANTOM KILLER—VIGILANTE IDENTIFIED**❞**

He clicked his tongue.

Faster than expected.

Unfortunately it was louder today.

A burst of feed interference made half the plaza speakers whine. The footage stabilized just long enough to cascade into the familiar loop: council-approved anchors in collars, smiling without blinking, their voices flatlined by delay and overcorrection.

The first clips were stills. Damage sites. Melted containment facilities. He knew the images well—they’d been reused since the first leak.

But then the reel snapped sharp.

Grainy. Live-recorded. Stuttering on playback.

His face again.

Pulled from an old university staff registry. Hair short, posture formal. He had a faint smile on his face.

“Have you seen this man?”

The voice didn’t glitch this time. It came crisp and cheery like an automated checkout.

His body didn’t flinch. His mind did.

His hearing fuzzed out—a nice trick he’d learn. Easier to tune out that way.

More screens activated. Different angles. Blurred clips from surveillance cams and helmet feeds. One showed a corridor scorched black at the center—two bodies visible, one kneeling, one collapsed.

He didn’t look.

He caught the flash of movement in a storefront display instead. Another figure had replaced the newscasters.

Goldweaver.

The feed had the Council’s watermark. A sanctioned clip. Which meant it had been cleared before transmission, probably pulled under threat of escalation.

Her face was unreadable. She stared through the lens without blinking, chin slightly tilted as if bored. No backdrop. Just her and the statement:

“We will recover what’s ours.”

That was it.

Just that sentence.

She hadn’t appeared publicly since the body went missing. Not until now.

Phainon exhaled, slow.

Across the city, the broadcast was echoing on loop.

And it wasn’t just her face anymore.

News scrolls updated in real time:

❝GOLDWEAVER TERMINATES ALL COUNCIL OPERATIONS IN JOINT ZONES❞
❝HEIR UNDERTAKER STRIKES THREE TARGETS IN FIVE DAYS❞
❝BLACK TIDE CONTAINMENT FAILS—COUNCIL SUPPORT BLOCKED❞

Undertaker had summoned Pollux three times this week alone. The Council called them “thermal malfunctions.” But everyone knew better. Entire teams went dark in zones the Heirs used to co-patrol. Supply convoys, intel drops, even overflow medhalls. Gone.

And the message was always the same.

We asked. You refused. Now we take.

Hyacine had closed her medhalls to all Council ID. No negotiation. She hadn’t spoken to reporters in days following as well.

Goldweaver had shut down all coordination across former collaboration zones. Field teams found across the line were ignored. Not killed. Not rescued.

Just left behind.

Containment teams on Black Tide breaches used to work in tandem. Now? The Heirs held position and watched Council agents die. There’d been a breach two days ago in some sector, and no Heir squad moved to help.

The government’s response was a five-sentence memo about “internal oversight recalibration.”

They hadn’t spoken since.

And in the middle of all of it, they’d given the public something easier to hate.

Him.

Why?

He didn’t deny killing Mydei.

Because he had.

He’d stopped feeling the horror at that sentence a long time ago. Which was, in itself, a deeper horror.

If anything remained—*if the Council still had his body, using it, desecrating it*—then that needed to burn too.

The footage repeated.

His face. The corridor. A smear of blood and a voice on loop:

[“Have you seen this man?”
“Heir forces vow full retribution.”
“Council denies all responsibility.”]

He adjusted his coat. Pressed one palm against his side.

He passed beneath a cracked walkway. A teenager crouched near the base column, arms wrapped around a thermal canister, the flicker of a hand-lit match warming their face. A ragged Heir insignia stitched on the coat sleeve. Burned halfway through.

The kid didn’t look up.

Didn’t need to.

Everyone in the Sprawl had learned the same thing:

Don’t look at people. Don’t let them look back.

The Sink didn’t show up on maps anymore.

If you ended up here, it wasn’t by accident.

It had been a maintenance bar once—back when lower sector workers had regular hours and enough credits to drink. Now it sat buried three levels below the Tesserae Sprawl, at the edge of a derailed service tunnel and some forgotten Tide infrastructure. If you knew the code, the entrance unlocked from a rusted keypad on a loading shaft. If you didn’t, you stayed lost.

The Sink didn’t cater to anyone. It tolerated them. The lighting was low enough to misread a face, the booths deep enough to disappear into, and the walls pulsed with slow, rhythmic light from outdated Tide-core wiring—still warm, still alive, but decades behind modern safety protocols.

Most of the regulars were grounders. People who weren’t paid to exist above surface level. Technicians with burnt-out augments. Freelancers who couldn’t afford a second strike. Brokers who used to be higher up, before someone rewrote their chain of access.

The place wasn’t full, but it was never empty. Voices murmured over wet glass. Music came from an analog speaker, soft enough not to interfere with conversation. Someone at the back was patching a neural rig with kitchen tools. A woman at the end of the bar popped open a stim patch with her teeth and muttered something about bad code. Nobody listened. That was the Sink’s only rule:

Don’t be the loudest person in the room.

Phainon walked in with no announcement. Just the hydraulic slide of the door resealing behind him and the faint hiss of pressure equalizing.

The air inside was heavier than outside—metallic, and thick with secondhand chemicals. The light from the Tide-core wiring cast a dull pulse

across the ceiling like a slow heartbeat. Humidity clung to the walls. Condensation fogged parts of the mirror behind the bar. The floor had been swept, but barely.

He stood in the entrance for a moment longer than needed, letting the water run off his coat's hem. The hood stayed up. His gloves were still damp. A few people noticed him. Not many cared.

At least, not until he pulled the mask off.

It came off with a low snap of seal and magnet. His face, pale under the phosphor glow, wasn't a surprise anymore. The recognition was quiet.

No shouts. No dropped glasses. Just a slow halt in background movement. The woman with the stim patch blinked, then looked away. The man with the neural rig stood, unplugged, and made for the side door. The couple in the booth didn't speak as they packed up. Nobody ran. They just left.

It wasn't panic. It was logistics.

You didn't stay in a room with a criminal unless you had a reason to.

Within three minutes, the bar was empty. Except for one man.

He sat two stools down, elbows on the bar, swirling the last of a glass with a kind of unbothered grace.

Mid-fifties. Face lined, but not weak. His coat was military-cut but softened with age. An old overlay flickered in his right eye—likely tactical, probably still patched into something passive. He looked up, but didn't move.

Phainon didn't speak yet. Just walked forward and sat one seat over, dropping his gloves on the bar with quiet finality.

The man lifted his glass like it was a greeting. "Rough weather."

Phainon's voice was steady, tired. "You tell me."

The man gave a faint smile. "Didn't think you'd come here yourself."

“Didn’t think you’d be dumb enough to stay.”

That earned a short laugh. “I get paid to sit. Nobody said anything about running.” He glanced at the bottle beside him. “Drink?”

Phainon didn’t move. “It’s on me. You drink.”

The man nodded once, raised the glass, and tossed it back without ceremony.

For a while, neither of them spoke. The bar ticked with the residual hum of outdated tech, and upstairs, rain continued to find its way through cracked ductwork. Every few seconds, the lights in the wall pulsed, catching faint reflections across metal surfaces.

Then Phainon shifted, speaking flatly.

“I skinned the last person who lied to me.”

There was no pause.

“Didn’t even ask him anything at first. But it took a while. And I can do worse.”

The man met his eyes. Didn’t blink. “So you’re skipping the warm-up?”

“I’m skipping the wrong answer.”

Phainon finally turned his head fully, and this time, his expression made the atmosphere change. Not violent. Not unhinged. Just very, very clear.

“Where is she?”

The man didn’t flinch. Just leaned back slightly, then gave a low whistle.

“You’re gonna have to define she, friend.”

Phainon said nothing.

But he didn’t look away.

He licked his lips once and tapped the empty glass against the bar.

Phainon leaned his elbow on the bar. His posture was relaxed. His voice even more so—measured, polite.

“Apologies. That wasn’t clear. I don’t need what you’ve heard. Just what you believe.”

The archivist hesitated. Tried a smile that didn’t quite reach his eyes. “Look, man, a place like this? You hear a lot. Some useful. Some just noise. Hard to say what’s real half the time.”

Phainon nodded thoughtfully. Then raised two fingers toward the bartender.

“Another round. For my friend here. He’s been helpful.”

The man blinked. “I—thank you?”

“Of course. No pressure.” Phainon didn’t blink. “We’re just talking. You stall, I buy you drinks. You lie, I smile and let you keep going. Then I leave.”

He let that settle.

The archivist glanced down at the glass already in front of him. He didn’t touch it.

“You’re doing fine,” Phainon added. His tone didn’t shift, but it softened slightly. “Better than most. One man yapped for twenty minutes over a location he didn’t even give. Screamed through the sedation. I ended up missing the real detail he tried to say.”

The man swallowed. His jaw tensed.

“You don’t have to—”

“Please,” Phainon interrupted. Still polite. “You don’t need to reassure me. I’m not gifted at this. But people talk. Sooner or later. Something just clicks.”

Silence took its time stretching between them.

The old lighting above their heads buzzed—soft, erratic. A valve clicked somewhere behind the bar. The bartender didn’t move.

The archivist tapped the edge of his glass once with a finger. Then again. Then stopped. He stared ahead like he was reading something only he could see.

And finally, he spoke. Quiet. Tired.

“She vanished. Into a collapsed… spatial sinkhole. It’s not stable. Half-aware, leaking—something. It shouldn’t exist anymore. Should’ve collapsed fully. But it’s still active. Still… pulling.”

Phainon listened. Unblinking.

“She went in,” the man continued. “Walked into it like it was open ground. I don’t know how. It should’ve killed her. But it didn’t.”

Phainon’s head tilted slightly. “Go on.”

“She’s still alive. I’ve seen the spikes—data fragments, metaphasic drift. She’s in there. Not stuck, exactly. Just… inside. And she’s manipulating the Tide like it’s fluid.”

“Where.”

The man reached slowly into his coat. He pulled out a folded square of paper—creased, soft with age—and slid it onto the counter. Then took a pen from his sleeve and scratched something down. Numbers. Slanted writing.

“That’s the closest we’ve tracked it. Not a fixed point. But near enough. It’s not stable. Most people can’t reach it without tearing open a dozen fractures

on the way in. But you?" His eyes flicked toward Phainon. "You might not need the front door."

Phainon picked up the slip. Gave it one glance. Then folded it cleanly and slid it into the inner pocket of his coat like it was a receipt.

He stood.

"Thank you," he said, genuinely. It landed without edge.

The man raised a hand—not to stop him, just to get his attention—then pushed the untouched drink across the bar.

"If you really want to thank me," he said, "you'll sit and have one."

Phainon paused. Just a beat.

Then he chuckled.

And sat down.

He didn't just walk out of the place and vanish. Getting to the edge took time.

A decomissioned service hauler got him most of the way. It still reeked of sun-bleached rubber and mold-slick tide gaskets, but the filters hummed, and the lights worked. The others riding with him—three freight runners and a contract mechanic—kept to themselves. Eyes stayed down. One look at his face was enough.

Phainon chose the far corner bench. Leaned his head back. Let the inertia of the slow crawl across the lower districts lull him into something close to rest.

He could've used his abilities. Go from here to there in an instant. But not now—not yet. He needed to preserve his energy. The static inside his skull had gone from distant hiss to crackling feedback, and the bleeding had

started again. He wiped his upper lip with the back of his sleeve and didn’t look down.

The hauler rattled across one of the last still-standing city trusses—weather-warped and suspended over an abyss of ruined sublevels. It passed into silence. Only the soft buzz of old paneling and the mechanical breath of the engine loop filled the space.

He slept.

When he woke again, it was dark outside. Not night—just the bruised cast of industrial fog smothering the upper skyline. The others were gone. The driver hadn’t spoken a word. They were nearing the edge now, into sectors that weren’t even zoned anymore. He blinked at the haze through the grime-streaked window and knocked on the partition.

“Stop here,” he muttered.

The hauler hissed to a halt. No questions. No goodbyes.

He walked the rest of the way.

By now, time really didn’t matter.

The buildings leaned like drunk titans, half-swallowed by earth and sea, collapsed in slow, sinking heaps. Some leaned so far over they met their neighbors in sagging, joyful embraces, fusing at the rooftops. Corrosion marked every surface. Tide static hung in the air—too dense to patrol. Which was why no one did.

The sea whispered below. Seaglass wind moaned through broken walls, scattering dust and mineral shimmer across the shattered pavestones.

Phainon stood at the edge of a toppled service plaza. Exhaled through his nose.

He stretched.

First his arms, then shoulders, neck, spine—like shaking off sleep that never quite ended. Somewhere between his ribs, something pulled tight.

“If Anaxa were here,” he murmured, rubbing the back of his neck, “this would’ve taken half the time.”

A breath. Almost a laugh, but not quite.

Anaxa would’ve complained. Would’ve made a game of it. Bribed a guard. Hacked a stabilizer. Started a bar fight just to win an exit tunnel in the chaos. Bastard had a plan for everything—improvised, sure, but it always came through.

That’s why Phainon didn’t speak of him like he was dead.

Anaxa wouldn’t vanish quietly. If he went out, he’d tear the sky down with him.

Still—he hadn’t heard anything of him. The guilt scratched louder in silence.

Phainon shook his head. Rolled his shoulders once more.

“Alright.”

One step forward. Focus.

His fingers twitched once. The air flexed. The energy around him shifted like tension on a faultline. He pressed his palm to the ground—just enough to anchor the pattern—and exhaled.

Then, he tore.

The seam shrieked as it opened.

A fold, twisted steel, and tide-laced architecture. A conceptual slit knotted in five dimensions and barely holding its form. The shape flickered between

real and impossible. Glass cracked under his boots. The walls flickered in and out of geometric alignment.

“Shut up,” he muttered.

He wasn’t sure if he was talking to the fold. Or his mind. Or both.

Blood slicked his upper lip again. He blinked once. His vision ghosted white. Couldn’t see for a moment—but kept going.

He pulled the seam wider, threading the conceptual anchor tight. If he lost grip, it’d collapse, and possibly take him with it. He ignored the ringing in his ears. The sharp taste of copper in his mouth.

He made the opening just wide enough to pass through. No bigger. The more surface area, the higher the failure rate.

He gritted his teeth. Pushed once more.

Then he *stepped in.*

What came after didn’t sequence properly.

First came silence. Then came the dark. Not black, just… inverted. He’d definitely passed out after that. He had no idea how long he was unconscious. It might’ve been seconds. Might’ve been hours.

Whatever it was, he came to on his knees.

The light here was wrong. Bent sideways. Everything looked distant. Colorless.

Then he heard it.

Sound.

Music.

Strings, not electric. Bowed by hand. No rhythm, no accompaniment. Just a lonely, unspooling melody drifting through what used to be an atrium. Faint enough that it could've been a hallucination. But no—there was resonance. It was real.

He staggered upright.

Whatever this place was—it wasn't dead.

Not yet.

Phainon staggered forward—his footing slipped, and his hand shot down to brace against the ground. Blood welled in his mouth and he spat it out, watching as it hit the stone and hissed faintly.

He stayed like that for a moment, hunched, one knee angled to catch his weight, the other hand clenched so tightly it trembled

"Alright," he muttered under his breath. "Let's not die just yet."

It wasn't convincing. But it was something.

His sleeve swiped at his mouth, smearing red across already dried streaks. Pain crackled in his spine and the muscles in his jaw kept twitching like they wanted to lock. But through the static blur of his vision, one thing held steady:

The sound of a violin.

He turned toward it.

The corridor ahead bent like a broken memory. Beams jutted from the floor at impossible angles, slanting into ceilings that didn't meet the walls. It's as though geometry itself had collapsed under strain. Light folded like bruised skin, flickering, glitching. Pools of black liquid shimmered along the street, refusing to ripple—uncertain if they were fluid or solid.

It was the Tide. But not like he'd seen it before.

It was water, or nearly. Tangible. Reflective. Moving without current, rippling without touch.

And still, the music.

He didn’t follow it so much as drift. Half-limping, half-led, his weight shifted toward the sound because it was the only thing in this warped place that didn’t deform under scrutiny. It kept him oriented.

A broken sky arched above him, too wide and buckling—and then—

The melody dropped lower.

And the cathedral came into view.

It shouldn’t have been standing. Its central dome had collapsed long ago, but the bones of the structure—its spires, its buttresses, its twisted ribs—somehow held together by reverse gravity. Debris floated upward like ash in slow motion. Fragments of stained glass hovered midair, refracting violet, cyan, and fractured gold. The floor flickered like a lake, transparent but stone beneath.

And in the middle of it, suspended just above the rippling surface, she played.

Hysilens.

Seated in a ring of shifting light, arms poised in unnatural composure, she moved with the precise, unhurried grace of something utterly unbothered by time. Her hair, long and pitch-dark, hung weightlessly down her back. Her body shimmered slightly at the edges, refracting light—translucent in some places, glasslike, the bones faintly visible through her skin.

Her bow glided elegantly. Each note layered itself across the next like filaments of pressure pulling the space taut.

Phainon stopped moving.

He stood still, letting the sound pass through him. A melody more dissonant than beautiful, but deliberate.

He stayed there for as long as she played.

When the last note fell away, the cathedral seemed to still around it—as though something immense had held its breath.

Then silence.

Then her eyes.

Violet-laced blue, like ice cracking under moonlight.

Phainon didn't speak right away. He let the weight of her gaze settle. Then he straightened—not fully, but enough to breathe past the bruises in his ribs—and met her eyes without flinching.

"If I had anything left in me," he said, voice sardonic, "I'd have applauded."

A beat. Just enough time for her to blink once.

"Is that so." She mused. "And what exactly did you think you were hearing?"

He didn't answer the question directly. Just tilted his head slightly.

"You're Hysilens."

She didn't respond.

Another step from him—tentative, cautious. His boot touched the cathedral floor and sent a ripple outward, light distorting beneath him as though he were stepping into water without getting wet.

"This place…" he looked around, eyes scanning the floating debris. "Not exactly easy to find. Then again, I suppose that's the point."

She didn’t reply, but her eyes narrowed slightly.

So he continued, voice lowered now. “You used to be an Heir. Tactical stabilizer. Field operative.” A pause. “You pulled people out of the Tide after they’d already gone under. Not just recovery. Reconstruction.”

His gaze lifted briefly—toward the shattered cathedral ceiling, the light bleeding in from the warped sky.

“Then came the Council operation. Some joint deployment, neutral ground. No one ever confirmed what happened after that.” He looked back down at her. “You vanished. Rumors split—some said you defected, joined the Council. Others said you died.”

A shrug.

“Turns out neither was true.”

His voice quieted.

“You walked straight into the Tide,” he added, “and made a home out of it.”

Her eyes didn’t waver, but the bow in her hand shifted slightly. A micro-adjustment. And maybe the faintest flicker crossed her features at the word *Council*—not a reaction so much as a recalibration.

Then, finally: “You didn’t come here to recite my file.”

“No.”

“Then get to it.”

He took in a slow breath.

“I need your help.”

That earned the first flicker of visible interest. Her brow arched, just slightly.

“The Council has someone I want,” he said. “I think you can help me find it.”

She stood.

The movement was fluid—too fluid. As if she wasn’t bound by friction or physics at all. The air didn’t resist her. The waterlike floor didn’t register her weight. For a half-second, he braced himself—expecting retaliation, recoil, or attack. She’d probably killed for less than intrusion before.

But she didn’t strike.

She studied him instead. A long, soundless inspection.

Then, softly:

“Ah.”

The smallest smile touched her mouth.

“Phainon, then.”

He stopped dead in his tracks.

“News filters down here too,” she said. Her voice wasn’t quite mocking, but it carried the echo of amusement. “Even if it arrives in pieces.”

Her feet touched the floor now.

She walked forward, steps soundless, but somehow still leaving ripples in her wake.

And when she came close enough to see the exhaustion riding his posture, she stopped.

Her gaze narrowed.

“And by someone,” she said, “I assume you mean Mydeimos.”

He froze.

It wasn’t surprise. Not really. It just hit too fast for him to brace.

Of course she knew.

They’d worked together. Somewhere along the line.

He didn’t speak.

She didn’t press.

They just stood there, locked in a moment that stretched too long to be comfortable.

Neither blinked.

Neither looked away.

And neither—not yet—asked the obvious question.

Hysilens is the first to move. Just a step back.

She doesn’t drop her gaze. Only lowers the violin from beneath her chin, her fingers slipping off the strings.

“You want my help,” she says slowly.

“I could be flattered.”

She clearly isn’t.

“But flattery’s cheap here,” she adds. “Especially from someone like you.”

Then, simply:

“No.”

Silence spreads.

Phainon doesn’t react—not fully. But the hit lands. A flicker across the jaw. One tendon pulls tight at the side of his neck. He doesn’t beg but he has to work harder now just to stand still.

He draws a shallow breath.

“You’re the only one who can find him.”

A beat. Then: “The only one who’d know where to look.”

She doesn’t give him the dignity of reacting like a person being asked a favor.

“If the Council has him,” she says, lifting her chin slightly, “then he’s not yours anymore.”

A pause. Just long enough for it to sting.

“He’s theirs. Or he’s gone.”

Phainon shifts his weight, briefly favoring the leg that’s still healing. Then his voice changes.

He switches tactics.

“You saw something,” he says. “During the operation. Didn’t you.”

Hysilens doesn’t flinch. But something in her posture freezes—shoulders too still, spine aligning a little too perfectly. She says nothing. Phainon doesn’t press.

“I’m not asking what it was,” he says. “I’m not here to drag it out of you.”

Another pause.

“But you saw it. So you already know what they’re capable of when no one’s looking, right?”

She doesn’t respond, but she’s not weighing whether to speak anymore—she’s watching him now. Evaluating.

He takes one breath, slow. This next part costs him, and it shows—just barely. The strain flickers behind his eyes, too quickly buried to read.

“I’m here to make sure they don’t do something worse to him.”

He doesn’t say the word again. *Corpse*.

And that’s when she finally shifts.

Not much. Just enough to signal a recalibration. A step back. A tilt of the head.

“Oh,” she says quietly.

A pause. Then:

“That’s different.”

She steps back again, and the surface beneath her shifts. The floor ripples faintly, a dark bloom beneath her feet.

“You worked with him,” Phainon says softly. “You knew what he was like.”

She lifts her head again. And something—some flicker that never makes it to a smile—moves at the corner of her mouth.

“He burned too hot,” she says simply. “They always go for the ones like that first.”

Phainon nods. Once. It’s the only movement he allows himself.

She exhales through her nose—quiet, clipped.

Then: “All right.”

He blinks.

That was… faster than expected.

He doesn’t react, but the tension in him spikes—barely visible, but it’s there. He knows better than to trust the first yes.

And she notices. Of course she does.

“But,” she says, and the word stretches a little, “I’m not leading a loaded gun through the dark. If I’m going to help, I want to know what I’m working with.”

He studies her. “You want a test.”

She turns slightly, angling her body to retrieve the violin. As she lifts the bow, the water beneath them begins to shift, darkening in long, slow pulses like ink spreading from a deep wound.

Phainon’s eyes narrow.

“I’m lucky it didn’t take more to convince you,” he mutters. Then corrects himself, sharper: “How long?”

She’s already tuning, adjusting one peg near the scroll. Doesn’t look at him.

“Five minutes.”

She holds up five fingers. Then sets the bow to the strings.

The first note is low. Uneven. Resonant in a way that suggests depth more than volume.

The change is immediate.

The cathedral doesn’t dim, it *sinks*. Light stretches wrong across the space. Edges blur. Reflections melt into their sources. The air thickens with something weightless and wet, as though they’ve dropped beneath water.

Then it hits him.

Not like wind. Like pressure.

The Black Tide—or whatever she's drawn from it—rises around him with the slow certainty of drowning. It presses behind his ribs. Fills the spaces behind his teeth.

His first instinct is to resist. Tense, react, defend.

But he knows better.

Instead, he exhales.

Closes his eyes.

Lets it take him.

Because the test has begun.

And no one fights the ocean.

[142 days before breach: Aedes Elysiae, Agricultural District]

The hill wasn't special, not really. But it felt like the top of the world. Straw-colored grass rippled in all directions, swaying with the weightless rhythm of late summer, and the air smelled like sun-warmed dust and something faintly sweet—probably the wild mint growing near the fence post.

Phainon lay flat on his back, arms behind his head, a bent stalk of wheat hanging loosely between his teeth. His shirt was rolled halfway up his ribs and the skin beneath was striped with dirt from sliding down the hill earlier. He'd lost a sandal doing it. No one had found it yet.

Above him, the sky stretched wide and blue without apology. A hawk wheeled far off toward the silos, lazy in the heat.

A pebble bounced off his chest.

He grunted, didn’t move.

“You deserved that,” Cyrene calls sweetly from a few feet away, half-lounging against the fence. She’s trying not to laugh. “For slandering Snowy.”

“I didn’t say he was that dumb,” Phainon said through the wheat stalk. “

“You said if he were a person, he’d ask if the sun sets in the east.”

“Which it doesn’t.”

“You know what I mean.”

“I know that dog chased his own reflection for twenty minutes and fell into the trough trying to bite it.”

As if summoned by insult, Snowy barked near the barn. Then again, closer. Then—in a clumsy sprint—tore up the hill and collapsed sideways in the grass with his tongue lolling and tail thumping like a malfunctioning metronome.

Cyrene sighed, dropped down beside him cross-legged, and uncapped the canteen. She took a sip, then handed it over without speaking.

Phainon sat up just enough to drink, wiped his mouth with the back of his hand, and flopped down again.

“He followed me all the way to the aqueduct this morning,” she said, glancing at Snowy, who had started chewing the corner of his own foot. “Wouldn’t shut up the whole walk.”

Phainon blinked. “Wait. You walked the aqueduct?”

She gave him a look. “Yes.”

“Alone?”

“Yes.”

“That’s— That’s like, two kilometers of open beam.”

“I know.”

“You could’ve died!”

“I didn’t.”

“You could’ve broken every bone in your body.”

“I didn’t.”

Phainon groaned and dragged the back of his hand over his face. “Ugh. I’d rather jump off the silo.”

“You won’t even jump from the hayloft.”

“I would now. Out of spite.”

Cyrene teased. “Against what? Gravity?”

“Against you. You’re gonna get all the bravery credit now and act insufferable about it.”

She was already laughing. “I’m always insufferable.”

“That’s true.”

They let it sit.

A chicken screeched from the other side of the hill, then immediately went silent again. Someone’s screen door slammed shut in the distance—probably the Marescas two plots over.

Cyrene pulled a strip of dried apple from her pocket and broke it in half. She offered one to Phainon. They chewed in silence, watching the wind bend the wheat like water.

Then, without warning, she said:

“If you had to leave—like really leave, tomorrow—would you tell me?”

She asked it like a joke, but he knew why. His parents had been talking lately about moving closer to the city. Better schools, better chances, all that.

Phainon chewed once, twice more, then rolled the apple stem between his fingers. “I’d carve your name on the train car.”

She looked over. “You’d what?”

“So you’d know which one I took.”

She laughs, more startled than anything. “Why not just send a message?”

“No fun in that,” he said. “You’ve got to hunt it. Like a clue.”

“Dumbest—and cutest—thing I’ve ever heard.”

He smirked a little. “Yeah. But you’d remember it.”

She didn’t say anything for a while. Then leaned sideways and tugged a little purple wildflower from the grass, twirled it once between her fingers, and tucked it behind his ear.

Their shoulders were close, almost brushing. But not quite.

He shifted the wheat stalk to the other side of his mouth.

Snowy, oblivious, started chasing the same dragonfly in an endless, uneven loop.

The sun stretched across the field until their shadows went long.

⟲

[54 days before breach: Aedes Elysiae, Agricultural District]

It looked the same, at first. Maybe a little dimmer. Maybe the light had turned brittle around the edges.

Phainon stood outside the fence, a hand still half-curled from carrying something. Grocery bags? He wasn’t holding them anymore.

The hill looked distant and golden like it always did in late summer. But the wheat didn’t move.

Not in the breeze. Not at all.

His neighbor, Mrs. Erilan, waved from her porch like she always did.

“Dinner’s in the oven already, dearie,” she called out, bright and warm.

He waved back.

“Dinner’s in the oven already, dearie.”

Same pitch. Same words. The porch swing creaked once.

She wasn’t sitting in it.

The silence that followed lasted exactly four seconds. Then the same crow on the same post raised its wings. Froze. Its feathers stayed caught in mid-flap.

Phainon stared at it.

Then walked toward the house.

His mother stood at the sink. Water running, hands in the basin, sleeves damp at the wrists.

“Already eaten?” she asked, not turning around.

“No.”

She nodded.

A beat.

“Already eaten?” she asked again.

He paused in the doorway, one foot still on the mat. “You just said that.”

She didn’t turn. The water continued to run. One of the faucet knobs trembled slightly, like the pressure was stuck inside the pipe.

Outside the window, the sky looked exactly the same as before. Orange, pale, brilliant. Sunset. Still. The windmill in the distance hadn’t shifted. Not a single blade.

He tilted his head.

The shadows on the ground were longer than they should’ve been.

Too long.

They leaned across the wheat like claws. Unmoving.

His breath caught in his throat, though he didn’t know why.

Maybe it was just the stillness. Maybe it was the smell—not the usual sweetness of wheat, but something drier. Faintly scorched. Like the scent of a fuse just after it’s been burned.

He blinked.

The crow on the post still hadn’t moved.

He stepped back toward the porch, trying to feel normal about it. One foot, then the other. Wood creaked under him the way it always had. That should’ve helped.

It didn’t.

In the distance, Snowy barked.

Then again.

Then again.

Three times. Same pitch. Same beat.

He gripped the doorframe before stepping out.

Then looked across the fields.

No change.

But past the far hill, just above the horizon—something dark curled up into the sky like smoke.

But their was no fire.

He stared. The windmill stayed still.

He must be hallucinating.

Maybe it was the quiet.

Maybe it was nothing.

But somewhere in the sky above the wheat, the sun hadn’t moved in hours.

⟲

[7 days before the Breach]

It’s late afternoon when Cyrene finds him.

She’s barefoot, walking the split-rail fence like she did as a kid—arms out for balance, boots swinging from two fingers. Her shirt’s half-untucked. Dust freckles her calves.

Phainon’s halfway through patching the gate. He leans on the post, hammer hanging loose, a half-driven nail still between his fingers. He watches her

quietly.

She hops off the fence and lands with a soft thud. Five steps between them. Wheat moves behind her in slow, sunlit waves.

“There’s something wrong with the town,” she starts.

Phainon doesn’t stiffen. Just wipes his hand on his shirt and gestures for her to go on.

Cyrene’s voice stays steady—but tight.

“I went to my uncle’s today. Fed the cows like always.”

Beat.

“But they looked… rotted.”

His eyes narrow slightly. She presses forward.

“They weren’t dead. Just—” she makes a shape in the air—“soft. Skin pulled wrong. One had holes in its back. Another blinked at me and something slithered under its fur.”

She hesitates.

“I think they were breathing. But not right.”

The hammer lowers. Phainon steps closer now—not doubting her exactly.

“And your uncle?”

“Gone. Stable door was open. His boots were by the trough. Mud still wet.”

She looks up, then away. Her face is pale.

“I called for him. Nothing answered.”

A breeze rolls the wheat flat.

Phainon doesn’t react. But when the wind hits again, his fingers flex.

A third gust. Identical.

He glances up. The clouds haven’t moved.

Beside him, Cyrene exhales. The breath catches halfway.

Neither says a word.

A crow lands on the fencepost. Its wings don’t rustle.

Cyrene’s hand finds his wrist.

“Let’s go back.”

He nods.

They leave the tools in the dirt.



The stars are up.

But they’re in the wrong places.

Phainon can’t name constellations—but he knows that pattern never existed. A cluster to the west keeps flickering, like it’s buffering.

They try to sleep in shifts. It doesn’t work.

Cyrene’s staying the night. She doesn’t say why, and he doesn’t ask.

Sometime after midnight, the porch boards creak.

She’s outside, sitting on the steps, jacketless, arms wrapped tight. Shivering.

He joins her.

“They weren’t maggots,” she says eventually, staring at the grass.

He waits.

“In the cow’s eye. I looked closer. They were like… miniature cows. Shaped the same. Breathing. Just slightly off. Their mouths kept opening, but none of them made a sound.”

Phainon hands her his coat. She leans into it, jaw tight.

“Do you think we’re sick?”

“No fever,” he says.

A moment.

“But you don’t think it’s in our heads either.”

He doesn’t answer.

The porch light flickers above them. Twice.

But it isn’t on.

Cyrene turns her head sharply.

“I heard my name.”

Phainon straightens. Eyes scan the horizon. Nothing.

Only wind.

She grips his hand. Her pulse is out of sync.

⊕→

[ERROR TIMESTAMP | BREACH +0.0]
Aedes Elysiae
STARTING POINT: First Black Tide Surge

They run.

Not toward anything—just away.

Behind them: the sky splits like mirrored glass. The trees are blurring. The world vibrates in half-frames.

Phainon jerks—arm pulled back a second too late. He's reliving the moment in delay. Muscle memory catching up out of sync.

Cyrene grabs his hand. "Think of something—" she chokes. "Anything. Before this."

Her voice stutters.

"I mean—god—I mean—it'll pass. We're—fine—"

Blood drips from her nose. Her outline glitches—jumping half a frame with each step. Her fingers feel sharp, pixelated. Her pulse doesn't match time anymore.

The ground loses shape.

Then—

Memory.

They stop running. Cling to each other, foreheads pressed.

The hill. The rusted train car. That late summer day. Wheat rolling in quiet arcs. Her laugh.

Neither says it out loud. But they know.

The wind halts. The sky ceases to crack.

And something *holds*.

A conceptual lock. A memory loop.

A closed system built on perfect mutual recall.

The wheat field again.

Static clouds overhead. The world hushed.

Phainon kneels beside her. Her face is still. Bleeding at the corners. Eyes gone cloudy.

He touches her cheek—his fingers go through her like mist.

“It’s okay,” he whispers, even though it isn’t.

Cyrene flickers once. Then again.

“I’m—still—” her voice distorts. “Still—still—here—”

He grabs her hand. Ice cold.

The wind freezes mid-motion. Light fractures, then corrects.

He reinforces the memory. Tightens the loop. Wheat stiffens. Light returns. Sound realigns.

She doesn’t stabilize.

Her shadow twitches. Cuts out. Reappears.

Phainon builds faster. Every blade of grass, every cloud shape. Every line of her voice, each brush of wind—all constructed.

He’s not trying to survive.

He’s anchoring her.

They were both fine. Everyone else is gone, but they weren’t. And now she’s fading.

So he roots the memory around her body.

Her exact weight. Her last smile. Her voice the second before it broke.

She smiles.

Once.

And goes still.

But the field doesn’t collapse.

Not yet.

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[DATA CORRUPTED—LOOP END UNSTABLE]

There are no wheat fields anymore.

Phainon kneels in the rot.

Cradling what’s left.

Cyrene’s body is decayed—jaw slack, hair brittle, ribs visible. But his arms hold her like she’s still warm. His head is tilted, like he’s listening.

His mouth is curved.

Like she’d just said something funny.

He hasn’t moved in years. Or minutes. Or never.

Around him, the memory bleeds. The last of the loop flaking into noise.

Council agents breach the pocket.

The scanners fail.

“This isn’t—” one stammers. “This isn’t possible—”

The moment they touch him—

Everything breaks.

The sky collapses. Light fails. Air unravels.

But he’s still holding something.

Inside the containment bag: one dried flower.

Evidence Bag #496.

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The sky is impossibly bright. The wheat glows untouched, unbroken by wind.

Birds hum somewhere in the trees. Wildflowers crest the slope in swaying bands of color—the kind Cyrene used to braid into their sleeves when they were kids. The whole field smells like sun-warmed syrup and dry dust.

She's laughing before she calls to him.

Phainon stands partway down the hill, holding a coil of fence wire in one hand and a cup of nails in the other. He doesn't remember picking them up. Doesn't remember what he was fixing.

Cyrene balances barefoot on the top beam of the fence—arms out, hair catching the light. She squints down at him, smiling.

"If you had to leave," she calls, tone easy, "like—really leave. Tomorrow. Would you tell me?"

Same cadence. Same voice. Down to the last inflection.

The grass stays still.

Something shifts behind his ribs. His throat works, but he doesn't answer.

Cyrene tilts her head at his silence. "Phainon."

He blinks.

There's blood on his fingers.

A faint smear. Out of place.

He doesn't move.

She hops lightly from the fence and walks toward him. Her feet leave no impression in the dirt. The flowers don't bend as she passes.

She grins up at him, undeterred. "Heeelloo? Did you fall asleep with your eyes open again?"

Still playful. Still a child.

He doesn’t look at her.

“…Oh.”

He stares at the blood. Lifts his eyes to the sky.

“This isn’t real.”

Her smile falters.

“What?”

His voice flattens.

“This already happened.”

Cyrene frowns. She steps closer. “You’re acting weird.”

He finally looks at her—fully this time.

“This already happened.”

The field stills.

Sound falls away.

The birds vanish. The trees lose depth, fading like a stage set pulled too far from the audience. The scent of wheat and wildflowers thins and disappears. Everything begins to lose texture.

Phainon turns in a slow circle. The sun casts no heat. One by one, the fence boards start to vanish.

Cyrene hasn’t changed—not quite. But she doesn’t blink anymore. Her arms hang loosely at her sides. The smile lingers on her face, but it’s become something else—a memory stretched too long in sunlight, faded around the edges.

Phainon steps toward her. He draws a breath, shallow and uneven.

She tilts her head, watching him. Still smiling.

The field begins to fold. Not all at once, not loudly. False panels peeling away. Flat pieces pulled from behind the backdrop.

He stops in front of her.

His fingers twitch.

“…Thank you,” he says quietly.

And then she’s gone.

Not shattered.

Just no longer needed.

He comes back violently.

A sharp inhale tears through his chest—too fast, too wet—as if he’s surfaced from something that wasn’t water. His spine arches with the force of it. His lungs fight to stay filled.

But the room is still.

Dry.

Silent.

The violin has gone quiet.

There’s no field. No warmth. Just the polished stone beneath him this time.

His hand is still raised—halfway to a face that isn’t there. It hovers for a breath, then curls in on itself.

He lowers it.

The hush that follows feels like judgment. The walls give nothing back. There is no sympathy here.

He doesn’t move.

Eventually, he exhales through his nose. Not quite a laugh—more a crack of disbelief.

“That was a low blow,” he mutters. His voice scrapes as it leaves him, roughened by whatever that place pulled from him. “Even for you.”

There’s no answer.

He turns his head, slow. His ears are bleeding. He leaves it alone.

Then he laughs—once.

Short. Bitter. Joyless.

The noise catches at the edges of his breath, jagged and raw.

He wipes the salt from his temple with the back of his wrist.

Lifts his gaze to the ceiling.

“Was that supposed to be hard?”

Silence.

Then, finally, the voice.

Unmistakably clear.

“You pass.”

Phainon’s head tips forward, shoulders rising and falling in uneven pulls.

“…Was that it?”

A beat passes.

“Or is there more?”

Hysilens doesn’t shift. Her posture stays composed, the violin now silent at her side. When she speaks, it’s with the same evenness as before.

“I have one more condition.”

He shuts his eyes for a moment, drawing air in through his nose, letting it out with a thin, humorless breath.

“Of course you do.” His gaze lifts again. “What is it?”

“We’ll need her.”

A faint crease forms between his brows. “…Who?”

“Goldweaver.”

The air in the chamber tightens—sharp and sudden, like stone flexing in frost.

His answer comes without a breath’s delay, iron-edged.

“I’d rather die.”

Hysilens doesn’t blink.

“Then die. But this stopped being about you the moment you stepped in here. She deserves to bury her dead.”

The silence that follows is heavy enough to pull at the walls. Phainon’s jaw works once, the corner of his mouth twitching toward something between a sneer and a grimace.

A long breath leaves him. “…Fine.”

Her eyes narrow.

“You mean that?”

“He died. I didn’t.” His tone is flat. “That’s the only part that matters now.”

Another silence. Not cold this time—simply measured.

“When do we leave?” he asks.

Her gaze tracks over him briefly—the tremor in his breath, the bruising along his shoulders, the faint trickle of dried red at his ears—before meeting his eyes again.

“First,” she says, “we get you into a state where you won’t collapse before the door.”

“And after that?”

The smallest curve tugs at her mouth.

“Why not tonight?”

She extends her arm toward him. An invitation, the kind of gesture that feels rare even to her.

Phainon stares at her hand, then at her. Slowly, his own rises—still heavy, still shaking faintly—and closes over hers.

The cold doesn’t lift from the chamber. But the quiet that follows isn’t the same as before.

Chapter End Notes

> Alright, before you get all confused (cause I definitely didn’t explain this well here), here’s the deal on how Phainon’s ass survived and why Cyrene didn’t, and how he ended up with his powers. I was going back through this and earlier chapters and realized I left this way too vague and abstract.

So, like Caenis said last chapter, the “solution” was memory, that applies here too. Long story short: Cyrene was already kinda dying, just like everyone else in the district, but she and Phainon didn’t drop right away because in the final collapsing moment, they both clung to the exact same memory that was in the beginning of the loop where they were talking about Snowy (albeit the scene was slightly different with the blood and setting, though that was because the loop was starting to break)

If you’re sitting there wondering ok so like how the fuck is that relavent, yeah, my bad for not explaining it better, but memories are the bread and butter of surviving the Tide basically in this au.

See, the Black Tide erases meaning by contradiction and entropy, but a perfect, shared memory? That can’t be corrupted. It stalls the Tide right there since, what can it even do? They have a tether that grounds them to the world, which also works as proof of their existence as well (which can’t be erased. The point of this was to connect Eurypon’s theory with this as well so I hope someone caught it)

Phainon, barely hanging on, started instinctively bending the breaking space around them to keep that moment intact. Not to escape, but to keep it real, which also meant keeping Cyrene real, since the Tide basically wipes people out on a conceptual level.

Problem is, Cyrene was already dying and couldn’t handle the strain. She started to fall apart, so Phainon, desperate as hell, built the rest of that memory bubble around her corpse. She couldn’t keep the memory going anymore, but yeah, Phainon survived only because they were linked through that memory.

I was gonna explain exactly how he got his powers here too from the incident (Hint: it’s related to how this was quite literally the first EVER breach and sighting of the Tide), but I’ll try to slip it into the story somewhere. If not, I’ll just toss it in the chapter notes later like this.

Anyway, thanks for reading and sticking for this long!!

Chapter 18: Naptime at the Slaughterhouse

Chapter Summary

> Mydei tries his hand at running away with Anaxa and Cipher while high (read: promptly blacks out), Hysilens plays bodyguard in what may or may not be former… something behavior, and Phainon commits one-handed ultraviolence while simultaneously functioning as the world's deadliest weighted blanket.

Chapter Notes

> Heyy, I only beta-read about 80% of this, so please let me know if I missed anything! Also… I won't lie, this one was a bit rushed, so if it shows, totally my bad😭.
>
> I also take back what I said about the comedy last chapter, this one's a bit more lighthearted, but honestly, there weren't enough funny moments or interactions like I'd originally hoped, so it might come off kinda dry. If I get some free time, I'll try to fix it, but really sorry if it doesn't quite hit your expectations. Still, I hope you enjoy it <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The wind never stopped up here.

It slipped through the jagged wound where the north wall used to be, cold enough to bite. It carried the city's noise in scraps—sirens, engines, the metallic pulse of some distant club—layered together like static through a blown speaker.

From this height, the skyline looked split in two. The new spires rose in clean chrome and holo-glass, bright enough to cut the eye, while the Old District below crouched in shadow, its skeletal high-rises slick with rain and firelight. Somewhere in that mess of towers and ruin, the Council was still tearing up the city looking for them.

Their hideout had once been a corporate boardroom. Now it looked like a scrapyard someone had decided to stack vertically. Armored shutters leaned at wrong angles. Discarded ad panels had been flipped around, their blank backs hiding the faded grins of spokesmodels who'd probably died before any of them were born. Electrical cables looped across the floor like exposed veins. The stolen generators in the corner rattled and hummed until the whole place seemed to breathe.

Out on the street below, a neon sign tried and failed to complete its loop, blinking eternally between **Loa—** and **S—ing.**

Cipher was holding court in a high-backed leather chair she definitely hadn't paid for, the old company initials still faintly embossed in the headrest. She was halfway through an evidence bag of potato chips, chewing with enough sound that every crunch landed like a gunshot.

On the table beside her, Mydei sat cross-legged, polishing the sidearm he'd liberated from a Council operative twenty minutes ago. He didn't look up from the task, though the muscle at his jaw twitched every time Cipher bit down.

Across the room, Anaxa was bent over a glowing scanner array, muttering without looking up.

"If one more of you drags dirt into my diagnostic zone, I'm installing a guillotine in the doorway."

Mydei let the sigh escape before he could stop it.

Now, you'd think he'd be used to situations like this by now.

It's been… a while since Anaxa had first broken him out of the Council facility, and at that time he'd been convinced they wouldn't see the light of day again.

Until Cipher.

To this day, he had no idea how Anaxa had gotten hold of her. She had a reputation for being everywhere *except* the city, yet she'd appeared within the hour, maps spilling out of her bag, rattling off three separate exit routes for a Council building that supposedly had no exits. She'd walked them out like she was returning a library book.

The Council had been in full meltdown since. Losing both Mydei and Anaxa in the same week had been enough to send them into overdrive, locking down half the city in overlapping webs of scanners and drones.

And that—unfortunately—had been Cipher's topic of choice for the past five minutes.

"But—"

Anaxa cut her off by flicking a feed onto the main screen. The city map lit up in a pulsing red lattice, zone after zone stitched shut.

"You see this? That's why we don't step into Heir territory. That is a killbox—one they wrote legal paperwork for."

Cipher crunched another chip. "We could still—"

"No."

Mydei tilted his head. "I could—"

"Also no."

Cipher frowned. "…You didn't even let me finish."

"Because your sentence was going to get us killed."

Mydei set the sidearm down, slowly. "So we're stuck here. And the Council's tightening the net."

"Exactly," Anaxa said without looking up.

Mydei glanced over at Cipher. “And, correct me if I’m wrong, but you’re officially an *actual* fugitive now?”

Cipher whistled and found something very interesting on the ceiling.

That answered that. Of all the times for the city to cash in on her laundry list of thefts, it had picked the week she’d been useful.

So here they were—three very wanted people in a tower missing half its walls, staring at a map that promised death in every direction.

And the worst part? This was still the safest place they had.

Cipher broke the silence first.

“So, we’re agreed. The plan is: no plans.”

“That’s not a plan,” Anaxa said without looking up from the scanner array.

“It’s been our only plan for weeks now,” Mydei countered.

Anaxa’s head lifted just enough to aim a flat, unimpressed look across the room. Mydei held his gaze, then let his expression shift into something Anaxa recognized immediately.

Anaxa groaned. “Not this again.”

“Oh, I’m sorry,” Mydei began, voice soft with mock sympathy, “maybe if I’d known my boyfriend was an infamous criminal antihero mastermind—one with a distinguished career in justice-flavored killing sprees—”

Anaxa pinched the bridge of his nose.

“—and that his so-called *university professor friend* was actually his long-time partner in dismantling institutions for fun—”

“That’s not even—”

“—and that the two of you have been running joint black operations under both the Chrysos Heirs *and* the Council’s nose for years while I was thinking, ‘Wow, they must’ve met at a lecture on economics,’—”

Anaxa’s jaw worked like he was chewing rocks.

“—then maybe,” Mydei finished, “we wouldn’t be in quite this mess.”

Cipher’s snickered. Anaxa muttered something to the scanner that might have been an insult, might have been a death threat. Mydei gave him a glare so half-hearted it barely counted.

Truth was, they didn’t have a plan because every viable option ended with their corpses in a Council evidence vault. Heir territory was sealed—choked with Council biometric checkpoints and patrol grids tight enough to tag them the second they crossed the line.

And revealing Mydei was alive? Sure, it sounded like the easy win—instant public outrage, Heir leadership shielding him, the Council exposed. Except the Council’s whole strategy hinged on turning the Chrysos Heirs into a political island. The moment Mydei surfaced, they’d make the Heirs a co-defendant in every “terrorist” act the Council had ever manufactured by claiming he’d been working with the Flame Reaver. He’d be trading his skin for theirs.

So they stayed in the shadows. Injured shadows. Mydei was still carrying more internal stitches than blood cells. Cipher had officially made it onto the “do not attempt arrest without air support” list. And Anaxa… Anaxa had been cut off from his playground.

The Council had burned through their own defense budget building a kill switch for him—an active, citywide intrusion scrambler keyed to his digital signature. Anything he touched online spun itself into static before it even reached the servers. That didn’t stop Anaxa though, but even *his* workarounds had to brute-force their way through it, and the strain was showing.

But if they couldn’t be safe, they could at least make the Council miserable.

The weapons job had been first—an entire convoy redirected to a phantom "Warehouse Zero" that had never existed outside Anaxa's code. Cipher made sure the crates didn't sit still long enough to be reclaimed, moving them through a chain of underground cells until they vanished into a dozen different hands. The Council found their guns again only when they were being used on Council patrols.

Then the treasury hack. Anaxa's mechanical worm (Don't question it, he doesn't know either) rewrote the Council's finance AI's priorities overnight, redirecting "public security surplus" into binding humanitarian grants for anti-Council relief groups. The money was stuck in escrow contracts designed to auto-trigger penalties if touched—locking procurement lines for weeks and forcing entire divisions to ration.

And the biotech stunt… pure, indulgent malice. Anaxa had swapped vault manifests so precisely that the Council, believing they were receiving high-grade gene sequencers, installed industrial algae bioreactors in sterile labs. The systems self-calibrated. The next morning, the labs were swamped in green foam, and the sequencing teams were wading through ankle-deep slime.

That had been a good week.

Still, every strike they made only tightened the noose. And as Cipher kicked her boots up onto the table, scattering a pile of spent ammo casings, Mydei found himself wondering—not for the first time—how much longer they could keep pushing before the Council finally cornered them.

"Oh, right," he said. "Remember when I mentioned Caenis planning to use me as a vessel? For—" he made a vague, spiraling gesture "—stealing everyone's abilities somehow, with Phainon in the mix?"

Of course he'd told them about that the second they got out, he's not stupid.

Cipher gave a lazy thumbs-up. Anaxa nodded once, distracted by the stream of data finally coming in.

Mydei paused mid-roll, the casing sliding from one knuckle to the next. His brow furrowed. “There was something else, though… I’m not exactly sure what that means in this context. And I think I need your help with it.” He looked at Anaxa. His tone had shifted—less throwaway, more deliberate.

That got Anaxa’s attention. The scanner kept humming, but his hands stilled on the console. “…Go on.”

Cipher gestured vaguely between them. “Cool, so I’m just here then?”

“Pretty much.”

She nodded wisely. “The lion does not concern himself with—”

“Quiet.”

Cipher pouted, but leaned forward in her chair, curious now.

Mydei exhaled. “It might not be relevant. But I’d like some peace of mind. Back in that incubator—” His voice thinned slightly at the word. “—there was a readout I could see from inside. I didn’t understand most of it, but one thing stood out: a reading with an unbalanced pattern. Sometimes spiking up, sometimes dropping—no steady baseline.”

Anaxa tilted his head. “…And? What was this reading exactly?”

“Ontological Stability.”

Cipher blinked. “That’s… a good thing, though? Literally means you existing, right? Like, congrats, you’re real?”

Mydei gave her a look, then glanced at Anaxa. “Tell her.”

Anaxa’s mouth twitched like he might agree with Cipher out of spite, but he didn’t. “She’s not entirely wrong. Ontological stability’s a metric for… continuity. Being anchored. A thing that’s stable in that sense won’t just flicker out of existence if no one’s looking. But—” His eyes narrowed slightly. “—the fluctuations matter.”

Cipher crunched a chip. “Okay, but… why would it fluctuate? Either you’re real or you’re not.”

“That’s the simple version,” Anaxa said. “Reality’s not binary when you start factoring in ontological variables. If the measurement’s moving up and down, it means…” He trailed off, searching for the right phrasing. “…It means something’s interfering with the definition of you. Actively.”

Mydei sat back against the table. “Interfering how?”

“Could be memory edits. Could be causality tampering. Could be someone rewriting your personal continuity in real time.”

Cipher frowned. “That’s—hold on. Wouldn’t you notice if someone was doing that?”

Anaxa glanced at her. “If they’re good, no. By definition, you’d only remember the current version.”

Mydei’s fingers tapped restlessly against the table. “When I was in there, the number didn’t trend up or down. It wavered. Like… they were trying to keep it in a specific range.”

Anaxa’s head tipped, considering. “Holding you below full stability keeps you permeable. Too high immediately and you’re fixed—harder to alter. Too low and you risk collapse. But a controlled middle ground? That’s a staging point. They can shape you from there, slowly increasing.”

Cipher’s brows knit. “Why the hell would anyone want that?”

Anaxa’s gaze slid back to Mydei. “Because it’s easier to graft something onto a self that isn’t fully… settled.”

The words hung there. Mydei didn’t move for a moment. Then he said, almost carefully, “And if Caenis’s endgame was a vessel—”

“They were prepping you,” Anaxa finished.

Cipher let out a low whistle. “Okay. That’s… worse than I thought.”

The three of them sat with it for a moment, the hum of the stolen generator filling the silence.

Mydei's voice was quieter when he spoke again. "So when we say 'reality' here… we're not just talking about the reality. We're talking about theirs."

Anaxa's expression darkened. "And theirs can overwrite yours."

The brass casing slipped from Mydei's hand, rolled across the table, and dropped to the floor with a faint metallic clink.

It sounded loud in the stillness.

"…Shit," he breathed.

Well, they had a plan now.

At least, on paper, it was a plan.

During the earlier discussion, everyone had been unnervingly calm, there were even moments where it almost felt like they were having a normal conversation.

Now?

It was like watching someone light a match in a room full of leaking gas.

The absence of tech, of any real network access, had finally gotten to Anaxa. He was tearing through the workbench like a man gutting a corpse for salvage—sleeves shoved up, hair sticking out at angles, eyes ringed in sleepless shadows. Dead datapads lay in pieces around him, their guts spilling wire and cracked crystal displays. He didn't so much work as he attacked each device, muttering a steady stream of half-finished curses, equations, and paranoid observations that tangled together into something just shy of coherent.

Cipher leaned toward Mydei, her voice barely above a whisper.

“…Is he—”

“Look at him,” Mydei murmured back without glancing over. “What do you think?”

As if on cue, Anaxa let out a short, high laugh. Both Cipher and Mydei winced at the sound.

Then Anaxa straightened suddenly, wrench in one hand, the other stabbing the air at Mydei like he was punctuating each syllable with violence.

“Do you get this? It’s not brainwashing. It’s *metaphysical eminent domain.* They own your plumbing. They own your reflection. Hell—” he leaned forward, teeth bared in something that wasn’t quite a smile “—they own your shadow.”

Cipher couldn’t resist. “At least they didn’t rezone him for condos.”

SLAM. The wrench hit the table so hard that a handful of screws jumped like startled insects.

“…It’s a little funny,” Mydei said after a beat.

Anaxa’s head snapped toward him, glare sharp enough to peel paint. Mydei didn’t blink. He’d found that humor, for him, had become a survival tactic. If you didn’t let the knife scare you, you could turn it into a punchline. If you could keep laughing at the dangerous things, it lost a little of its edge. Or so he kept telling himself.

“It’s horrifying,” Anaxa bit out, “and I’m fixing it.”

Cipher eyed the wreckage on the bench. “…With… broken datapads?”

Anaxa didn’t even acknowledge her, shoving a cracked casing aside to drag a soldering tool into reach.

“You can’t debug ontology,” Mydei said, more out of habit than actual belief.

Anaxa gave a quiet, almost conversational chuckle—and somehow it was worse than the manic one earlier.

“Oh, can’t I?” he murmured, not looking up. “Give me a framework, I’ll rewrite the plumbing. Give me the right lens, I’ll steal back the damn reflection. Then we’ll see who owns whose shadow.”

The generator in the corner let out a faint, uneven whine.

Cipher glanced at Mydei. “You think he’s serious?”

Mydei kept his eyes on Anaxa’s hunched back. “…Yeah. That’s the problem.”

Anaxa hadn’t stopped moving in over an hour.

The workbench wasn’t cluttered anymore—clutter implied intention. This was wreckage.

Cracked datapads lay like dissected animals, their casings gutted, copper veins exposed. Notes—half equations, half jagged diagrams—were scrawled across overlapping sheets, all curling at the edges.

He moved between the mess like a predator in a cage, muttering under his breath:

“…continuity anchors… frame persistence… lattice bleed thresholds…”

Cipher leaned against the far wall, arms crossed. She chewed the inside of her cheek, her eyes tracking him like she was waiting for him to combust.

Mydei just stood there, gaze flicking between them, unreadable as ever.

“You’re just gonna watch him grind himself into paste?” Cipher murmured.

Mydei didn’t look at her. “He’s not grinding out. He’s calibrating.”

“That what you call it?”

“It’s the sound of him convincing himself the problem’s impossible so he can’t be blamed for not solving it.”

Anaxa’s hand twitched, almost sending a tower of stripped boards to the floor.

“It *is* impossible,” he snapped without turning around, “because it’s built to be. That’s the elegance. That’s the trap.”

Cipher rolled her eyes. “Great. So we’re dead in the water unless someone has the magic phrase to snap you out of your spiral.”

Mydei pushed away from the wall. “Forget snapping him out of it. Standing here feels like watching someone drown from the shore. Anaxa. Talk to me. This ‘frame’—what is it really?”

Anaxa stopped pacing. For a second it looked like he wouldn’t answer, then:

“The quantum-locked identity frame. Imagine a deed. To you. Written into the lattice of your brain at the subatomic level. That’s your continuity anchor. Without it—” He flicked a glance at Mydei. “—you’d vanish. Not die. *Erase*.”

“So,” Mydei said slowly, “if you take it out, I pop like a soap bubble.”

“Yes. Continuity collapse. Like deleting a file, then setting the drive on fire.”

“…So make a restore point.”

“That’s not how—” Anaxa stopped mid-retort. His pupils narrowed, mind re-routing. “Wait.”

Cipher cut in before the silence could calcify. “Oh, so we just yank the plug, reboot him, and hope the operating system doesn’t blue-screen his soul?”

Anaxa opened his mouth to shut her down—but the smallest hesitation caught in his expression.

She smirked. “Or better—slip him a nice fat virus. Make him so buggy the system can’t even load him.”

It was meant as a joke. Anaxa didn’t laugh.

He went still. Not calm—predatory stillness.

“…Contaminating variable,” he murmured. “Unstable input.”

Now his attention was on the far corner—where a battered console sat under a sprawl of schematics. He was already peeling them back with quick movements, the air around him tightening.

“This isn’t *entirely* crazy,” Mydei said, stepping closer. “I already mentioned my stability reader wasn’t fixed. Maxing it immediately would’ve—“

Anaxa’s finished for him, repeating what he’d said last time with realization slowly dawning on him. “Too stable and the frame becomes self-defining. They lose the ability to overwrite you. The control depends on keeping you just unstable enough to need their definition.”

Cipher’s eyes lit. “So we shove it the other way. Make it so volatile they can’t hold the definition at all.”

“Yes.” Anaxa’s voice sharpened. “We flood the frame with instability. Force a *controlled* crash. And in the reboot cycle…” He tapped a schematic—two short, deliberate strikes. “…we seed the identity from your subconscious, not theirs.”

Mydei crossed his arms. “…That’s the ‘rewiring the plumbing’ nonsense you were on about earlier.”

Anaxa finally looked up. His smile was too exact, too dangerous to be reassuring.

“Exactly. And I’m the plumber.”

The Spire Run.

Cipher had said it offhandedly—a placeholder name for the op—but it stuck.

Fitting enough.

Anaxa and Mydei stood in the wind-shadow at the Aeon Spire's base, necks craned toward a tower so tall its crown dissolved into the sky. The haze swallowed the upper struts entirely. From here, it wasn't clear if the cloud cover was natural or projected—the Spire generated its own microclimate, after all.

It wasn't exactly beautiful. More… unsettling. The structure had the anatomy of something that grew instead of being built, a skeletal lattice wrapped in mirrored skin that flexed faintly, as if breathing. When the surface caught the city lights, they slid and warped like reflections in a disturbed pool.

Anaxa's walkie gave a dry crackle. "Action."

Across the city, Cipher's voice came back with a yawn. **"Yes, sir."**

Mydei snorted faintly at that and fell into step behind him as Anaxa moved off the edge of the observation platform, under the first support strut's looming shadow. The air shifted here—unnervingly still, scrubbed of any grit or scent.

"You're still sure splitting the list was smart?" Mydei's voice was serious now, all business. "We could've run all three targets together, kept mutual cover."

"Three operators on three objectives is wasted precision," Anaxa said without looking back. His gaze traced the Spire's support lattice like he could see the circuitry under the panels. "One ghost for the soft grabs. Two for the hard one. Division of labor."

The mirrored skin above shimmered. Mydei's eyes caught on it—the skyline behind them fractured into liquid distortions.

"Metamaterial sheath," Anaxa murmured, catching where Mydei was looking. "It modulates transparency based on clearance level. At street height, you see a shiny weather tower. Above the third strut, it's a perfect mirror unless you're Council-tagged."

"And we're not Council-tagged," Mydei said.

A thin smile. "Not yet."

The walkie cut in again cheerfully. **"For the record, if this goes sideways, I'm selling your faceprint to the blacknet."**

Anaxa thumbed a response without missing a step. "You'd get a fortune. Stay on task."

Mydei's glance flicked to the slim device in Anaxa's coat. "Still not seeing why we start here instead of—"

"Because the Quantum Entropy Generator doesn't leave the Spire without collapsing into useless slag." Anaxa's tone was patient, but edged. "Vault Theta—six sublevels down—is the only place it stays coherent. We get it first by physically tweaking it or the rest doesn't matter."

"And it does…?"

"It blinds them," Anaxa said simply. "Drowns their predictive computation in quantum noise until the surveillance net can't tell a shadow from a body. It's like—" he drew a small shape in the air, "—dropping ink into clear water. Every model, every probability map, turns to static. For you…" His eyes met Mydei's. "…it makes your ontological frame too unstable for them to lock."

Mydei's mouth tightened. "So step one in evicting them from my head."

"Step one," Anaxa confirmed, "and the hardest to touch without waking every containment protocol they've got. Which is why Cipher's running the

other grabs solo—she’s fast enough to ghost through the sweeps.”

“The other grabs being—?”

“Neural Interface Rig,” Anaxa said, ticking it off like a grocery list. “Direct, unmonitored link between generator and stabilizer. Without it, every transmission screams for attention.”

“And the stabilizer.”

“Biochemical anchor,” Anaxa said. “Locks your metaphysical substrate to your biology during the counter-intrusion. Without it, the ‘de-ownership’ could crack your mind or leave you an empty shell.”

They paused in the lee of an angled girder.

Mydei exhaled slowly. Even talking about these types of components was illegal—the kind of illegal that triggered retroactive sweeps.

The walkie crackled again—Cipher, voice low now. **“Rig secured. Stabilizer next.”**

Anaxa clicked his tongue in approval, turning to Mydei.

“You ready?”

Mydei’s reply came slowly. “You’re the one with the map. I’m here to make sure you don’t redraw it halfway through.”

Anaxa’s grin was razor-thin. “Redrawing it is the fun part. Move.”

They slipped deeper into the Spire’s understructure, vanishing into the gleam and shadow beneath its mirrored skin—where the city’s reflection bent and broke into ghosts.

Anaxa walked ahead, hands buried in his jacket pockets, eyes skimming the converging cross-corridors as if he were counting them. His pace was easy, but his gaze kept tally—people, cameras, angles where the wall’s light broke into shadows.

“They rotate crews every forty-eight hours,” he said without looking back. “Means Level Seven’s swapping half their techs this morning. And we happen to be two of them.”

Mydei closed the gap between them, voice low. “We happen to be?”

Anaxa’s mouth curved—something between a smirk and a blade being sharpened. “Already in the system. Nexel Safety Compliance, Secondary Division. You’re a maintenance subcontractor. I sign your clearances. Both of us just came off a contract in Sector C.”

“And if someone’s actually from C?”

“They’re not,” Anaxa said, tone flat. “Sector C’s mid-refit. Everyone stuck there is on respirators, babysitting pressure valves, and praying the scrubbers don’t choke. Nobody pulls a double to come here.”

The floor under them shifted from ribbed composite to smoother alloy plating as they followed the corridor’s slow curve. Overhead, a strip of conduit lighting hummed, spilling a tired, bluish glow on the brushed steel walls. The air smelled faintly ionized—circulators nearby.

They reached a junction where the noise thickened: the murmur of voices, the clank of gear against metal, the hiss of a decompression valve somewhere out of sight. The corridor widened into a service concourse—a rectangular space with an equipment rack down one side and a datawall scrolling maintenance alerts in orange text, each tagged with a sector code and urgency rating. Six or seven techs in grey jackets clustered in twos and threes, talking over each other in clipped bursts:

“…intake valves still tripping after the flush…”
“…filters running hot again…”
“…get the Phase 4 kit loaded before—”

Anaxa slowed just before the threshold, letting a genuine crewman with a heavy tool harness pass them. “Rule one,” he murmured, almost conversational. “Don’t walk in. Walk with.”

He matched his stride to the man’s, letting the crewman’s body language carry him forward into the knot of workers. Mydei fell in half a step behind, close enough that anyone glancing over would assume they’d been part of the same group since the last checkpoint.

A stocky woman with oil smears up both sleeves noticed them first. Her eyes flicked over Mydei’s jacket, then to Anaxa. “New?”

“Transfer from C,” Anaxa said easily. “Safety compliance sweep on your calibration run.”

She groaned in recognition. “Another one? Last week we lost twenty minutes to—”

“Not me,” Anaxa cut in. “If I’m doing it right, you won’t even remember I was here.”

That won a shrug. She turned back to a debate with another tech about whether the new venting firmware was worth the downtime. The noise and motion closed around them, masking their presence better than silence could.

Anaxa brushed Mydei’s sleeve in passing—light enough to be mistaken for nothing.

We’re in.

The knot of workers funneled toward the platform doors, boots scuffing paint that had been worn to bare steel in places. White stenciling on the deck—**T-5 →** with a stylized chevron—pointed the way to the tram line. Beyond the marking, the platform stretched like a hanging balcony built into the understructure’s ribs, the drop below hidden in shadows.

Overhead, a magline track glinted like a taut black vein, vanishing into a dim vertical throat above.

Somewhere in the queue, a tech in a grease-darkened jacket glanced up from his tablet and grumbled, “Vent B-ninety-four’s still out of alignment.

If I have to hear that seal rattle the whole way up, I’m shoving my head through it.”

Anaxa didn’t miss a step. “He’ll check it,” he said, jerking his chin toward him.

Mydei looked up, slow and flat, but the rest of the crew had already stepped aside to give him space.

“Make it fast,” the tech called over his shoulder, already moving on to a rant about cold drafts in the upper tiers.

Mydei crouched by the wall grille. His fingertips worked the frame like he was checking for warping, but his other hand slipped a coin-sized disc under the lip. Through his glove came a faint vibration—security mesh was old-model, the sensor loops staggered enough to leave neat, predictable blind spots. He traced the gaps with his gaze, fixing them to memory.

Anaxa loitered just beside him. A passing crewman gave him a brief nod, so Anaxa threw him a tired half-smile.

“They ever roll out that intake patch?” he asked, casual. It was quite uncanny seeing Anaxa act like this, Mydei shuddered slightly.

The man barked a short laugh. “Patch? We’re still nursing those vents by hand. Whoever greenlit the last firmware deserves a week in the trash compactor.”

Anaxa sighed. “Save me the trouble and I’ll nominate them myself.”

The man chuckled and moved on, pulled away by someone shouting from farther up the line.

Mydei stood, dusting off his gloves. “Seal’s fine,” he reported, for anyone listening.

“Good enough,” Anaxa said, already steering them toward the boarding queue. “Grab the seven-mil from the bay before we move.” The words were

easy, the tone light—but the subtle angle of his hand pointed Mydei toward a side corridor. On the schematics, that path skirted the service elevator bay.

The tram arrived with a sigh of pistons. It clung to the magline above like a silver fish to a hook, plating scored from years of freight runs. The narrow windows were layered with impact film, more for the crew's peace of mind than actual safety.

Inside was all brushed metal and industrial efficiency: fold-down perches, standing grips, and wall-mounted consoles lit with dim amber readouts. The air smelled faintly ionized.

The floor gave a muted thud as the clamps took hold, and then the car slid upward. Outside the windows, the view shifted from the platform's shadow to the cavernous crossbeams above.

The tram shuddered over a junction. Somewhere far below, the echo of dropped metal rang up the shaft, swallowed again by the hum.

Anaxa kept his hands in his pockets, gaze on the window slits, but his focus was on the sound of the crew.

Eventually , the car eased to a halt on a mid-tier platform. Doors hissed open. Most of the crew filed out without slowing, boots clanging on grated decking.

Anaxa didn't follow right away. He let a few go ahead, then stepped out with Mydei at his shoulder, slowly separating from the group.

The elevator bay was to the left, guarded by a man in a pale vest leaning lazily on a waist-high barrier. To the right, corridors branched into the maintenance maze, each stenciled with sector codes.

Anaxa's voice was quiet. "Thirty seconds."

Mydei peeled off, posture still that of someone sent for a tool. His thumb brushed the seam of his jacket, waking the disruptor disc. Two turns later,

he found the dead corridor—dust hanging in its still air—and pressed the disc to a conduit plate.

A soft chirp. A slow red blink on a far sensor.

Back on the platform, the guard's earpiece crackled. He muttered, pushed off the barrier, and walked off toward the fault, vanishing behind the first corner.

Anaxa's mouth twitched into the smallest smile. "Bingo."

Anaxa's fingers slipped under the coil of black polymer at his belt. The leapfrog card clone sat in his palm, no bigger than a stick of gum, and just as unremarkable—except it was about to impersonate an executive keycard for exactly sixty-three seconds. He pressed it to the reader like he was swatting away a fly. A muted chime, a green diode blink—his timer started ticking down.

63.00.

"Politeness is optional," he muttered, jerking his chin toward the doors.

Inside, the lift was all cold light and thin metal—less of a passenger space, more of a cargo vein running down into the Spire's gut. Mydei had one step inside before Anaxa yanked his arm hard enough to make him stumble.

The doors sealed them in. The hum of distant turbines rolled through the walls like a constant, low drumbeat. Mydei's eyes tracked the sliver of open shaft at the far panel's edge—a dizzying drop disappearing into strobed shadows.

"Keep staring, and you'll start imagining what it feels like to fall," Anaxa said without looking up.

Mydei snorted. "Not planning on finding out."

Anaxa popped the control panel with a practiced flick, exposing a layered mess of fiber lines and armored circuit boards. From a side pouch, he pulled something that looked halfway between a pocketknife and a detonator.

“This is me,” he said, slotting the device in—a physical key injector, feeding a rapid sequence of authentication spoofs directly into the lift’s onboard system. “You—” He pointed to a panel flush with the wall. “Behind that is a mechanical failover. Pressure sensor in front, rotary lock behind. You let go, the panel slams shut, we start over.”

“Sounds fun,” Mydei said, pressing in until the panel clicked. He found the lock’s ridged edge with his fingertips and began to turn. “So, what’s the plan if sixty-three seconds runs out?”

“Pray,” Anaxa said flatly, eyes on the injector’s scrolling debug feed.

HANDSHAKE // BYPASS LAYER-1 // GOV-LOCK ACCESS
AUTHCHAIN: INJECTOR -> LIFT OS -> FAILOVER

The timer hit **12.09.**

“Mydei—”

“Yeah, I can feel it tightening,” Mydei said. “You’ve got maybe ten.”

Anaxa’s hand darted to pull a micro-bridge cable from his teeth, clipping it across two live nodes. The lights overhead flickered, the hum deepened. Then—

The floor dropped. Gravity went light, the air rushing past them as the lift tore downward. Mydei bent his knees automatically, back braced to the wall while Anaxa’s grip went white-knuckled on the panel edge.

The freefall ended just as violently. Anaxa’s head almost met the wall; he swore in something guttural and untranslatable.

“This lift’s a disgrace to engineering,” he hissed.

“Yeah, no kidding,” Mydei said, pulling him away as the doors creaked open.

The hallway beyond was sterile, empty—and alive with security. Ceiling-mounted camera domes swept in precise arcs, laser sensors flaring faintly at

knee height. Mydei moved first, dragging Anaxa into the shadows of a wall support.

“Fourteen-second sweeps,” he murmured. “We move on the blind.”

They ghosted through in bursts—five steps, freeze, shift again—keeping to architectural blind spots until they reached an unmarked, reinforced door. Mydei started to pass it until Anaxa’s elbow caught him in the ribs.

“This one.”

They ran.

The impact against the crash bar swung it open into a wall of freezing air. Breath crystallized instantly, the temperature drop sharp enough to sting exposed skin.

“Welcome,” Anaxa said through chattering teeth, “to Vault Theta.”

The chamber beyond spread out like a cathedral to refrigeration—rows of frost-rimmed containment units stretching into the dark, each one humming faintly, each one locked behind its own layer of cold.

Mydei blinked against the glare, scanning the aisles. It was… grand, yes, but not in the way he’d expected. For something meant to house one of the most volatile devices under Council control, there was no ostentatious shielding, no palace-like sanctum. Just industrial frost and steel. Function over theatre.

“…That was easy,” he murmured.

“What?”

“This feels too easy.” His head tilted slightly, as if tuning his ear for alarms or the faint footstep of an approaching guard. Nothing.

Anaxa’s brows drew together, but Mydei was already wandering forward, fingers tracing the cold glass of a containment unit. “Never mind. You know what to do from here?”

There was a pause before Anaxa nodded. “We should be done in less than ten minutes.”

“That fast?” Mydei’s gaze stayed on the frosted etchings of a serial number. “No wonder Phainon could clear so many zones in a night.”

That name lingered in the air like condensation. Anaxa’s steps slowed, voice quieter. “…You’re taking that better than I thought you would.”

Mydei stopped mid-stride. For a moment, his profile was unreadable. Then a small, almost weightless laugh escaped him. “…Trust me. I’m not.” The humor didn’t touch his eyes. He moved on before the words could settle, tone brisk again. “Come on.”

Anaxa said nothing—just followed.

The generator lay at the aisle’s far end, a thing out of place in the utilitarian cold. A dense cylinder, wrapped in layered crystal cores that rotated in slow, hypnotic arcs inside a mag-lev cradle. The light bent faintly around it, its edges refusing to stay fixed.

Anaxa crouched, gloves brushing frost from anchor housings. “Drop it, and we’re dead in three dimensions.”

“Reassuring,” Mydei muttered, kneeling opposite.

The process was surgical. Anaxa clipped copper-gallium clamps to each resonance anchor, their tiny status LEDs pulsing in rhythm with the generator’s hum as they mimicked the frequency signature. The vibration passed faintly through the floor and into Mydei’s knees.

His task was the physical half—unbolting cold-sealed mag-cradle locks, the metal reluctant to turn under the bite of subzero air. Every movement had to be steady; release the pressure too quickly, and the anchor field could snap back with enough force to shear the cylinder in half.

The final lock gave with a brittle crack. Frost hissed into the air as Anaxa’s tools worked seams along the crystalline casing. The shell split open like a

geode, revealing a smaller, denser core no longer than Mydei's forearm, its surface veined with fine latticework that glowed faintly from within.

"This is it?" Mydei's breath fogged the space between them.

"This is what matters." Anaxa slid it into a padded, insulated case, sealing it with a magnetic clasp.

No alarms. No klaxons. Just the hum of refrigeration.

Mydei exhaled, rubbing his hands together for warmth. "I'm assuming we're not taking the tram back."

"Originally, yes. But…" Anaxa's gaze unfocused briefly, running calculations. "…it's probably compromised."

"Then try this." Mydei leaned against the cradle's frame. "Garbage lift to sublevel waste filtration. Maintenance pod to the neutral-sector hydroplant. Then we cross into the outer sector on foot—there's an old skywalk. Unlit, but it's still standing."

Anaxa blinked at him. For the first time all night, a small, genuine laugh broke from him. "You truly are a delight, Mydeimos. No wonder I never wanted to kill you when you'd visited the university."

Mydei smirked faintly. "So that's a yes?"

"Of course." Anaxa slung the carry-case strap over his shoulder, the generator's weight settling against his back. "Let's move."

By the time they reached the rust-stained safehouse, Mydei's calves burned from the wind shear across the skywalk and the harness had carved neat grooves into his shoulders. He stretched his arms overhead, rolling the ache from his neck, and glanced at Anaxa, who was busy flexing his hands.

"When do you think Cipher's gonna—"

"—Now. Glad to hear you missed me."

The voice came from deeper in the warehouse, loud enough to echo. Cipher stepped into view between two stacked pallets, hair wind-tangled, eyes half-lidded. In one hand, a bag; in the other, an exaggerated yawn.

“Next time,” she said, tossing the bag onto the nearest table with a satisfying *thunk*, “someone else gets to play fetch.”

The contents clinked together—metal on polymer. Mydei caught a glimpse of the Neural Face Rig’s carbon-fiber jaw frame and the matte-white capsule of the Biochemical Stabilizer as Cipher unzipped the bag and nudged it toward Anaxa.

She tapped the capsule like she was testing if it was ripe. “Can we start?”

Anaxa didn’t answer—already pulling the components toward himself. He hummed low, a tune without melody, hands moving with the precision of someone disarming a bomb. The rig’s microfilament contacts got an inspection under his portable scanner; any speck of debris could scramble skin conduction mapping. He linked the rig’s spinal tether to the stabilizer’s socket, waited for the amber LED blink, then slid a wafer-thin bridge module between them.

“That’s your translator,” he murmured. “Tells your cortex and blood chemistry to shake hands. Without it, you’re signing both death certificates.”

Mydei leaned back in the chair, watching him. “So the fun part’s next.”

Anaxa’s mouth twitched. “Fun’s one word for it.”

He peeled the protective backing from the jaw frame’s contact pads. The adhesive was laced with hair-thin microcapillaries—each ready to draw blood samples the moment the rig came online. He fixed the frame snugly over Mydei’s lower face, pivot arms locking at the temples. Next came the stabilizer: a narrow polymer cuff clasped around Mydei’s wrist, its underside riddled with injectors fine enough to pierce skin without a mark. It looked like an oversized watch until Anaxa slid in the synth-serum

cartridge. The cuff chirped, and green text scrolled: ***Buffering metabolic interface…***

“When this kicks in,” Anaxa said, tightening the last fastener, “you’ll feel heat in your jaw, down your spine, then it’ll build in your skull. Don’t fight it. Eyes open.”

The first wave was almost gentle—warmth blooming under the jaw pads, the way sunlight soaks through a window. Then it spread backward along the skull’s base, trickling into his spine. Mydei kept his breathing steady. He’d done worse. He wasn’t going to flinch.

Anaxa adjusted dials, smooth and unhurried. “Pushing cortical sync rate in half-hertz jumps. Too slow, it drags; too fast, it tears.”

The warmth grew heavy. Pressure gathered in the back of Mydei’s head, patient and immovable. He gripped the ground, knuckles pale, and focused on not letting the muscles in his jaw twitch. Sweat prickled his hairline. The warehouse air felt thinner, like it was being rationed.

Cipher leaned on the table, watching. “He’s turning red.”

“It’s vasodilation,” Anaxa replied. “Stabilizer’s hitting target.”

The pressure edged into ache. Mydei kept his gaze level, refusing to blink more than necessary.

“Ten seconds,” Anaxa said, adjusting a fine-tune slider.

Nine. Eight. The ache thickened, flooding the inside of his skull. Six. Five. His pulse thudded in his ears. Four. The whole room narrowed to heat and noise and the stubborn line of his jaw. Three—

White static ripped across his vision, then cleared so sharply it felt like breathing after being underwater too long. He jerked upright, the tether snapping taut.

Cipher’s hand landed on his shoulder. “Easy, champ.”

He kept his eyes shut, riding the last waves of pain until they dissolved into something feather-light. His shoulders loosened. Breath left him slow.

Then the lightness tilted—slid—into euphoria. His head tipped back, and his lips curved in the faintest smile.

"…Is he dead?" Cipher asked.

"No," Anaxa said, running a check.

For a beat, Mydei didn't move. Then after a moment, he sat up with perfect calm. Cipher exhaled. "So it's all fine now?"

"Yes," Anaxa said, then hesitated. "…But—"

Cipher gave him a look. "But what—"

Mydei cut in dreamily. "You ever notice if you put your heads together, you'd look like a really judgmental owl? Like… one of those ones that runs a post office."

Cipher blinked. Once. Twice.

Anaxa, completely straight-faced, nodded. "Yes. I see it."

Cipher turned on him. "…Is he high?"

"Extremely. Keep him talking."

Mydei smiled at them both, eyes half-lidded. "You're all… glowing. Like bread… in a toaster… right before it's *perfect*."

Cipher covered her face with both hands. "We risked our lives so he could become a kitchen appliance critic."

"Let's get back on topic."

Mydei slouched deep into the chair, limbs loose and head tipped back like the ceiling might start telling him secrets. His pupils were blown wide, tracking invisible things in the air.

Cipher leaned on the table beside him, chin in one hand. “Two fingers—how many?”

“Seven,” he answered without hesitation.

Anaxa, crouched behind the rig’s housing, didn’t even glance up from the tangle of cables. “His math’s fine. His vision isn’t.”

Cipher hummed, satisfied. “Figures. Math’s always been crap anyway.”

Mydei’s mouth curved. “I can multiply… sometimes.”

“That,” Anaxa murmured, “isn’t the flex you think it is.” He made a final adjustment, then sat back on his heels. “Here’s the situation—he’ll stabilize in forty-three minutes. For now he’s metabolically hypersensitive. Keep him seated. No bright lights. No sudden movements. Neural mesh is still settling—push too hard and we risk seizures or cognitive skips.”

Cipher straightened a little. “I’m not about to start juggling flares over him.”

“Good,” Anaxa said. “And avoid loud noises. His auditory cortex is spiking—everything will sound amplified.”

Mydei turned his head toward her. “Anyone else hear that humming?”

“That’s your bloodstream,” Anaxa replied without missing a beat.

“Or your brain leaking,” Cipher offered.

He considered that, nodding slowly. “Nice. Feels fizzy.”

Cipher shook her head, chuckling. “You’re a mess.”

“Shiny mess,” Mydei corrected, squinting up at her hair. “Your head’s got twelve little suns… but they’re arguing.”

Anaxa’s eyes narrowed a fraction, but he didn’t look up. “Hypersensitive,” he repeated, like the word itself was a verdict.

They fell into a rhythm—Anaxa explaining, Cipher poking, Mydei wandering off into miniature hallucinations—until a faint *thunk* in the distance threaded itself into the warehouse’s usual creaks. Neither Anaxa nor Cipher reacted at first.

The second sound—soft metal groan, somewhere high above—made Cipher’s weight shift almost imperceptibly to the balls of her feet. Her gaze flicked past Anaxa’s shoulder, then settled there.

Mydei tilted his head in the same direction. “That’s not my blood, right?”

No answer.

The air seemed thicker now, carrying a low vibration just on the edge of hearing. Anaxa’s hands slowed over the rig controls.

“Probably nothing,” he said, though his tone had lost some of its certainty.

Cipher didn’t move.

Mydei broke the quiet with, “Does anyone smell toast? Like, toast that’s… weird?”

Anaxa started to reply, then caught the fact Cipher still hadn’t looked away from whatever she’d locked onto. Her hand hovered near the knife at her hip.

“Cipher?” he said.

No answer.

He stepped closer, brows drawn, and began to reach for her shoulder—

—she moved in a blur, grabbing his jacket and yanking him hard to her side.

An instant later, an armor-piercing round tore through where his head had been, shredding roof plating before punching into the concrete floor with a brutal, echoing crack. A thin cloud of dust unfurled from the hole, drifting down in slow spirals.

Silence.

Anaxa was frozen mid-breath, eyes fixed on the crater.

The vibration came again, louder this time—low mechanical hum swelling under the faint whine of something airborne.

Cipher's voice cut through, sharp and cold. "Up. Now."

Mydei blinked, sluggish but unbothered. "Is this… the part where we get blendered?"

Neither answered.

Outside, the hum split into layers—the rapid pulse of drones riding over the heavier thrum of tiltrotors. The warehouse's rusted siding trembled faintly in their wash.

Then the loudspeaker crackled to life, voice amplified into a cold, procedural rhythm:

[Attention, occupants of this facility. This is the Council's Central Intervention Unit. You are surrounded. Lay down all weapons immediately, step into the open with hands visible. Noncompliance will be met with lethal force.]

The words seemed to hang in the air after the speaker clicked off.

"…Fuck," Anaxa muttered.

Cipher was already moving, sweeping her bag from the table and scanning every angle between them and the exit. She hooked an arm under Mydei's and pulled him up with practiced efficiency. "Well?" she shot over her shoulder at Anaxa. "You listening?"

He clicked his tongue but fell in behind her, eyes still on the bullet hole.

Mydei stumbled along, mumbling with quiet conviction, "Don't touch the suns. They bite when they're scared."

Five minutes. That's all Cipher's trick had bought them.

"No one saw us leave," she'd said, back in the safehouse. And for those five glorious minutes, reality nodded along. Guards glanced past them. Cameras lost interest. Even the air felt like it had somewhere else to be.

But the lie was fraying now—he could feel it in the way the city's eyes were back on them.

The first siren confirmed it.

Anaxa took the stairs two at a time, scanning every bend in the railing. "Eyes back on us. Patrol drones, five o'clock."

Cipher hauled Mydei up the last steps before his boots could eat each other. "Stay vertical."

Mydei's brain was drifting somewhere between lucid thought and confetti. Whatever the Council had dosed him with sloshed through his head like bad liquor. "The walls are breathing," he announced. A beat later: "Anaxa, your hair's on fire—wait. No, just ugly."

Anaxa didn't even look back. He just smacked him in the head on his way past.

They burst through the roof access door into a blade of cold wind. The rooftop stretched uneven and cluttered—vent housings, glass skylights,

antenna arrays buzzing with static. Beyond the ledge, the city's administrative crown rose in mirrored spires, moonlight glinting off their faces like a warning.

The sky was worse.

Six quad-rotor drones banked toward them from different angles, shock-net launchers twitching in their undercarriages. From far below, shouts rode the wind upward—a vertical echo between the concrete cliffs. Somewhere out there, a Council gunship's running lights pulsed like a slow heartbeat.

"High ground," Anaxa said, already moving.

They clambered over a rattling maintenance scaffold, then up a narrow ladder bolted into the wall. Cipher dragged Mydei after her, his boots scraping sparks off the metal. The air up here stank of scorched copper—probably from the east-side Administration vent towers.

A net sang past Anaxa's shoulder, fizzing as it snagged an antenna.

They kept moving—leaping narrow gaps, ducking under guy wires, skirting skylights that flashed quick glimpses of the world below: rows of identical desks under pale strip-lights, Council clerks hammering keys without ever looking up.

Another siren wailed from somewhere deeper in the district. Mydei, still half gone, lifted a lazy wave at a drone overhead. "No autographs today!"

"Shut up," Anaxa snapped, eyes locked on the next jump. Rain-slick ledge—half-second slowdown—half a second too long.

A net slammed into the roof in front of Cipher, hissing open like a metal flower. She vaulted it clean, catching Mydei's sleeve before he could step right into it.

One more jump—then they landed hard on a wide, flat rooftop. Too wide. Too exposed.

"Fuck."

Drones spread in from one side, their shadows crawling over the tar. From the other, two gunships crept closer, rotor wash peeling grit and paper across the roof.

Cipher scanned the edges: sheer drop. Only one visible exit—a yawning ventilation shaft.

“We could go down,” she offered.

Anaxa didn’t even glance at it. “Not dying in a tin coffin.”

Boots pounded up the roof access, rifles raised. Gunship spotlights cut across the three of them.

Anaxa’s gaze shifted to Mydei. “We jump, or we’re caught.”

Mydei blinked at him, nodding with all the gravity in the world. “Falling’s just flying… if you think about it.”

The wind pulled at their clothes. The sirens blurred into a dull tunnel-hum. For a moment, they just stood there, three silhouettes against the bright steel of the district.

Anaxa’s voice dropped. “We’ll make it.”

A pause.

“I’ll make sure of it.”

Cipher exhaled, patting them both—quick, grounding. “Ready?”

The drones tightened their circle. The gunship’s shadow swallowed the roof.

They leapt.

Mydei went first, laughing, a streak of pale and dark flung into open air. Cipher followed in one arc, boots scraping the ledge before she vanished after him. Anaxa was last, a shadow breaking away from the roofline.

The drop bit at them immediately. Air rushed hard against Mydei's face, roared past his ears, tore at his clothes until every seam felt loose. The building behind fell away faster than he could think about it. His stomach hung somewhere above.

He didn't fight it. He let the fall take him, weightless and untethered, a body drawn toward gravity's quiet certainty.

The skyline tilted back, and then there was nothing but sky.

He tipped his head up. His hand lifted without asking him first, reaching toward the constellations as if they'd drift a little closer if he asked nicely enough. Stars spun slow in the dark, clean and sharp as cut glass—no city haze to dull them. The moon lingered low and round, a pale coin in the dark.

It had been a beautiful night. The kind of night you could get lost staring at without minding if you never found your way back. He let that thought sit, slow and warm in his chest, the air's bite softening to something almost gentle.

Somewhere in the rush, something else threaded in—faint at first, so soft he thought it was his ears playing tricks on him.

A violin.

One pure note held long enough to tremble, then another. Slow bow strokes, deliberate. Mydei closed his eyes, and the city, the shouts from above, even the fall—all of it slipped back.

The music was patient. Each note stretched so far it felt like it might snap, and when the next came it was like an exhale he didn't know he'd been waiting for.

He thought of the way the moon seemed to watch the city tonight. Of how the stars looked like they'd been spilled there just for him. Somewhere in that soft haze of sound and air and sky, he realized he missed the sun.

He didn’t mean it as poetry, he meant it plainly.

The violin’s tempo edged forward, heartbeat-quick now. The threads of sound pulled tighter.

And then—everything above them stopped.

The drones froze mid-flight, each one rigid in the air, as if the whole night had been put on pause. Light spilled erratically from their frames, twitching and flaring.

A harsh, metallic scream ripped out from them in unison, stabbing the air with feedback sharp enough to make his teeth ache. Mydei flinched. The drones dropped all at once, heavy metal bodies hitting pavement far below. Floodlights blinked out one by one, leaving the street in cold shadow.

The air felt bigger now. Too big.

Something moved below—fast, thin arcs of light tearing upward from the dark. Gold, but almost alive in the way they curved and twisted.

They reached Cipher first, winding around her torso like ribbons, slowing her descent until she hung suspended, swaying gently. Another coil swept around Anaxa, halting his fall in a more violent, albeit still gentle catch.

Relief loosened Mydei’s shoulders. Good. They’d be fine.

The threads arced toward him next. He shut his eyes again, letting the thought settle in. He could still hear the violin, steady, certain.

The gold touched—

—and convulsed.

The glow shattered into static, flickering between blinding white and nothing at all. In a violent recoil, the threads snapped away from him, retreating back into the dark like something had driven them off.

He barely had time to be confused before the world slammed back into him.

Not gold this time—arms.

A body intercepted his fall from below, the impact a bone-deep jolt. The hold was unyielding, ice-cold through his clothes, crushing in its grip—enough to bruise, enough to hurt.

And yet—he didn't pull away.

The cold felt like something solid to hold on to. He leaned into it, eyes still closed, breathing slow into the space between them.

When he finally opened his eyes—

The face above him was ghost-pale, eyes wide and empty. And then—something broke.

Shock. Relief so sharp it bordered on madness. Guilt, and the kind of desperate joy that made his breath hitch.

The hand at his back trembled violently. His mouth opened—no words at first, just the sound of breath catching, breaking—and then, hoarse, "… Mydei?"

It sounded like a prayer he hadn't believed would be answered.

A smile tugged faint at Mydei's mouth—tired, almost lazy in its quiet acceptance. He shut his eyes again and pressed closer, until there was nothing between them but the cold and the hold and the sound of the other's heartbeat against his ear.

He had found his sun it seems.

Mydei's head was still tipped against the shoulder that held him.

The chill seeped through his cheek, but the arms around him were solid in a way that told him they weren't about to let go. Not even when the impact of their fall had faded.

Breath touched the top of his hair, uneven, ragged in a way that spoke more of disbelief than exertion. Mydei could feel it in the faint tremor under his temple, the way every muscle in that hold seemed caught between crushing and cradling him.

He tilted his chin up. Slowly—like lifting his head through water—his vision sharpened on the face above him.

The eyes were too wide. Fixed on him like he might vanish.

“You look like Phainon,” Mydei murmured. His voice slurred faintly around the edges, his thoughts a little frayed. Then, after a pause long enough to almost forget the first words—soft, almost amused: “Oh. You are Phainon.”

The name hit the air like an explosion in silence.

The grip on him tightened, painfully now, enough to push a faint sound from his throat.

The man’s mouth worked once, twice, as if language had momentarily deserted him.

“Mydeimos—”

It broke halfway out, almost a stutter, but not from hesitation.

He said it again, lower this time, and it scraped raw: “Mydei—”

The name cracked like he’d been holding it in for years.

Glass. That’s what his eyes were made of right now—glassy in a way strangers might take for calculation, but Mydei knew better. Knew he was watching a man actively wrestle tears down with sheer force of will.

Before he could answer, before the half-smile forming on his lips could settle—

A voice cut through the alley, quiet but clear as crystal.

“Did you get him?”

It didn’t belong here, its echo threading through the dead air like it had been waiting for this silence.

“…Hysilens?”

The name slid out before he could catch it. Mydei craned his neck, blinking toward the shadows.

She emerged like she’d been there all along, violin still in hand, bow suspended midair. The pale gleam of the wood caught in the faint light, and her expression barely concealed the way her eyes tracked him first.

Another figure followed.

He already knew who it was before even getting a proper look.

Aglaea.

Her hair caught what little light there was, threads of gold weaving in the dim. The faint shimmer of the threads still faded around her fingers as her gaze swept over him—not fast, not slow. Just precise, cataloguing every detail like she was trying to reconcile it against memory. Her face was the same cool, unshakable calm she’d worn for every Council meeting and negotiation, but there was something taut beneath it. A tension that wasn’t hostility—more like a tether that had been straining too long and had just, without her permission, gone slack.

The violin’s last note faded into the air between them. Hysilens hummed it under her breath, lowering her bow.

“I’ve kept my side of the bargain,” she said, and this time her gaze sharpened on Mydei, the words thinning like glass. “…and more, it seems.” Then, to the man holding him: “He’s yours.”

Phainon laughed once—a short, fractured sound that didn’t know whether it wanted to be a sob or a breath. He pulled Mydei in, so close now the world outside his chest might as well not exist.

Mydei let his head rest fully against him, heavy-lidded, catching the uneven rhythm of his breathing.

From the corner of his vision, movement—Anaxa, standing with an expression that could slice through steel, gaze fixed on Aglaea and then flicking to Hysilens. The air between those two was a drawn wire, humming with tension only they could hear.

“Careful,” Mydei mumbled, wriggling faintly. “You’ll squish me.”

That earned him another sound from Phainon—not quite a laugh, not quite sane—his head bowing over Mydei’s hair, the edges of disbelief fraying into something perilously close to joy.

Cipher, still pale and leaning on Aglaea for support, gave Anaxa a look that plainly said *don’t start*. He didn’t return it—his focus stayed locked where it had been.

Phainon’s attention shifted toward Aglaea—no, not her. Past her.

“Professor…”

The word barely made it out, cracking halfway.

Anaxa’s expression didn’t shift.

“If you’re about to apologize,” he said evenly, “don’t.”

Silence dropped like another body into the alley.

Then—

A gunshot.

The sound tore through the stillness, loud enough to make Mydei’s mind briefly clear. Nobody moved. Nobody except Aglaea.

She lifted her fingers an inch.

The bullet froze midair as string caught it—spun with a tortured screech of metal—and then hit the ground in a mangled knot.

Hysilens exhaled, bow still in hand. “Pests.”

She adjusted her stance, the bow rising—but then she hesitated. Her gaze flicked to Aglaea.

Mydei had seen Aglaea stop more chaos than this with a single sentence with her presence alone. He expected that here.

Instead:

“No need.”

The words landed heavier than they should have. Even Anaxa’s gaze broke for a fraction of a second.

“I’ve had enough of the Council’s deceit,” Aglaea said. Her tone was eloquent, but under it was an edge like a blade drawn deliberately slow. “And enough of their arrogance. I intend to… correct that personally.”

A pause.

And for the first time, Hysilens smiled. A small, flickering thing—but it sharpened her whole face.

“I thought you’d changed,” she murmured. “Seems you haven’t.”

“…How would you know?” Aglaea’s voice was quiet, but it closed the space between them like a door shutting in someone’s face.

Hysilens didn’t answer after that. After a beat, her expression smoothed again. “Let’s take care of them first.”

Mydei shifted faintly in Phainon’s arms, eyes going a little bright in their haze. “I’ve decided,” he said solemnly, “I’m king now. King of Castrum Kremnos.”

Cipher groaned at the mention of that restaurant. “Oh no.”

“You,” Mydei announced, pointing lazily up at Phainon, “are my shining white knight. Go smite the goons.” He giggled uncharacteristically, entirely pleased with himself.

Cipher stretched, muttering, “I’ll explain later.”

Phainon blinked, like his mind had short-circuited just a little from the whiplash, and then let out a short, breathless chuckle that still had something dangerous and slightly unhinged under it. “…Yeah. Of course. Yeah.”

Farther down the street, a Council enforcer shouted something. The voice broke mid-sentence—glitched into static—then silence.

Hysilens didn’t look up. “Not bad,” she commented, and then the bow came down on strings again, the first slow note blooming into the air.

They didn’t stand a chance in the first place.

He couldn’t say when he lost hold of the moment. Somewhere between the shouts and the crashing floodlights, between the violin’s phantom echo and the plunge of vertigo, his mind blurred into static. When thought returned in fragments, it was only to impressions: Hysilens, sword unsheathed for once, moving with precision as she carved a path toward Aglaea. She gave no sign of urgency—face flat, voice absent—yet her body interposed itself between the blade and Aglaea as though she’d always done so. A sharp kind of tenderness lived in the guard she offered, one Mydei, even half-fading, could almost recognize. Cipher was violence at the edge of vision, every flicker of her knives unspooling another Council life into sparks and ruin.

And Phainon—Phainon was everywhere.

The rooftop had drowned in blood. It blackened the tiles, ran into the seams of shattered stone, matted steel and flesh alike until the floor glistened red.

Phainon walked through it like it belonged to him. One arm crushed Council throats, tore drones apart as though they were made of paper; the other held Mydei close. No blood reached him, no shockwave of violence broke against his body. All the butchery radiated away in arcs of gore, leaving only the steadiness of a heartbeat against which Mydei's head lolled, dazed.

His weight sagged further, too heavy to hold upright. The world pitched and he felt himself sliding, yet Phainon's grip was iron, locking him in place while the slaughter went on. His cheek pressed to the man's chest as his eyelids dragged low. The rooftop shook under the weight of screams and snapping bone, and still he drifted.

He didn't remember the last bodies falling. Didn't remember the sound of throats giving way or the sparks of drones cut open.

It might have been minutes. It might have been hours. He stirred only when a rough hand found his cheek, thumb grazing skin with a tenderness so at odds with the battlefield that he thought it hallucination. His eyes cracked open to blurred outlines: pastel face, ragged breath. Then the warmth of a forehead pressed into his hair, voice sinking low enough to be mistaken for dream.

"You can rest now."

Phainon's breath stirred him, calm in cadence. Mydei hummed something faint and senseless, words too slurred to hold meaning, then let his eyes fall shut at last. The fight had ended; he no longer had to force himself awake.

So he drifted, sinking deeper into Phainon's arms, while the rooftop lay heaped with severed limbs and spreading pools of blood. The air stank of iron, bodies stacked like offerings at their feet. Yet even then—

"See you tomorrow, Mydei."

Chapter End Notes

Ehh, not gonna lie, I feel like I kinda half-assed the reunion😭 but hopefully it’s not TOO terrible? Also, quick heads up, updates might be a bit slower now that summer’s over and school’s back, so sorry if they come a little late. Still planning to finish this before 3.6 drops tho, so don’t worry about that!

Also… what did you all think of 3.5?

Chapter 19: Council-Slaying for Dummies

Chapter Summary

> The gang argues, panics, trauma-dumps a little, and then somehow manages to cobble together a five-phase plan that sounds just plausible enough to work. Aglaea flexes her “actually I’m in charge” muscles, Hysilens is still chilling with them, and everyone else leaves the meeting looking like they just survived a group project. Meanwhile, Phainon and Mydei quietly reconcile to prove they’re definitely fine now (probably).

Chapter Notes

> Oops, did I say 3.5? Totally meant this’ll be finished in 3.6 haha…. (don’t kill me plz I’m sorry)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Money didn’t just move through the city—it engineered it.

It bent streets into grids, sculpted towers out of glass and steel, and redrew skylines with every fluctuation in the market. Down in the financial district, that truth was impossible to ignore. The air itself seemed regulated, filtered until even the smog felt curated, like luxury goods for lungs that could afford it. Buildings shimmered under the weight of commerce, and every reflection in their mirrored surfaces reminded you who really owned the daylight.

And at the center of this engineered order rose the compound.

To anyone untrained, it was another corporate fortress: sleek facades, clean symmetry, logos slapped across the glass to disguise its true nature. But the faint traceries of gold veined through the building betrayed it. At night, they pulsed like capillaries, a steady glow that made the tower feel less like architecture and more like anatomy. A body, a system. And like all systems in this district, its heartbeat was tied directly to the Chrysos Heirs.

The Council would never admit it, but they were tethered to it too. They might sneer at the Heirs in public, call them reckless, dangerous, destabilizing—yet everyone knew half the Council's budgets depended on the markets that pulsed beneath these streets. A misstep here didn't just risk bad optics. It risked collapse. To march teams into this block would mean tanking the very foundations that kept their power solvent. In other words: the Heirs had carved out a sovereign state in the one place the Council couldn't afford to bleed.

Inside, sovereignty revealed itself without apology.

Medical wings gleamed with sterile precision, their walls saturated with the faint hum of resonance machines, tuned to frequencies that never failed, because failure here was unacceptable. Conference halls stretched out in reflective steel and glass, sharp as blades, as if the rooms themselves had been designed to cut down hesitation. Security wasn't subtle. It didn't have to be. Men and women in matte uniforms stood like punctuation in the silence, visible reminders that the Heirs didn't hide their power—they enforced it openly.

It was the safest place he could be.

The safest place *they* could be.

And still Phainon felt cornered.

He had not left the medical wing in two days. Not properly. Sometimes he drifted as far as the end of the corridor to fill a glass of water. Once, he leaned against the far window, staring at the skyline until the glow of it felt like a weight pressing into his skull. But he always returned to the same chair outside the private suite. Always the same rhythm: sit, wait, tap his fingers against the leather armrest until it felt molded to his shape.

The holo readouts floated in the air like blue ghosts—transparent sheets pulsing with vitals, resonance markers, probability graphs. To anyone else they might have looked like reassurance, proof that the machines were doing their job. To him they were stock tickers before a crash. Each dip

made his teeth grind. Each spike sent a surge of fragile hope ripping through his chest, sharp enough to ache more than despair ever did.

So he gave his hands tasks. Strips of geometry peeled themselves into being, constructs folding out of his palms like blocks extruded from wire. He wove and unwove them, shapes collapsing back into sparks, then reassembling again. He told himself it was practice for his abilities. He knew it was distraction.

Because the thoughts always came, whether his hands were busy or not.

And here, in a fortress that could repel armies, he still felt worried. The Council's reach pressed against his mind like a shadow stretching from far away. Caenis's name hung at the edge of every silence. But worst of all were the memories—the ones he couldn't keep out, the ones no guard could shoot down.

And those, he carried with him into every heartbeat.

Mydei had been under sedation for two days.

The Heirs' medical team said it was necessary—that his system needed to stabilize, that the backlash had been too severe to risk him waking too soon. They spoke with the calm, clinical precision of people who had seen a hundred emergencies worse than this, but none of it made the hours pass faster.

And as anyone could predict, Phainon hadn't stepped inside the suite once.

Instead, he stayed in the hallway, locked in his vigil. The holo projections cycled endlessly in the air before him, washed in shades of blue that bled into his vision even after he blinked. Vital signs, resonance maps, brainwave fluctuations—all floating like scripture waiting to be interpreted. He read meaning into every dip and spike, convinced that if he stopped watching, if he gave the data a moment's freedom, Mydei would slip away again.

Anaxa had told him more than once it wasn't healthy.

That he was spiraling.

That obsession wouldn’t change the outcome.

Phainon heard him.

He just didn’t care.

The others had busied themselves in their own ways since the escape. The compound’s walls made it easy to mistake silence for safety, but beneath the stillness, tension ran like an undercurrent. They’d basically beaten the Council’s people bloody in the streets, torn through city units, left their pursuit in ruins—and somehow, against probability, every one of them had made it out alive. Anaxa had still been there when the dust settled *(he hadn’t prayed in years, but that night he had).* Mydei, battered but breathing, had not been ripped out of Phainon’s reach this time. Even Cipher—sharp-tongued, usually so insidious—had guided them through the chaos with the kind of silence only someone experienced could manage.

It should have felt like victory.

But victories didn’t look like this. Victories didn’t leave you pacing a hallway with your throat tight and your stomach hollow, waiting for blue light to tell you if your world still had a pulse.

Chrysos tech was advanced, but it was still working against odds that couldn’t be smoothed over with clean lines and confident assurances.

Still, he watched.

Because logic demanded vigilance. Because reason told him that every system had cracks, and cracks only widened when ignored. He told himself a lot of things. Sometimes things that sounded noble in his head. Sometimes it sounded pathetic. He didn’t know which was closer to the truth.

And underneath all that reason, beneath the data and the graphs and the blue glow soaking into his bones, there was the simpler truth: he was afraid.

Not of the Council, not of Caenis, not even of the next conflict waiting outside these walls. Those were threats he understood, enemies he could deal with.

What terrified him was the quiet—the possibility that when the sedation lifted, when Mydei finally opened his eyes, the fragile thread binding everything together would snap. That after everything, after two days of holding his breath, Mydei would despise him.

So he stayed.

And the hours continued to slip away, one graph at a time.

Phainon sighed.

“I know you’re there, Goldweaver. Don’t bother hiding.”

He didn’t look up right away, just turned his head enough to let her see the exhaustion etched into his face, unapologetic.

“Or should I say—Aglaea?”

Her presence wasn’t a surprise. Of course she’d come. From the moment they’d pulled her into this, it was only a matter of time. The whole ordeal had been a mess barely stitched together—Hysilens stepping in at the last second, keeping Aglaea from cutting him open in the middle of negotiations. He’d measured the risk in that instant with cold clarity. If she struck, he could rebuild. It would have hurt like hell, yes, but survival had never been the problem. What mattered was that they reached an accord. A fragile one, propped up on logic, necessity, and—though she’d never admit it aloud—Mydei.

Since then, they’d called it “bonding.” A polite word for slow dissection. Information traded in careful measures, pieces of themselves offered and withheld. Somewhere in that process, the name beneath the mask slipped free: the Goldweaver was Aglaea, the Heirs’ steady hand. It hardly changed anything—she’d still been here—but knowing was nice.

She stepped into view dressed as if she'd walked out of a council chamber rather than a battlefield: tailored white suit, every seam exact, gold accents pared down to a whisper. She looked untouchable, but the faint shadows under her eyes betrayed the strain. Even Aglaea had limits.

For half a second, instinct moved through him—an urge to steady her, to guide her to the chair and help her down. The thought barely surfaced before he strangled it. Aglaea didn't need gestures. She didn't want pity, and he wasn't about to offer it.

He forced the impulse down where it belonged, iron-bound and buried.

Instead, he inclined his head with politeness.

"Please take a seat, Lady Goldweaver."

Formality felt safer. He doubted she wanted him to say her name so casually anyway.

But her gaze found him, strong despite the fatigue.

"Aglaea is fine, Phainon."

The way she said his name lingered, deliberate. If it struck a nerve, he gave no sign. He only waited, still as stone, until she sank into the chair opposite. Then he crossed the space at his own pace, lowering himself into the seat across from her.

Silence stretched. Not empty—measured. A line drawn between them, each waiting for the other to mark the first step. Aglaea's face smoothed into composure, the kind you only earned after years of swallowing reactions before they surfaced. He could almost respect it.

When she finally spoke, her voice was calm, layered with that cool steadiness that always seemed to hold weight no matter how simple the words.

"Now," she said, eyes on his. "We have much to discuss."

Phainon matched her stare. There would be no pleasantries here, at least not tonight.

“Where do you want to start?”

Aglaea didn’t waste time. She leaned forward, arms folded.

“I’m assuming you’ve already pieced together their angle.”

Phainon’s jaw worked, eyes fixed on the wall. “Anaxa confirmed it,” he said flatly. “They want to hollow him out. Mydei’s stabilizer makes him the only viable shell. Immortal. Consistent resonance lattice. And me—” his lip twitched, “—as the key to pull the rest in.”

He didn’t spit the word key, but the contempt behind it poisoned the air.

Aglaea’s gaze flicked to him. “Profiles harvested. Layered into him like executable code. Cifera’s intelligence matched that almost to the letter.”

Phainon’s pulse hammered against his throat. He exhaled slow, forcing the spike down, but it was still there, running hot beneath the words. His hands curled into fists, and he didn’t bother to unclench them.

Aglaea noticed, but didn’t call it out. Instead, she drew in a breath, then released it, softer now. “You understand the reason I told you about that initiative. I wasn’t… volunteering that. You made it clear you wouldn’t let go until you knew.”

“Everyone kept it from me.” His tone wasn’t accusation so much as statement, said bluntly.

“Because it wasn’t their story to tell,” she answered evenly. Then, a beat: “Same as you, Khaslana.”

That landed. Phainon’s silence stretched—not defensive, but conceding. He *had* pressed her, practically begged her to lay out the Initiative, the stabilizer trials, what Eurypon had done. He’d wanted to tear the curtain back, no matter how it looked on Mydei. And in return, he’d had to put his

own rot on the table: Caenis, the numbered designation, the failed attempts that had left him scarred in ways he couldn't measure.

Unfortunately, it still wasn't trust as it was mutual necessity. A ledger scratched open between them.

Aglaea shifted her weight. "The Council never trusted the Heirs. That hasn't changed. Independence has always been the threat. The Initiative was one blade they forged to cut it down. What happened to Mydei… wasn't random. It was a prototype in a longer chain."

Phainon exhaled through his teeth. "I know what prototypes look like. I was one. Caenis had done the same and called it calibrations—breaking us down to raw resonance, testing which lattices held under pressure. When they didn't, she scrapped them and started over. I wasn't the only designation, and I'm assuming it's the same for Mydei."

Aglaea hummed in acknowledgement before continuing. "Cifera suspected as much. Taking account this new information, Mydeimos wasn't chosen later, but earlier. Before Eurypon's descent to madness, before your breach even went on record. If both your timelines overlap…"

Phainon finally turned his eyes from the monitors, meeting hers. "Then this was laid out years in advance."

Aglaea inclined her head once. "Exactly."

The hum of the med-equipment filled the space between them. Neither of them looked away.

Phainon leaned back, eyes narrowing as he tracked the threads in his head. "I always marked the beginning of this while fiacso after **Δ7**, the project's name. After the breach. That's when the Council finally took me seriously in those labs as they realized what I was capable of." His added thoughtfully. "Weeks after, maybe a month at most. That was my frame."

Aglaea's response was immediate. "I'd dated it later. After the first Tide incursion. Public favor swung to the Heirs, and the Council was forced to

shift tactics. Their window to dismantle us closed. From there, the tides changed."

Her hands rested on the table, fingers still.

Phainon exhaled, exhausted. "So both timelines fail. Which means we're both wrong." He tapped the edge of the datapad absently, thought running ahead of his words. "They weren't reacting to breaches or to us. The Tide was was infrastructure. A resource. Survivors became vital assets to test, refine, and weaponize because of their higher immunity."

Aglaea tilted her head, processing. "The profiles were stripped down, erased, then folded into new lattices. Different methods between Eurypon and Caenis, but the endpoint aligns."

Her conclusion slid neatly into his.

"And Mydei," Phainon said, "was never just anomalous. His tether was the solution they'd been waiting for—stable containment without degradation."

Aglaea finished his words for him. "Which means his endurance is evidence. Proof their system works outside the lab, and proof they can build on it."

"Then their oversight was assuming they could isolate every variable."

Aglaea's brow lifted a fraction. "You."

"Me," Phainon confirmed. "And by extension, him. I don't intend to let either be used any longer."

She accepted it as such, giving the smallest nod before leaning forward. "So the adjustment is this: it isn't a shift in policy but a sustained initiative maturing into application. Decades feeding into this convergence—your functionality, Mydei's survival. They've positioned themselves to believe the framework is complete."

Phainon's expression thinned into something like a smile, but there was no humor in it. "Then our work is to strip the board before they can even place

the pieces.”

Aglaea considered, then aligned with him. “Agreed. We’ll map their sequence from the earliest recoverable point. Trials, breaches, cover operations. If they’ve layered this long, they’ve left seams. And seams mean access.”

“Access,” Phainon echoed, leaning forward now too. “And leverage.”

She allowed the faintest curve of acknowledgment at the edge of her mouth. “Then let’s begin. Start with your earliest viable record—we’ll build out the grid, and compare against Heir archives. The overlap will give us their true timeline.”

Phainon’s eyes flickered. “Good. Now we’re talking.”

Brainstorming, huh? Not his usual forte, but he’ll do his best.

“How many survivor accounts did the Heirs catalog after Elysiae?”

Aglaea didn’t glance up. “Fourteen.” A pause. “One held. The rest collapsed.”

Phainon’s mouth twitched as he remarked idly. “Council filed it as one. Guess who.”

Her eyes lifted briefly to him. “Efficient.”

“Convenient,” he corrected. A tap of his stylus set a sharp cadence against the tablet. “Erase the failures, crown the anomaly, and you’ve got a neat origin story. NeiKos496. That’s your Phase Two.”

Aglaea marked a line across her notes. “Which means Phase One is the trail—spending spikes six months before Elysiae. Shell firms, phantom contracts, shadow budgets. They were preparing.”

He gave a low hum, not quite agreement, not quite dissent. “Paranoia before the breach. Opportunism after. They couldn’t have known about the Tide

before, but the warning signs were there. Phase One into Two is seamless."

Aglaea underlined with a flick. "And Phase Three is Caenis. Calibrations. Prototype work, as they called it. Your testimony matches the ledger surge —'infrastructure stabilization research.' Same subsidiaries, but doubled."

Phainon sighed. "I was the control sample. The first cut."

Her voice was crisp. "Phase Four belongs to Eurypon."

A click of his tongue. "Obsession with memory, identity grafts. The Council didn't just indulge him—they bankrolled him. Ran him in parallel to Caenis."

"Redundancy," she said evenly. "Two lines, one project. Fail-safes in human form."

He leaned back, eyes narrowing at the half-formed sequence glowing before them. "Phase Five, then. Divergence. Caenis yields corpses. Eurypon yields cracks. The Council keeps feeding both, waiting to see which collapses slower."

"And Phase Six," Aglaea's voice lowered, "is the convergence. Mydei."

For a moment, the room held its silence.

Phainon laid the stylus down, steadier this time. "So. Pre-Breach paranoia. Elysiae's collapse. Caenis' calibrations. Eurypon's obsession. Their divergence. Mydei's survival. That's the skeleton."

Aglaea inclined her head. "And Phase Seven is aftermath. The cover-up. Budgets siphoned into deeper black ledgers. The Initiative scattered, not ended."

He gave a thin smile. "Which means we drag it back into the light."

The cursor blinked, patient, expectant. For the first time in hours, their threads aligned, two bodies of notes converging into a structure neither could have carved alone.

Phainon broke the silence, voice low, almost absent. “Do you want to run it through?”

Aglaea blinked once dazed, rare for her, as if surfacing. “Yes. Let’s.”

Turns out when two of the most informed people alive—both on different yet strangely parallel sides of the coin—finally put their notes together, you don’t just get two and two. You get four, then eight, then a whole map forming before either of them can stop it.

She swiped her hand, and the scattered fragments sharpened into a single screen:

[Joint Draft | Compiled Notes: Goldweaver + Phainon]
Working document. Accuracy approximate. Subject to revision.

╠═══ Phase I: Pre-Breach Foundations ═══╣
(Posture: paranoia → opportunism)

— Council stance prior to the Tide: dismissive. Breaches treated as statistical noise, nothing systemic. Containment funding capped at lowest tier.
— Resource allocation: >70% redirected to Chrysos Heirs contracts (security, infrastructure).
— Council propaganda frames Heirs as unstable radicals, yet underground credibility of Heirs steadily rising. “Necessary devils.”
— Expenditure anomaly flagged: six to twelve months before Aedes Elysiae. Sudden spike in vague budget lines: infrastructure resilience, anomaly research.

⟶ Goldweaver’s anotation: traced two shell subsidiaries. One posing as maritime infrastructure, one as a charity clinic. Both non-operational fronts. **Margin:** Already preparing for something. Before the first breach.

Aglaea nodded faintly when he saw his note.

———

╠═══ Phase II: First Breach — Aedes Elysiae (Year 0) ═══╣
Designation: The Spark Event

— Collapse of Aedes Elysiae following first uncontrolled Black Tide breach.
— Council presence: absent.
— Chrysos Heirs: triage effort focused on sectors with high survival probability. Aedes Elysiae abandoned.

Civilian record: Council negligence immortalized in collective memory. Heirs' credibility reinforced despite official narrative and smear campaigns.

——— Event notes:

• Two survivors attempted resonance stabilization. Anchor tether: shared mnemonic.
• Result: one unraveling, one adaption
• Stabilizer residue: localized anomaly pocket sustained around remains.
• Time differential recorded. Internal duration: indeterminate (years). External lapse: approx. days.

———

Aglaea's eyes lingered on the last entry.

"So Eurypon's theory wasn't wrong." To bind yourself to a memory, looped as proof of existence.

Wasn't that exactly what he'd done?

Phainon didn't answer right away. He hummed absentmindedly. "I suppose it wasn't."

She let that rest, no more said.

—

Council Response (delayed):
— Outer perimeter only. Interior labeled unsalvageable.
— Survivor collection = not rescue. Transfer to quarantine facilities under Caenis oversight.
— Standard process: tagging, dissection, erasure.

Designation Record:
Subject: Δ7 (alias: Khaslana)
Lab ID: NeiKos496 (Cycle 33,550,336)
Note: First documented survivor exhibiting stabilizing adaptation under Tide conditions.

———

Phainon's gaze stayed fixed on the line. His jaw tensed, loosening only after a long inhale. Then he lowered the stylus and added:

Council acquisition of anomaly residue subcontracted to Anaxagoras (Council Auxiliary). Δ7 extracted from primary facility under "operational discretion."

The cursor blinked at the new line.

Aglaea looked over at him—sharp, searching—but said nothing.

Phainon found himself grateful for that.

When she finally spoke, it was casual, almost distracted. "Do you remember what Anaxagoras reported back?"

"Nothing worth reading," Phainon muttered. Then, quieter: "Nothing true."

╔═══ Phase III: Prototype Era ═══╗
(Council doubles down)

— **Estimated:** 1–3 years post–Aedes Elysiae.
↳ [duration blocked. memory fractured. *why?* unusual, considering other intact recalls. *ask Anaxagoras?* → never did. reasons = obvious.]

— **Overseer**: Caenis.
- her branding: *“Calibrations.”*
- method: closed facilities; survivors stripped down to resonance threads.
- result: near-total failure → death, collapse, or blanking.

— Council objective: chart conceptual lattices, test stabilizers, isolate anomalies (esp. Phainon’s).

— *Prototype file:*
- Subject Khaslana (NeiKos496).
- Designation: “Original Prototype.”
- All later data sets measured against him.
- Adaptation never replicated.

— *Council action (parallel):*
- sudden budget surge labeled “infrastructure stabilization research.”
- allocations obscured; trail cuts mid-ledger.
- likely destination: Caenis’ expanded facilities.

———

Aglaea dragged her stylus under the line about the budgets, pressing too hard so the underline jittered. “It’s instantaneous. One cycle they were flat, next cycle the funds triple. And no recruitment records to match.”

“They weren’t recruits,” Phainon said. “They were stock.”

She glanced up. “You’re certain?”

“You’re seriously asking that? I’m not gonna sugarcoat it.” He paused. “You don’t hire people for that, it’s *acquired*.”

Aglaea hesitated, then scribbled in the margin: ***not recruits → acquisitions.***

“…Are you all right with it being written down like that?”

“It’s already written, what difference does it make?”

———

╔═══ Phase IV: Eurypon’s Rise & Obsession ═══╗

— Initial scope: memory mechanics, continuity of self.
— Council redirects him → existential tether research.
— Transition: theory → live trials.

- Early: volunteers.
- Later: dissidents, prisoners, displaced bodies. Younger and healthier test subjects for experimentation.

After subject anomaly discovered in Aedes Elysiae: survivors recognized as exploitable resource. Council invests in Eurypon.

Dual operations split:
- **Caenis** → survivor calibrations.
- **Eurypon** → synthetic anchor grafts.

Initiative formalized
Kýklos Thanatou Eikon (KTE)

- Cover story: containment program.
- Real axis: immortality project.

———

Phainon twirled his pen. “Containment. I should’ve bet money on that word. It’s the kind you can eat at Council tables without vomitting.”

“They likely needed it,” Aglaea supplied. “If they’d written ‘immortality,’ provinces would’ve rioted.”

“And yet no riots for slaughter.” His voice was absentminded, but it carried. “Strange where people draw the line.”

She didn’t answer. Instead, she bracketed the sentence and amended:

[Containment = camouflage, not function.]

———

╔══ Phase V: Divergence & Collapse ══╗

— **Caenis’ labs:**
- all prototypes failed catastrophically.
- Council salvaged the debris → data recycled.

— Eurypon’s labs:
- anchors gave partial stability.
- subjects endured longer, collapsed harder.
- researcher deteriorated under resonance exposure → progressive cognitive erosion.

— Council approach: maintain both streams.
- dual budgets, mirrored line-items.
- redundancy or fracture? *[disputed]*

———

Aglaea leaned over the projection, pointing at the redundant ledgers. “This is it. This is the proof they weren’t unified. Two budgets, one project. Paranoia institutionalized.”

“Or competition,” Phainon said, leaning back with arms crossed. “You’re giving them too much credit calling it paranoia. They weren’t hedging—they were splitting into camps.”

“So internal sabotage?”

“Sabotage, rivalry… call it what you want. Redundancy is just division in disguise.”

Aglaea chewed her lip, then scrawled across the margin in uneven script:

Dual funding = fracture, not security.

She paused, and then, quieter, almost to herself: “And fracture is how things rot from the inside.”

“…Let’s continue.”

———

[Phase VI — The Collapse of Projects]

— **Exposure escalation:** Eurypon overreaches, attempting to bind a stabilizer lattice directly into his own son. [*madness? calculation?*]
— Gorgo’s intervention. Shielded impact. *(— died there.)*
— Resonance failure: catastrophic implosion of the lab’s framework. Black Tide surge consumes remaining systems.

Outcome:
• **Eurypon** — dead. *(method uncertain—[struck] self-destruction [struck])*
(margin, darker color: “we both know what happened.”)
• **Gorgo** — deceased, final act anchoring lattice.
• **Subject (Mydei)** — survived. Only viable lattice-host recorded.
• **Council** — immediate cover-up. Heirs credited for “purging rogue breach.” Records scrubbed. Vaults sealed.

———

[Phase VII — Aftermath & Repositioning]

— Public front: Initiative dismantled. Heirs paraded. Council untouched.
— Reality: Δ7 fragments survive. Khaslana’s archives obliterated. Eurypon’s schematics, partially preserved. Caenis slips free, retains shards.

— Budgetary ghost trail: funding doesn’t vanish, only reburied. Black budgets expand. Vault research continues.

(margin, faint and half-struck: “and this leads us directly to Caenis’ present design—your creation mapped, Mydei’s lattice weaponized.”)

———

Phainon’s eyes lingered on the screen as if the words themselves were volatile. His fingers flexed once against the table before he finally leaned back.

“After all that, it seems we’ve only just carved down to its foundations.”

Aglaea looked over it once more. “And with you free, with Mydei proven —” she underlined *only viable host* twice “—they believe they’ve closed the circuit.”

“Circuits can be broken. And this one will.”

The draft had grown longer under their hands, margins crowded with correction.

Then Aglaea stopped before she lifted her gaze. “I imagine you’d like to add more.”

His eyes flicked to her, unreadable, before he returned to the page. “I don’t know what you mean.”

She studied him, then deliberately scrolled the document back up, tapping one line with the pen’s tip: *Δ7 fragments survive. Khaslana’s archives obliterated.*

“That doesn’t reconcile. Not with what we both know. There’s something missing.” Her voice was calm, almost mild — which only worsened the point. “Spare me the pleasantries, Phainon. If we are dismantling the Council’s stranglehold, there can be no omissions.”

Her hand lingered on the margin, where his silence had already left a gap too wide to ignore.

“So tell me…” She turned slightly, her eyes catching his at last.

“Who exactly *is* Anaxagoras—and how did he succeed in helping you escape?”

Phainon closed his eyes and counted to three. When he opened them, Aglaea hadn’t moved an inch.

“You really don’t miss anything, do you?” he muttered.

“Excuses are pointless. Don’t bother.”

He groaned and tipped his head back. “Fine.”

Anaxa’s going to kill me for this, he thought. Then, with a grim little smirk: *but he’d understand.*

“Anaxagoras,” he said slowly, “wasn’t some scholar or Council darling you’d put on a file, fortunately. He was an unregistered contractor. A transient. The kind who lived under ten aliases and torched them as soon as they got too close. A ghost-for-hire with a reputation so toxic that even being seen with him could sink your career.”

His lips quirked. “Archivists had a name for him, though. The Blasphemer.”

Aglaea’s brow arched, but she didn’t interrupt.

“Why?” Phainon leaned forward, elbows on his knees. “Because he dealt in constructs and manipulations so far past regulation that even the Council wouldn’t touch them. Forbidden work. Black-market work. And of course, that’s why they needed him.”

He rubbed his eyes. “After the project collapsed, they panicked. The Black Tide shook them so bad they started scraping the bottom of every barrel they could find. They pulled him in quiet, no recordstrail. Just another

disposable expert they could throw at the breach zone and then bury if things got messy."

He tapped the edge of the table. "That's how I met him. He stumbled across me by accident."

Phainon let out a low whistle. "And at first? He didn't care. Why would he? One kid in a pile of corpses wasn't worth his skin. I knew it. He knew it."

His gaze drifted, shadowed. "What changed? I still don't know. Maybe pity. Maybe he saw my resonance and thought I was proof of one of his half-mad theories. Back then, I wasn't a child to him—I was a test case. Whatever it was, he pulled me out."

He spread his hands, palms up. "Not quickly either. Containment was tight, surveillance everywhere. He spent days, maybe weeks, working out how to extract me without leaving a trace. And when he finally made his move?" A thin smile crossed his mouth. "It was an acquisition. A partnership, whether I liked it or not."

His voice softened. "He saved me because it was useful. And I… was too desperate to care."

Finally, Phainon lifted his hands in a half-hearted shrug. "So. Interrogation over? Hope that scratched your itch."

Aglaea's hum was noncommittal as she uncrossed her arms and scribbled something in her notes. "Then it's fortunate I've already sent him digging through their servers."

Phainon went still, then rolled one shoulder. Of course she had. Smart move. He was just starting to lower his hands when she added, almost casually:

"And I've also asked him to speak with Mydei. He should be waking by now."

The words hit like ice water down his spine. His blood iced over, breath caught in his throat.

"You what."

Aglaea didn't flinch under his glare. She simply set her papers down. "As I said—after much convincing, I had Anaxagoras go to Mydei to—"

Phainon's hand curled on the armrest, knuckles white. His interruption was sudden. "And pray tell, *why* would you do that exactly?"

Aglaea met his eyes. "Why not? He's going to assist us. At some point he needs to know everything we've recorded here. Everything you've refused to tell him. Better it come from someone who won't sugarcoat it."

He sat back too fast, like distance could steady him. His arms folded, posture feigning composure while his pulse slammed in his throat. Calm. Controlled. Measured. But his chest felt tight, each breath shallow. "You don't know what you're doing," he said carefully. "This isn't—this isn't something you get to decide."

"No secrets applies to everyone," Aglaea cut in, steel ringing in her tone. "Everyone."

The words sliced, too quick, too final.

Phainon's jaw clenched, his composure splintering. "You think you're doing him a favor? Throwing Anaxa at him the moment he opens his eyes? You'll drown and overwhelm him before he has the chance to—"

Aglaea leaned forward, glaring. "What *drowns* him, Phainon, is silence. Pretending nothing happened and that he isn't owed the truth. That's what breaks him."

He felt his pulse spike, panic bubbling past the dam he'd built for months. "You don't have the right—"

Aglaea's hand snapped her pen closed. "Neither do you." Her voice didn't rise, but the finality in it hit like a slammed door. "You're not the only one

who’s worried about him. Stop acting like you are.”

His throat tightened. The room felt smaller, suffocating. For a moment he could barely hear over the blood rushing in his ears.

They locked eyes, both refusing to look away. Silent fury—and under his, something rawer. Fear.

The chair legs screeched as Phainon pushed himself to his feet, movements too sharp, too deliberate. He turned for the door, the beginnings of an exit meant to slam the whole conversation behind him—

“By the way,” Aglaea said without looking up, “I’ve convinced Hysilens to extend her stay.”

He stopped cold.

The words dropped into him like ice water. Hysilens—who had sworn she’d leave once Mydei was found—was still here. Still waiting. That meant bargains had been struck. That meant time had been bought.

That meant there was no more hiding.

He should feel grateful. He should. Instead bile climbed his throat, his gut twisting hard enough he thought he might double over. If Hysilens stayed, then this was real. This was happening. Mydei would wake. Mydei would *know*.

His breath stuttered. For a wild second he almost wished Aglaea had let Hysilens walk away—so he could delay this a little longer.

Aglaea’s gaze finally lifted to his. “Go,” she said, calm but implacable. “Talk to him. Don’t delay it.”

Phainon stood frozen, every muscle taut, fighting the urge to flee. Then, after a long, brittle pause, he turned and walked out. Each step echoed sharp, too loud in the hall.

He didn’t realize until the door shut behind him that his hands were trembling.

Phainon wasn’t scared.

Of course he wasn’t.

What reason did he have to be scared? None at all. Absolutely none.

Which was why he was—once again—back in the medic wing. Same hallway, same door. Mydei’s door. He’d been here so many times in the last few days that the nurses had stopped even glancing at him. He was a fixture now, like a painting nailed into the wall.

The only difference this time was his hand on the handle.

And for some unfathomable reason, it refused to turn.

Strange. Truly strange.

He stared down at his fingers, knuckles blanched white from how tightly he was gripping the metal. He must’ve been standing here for five minutes. Ten. Who knew? He wasn’t keeping track. Keeping track implied waiting. And he wasn’t waiting. He had no reason to wait.

He could go in whenever he wanted. Walk through, say a few clever words, sit at Mydei’s bedside like always. He’d done it before. Hundreds of times. It was easy.

So why wasn’t he moving?

The thought came too quickly, uninvited: *Anaxa’s been inside with him.*

Explaining. Filling gaps. Answering questions Phainon had carefully dodged.

His stomach knotted.

What if Mydei knew now? Not the cheerful professor who tripped over his own shoes, not the overbearing partner who always smothered him in affection—but the other thing. The thing he is. The things he had done.

Would Mydei hate him for it? Would he look at him differently?

The worst part was knowing that the answer was probably *no*. That Mydei wouldn't hate him. That he would listen, nod, maybe even forgive without asking. Because that's who he was. That was the kind of patience Mydei carried like armor.

And yet—that made it worse. Because it meant the fear wasn't about Mydei at all. It was about himself. About being god damn it, perceived. About being left behind once Mydei saw who he really was.

The longer he stood there, the faster the thoughts crowded, each one twisting tighter than the last until the air itself felt thin. He pressed the heel of his palm against his brow, trying to will the noise away.

And then the door opened.

He jolted back, hand slipping off the handle.

Anaxagoras stepped out.

For a moment, Phainon just stared. The professor looked exhausted, his steps slower than usual, his shoulders slumped. He should've been flat on a bed still, not walking out of Mydei's room.

Phainon reached out on instinct, catching his wrist. "Professor—you shouldn't be up. You're not healed. Why would you—"

Anaxa stopped him with a look, steady and sharp even through the fatigue. "Why would I what? Rest while you turn to stone out here?"

Phainon faltered. "…That's not—"

"Exactly what you're doing," Anaxa finished, gently pulling his wrist free.

Phainon tried to muster a protest, but it died on his tongue.

Then Anaxa did something rare. He set a hand on Phainon's shoulder. Not heavy or cndescending. Just… grounding.

"You've stood at this door every day," Anaxa said quietly, voice like worn parchment, "and each time you walk away with nothing but heavier steps. If you keep circling like this, you'll grind yourself down before he ever says a word to you."

Phainon swallowed, throat dry.

Anaxa gave his shoulder a small squeeze. "You want the truth from him? Then give him yours. Stop circling. Go forward."

The words cut through cleaner than any scolding or lecture ever could have.

Anaxa let go and straightened, his exhaustion etched in every line of him. "You've delayed long enough," he added. "Don't make the mistake of thinking time will soften it for you. It won't."

And with that, he turned and walked down the hall, not once looking back.

Phainon stood frozen, pulse roaring in his ears, the weight of that hand still lingering like it had branded him.

Slowly, almost against his will, he turned back to the door.

His hand found the handle again.

This time, there was no hiding.

He braced himself—and pushed.

The door shut behind him with a quiet thud, and for a moment Phainon just stood there, blinking at the room. It wasn't grim or suffocating, nothing like the image he'd been bracing for. The air smelled faintly of lavender disinfectant and fresh sheets. A vase of wilting flowers sat on the nightstand, their petals curling but still bright. The blinds were tilted open

just enough to let sunlight spill in stripes across the floorboards, warm and soft, almost domestic.

It was too normal. Too still. The kind of normal that pressed in on him, made his pulse feel out of place. He stared at the curve of the chair leg, the neat fold of a blanket at the foot of the bed, the way dust motes drifted lazily in the light—details that had nothing to do with why he was here.

“Phainon?”

His name cut clean through the haze. He jerked, every muscle tightening before he turned toward the bed.

And there he was.

Mydei.

Alive, awake, and looking at him.

Propped against a stack of pillows, the sheets pulled neatly over his lap. His hair fell in messy strands across his face, one braid slipping loose down his shoulder. His skin was still pale from the ordeal, but the familiar markings along his arms glowed faintly, proof he was whole. His eyes—sharp, golden, impossibly steady—found Phainon like they always did, and for a second it felt less like being seen and more like being caught.

Phainon’s chest locked. His throat turned dry, useless. All he could do was stare, drinking him in like someone clutching at proof a ghost was real.

It took effort—more than it should have—to move his feet. He shuffled to the chair beside the bed and lowered himself into it like a man easing into enemy territory, stiff-backed, fingers twitching before he jammed them into his pockets. He tried looking at Mydei, failed, tried again, each glance darting away too fast, like he couldn’t look for long without burning himself on it.

A cough slipped out, more nerves than anything, and he forced a laugh to follow it. It cracked halfway, painfully obvious. “Well… guess this is…

happening.”

Mydei blinked once. His voice came flat, unimpressed. “What gave it away? The part where you sat down?”

Phainon winced, shoulders hunching. “Alright, fair. Didn’t need the commentary, though.”

Mydei’s mouth twitched—not quite a smile, not quite not.

The silence that settled after wasn’t crushing, but it wasn’t easy either. The kind of silence where a monitor beeped steadily in the background, loud enough to remind Phainon how hard his own heart was hammering. He sank a little lower in the chair, one hand scrubbing at the back of his neck, muttering mostly to himself, “Yep. Nailed that first impression.”

For the first time since stepping inside, the tight knot in his chest shifted—still there, but looser.

Phainon inhaled, fingers twitching against his knees before he tried on a laugh. It came out scratchy, half-spent before it even left his mouth. “Alright. Cards on the table.” He flicked his hand like he was about to do a magic trick, then dropped it limply back into his lap. “Surprise—I’m a terrifying, infamous antihero with a body count longer than this hallway. Don’t all clap at once.”

He meant for it to land like a joke, but exhaustion dulled the edges, left it flat.

Mydei didn’t say anything.

The silence stretched, heavy and sharp. Phainon’s throat dried out, his neck prickling as though the walls themselves were watching. He tried to hold Mydei’s gaze, couldn’t. His chest seized, his stomach turning with each second that passed. He pictured the judgment behind those gold eyes: disgust, calculation, quiet condemnation. *He’s tallying it all up, every name, every lie, measuring me against them and realizing I’m not worth the air. Gods, he’s—*

“…and I’m a deranged vigilante with immortality issues,” Mydei said at last, voice calm, almost dry. “Raised as a weapon by the Heirs as a child after my father experimented on me and killed my mother.” He angled his head, gold eyes catching Phainon’s like a hook. “So, what’s your point?”

Phainon blinked, words collapsing in his throat.

A sardonic beat passed. Then Mydei’s mouth quirked, faint as a hairline crack. “Made for each other, aren’t we?”

The tension in Phainon’s chest twisted, then broke. A laugh tumbled out of him, shaky but real. He leaned forward, pressing his hand to his forehead, shoulders sagging like someone had just pulled the pins out of him. “Right… yeah. Let’s… talk about it.”

He let the words sit, then more serious as he forced himself to get to the point: “I killed you. Or I thought I did. And you—” his hand swept vaguely at Mydei’s very alive form, “—you came back. Do you know how insane that makes me feel?”

Mydei’s brows lifted slightly, like he couldn’t quite believe he had to spell it out. “Insane enough that you’re still sitting here instead of running off to brood somewhere dramatic.”

Phainon groaned, dragging his hand down his face. “Brooding’s a coping mechanism.”

“Apparently so is oversharing.”

“Hey!” Phainon peeked out between his fingers, affronted but more relieved than he wanted to admit.

Mydei’s expression softened just a fraction. “For the record—I didn’t find out from you, or from Aglaea, or even Anaxa. I pieced it together from the archives.”

Phainon’s stomach dropped. “Archives?”

“Yes. Reports, recordings. Not flattering ones.” Mydei tilted his head. “Trust me, I was surprised too.”

“That’s supposed to make me feel better?”

“I said surprised, not repulsed.”

Phainon blinked at him, and the spiraling slowed. Just a little. The ground didn’t feel quite as shaky under his feet.

“Gods,” Phainon muttered, leaning back into the chair, “you really are the worst person to confess to. How’re you taking this so well?”

Mydei’s lips curved again, dry amusement threading through his voice. “If you can accept me for who I am, why can’t I do the same?”

Phainon’s decided to ignore that. His fingers tapped once, twice, against his knee before he finally blurted, “I can tell you about Caenis. About her… uh, leisure activities, let’s call them. If you want closure or something.”

Mydei’s response came almost too quickly, a faint shake of the head. “No need. We’ll hear about it soon enough anyway. I’m fairly certain Aglaea and Anaxa have already made sure we both know the broad strokes.” He breathed in, closed his eyes for a moment, then opened them again. “Besides… I’d rather we talk about it ourselves. Later. Not now. And not the way you’re thinking.”

Phainon cocked his head, trying for levity, even as his mouth pulled tight. “It’s fine. I totally could—”

“Phainon.” The way Mydei said his name cut him short. “I didn’t mean in that way.”

“Oh.” A blink, a little slump of his shoulders. “…Ok.”

Phainon shifted in his chair, eyes flicking toward Mydei and away again before he risked a crooked half-smile. “What, no lecture? No righteous glare? You’re really slipping, Mydei.”

Mydei glanced at him sidelong, unimpressed but not unkind. “You’ve already ripped yourself apart over it. What’s left for me to add?”

Phainon let out a breath, sinking a little deeper into the chair. “You always ruin the bit. You know that, right?”

“Consider it a talent,” Mydei said dryly.

For a moment, Phainon just looked at him—really looked. Not at the tattoos, not at the whole Godslayer thing, but at the man in a plain hospital gown, hair a mess, sitting upright in bed like he wasn’t supposed to be there but somehow belonged anyway. The sight made something tight in Phainon’s chest give way.

He chuckled. “Gods, look at us. This is absurd.”

Mydei raised a brow. “What is?”

“All of it.” Phainon waved a vague hand between them. “Matching tragic backstories, endless trauma, sitting here trying to talk like normal people. If this was a book, we’d be the worst romance novel in history.”

“Speak for yourself,” Mydei returned without missing a beat. “I’m delightful.”

Phainon snorted loud enough that it startled him. He scrubbed a hand over his face, grinning despite himself. “Oh, sure. Delightful. That’s exactly the word I’d use.”

For the first time since walking into the room, he didn’t feel like the floor was about to collapse under him. The absurdity, the banter, the fact that Mydei was here and answering him at all—it was enough to make him believe, if only for a moment, that everything really would be fine.

Phainon leaned back in the chair, arms folding tight across his chest. For once, he didn’t try to fill the silence.

Mydei broke it first. “You should have trusted me.”

A pause, his eyes flicking down, then back. “So should I.”

Phainon huffed, a smile tugging at his mouth. “Yeah. I should’ve. You should’ve.” He ticked the points off on his fingers. “Look at that. We both suck. Solid teamwork.”

That earned him the barest snort from Mydei.

Then Mydei’s voice shifted. “You thought you lost me.”

The words hung there. Phainon’s grin faltered, his throat working around something that didn’t want to come out. “…I did.” Barely audible.

It landed heavier than anything else they’d said.

Mydei didn’t argue. He only lifted a hand, steady and sure, and set it against Phainon’s cheek. The contact was simple, unforced—like placing a marker down on a map. “Then don’t let go this time.”

Phainon flinched, then leaned into it before he could second-guess himself. Just long enough to breathe, to feel the warmth of it. No speeches, no drama. Just that.

The quiet stretched, softer now.

Finally, Phainon muttered, “We’re a disaster at first impressions. But second chances? Those we might actually get right.”

That pulled the faintest smile from Mydei—the first in too long.

“So… we’re good?” Phainon asked.

“We were always good,” Mydei said. He let the hand drop back to his lap. “I am still going to beat the shit out of you when this is over.”

Phainon’s laugh came quick, a little frayed at the edges. “Thanks for the warning.”

…

“…What if I like it, though—?”

“Phainon.”

And just like that, the air felt lighter.

Well, after that whole ordeal—and the rare miracle of a halfway-decent conversation—it was, regrettably, time to move. They didn’t have the luxury of lingering, no matter how high emotions had flared. And so: the current debacle.

“Phainon.”

“Hm?”

“Stop.”

“Stop what, Mydeimos?”

Mydei’s sigh was loud enough to echo off the sterile walls. “Why are you calling me by my full name—never mind. *Stop it.*”

Because Phainon was *latched* onto him. Draped across his side like a living weighted blanket, clinging with the stubborn devotion of a barnacle and the smug grin of someone who knew exactly how ridiculous they looked.

“Mydei, you walk too fast,” Phainon complained, digging in further. “What if I trip? What if I faint dramatically in this soulless government hallway? You’d never forgive yourself.”

“You’re not going to faint,” Mydei deadpanned, prying at an elbow.

“You don’t know that. I could have a delicate constitution.”

“You’re a murderer with a hit list. ‘Delicate’ is not the word I’d use.”

“Wow. Cruel. Here I am, fragile as glass, and you call me—what was it—ah yes, a dumbass.”

“That’s because you *are* a dumbass.” Mydei gave him a sharp shove.

Phainon stumbled half a step, then instantly reattached himself, looping both arms around Mydei’s shoulders this time. “Koala mode. Can’t shake me off now.”

“Koalas sleep twenty hours a day,” Mydei muttered, struggling forward. “Please aspire to that.”

“No can do. I’m thriving. Bonding. Reconciliation arc, you can’t break the trope.”

Mydei pinched the bridge of his nose. “Unbelievable.”

By the time the automatic doors slid open, Phainon had worked himself into full deadweight, forcing Mydei to half-drag him inside.

Three pairs of eyes swiveled toward them.

Aglaea and Hysilens sat in crisp, professional stillness on one side of the briefing table. Opposite them stood Anaxa, arms crossed, mid-glare at Aglaea before turning the full force of it on the late arrivals.

“Well,” Anaxa said, drawl sharp enough to slice, “look who decided to reconcile. Only two hours past our scheduled time. Meanwhile, I’ve been trapped in here with this woman.” His voice dripped venom on the last two words.

Aglaea didn’t so much as blink. “You say that as if my company were punishment. Correct me if I’m wrong, but you initiated the discussion on fringe-colony taxation codes, Anaxa.”

“That wasn’t discussion—that was assassination by boredom.”

“Or perhaps you simply lacked the education to follow.”

Phainon perked up immediately, practically vibrating with glee. “Oh, this is *fantastic*. You two are like an old married couple who divorced three times and still send each other hate-mail.”

“Phainon,” Mydei muttered, warning heavy in his tone.

“No, no, don’t stop him,” Aglaea said sweetly, still smiling at Anaxa like a portrait in a gallery. “It’s refreshing to see someone else recognize his flair for dramatics.”

“Dramatics?” Anaxa’s composure cracked, eyebrows shooting up. “You staged a thirty-minute *lecture* on the ‘philosophical ramifications of exile law’ while I asked a simple logistical question about fuel reserves. Fuel reserves, Aglaea. The difference between survival and being stranded, and you gave me a dissertation.”

“It was relevant.”

“It was deranged.”

“It was *comprehensive*.”

“You’re insufferable.”

“And you’re obtuse.”

“Oh, it’s heating up,” Phainon whispered to Mydei, eyes gleaming. “Bet you ten credits she breaks him first. Look at that smile—she’s ruthless.”

“You’re not betting on this.” Mydei’s tone was iron.

“Fine, but admit it—this is better than daytime theater.”

“Barely,” Mydei said, but he didn’t move to stop it.

Aglaea leaned forward slightly, as if presenting in court. “If you cannot endure basic discourse without whining, perhaps you should reconsider your claim to leadership.”

“Basic discourse?” Anaxa let out a short laugh. “You weaponize vocabulary like it’s a dueling pistol. You don’t converse, Aglaea—you lay ambushes.”

“Perhaps you’re simply too slow to dodge them.”

“Slow? From the woman who takes forty minutes to define the word *jurisdiction*?”

“It required nuance.”

“You required a muzzle.”

“Oh my god. I’m living for this. They’re gonna start throwing case law at each other like daggers.”

Before Aglaea could retort, a single sound cut through the room.

Hysilens cleared her throat.

Not loud. Not long. But sharp enough to cleave through the tension like a blade.

Instant silence.

Phainon wilted, peeling himself off Mydei with exaggerated reluctance, slouching into the nearest chair. He cleared his throat, far too loudly. “Right. Plans. We need to—uh—come up with one.”

Anaxa seized the pause like it had been his all along. “No need.” He smoothed his sleeve, face snapping back into elegance. “While you two were… *indisposed*, some of us collaborated with other parties to build a working strategy.”

Phainon whistled low, getting up to all towards him just to drop back into the seat beside him. “God, I missed this. Planning with you—it’s like muscle memory. Everything without you was twice as hard. Three times.”

“Don’t flatter me.”

“Not flattery. Desperation.”

Across the room, Mydei drifted toward Aglaea’s side, only to hesitate when his gaze met Hysilens’. For a beat, the two held still—a flicker of old

history, recognition unspoken. Then both inclined their heads in brief acknowledgment, settling beside each other without a word.

Anaxa rose, Aglaea following smoothly, both straightening into crisp professionalism as if the earlier sparring had never happened.

“Now,” Anaxa said, tone clipped back into precision, “shall we?”

He tapped the console, city-core schematics flickering up in pale light.

“Alright. Phase one: pressure. Aglaea, that’s your wheelhouse. You get the Heirs moving in sync and drag the neutrals into daylight. No more polite nodding from the sidelines—we need them loud, public, staking their reputations. The point isn’t to topple the Council overnight. It’s to make the cracks visible.”

Aglaea tilted her chin, faintly amused. “You make it sound brutish.”

“Good,” Anaxa said smoothly. “Brutish plays. This is theater.”

Phainon, leaning forward now, gave a small nod. “Theatrics work if the optics hold. But if the Heirs overplay it, the Council can spin us as agitators. How are you keeping that leash tight?”

Aglaea’s reply was all teeth. “By picking districts where the Council can’t afford bad press. Let them call us agitators while the cameras roll on grieving families.”

“Fair,” Phainon murmured, sitting back again, calculation flickering in his eyes.

Anaxa flicked the schematic, zooming in.

“Phase two: money. Cipher traces the rot—ledgers, contracts, the payments nobody wants public. If even half of it sticks, Councilors start turning on each other before the week’s out.”

Cipher lounged against the table edge.

Phainon pauses. When did she get there? He swore it was just them—you know what never mind he won't question it anymore.

"Just remember—people need to believe it. My gift doesn't run on autopilot."

"Which is why we back it with evidence," Anaxa countered. "Documents, testimony, receipts. Dress the lies in truth and they'll eat it up."

Cipher smirked. "Propaganda with paperwork. Cute."

"Phase three," Anaxa continued, "is disruption. My department. I drip-feed classified directives, enough to inflame outrage without burning our stash. At the same time, I'll throw false breach signals into the grid—make the Council's enforcement scatter. They'll look frantic, guilty, and thin-stretched."

Phainon gave a quiet huff. "Chaos by bureaucracy. Efficient. Just watch your timing—too many false alarms and they'll wise up."

"Noted," Anaxa said. "Which brings us to phase four."

The air shifted. Even Phainon straightened a touch.

"Caenis," Anaxa said simply. His gaze cut to Phainon, then Mydei. "That's yours. How you handle her—capture, expose, kill—that's your call. The rest of us clear the stage."

A silence held. Mydei didn't blink. Phainon's expression was carved granite.

"Details?" Phainon asked at last. "Because walking in blind is how people end up dead."

"You won't be blind," Anaxa replied. "Hysilens buys us windows. Cipher floods the cycle with proof so Caenis can't bury the narrative. The goal is containment and evidence. The moment you two confront her, the rest of us make sure the world is watching."

Phainon gave the faintest nod, like he'd slot it into a plan already forming in his head.

"Which leads us to surveillance," Anaxa went on. "The Council sees everything. Hysilens?"

The violinist inclined her head, calm as ever. "I can collapse their nets. Briefly. But you'll have to be exact."

"I'll be exact," Anaxa promised.

"And if you're not?" she pressed.

"Then we improvise," Anaxa said without missing a beat.

Phainon muttered, "Always reassuring."

Mydei gave him a look. "You've survived this long on improvisation."

He didn't flinch, only lifted a brow. "Exactly why I don't recommend it."

Anaxa cut in, crisp. "The fallout isn't revolution. The Council survives. But it limps. Plan dismantled. Caenis gone. And the Heirs? No longer pawns—partners."

Aglaea's sighed. "Finally, a language I can endorse."

Anaxa exhaled, almost weary. "Then do me a favor and endorse it punctually." His eyes cut to Phainon and Mydei.

Phainon lifted his hands in mock surrender. "Don't know what you're implying."

Mydei muttered, "You're insufferable."

"Compliment accepted," Phainon said dryly, but the edge in his eyes hadn't softened.

Aglaea didn’t say anything at first, letting the quiet stretch after Anaxa’s rundown. Then she leaned in, resting her palms on the console so the light from the schematic washed her sleeves. “Four phases is elegant, but insufficient. We’re not dealing with amateurs. The Council will ride out the storm if we don’t close the cycle. I’m adding a fifth.”

Anaxa arched a brow, faintly skeptical.

“Everything you’ve built covers disruption. Pressure, fracture, exposure, confrontation. That’s strong enough to wound them, yes. But if we leave it there, they recover. They consolidate, rewrite, bury the evidence, and three years from now the Initiative returns with a new face. Phase Five is durability. Long-term locks—oversight structures, redistribution of proof, institutional safeguards that stop them from crawling back into the dark. That part falls to me.”

Her tone left no opening for rebuttal, and for once even Anaxa let the silence pass.

It was Hysilens who broke it. “Then you’ll need cover built in. The Council won’t only fight you in chambers—they’ll bleed you in the margins. Attrition, process, delay. If we mean to keep momentum, I can engineer silence in the right places. Not just blind spots, but gaps in the record—meeting minutes scrubbed, trace-logs lost. When they look back, they won’t be able to prove what they missed. That gives your reforms space to root.”

Aglaea inclined her head. “Exactly. This is a rough framework. I’ll refine the timing, sharpen the distribution, and fold in those contingencies. But tonight we’ve done what we needed: a spine to build around.”

She straightened, gathering her notes in a clean motion that felt very much like dismissal. “That’s enough. We begin preparation tomorrow. Get rest while you can—you’ll miss it soon enough.”

The chairs creaked and slid back, their glow dimming as the projection winked off. Conversation dissolved into low murmurs as they filtered toward the exit.

Phainon fell into step with Mydei, the two of them walking in a silence that didn’t press. He thought nothing of it when Aglaea’s voice carried across the chamber.

“Mydei. Hysilens. Stay a moment.”

Phainon slowed without realizing, glancing over his shoulder. Mydei met his eye briefly, then tipped him the faintest nod. Phainon gave one in return and turned forward again, his stride steady. Maybe it was better this way—let Mydei handle Aglaea without him hovering at his side.

He was nearly at the door when Mydei’s voice followed him.

“Phainon. My room. Later.”

The words caught him mid-step. For a heartbeat, he stilled. Then he dipped his chin once—quick, precise, acknowledgment without theatrics—and kept on.

His face was unreadable as he left the chamber, mask steady as ever. But once the doors slid closed behind him, the weight eased. In the half-lit corridor his steps found a lighter rhythm, and a small, almost reluctant smile pulled at his mouth.

A little spring carried him forward. They were going to be all right.

Chapter End Notes

> Well you know what, screw any schedule I set before we’re gonna raw dog this fic. I got preoccupied with writing for Myphai fest which took a bit too long so that’s the excuse I have, my deepest apologies once more
>
> Hey on the bright side two more chapter to go…? If y’all still are interested😭

This chapter isn’t quite what I wanted and is somewhat rushed since I did wanna get an update out sooner and keep it under 10k, but the next chapter will be much longer and better paced!!

Works inspired by this one

Fanart of Paper Cuts and Pyres by Irgendwas

Ludiosis Illumoria by Traumatizedbean

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